

미망아후의 세계

성훈 현대 판타지 소설

1



Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/the-world-after-the-fall-16091325>

The World After the Fall

The World after the End

Author: [Sing-Shong](#)
RANK 478

4.4

247

Chapters

1.58M

Views

6.13K

Bookmarked

Completed

Status

Categories

- [Action](#)
- [Adventure](#)
- [Drama](#)
- [Fantasy](#)
- [Mystery](#)
- [Shounen](#)

The World After the Fall novel is a popular light novel covering Action, Adventure, and Drama genres. Written by the Author Sing-Shong. 247 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

One day, a tower appeared in the skies of all the major cities...

Humans were suddenly summoned to become “Walkers”, and they needed to clear the tower to save the world.

.

.

Floor 77:

The “Stone of Regression” was discovered. Walkers could now “return” to the past. Slowly... everyone left.

.

.

Humanity’s last hope, “Carpe Diem”, was formed, joined by people who refused to abandon the world.

.

.

The last Walker reached floor 100. He no longer knew what to believe.

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Comments on the novel chapters for the last week.

(4 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 247: Ouroboros (3) - Epilogue

- 1
Reading_Steiner
Reader
4h

This is the story of a human who chooses not to regress. For those who want to read the Novel, Manhwa episode 95 and onwards progress differently from the novel and there are some changes so you can start from 111. But my suggestion is that you start from the beginning. I wish everyone a good day and a good reading.

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 7
smokinalldeads
Reader
2mo

the nightmare of beginnings was created by sewrin as shown in the ch247 and when jaehwan entered the tower of beginnings (which was created at the start of the loop by sewrin in the past) he could only enter with his 10 year old self because it represents the beginning of the cycle (66666) and himself because it represents the end of the cycle. Now in the nightmare of beginnings jaehwan creates the story of the world after the fall and believes in it making it real. The nightmare of beginnings is the actual start of everything (reality) because we see that jaehwans friends tp with him back to reality. The

nightmare of beginnings were built with old roots of the old cycle and basically represents the restart of the cycle and the ending of the old cycle. So basically the nightmare of beginnings jaehwan enters (after killing big brother) is actually the tower that sewrin built from a past cycle or more accurately the start of the cycle The tower she built rn creates the tree and cycle

Edited: 2mo

[Reply](#)

1 0

o 1

OnceILikedHTTYD

[smokinalldeads](#)

Reader

22d

The most complicated novel read so far .I like that every idea of power attaining and opposition between them can be related to many things in our lives and is metaphysical interpretation on what happens in our lives.

[Reply](#)

1 0

• 1

tribluation

Reader

3mo

i'm gonna read this but the manhwa is already at like 150 chapters so for the novel to only have 247 I wonder how quick it's gonna end 🏴‍☠️ uh can someone tell me the chapter the mc fights the 5th of the seven stars

Edited: 3mo

[Reply](#)

3 0

◦ 1

pangubiology

[tribluation](#)

Reader

3mo

it diverges a lot from the manhwa id recommend starting ch
113/121

[Reply](#)

0 0

• 1

Yuki312

Reader

3mo

Where do i start for the 8th floor on metabus?

[Reply](#)

0 0

◦ 1

pangubiology

[Yuki312](#)

Reader

3mo

the manhwa diverges a lot after ch 121 theres no metabus

[Reply](#)

1 0

• 38

Teck877

Reader

9mo

I remember reading the first few chapters and finding them particularly difficult to understand, I guess it's time to give it a second chance.

[Reply](#)

4 0

◦ 3

Dacasick

[Teck877](#)

Reader

5mo

How was it?

[Reply](#)

0 0

▪ 38

Teck877

[Dacasick](#)

Reader

5mo

It's still on my list of novels to read.

[Reply](#)

3 0

▪ 14

ShurikanShadowscapes

[Teck877](#)

Reader

4mo

Having read it, it's a bit strange. The various different powers and abilities do get fleshed out and more easily understandable as the story goes. Having said that, it is still a very weird novel, and I don't know how exactly to put why it felt weird into words. I don't regret reading it, but I'm not sure if I would read it again.

[Reply](#)

2 0

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- 1
sidp2201
Reader
9mo

Holy f*ck... this was a journey ... The novel started in a completely different way to the way it ended. While there were scenes which were disjointed over the chapters creating some [chaos], it has a huge [depth] to it. The story feels incomplete as it does not really have a "and everything was well" ending, but it is not. It is not just about the protagonist going from strong to stronger, this is a phycological thriller and gives an [unique world] view to the reader.

[Reply](#)

6 1

- 11
libetsdelay
Reader
10mo

if you guys enjoyed orv, definitely check this novel out since it's more of a short read and has veryyy similar themes to orv. to me it felt like a rough draft of orv since you'll see connections between the two novels. but yeah this was an incredible story that gives you a lot to think about (cycles, ego, present>past, revolution, etc.) however i

think development within the characters was a bit lackin besides jaehwan, so i personally had an issue getting attached to any of them. but yeah maybe if this novel was longer and fleshed out, it would have the potential to be on par with orv but orv is just a masterpiece.

[Reply](#)

11 1

o 1

Hamood000

[libetsdelay](#)

Reader

3mo

Felt nothing like Orv in here, But ill say, it's definitely peak.

[Reply](#)

1 0

▪ 11

[libetsdelay](#)

[Hamood000](#)

Reader

3mo

right orv is just too good tbh nothing rlly on its level unless you got any recs

[Reply](#)

1 0

▪ 1

Hamood000

[libetsdelay](#)

Reader

3mo

well its either lord of the mysteries or reverend insanity

Reply

0 0

○ 1

Simples

libetsdelay

Reader

5mo

What work is this orv?

Reply

0 0

▪ 11

libetsdelay

Simples

Reader

3mo

orv = omniscient reader's viewpoint, its the author's more popular work and wonderfully written story

Reply

0 0

○ 9

Alan2020

libetsdelay

Reader

7mo

There's a manwha on it try that

Reply

0 0

- 11
libetsdelay
[Alan2020](#)
Reader
7mo

yeah i have but now its diverting from the novel soooo

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 9
Alan2020
[libetsdelay](#)
Reader
7mo

Oh.

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 3
Jakers
[libetsdelay](#)
Reader
10mo

they're both written by the same dude

[Reply](#)

7 0

- 11
libetsdelay
[Jakers](#)

Reader
8mo

ik im saying that they're definitely similar beyond just the writing style 😭

Reply

2 0

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- 5
kadenless
Reader
11mo

the crossovers between twatf and orv are the best.

Reply

4 0

- 19
remonwater
Reader
11mo

Why am I just now learning that the orv author wrote this and that there is a small crossover. I'm gonna have to read immediately

Reply

7 0

- 13
Polle
[remonwater](#)
Reader
9mo

what's your resume?

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 16
ARS404
Reader
11mo

This novel is great. This novel is bullshit. Read it

[Reply](#)

9 0

- 11
libetsdelay
[ARS404](#)
Reader
10mo

ouroboros!

[Reply](#)

5 0

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Chapter 1: Prologue

"Hey, if any one of y'all want to go back to the past, lemme know. I'll kill y'all."

-From the records of [[Carpediem]]

Prologue. Carpediem

A sky hidden by the sky-soaring towers.

Various ruined structures. Faint sounds of moans and screams. Explosive smoke everywhere.

And continued silence.

Needless to say, this was the world after the apocalypse.

You all might know of this. I will not go into the details, but you will understand once you read the history.

Year 2018.

Enormous structures, or the [[Tower of Nightmares]], appeared in the skies of various cities around the world, including Seoul.

...I just realized it's a ton of work to go through every date. Besides, there are all sorts of similar fantasy novels that consist of similar stories, and that makes me wonder if I even need to explain everything.

But this'll make it simpler, so I'll continue on for a bit.

I should at least explain why mankind reached such an end.

As you might know, the beginning was calm.

In 2018, an enormous structure called the [[Tower of Nightmares]] appeared in the sky above the city. The tower did not state anything nor did it explain itself, but the humans began talking. There were rumors and speculations that the end had come.

Then the tower called upon humankind.

[[Tower Walkers]]

The ones who were later referred to as Walkers.

These people were summoned by the tower's 'message' and they had earned the power and right to climb it. This was the message: 'Accept the summon if you want to stop the extinction of mankind.' And thousands of people responded to it.

It was about a ten thousand to one ratio if one considered the entire population, but it was still fortunate. There were that many people who were willing to do what it took to save mankind.

But the information extracted from the Tower of Nightmares showed various rewards for climbing up the tower, which probably had attracted a lot of people too.

Anyway, these people then received the power called the [[Interface System]] that allowed them to earn items and skills just like a game to climb up the Tower of Nightmares.

People were not so eager to climb, however. There was the possibility of encountering various dangers and the human extinction that the tower mentioned was also very vague.

That was when the First Tower Impact occurred.

The tower let some monsters loose to kill the inhabitants below, killing one-third of the Earth's population.

Now, you might know what happened afterward.

Those Walkers were given an important task to climb up the tower for the sake of humanity.

But this story full of clichés does not end here.

Year 2023

A revival item, [Returning Stone], was found.

Just like the name said, it worked exactly as indicated.

Now you'll know what this story is about. Yes, it's a story that everyone might know.

Just when the world was about to end, the main character accidentally found the item that would take him back to the past.

With the discovery of the [Returning Stone], there came the truth behind the story that might've only existed in novels.

Time traveling back to the past.

It was a good thing, but there was a problem.

"Dammit! I'll just go back then!"

"Yeah! We're screwed this time!"

"Me too!"

"F*ck it! Me too!"

Too many had gone back to the past.

Jaehwan spoke as he saw a group of people turning into light as they disappeared.

"There they go again..."

"..."

"Is that the last of them?"

"Probably."

Yoonhwan answered as he watched them. They were watching those lights disappearing from the 98th floor of the tower.

Those lights that disappeared through the sky were as beautiful as meteors.

The light that had hope on the new life of the past.

They would now forget every hour they spent in this ruin and start life anew in the peaceful past.

The safe, peaceful life that everyone once knew.

"Good."

"No way."

Jaehwan understood why people would want to go back to the past.

They all probably had their own stories.

Everyone would've wanted to become the 'main character' of the world.

But it made Jaehwan wonder.

Did they even think about it once? The fate of people who would continue to live in the world that they had abandoned?

It had been 10 years since the discovery of the [Returning Stone]. Other than the Walkers who were killed, all the remaining Walkers went back. Thousands of them gave up on the chance to save mankind and returned to the past.

The [Returning Stone] was the reward on the 77th floor.

It was a giant stone that blocked the pathway to the 78th floor.

Everyone later realized that this giant stone was actually an item.

The item had the following properties:

[Item Details]

Name: Returning Stone

Rank: Legendary

Description: Sends the user back to the past when the user was summoned. The user's memory stays intact. The stone is broken into pieces for use.

Nobody believed it at first. Although the items that the tower gave were fascinating, it seemed too good to be true.

But people were tempted.

These Walkers were those who had experienced various supernatural phenomenon in the tower. But most Walkers were without skills or the items they sought. These kinds of Walkers were tempted.

Start all over again with every piece of knowledge they'd acquired?

"If we can break it down to pieces... everyone probably can take it!"

The first one who used the stone was Sword Panic, or Hwang Inchan, the leader of the front-line adventure group [[Blade Walker]].

"It might be fake so I'll test it beforehand and let you know."

And that was his last words. Jaehwan was there when he said it.

'Everyone was fooled.'

It didn't make sense. If it really took him back to the past, then there was no way for him to come back to let everyone else know.

But it was enough to make people panic.

"Is it true? Did he really go to the past?"

Some were skeptical but there were a lot who took the pieces for themselves. Inchan never returned.

Thus, the people were curious.

Why isn't he reappearing in this world? Why is the world still the same?

The answer came from the team's sole Japanese member and the middle-school's science teacher Sakamoto.

"Maybe it's only natural."

He explained the multi-universe theory and the parallel universe theory, going through the possible outcomes. According to some theories, it seemed that their history probably had parted ways from Inchan's world.

"Inchan must have returned successfully, but the world he returned to had divided into another route where we will never meet him again."

Most of the people were not very science-literate so they couldn't understand much.

But two things were certain.

One was that Inchan did return to the past, and him going to the past did not change the current world.

"Hey, is there a possibility that Inchan was transferred to elsewhere?"

"Look at the description on the stone. As far as I know, item descriptions have displayed any lies to this date."

What Sakamoto said was true.

"I think it will send us all back to the world, but its all theoretical so we can never be sure."

And like that, half of the leading expedition team went back to the past. If they were to fall into the same time period as others, they wanted to be a step ahead and be top of the others who had also gone back to the past.

That was when mankind began yearning for 'time travel to the past.'

Everyone began thinking about what to do if they returned to the past.

There were some who thought it'd be better to go back faster while others thought it was better to try getting to the higher floors beforehand. There were some who even took advantage of the stones and sold it to the Walkers on the lower floors.

Then, the Second Tower Impact occurred.

It was the disaster that unleashed terrible monsters from the towers to the ground. It killed almost all of mankind except Walkers who were on the tower.

The Walkers were left with one of two choices.

Pay whatever it takes to get their hands on the [Returning Stone] to go to the past, or stay and die. But Jaehwan chose neither of the options.

"Damn idiots. Stop going! What will become of this world if you all go?"

Even with the best, front-line team [[Blade Walker]]'s dismantle, Jaehwan and a few of his friends proceeded further to higher floors.

Then they were stuck on the 85th floor. Most of Jaehwan's friends were killed. There was no going forward.

Jaehwan began persuading and training other Walkers coming from below. He handpicked individuals who might not be tempted by the [Returning

Stone].

The final assault team [Carpediem] was created.

The final team that stayed behind to protect the world.

Jaehwan led the team and broke through the 85th floor.

They went up and up.

There were some casualties and some went back to the past.

But they persevered.

And so, they reached the 98th floor.

Jaehwan blamed the Walkers who returned to the past. If even half of them stayed, the world would not have ended this way. Even after multiple tower impacts, mankind persevered. Many were dead and wounded, but they still somehow managed.

But they were at the limit.

Only two [Carpediem] members remained.

Jaehwan did not give up.

"Let's go, Yoonhwan."

As far as he knew, the 100th floor was the tower's last floor.

There were only two more floors.

Two more floors until the end of this hellish age.

The humankind would be freed. The world would be given another chance.

Or that's what Jaehwan thought. Or what he believed.

"Yoonhwan?"

No answer.

"Hey."

One of the final members. Smile Knight, Kim Yoonhwan.

He smiled even during the worst times, and thus the members gave him such a name. But he wasn't smiling now.

"Wait..."

Where did he get the stone? Jaehwan glanced at the small stone that Yoonhwan was holding.

"You... are you going to the past also?"

He couldn't believe it. Yoonhwan lowered his head and Jaehwan tried to jump at him, but he suddenly turned his back on him.

"...Go."

"I'm sorry, Jaehwan."

"Go away. Before I change my mind."

Jaehwan walked toward the gate to the 99th floor while Yoonhwan watched his back.

It had been the back that he followed all the way here.

The gate opened and Jaehwan walked in. As he disappeared, Yoonhwan staggered and set himself up against the pillar of the tower.

His breath began to grow heavy as blood streaked down between his clothes.

There was a small hole around Yoonhwan's chest.

It was the wound from the boss monster, Giltikas.

It wasn't something that a mere potion could heal. Only a rare-ranked Priest would be able to heal it but there were no more Priests left in this world. His best friend would have noticed the stone he was holding wasn't a [Returning Stone] immediately. Yoonhwan tightly held onto the stone. He felt the cold, rough edges. It was something he could only feel in this world.

He had learned this from Jaehwan.

He had learned how to clutch this rough, worthless life and never let it go.

But it was time to let it go.

Yoonhwan walked to the edge of the tower and stood there.

"It was nice to have known you, Jaehwan."

Then his body disappeared off to the clouds and Jaehwan stopped as he opened the gate to the 99th floor. He used his right hand to wipe off his face. He waited until he stopped shivering and started to calmly breathe again. But he did not look back. He walked up toward 99th floor alone.

His world was not yet finished.

Chapter 2: Millions of Stabs (1)

Ten years passed by. It had been a long time. Jaehwan had spent all that time alone on the 99th floor.

He had gone through thousands of dangers that almost killed him. He faced many dangerous situations as he climbed from the 1st floor to the 99th floor, but the number of dangers he faced just on the 99th floor easily took the cake.

The boss of 99th floor, Velkibus.

The dragon that came from [Forgotten Land] had a breath attack that Jaehwan could not resist even with his [Frost Resistance] that hit its maximum.

Not only that, the durable dragon scales had crushed swords and armor many times. If it wasn't for the pieces of equipment left behind by the other Walkers, he would have had to give up a long time ago.

The Dragon Sword from 85th floor, the Frost Armor that Yoonhwan left behind, the [Bracelet of the Fire King] that Seoyul gave him before she died had been a huge help.

Han Seoyul.

Jaehwan thought of her. She had died even before she got up to the 77th floor.

Jay, the blacksmith of Atopos asked, "Jaehwan, are you going to try again?"

The village that formed after killing Monster Dragon Alteminas of the 50th floor, Atopos.

People of the world still had hope when the village was formed. Many Walkers were killed and wounded on the frontlines, but it still gave them hope. Priests formed an emergency team to heal the wounds while blacksmiths worked to provide free repairs to those who fought.

[Jay's Blacksmith] was run by old man Jay and it was one of the best.

But he was now the last blacksmith left in Atopos.

"Jaehwan?"

"Oh, right. Sorry."

Jaehwan came back to his senses.

"Yeah. I think I can do it this time."

"Are you sure?"

Jaehwan smiled. "Yeah."

It was a lie. He had no chance. He had no idea when, or if he could kill it. But he had to say it this way. Jay laughed.

Jay was a foreigner.

As people got up on the tower, their languages were combined into the common language of the tower, but the cultural differences still remained. But Jaehwan considered Jay like a family. Jay hammered the Dragon Sword as he talked to Jaehwan.

"There are no more supplies coming from below. It wasn't a lot but there was some coming up until a few months ago."

Jaehwan nodded. Last week, he had checked out every floor starting from the 1st to 99th floor. But there were no survivors. He even had waited a week at the summoning area of the 1st floor but there wasn't even one who was summoned from below.

It probably meant that mankind had been wiped out. But it seemed possible.

Jaehwan did not know what the year was. There had been at least ten Tower Impacts and there probably was no one who could survive. Jaehwan managed to find one clue that was considered as a hidden piece.

The passage that used to be blocked by [Returning Stone] in the past, had some scribbling.

-Tower within the tower. A nightmare within the nightmare.

He couldn't understand it, however.

"Oh and ol' granny from [Hiren Potion] disappeared the other day."

"Hiren..."

Hiren, the ol'granny from [Hiren Potion] was one of the last supporter Walker remaining at Atopos. The ones who came into the tower did not age. If she disappeared, it was only one of two reasons.

Either the one went to the past, or jumped off.

Jaehwan wanted to ask which option Hiren took. But it probably was the same even if he knew. Then Jaehwan saw something deep within Jay's old eyes. It seemed he will not see Jay for much longer also.

"Jay, can you teach me the blacksmith skill?"

The hammering stopped and both men looked at each for a moment.

Jay nodded silently.

Back to the 99th floor.

The Frost Dragon Velkibus was astonished at the human who had come again.

-You are one of a kind. No humans have come to the 99th floor alone until now.

Jaehwan laughed. It was ironic that his hard work was being recognized by such monsters instead of mankind.

"I'll be sorry to kill you."

-I'm sorry to say that is impossible, human.

"No way. That scale of yours is cracking, didn't you notice?"

The dragon roared and Jaehwan charged with his sword in front.

It was a simple attack.

'Stab'.

Jaehwan had started climbing the tower much later than others. It made him miss out on the chance to get hidden skills or classes so Jaehwan gave up on everything else and concentrated on the 'Stab' skill.

He stabbed, stabbed and stabbed.

After about 50 million stabs, people began calling him 'Jaehwan the Persistent Stabber.' And that's when he felt his [Stab] changing. It became faster and more accurate. It had become stronger.

60 million, 70 million... and 100 million times.

His basic [Stab] skill now had become powerful enough on par with even rarest of hidden skills. Also, it was only a basic move so it did not require him to use his mana, which made him attack endlessly.

But it was not enough to handle the Frost Dragon of the 99th floor. He barely made a scratch when he stabbed one point of the scale hundreds of times. But there were times when he managed to damage the scale with one strike.

'There, I see it again.'

His sight became blurry and his stabbing changed its power. It was not fast, but not slow. But the stab wasn't avoidable.

"KAAAAAA!"

The Frost Dragon roared in pain.

He couldn't remember but this occurred rarely. Maybe out of one in hundred thousand times, he saw a faint line on his sight. He followed it without thinking. If he were successful in following the line, his stab managed to inflict an attack that equaled thousands of attacks.

'Dammit, it's still not enough.'

The dragon took a deep breath and released it, filling the tower. It was a critical strike to Jaehwan who was already in bad shape. His health was dropping rapidly toward 0. Jaehwan barely managed to avoid the breath.

-It is unfortunate, human. If there were 10 more like you, you might have defeated me.

"Shut up."

-If your foolish race wasn't tempted by the [Stone of Nightmare]... it would've changed the fate of your race.

"Huh? Stone of Nightmare? What do you mean?"

The dragon did not answer, instead, its huge claw swung at him.

"...I will come back."

Jaehwan jumped backward to run and Frost Dragon did not go after him.

Five more years had passed by.

[Legend Incarnate: You have succeeded in hunting 'Frost King Velokisus']

[You have achieved an impossible feat alone.]

[Acquired a new title: 'Nightmare of the 99th floor']

[Acquired weapon: 'Frost Dragon Sword']

[User's level has reached the limit.]

[User's HP has reached the limit.]

[User's Strength has reached the limit.]

[User's Dexterity has reached the limit.]

The gigantic dragon's body was disappearing.

-You... really are amazing, human.

"Speak. What is the [Stone of Nightmare]?"

-You know the answer to it.

Jaehwan did not want to believe it. He needed to learn more.

-You will know everything once you reach the final floor.

The Frost Dragon did not speak anymore. As Jaehwan finished while it disappeared completely, he stood up and looked at the gate to the last floor. It had been so hard to even kill the Frost Dragon so he couldn't imagine what might be waiting for him on the final floor.

But he did not stop.

[[100]]

Jaehwan checked on the number at the gate. It was covered with dust, but he reached out to clean it off. Many memories flashed by him as he looked at the number.

'Jay would be proud.'

Jaehwan opened up the gate.

The 100th floor of the tower looked like an emergency operating room from various horror movies, but on a much larger scale. Thousands of hologram panels showed various places of the tower and some of them were showing Jaehwan.

The Jaehwan in the hologram screen seemed dumbfounded.

"Oh, you're here already. I thought you were going to stop by the village first."

Jaehwan grew tense and looked around. But there were no signs of any humans.

"Relax, relax. I forgot to send you an important message, stay where you are. These look fancy but they're really archaic so I have to do some manual work."

After a few moments, a screen popped up in front of Jaehwan.

[Congratulations. You are the first to clear the tutorial game of World 294.]

[Your achievement will be recorded in the Immortal Library of the [Akashic Records]. Only the lords of the [Great Lands] will be granted access to the records.]

Jaehwan grew confused.

'What the hell is going on?'

Chapter 3: Millions of Stabs (2)

Tutorial game?

So everything had been only a tutorial?

Through the various floating hologram panels, a figure walked out.

"Whew, there we go.... OH?"

The figure looked at Jaehwan.

"WOW! We finally meet!"

The figure was a man in a suit with the head of a lion. He even had a gentleman's hat on him. The lionhead spoke.

"I'm surprised! You came all the way here alone! This has never happened before!"

"...What is the meaning of this nonsense?"

"Whew - what a fearsome man! Still eager to fight, eh? You sure are the Walker who received the attention of all the lords of the [Great Lands]!"

"Who the hell are you?"

"Right! Gotta mind my manners."

The lionhead then took off his hat and bowed gracefully.

"I'm the Demon, Beastlain. I'm the master of the [Tower of Nightmares], which you just completed and I'm the master of World 294's tutorial game."

Game. Tutorial game. He had not been mistaken. All of it, which wiped out mankind, had only been a tutorial. Jaehwan couldn't say anything. He was fighting a cacophony of emotions. Part of him told him to accept reality while part of him wanted to go mad.

After a while, he came back to his senses. No, he came back armed with a colder look in his eyes.

Beastlain seemed impressed.

"Oh? You recovered pretty quickly."

Jaehwan expressionlessly looked at Beastlain. If he couldn't withstand the shock, he wouldn't have made it this far alone.

"If this is a tutorial, does that mean there's a main game waiting for me?"

"OH HO! You sure are quick to understand! Most Walkers who manage to finish either tried slashing their sword at me or went mad."

"What's the main game?"

"It's as you expect."

Beastlain then let out a horrible, eerie laugh and snapped his fingers. Then the hologram panels immediately showed various screens.

[1st Floor]

Jaehwan was standing within a group of many.

"What is this? This is just like a game."

It was the first time Jaehwan was summoned.

[7th Floor.]

Three people were forming a party. Someone started speaking.

"I'm Yoonhwan. She is Seoyul."

It was the first time he met Yoonhwan and Seoyul.

[32nd Floor]

Jaehwan had just managed to survive through the 'Shadow Cavern Trials' for a month.

It was the first time when his [Stab] had become powerful.

[54th Floor]

Jaehwan was standing there and there were people around him.

"I'm Jaehwan. I'm from Seoul and my class is a Swordsman."

Then he joined [Blade Walker].

[66th Floor]

While he was fighting the boss monster Succubus, he looked at the woman next to him.

It was first time he fell in love.

[76th Floor]

Among the bones of undead, Jaehwan wailed as he held on the woman.

He felt heartbreaking pain. It was when he lost Seoyul to the Death Knight's attack.

[77th Floor]

People disappeared with the lights. Enraged.

It was when the [Returning Stone] was found and [Blade Walker] had disbanded.

[85th Floor]

Shout of people who just cleared it.

Day of beginning of [Carpediem]

[98th Floor]

Monster Giltikas

When he became alone after losing Yoonhwan.

[99th Floor]

When he just killed Frost Dragon while ago.

"This..."

Jaehwan could not speak. Everything he had done all this time had been recorded.

"It was an epic drama that went on for 30 years! I was glad to have you! You know, if you stay here while doing the same thing over and over again, it's refreshing to see a story of a man like you! I'm almost certain that the lords of the [Great Lands] would have been delighted while they looked at your story."

Beastlain explained eagerly.

'Who are those lords and the [Great Lands]?''

Jaehwan had lot to ask but he held on to it.

"What's your point?"

"It's simple. You can now, start the game all over again." Beastlain continued, "With all the memory of course. It's the privilege only given to the man who cleared the tutorial game! Isn't it wonderful? It's something

only exists in a novel in your world! The one who starts anew with all the memory! Isn't it great? Isn't it tempting? How do you like it?"

Jaehwan became dumbfounded. He said it was a reward. But wasn't the reward of clearing the tower salvation of mankind? Or what exactly was the reward for reaching the top? Did the tower speak of it?

It did not.

The tower never said a word about a 'Final Reward'.

It only had been mankind's wish. They automatically thought, just like in other usual games, if they cleared the tower, they would be granted salvation.

The purpose just appeared on top of their heads and only thing mankind was able to do was to try to get to the purpose.

And there it was. The final reward, awaiting in front of Jaehwan. Only given to Jaehwan.

"So you want me to do everything I did all over again?"

"Well, you can say that. But with slight differences, of course."

Jaehwan couldn't understand what was going to happen. He had been fighting only to save this world. To save the world whereas everyone had abandoned it. The purpose that kept him sane as a human being. But after he was successful in clearing it, the only thing remaining was him wanting to give up on the world.

"So... you want to send me back to the past." Jaehwan's voice grew cold, "If you've been watching me, then you should know. I'm not going to the past."

Beastlain became confused.

"Past? Are you talking about the past?"

"Yes."

Then came the maniacal laughter.

"What's so funny?"

"HAHAHA! RIGHT! You are absolutely right. You are the type that will never go to the past! Otherwise, you would not have made it this far. HAHAHAHA!"

Beastlain laughed maniacally for while longer. He then suddenly stopped abruptly.

"I will tell you a truth. One that is very brutal, but very accurate."

He began explaining in a cold, eery voice.

"No item within or outside this tower, not even the one at the [Great Lands], can send you back in time."

Chapter 4: Millions of Stabs (3)

No way to go back in time?

"What do you mean? There must be an item that sends you back in this tower..."

Then Jaehwan realized.

Beastlain said that there were no items that could send anyone back in time. He also explained that Jaehwan could start from the beginning. It didn't make sense. But there was one thing would allow all of this to make sense.

66th Floor.

Jaehwan had fought Succubus, the lesser version of [Nightmare].

The team had spent a lot of time to defeat the monster. The illusion that made by Succubus caused weak-minded Walkers to fall. The floor had become an orgy. Walkers who were trapped in the dreamland created by Succubus raped each other time and time again.

Jaehwan knew its power first hand. He almost raped the female Walker next to him because of it.

"Stone of Nightmare."

Beastlain narrowed his eyes.

"How do you know that item? That's the information you can't get."

"The Frost Dragon told me."

"Oh ho! That's troubling. You should not know about it yet!"

Beastlain mumbled quietly.

"...This is why AI algorithm needs the best considerations! Those stupid [Creators]. It's because they made a stupid number of those monsters without thinking!"

Jaehwan spoke as he watched Beastlain mumbling to himself.

"So those who used the [Returning Stone] did not go to the past."

Beastlain turned to Jaehwan and paused. He then answered.

"Well, I guess since you are the first Walker to clear the tower alone, you have what it takes to know. Yes, you are right on that."

Beastlain snapped and the screen changed again.

"The one you found on 77th floor was not a [Returning Stone] but a [Stone of Nightmare]. It's a stone that traps you into a dream created by the Nightmare itself. It's a very special item."

The screens showed countless Walkers. Sword Panic Hwang, Inchan... Science teacher Sakamoto... Everyone who had traveled to the past were there. They were living in a never-ending dream world, within their fantasy. Beastlain seemed to be amused by it.

"But I did not lie. You can consider that they really did go to the past... In a certain way."

Jaehwan couldn't speak. What Beastlain said was right. They were those who gave up on the present and went back. They were the ones who easily cut ties with others for themselves. They were the ones who only valued the world they wanted to see. It seemed like the same end that they might have wanted.

"Well, but you all in this World 294 are a weird race. You were all great until the 77th floor, you know? Many challenged this tower from various

worlds, but none were as successful as you. It was like all of you had tried this kind of game for a long time."

It sure was. Until they arrived at 77th floor.

"I even thought that if this progressed, the tutorial game would be cleared too easily. It was almost frightening! But the results were unexpected."

The screens showed people using the [Returning Stone] at once.

"You, the humans are probably the only race that wishes to travel back in time."

Jaehwan then mumbled as he saw the image of people disappearing into the light.

"Yeah... maybe so."

Beastlain nodded.

"So, you probably have heard enough. Let's get to the..."

Jaehwan interrupted him.

"You want me to start the game from beginning."

"Haha, you sure got that right."

"Without sending me back to the past."

"Right. It is done by..."

Jaehwan nodded.

"Yeah. Thanks to you, I now realize what this tower is."

"Yes?"

Jaehwan had been curious for long time. The enormous tower that appeared all of a sudden through the sky. And the mysterious message.

[Congratulations! You are chosen to be [Time Walker] to save the world from the will of the [Tower of Nightmares]! Do you accept the summon?]

[Yes / No]

He agreed to the summoning. That's why he was here.

Jaehwan walked up and placed his hands on the walls. He felt the cold feeling of the stone. He had spent more time within the tower than the time he had spent time on Earth. But after all this time, he had never realized that this giant structure was an [Item]. It was time to change what he knew. He closed his eyes and focused on the tower. He imagined the shape of it. Everything he had seen and experienced.

After a few moments, his head hurt. It was as if something within him had broken down. Then a window popped up with an item description.

[Item Detail]

Name: Tower of Nightmares – Tutorial Mode

Description: 2nd Creation of Nightmare [Mulack], the creator of the 'Fortress of Remorse.' Traps the one who accepts the summon into its dream world.

"This tower is a giant [Stone of Nightmare]."

Jaehwan spoke. "I was already within the 'Dream of Nightmare' created by this tower from a long time ago. From the day I accepted the summoning."

Silence fell. Beastlain was lowering his head so his face couldn't be seen. He shivered as if he cried for a seconds, then raised his head.

"HAHAHAHA!"

He laughed so hard. But his laughter now contained an anger of some kind.

"This... this is amazing! You have astonished me so many times!"

Beastlain snapped his fingers again and the screens changed. The screen was now showing the outside world.

Jaehwan was dumbfounded. The world was fine. The city, people, everything that he considered to be gone after the Tower Impact was still standing. No one had been killed yet.

"As you can see, no one among you has died yet. Isn't it troubling if all of you died before even the 'Real Game' began?"

Beastlain continued, "Haha, isn't it wonderful that no one died? I believe it's good news for you humans who form groups like 'Family' or a 'Friends'."

All the people who seemed to be Walkers were sent to hospitals to be taken care of. It seemed the government was working to protect them. Among those patients was the unconscious Jaehwan. It had been many years, but his face on Earth was still his young self.

"You had lived tens of years here, but only a month has passed in your world."

Jaehwan nodded.

'Right... this is a dream. That explains the time difference.'

But this was only true if he could trust the image shown by Demon Beastlain. He had no power to discern if this was all true. The demon already had lied to him, so he could not see what was the truth. Then all the screens turned off at once.

"Well, we have used up too much time! Anyway, I assume you realized you have nothing to lose with my offer then. You are not going back in time. You're just restarting it."

Beastlain then began punching something in the air.

"It has been a pleasure."

Something popped up in front of Jaehwan.

[Gamemaster is trying to terminate the Tutorial Game. You can return back to World 294, and join the real game with all of your memory intact. Do you accept the offer?]

[Yes / No]

Jaehwan looked at the screen and made a choice.

-You have refused the offer.

Chapter 5: Millions of Stabs (4)

"...What?"

Beastlain seemed to be disturbed.

"RIGHT! You don't think the memory is enough as a reward!"

Beastlain laughed as he slapped his forehead with his hand.

"Good. You have what it takes. What do you want? A hidden item? Hidden skill? Or information about hidden classes?"

But Jaehwan spoke the unexpected.

"I don't want anything."

"Then why..."

For the first time, Beastlain was troubled.

"I will kill you and move onto the next floor."

Beastlain's expression changed.

"Next... floor? There is no next floor. This is the end. Why do you think there is a next?"

"Because I decided to not trust you all."

"Huh? You don't trust me? After all that proof?"

Beastlain seemed irritated.

"Besides, you can't win. You can't kill me. The difference between you who just finished the tutorial game and me, Demon Beastlain, is as different as the difference between a human and a dragon."

"That's not much."

Jaehwan spoke as he clenched the Dragon Sword from the 85th floor and the Frost Dragon Sword from the 99th floor.

72 times.

He challenged Beastlain 72 times within 2 months and he never even scratched on him. When the battle was over, he returned almost dead each time. Yet Beastlain never killed him.

He used everything he knew, every power and trick he acquired as he climbed up to the 100th floor.

Yet he was no match against Beastlain.

He took the remaining potions from [Hiren Potion] to slather onto himself and filled the tub with the holy water he got from the temple's storage and dived in it. His fatigue quickly dissipated. He also stopped by [Jay's Blacksmith].

"Jay, I'm here."

Nobody answered.

When he returned to Atopos for the first time after he had been defeated by Beastlain, the Blacksmith Shop was empty. He had learned blacksmithing skill for this very moment, but he couldn't believe it was real.

His last friend had left.

He was really alone now.

Jaehwan picked up the hammer his friend had left behind.

The 100th floor of the Tower.

Beastlain chewed on his fingernail as he watched the hologram of Jaehwan hammering his sword.

It was troubling. It was the first time something like this had happened.

The process of [Cultivating] to create the [Product] to withstand and adapt to life in the [Great Lands].

It was the first time after Beastlain had become the [Cultivator] that he faced such a problem.

'I have to endure it... he's the precious [Product]. A very special one indeed.'

He had installed [Tower of Nightmares] in many other worlds, but none were like him.

'Why doesn't he want to start the real game? I even offered to give him everything!'

A single Walker was now a hindrance to his entire cultivation process and Beastlain groaned.

The cultivation was divided into two parts.

First, to sort out the best quality [Products] through the 'Tutorial Game' or the [First Cultivation]. Secondly, raise those that were picked out by going through the 'Real Game' or the [Second Cultivation].

Beastlain could not start the second part of the process for three months because of Jaehwan. Unbeknownst of the frustration, Jaehwan steadily hammered the sword.

'This is crazy!'

Beastlain was tempted to kill Jaehwan and finish the game countless times throughout the day.

'Should I just kill him? But the [Harvesters] won't like it if I do...'

The Tower of Nightmares was a creation of 'Nightmares' who were usually called [Creators] that ran on the power of the Great Tree, or the [Tree of Imagery] located at the center of the [Great Lands]. It meant everything that happened within this tower was the dream created by the Tree of Imagery. This also meant that without any special way, no one who died in this dream will have its spirits die also.

But there was no telling.

The power balance between Beastlain who had acquired '3rd Adaptation' power and Jaehwan who did not even finish the '1st Adaptation' was too much. If Beastlain accidentally harmed Jaehwan's spirit, there was a chance where Jaehwan would be starting the real game with a damaged spirit.

'I can't let that happen though.'

That would surely enrage [Harvesters] or the Lords of the [Great Lands].

There were so many who already eyeing Jaehwan. There were some who were making their offers already, wary of the bid getting too high.

A Walker who cleared the 99th floor alone. This was a sole achievement not found within the entire Material World.

'They were fooled by those Nightmares with this stupid tower... what kind of control is this?'

The [Tower of Nightmares] Beastlain was controlling was the first-generation tower created by Nightmares.

'I can't end the game without the [Product]'s acceptance? What kind of system is this?'

If he had started the game with the new 3rd generation Tower, this would not have happened. It would have allowed him to start the real game without the [Product]'s agreement.

It was a shame that they had no money.

This was something they came across when they were looking for the cheapest tower. This was bought because it was told that the tower was created by a [Master]-level Nightmare. But after trying it out in the real world, it was really archaic and although it was created by a [Master] Nightmare, but it was created before the Nightmare earned the title. It did work as intended but it had small problems in a lot of places.

'I will surely bring this problem up when this is done.'

Beastlain gritted his teeth as he thought about the Nightmares who sold the tower.

Another month went by.

"Hey, aren't you tired of this?"

Beastlain yawned as he deflected Jaehwan's attack. Jaehwan stabbed on various parts on Beastlain, but he could not even touch the hair of Beastlain's mane.

"If you agree to start the game, it will be good for both of us and of course your world. Why aren't you starting?"

Jaehwan did not answer.

"I think you are misunderstanding because of your victory against the Frost Dragon. It's no use. That dragon was only a mere copy and I'm the real demon. If you really want to fight me, you need to finish the real game and spend at least tens of years at [Great Lands] to even have a chance."

Jaehwan thrust wordlessly.

"Come on! Please! What do you want? Answer me! I can give you everything you want!"

Beastlain could not understand. All this fighting had no meaning.

It meant something to Jaehwan. Jaehwan had not been idling around for the past three months. There were a few reasons he held on the tutorial game.

First, Jaehwan's spirit was changing.

Beastlain who gained access to the tower by linking to the Tree of Imagery could not feel it, but his spirit was undergoing a change.

Chapter 6: Millions of Stabs (5)

[User Details]

Name: Jaehwan

Level: 100 (At maximum level)

Title: (EX) Nightmare of 99th Floor

Class: Swordsman

Skill: (EX) Perseverance

[Status Detail]

Strength: 100 (At maximum)

Dexterity: 100 (At maximum)

Stamina: 100 (At maximum)

Will: 100 (At maximum)

Mana: 100 (At maximum)

He pulled up the screen through the Interface System. Jaehwan had tried hard to reach the limit at every end all this time. 30 years, and he had hit the maximum limit on all stats. That was when he began to think.

Can humans really be calculated with such numbers?'

After some time, he began seeing something weird. He thought it was just an illusion, but it wasn't. He realized what he saw was the nature of this world. It was sometimes a smooth particle and sometimes became rough rocks. It always seemed to be in various shapes and sizes.

That's when his stabbing became unstable.

He felt a weird sensation each time he used his [Stab] skill. The skill that he had stuck in its form in perfection, had become loose and Jaehwan felt something he had been forgetting was coming back.

It was the feeling of being 'alive.'

Jaehwan named it [Suspicion] for now. The power to look into the truth of the world. However, he had no idea how to use the power yet.

The quick thrust of Jaehwan's Dragon Sword was easily deflected. Beastlain shouted in irritation,

"Hey, Jaehwan! Talk to me!"

Jaehwan did not answer.

"Wow, this is crazy!"

Beastlain seemed frustrated.

"You are not going back! You're just starting the real game!"

The second reason Jaehwan wasn't ending the Tutorial, was the demon Beastlain.

After some time, Jaehwan realized that for some reason, Beastlain could not kill Jaehwan.

'I don't know why, but he can't force me.'

Beastlain not forcing the game to end or not killing Jaehwan right here was the proof. If he had opened the tower, he must have the power to close it,

but he didn't do so. There must be a reason why. For Jaehwan, Beastlain was just a good teacher right now. He challenged him countless times to adapt to the change happening with him.

Beastlain was growing even more frustrated.

'Dammit, the due date is coming closer!'

However, there was nothing he could do. The only thing he can do was to ask Jaehwan,

"Hey! Please, answer me!"

"Answer what?"

Jaehwan asked as he pulled away the sword grabbed by Beastlain.

"Wow, thank you! I thought you had gone mad because you didn't speak! I was worried that the precious [Product] had been damaged... uh, nevermind that,"

Beastlain stuttered.

"Good. What do you want of me? I will do anything, other than killing myself, and moving to the next floor."

Jaehwan then stopped the sword.

'There we go.'

After Jaehwan realized he had the upper hand, he had been waiting for this very moment. He had waited until the Demon in front of him become frustrated. Jaehwan waited until Beastlain could not wait any longer and took the bait.

"I need to ask you something then."

"What is it? Anything!"

Beastlain brightened up and continued,

"Do we now have room to negotiate?"

"Well, that depends on you."

The answer made Beastlain frown.

After pondering for some time, Beastlain sighed and explained,

"Don't be surprised. The universe isn't connected in just one dimension."

"I know."

"...huh? You know?"

Jaehwan scowled.

"Do you think I'm a fool?"

Jaehwan did not know much about the universe. Everything he knew about it was what he had learned from school and what he had heard from Sakamoto when he climbed the tower. But he did hear a lot of different theories about the universe.

"So, the universe is comprised of [Great Lands] and countless [Distant lands]?"

"You are right."

According to Beastlain, the universe was comprised of one main dimension called [Great Lands] and millions of other [Distant Lands]. The earth was a small planet within one of many [Distant Lands]. Beastlain called Earth as World 294. Jaehwan summarized the explanation,

"So this Tower of Nightmare is to prepare Walkers to adapt to the [Great Lands]."

"Right."

"And only the Walkers who successfully completed the Tutorial and the real game gets to move to the [Great Lands]."

"You are absolutely right. You sure grasp the idea quick."

Beastlain did not use the word [Cultivation] or [Harvest]. He knew what the product would become if he heard it. Jaehwan then asked,

"So what does adaptation do? Does it just mean getting stronger?"

Beastlain shook his head.

"No, it's to get used to the [Interface System] of the [Great Lands]."

"...the one to use skills, get items, or invest status points?"

"You can say that."

Beastlain grinned.

"Most races going to the [Great Lands] without preparation die out because they can't adjust to the system. That's why we made this [Tower of Nightmare] to help them adjust. Through the tutorial and the real game, you learn what it is like to have the system on the [Great Lands] and increase your survival rate. Demons like me work as an aid to this game."

Beastlain was careful with his explanation, but he was also astonished. He had seen no product this calm after hearing the truth about the world. All the products he had cultivated either refused to believe it or had gone mad. However, Jaehwan calmly accepted what he was hearing. It seemed like he had been born for the game. And Beastlain was satisfied by it.

"Let me ask you one more thing."

"Go ahead."

"Why are you doing 'this'?"

Beastlain smiled bitterly. He knew that Jaehwan would ask this in the end. He had cultivated thousands of products for hundreds of years. Some had become powerful beings in the [Great Lands] while some had perished to its spirit. But all of them had asked this.

-Why are you doing this?

Beastlain asked back.

"I don't get your question. Do you want to know why I manage the Tower of Nightmare?"

"Yes."

"Well, I don't think that's what you really want to know."

Beastlain grinned and continued speaking,

"Isn't it that you want to know why I brought the Tower of Nightmares into YOUR world, instead of countless other options?"

Chapter 7: Millions of Stabs (6)

Jaehwan did not answer and it made Beastlain amused. The moment he looked forward to the most was going to happen now.

"There was no reason. It's only out of a whim that I picked out your world."

A disaster that only happened because of a whim. Most [Products] could not accept this. They were devastated to hear that their race was faced with doom for such reason. Most speculated that it somehow had a grand reason or a grand being behind it. But there was no such thing.

It was all out of coincidence. On a whim.

"...a whim?"

"Yes. I just happen to came across your world and started the game. There's no reason for choosing your world. It just kind of happened. Just like how you were born in your world."

Beastlain continued.

"You might be considering yourself unfortunate. You must be sad that a demon like me came to your world and killed your people."

Jaehwan did not answer.

"Think about it. Even if I didn't come here, do you think your race will live on for eternity? No way. You will all die in due time. All beings in the universe dies soon or later."

Beastlain continued. He was now getting to the climax. He will now be given with the face of a despaired [Product] who could not face reality. This

was what Beastlain loved the most.

"In that case, you can consider yourself lucky. At least you have received a chance to move onto the new world. It had made all the death very worthwhile. You will get a chance to move on to the [Great Lands] and challenge to become a..."

"That's enough. Let's skip the boring stories."

"...What?"

Beastlain could not believe what he was hearing.

"What I'm wondering about isn't that."

"But..."

"It seems like you've misunderstood. Let me ask you again, clearly."

"P-Please. Go on."

The reins of the discussion had been passed on.

"What I want to know is that why are you managing this tower. What kind of reward do YOU get by doing this?"

"T-that..."

Beastlain was shocked. This [Product] didn't seem to budge at his explanation and asked about the vital point without getting swayed.

"...It's just- just volunteering. Someone needs to do it, so here I am. Haha."

The awkward smile made Jaehwan narrow his eyes.

'Volunteer?'

Jaehwan looked at the particles floating above Beastlain and thought. As his [Suspicion] skill got stronger, he was now able to distinguish various

particles. Some stood in its place while some moved about actively. The particles that floated above Beastlain were very distinguishable. They touched Beastlain and moved in some kind of formation, and disappeared toward the outside of the tower quickly.

To Jaehwan, the formation seemed like a word. It seemed Beastlain was talking with someone from afar.

'Lord... ..sends... message...'

'Product... cultivation... harvest... yet...'

'Don't kill... the product...'

'The land... not... conversation...'

'You can't... due date... no time...'

Jaehwan spoke again.

"...Hmph. Let's go back to the story then."

"Okay."

Beastlain felt sweat running through his back.

"You spoke of a 'Lord' back then."

"Yes, I did."

It finally came. Beastlain had never spoken with a [Product] this long before finishing up the real game, so he was being extra careful that he did not make a peep about cultivation or harvesting and such.

"Who are they? Are they Kings?"

"It's similar. They are the rulers of the [Great Lands]. The one who enters the [Great Lands] will be offered to join the forces of the Lords."

"...Forces?"

Beastlain noticed Jaehwan's interest. No [Product] had ever shown interest in the Lords of the [Great Lands]. Choosing the right Lord changed their future.

'You still are a Product after all.'

Beastlain grinned and continued.

"Not all of them will be offered. Only the strongest will be offered... but I'm sure you will be offered by the strongest of the Lords."

To put confidence into the [Product]. That was the first step. But Jaehwan seemed emotionless. Beastlain became wary of it, but continued anyway,.

"If you follow my guidance, with the honor of the demon, I will swear that I help you on your future. It means I will do my best to have you sent to the best of the Lords. Of course, that's only if you clear the real game."

Jaehwan's mouth almost came to a scoff.

'He sounds like an insurance salesman.'

Jaehwan paused for a long moment, then asked, "How can you prove that you are not lying?"

Beastlain seemed to think Jaehwan had fallen for it, that his mouth turned into a faint grin.

"You don't need to trust me if you don't want to. I explained everything I can. There's no more."

Jaehwan nodded.

"Okay. I will do as you say."

"Did you finally make up your mind?"

"Exactly 10 days. In 10 days, I will get out of this place."

Chapter 8: Millions of Stabs (7)

9 days later.

Beastlain was lying on the ground, watching through hologram panel, cursing with all kinds of foul words. The panel displayed Jaehwan.

"Haha... f*ck."

Jaehwan was still hammering on the sword.

"...that evil sh*t."

Next to Beastlain was a pile of information that consisted of the [Great Lands] that Jaehwan requested. It did not contain anything about cultivation, the process of it, the [Product], or the Harvesters.

'I hope he doesn't recognize it.'

Demon Beastlain.

Ranked 8152nd among the Demons, or a middle-rank Demon.

His friends in the Material World called him the [Gentleman of Deception].

It was a shame for a Demon with such a name to have a hard time against a pitiful human. He would be teased for the next hundreds of years by his friends if they knew about it. Without the message he received from the harvester, it would have been easier.

[Do not kill the Product and have him face the real game. It is an amazing achievement to clear the 1st generation tower's hellish difficulty alone. It is rare, even within the Great Lands. If the cultivation is successful, he will

become an extra-special grade Product. If you damage his spirit due to your lack of attention, we will never make a deal with you in the future.]

'I'm almost there... almost...'

Beastlain then called up another screen.

[Activating communication network: [Little Brother]]

'Let's see... what video should I upload this time? Oh, yes. I should upload the moment he killed the Frost Dragon.'

The Tower of Nightmares installed in World 294 had been a huge gamble for Beastlain, but it seemed like it had paid off this time. If he managed to finish harvesting, he would be allowed to go through the 4th mort and rank up to a middle-high rank Demon.

With that, [Big Brother] would notice him and he would be offered a job as a public cultivator and he'd be able to live lavishly afterward. He was almost certain of this. Even now, the communication network [Little Brother], which was under the control of [Big Brother] was receiving countless messages.

..

['Ziegfried' the Lord of Destruction likes your video.]

['Ainix' the Lord of Gold likes your video.]

['Abraxas' the Lord of Undying likes your video.]

['Illiones' the Lord of Forest likes your video.]

"HAHAHA! Those Lords are all over it!"

It wasn't the Lords themselves that pressed on 'Like' button or sent the message. They were far more dignified beings to do that. It was probably their servants who did it under their names, but it still meant a lot. It was the

same as receiving the message from the lords themselves. This meant that all the Lords were observing his cultivation.

This was one of the luckiest events that would happen in thousands of years.

When he found Earth, World 294, he knew he was lucky. World 294 had no threats that could pose a threat to his cultivation. It was far from the Angels, the other [Cultivator], and was a place where he can connect to [Big Brother], making it easier for him to gain approval to quickly start on the work. He gained the approval from [Big Brother] and he started seeking out [Creators] right away.

'...makes me sick to think of them. Damn Nightmares.'

He would not have begged so hard under normal circumstances. He would have just rented the tower and returned it to them otherwise. Yet, this time it was different.

He had been spending modestly because he was only a middle-rank Demon, but he needed to prepare himself to reach the top ranks. He couldn't keep borrowing the tower even after he reached one of the top ranks, which would be considered humiliating.

Owning a tower. That was the dream of all Demons.

Beastlain went out to do all sorts of biddings that those Nightmares asked of him so he could get the best tower possible at the best price. He thought he got the best tower in the end.

2nd creation of the [Master] level creator, Mulack.

It was a tower that was made when he wasn't even a really old master yet, but it did prove to be a good tower.

'If not counting the devices are archaic.'

Besides, the Lords would be glad that the [Product] had been cultivated within the [Master]'s tower.

But his luck ended there.

The race of World 294 were even better [Products] than he realized. They adapted quickly as if they had known such games for a long time. This adapting ability was the key to become strongest within the Great Lands. Beastlain had met various races of 'Humans' but had never seen them adapting to the game this fast.

'Lords will love it.'

But his luck ended on the 77th floor. Something he could not understand happened. Most of the [Products] had failed by the trap at the 77th floor.

Beastlain could not believe what he saw.

'How can this be!'

Most [Products] who he seemed to fetch a good price had failed. Beastlain had despaired.

'Returning stone? Such a thing isn't even listed in the tower's manual!'

He spoke as if the [Returning Stone] was intended to Jaehwan, but he had not expected of such item. He was worried as the creator of this tower was famous for his madness but never thought such a strange trap would have existed.

He wanted to remove the item at once, but if the [Harvester] found out through [Akashic Records] that Cultivator had interfered in cultivating [Products] to create better [Products]

illegally, his credit will be crushed.

The race that threw away the present to have a chance to go back into the future.

Lords of Great Lands did not like those kinds of losers. The great beings living in a bloodbath of the war did not care about the past or the future. They only existed for the presence.

Beastlain thought his life was over, as he watched humans trying to return to the past.

He had no way to repay his debt he made to purchase to tower now. He thought about going into hiding for a long time. There were some Products remaining, but the number was not enough to clear the tower. Beastlain then increased the tower's speed of the time to its maximum and left the tower to have a Spirit Beer. He had planned on going out for one or two days, but he drank so much that he slept through a few weeks straight.

'DAMMIT!'

It was only a few weeks at the [Great Lands], but it meant tens of years at the tower. It was definite that no [Product] was remaining within.

But the unexpected happened. Cultivation was still in progress.

Beastlain quickly examined the recorded video on a hologram.

There was one human that still remained. Beastlain was in shock.

Most [Products] barely managed 10 years within the tower because their mental state couldn't handle the stress. But the [Product] had managed to survive for 30 years and was at the brink of clearing the 99th floor. His spirit was unhinged. Beastlain was shocked. And overjoyed.

'THIS IS IT! IT'S HIM!'

Clearing the infamous difficulty of 1st Generation tower alone. It was unheard of in the entire material world. It was why Beastlain had to accept every nonsense that the [Product] was doing until now. There was no telling how high of a price the [Product] might fetch him. He could not dare to damage it.

[Ignis the God of Fire, wants to send you a message. Do you accept?]

"Huh? Ignis?"

Beastlain was shocked.

"Gods too?"

Like the Lords who wanted the [Product] to increase their forces, Gods needed [Products] to become their avatars. But most Gods were in contact with beings that were called [Angels] in the Material World. Lords talked with Demons and Gods talked with Angels. That was the unmentioned rule. But it had been broken now.

[Agreed to receive a message from Ignis]

Ignis: You bastard, why do you accept it so slowly? You wanna die?

Beastlain: ...Aren't you a bit rude for an avatar? Who're you?

Beastlain became annoyed. Even if the avatar borrowed the name of the God, manner was important.

Ignis: It's me, you f*ck.

Beastlain: I don't know who you are if you don't say...

Ignis: You f*cking blind? Don't you know when you see the ID?

Beastlain: Wait... are you God Ignis himself?

Ignis: You f*cking little Demon. Do you want a piece of me for real?

Beastlain: N-no! Not at all. I am so sorry, O' Great One.

Ignis: I saw your video.

Beastlain: D-did you see it?

Ignis: Tell me straight up. Don't even think about lying.

Beastlain: ...Yes, Great one.

Ignis: You f*cked around with the mechanism, right? Or how can a f*cking human clear the 1st gen tower alone? Huh?

Beastlain: I didn't do anything.

Ignis: Don't f*cking lie to me. ...C'mon. I won't tell anyone.

Beastlain: I'm telling you the truth.

Ignis: F*ck? Okay, how much are you going to sell for it then?

Beastlain: I-I'm not selling it!

Ignis: F*CK! How much! Tell me! F*cking tell me now!

[Terminating the chat room]

[Ignis the God of Fire has sent you a message]

[Ignis the God of Fire has sent you a message]

[Ignis the God of Fire has sent you a message]

[Ignis the God of Fire has sent you a message]

[Aborting [Little Brother]]

Beastlain was shocked.

'Dammit. Even the gods are interested in him... Ignis...'

Ignis was a top-ranking god. This meant the [Product] surely was gathering a lot of attention. It made Beastlain become happy with the thoughts.

'It's tomorrow now.'

Next day, on the 100th floor of the tower.

Jaehwan read through the information provided by Beastlain and memorized it carefully. Beastlain asked, "Are you done?"

"Yeah. Thank you."

Beastlain almost shouted in joy.

'DAMMIT! FINALLY!'

Beastlain barely managed to hold back his grin.

"If you're done, shall we start?"

"Sure."

Beastlain punched something in mid-air and a familiar window popped up.

[Gamemaster is trying to terminate the Tutorial Game. You can return back to your World 294 and join the real game with your memory intact. Do you accept the offer?]

[Yes / No]

Jaehwan then pulled out his Dragon Sword.

"...What are you doing?"

"You know what it is."

-Offer rejected.

"I'm hunting you down now."

Chapter 9: Millions of Stabs (8)

Beastlain became dumbfounded and looked at Jaehwan.

"My... I was worried that you would do that. It's the first time I've met someone like you."

"I've heard similar things in the past."

Jaehwan spoke as he felt rough energy focusing into both of his swords. His immense spirit power was gathering at their tips.

"But this is my answer."

Beastlain then held up his both hands.

"Oh well, I give up. Do what you want."

Jaehwan's sword thrust at Beastlain. At that moment, a weird magical rune began to shine and sprouted black wood that bound Jaehwan in his place. It was the Black Iron Wood that existed on the 91st floor.

"I should've done this from the beginning."

"...what are you going to do? You would need my agreement or you can't end the game."

"Well, we'll find a way. Won't we?"

"You're going to torture me," Jaehwan continued. "I have gone through all kinds of hell. Do you think I will lose to torture?"

"Of course, of course. Haha." Beastlain grinned.

"I actually gave up on receiving any agreement from you a long time ago."

"What?"

"Let me ask you this time. Why do you think this tutorial will continue forever?"

"Wait..."

"Haha, you should've guessed. It has never reached this point before, but the Tower of Nightmares terminates the tutorial 100 days after it has been cleared."

'But you postponed my due date, you bastard.'

Beastlain did not speak that out loud.

"I wanted 10 more days just because I wished to end this game in a more natural and safer way. And also to stop you from doing anything stupid. You can now wait there until the tutorial ends and enjoy the new game."

It didn't seem he was lying. The tower had been slightly trembling since a while ago. It seemed that what Beastlain said was true. Beastlain felt some kind of victorious satisfaction as he looked at the face down Jaehwan. His plan had been disturbed but now, this human would accept his fate. However, it was then...

"Demon Beastlain."

"Yes?"

"You are called the Gentleman of Deception in the [Great Lands]?"

"...Right. How did you know that?"

"You have lived 784 years and worked on 128 worlds to [Cultivate] various races. Spewing your filthy lies, such as promising the [Products] that you will make sure they go to Great Lords."

"H-HOW DO YOU KNOW?!"

Beastlain seemed in shock.

"What's so surprising? Is it shocking to hear this from your [Product]?"

"How...!"

"You're thinking of selling me to the [Harvester] called the Lord of Darkness. For that, you will receive a great reward that you need to go on your 4th Mort."

Jaehwan looked up to the ceiling as he spoke. His [Suspicion] skill that he had trained for the past 100 days was working well. The particles within the tower were chattering and Jaehwan listened. [Suspicion] showed him a new world. A new world that told him a new story.

[...Lord of Darkness. The first stage of [Cultivate] will be ending soon. The deposits will be...]

[...This Product is an extra-special grade. I have never seen such a Product in my 784 years of life...]

[...After this deal is done, I will be a high-ranking Demon after my 4th mort. If you trust me through the cultivation...]

"...Who are you?"

"A [Product]. The [Product] that you raised here for over the past 30 years."

Jaehwan felt the tree binding him becoming loose. This was another power of his [Suspicion]. It allowed him to deny the presence of material and dismantle it.

"But not anymore."

Two swords were thrust into the space. Beastlain barely managed to dodge the attack, but his left arm was left with a long gash. It should be impossible. The enemy was a puny Walker who just cleared the tutorial,

while Beastlain was a Demon that finished the 3rd Mort. Only a being who passed at least the 1st Adaptation would be able to hurt him.

'Wait... Over-adapter?'

Over-adapter.

A [Product] that had grown beyond the imagination.

'How did an Over-adapter appear within my tower!'

There had been no records of an Over-adapter appearing during the tutorial. This was a top ranking talent even in the [Great Lands]. Beastlain could imagine the Lord of Darkness being overjoyed to hear this.

'But he's still at 1st Adaptation level. If I hold out for a while, the game will end.'

Beastlain bit his lip.

"This is pointless! You will be joining the game no matter what! Doing this to me is a loss!"

"We will see about that."

Jaehwan's specialty was unleashed at the tip of the Frost Dragon Sword.

Stab.

Or it was hard to even call it at that anymore. From the movement to its power, Jaehwan realized through his [Suspicion]. After countless times of using [Suspicion], he realized.

'I have [Understood] the stabbing.'

It was no more a mere thrust.

It was like a flash of lighting. Beastlain's body began spraying in blood. His eyes opened in shock.

"2nd Adaptation?!"

The speed, and the power. This wasn't possible for anyone before the 2nd Adaptation.

And throughout all history, there were no 2nd Adaptations born from the tutorial.

Beastlain was given no choice. If Jaehwan really did manage to gain the power of the 2nd Adaptation, Beastlain had to bring out his power from the material world to fight. He quickly brought his synchronization to 80% to borrow his original body's power.

Strong spiritual power covered Beastlain's body as a dark aura began swirling around him.

It was the power of a Demon of the 3rd Mort.

A Demon's 3rd Mort did have similarities to the 3rd Adaptation, but there were differences. Most adapters could not defeat Demons at the same stage. Even if the stage were the same, there was a huge difference in hands-on experience from age. A huge claw raised from Beastlain's hand swung at Jaehwan, damaging him instantly.

Jaehwan's body began bleeding like a fountain and his health dropped by half.

"SURRENDER NOW!"

Jaehwan felt his legs trembling from the terrible energy coming from Beastlain. It was definitely a Demon. There was no chance that he could win. The particles forming the tower seemed to be at their limit also.

'Is this the end?'

Jaehwan made his last attack. His perseverance was what brought him there. He kept stabbing and stabbing. How many times did he stab? 100 million times? 200 million?

The only one who knew the answer was Jaehwan's body.

9,999,999,991

9,999,999,992

9,999,999,998

9,999,999,999

10,000,000,000!

At that moment, Jaehwan saw some kind of weird line in front of him.

He had a similar experience before when he fought against the Frost Dragon on the 99th floor. Also when he had to fight to the brink of death, he found the line. And when he did, he followed the line without thinking. It showed up when he forgot about everything else.

'Is that it?'

Jaehwan shook in excitement. He released himself upon the line. All of his knowledge, his power, his experience. It was all thrown away at the line.

His body then began to crumble.

All the data that made up his body had been destroyed. The various status that formed his body, the power, strength, dexterity, skills, all other information.

Everything that formed his status was taken away from him.

State of complete void.

When all those particles disappeared, his body was left with his true spirit. It seemed like if he was reborn. He was not data. He wasn't here because of a percentage. He was a living human.

'This is it.'

Jaehwan thought.

'I wasn't a human until now.'

A light shone from Jaehwan's body and Beastlain could not do anything. It was the first time he had seen such a thing in his 784 years of life.

"What is... that?"

Beastlain realized he had been mistaken.

This wasn't [Adaptation].

The world had something more terrifying than [Adaptation].

The power that everyone avoided and hated to mention.

A power so terrible that it could do more than shake up the [Great Lands], it could actually destroy it.

The beings of the [Great Lands] called the power -

[Awakening]

Chapter 10: Millions of Stabs (9)

[Awakening].

Beastlain could not believe it, but there was no other way to describe this phenomenon. If that was not the 'Awakening,' then what was?

However, there was no time to be shocked. A countless number of sword attacks were thrown at him. The attack power was also increasing. Beastlain frantically used his claws to deflect the attacks. After blocking or deflecting every attack, and just when he thought it was over, he knew he had lost.

"....what... how can this be...?"

He felt a searing pain that seemed to rip apart his very being. His body had no visible damage, but he could feel the pain.

"Don't worry, it won't kill you. But it might be more painful to be alive."

What Jaehwan attacked wasn't the Beastlain's spirit here. He attacked the line that connected him to outside of the tower. Jaehwan did not know but this was the 'Link' that existed between Beastlain's spirit to its body.

The link was disconnected by Jaehwan's stab.

"AAAAARGH!!"

Beastlain screamed in terrible agony.

Jaehwan took a deep breath and began to speak,

"Listen carefully for the last time. Humans are not something you can sell. We are not something you can put some stupid levels or status and put a

price tag on."

The Tower of Nightmares was trembling at a visible level. Jaehwan continued,

"I will not follow the damn scenario prepared by you all. I will destroy this place and move up to the next floor. I will keep going up, and see the end of your world."

Beastlain, for the first time, felt fearful of this [Product]. Even high ranking adapters over the 4th Adaptation did not give off a feel like Jaehwan.

Awakener at the level of [Void]

A being whose status can't be shown by the system. Even Beastlain, who was the master of the tower, could not see Jaehwan's status.

[User Detail]

Name:??????????????

Title: ???????????????

Class: ???????????????

Skills: ???????????????

Beastlain shouted in pain.

"PLEASE! STOP! There... there's no next floor!"

"No, there is."

Jaehwan had been saying 'Next floor' not because he was guessing.

"I know there is."

From the 1st to 99th floor. Jaehwan had found scribbles from the passage between the 77th and 78th floor as he searched for survivors.

[Tower within the Tower. Nightmare within the Nightmare]

There were more clues like this.

On the 66th floor of the tower. There was this scribble at the back of the Succubus's chair.

[All Tower of Nightmares are copies of the 'The First Nightmare' located at the top of the 'Tree of Imagery'. I only think about one thing when I make my creations. If I borrow its powers, I will always end up with the same problem. All of my creations are just roots to maintain 'The First Nightmare'.]

Scribbles that seemed to be left by some artist. Jaehwan figured this could be a hidden clue so he took note of it. Similar scribbles were also found on the 47th floor.

[I came to this conclusion. Shouldn't we climb up to the 'Tree of Imagery'? Should we not see the secret of true creation? At the top of the 'Tree of Imagery,' shouldn't we face 'The First Nightmare'?]

He couldn't realize what it meant back then. But after Jaehwan found out about the truth of the tower, these scribbles held new meaning. He realized it right away.

These were scribbles left by the creator Mulack.

He couldn't comprehend all the words but it did give him new insights.

Tower within the Tower, Nightmare within the Nightmare.

Tree of Imagery, Roots.

The First Nightmare at the Top.

It pointed to one fact.

'The world is connected.'

It was only a theory, but enough to try out if it was true.

Jaehwan glanced at the ceiling of the 100th floor and stabbed into it. The ceiling cracked and Beastlain wailed,

"NO! MY TOWER! NOOOOOOO!"

Again, and again.

Jaehwan saw it clearly through his [Suspicion].

The great flow of energy that sent particles that allowed the tower to be maintained. From the top to bottom. This area was at the far end of an enormous network of energy flow.

Jaehwan knew if he followed the flow, he would arrive at the secret of the world.

The 100th floor was not the end.

'If this is a root, I probably can reach up through it.

The ceiling collapsed from Jaehwan's attack and a bright light began to shine through it.

"NO! If you go through that way, you will never...!"

"Good-bye."

He might have to play the real game in the future. But this was not the time. He was weak and lacking in knowledge. It was hard to fight off just one Demon. He needed to know more and become stronger.

Light embraced Jaehwan as he jumped up into it.

He was not going to travel to the past, nor would he travel back to the world he left behind.

He chose to be in the present. This was the world he chose to be in.

Chapter 11: Witch of Massacre (1)

[If you wish to become strong, climb the Tree of Imagery, only if you are confident that you will not go mad.]

-Huhyoo, Lord of Steel

Episode 2. Witch of Massacre

In the forest that seemed to be endless, the sun was high in the sky, with its heat drying up his entire body.

He could not feel how long he had been wandering.

Jaehwan wiped off his sweat as he glanced around.

'Finally.'

The footprint he found through the bushes were about the size of Jaehwan's. Even if it didn't belong to a human, surely it had been left by some form of bipedal being.

It had been a month since he broke free of the Tower of Nightmares. He had traveled through an endless forest all that time.

He wasn't sure where he was.

He must be somewhere among the [Great Lands], but he just couldn't figure out where it was. The heat of the forest made Jaehwan think it was 'Fiery Region', or one of the 12 regions from Beastlain's information about the [Great Lands], but it didn't look like it was true since it did not have the famous 'Burning Tree' of the Fiery Region.

Jaehwan then thought he would know once he met with someone. He did encounter monsters similar to what he had seen at the tower, but these monsters had some special features. They all had horns, varying from one to five.

Yet none of them were enough of a threat to Jaehwan.

The strongest one he fought so far was a five-horned wolf. It moaned in pain as Jaehwan stabbed it, but it did not die at once. After a few more stabs, it was dead.

'So the monsters are mostly weak here.'

He couldn't figure if he had become strong, or these monsters were weak. But it wasn't only monsters that he came across.

He did encounter some mysterious intelligent beings.

They were non-humans who wore white robes like ancient monks, but they had green skin and a pair of antennae on their heads.

"Worthless human### HOW DARE###"

"HOW### INSOLENT###"

He couldn't understand what they were saying, but he tried hard to speak to them as it was a rare occurrence for him to met an intelligent being. Even with his [Suspicion] at full power, he still couldn't understand their language.

"##### HORN!! #####"

They pointed and shouted at the horns of wolf that Jaehwan killed and carried on his belt.

"This?"

"####PUNY HUMAN!### HORN OF PENTAHORN!!"

"Yeah, yeah. I'm a puny human and this here is a horn."

It seemed like he was able to speak.

"#### HORN! ####"

A few of them approached Jaehwan and he felt a bit alarmed.

'Why are they coming all of a sudden?'

"####"

There was no way he could understand. They did mention something about a horn, so Jaehwan flashed it as he spoke.

"Good. I'll give you this if you tell me where this is..."

Then they attacked with their swords unsheathed. It wasn't just a threat. Jaehwan then turned to the sky. The sun-like thing was up there. It was hot.

"Hey."

He dodged.

"Antennae."

He dodged again.

"If you do that again, I'll kill you all."

And he dodged yet again.

"Die."

Soon, all of them lay dead. They bled blue blood before they died and perished to dust. Jaehwan grabbed the last surviving one by its antennae and asked,

"Let me ask. Where is this place?"

"HOW### HUMAN###"

He pulled it harder.

"Where."

"Tree of Imagery### Chaos...###"

He pulled again.

"Tell me so I can understand. What are you? Demons?"

"### WE ARE FAMOUS### NO##"

He pulled yet again.

"I told you to say it so I can understand."

"HHA### EJJJ# ARGG#"

It continuously spoke in a weird language while Jaehwan pulled its antennae, and soon its eye turned back, showing the whites. Then Jaehwan could understand what it said.

"HUMAN. KILL. YOU."

And those were its last words as it bit its tongue and killed itself, turning into white dust.

'I thought they were weaklings.'

It seemed as if it had a way to come back, since it committed suicide without any hesitation. Jaehwan was astonished, and he buried the parts of antennae on a hill, which also turned into powder and disappeared.

He couldn't get much information but he acquired something.

It was the items that the group had in their belongings.

Most of the things weren't useful but one was good. After checking it with [Suspicion], the small white bag he had on his back was as follows:

[Item Details]

Name: Small Dimensional Backpack

Description: Use dimensional space to haul various objects. Provides 2 square meters of storage space.

'It's like an inventory.'

After he got out of Tower of Nightmares, he was not allowed to use most skills that were provided by the Interface System, such as inventory. It was weird as Beastlain had said that the Interface System worked throughout all the [Great Lands].

It was maybe because of the weird experience he went through before he got out of the tower.

The feeling of his body dismantling, and reassembling into a new thing.

He could not even use his [Item Identifier] skill so he had to rely on [Suspicion] to determine the details of an item.

Anyway, the backpack was the most important thing. Jaehwan gathered everything left by those he killed.

'What is this? A jewel?'

They had well-cut crystal-like jewels. Most were blue-colored and some were red. Two of them were black, and one of them came from the last one that had committed suicide.

It might be of value so Jaehwan put it into his bag.

'I should throw these away.'

The other equipment that they had on was too big to fit in the bag. As Jaehwan was deciding on what to do, the Frost Dragon Sword at his waist began vibrating.

"Again?... Okay."

After he got out of the Tower of Nightmares, his Frost Dragon Sword had become weird. Weird black energy began radiating through its blade and kept on vibrating as if it now had a will.

It vibrated harder when it became hungry.

Jaehwan took out the sword and thrust it into a pile of equipment. Then the blade opened up like a mouth and began devouring the equipment. Jaehwan looked at it in awe. As the sword ate up the equipment, the color of the sword turned even darker. It also seemed to be increased its durability.

'Hmm...'

Jaehwan did have a speculation on what the sword had become, but it was only a guess at this stage so he decided to leave it be. There was something more important at hand. The last good thing he earned from them.

It was the map of this forest region.

It was different and crude from the map of Earth, but he had no problem using it with the help of [Suspicion]. He read the name of the map.

'How do I read this? Tree... Im... Chaos... Hm...'

The top of the map read [Tree of Imagery – Chaos]. Then he remembered Beastlain mentioning the Tree of Imagery once.

"Tree of Imagery is a huge tree located at the center of [Great Lands]. Its purpose... well, it's not important. You'll know later."

The name also appeared with scribbles left by Mulack, the creator of the tower.

[...My creation is a root to maintain 'The First Nightmare' at the top of Tree of Imagery...]

After combining of these clues, it seemed that the Tower of Nightmares was connected to the Tree of Imagery somehow, meaning the place he had arrived at after coming out of the tower was either very close to the tree or a place that was connected to the tree.

What was certain was that this area wasn't in the information that Beastlain had given to him.

'Damn Demon.'

It seemed like the races he killed were moving toward the mark on the map. It was possible that it was a village of some kind. After a long examination of the map, Jaehwan was able to make out where he was on the map.

'I need information first.'

He had been lucky to meet weaker foes, but there was no telling if it would continue to be the same. He needed to meet someone so he could gather more knowledge. He needed to consider himself as a newbie in this new world so he could survive.

But it didn't mean he would learn how to cooperate with this world.

Learn about the world, but never cooperate with it.

That was what he decided when he broke out of the Tower of Nightmares. It was also what made him break out of the tower in the first place.

'There might be someone who broke out of the tower like me.'

Jaehwan wished to see a living human if possible. He thought there might be humans living here who were freed from being a product. Beastlain spoke to him once.

'There are a lot of humans out in the [Distant Worlds]. World 294 is only one of them.'

If what he said was true, there was a possibility that humans lived in the [Great Lands].

He was curious. He was curious about how the humans in this lands lived, and what they thought about it. And what was it like to live after they left the tower?

After a long walk, Jaehwan stopped.

"Found it."

In front of the direction of the footprints was the sound of weapons clashing. He was able to see the owner of the footsteps. Through the bushes, there were about five people hunting horned monsters.

They were humans.

Chapter 12: Witch of Massacre (2)

Kanghun, an officer from the Red Fox Clan, was happy. They had found a good prey.

"Keep the formation! Do as we practiced!"

"Yes, sir!"

His teams quickly circled the monster. What they were fighting was a mid-sized 'unihorn.'

'One for now.'

They were powerful monsters found among the entire [Chaos].

Monsters named after the number of horns it had. They were called uni, bi, tri, quad, and penta-horns, according to the number of horns they had with the strength that only experienced [Adapters] in the [Great Lands] could handle.

1st Stage Adapters could handle one unihorn and the only 1st stage Adapter in the team was Kanghun.

'It's not necessary for me to step in for now.'

Parties of five were usually formed to fight a unihorn, but his party was special. Four of the party members, including Kanghun, were from the professional hunting clan, 'Red Fox'. The others were [Non-Adapters], but they were experienced unihorn hunters. They were waiting to become 1st stage Adapters.

[Leader, are you really going to continue?]

[Yeah.]

[But she seems to be fishy... are you sure?]

[Don't worry. Trust me.]

Kanghun glanced at the woman shivering at next to him. She was the only non-clan member of the party. She wore a dark silk robe to cover herself, but it didn't hide her beauty. She had bright red hair and pale white skin. She also had various trinkets and pieces of jewelry that sometimes peeked out through the robes. All of them seemed to hold great value.

'Wonderful.'

The professional hunting group, 'Red Fox.'

Most people knew of it, but they never outright mentioned what Red Fox hunted most. They hunted [Adapters]. This woman seemed to have walked into the group of hunters without knowing. They did not know where she belonged and where she came from, but Kanghun did not care. He had checked her spiritual level when he let her join their party.

'She's only a Non-Adapter.'

A [Non-Adapter] was nothing to worry about even with a good background.

She probably had acquired all those items by luring men with her beauty.

Kanghun looked at the woman with lustful eyes on her body shape that could be seen through the robe.

'You might have been able to lure those men, but it will not end up like that this time.'

Then, when a woman made some kind of mistake and screamed.

"NO! I'm so, sorry!"

"Haha. It's okay."

Kanghun answered as took the dagger out that was stuck in his leather armor.

'B*tch.'

It seemed like it was her first time coming out to hunt. She had no knowledge regarding formations and there were many incidents where she attacked the party instead. It was her who brought the unihorn they were fighting in the first place.

'I'll let it go because you're cute.'

But soon, she had brought another unihorn.

"I'm sorry!"

"No problem. Let's get'em all!"

Two was okay. Kanghun was nearing the end of the 1st stage so he was able to fight at least two unihorns by himself.

It was a good chance to kill the two of them and get the woman.

Everything seemed to be fine. Until another unihorn was brought upon them. The woman apologized.

"I'm SORRY!"

"...Be careful."

Kanghun answered as he frowned. It was hard to handle three of them at once.

'What did she do?'

Three unihorns appeared in such a short time. It seemed impossible to fight this. At least they were unihorns, so that was fortunate. If it was a bihorn...

"Oops! I'm sorryyyyyy!"

And there she was, running as she waved with the monster chasing her from beyond. The giant monster was 10 feet tall and had two horns on its head.

'...that B*TCH!'

And there was one who was watching everything.

It was Jaehwan.

'They will all die that way.'

They seemed to be fighting well against the one-horned monsters, but they started losing as soon as the two-horned one appeared. Jaehwan was disappointed. He thought people in the [Great Lands] were really powerful, but he now became curious as to how they even cleared the Tower of Nightmares.

'And they also have that weird woman.'

He wasn't sure if she was trying to hunt or ruin the hunt.

'She seems to be the strongest though... are they not friends?'

Jaehwan pondered. He wanted to help, but he couldn't make a decision as he wasn't sure what was happening.

'Let's look into it further.'

Finally, they killed all three unihorns. It was a decisive battle.

'Now, there's one.'

If Kanghun was not at the end of the 1st stage, and that bihorn had fully matured, they would have been wiped out a long time ago. It also helped to have middle-grade skill from a higher clan [Fire King Squad], especially with the help of his Clan Master.

Middle-grade skill: [Breath of the Fire King]

It allowed the user's sword to be imbued with a glowing fire that increased its power. It was a great skill for 1st Stage Adapters who could not yet put their spirit power into the sword. The low-level skill did not allow Kanghun's sword to show the fire on the blade, but it did help him stay alive. He felt dazed by using the massive amount of spiritual energy, but it seemed like they would be able to win soon.

A bihorn was a great reward when they killed. Even without the woman's item, if they managed to bring the bihorn's horns...

"Let me help! Hee-yah!"

"UGH!"

Kanghun turned down to see the dagger stuck in his thigh. The woman looked up to him with remorseful eyes.

"I-I'm sorry!"

"YOU B*TCH!"

"HUH? Who're you calling b*tch! I was only trying to help!"

And that time, the bihorn attacked. With a crack, Kanghun's sword was broken and the shadowy figure of bihorn attacked.

"DAMMIT!!!!!!!!!"

And that moment, a bright light shot out from the forest toward the monster. The bihorn then was struck and fell down with a loud sound.

Blue blood spurted out from the monster and sprayed upon Kanghun's face. He could not understand what just happened. When the monster disappeared, he first noticed the sword covered in a black aura. It was radiating with ghostly energy.

But the sword seemed to extremely fine.

Everyone fell silent. Who was the one with such a sword? And when its owner showed himself under the bright sun, Kanghun sighed. It was a ragged man who looked like he just came out from hiding within the room for tens of years. Kanghun then came back to his senses and asked,

"W-who are you?"

To Jaehwan, that sounded like this.

"#W*H@#?"

Jaehwan thought there was no easy way.

After a while, Jaehwan successfully managed to speak with the party. It was the result of using [Suspicion] to its limit.

"So... you are Jaehwan?"

"Yeah."

"And you just happened to be walking by?"

"Yeah."

"And you don't speak our language?"

"Yeah."

"That's weird... the language barrier doesn't happen in this place that often..."

"Yeah."

"...But is it really okay if we take the body of the bihorn?"

"Yeah."

"Don't take back your words!"

"Yeah."

"Haha! Great!"

Kanghun laughed. He was so happy. He had hunted down a bihorn and was handed over the body in its entirety.

"HAHAHA!"

He laughed hard while Jaehwan looked at him.

"You seem happy."

"Of course! It's a bihorn! Don't you know them?"

"No."

"...Haha. You must be joking."

Kanghun's eye squirmed in irritation.

'What a fool!'

They had captured the bihorn with a party formed to hunt unihorns. This wasn't something that could be achieved without a god watching over them. Non-Adapters could not even make a scratch and even the 1st stage Adapter would need to do its best to at least strike against the monster. That was the bihorn. His party was not enough to handle a bihorn.

Some might ask if it might change the result with some luck and perseverance.

But that was because they do not know about the [Interface System]. Under the system, the fight in this world was very honest. Strength was measured by status and skills. So the higher the status, the more powerful it will become to always bring victory to the higher status.

But Kanghun had achieved it.

He had killed the bihorn so he would now walk up to the 2nd stage Adapter when he returned.

Mino, who was watching everything from the back of the party was uncomfortable.

'Dammit. That was so close!'

Mino, the Assassin from Dark Forest Clan, was one of the Ten-Clan.

She was the one whom they called the 'Witch of Massacre'.

Chapter 13: Witch of Massacre (3)

'Witch of Massacre' in a unihorn hunting party?

People who knew would have laughed. She was powerful enough to handle trihorns alone. If she had joined the unihorn party, that meant there was only one answer.

'What a stupid task it is.'

Red Fox Clan.

A clan that was infamous for hunting Adapters.

Mino had received a request to hunt them down from a certain Adapter. The problem was that it wasn't given to her as an official request from the Dark Forest Clan.

The Dark Forest Clan forbade Assassins from accepting personal requests.

Therefore, she did not try to kill them by herself and lured the monsters instead. She could not reveal herself.

'Dammit... I was sure that bihorn was going to finish them.'

Unique skill: [Lure]

This was the skill that gave her the nickname of the 'Witch of Massacre.'
This allowed her to bring monsters around her. Everything went as planned.
Until that strange man happened to walk by and killed the bihorn.

'Just walking by? No way!'

Mino glanced at dead corpse of the bihorn that Kanghun and the other men had picked up. It was still fresh in her memory when the monster was killed. Mino saw it clearly right in front. There were a lot within the [Chaos] who could kill bihorns, but the problem was how it was killed.

'He just stabbed it to death.'

Killing a bihorn without using any skills. It didn't seem possible. It wasn't possible for Mino, or anyone else she knew. The leader of her clan, the Black Forest, might be able to do that, but such a powerful figure walking around didn't make sense either.

'Is he from a renowned family?'

There were some from renowned families from the [Great Lands] that would visit [Chaos] to train.

'No... they will not be ragged like him.'

The ones from renowned families moved in groups, wore peculiar clothing, and their walking style was easy to notice. He definitely wasn't one of them, but she couldn't make out who he was.

-Skill failed.

-Skill failed.

She had only been using the Assassin skill [Close Examination] on the man named Jaehwan. However, as if it were broken, her skill wasn't working correctly.

'Dammit, it's doing it again. I should learn some good skills now...'

She was now left with using her secret items and her guess to find out about the man. She managed to acquire two pieces of good information.

One was that man had no skills related to 'Walking.'

'He walks too plainly. If he's powerful enough to stab the bihorn to death, he must have learned some kind of walking skill...'

The walking skill was an important passive skill to have within the [Great Lands]. To ensure one's survival, one would need to quickly run away from stronger foes. Yet, that man didn't seem to have anything. In addition, there was something else that was weird.

The man's spiritual power rating was at the level of a [Non-Adapter].

Mino was shocked when she checked the rating. The Dark Forest Clan distributed accurate tools to check spiritual power for absolute accuracy as their targets might be concealing their power. Their machines allowed them to see through the spiritual powers of even the powerful ones. The machine showed the lowest rating possible for the man.

He had no skill, and he had no spiritual power.

But he killed a bihorn with one stab.

Mino was shocked.

"Let's rest here."

Kanghun took three of his clan members and chose a spot in the distance. A hawk made out of spiritual power was then sent out. It was a message-delivering skill. They were reporting the hunt.

Mino was sitting down on a cut-down tree next to Jaehwan.

Silent fell.

Mino then asked a question, breaking the silence.

"What are you?"

"..."

"I saw you kill the bihorn with one stab."

She spoke to let the man know that she knew about his secret, but he didn't answer. Mino then spoke again.

"There's almost no Adapter in [Chaos] who can kill a bihorn with a single stab. Who are you? Where did you come from?"

"...What is [Chaos?]"

'What is [Chaos]?'

"Are you kidding me?"

"No."

"How can you not know about [Chaos] then? Who are you?"

No answer.

"...Do you know what I'm asking?"

She then realized he seemed to be having a hard time understanding the language. She then realized he might've not understood her. She tried to ask him again, but she couldn't think of a better way to word it.

'Hmm... What should I do?'

It would've been easy if she showed her status window and used it as an example to show the name, clan, age, and such, but it was taboo to share personal information between Adapters. Showing one's skills and status was the same as showing one's weaknesses.

Besides, she was an Assassin from the Dark Forest Clan.

Then she decided to show a separate status window that didn't include important information. That was when she accidentally pressed on the wrong window.

"This is me-"

[Individual Details]

Name: Han, Mino

Height: 5 feet 6 inches

Weight: 103 lbs

Three dimensions: 36-24-34

Breast size: 65D

Etc: Spot near the bottom end of the left eye. There's also a small spot on the right breast. Also the hip...

"AHHHH!"

She quickly closed the window, which showed her physical attributes.

Jaehwan nodded.

"I see. I know about you now."

Mino screamed as she flushed red due to embarrassment.

"You knew what I was asking all along?!"

"I didn't say I didn't understand you."

"Then did you ignore me?!"

"No."

"Then tell me! Let make it fair!"

"...about my three measurements?"

"NOT THAT! ABOUT YOU!"

She screamed and Jaehwan grinned. There was a reason why Jaehwan didn't answer her directly.

As she asked who he was, he could not think of what he should describe himself as. When he was on Earth, he was the child of someone and a friend of someone. He attended college and also joined a club. He also tried to take up a job and worried about his country.

But after he came to the tower, all of that was gone.

He then made new friends and memories.

Yoonhwan, Seoyul, and Jay...

But after the tutorial was over, all of that disappeared. The only one with that terrible 30-year memory was Jaehwan because he was allowed to keep his memory for the reward of clearing the tower. His friends who he worked to climb up the tower might be alive somewhere on Earth, but they would no longer be his friends. None of them would remember Jaehwan anymore.

Everything had left him.

His past, future and his acquaintances.

But he was here. Then who was he?

"...I don't remember."

That was the only answer he could give. And an honest one at that.

Mino was unconvinced.

"You think I'm a fool?"

"...?"

"Do you think if you say you lost your memory with a grim face, I will just nod and agree?"

"I didn't say I lost my memory."

"YOU JUST DID!" Mino shouted.

'Does he think he's a [Powerful one from the Depth] or something?'

There were people who did lose their memories in [Chaos], but it was rare to find someone who had lost it all like this man. There was only one group of people who experienced memory loss like that. They were the powerful ones who came back from [Depth], above [Chaos]. Their individual status windows were destroyed so they didn't show anything.

But the man didn't seem like he had come back from the [Depth].

That was when the sword Jaehwan was holding began vibrating as if it was crying. She knew it wasn't a normal sword, but a sword that cried? What was more surprising was what happened next.

"Okay, I got it. Stop crying."

Jaehwan then began taking something out from his bag. Then the sword opened its blade up like a mouth and began munching the item that Jaehwan gave it. Mino's eyes shook.

'Spirit Weapon!'

The weapon that grew by eating other items. Spirit Weapons only existed within the [Great Lands]. If that item was a Spirit Weapon, it made sense why the man was so strong.

Killing a bihorn with a single stab.

It was possible with the powerful damage that a Spirit Weapon could inflict. So, it was not the man's power that allowed it to happen. It was the sword's power.

Mino then glanced at Kanghun and the Red Fox. Luckily, they didn't seem to realize what was going on here. Mino then scolded Jaehwan in her thoughts.

'You're so vulnerable.'

Whoever he was, showing a Spirit Weapon out in the open like this showed how foolish he was. The weapon was probably very powerful, but relying on the weapon's power had its limit. Even if he was not killed here, he would soon be killed by his naivety.

Either way, it didn't matter. She just needed to complete her mission.

'The problem is, I'm about to fail my mission.'

The Red Fox was now coming back to them. It seemed like sending the report had gone well as they were all seemed to be glad.

That was when Mino thought of an idea. It was a bright idea to show some of her anger for taking a peek of her three dimensions and achieve her goal at the same time. Mino then held on Jaehwan, who was dusting his butt off as he got up.

"OH, WAIT!"

"...?"

"Now that I think about it...!"

Jaehwan felt something soft touching his arms. He flinched and tried to pull his arm away, but Mino did not let it go.

"You're Jaehwan! Jaehwan right?"

Jaehwan looked at Mino speaking to him in a sweet voice.

'Is she mad?'

He wondered if this woman was the same woman who showed off her three dimension sizes just now.

"Don't you remember me? I'm Mino! Mino Han! You know, the one you hunted with before... didn't we promise to hunt together again?"

Hunting?

He searched his memory just in case, but he had no such memory. It only had been a month since he came to this place after he got out of the tower.

"I'm sorry but..."

Before Jaehwan could finish speaking, Mino's elbow poked his side. Mino winked at him and Jaehwan spoke again.

"I don't know you."

Kanghun and other party members looked at him weirdly. One of them even laughed and Mino bit her bottom lip.

'Dammit... you.'

It seemed they were thinking Mino was trying to ask Jaehwan out and failed. She had expected this.

"Oh, so you don't remember me?"

"Right."

"Yeah... I thought so too."

"...?"

Jaehwan raised his eyebrows, but Mino smiled brightly and spoke.

"You lost your memory, right?"

Chapter 14: Witch of Massacre (4)

"Jaehwan! You lost your memory!"

Jaehwan looked at Mino's face more closely.

She sure was a beauty. However, this beautiful face was forcing Jaehwan to agree that he had lost his memory.

"Didn't I say I didn't?"

Mino grinned and answered, "I see... then can I ask you something? You must know these if you did not."

"...Go ahead."

"The region we are in. What is it called?"

Jaehwan couldn't answer. He had heard from various sources until now, but he did not know the correct words to describe it. As he became silent, the other party members eyed him weirdly. The attention was something he didn't like.

Then Jaehwan suddenly heard Mino whisper the answer.

[The answer is 'Chaos'.]

Jaehwan decided to go with the answer for now.

"...Chaos."

"Oh. You know."

Mino smiled. It seemed she was more interesting than expected, considering that she was the type to walk around showing off her size measurements.

[But you really didn't know.]

Mino sent a message as she looked at Jaehwan with a grin.

"That's weird... I thought you really did lose your memory."

[That's weird... how come you don't know?]

The two voices came at once. As far as Jaehwan knew, the skill [Whisper] did not work while speaking. It seemed the woman was using a different skill to send the message.

"Let me ask you one more thing then."

"...Go on."

"Do you know where [Chaos] is located?"

He had no idea. As he fell silent, Mino's voice came again.

[The answer is the Tree of Imagery. Chaos is the tree trunk portion of the Tree of Imagery.]

Jaehwan looked at Mino for a second and answered, "Chaos is the trunk of the Tree of Imagery."

As he answered the second question correctly, the members seemed to lose interest. Kanghun stepped up to solve the situation.

"Haha, I guess Mino must have misunderstood. Isn't that right, Jaehwan?"

Jaehwan nodded and Mino spoke.

"I'm sorry, I guess I misunderstood. Sorry, Jaehwan."

But the voice that came into Jaehwan's head was different.

[I don't know who you are and why you don't know this basic stuff, but I know two things. One is that you don't want attention and two is that you're pretty strong.]

Jaehwan listened without answering.

[I think we can make a good deal. What do you think?]

She had complete control now.

Jaehwan was able to gain some pieces of information from Mino.

First, these members were evil criminals.

Second, Mino needed to kill these party members killed for a certain reason.

Third, Mino could not reveal her identity for another reason.

Fourth, if those party members are not killed, Mino and Jaehwan were the ones who would die tonight.

After hearing all the information, Jaehwan was able to understand what she wanted.

'So she wants me to kill these guys.'

But he did not have the intention to do it yet. He knew these guys seemed like bad people, but it wasn't right to judge them through the first impression. In fact, Blacksmith Jay looked like a gangster at first but he was a good man at heart.

[You'll see soon enough. They will try to kill you too.]

And the night came.

The one who offered to camp out was the leader Kanghun. The village wasn't far, but Kanghun reasoned that it might be dangerous to move at night as more monsters might come out.

Jaehwan feigned sleep and used [Suspicion] to listen to the conversation between the parties with [Whisper].

[Leader, is that really?]

[Yeah. It's a Spirit Weapon for sure.]

[Spirit Weapon?]

[It's a weapon that eats up other items to continue growing. It's a valuable weapon used only by the Lords of the [Great Lands].]

[OH! Weapons used by the Lords!]

[Yeah. I don't think his weapon would be that powerful, but it's still an opportunity.]

It was as the woman had thought.

'So... I think they are talking about my sword.'

It was unexpected. According to Beastlain's information, items that dropped from the Tower of Nightmares was trash compared to items from the [Great Lands]. Jaehwan did not think his sword would draw attention because of that.

'I guess it was one of a kind.'

He was fascinated as the sword ate up all types of equipment, but he never thought it would hold any value. He just kept it because he didn't have anything else on him.

The men continued discussing.

[But leader, isn't he strong?]

[Yes.]

[He killed a bihorn with one strike. How can we defeat him?]

[You fool.]

Kanghun scoffed and continued.

[Did you see how he killed the monster?]

[Uh... something kind of flashed and...]

[He killed it with a stab.]

[Huh?]

Man seemed dumbfounded.

[How is that possible?]

[It's not possible. I bet my life that there's are very few people who can kill bihorn with a stab throughout the entire [Chaos] region.]

[S-so he's that strong?]

[Ugh, you fool. Hey, don't fool around and use the measuring device and check his Spirit Power.]

[Yes, sir!]

After a while...

[H-huh? Leader, his Spirit Power rating is the same as a Non-Adapter. It's lower than mine!]

[Isn't it? I knew it.]

Kanghun cackled.

[Then how did he kill the bihorn?]

[Hey, did you forget what we started talking about?]

[Uh... spirit... wait.]

[You're right.]

[Is that Spirit Weapon that strong?]

[As far as I know, all Spirit Weapons come from the [Depth]. You know about that place, right?]

[Yeah, the branches of the Tree of Imagery, right?]

[Right. That's the place.]

[Oh... so it's the weapon from the branch!]

Jaehwan could not help but laugh.

'I wonder what they would think if I brought this from the roots.'

The conversation allowed Jaehwan to acquire the much-needed information. He was able to know the basic regions of the Tree of Imagery.

Tower of Nightmares, the roots.

Chaos, the trunk.

Depth, the branches.

So the tree was divided up into three big regions.

'So the Tower of Nightmares was only one of the countless roots.'

He broke free from the roots to the trunk. That was this place, Chaos.

Men continued to speak to each other.

[But Leader, how did he get the weapon? If he's from the Depth...]

[No way. Do you think Depth is some kind of a children's playground?]

[What if he's from a renowned family? There's a chance if he has such a weapon.]

[No, all members of renowned families send a message before visiting Chaos. The most recent family that sent a message to visit here was the Greens, but what part of him looks like them?]

[I heard they have these antennae stuff on their head.]

Kanghun nodded.

[And there's another piece of evidence that proves he's not from any of the renowned families.]

[What is it?]

[It's the smell.]

[A smell?]

[Doesn't he smell of something?]

[Hmm... huh? Is this...?]

Kanghun grinned.

[Yes... it's the dream smell.]

[Dream smell only comes from the roots or the branches... then he's either of two. A Strong from the Depth or a rookie.]

Jaehwan groaned. He did not know he would bear such a scent.

[He can't be the Strong of the Depth. He's a Non-Adapter. Doesn't make sense.]

[Then, is he a rookie?]

Nobody answered but it seemed that they had come to a conclusion. They began to be filled with greed and lust.

[...what about the woman?]

[You guys take care of her. He's more important.]

[Hehe... sure. We'll take good care of her then.]

The men began to make their move.

'Ugh... so it did come to this.'

Mino was right. These guys were criminals. Jaehwan did expect it, but it was a shame that his expectation did not betray him.

At that moment, something rolled and bumped into him.

"Oops!"

A soft feeling came from Jaehwan's right elbow. It was unmistakably a 65D sized breast.

"I didn't know you were here!"

[What are you doing! They're on the move!]

"Oh, Jaehwan, they're holding swords!"

[Come on! Do it as we planned!]

"EEEEK! Jaehwan! Help!"

[Whoa, are you not going to live up to the promise?]

The plan was to have Jaehwan speak the promised words and start fighting. This was what he was supposed to say.

'HAHA! Red Fox, I was waiting for you. I am the Strong of the Depth who has come to punish you!'

But he did not want to do that. He did not know what the Strong of the Depth was, but doing such thing just because he was taught about the region's name didn't seem fair.

[Come on! They're running in!]

Mino shouted but Jaehwan shrugged. Technically speaking, Jaehwan never even made a promise. It was Mino who just ordered him what to do.

Swords flew in.

"Kill them!"

Mino hugged Jaehwan and rolled to the side. Swords struck down on where they were lying and Mino shouted, "Come on! Use your sword! The black one! Get'em with it!"

"I don't have it."

"WHAT?!"

"I don't have it."

Jaehwan pointed at Kanghun and Mino's eye opened in shock. The Spirit Weapon was in Kanghun's hand.

"I let him borrow it."

"WHAT?! WHY!"

"He wanted to have a look while he stood guard."

"You let him take the weapon for that stupid reason?!"

Of course he did not lend his weapon because of such reason. Jaehwan actually had a different purpose.

'I'll see how strong she is now.'

Jaehwan grinned as he watched the swords flying in.

Chapter 15: Witch of Massacre (5)

Kanghun grinned and the men with swords circled around Mino.

"Stay still... we'll have some fun soon."

Mino closed her eyes and looked down.

It seemed as if she had given up on everything, but the Assassins of the Dark Forest knew what happened to enemies when she made such a face.

Mino's hands moved as the three men jumped at her.

The movements were so quick that they weren't even visible. The three men excluding Kanghun shook violently as if they had been struck with lightning and fell down. There were daggers in each of their chests. Kanghun's face turned grim.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I may have thrown them too hard because I'm pissed."

Mino smiled but her words became more vicious as she spoke.

"I failed on luring the monster... this partner won't cooperate... and the Spirit Weapon is in some fool's hands... so everything is working out... not so pleasantly."

Kanghun felt his heart dropping as he heard the woman's ominous words.

"Why don't you return that sword to the owner?"

"...What if I won't?"

"It's bad to have such weapon that's not suited for your level. You will face trouble."

"This weapon fits me better than that fool."

"You think so? Then I guess I have no choice."

Mino took off her black robes and revealed her dark stealth cloth. Within her cloth, seven daggers came out to float by themselves in the air.

"You will now face trouble."

Kanghun looked at her for a second and answered bitterly.

"Right... you really were the Witch of Massacre."

"Huh? Did you know?"

"...how can I not know? You lured all those monsters so easily. Only a fool would not know."

Kanghun answered as he gritted his teeth. Mino slapped her forehead and mumbled, "Dammit. Leader will lecture me again..."

Then, a vicious aura of energy began radiating from within her. Mino, who was posing as Non-Adapter was now exploding with Spirit Power only a high-level Adapter could use.

"So, it is true that Assassins from the Dark Forest can control their Spirit Power."

"You know a lot for being a grunt."

"...Who asked for the job?"

"Who cares? You guys killed too many Non-Adapters that there are so many who want you guys to die."

"What, there's no way Dark Forest would work for such..."

Then Kanghun seemed to have realized something and asked, "Wait - the job. Was it a personal request?"

"Why would it matter?"

"If that is the case, you can't fight 'us'. Witch."

"What?"

Mino then felt something changing in the surroundings. The forests around had been suspicious for a while because she felt a lot of Spirit Powers. But it was distant and wasn't far from the village so she didn't think it was anything serious. There was the possibility that they were hunters going out on a night hunt, but they were all gathering in one place.

Mino's face turned pale. She remembered Kanghun sending the messenger bird.

"You think I didn't ask for reinforcements when I have the Witch from the Dark Forest and a man who killed a bihorn with one attack?"

"..."

"Well, I would not have asked for this much if I knew I would get hands on this Spirit Weapon so easily."

Shadowy figures began showing themselves above the forest. There were a lot of them. Most were at least 1st stage Adapters while some were in the 2nd stage. And among them was someone who Mino wasn't sure if she could with a one-on-one fight against. It was a man with black cape and a hood.

"Black Fox... you're here too?"

"Witch of Massacre."

"You're that bored?"

"Think of it as an honor... that half of the Red Fox gathered just to kill you."

Klant the Black Fox. He was famous around the region for being a powerful 3rd stage Adapter and the Clan Master of the Red Fox Clan.

"...this is so freaking great."

She spoke but the situation was dire. Mino counted the numbers of the enemies and asked without looking back.

"Hey, memory-loss. Oh, wait, the Strong of the Depth. Are you there?"

The voice came from behind.

"Yes."

"I know it's bit late but I'm sorry."

"..."

"I just wanted to make it look like the Red Fox had been killed by the Strong of the Depth."

"I know."

"You did?"

Mino answered in surprise and Jaehwan repeated what he memorized in an emotionless voice.

"HAHA. Red Fox, I was waiting for you. I am the Strong of the Depth who has come to punish you."

"...so you memorized it all but didn't do it?"

"I might have used it if it was better worded."

Mino grinned.

"Haha, I see. Well, I'm sorry I forced it on you."

Mino smiled but her voice became serious.

"I'm really sorry."

There were a lot of mixed emotions in it. Jaehwan looked at Mino's back wordlessly. He knew she did not mean any harm, but it wasn't something that could be done just by saying sorry. Mino bit her lips and spoke.

"You should run."

"Why?"

"Because I can't save you."

That was her last way to repent. She knew that Jaehwan could not run. Jaehwan did not have any [Walking] skill that would enable him to run out of this mess. So Mino threw something over her back.

"What is this?"

"It's a [Stone of Escape]. You can teleport to nearest fortress. I only have one, so you should use it."

"What about you?"

Mino did not answer and Jaehwan looked down at the stone. It looked very familiar. It had the shape of the stone that Jaehwan despised the most.

But this wasn't the stone that would send him back to the past. This stone was to save someone of the present.

It was the stone to save someone to have them move on to the future.

"Yoonhwan..."

Jaehwan thought of his friend. The friend whom he could not save at the 98th floor of the tower.

Yoonhwan also held on the stone at the time.

He spoke as if it was the [Returning Stone] but Jaehwan knew that it wasn't anything like it. What if Jaehwan handed this stone to Yoonhwan at the time?

Jaehwan clenched the stone as if the stone was the answer he had learned. The feeling of the stone's rough edges came to him as if it were alive. Jaehwan spoke.

"Hey, let me ask you one thing."

"...What is it."

Mino did not look back and answered in tense voice.

"If you could go back to the past, would you go?"

Mino became dumbfounded.

"...Do you have to ask such thing at this time?"

She couldn't understand but she answered without hesitation as if the answer had been made long ago.

"I will never go back."

"Why?"

"Because I have lived so hard."

She didn't go into any details but Jaehwan felt like he understood her.

"If I die, I die today. I'm not going back."

However, that answer made Jaehwan's heart pound. She would not know that her answer just changed her entire fate.

'Yes, that will do.'

Jaehwan placed his hand on Mino's shoulder and walked up. Mino looked at him wordlessly. That was the step she could not dare to take, but Jaehwan stepped forward fearlessly.

"You will not die today."

Chapter 16: Witch of Massacre (6)

"Wait! You don't even have a sword!"

"I have one more."

Jaehwan pulled out a sword from his dimensional backpack. It was the Dragon Sword that he got from the 88th floor of the Tower of Nightmares.

Mino shouted, "That's not going to be enough...!"

The fight erupted before she could finish. Adapters quickly lunged at once all together. There were attacks from various weapons in a continuous strike. Some even had special skills that Mino recognized.

'Fire King's Fourteen Strike...!'

It was the main attack skill of the Fire King Clan of the Ten-Clan of Chaos. If trained to the extreme, it allowed the weapon to wield fire and burn the area.

'So, the Fire King clan really was selling skills to lower clans..!'

The forest was burning. The fire of the Fire King burned everything in its path and the mad fox ran rampant from within. Jaehwan readied himself.

Mino knew what he was trying to do. She needed to stop Jaehwan.

A mere [Stab] was not enough to defeat the Fire King's Fourteen Strike.

But Mino could not believe what she saw. She could not believe her five senses. The law of time was being distorted in front of her eyes.

[Void]

Mino, who was right next to Jaehwan, was able to see it for just a slight moment. The swords rushing to Jaehwan were slowing down, and Jaehwan moved through them effortlessly.

'...Am I dreaming?'

None of the attacks could land on Jaehwan's seemingly frail body. It seemed as if Jaehwan did not exist.

[Suspicion]

Among the weapons, there was a way that was only shown to Jaehwan. The one line that was only visible to the one who is suspicious of the world. Jaehwan's sword moved.

It was a stab, a mere stab.

It wasn't anything grand, but with accurate, rhythmic movement, the blade slashed the enemy's bodies. Lightning flashed and brightened the darkness. Six of the Red Fox members disappeared to dust.

"DAMMIT! KILL HIM!"

The rest of them became frantic and began pairing up to attack. Fire King's Fourteen Strike attacked from all four sides, a prison cell made from the fire. It was an attack that none would stand a chance against.

Yet, Jaehwan came out from it unharmed.

"...How?"

There was much more to it than him remaining unharmed from the fire.

[Understanding]

The fire was now gathering at the end of his blade, as if it actually originated from his blade. Something bad was going to happen. Klant, the

Black Fox, shouted as he felt an attack incoming.

"Everyone! Get to cover!"

Then Jaehwan thrust. But it wasn't just a simple stab.

The air was extracted and grew silent. In that short silence, Klant and the other Adapters felt their breath stop and their lungs getting struck. Klant had felt this feeling a few times during his lifetime.

It was when he stood upon a Leader of the Ten-Clan, the strongest of the Chaos.

As the air exploded, the flame shot out. The forest and humans alike burned as they were swept away by the storm of fire. Screams were covered by the explosions and broken trees and were scattered away.

What was left after the fire was burnt ash.

Mino had watched everything from start to finish.

That was when she knew. Jaehwan had given the bihorn corpse not because he was a fool. He had lent his Spirit Weapon not because he was a fool. The reason he didn't run even when he was cornered by all these Adapters wasn't because he was a fool.

He was just plainly too strong.

Klant, who barely managed to hide behind the trees, mumbled,

"...Where did such man appear from?"

He did get a report that a fool came with a 'Spirit Weapon' while he was on the way to the [Witch Hunt]. But it wasn't a fool; it was a monster. After blocking the Fire King's Fourteen Strike, he dismantled the skill and returned it with a more powerful attack. One simple attack eradicated half his team.

Defending the middle-level skill was possible for 3rd stage Adapter, but dismantling it and sending it back was unheard of. Klant couldn't even guess how strong the man was.

Kanghun stuttered as he saw Klant looking at him.

"Th-this can't be true!"

"Retreat!"

Kanghun gritted his teeth.

"I have the Spirit Weapon! I probably can defeat him with this weapon!"

Klant glanced at the black sword that Kanghun claimed to be a Spirit Weapon and shook his head.

"No. He's too powerful."

"That's not true!"

Kanghun then charged toward Jaehwan. Jaehwan was approaching through the fire and Kanghun used his best skill to attack. The weapon was powerful enough to kill a bihorn with a stab. With this weapon, he would surely-

His attack was dodged easily. There was only the sound of his weapon swishing through the empty space. Kanghun felt his energy fading until Jaewhan effortlessly grabbed the blade.

How?!

Kanghun could not understand. After all, he had done during the past, after graduating from the Tower, walked through the [Great Lands] and came to [Chaos], trained on his skills and gained status... he had endured so much.

Kanghun remembered Jaehwan's Spirit Power.

[Spirit Power: 154]

Most 1st stage Adapters had an average of 1000 so it was nothing.

"How did you manage with such stats..."

Jaehwan's eyes narrowed.

It had been a while since he heard of it. There was a time when he worked hard to increase his stats and level up. Those were in his Tower days. He had worked so hard to gain stats and gather better items. Jaehwan understood Kanghun, and that's why he could speak to him.

"That's why you're weak."

"...What?"

Jaehwan walked up to him. As he got closer, Kanghun stepped back out of fear. He could not understand the depth within Jaehwan's eyes. It was not something to be understood by numbers or stats. When Kanghun came back to his senses, he was kneeling down. Jaehwan reached out and took the sword from Kanghun and pointed the sword at the fleeing members of Red Fox.

Stab. But it was much more serious. It was if he were demonstrating what was it like to use the skill.

Kanghun shivered as he knew what about what was going to happen.

"...Wh...what are you?"

As his eyes filled with despair, a light was fired out from the blade, a powerful and vicious energy that seemed to be aimed at the world itself. Klant, who was running away in distance, looked back in shock but it was too late.

"I can't believe..."

Klant fell to the ground with a hole in his chest. Similar sounds came from throughout the forest.

That was the last thing Kanghun was able to see.

During the dark night, a bonfire was started. Mino looked up to the dark skies and reminisced about the old days.

'Mino, you're not fit to be an assassin.'

That was what she heard from the leader after her first failure. No, it was what she always heard each time she failed. The leader always spoke to her that her soft spot would be her doom.

She wanted to deny it.

Thus, she took the personal request even when it was forbidden. She intentionally took the hard jobs such as wiping out bandits and criminals, hoping to learn about being cold-hearted from them. After half year of hunting down various criminals, she even acquired the title, 'Witch of Massacre.' However, she wanted to ask today,

'Hey Leader, do you know that I'm alive because I'm not acting like an assassin?'

She then turned to Jaehwan who was feeding the equipment he picked up to his weapon. He was mysterious.

'Who is he?'

The fight was still lingering in her eyes. She had never seen such a fight before. It was shame that she offered to let him run.

"Hey."

Mino hesitated but soon decided to call Jaehwan.

"What are you really?"

Jaehwan glanced at her and looked back down on his sword.

"Can you tell me? Please?"

"About me? Hmph."

Jaehwan then looked at Mino and grinned. He then began to speak.

"You know about me already."

"...What?"

"Did you forget?"

He looked as if he was disappointed and Mino became confused. She could not remember him talking about himself or anything. As she was thinking, Jaehwan shook his head.

"Sadly, you seem to have lost your memory also."

"Huh?"

"At least I'm not the only one who lost the memory."

Mino then realized something and answered in dumbfounded voice.

"Whoa... you... you really..."

She didn't imagine he would return what she did today at this moment. Mino laughed.

"Shame on you."

Jaehwan didn't answer.

"Give me back my stone."

"I don't have it."

"Huh? Why?"

"Because I lost it."

"What? It's expensive! How did you lose it?"

Jaehwan did not answer as Mino began speaking to him. The sounds of his sword eating away the equipment and Mino talking from his side were somehow very peaceful. It seemed Jaehwan had traveled back to the time that he had lost. A cool breeze brushed his hair and Jaewan looked up to the sky.

It was interesting. There were skies and stars. Jaehwan thought what he had been looking for was maybe like the night sky. Something that might prove that he was human in this unrealistic world.

"Do you really want to know about me?"

Mino stopped speaking all of a sudden.

"Then listen carefully."

Mino nodded eagerly and Jaehwan spoke.

"I'm human."

"...Are you kidding me?"

Mino tried to shout but Jaehwan asked.

"Are YOU human?"

"Of course, I'm human! I mean-"

Jaehwan grinned.

"Then that's enough."

"What?"

"It's enough."

"What do you mean..."

Mino tried to ask more but forgot what she was going to ask as she looked at Jaehwan. She had never seen a man that looked this lonely. As she looked at him for a while, she understood. Maybe he was right. Maybe it was enough.

Jaehwan reached to his pocket. There was a small stone at the end of his fingers. It was small, but well-crafted. Cold, but dense realism. The stone that only takes you to the present, the stone that tells you that the place you should return to is only the present.

Jaehwan then dreamed of the old days, before the Tower of Nightmares appeared. Before nobody tried to return to the past. It was harsh and sometimes full of despair, but nobody returned to the past.

One month after escaping from the Tower.

Jaehwan had met a human for the first time.

Chapter 17: Silver Bind (1)

[What do you know about the [Great Lands] when you didn't even go into [Chaos]? ...huh? Me? I've never been there either.]

-Gainach, Lord of Sloth

The next morning, Mino was dumbfounded when she heard from Jaehwan on their way to the nearest fortress.

"...What did you want me to talk about?"

"About you."

"What about me?"

"I want to know what was it like when you cleared the Tower of Nightmares."

It was a boring trip, so chatting between them was natural. Mino would have considered it as such, but the problem was the topic.

"Don't you think it's a bit rude to ask that all of a sudden?"

Asking what happened in the tower was a taboo between Adapters. That's why people did not even mention it by the name 'Tower of Nightmares,' and instead called it 'Roots'.

Nobody wanted to remember the time of when they were a [Product].

It had been eight years since Mino cleared the tower, but she still had nightmares from when she managed to survive through the Roots.

"I want to listen to your story in return for saving your life."

Mino bit on her lip and spoke.

"...Okay."

She thought about it for a second and began her story.

"My homeworld was called 'Arkal'."

10 years ago, a Tower of Nightmares appeared in Mino's World 7651. She did not remember how it looked now, but what she remembered was that just like how her world was nothing special, so was the tower. It was one of the mass-produced towers created to [Cultivate]. But the people's lives and deaths that happened within the tower weren't mass-produced.

After beating the tutorial and the real game, she reached the 100th floor. There, she, along with her friends, met the Demon, or [Cultivator]. She still could not forget what the demon said after looking at them disinterestedly.

-Bah, this is a failure. You're all Non-Adapters.

The forest was still dense. Jaehwan pushed on, "What happened next?"

Mino seemed reluctant to continue.

"It's a common story of a girl getting out of the Roots and surviving through the Great Lands."

"Care to go into details?"

Mino let out a deep sigh.

"...If you insist."

She still remembered her excitement when she set foot upon the [Great Lands]. Demons spoke to her.

-No money, or education matters within the [Great Lands]. The only thing valuable thing was the numbers.

It was the promised land after a long nightmare. Mino thought everything would turn out great. She thought with her items and skills, she would enjoy life on the [Great Lands].

But she was mistaken.

The [Great Lands] was not the utopia that the Demons spoke of. Mino had to gather skills instead of money and increased Spirit Power instead of education.

More, better, and higher.

And Mino was a Non-Adapter, not to be associated with such words. She was at the far bottom of the food chain. So there was only one thing she could do. She always had to run, run, and run.

"After that is as you know. Most people come to Chaos for similar reasons."

Mino frowned as she spoke, seemingly pained to have to reminisce about her past.

"You're cruel to make me remember of all that."

"I'm sorry. But I wanted to hear it."

Jaehwan did not need 'Mino's story'. What he wanted was the common story of Adapters who cleared the Tower of Nightmares.

"...It's okay. I'll just consider it as having paid my debt for you saving me yesterday. Besides, it wasn't all that bad to speak of it, I think time really did pass quicker."

Mino seemed refreshed as she spoke. It was as if she just finished a long novel that she had been hesitating to read.

One forest ended and another forest began. Now there were more shallow trees. Mino then spoke as if she was waiting.

"Okay, it's your turn now."

"My turn?"

"Shouldn't we play fair? I talked about mine, so you should talk about yours."

She was about to say that she would consider it as repayment but changed her mind.

"You still want to know who I am?"

Mino grinned.

"No, I just want to know about your story."

Knowing about a person meant one needed to know the story behind them. It was obvious that who he was would be shown from his story. Jaehwan thought she suited the name 'Fox' more than those Red Fox members that he killed yesterday.

"Did you forget that I lost my memory?"

"...You and your memory loss. Are you still upset about what I did yesterday?"

Jaehwan shook his head and Mino eyed him strangely. Jaehwan did mention he did not know anything about [Chaos]. However, that was strange. There was a possibility of someone not knowing about [Chaos] if he was outside, but anyone inside it should know.

That was the kind of world [Chaos] was.

"So... you don't have any memory of when you walked into [Chaos]... I mean, any memory of the [Great Lands]?"

"You can say that."

He had never been to the [Great Lands], so he was not lying. Then Mino looked at Jaehwan with an expression that he saw for the first time on her face. It seemed-

"If that's true... I envy you."

It was the expression of someone who was truly envious.

"What?"

"I envy that you don't have any memory of that place."

Jaehwan became curious and asked, "What part about memory loss do you envy?"

"Most people here will envy you also."

"Why?"

Mino did not answer.

Then a tower that seemed to belong to the fortress appeared in the distance. They were nearing their destination.

"That's Gorgon Fortress. It's the largest one around here."

Jaehwan felt strange looking at the walls of the fortress. So, even within [Chaos], there were groups of people living in communities. It seemed the world still had basic human civilization.

-Most people come to Chaos for similar reasons.

Jaehwan became curious. Under what circumstances did Mino come here to have said that? Jaehwan asked about it casually. Then, he realized he had made a mistake.

"...You asked 'How' I came here?"

It was a cold voice. Mino's expression was frozen solid.

"You will regret that you even asked once you find out the answer to that."

She then walked ahead.

The forest ended and there was now a medieval castle in front of them. He had never seen a fortress as large as this. The Atopos that humans built to the 50th floor was probably a shack compared to this. The walls had various traces of reinforcements and repairs that showed that the fortress had been standing here for quite some time.

But, there was an interesting place by the entrance. It had a great magic rune.

Jaehwan felt something familiar from it. He knew a similar place. It was similar to the 'Summoning Ground' of the 1st floor of Tower of Nightmares.

"I-I don't want to die!"

"Save me!"

On the magic rune, naked people were cowering. Some were grabbing their chests and wailing, while others were moaning in pain. Some had destroyed faces as if they had been attacked while some seemed to be sleeping peacefully. But Jaehwan knew at once.

They all had different expressions, but they were in fact, in one emotion.

Jaehwan knew when people felt such an emotion.

At that time, the rune shone and another group of people appeared on top of it. People naked, shivering in fear. Screaming, moaning in despair...

He felt a chill run down his spine.

"So, they are..."

"Do you know what you asked me now?"

Mino seemed pained from even watching.

"...You asked 'how' I came to [Chaos]? Don't you ever ask that to anybody here."

Mino then took a dagger out from her clothes and made a small cut on her pinky finger. The blood spilled out from her finger and into the air, then it became white powder and disappeared.

In this world, the spirit disappeared into white particles.

It wasn't surprising as he had seen it hundreds of times and also saw when he killed Red Fox. But that's why he forgot. He had forgotten that the human body did not disappear. They bled and died in agony.

They did not disappear into powder.

Jaehwan finally understood the truth of this world.

"I see... so people here already have..."

Jaehwan looked at the summoning ground with a sad expression and Mino nodded.

"Welcome to the world of the dead, [Chaos]."

Chapter 18: Silver Bind (2)

The [Great Lands], the promised land.

Adapters who had lived for some time within the land knew what the 'Promised Land' stood for. The land did not promise any chances, but promised one thing.

It was related to death.

"...you can only come here when you die."

Jaehwan realized why he wasn't able to move to the [Great Lands] and had instead come to [Chaos]. If he had his body, he would've been able to move onto the [Great Lands]. But Jaehwan broke out of the tower after clearing the tutorial with only his spirit. That was why Tree of Imagery categorized him as a 'dead man' and sent him here.

It was the place where all spirits withered away from the Great Lands gathered.

That was Chaos.

Jaehwan looked at the naked people who were sent out in spirit form. They got out of the roots but were sent to the trunk. Most of them were men but some were women. However, they all had looks of despair. Some of them did not even realize that they were dead.

"So, this is the 'last chance' given by the damn [Great Lands]."

Mino spoke as she looked upon the summoning ground.

"If you die here, you're finished. The spirit will be sent as nutrients for the Tree. There are no more chances."

Jaehwan thought about the Red Fox members who had scattered away.

"So, the people here still have a 'chance'?"

"Yes."

"Is there a way to find a body?"

"It's a really small chance but if you survive here..."

It seemed brutal. Even after death, you still needed to find a way to 'survive'. Mino looked bitter as she at the people.

'That's why she's envious of me.'

She, too, had come here upon her death. It was a memory that no one wanted to think. Jaehwan's question, "How did you come to [Chaos]?" meant that he was asking, "How did you die?"

The rune faded and soldiers came over the bridge from the fortress entrance.

"Damn, there's a lot this time also. Let's get to work!"

A bearded man in a uniform shouted and soldiers began working to hold up the wounded.

"Hey! Get yourself together! You died because you're so helpless!"

The newcomers were escorted into the fortress by the soldiers. It seemed that it was their job to take care of the dead.

"Hey, put this on and go stand in the line."

Tens of people lined up in front of the office. Upon a small stage in front of the office stood the bearded man. He looked around and then spoke,

"You all probably know where you are by now. You might be thinking that it's not true, but it is. You all are 'REALLY' dead. Most of you probably died in the first battle of the [Great Lands]. Your heads were probably crushed or your intestines were blown out like insects."

Everyone's expressions became grim. What he said was true. Most of the people standing there had died as soon as they entered the [Great Lands].

"Do any one of you know why you died?"

Nobody answered as the bearded man stayed silent. He took out a cigarette from his clothing and lit it. He was giving them time to find a reason. It allowed them to come to a conclusion.

Some of the women were shaking with cold as the rags that covered them weren't enough. The bearded man threw his cigarette to the ground and stepped on it. Then one of the men asked with a shaky voice, "Was it... because we were weak?"

It seemed like he was being crushed from within just by saying it. The bearded man scoffed, "Yes, but to be more precise..."

He drew in everyone's attention.

"You all died like insects because you did not put in enough work."

The people began to mumble to each other. They disagreed. Every one of them here had put in enough work. The Tower of Nightmares wasn't easy to clear if they did not try. Some even glared at the bearded man.

"You look like you don't agree. Think about it. Did you try really hard? To your 'last' breath?"

He intentionally emphasized the word 'last'.

"You have died once, so now you will know. You, after getting killed with your intestines gutted open, head chopped off, being raped and left for dead, will know. You will know what I mean by 'dying breath.'"

The people moaned and cried, the memories of their deaths were still fresh. They could not look at the bearded man. He was right after all. After they died, they now realized that they had never tried so hard to the point where it might kill them.

"But you all are lucky. You will be given another chance. A chance to try harder."

Some looked up at him.

"You need to know only one thing. If you die here, you will 'really' die."

Those were terrifying words for the people who had died once.

"So what you need to do here is only one thing. Survive. Keep surviving."

Survive.

"Live, and work on your skills. Empower yourself. Wait for a chance."

Wait and grow in power.

"That's when the miracle will come. I assure you, the ones who try hard will get a chance to leave the Tree of Imagery. Try hard to avenge your enemy. Do what it takes to return what you have suffered. That is all I can say."

The people who listened were speechless. Some even shivered.

The speech was over. The soldiers around them clapped emotionlessly. Then, they began guiding the newcomers into the office.

"Men, this way. Women, that way. Come."

The soldiers approached the bearded man as he came down from the stage.

"It was a great speech!"

"What a great speech it was, Lieutenant!"

The bearded man took the water from the soldier and mumbled,

"...Nah."

He was uninterested. He had probably repeated the same speech over hundreds of times. The words all sounded great, but he knew they were all lies.

No one among them would be able to leave this Tree of Imagery. Like everyone did when they were in the [Great Lands], most would die on their 'First Hunt', and those who survived would continue to barely live.

Like himself.

Then someone said, "James, that was some speech. I thought you only did that when you ask girls out."

James narrowed his eyes. There was a man and a woman approaching the gate. The woman was a beauty, she wore a black robe and had bright red hair. There was no way he would not remember such a beautiful girl.

"Did you forget me already? C'mon, James."

Something flashed in his head and the woman's features changed. Long black hair and glistening eyes. Pale skin that was almost white. James brightened up.

"...Wow! Who do we have here? Isn't it Mino from the Dark Forest?"

Mino frowned as she quickly changed her features again.

"Don't say that out loud!"

Jaehwan glanced at James and Mino. It seemed the two of them knew each other.

"So, you're now a Lieutenant Captain?"

"Yeah, that's why I did that speech."

James scanned Mino's body up and down as if he was starting a check at the gate.

"I waited too long for your speech to end. It would be great if you let us pass quickly."

James grinned.

"What brings you all the way to the North entrance? Don't you normally use the other side?"

"Yeah, I just happened to come this way today."

Mino didn't seem to want to go into detail and quickly answered,

"I don't need to 'Identify' myself right? You know my face."

Jaehwan then looked at Mino. She then sighed and smiled.

[You don't know about 'Identify' also?]

Jaehwan nodded, and Mino sent another Whisper.

[Everyone entering the fortress must identify themselves. You usually pop up the User Details to prove it... you know how to do that, right?]

Jaehwan had not done it, so he did not know. But, he had a bigger problem. He could not use the Interface System at all. Ever since he had broken out from the Tower of Nightmares, he could not use any of the abilities related to the Interface System. That was when Lieutenant James spoke, "Mino."

"Huh?"

"I'm sorry but things have changed."

"...What? What do you mean?"

"Our policies have changed. We need certification from everyone who enters the fortress now."

"Certification?"

Mino looked confused.

"You mean the old certification that [Big Brother] used to distribute?"

"Yeah."

"Why? Wasn't it gone after we were allowed to use the Interface System within the Tree of Imagery?"

"I heard that the system has some problems right now and doesn't work properly."

Mino then remembered her skill to identify failed. She thought her skill was broken, but it seemed like it was related to this.

"Anyway, there are a lot of cases where the User Status window is corrupted. That's why all the fortresses in [Chaos] now requires 'Certification' to identify themselves."

"Why now...?"

It was annoying. Mino ranted and looked at Jaehwan.

[Hey, do you have certification?]

Jaehwan did not answer.

[...I guess you don't.]

Then something came up in her mind. There were a lot of instances where the man made some rude mistakes such as asking about her past and asking taboo questions.

Mino grinned teasingly.

"James."

"Huh?"

"I forgot my certification, but won't this do? We're not strangers after all."

Mino smiled and handed James something. It was an envelope with white powder. James looked at it and answered,

"Good medicine. How many horns was this?"

"Bihorn."

"You must be having good hunts these days."

James smiled as he accepted the envelope stuffed it into his pocket, satisfied. He then turned to Jaehwan and asked, "Is he your friend?"

"I don't know him."

Mino walked past James and grinned teasingly.

"Uh, he said he lost his memory...? Or something."

Jaehwan stood without a word and James spoke,

"Then I need your certification."

"I don't have it."

"Huh? Then you can't come in."

"Do you need it?"

James and the other soldiers became dumbfounded.

"Of course."

"Because I can't prove myself?"

"Right."

"But I can prove to myself that I am me. Why do you need anything else?"

"Haha, are you trying to fool around with me?"

The soldiers began closing in as they gripped their weapons. Mino grinned as she watched from the entrance of the wall.

[Why don't you ask me for help now? If you want, I can help you.]

Even if Jaehwan was powerful, he was only an individual who needed to follow the rules of this world. This world had rules.

'Maybe I overdid it.'

Even without a Certification, it was easy for her to persuade one or two soldiers. But something weird happened. The energy changed within Jaehwan. His left foot stepped back and he lowered his shoulders. It was a slight change that only Mino noticed, and if he were to lay his hands on the swords...

'Wait!'

Mino quickly used Whisper.

[Wait! Don't do that!]

She sounded desperate.

[I know you're strong, but you will become a criminal if you kill them!]

Jaehwan didn't seem to want to budge and Mino bit her lip.

[You can't fight the whole fortress! Do you know what that means?]

However, that did not change Jaehwan's stance. The foolish soldiers did not know, but Mino shook at the powerful presence gathering within Jaehwan. It even gave her an illusion of Jaehwan killing everyone here and strolling in.

The devastation from yesterday came back to her. The terrifying stab that burned the entire forest.

Mino realized she had made a mistake.

This man wasn't just strong. He was also not bound by any laws.

She knew then that he would draw his sword. He would kill all the soldiers and if needed, fight the entire fortress. The matter of 'if he could win or not' didn't seem to bother him.

Mino became pale.

Chapter 19: Silver Bind (3)

Killing soldiers was easy for high-ranked Adapters in [Chaos]. The problem was what came after.

Fighting the 'Fortress'.

This was very different from fighting against an individual or a clan. The fortress worked as an administrator who controlled the Interface System and information about Adapters.

A fortress meant it was a world.

The leaders of the Ten-Clan could kill high ranking Adapters single-handedly, but they would not attempt such a foolish action. There was no benefit to it.

Mino realized that this man would not care about any of that.

"Wa-wa-wai-wait-WAIT! James! He's my friend!"

"...Didn't you say you don't know him?"

"I was just fooling around."

Mino answered quickly, smiling awkwardly.

"..."

"Please, can you let him pass?"

James looked at the man again. It seemed like he was only a rookie in [Chaos]. James, with his job to teach newcomers, did not want to let the

man go after he did something that he was not allowed to do.

"What if I say no?"

'It will mean death for all of you, you fool!'

But she couldn't say that. Her joke was now endangering a man's life.

"I'll treat you once if you let it go this time."

"No."

Mino bit her lip.

"What's with you? I'll pay more if you need it. Do you want a horn?"

James narrowed his eyes at Mino's over-eagerness.

"You doing that makes him more suspicious. I'll take him to the Captain."

Mino frowned. All gates of the fortress had a Captain. Most of them were powerful enough to easily handle 1st or 2nd stage Adapters. The one at this northern gate was the most famous among the gates. People called him...

Karlton the Stubborn!

Mino had to go through a series of annoyances because of him in the past. Karlton was infamous, but it wasn't because he was violent, rude, or corrupted. It was the opposite.

No gate captain was innocent and Karlton was no exception. Born within the subfamily of the Sky people, the ones who inherited the blood of Angels, Karlton was a person who went by the book.

That was the problem.

The gate captains needed to be corrupt. They needed to be bribed to let criminals pass. That would allow the fortress' underground markets to thrive, allowing the officials in the fortress to gain more profit.

However, Karlton never allowed any unjust habits.

That was why people avoided coming through the northern gate. Even innocent people had been taken in for simple mistakes.

Mino looked at Jaehwan.

'If he meets Karlton, it will be the end for him.'

One was an outlaw who did not abide by the rules, and the other was a Sky person who did not let such things happen. She felt sweat rolling down her back.

"James, he's not a bad person. You're mistaken! Come on!"

Mino began to explain frantically.

"This person saved me! You know the Red Fox Clan, right? He killed them all single-handedly!"

"Killed the Red Fox Clan alone?"

"Yeah! He's not suspicious!"

James looked at Jaehwan again. He seemed to have a good sword, but other than that, he looked like a beggar.

"...It makes him more suspicious, you know."

"N-no, I mean... Hey! You should say something!"

Jaehwan narrowed his eyes at that. It seemed that he was also enjoying the moment. Mino sent a [Whisper].

[Come on! I was just joking around!]

Mino begged and Jaehwan answered, "She speaks the truth."

Mino frowned.

"Please, explain in detail! Tell him how you killed them and where!"

Jaehwan did not answer and James scoffed. Another [Whisper] was sent to Jaehwan.

[Come on! Please! I'm sorry! I'm sorry, okay?]

Mino then saw Jaehwan focus on someone approaching. A powerful Spirit energy was approaching. It was the person that made her efforts useless.

It was a tall, fair-skinned, handsome man. Other than a silvery wing on his back, he looked just like a human.

The most stubborn one within the Gorgon Fortress.

Mino became grim as James brightened up.

"...What is going on here?"

It was Captain Karlton the Stubborn.

After hearing what happened, Karlton scratched his clean chin. It was his habit when he was thinking. He was famous not only for being stubborn but also for his handsomeness.

It was beautiful to see how he gently touched his chin with his blonde hair tied behind him. Some sculptors even sculpted Karlton touching his chin and sold them to the women in the fortress.

The most famous of all was [Karlton in deep thought].

But to Mino, he was just a stubborn, annoying gate Captain.

"So, Captain, he killed the Red Fox Clan..."

"Everything's fine about the Red Fox Clan now. Thank you."

Mino closed her mouth. The situation had gotten worse. Karlton asked Jaehwan, "So, you want to enter our fortress?"

"Yeah."

"But you don't have a Certificate."

"Right."

"Then you can't enter."

"Why?"

Karlton closed his mouth. Why was he asking the obvious? He couldn't understand it. He had been doing this for over 55 years, and no one asked such an obvious question. It was just not possible. There was no reason for it. However, Karlton seemed happy to hear that question.

Mino slapped her forehead. It was time for 'that'.

Karlton opened his mouth,

"If you cannot prove yourself with a Certificate, a Captain has the right to turn a visitor away. It is written in Chapter 27, the 4th Line of Gorgon-Entrance Code of Law. And according to Chapter 34..."

The soldiers became excited.

"It's here! Captain's [Stubborn Encyclopedia of Law]!"

"It's been a while since I've heard it."

"How does he memorize all that?"

"I sometimes think it might be a lie. Doesn't it sound different every time?"

The soldiers seemed excited because they trusted their captain. The one that Adapters agreed to be the strongest of the gate captains was obviously Karlton. For the past 55 years, not once was his gate breached. Nobody knew how strong Karlton was.

"...and according to the law in Chapter 2, line 7, we can take custody of the traveler..."

Jaehwan interrupted him. "Stop. I get it."

The guards immediately turned to Jaehwan.

"So you want to arrest me?"

Everyone moaned. No one had spoken like that to Karlton in the last 10 years. Karlton did not change his expression but every soldier knew. Karlton was really angry now.

"If you do not have the 'Certification', I might have to do that."

"Why do I need that to prove myself?"

"Because you need it. Everyone here uses it to prove themselves."

"What does it contain?"

"Your true name, organization, class, skills and status, criminal record, corruption rate of the spirit and..."

"Then I really don't need that 'Certification'."

Karlton raised his eyebrows. Everyone in [Chaos] had a certification and used it to identify themselves. It was one of the few ways to prove themselves in [Chaos]. But this man was denying its importance.

"I don't understand you. How are you going to prove yourself?"

"I won't prove myself."

Karlton was shocked. It was a rare case for an Adapter to be this defiant throughout his 55 years of duty. Most Adapters could not resist the bind that his law readings gave them. He didn't just read the laws for no reason.

Skill [Order of Law]

It was a skill only a few people in the fortress could acquire. Karlton was the only one who was allowed to learn even though he was only a gate captain. Even 3rd stage adapters could not resist his [Order of Law].

However, this man easily ignored it. What was weirder was that it was Karlton who had received damage by using the skill. A spirit that not even [Order of Law] could break through. Karlton was astonished.

'He seems to be proving himself by not proving himself.'

How was that possible?

"Then, I, Gate Captain Karlton, will arrest you under the Gorgon Gate Code of Law, Chapter 2, Line 7."

Karlton's hands began to be covered in a silver aura. The silvery net shot out from his hands and wrapped Jaehwan's entire body. The guards shouted in excitement. It was a rare sight.

"Wow!"

If [Karlton in deep thought] was the favorite for women collectors, then there also was the wealthy collectors' favorite. A sculpture of Karlton covered with a silver aura.

[Karlton of the Silver Bind]

The motive for the sculpture was standing in front of them. Silver Bind was another one of Karlton's nicknames.

The unique skill of the Sky people, [Silver Bind].

This was the best skill Karlton had. It bound the target no matter how powerful the target was. However, Karlton was shocked yet again. The net aura that was shot out at Jaehwan dissipated into smoke and disappeared as it touched him.

"...But how?"

There were some who had resisted [Order of Law] as some Adapters had powerful Spirit Power. But even they were powerless against [Silver Bind].

Everyone who disobeyed the Gorgon Code of Law was 'Evil' who could not be freed with the [Silver Bind]'s power. But [Silver Bind] was now saying that this man was not 'Evil'.

Mino took the chance to interrupt them.

"Captain! He has the Certificate but he just forgot about it! I'll make sure he carries it around if you let him go this once! Please!"

Mino's small shoulders were shaking and her hands were pale. Jaehwan looked at Mino. If she was doing to this extent, the fortress seemed to hold great power.

'Code of Law... hmm..'

Jaehwan then changed and let go of his powers. Mino brightened up.

'Finally, he's listening!'

It wasn't anything troubling actually. All he needed to do was to follow the Captain and provide information through the Interface and receive a new certificate.

"Good. I will follow your Code of Law."

Mino became worried that he was too willing, but Karlton nodded.

"Good. So, I will now arrest..."

Jaehwan shook his head.

"No, I don't need to be arrested."

"What?"

"Don't I just need to do what this woman did?"

Mino flinched. What did she do? She immediately turned pale.

"W-wait!"

However, Jaehwan already took something out from his backpack and threw it to Karlton. Karlton caught it easily.

"Take that and let me go. That will do, right? I saw that you all seemed to be doing that."

Everyone was dumbfounded. It was even more interesting to see James whose eyes met Jaehwan's.

'D-damn bastard!'

Karlton was looking down at the thing that Jaehwan threw to him.

"What's wrong? Isn't everyone doing this? That's what I saw a while ago."

[Code of Law]. Everyone knew, but not all followed.

Jaehwan spoke again, "Isn't it enough? Then take this also."

Another thing was thrown at Karlton, as Mino shouted in a [Whisper].

[W-WH-WHAT'S WRONG WITH YOU?!]

The air became cold as James and the other soldiers who knew about the bribery became pale.

'We have to kill him now...!'

If Karlton knew what they had been doing, they knew that this would not end lightly. James took up his weapon.

"How dare you try to bribe the Captain! You fool!"

"Captain, we should kill him now!"

This was one thing that could never be done to Karlton the Stubborn. A total of 154 Adapters tried to bribe Karlton and had lost their lives. And this was the 155th one.

However, Karlton did not budge.

"...Did you say you're Jaehwan?"

Karlton stared at the teal gem in his hand for a long time. Then, something unexpected happened. He suddenly became polite.

"You sure know how to crack a joke. I was waiting for you, The Messenger of the Greens."

Chapter 20: Silver Bind (4)

"What happened?"

"Captain allowed someone without a Certificate to enter..."

"Did he get bribed?"

"Be quiet!"

The soldiers seemed to be in shock as James glared at Jaehwan.

'...who the hell is he?'

And after a while, Mino and Karlton walked out of the office. Mino seemed she had been shaken as she definitely had a hard time going through the [Order of Law].

"Mino, you should always carry the certificate. And never bribe again. I would have to punish you, but I'm letting you go because Jaehwan asked me to."

Mino looked lifelessly at Jaehwan as Karlton continued,

"Jaehwan has proved his identity."

It was the object Jaehwan threw at Karlton. It was the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit] created by one of five renowned families of Great Lands, the Greens. It was mostly used by members of the Greens to prove their identity, but there was a reason why it was famous.

The stone would boost an Adapter's Spirit Power when carried around with them.

The one he threw at Karlton was powerful enough to change a Non-Adapter into a 1st stage Adapter. That was enough to prove Jaehwan's identity.

"These stones have been examined, so I will return it to you."

"You don't need it?"

"You should not give it away to anyone. You should value what you have, Messenger of the Greens."

Karlton handed over the two stones to him. After guiding Jaehwan and Mino inside, he took out something that looked like a temperature measurement device.

"This checks the Corruption level of the Spirit. Everyone must be tested with this, just in case."

Jaehwan looked at Mino as she would usually explain in this case. But Mino still looked lifeless.

"She will be like that for a while since she was punished with the [Order of Law]."

Jaehwan nodded.

"I will start with Mino."

The machine beeped for a while and then a floating small screen displayed in the air.

[Result: Caution - corruption has exceeded 15%. Recommend taking medication.]

Karlton became grim.

"Mino, according to Chapter 8..."

Mino then took out some medicine and swallowed the pills with a deadpan face. It was then Jaehwan's turn. He felt something quickly surging through

him while the device beeped. It seemed Karlton had never seen such a device before.

'Is he a corrupted spirit?'

The result popped up.

[Result: Cannot measure corruption level.]

Karlton became dumbfounded and apologized to Jaewan, "I'm sorry. Let me try again."

[Result: Cannot measure corruption level.]

Karlton fell silent. This machine never made any errors. Not once since the device was created had he heard that it make an error. The only occasion where the device could not measure was when the spirit's corruption level was at 0%.

0% wasn't something that could be achieved just by eating good medicine. No one in this fortress had such a pure spirit. Karlton seemed to understand.

"I see... that's why my [Silver Bind] did not work on you. I have never seen such a pure spirit like you."

Karlton remembered that all of his skills were useless against Jaehwan.

"Everything is done. You can go now."

Jaehwan did not leave. He opened his mouth...

"Captain, can we really just let them go?" James asked as he saw the two of them disappear. He could not understand.

"James, didn't you know that ones from Green are coming to [Chaos]?"

"Yes, but..."

There's no way they would not know. All five renowned families sent a message to the fortress before they visited [Chaos]. They were the only ones, along with the [Nightmares], who could visit [Chaos] without paying the price of death. James knew that they were coming.

"But he doesn't look like he's from the Greens."

Green skin and two antennae. The people of Greens looked very distinct. Karlton nodded.

"Right. He doesn't look like them at all."

"Then how do you know if he is from the Greens?"

Karlton smiled bitterly and asked, "James, do you know what the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit] does?"

"Doesn't it increase an Adapter's power?"

"Right."

Everyone knew about the stone. All Adapters wished to put their hands on it.

"Then do you know about its traits?"

James became dumbfounded but Karlton took off his white gloves and showed his hands. It was as if his palms had been burned. It wasn't a burn, but James knew what it was.

"Corruption...!"

James could not believe it. Corruption was like a plague that existed within [Chaos]. Everyone in [Chaos] would rack up corruption little by little, just by living here, and when it reached 100%, they would meet with a fate more horrific than death.

But there were ways to defend against it. It was to eat the horns.

Those who took those medicine created using the horns were allowed to live longer, and Karlton, was the one with the cleanest of spirits within this fortress.

However, his spirit was corrupt, only at the palm.

James took out medicine from his pocket frantically and powdered Karlton's hand. It was the medicine he got from Mino.

"...Is this from the stone?"

Karlton nodded.

"James, have you seen anyone other than the Greens holding the stone?"

James thought about it. He had never seen anyone else.

"Isn't it weird? Why won't others try to take it as their own?"

That definitely was weird. There were Greens who traveled alone and if they all had those stones, some might have attacked them in order to take the stones for themselves.

"It's because of the corruption."

Karlton nodded again.

"Yes. No one other than the Greens can handle those stones. They are the only ones who are allowed to carry the stones without corrupting their spirits."

If that was true, then it wasn't weird for Karlton to consider him to be from the Greens.

"But I have never seen Greens without antennae."

Karlton smiled bitterly and hid the silver wing behind his back.

"James, who do I look like now?"

"...Huh?"

James then understood.

Karlton Javier.

A crossbreed of the Sky people and humans.

Since he was half-human, he was not born with the Sky people's unique traits of long pointy ears and a gem on the forehead. All he had inherited was the silver wing. Without it, there was no telling that he wasn't human.

'Right... if that man is like him...'

That was when James stopped.

'But [The Stubborn] let go of him for that petty reason?'

James looked at Karlton.

"You seemed unconvinced."

"...I'm sorry."

"No, your suspicion is well placed."

"What?"

"I would not have let him pass under normal circumstances."

James then realized something.

"Was there an order from the inner castle?"

"Yes, they were in a hurry. They will go look for those two as I already sent a message. Whether he's from the Greens or not, he carries the stone and he can use it so it won't matter."

The Stone of Forgotten Spirit.

The stone that empowers an Adapter's Spirit Power. The stone that corrupts anyone other than the Greens.

Finding one who could use such a stone was important.

James suddenly thought of something.

"...Is it related to the Master's sickness?"

"I don't know the details. But..."

He was certain that something was going to happen in Gorgon. Karlton recalled the conversation with Jaehwan.

"I don't know what you are up to."

"..."

"I'm not that Greens person. You must know that."

"Of course I do."

"Is it okay to let me go then? Isn't it against your 'justice'?"

Karlton smiled.

"Soon, our justice will meet again."

Karlton then remembered Jaehwan's terrifying energy. It was that energy that made Karlton exit the office quickly. He didn't know why, but the man seemed to want to fight him.

'No, maybe what he wanted to fight was...'

Karlton then looked at the wall of the fortress. If Jaehwan did not give him the stones, or if he had drawn his sword, what would have happened? Karlton wasn't sure.

"Oh, and James."

"Yes, sir?"

"Jaehwan told me that you are the one who took the bribe."

"T-that is..."

"According to the Code of Law, Chapter 34..."

James frowned.

Chapter 21: World of 1% (1)

There's a world that you can never reach just by trying.

-Meikal Garnad

In [Chaos], there were outposts that allowed Adapters to rest while hunting. The most famous among them was the Three Palace's Four Fortress. The four fortresses had considerably easier entry and allowed settlements that a lot of Adapters loved to visit. Gorgon Fortress was one of those four.

'I should've just fought him.'

Jaehwan thought about Karlton reading the law to him.

Jaehwan did not trust anyone who spoke of laws. Even back in his tower, there were a lot who worked in law-related fields.

-All humans within the tower are equal.

They first began creating laws to protect the weak. It seemed reasonable to create laws as the tower was completely divided from the outside world. They made many laws and some even seemed to protect the weak.

But it was a lie.

The laws became things that only those who made them could understand and people fell prey to the laws that they did not even know about. They had to pay heavy taxes and had to hunt in controlled areas under the guise of 'protection'. They were also only allowed to acquire weak skills and weapons.

The laws that worked considering all humans as equal had succumbed to skills, status, items, and levels.

The laws were weak against the strong, vicious against the weak, and became complicated to keep in place. When the tower was at its limit because of the society that the laws had created, the ones who created those laws disappeared into the past. They were abandoned.

Jaehwan made one law after the 85th floor.

All 'humans' live today.

That was the law he had been following all this time.

'Anyway, this place is too complicated.'

Jaehwan frowned. He also had a burden. Mino still seemed to be dazed. She, however, did follow Jaehwan as he walked. It was annoying to take her with him, but he didn't feel good to leave her be when she was the first 'human' that he had met. Jaehwan decided to walk around until Mino came back to her senses.

He walked through merchants selling various herbs, equipment, and various foods.

"I haven't seen the castle master recently..."

"I heard he's sick."

"Hmm..."

After a long walk through many merchants, Jaehwan realized he had lost his way. He was now in a back alley of the bazaar. Deep in the alley, people that looked like gangsters were inhaling the 'medicine' that Mino took.

'Where the hell am I?'

Jaehwan activated [Suspicion] and [Understanding]. It was so he could gather any information he heard from his surroundings. However, he ran

into a problem. It was his first time visiting such a crowded place. He was bombarded with information and received a headache. That was when he obtained an important piece of information.

"Hey, it's about time you woke up."

Mino slowly came back to her senses.

"...why am I here?"

"Don't ask and lead the way. I'm having a headache."

Mino looked around and then guided Jaehwan.

"Let's go that way first."

As they walked out to the alleyway, they arrived at a big road with fewer people. Jaehwan felt his headache disappearing.

"Good. You can go now."

"...Don't you think that's rude?"

She now remembered everything that had happened. Mino's face blushed.

"You're a hindrance."

Mino shouted, "I was just trying to tease you!"

Mino then felt every strand of her hair rise as Jaehwan glared at her.

"...I'm sorry."

It was too much for a simple tease. After all, Jaehwan did save her life. The incident that they had just gone through might not have happened if Mino hadn't tried to tease him.

"...I'm really sorry."

Mino looked at Jaehwan, but he did not answer. She waited for an answer, but she realized that Jaehwan always did not answer. She didn't even know who he was.

The one thing that she knew was that he was a human.

He was the kind to ask, not to answer. He asked if she would go back to the past, and he also asked why would he need the Certificate to prove himself. He asked questions that she had never even thought about.

That was all that Mino knew about Jaehwan.

"Where are you going now?"

"It doesn't concern you."

"...tell me anyway."

Mino looked hurt from such a cold refusal.

"I need to find something."

"What is it? Maybe I can be of help."

Jaehwan paused for a second and answered,

"[Nightmare]."

It was a name Mino had not heard for a long time. The beings that were called [Creators] in the [Great Lands]. The beginning of every nightmare.

"What are you going to do when you find them?"

Jaehwan did not answer.

"Avenge them?"

Mino thought Jaehwan might actually do that.

"You won't understand even if I explained."

Mino opened her mouth to speak, but closed it. She figured asking more questions might anger Jaehwan and she probably wouldn't understand anyway if she heard the reason.

"...It's hard to come across even in the [Great Lands]. They never stay in one place either."

"So, they're not here?"

"There might be one if you look through [Chaos]. They are one of the few who can enter the Tree of Imagery without dying."

It was interesting information, but it made sense. The Tower of Nightmares was a part of the Tree. But there was a Demon on the 100th floor. He was sure that these [Cultivators] or [Creators] knew how to access the tree without dying.

"Uh... I can't guarantee anything. "

Mino spoke after hesitating for a long time.

"I know a place where a [Nightmare] might be at."

"Where is that?"

"There's a blacksmith. The one made by [Nightmare]."

Jaehwan looked at his Frost Dragon Sword. He needed to stop by a blacksmith anyway.

"Oh."

Mino nodded. Carrying around that kind of valuable sword without a scabbard would draw too much attention.

"Shall I lead the way then?"

Jaehwan nodded as he gripped his sword.

"Yeah, but after I beat those that have been following us for a while."

Jaehwan turned. At the corner, there were the ruffians that were sniffing medicine back in the alleyways. The man who seemed like their leader walked up.

"Leader! It's him!"

"Haha! We got you now. Bring that sword to..."

As they took out their swords, Jaehwan stabbed with his sword.

The head of their leader turned into white powder and dissolved away.

After a moment, ten ruffians all disappeared into white powder and dispersed.

'I think there was one hiding that was not a ruffian...'

One was watching him from the top of the structure. He was noticed when Jaehwan used [Suspicion]. Jaehwan also knocked him unconscious while he was dealing with the ruffians. He didn't kill him because he wasn't a threat.

Mino spoke in astonishment.

"It's really amazing every time I see it. How do you manage to do everything by just stabbing?"

"That's the only skill I have."

"...you're kidding."

"No."

"Aren't there various types of stabs?"

"Yeah. Slight stab, regular stab, strong stab."

"...What did you just use?"

"A slight stab."

The ruffians were strong, considering that they were just fools lingering on the streets. Most were Non-Adapters but a few seemed to be at the 1st stage. However, they were killed by a 'slight' stab. Mino remembered when Jaehwan wiped out the Red Fox Clan and asked, "Have you only used 'slight stab' until now?"

"No, I used 'regular stab' once."

Mino thought it was when he wiped out the Red Fox Clan, but it wasn't.

'I killed that five-horned wolf with 'regular stab.'

Jaehwan also remembered that he had the horn of that five-horned wolf. It was the strongest enemy he had ever faced after he came to [Chaos]. The wolf did not die even after being struck by multiple 'slight stabs'. But it was killed in one hit with a 'regular stab' anyway.

"...Well, I have seen someone who uses only one skill, like you."

"Like me?"

"Yeah. But he uses 'slash'."

An Adapter that only used slash. Jaehwan became interested and was about to ask, but was cut off by the faint sound of metal being hammered from a distance.

It had been a long time since he had heard such a sound. Jaehwan remembered his friend Jay and his blacksmith.

Jaehwan loved hearing the hammering sound from Jay's Blacksmith as he dived into the Temple's holy water. It wasn't music, but it was a calming sound that gave him peace.

Even after Jay disappeared, the memory of that sound stayed in Jaehwan's mind.

Maybe it was because of the sound that allowed Jaehwan to press on and eventually break through the 100th floor.

"That's the biggest blacksmith in Gorgon."

[Twilight's Fall]

That was the name of the place.

The people of the [Great Lands] had once discussed this topic.

"Who are the best artisans in the Great Lands?"

The best artisans, after a long discussion, were unanimously decided as the [Nightmares]. If Lords were the most powerful beings in the [Great Lands], [Nightmares] were the best artisans within the [Great Lands]. 500 [Nightmares] that were called [High Artisans], and the 13 [Nightmares] that were called [Master Artisans], were considered the best [Creators] in the [Great Lands].

[Twilight's Fall] was a blacksmith shop made by the top-ranking [High Artisan], 'Ignell of the Deep Fall'.

Jaehwan looked around and nodded in satisfaction. This was a much better quality blacksmith than the one in Atopos. The inside was large and all the tools were top quality. Tens of artisans were working on various projects and the furnace at the center radiated an intense heat.

"So, a [Nightmare] made this place?"

"Yeah."

"Then, it might be here."

"Maybe."

One of the Apprentices, who was in charge of talking to customers, came and greeted them. It was a young, healthy-looking man.

"Welcome-"

"Are you a [Nightmare]?"

The Apprentice frowned at the question. [Nightmare] only meant one person. Mino quickly stepped up to interrupt, "I'm sorry, he's not really bright on such things."

"Oh, I see."

Mino smiled brightly and the pprentice accepted her apology.

[...He's a human no matter how you look.]

Jaehwan did not answer.

"What brings you here?"

"I came to meet the [Nightmare]."

"...You mean Chief Blacksmith."

The Apprentice seemed troubled.

"He's not in his seat right now."

"Where did he go?"

"Well... he likes visiting various places. Are you here with a request for him?"

Jaehwan thought about it.

"That might be a good idea."

"If I may ask, what are you trying to ask him to..."

"Scabbard."

"..."

The Apprentice looked at Jaehwan's scabbard-less sword and shook his head.

"Even if he were here, he wouldn't accept your request."

"Why is that?"

The Apprentice looked at Jaehwan and scoffed.

'So, he really isn't bright.'

He continued, "His specialty is not making weapons. Maybe you're not aware, but [Nightmares] specializes in making 'other' things."

Jaehwan wanted to ask what they were, but he realized he knew the answer. It was because he had spent 30 years with those 'other things' that they usually made.

Chapter 22: World of 1% (2)

Jaehwan shook his memories away. He was disappointed as he wanted to ask the [Nightmare] something.

"Who's the top artisan here then?"

"Hmm... It's Vice-Chief Meikal. But..."

The Apprentice looked at Jaehwan from top to bottom. Jaehwan also looked down at himself. He forgot that he looked like a beggar.

"The cost of a request from Meikal is expensive. You need the materials too..."

"I have the materials."

The materials meant horns from the horned monsters. They used steel and iron, but there was no material more valuable than horns within the Tree of Imagery. None of the metals were as light and durable as horns.

"...You have a horn?" he asked, his voice filled with suspicion. The horns that the [Twilight's Fall] used were the horns of a bihorn or higher. They had mass-produced weapons that could be used by Non-Adapters or 1st stage Adapters, so it was unnecessary for special requests with unihorns.

"We only take in horns from bihorns or higher. Why don't you just choose one from the mass-produced scabbards? They are still well-made..."

Jaehwan shook his head. As the Apprentice became red with anger, Jaehwan spoke.

"By bihorn, you mean the monster with two horns?"

"...Yes."

Jaehwan reached into his backpack and took out the horn. It was the horn he got from killing the monster wolf. After he handed it to the Apprentice, the Apprentice looked at it for a long time and then began to shiver.

'How many horns did this one have...?!'

He had trained in [Twilight's Fall] for a long time but he had not seen such a horn. The shine of the black horn and its durability... even its thickness alone was mesmerizing.

"This... this is so beautiful...!"

He realized this wasn't for him to decide; he needed to fetch the Vice Chief at once! After glancing around for a while, he stopped. There were tens of artisans that had gathered next to the central furnace.

"Oh, there he is!"

Before he could finish, Jaehwan had already begun walking. He was followed by a sighing Mino and the Apprentice with the horn.

Meikal, the Vice-Chief Smith of [Twilight's Fall]. Everyone in Gorgon Fortress knew his name. He was the only blacksmith with the title [Apprentice] amongst the humans. The title was usually only given to the [Nightmares]. So even if the title represented the lowest rank, it was a great feat for a human to have such a title.

"I'm an old man now."

Meikal remembered the day he first earned the title, tens of years ago. A [Nightmare] had come and spoken to him.

-Blame your heritage. You will never achieve a higher rank than [Apprentice].

He did not heed those words back then. Young Meikal back then thought he had time and passion. He thought he could get into a higher world if he

tried. He practiced while [Nightmares] slept, and studied metallurgy while [Nightmares] played.

But as he was faced with the twilight of his age, he knew.

It was something that could not be achieved no matter how hard he tried.

"I guess I've been doing this for too long now..."

Meikal mumbled as he looked at the horn in front of him. It was the horn from one of the Ten-Clan vice leaders from [Chaos]. It was to make a sword and the work was almost complete. The only thing left now was to put in the final touch.

'I need a place to fit a gem in the center of the sword hilt.'

Shaping the quadhorn wasn't easy as it was too durable; it was hard to tear it apart. He barely managed to craft the blade and shape it, but that level of finesse wasn't easy.

[Nightmare]'s unique skill [Craft].

When he became an [Apprentice], he received the skill from the [Nightmare]. Even with this skill, carving the horn out still wasn't easy.

Meikal put it down for now. He needed to rest before continuing the job. After he stopped working, artisans around quickly began reaching out to him.

"Master, can I try..."

"Let me try..."

Meikal grinned. It was good to be young.

"You should train more if you want to work on this one."

Meikal knew none of them would surpass him, but their passion motivated him. All he could do now was to make sure that the youngbloods and their

efforts were put in the right place.

"Good. If any of you can make a hole in this horn, whoever it is, I'll make you Vice-Chief for the day."

He was giving them hope in achieving something even though it wasn't possible. Meikal thought it was his job to provide such hope.

"Wow! Is that for real?"

Young artisans lunged at the horns and obviously, no one succeeded. Even the ones who had a bit of Spirit Power couldn't even make a scratch. That was when someone spoke up.

"Let me try."

It was an unfamiliar face. Meikal looked at him weirdly as he fanned himself against the central furnace's intense heat.

"No! You can't do that!"

Then Meikal noticed young Apprentice running after him, holding onto something. He was a young Apprentice who was in charge of the entrance. Meikal asked, "Naven, who is he? What is it that you're holding?"

"Uh, this..."

Naven wasn't sure how to reply. He glanced between Jaehwan and the horn, and Jaehwan answered instead.

"You need a socket in this hilt?"

Meikal narrowed his eyes. The man looked like a beggar but he sounded like an experienced artisan.

'I guess he's a traveling young artisan.'

Meikal waved his hands to let other artisans stand back.

"Let him be."

It was astonishing to see a man with such confidence in [Twilight's Fall] while being cornered by many experienced artisans.

However, he was still foolish.

The reason why [Twilight's Fall] was famous because of its classes. Meikal thought it was a good chance to show this young man the difference of classes. Then, he was shocked.

'...What?'

It looked like the man was trying to poke a hole using his finger. He was definitely crazy. Meikal had heard that high-ranked [Nightmares] could work on horns without any tools, but he had never heard of any human capable of doing that.

'If that can be done, I would not have done all the...'

With a loud boom, dust exploded everywhere. The sound itself was as if the whole building itself had collapsed.

Meikal didn't know. He did not know that it was the sound of his lifelong work that was about to become worthless.

As the dust settled, they were able to see the small hole in the hilt.

"Wh-What-WHAT?"

They all couldn't speak or believe what they were seeing.

"This should do, right?"

The man stood there with his finger in the hilt, spinning it around. Meikal felt like his whole world was spinning with it and asked, "...Who are you?"

Jaehwan thought it was tiring to hear that question now and answered,

"Vice-Chief."

Meikal then brightened up a bit. If he was the vice-chief of some blacksmith, he might be a skilled artisan.

"Vice-Chief of where?"

Jaehwan answered, "Twilight's Fall."

At that answer, some of the artisans frowned and shouted angrily,

"Don't mess around!"

However, Jaehwan spoke calmly, "Didn't you promise earlier?"

Promise? Everyone became dumbfounded. Then, everyone thought of what Meikal said earlier. Meikal's face was grim. Jaehwan spoke again, "For today, I'm the Vice-Chief of [Twilight's Fall]."

And at that moment, the quadhorn on Jaehwan's finger began to crack. Meikal grew pale.

"N-NO!"

The bone shattered into pieces and turned into powder. Jaehwan frowned and mumbled,

"...Dammit. I thought I was careful."

Chapter 23: World of 1% (3)

Meikal could not think straight. He didn't know what the man did, but it was a quadhorn that had been broken. The bone that was so valuable that it was priceless. What should he tell the owner?

"I'm sorry. I didn't intend to do that."

"Sorry? Are you saying you're sorry?"

Meikal roared as he trembled in rage. He was now thinking if he should hammer the man to death or put him into the furnace alive. But Jaehwan spoke, "I'll repay you with something better."

"...Repay?"

Everyone scoffed. It was the horn of a quadhorn they were talking about. A quadhorn was not only rare; it was so powerful that only the elders of the Ten-Clan could barely manage to fight one.

"You should keep your promise if I do."

"Promise?"

Meikal then remembered what he said about making space for a gem in the bone hilt. It was infuriating. He was talking about the promise even in this situation.

"If you can replace the horn, I will let you do whatever you want whether it's the Vice-Chief role or anything else. However, if you try to repay us with something stupid, you will not walk out of this place alive."

Jaehwan nodded and turned to Naven.

"Put it down here."

Naven brought over the horn and placed it down next to the furnace. It was the black, large horn of a monster. Everyone stopped, wondering what it was. Then they all gasped.

After a while, someone mumbled with a moan.

"I...It's the horn of a Garnak...!"

Pentahorns were categorized by their species because they were that dangerous and powerful. A Garnak was a wolf-like monster that required many elders and even the Vice-Leader of the Ten-Clan to fight it.

Everyone fell silent and Meikal ordered them in a heavy voice,

"Close the door. We are closed for the day."

Apprentices ran to close the doors to the blacksmith and the iron doors were shut. It was the third time that Meikal had seen an unprocessed Garnak's horn. The first time was when he had just come to [Chaos] while he was at another famous blacksmith, and the second was when the former Vice-Chief of [Twilight's Fall] worked on one.

"...It's amazing."

It looked like it was cut from a young Garnak as the horn had taken no damage. Everyone was focused on the horn.

"Is that enough?"

"....Yes. It's more than enough."

The value of a pentahorn was more than ten times that of a quadhorn. He could have just cut a part of it and it would've been enough, but this man gave it away whole. This was much more than enough.

Meikal pondered and answered,

"For today, [Twilight's Fall] is yours."

Everyone began mumbling but Meikal shouted angrily, "QUIET!"

Silence fell again and Meikal asked, "Where did you get this?"

"I killed it."

A man hunted a pentahorn down, but Jaehwan said,

"We'll start working so get ready."

"What are we working on?"

"I'm making what I need."

Naven then ran to Meikal and whispered. Meikal nodded.

"I see. So you need a scabbard."

"Yeah."

"What about the material?"

"This."

Jaehwan took out another horn. The pentahorn had five horns, so he obviously had more. But it didn't make sense to Meikal.

"Are you going to make a scabbard using a Garnak's horn?"

It was a pentahorn they were talking about. The material seemed like overkill just for a scabbard, so Meikal asked, "Can I take a look at the sword that you're trying to make a scabbard for?"

Jaehwan lent him the sword. After Meikal looked at its status, he moaned,

"Ahh... the Frost Dragon Sword."

"Do you know about it?"

"It's a sword made out of the Frost Dragon King's horn. Or at least that's what it says."

The Frost Dragon King was an Evil Dragon that lived in the 'Forgotten Region', or the most dangerous region among the 12 regions of the [Great Lands]. The sword was made from monster's horn. It was bound to be a powerful weapon.

However, it was a shame that this sword was only a replica.

It was obvious. Meikal had listened to the news of the [Great Lands] and had never heard of the Evil Dragon being hunted down. It seemed like a certain [Nightmare] had witnessed the Frost Dragon King and made a replica afterward.

"It's valuable since a [Nightmare] created it but it's a bit of an overkill to make a scabbard for a weapon at such a level. It might be better for you to make a new sword out of the horn..."

However, the sword began to cry. Meikal dropped it in shock and it landed on top of the Garnak's horn. The sword then vibrated even harder as it opened its 'mouth' and began devouring the horn.

"It's a Spirit Weapon..."

The Frost Dragon Sword began glowing as it finished eating the Garnak horn.

"I'm witnessing a lot of fascinating things today. Your sword is evolving."

The blade became sharper and the durability became tougher. It was now tough enough to compare to the Garnak horn. The black aura that the blade was radiating was now so dense that the only way to hide it was to cover it up with a cloth. It was in dire need of a scabbard. This kind of spirit energy needed to be covered up to keep unneeded attention at bay.

'It seems like the spirit of a higher race is absorbed within... why...?'

The blade kept on crying. Meikal checked the sword and spoke,

"It's a Greater Evolution. It will take some time to finish. But you will need a new name for it once it's finished."

"Name?"

"Spirit Weapons lose their original name when it goes through a Greater Evolution."

The sword was wailing now. Meikal then turned to Jaehwan.

"But now we don't have the material anymore."

The material had been devoured by the sword.

"It's okay. I have more."

Jaehwan took another one out from his backpack.

Meikal stood in front of the Garnak's horn. It was the first time he was given a chance to process a Garnak's horn. He had seen a horn that was processed a long time ago but...

'Can I really do it?'

He was a Vice-Chief and he had received the title of [Apprentice], but he barely managed to process a quadhorn.

'I'm not a true [Apprentice]... I didn't even create a tower.'

Although it was the same rank, the difference was too great. While humans were having a hard time creating a sword, [Nightmares] created towers that turned into worlds.

Meikal looked down at the Garnak horn. There were some materials that could be overwhelming just by looking at it.

"I'm sorry, but I don't think I can..."

Jaehwan was wearing something.

"What are you... no, Vice-Chief. What are you doing?"

Jaehwan pulled up his sleeves after changing into a smith's protective gear and spoke.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

Meikal became confused.

"I'm making the scabbard."

"...What?"

"You should help me."

He couldn't understand. Jaehwan had tremendous power, that was for sure. He had the power to destroy the horn. However, destroying it wasn't the same as processing it.

"But you can't..."

"Right. I can't do it alone."

Jaehwan nodded. He had the power, but he didn't have the necessary skills.

"That's why I need you," Jaehwan said as he glanced at the trace of the [Nightmare]'s skill [Craft] still lingering at the end of Meikal's hammer.

At the same time, within Gorgon Castle.

A middle-aged man in clean, formal clothing, coughed as he drank his tea.

"What? You lost him?"

"...I'm sorry, sir."

The man in dark clothes bowed his head as he kneeled in front of the middle-aged man.

"What happened?"

"I don't know, sir. I just... got knocked out and I woke up lying on a roof."

The middle-aged man frowned. He had been knocked out but did not know how he was knocked out.

"What stage are you at?"

"3rd stage, sir."

"What's your stealth rank and level?"

"It's at the high-ranked and master level."

"And you were found out?"

"...I don't know what happened, sir."

"This is crazy."

If a 3rd stage Adapter with a master level, high-ranked stealth skill was in hiding, it was hard for even higher ranking Adapters to find out. But the target had found him and easily knocked him out without him knowing.

'Karlton said he probably wasn't the 5th stage...'

Maybe he was at the 5th stage. If he was at that stage, the man needed to be prepared.

"We'll gather more men. Find him, no matter the cost."

At that moment, a deep thud came from the underground cell below the castle. It was a slight tremor, but the middle-aged man, who was a high-ranked Adapter, was able to feel it. Then he heard a faint, long scream coming from below.

He frowned.

"...Master, please hang on a while longer."

Chapter 24: World of 1% (4)

A day passed after coming to [Twilight's Fall]. The promised time for the Vice-Chief position had passed but the artisans didn't seem to mind. Maybe it was because it was a rare opportunity to work on the horn of a Garnak. Even just having a glimpse of the horn getting worked on was a thing of legend.

Mino quietly left [Twilight's Fall].

Middle-aged men were heard talking loudly from within the saloon. At the center was an old hologram machine that was showing a broadcast. The person on the broadcast was a pink-haired [Nightmare] with a small horn.

[The top ten videos, together with Siroen! It's about time to end. The last video is one you all might know! There isn't anything more famous than this video in [Little Brother] recently! It is the [Solo-clearing of the 99th floor] video!]

The video then showed a man solo fighting a giant Frost Dragon. The man kept stabbing it over and over, endlessly. His face was censored so that the Product information would not be leaked. The men at the bar rumbled while watching.

"I wonder what happened to him. The Lords want him badly."

"Huh? You didn't know? That tower is on hold for Cultivation."

"On hold? Why?"

"I don't know. Maybe some dumb Demon tried to cheat in it. There's a rumor that he ran during the Cultivation because of it."

"So that's a fake?"

"Of course. Do you think it's possible to beat a 1st gen tower alone?"

The men discussed it for a while but soon changed the subject. Besides, the subject of the matter was irrelevant to them now. This was [Chaos], the world of the dead.

"I hope I get a [Fruit] someday. I want to be revived."

"Haha, you won't even get a seed with that kind of thought."

"Hey! Give me a unihorn beer!"

At that moment, the door to the saloon slammed open and a woman walked in. It was Mino. She walked briskly to the bar and sat down. Her thin waistline and fair-skinned face immediately attracted all the attention of the men in the saloon.

"Hey, lady. Are you here alone?"

"Get lost."

"Yes, ma'am."

The men were shocked and scared by the vicious energy pressure that Mino was releasing and ran out. Mino laughed bitterly.

'I'm strong compared to those buffoons.'

She thought about Jaehwan and felt bitter. Then, the owner of the saloon appeared.

"You, girl, are bad for my sales."

"...Aunt Claire."

"So... Auntie... listen..."

Mino was too drunk to talk straight, but she kept on mumbling.

"I've heard enough, girl."

Claire, the middle-aged woman, frowned. She was a survivor from the world 'Arkal' where Mino had come from. She was the only one left alive from Arkal in [Chaos].

"So, what you're saying is this."

"...Huuuh?"

"You tried to cheat on a man and almost got killed, but he saved you."

"..."

"Then, you tried to prank him again and got what you deserved."

"..."

"And yet you still tag along with the man like a fool?"

Claire narrowed her eyes; she knew Mino well. Mino was like this since they met at the Tower of Nightmares. She was weak, but she had a temper. In addition, she also liked to prank people and cause trouble. She wasn't bad but she always got the people around her into trouble.

"You even got me killed once, remember?"

Mino drank her beer.

"...Am I that much of a nuisance?"

"I think the man is dangerous. Let him go. You can get any man you want."

"...Heh heh."

"Why are you still on his tail?"

Mino's eyes shook. She thought for a while and then spoke.

"It's just... when I look at him..."

Claire had heard many stories that followed starting with those words. She braced herself for a long love story or something similar. However...

"He makes me so mad."

It was unexpected.

"He's so arrogant, he's ill-mannered, and talks crap... but no one can stop him. He does whatever he wants but no one can stop him. Red Fox Clan. The Stubborn. Twilight's Fall. None of them. ...Claire, do you know what that makes me think of?"

Mino glanced around the saloon and continued,

"It feels like my entire life is a joke."

".."

"I didn't die because I didn't want to. Me and you. We did the best we could."

Mino smiled bitterly.

"And him... he just comes out of nowhere as if he wants to prove that all we did and all we fought for is wrong. He just destroys, kills, and break things apart..."

Her mug was emptied and then she refilled it again.

"Maybe I just want to see... someone stop him. I can't do it. But someone... might come along and put an end to him. So..."

Claire then understood what she meant. She also felt something similar, a long time ago in the past. She ignored it and ran, and got old. She knew what Mino was going through.

"Mino, let me give you advice."

"Huh?"

"Don't talk to him or even go near him anymore."

"...Why?"

"If you stay with him, you will 'really' die."

Mino flinched. She had never seen Claire's face this solemn since she got Claire involved in an incident where it killed the both of them. Before Mino could reply, a message energy made from spiritual power shot through the window of the saloon and reached Mino. She checked the sender.

[Karlton – Northern Gate Captain]

'...Huh? Why me?'

At that moment, Mino felt a terrifying pressure from all sides. It didn't feel like it was there to fight her, but the energy was overwhelming. And there were a lot of them. There were many that Mino could not guarantee victory against in a one-on-one fight that were closing in. Then, the doors to the saloon opened and men walked in. Mino pulled out a dagger from her clothes despite her drunken stupor. One of the men walked up to her and asked, "Are you the Witch of Massacre?"

"...What if I am?"

The gate closed upon her answer as the man smiled ominously and said, "I need you to do something for us."

The blacksmithing started by supplying spiritual power to the central furnace. With the horn of Garnak as the material, they needed more spiritual power than usual to create a more powerful fire from within. As the flame erupted, Jaehwan looked at the now-clean Garnak horn.

"Show me how you work on it first."

The first thing [Twilight's Fall] did when processing a horn was to create a basic ground. Meikal was actually designing how to work on the horn with a quill pen and white ink. The basic sketch needed to be detailed because once the horn was processed, it could not be undone.

The central furnace was now glowing with bright white flame and Meikal put the horn in a prepared setting and waited for the horn's bonds to loosen. After some time, the surface of the horn started emitting some kind of vapor and Meikal took out the horn and began cutting.

The cutter moved through the white inked mark on the horn. Even after it was loosened, the horn's durability was so tough that a total of 14 cutters were broken in the process. After it was done, Meikal said, "It's now up to skill from here on."

[Craft], the unique skill only given to creators at the [Apprentice] level.

The skill was at its max. The hammer shone with a white light that made it hard to believe that a mere blacksmith was wielding it. But Jaehwan's expression did not change as he had seen a similar thing in the past.

-Jaehwan, what I'm doing is not blacksmithing. It's just a game of chance.

Jay, the top blacksmith of Atopos, told him once.

-I've done what I can. I have mastered almost every skill related to blacksmithing and I can assure you that I can repair all the weapons from this Tower of Nightmares with a 99% success rate.

The weapons in the Tower of Nightmares were just common weapons in the [Great Lands]. All the items within the Tower of Nightmares were replicas from the [Great Lands]. However, a repair rate of 99% was one of a kind. The only one who had such a high success rate was Jay. In fact, Jaehwan had never seen Jay fail to repair something.

-But when I got to that percentage, I felt like I was missing something really important."

Jaehwan didn't get what he meant so he asked.

-I spent my time and effort to reach 99%. You know, sometimes I think I'm just trying hard to run away from that 1% instead of running toward the 99% chance.

It was not long after that discussion that Jaehwan acquired [Suspicion]. It was a power that was different from normal skills. It was imperfect but free.

"I got it. We'll take a break here."

Jaehwan stopped Meikal who was drenched in sweat. A long time had passed but there were no scratches on the horn. Only the chisel and hammer were broken.

"Crafting takes a long time. And if the material is the horn of Garnak, it might even take a month."

"I know."

"...You know? Haha," Meikal laughed.

"Don't tease an old man."

"..."

"You know I'm lying, don't you?"

Jaehwan did not answer. He just touched the surface of the horn. A material that no hammering could damage. Jaehwan could not use the [Interface System] anymore, but he knew what Meikal heard for an hour as he worked on crafting the horn.

[Skill has failed.]

"I'm too old to handle a Garnak horn. You should've visited me earlier."

Meikal slumped down on the chair next to the furnace and lit up a cigarette.

"You want one?"

Meikal offered a cigarette and Jaehwan shook his head. The other artisans' faces became heavy. Meikal wasn't the type to do something else while working, but now he had stopped and was smoking a cigarette.

"There are some things that you just can't do, even if you try thousands of times. Young ones like that Naven over there might not think of it, but I know."

Naven blushed. It was the Apprentice that showed Jaehwan and Mino around the day before.

"N-no, Vice-Chief!"

"Haha, have you forgotten that you talked back to me last time?"

Meikal then turned back to Jaehwan.

"He really tries hard. He was pushed out to the entrance because he talked back, but his future is bright. The future 'Mastercraft of Twilight' will be him. He might even get the [Apprentice] title if he's lucky, but..."

Meikal put out the cigarette against the anvil.

"We can't go beyond our birth. Not even him. Man cannot become the finest blacksmith. Just like I can't handle this Garnak horn."

Jaehwan knew this old man's thoughts weren't just because of the Garnak horn. It was something deep within him that crushed him. Jaehwan said, "You never know without trying."

"I've tried. Hundreds. Thousands."

"Then you should do millions."

"What if millions don't work?"

"Then billions."

"Billions? Haha, you're young," Meikal laughed.

"You probably think that I didn't try hard enough."

"..."

"But I did. Believe it or not, I did. I'm not sure if I tried a billion times, but I something close to that. I tried and tried. That's how I got here."

Meikal thought about his past. It had been a long time since he had arrived at this blacksmith workshop.

"How long have you lived?"

Jaehwan counted his age. He was 20 years old when he was summoned to the tower and he had lived 30 years within the tower.

"Fifty years."

"Really? So you must have died early."

Jaehwan looked like he was in his 20s. It didn't make sense if he died at the age of 20 and lived 30 years here. Meikal spoke,

"I have lived for 150 years."

Meikal's tone became a bit arrogant. He felt relieved after knowing Jaehwan's age. He thought that no matter how great this man was, he was too young to understand.

"You will not understand no matter how hard I try to explain. You have not lived as long as me."

No one could fully grasp another's time. It was true. Jaehwan answered, "No, I know."

Meikal chuckled. It must be the young blood in Jaehwan that make him insist. Meikal thought he should give this young man some gentle advice but Jaehwan spoke first, "You have tried harder than anyone else."

"..."

"You got here by trying and trying."

Meikal couldn't reply. It was just a simple sentence with basic facts, but Meikal was surprised. Shocked. There was none who accepted what he was. He was praised when young and admired when old. However, not once did he feel like he was accepted for what he was.

'I may have grown old.'

Meikal became bitter.

"Thank you for that."

Jaehwan did not answer and Meikal became curious about what the young man thought of Meikal's life.

"I want to ask you something."

Meikal took out another cigarette.

"What do you think I lack?"

"..."

"Talent? Birthright? Luck?"

Jaehwan looked at him. It was deep. No, it was more than just deep. His stare made Meikal feel uncomfortable.

"You do not lack anything."

"...What?"

"No. It's more like..."

"Like?"

"You have too much."

"Too much? What do you mean?"

Meikal asked back in confusion and Jaehwan answered, "You have lived for too long."

Chapter 25: World of 1% (5)

Lived too long? It was the artisans around them that became enraged at Jaehwan's words.

"How dare you?!"

But Meikal was calm. He was deep in thought at those words.

"...What do you mean?"

Jaehwan did not answer him outright.

"Use your skill again."

Meikal stood up and followed what Jaehwan told him to do. He held the chisel and the hammer and tapped on the horn. Once, twice, and a third time. Jaehwan stopped Meikal and asked, "What did you see?"

"...What?"

"When you used the skill, what did you see?"

Meikal became confused but Jaehwan shook his head.

"Look closely and do it again."

Meikal used the skill again. His ears were filled with the message saying 'Skill Failed'. He ignored the message and glared at the point where he had used the skill, but he couldn't see anything. All he saw was the hammer and the chisel.

"Yes, you will see that kind of thing."

"...Are you joking with me?"

Meikal almost threw the hammer at Jaehwan out of rage. Jaehwan asked, "Do you know how the chisel and the hammer manage to work on the horn?"

Meikal pondered and answered, "The [Craft] skill works..."

Jaehwan shook his head.

"I asked you the wrong question. Let me ask you again."

Jaehwan looked straight at Meikal, found the right words, and asked, "Do you know how your [Craft] skill works?"

Meikal's face turned grim.

"Young man, do you know what you're talking about?"

Meikal seemed angered.

"Do you want to know how the skill works?"

There were countless skills, but all skills were based on another. The skills of the origin. The [Craft] of [Nightmare] was one of those kinds of skills. They existed way before any other skill. They existed before the world even came into existence. At least that was what everyone living in the [Great Lands] thought.

How could a human explain the origins of such an existence? And what was the point of doing that?

Jaehwan nodded.

"Right. So you do not know what exactly you are doing and just kept on using your skill."

Meikal gritted his teeth. Jaehwan's words had injured his pride.

"...The spiritual power empowers the hammer and the chisel and wields the power to work on the horn. That's probably how the skill works."

"Really? If it's that simple, then why can't anyone else use it?"

"That's..."

It was simply because they did not learn the skill. Meikal tried to answer, but held back. It didn't make sense. If how the skill worked was that simple, then it did not make sense that one needed to learn the skill to use it.

"You don't know your skill, but you're using it."

Meikal started to hate the man. No one knew about how the [Craft] skill worked and this man was insulting him just because of it.

"You sound like you know how it works."

"Yes. I found out just now."

"What?"

Jaehwan then touched the horn with his hand. The surface swirled as if it was reacting to his touch. In the next moment, something unbelievable happened in front of Meikal.

"H-how did you use [Craft]...?!"

Jaehwan cut the horn with his finger as he ran it along the white marking. Meikal became dazed. He felt his legs losing strength and slumped to the floor. He was filled with jealousy and despair.

"...Wha-what are you? How did you earn such blessings and talent?"

"It's not a talent," Jaehwan answered firmly.

"Look again closely and tell me what you see."

Meikal looked at Jaehwan's fingertip again. The particles that his finger touched were dug up as if something had eaten them.

"...The particles are being destroyed?"

Jaehwan shook his head. Meikal focused closer.

"It won't be easy. Your hard work has made your 'world' more durable."

Jaehwan was correct. Even when Meikal was watching with his own eyes, he didn't fully trust Jaehwan. He was blinded by the suspicion that he was being cheated on. There was his distrust toward the young, and his stubbornness for his work. The product that he strengthened over the years weren't his skills, but his pride.

"Your work itself wasn't wrong."

"Then..."

"If you tried that much, you must've realized it by now."

The parts of the horn where Jaehwan's finger touched were destroyed.

"If trying that hard did not work, it's this world that is wrong. Not you."

"B-but..."

Meikal couldn't understand. How was that possible? Meikal thought about the days when he first learned the [Craft] skill. His young days were full of uncertainty. He believed that he could become like a [Nightmare] one day, but he was full of doubt. He wasn't sure that doing the same thing that a [Nightmare] did could advance him beyond those [Nightmares].

Meikal eventually decided to just try harder. He used the skill over and over again. He tried so hard that he couldn't even think. After pushing himself and being rewarded with a sense of achievement, he forgot about his doubt. However, it was natural as his success rate increased as his skill improved. It was the world that rewarded him for his effort.

That was how he got here.

There was no other way and his only way was now blocked.

"...This world is wrong?"

Meikal's voice became heavy, "And what do you propose that I do?"

It was the voice of his 150 years of hard work.

"You want me to fight the world?"

Jaehwan looked at Meikal. It was the old man's eyes who were betrayed by the world he believed in, but he still could not abandon it.

"...You may be old, but you can still fight it."

Meikal's eyes shook.

"Look again closely. Don't rely on anything else. Just use your eyes."

Meikal understood what he said. Jaehwan was telling him to throw away all the knowledge he had learned, and all the skills that he knew. Reject everything that he had built up over all these years. However, Meikal became curious about what he would see. Maybe it was only the part of his youth that was left in him.

Meikal forgot about the skill.

It was hard to break from the binding that restricted him, but he did not stop. He focused on Jaehwan's fingertip. He tried hard to see what he had missed. Jaehwan picked up the hammer and chisel and the [Craft] skill shone at the end of it.

After multiple taps, Meikal felt his spirit disintegrating. All his logic and senses were broken apart. Then he felt something being destroyed and a new truth came into him.

Then he felt that he saw something that he had never seen before. He closed his eyes to shut it out, but he knew. The world he had lived in was now gone. Now, he was stepping into a new world.

There was a horn in front of him.

Yet it was not a horn. It was a giant monster as tall as a fortress wall with many sharp teeth and spikes protruding from its body. Meikal shuddered and watched on.

He had been facing such a thing until now. He was using his puny skill against such a monster.

He looked around and there were dead bodies near the area where the artisans were standing. Their skin was rotten and their eyes were full of maggots. Meikal felt like he was going to lose his mind.

Then there was Jaehwan.

With his hammer and chisel, he was facing the monsters without any skills.

The monster attacked Jaehwan and he attacked back. The monster screamed and spat blood out from its body, but it didn't seem to be bothered. It was enjoying it. The dead bodies around them cheered, uncertain if they were cheering for Jaehwan or the monster. Among such chaos, Meikal was dazed and afraid.

'This man... was he always looking at such a world?'

The world beyond skills, status, or levels. Nothing was hidden so it was vulgar, but it was an honest world. Meikal was afraid, yet thrilled.

This was the World after the Apocalypse.

How could this world exist? And how did that man not go mad?

Meikal then locked eyes with Jaehwan. Jaehwan looked like an ordinary man in this world. He was no hero or savior of the world. He was just a common man. The only thing he had was the courage to not give up on this

world. Meikal then understood Jaehwan's madness. His loneliness. His sadness. He understood and knew that no one could fully understand Jaehwan.

The horn 'looked' at Meikal.

-You cannot come here.

The fear of the world's rejection. Meikal stepped backward in fear. There was nowhere to go. The monster approached with his large mouth wide open. The inside was filled with dead bodies and Meikal saw his reflection in the monster's giant eyes.

'How... how can I... in this world...'

That was what Meikal thought before the monster ate him. Almost.

Jaehwan frowned and pulled Meikal out. Jaehwan wiped off his sweat and spoke.

"Get yourself together."

"Ugh..."

"Did you forget that we're in process of working? Help me out."

Meikal faced the monster again. With Jaehwan's hand on his shoulder, Meikal gained courage. Courage to face the world without any skills. Courage to walk along a path he had never taken before. Courage to take the step that he could have taken a long time ago.

Then his hand became covered in flesh. The veins appeared within, and new blood flowed. His heart pounded, and his sight cleared. He felt his body was filled with energy, just like in the days of his youth.

He charged at the monster, toward the Garnak's horn.

Two days later, the scabbard was complete.

Chapter 26: Dead man (1)

[There's something worse than dying. If you have visited [Chaos] at least once, you would know.]

-Yoo Surha, the 2nd Squadron Captain of [Rupture]

Episode 5. Dead man

Three days later.

Jaehwan was standing at the entrance of [Twilight's Fall] with his scabbard. The work that he thought would take one day actually took three, but it was still much shorter than the average of three weeks for processing a horn. Meikal and a few artisans came out to say goodbye.

"...Are you really going on your way?"

"Yeah, I got what I needed."

He also had some unexpected information. When Jaehwan [Understood] the [Craft], he acquired some interesting information. Those monsters were not naturally occurring. The Garnak horn had already been [Crafted] before they worked on it. That meant-

'Monsters are the creation of someone else.'

There was no telling who did it and for what purpose, but they were carefully crafted masterpieces for sure. Jaehwan tapped on the scabbard and said, "I like it."

It seemed like his sword also liked it as it let out a satisfied cry. The scabbard glowed with a black light. Its durability and ability to cut off dark

energy from the outside was great, but the scabbard also had a power to scare off trihorns and below with something called [Presence of Garnak], which was useful. Meikal looked at the scabbard and asked,

"Oh, did you choose your sword's name?"

"No."

"If it's alright, can I name it for you?"

Meikal smiled and said, "I felt something after watching you for three days."

They were short but impactful days.

"I don't know what you wish to do and why you showed me that 'world'."

Meikal remembered the world. After he came out from it, everything seemed like a lie. He would probably never be allowed to see that world again. It was because of Jaehwan that Meikal, who was too used to the skill and interface, managed to see the world. Was it a dream? A hallucination? Or...

Meikal looked at Jaehwan.

"But I know one thing."

Whatever it was, one thing was certain.

"The people in this world will not like you."

In this world, the truth did not mean justice. People here were too used to the reality of their ways. They did not like uncertainty and complication and this man was a mix of all that.

"Some might be astonished by you, but most will not."

Meikal thought about Jaehwan when he first walked in. A man who knew of no modesty.

"Some might fear you."

He was violent.

"Some will belittle and look down on you."

And he looked foolishly weird.

"Some will ignore you."

Meikal knew. He knew what Jaehwan did would buy him hatred. The world would reject him and some would even want to kill him.

"But you still want to save that 'world?'"

Meikal wanted to stop him. Even if the world he was shown was great, and the world contained something that all people of [Great Lands] had to know, Meikal wished for Jaehwan to give up on it and live instead.

However, Jaehwan did not answer. Meikal then knew that the man did not have a choice. The world was his life. He would brave the world alone no matter what.

Meikal laughed.

"The only name fitting for that sword will be one."

Meikal ordered someone to bring a hammer and chisel and used the [Craft] skill to engrave the letters on Jaehwan's scabbard.

-Lone-denied

"Farewell."

Jaehwan nodded and walked away. Before Jaehwan could walk too far, Meikal said, "Let me ask you one thing."

Jaehwan stopped.

"In the 'world' that you see... what am I?"

Jaehwan did not turn back, as if he refused to turn. He answered, "...A human."

He then walked away. Meikal knew why he did not turn back. Meikal sighed.

'Who can understand his world?'

There was a woman walking toward him. Meikal laughed.

"Youth, eh?"

Jaehwan felt something had changed as he walked. Something that was normally beside him wasn't there. It sometimes poked him while he was at the blacksmith and lurked around like a cat, but it had gone missing since yesterday. Maybe it was finally gone.

"Are you looking for me?"

Mino appeared in clean clothing. She wore a short dark top with black tights. She still had the dark robe over her though.

"Where have you been?"

"Somewhere close."

"What did you do?"

"Stuff. I'm a busy woman you know? Oh, and take this."

"What is it?"

"Your clothes. You can't keep walking around like a beggar."

He then remembered his clothing was still ragged and took the clothes. It had a medieval style, but it was okay. Everything was black up to the coat.

"...It's just a token of my apology."

"I see."

"Maybe you should say thank you?"

"Thanks."

Mino then turned around to look at [Twilight's Fall] in distance. Meikal and the artisans were still watching.

"They must have liked you."

"No way."

"You looked like you were close to that old man though."

"You've got it wrong."

"But he looked at you like a lover or something."

"..."

Jaehwan did not reply. They walked the wide streets for a while. Then they came to the side of the road with more people.

"Why are you still following me?"

"Why? Do you think I might have some dark motive or something?"

"I'm also considering that."

Mino's expression changed for a short moment but Jaehwan noticed it. Mino smiled and asked, "How did you know?"

"...What are you up to?"

"I'm planning to kill you."

"And do what?"

"And take your Spirit Stone."

"And then?"

"...I didn't think about it afterward. Well, it will get me good money, so that's a start."

Jaehwan smiled. Whether she really meant it or not, it was not going to happen. Mino felt her pride getting hurt.

"I'm serious, you know?"

"Sure."

Mino was curious about where Jaehwan gained such confidence. She thought it came from his sheer strength, but Mino knew other powerful individuals like Jaehwan, such as the leader of the clan she was in. But Jaehwan's confidence was different from theirs. Mino then felt that Jaehwan was not from this world.

"What are you going to do now?"

"I'm going to meet up with the [Nightmares]."

"How?"

"Meikal taught me how."

"And what will you do when you meet them?"

"Ask about Tree of Imagery and find the way to go to the [Depth]."

Mino's face turned weird.

"...Why would you want to do that? To become strong? Or be reborn?"

There were people who wished to go up to [Depth], the branch of the Tree of Imagery. Many failed to do so and those who did mostly never came back. Even the ones who returned and earned the title of the 'Strong of the Depth' became victims to PTSD which destroyed them.

Tired, Jaehwan asked, "Are you THAT curious about my motive?"

"Yeah."

Jaehwan looked coldly at Mino. Mino flinched but did not step back.

"You won't believe me even if I tell you."

"...Try me."

Jaehwan turned up to the sky and Mino looked at him. Then Jaehwan said something.

Mino became dumbfounded. She couldn't understand it at first. It wasn't because she didn't understand the words he said. It was just because-

It was simply impossible.

Mino laughed out loud. It must be a joke, and that was what she thought. However, she realized that Jaehwan was not joking. She frowned.

After that, she felt even when she knew it was impossible, that Jaehwan might be able to do what he said he would do. She became angry.

"...What are you? What makes you think you can do that? Who are you to do that?"

"..."

"I hate you."

Mino could not even understand why she was getting angry.

"You do whatever you want, you have no manners, you don't talk, you look down on everyone and..."

She lowered her voice.

"You don't consider others as humans."

Mino realized she should not have said that but she continued talking, "They all are having a hard time even without you doing that. We barely got out of the roots, got to the [Great Lands], and died to come here."

Mino thought about why she was saying all this. Was it out of anger? She did not know. But she needed to speak.

"Did you ask me if I was human back then?"

Mino thought about what Jaehwan asked. She knew what he meant at the time, but maybe that was not what he meant.

"I am human. I'm not as strong or as confident as you, but I'm still a human."

Maybe the word 'human' meant something greater to him, but that was too hard for Mino.

"As far as I know, a 'human' is someone who lives day by day and considers it happiness to survive. Not living with some big dream."

There was a fork at the end of the road. Mino felt this was the fate laid out in front of her.

"In that sense, you don't seem like a 'human' to me."

And they reached the fork in the road.

"We should part ways here."

"..."

"I can't stay together for 'that kind of purpose' any longer."

Mino then ran into the road that was full of merchants. Jaehwan stared at her until she disappeared into the crowd. The first 'human' he had met. After a while, he mumbled, "...I should change clothes first."

Mino arrived at the saloon. It was Claire's.

'...What brought me here?'

Mino thought as she stared at the door. This wasn't the plan. Jaehwan should've followed her here and opened the door first, but she couldn't do it. She had lectured him about humans and stuff and could not bring him here. She wanted to let the man know that the humans here weren't bad. They might lack the requirements that Jaehwan had set, but they were still humans.

Mino opened the door and walked in.

"I'm sorry, Auntie. Am I late?"

Claire was tied down to the chair with an empty expression on her face. She turned to Mino and grinned.

"...I knew it, you brat."

"..."

"I should've stopped you earlier."

"I'm sorry."

Claire shook her head while laughing.

"You are 'really' getting us killed this time."

Claire cleared the Tower of Nightmares with Mino and even stayed with her in [Chaos]. Mino bit her lips as she glanced at Claire. She would not be able to save her friend anymore.

"Witch of Massacre."

A cold voice filled the saloon. It wasn't only the saloon; the entire area around the building was filled with terrifying energy. The owner of the voice was the man who had come to visit Mino days ago.

"What's happened to our deal?"

"He's not coming."

The atmosphere was horrifying. However, Mino just laughed in that atmosphere. Maybe she had been influenced by Jaehwan.

"He's gone to destroy the world."

Chapter 27: Dead man (2)

Mino thought that everyone around her had met a bad fate since her days in the Tower of Nightmares. In fact, her nickname, 'Witch of Massacre', wasn't something she actually acquired in [Chaos].

When she was in the Tower of Nightmares, the first party she joined was attacked by monsters and was wiped out. She was the only survivor of the group. The people back then considered her to be 'lucky'.

Mino felt strange. She felt like it was some kind of premonition.

It was only after the second and third party were wiped out that she knew for certain. She had survived all alone, again. People now were suspicious and began to wonder. After similar happenings occurred a few more times, people began to be wary of her and stayed far away.

-Is she the 'Witch of Massacre?'

The witch who brought the monsters. The cursed woman who killed all her party members. People shunned and abandoned her. The abandoned 16-year-old girl... that was Mino. Mino later found out that her bad luck was her passive skill.

High-grade skill [Lure]

It was the sole hidden skill in her Tower of Nightmares. Mino still thought of the day of the clearing; about what might have happened if she did not have Claire and her other friends with her. When everyone shunned her and she faced clearing the tower alone, they were the ones who came to save her from the danger.

That was why Mino still trusted humans.

Even if there were terrible things in the world, even if the world was filled with evil people, there were still some good people. Some were not strong or did not have talent, but they would still willingly die for others.

Mino survived because of them.

She tried hard to become strong and survive. If she was cursed and brought misfortune to others, she needed to be stronger than the curse. Thus, she joined the Dark Forest clan. To learn powerful assassination skills and gain spiritual power. The result was in front of her.

[Girl, don't hesitate if you've come this far.]

Claire was biting her lip hard. Her face was bruised and bleeding.

[Being weak doesn't mean we don't have the right to choose death.]

Mino became saddened.

[Hang in there, Auntie. I'll save you.]

Claire smiled bitterly. She and Mino both knew that it was impossible, but Mino couldn't give up. She glanced around. The situation was worse than expected. There were more than ten 3rd stage Adapters. The man in the center was even more powerful than what Mino could measure. They were much stronger than those Red Fox members.

There were not many organizations that had the ability to mobilize groups with these kinds of people within Gorgon Fortress. It was either the Ten-Clan or someone with power. There were only two from the Ten-Clan within the Fortress.

The Fire King Clan led by Kanghwang and the Arms Extreme Clan led by Shin Mukuk.

But these people didn't seem to be related to either of those clans. Kanghwang was known for his freedom and Mukuk was known for his noble manners. Both would not allow themselves to do such dirty work.

Besides, some of these men were comprised of assassination targets that she had been assigned to before.

'Desert Serpent?'

Desert Serpent was a 3rd stage Adapter who hunted down newcomers in the desert region, east of [Chaos]. He hid his face with a mask but his cross-shaped scar on his eyes was not something he could cover. She couldn't find him before and had to give up on the request, but here he was.

'Wait... all of them...'

She belatedly realized that these people were wanted fugitives and understood who they were. There was only one clan that could unite those criminals and use them.

Golden Sky Clan.

It was a clan made of ruffians and criminals, but the clan had become powerful. They accepted criminals that were shunned by the other clans. Someone among them walked up.

"You must be out of your mind, witch."

Mino felt a shiver run down her spine.

'4th stage Adapter...!'

And there was more than one. The two behind him were also close to the 4th stage. 4th stage Adapters were so powerful that three of them could even handle a grown pentahorn, or a Garnak. Mino knew their names. A 4th stage Adapter was so rare that their names were usually known within [Chaos].

"The Jan brothers..."

They were infamous around this region. They were high stage Adapters never joined a clan... until now.

"Why didn't bring him? Was it not part of the deal?"

"Did you hear the witch make the promise?"

Janya frowned.

"The stone belongs to us."

"That sounds persuasive."

"We were trading with the Greens. The man intercepted it."

"Right."

Mino narrowed her eyes.

"Then why don't you confront him yourself to get it back, or send a help request to the Fortress? Why go about it the hard way?"

"That's..."

Janya could not answer. Mino scoffed.

"It's not too late. Bring him here."

"What if I don't want to?"

"Then you will die."

Mino did not answer and Janya's eyes were filled with anger. At that moment, the 2nd brother, Janmyung, came out.

"I heard the women of Dark Forest are one of a kind! I've always wanted to have a taste."

Mino frowned.

"So, you do know that I'm from Dark Forest."

"Of course, I do."

"And you want to try and do that still?"

Mino pretended she was confident even when she felt every inch of her skin crawling.

"You guys think your clan is something just because you came up to the Ten-Clan level, but you will regret it. Dark Forest isn't that easy."

In fact, she had already notified the nearest Dark Forest station. But it would take them at least an hour to arrive and she had no way of dragging out the time. Suddenly, the third brother, Janmang, laughed.

"You think we are fools?"

"..."

"We know there is no Dark Forest branch within Gorgon Fortress. You will lie naked before they even come here."

"...You will be hunted by Dark Forest."

"That's for our clan master to deal with."

Janya flicked his finger and all of the Golden Sky members cornered Mino.

"Enough. We cannot waste any more time."

Mino bit her lip.

'Dammit...'

The Jan brothers' specialty lied in the [Shadow] skill. It was the leaked version from the renowned family, Black Spirit, and while it did not match theirs, it was still very powerful. However, Mino's skill did not fall far behind. Seven daggers floated behind her.

High-grade skill [Seven Daggers of Akaram].

It was what she had inherited from the clan master of the Dark Forest clan. It was said that the skill was given by a [Nightmare] and was proven to be very powerful.

"Haha! So, the witch knows how to fight!"

The Jan brothers left images as they moved through the shadows and swung the hidden blades at Mino. Mino's robes were cut as her white skin was revealed. Her right arm was left with a long cut.

"It will be fun to strip you naked!"

She managed to kill two 3rd stage Adapters, but there were still a lot of enemies. And the Jan brothers attacking from her blind spots was troubling.

'If only this was outside the fortress...'

Outside fortress, she could use her [Lure] skill and she might have been able to bring in monsters to fight in the chaos, but this was inside. She sent out a few daggers imbued with spiritual power and made a side of the roof explode. The hole was big enough for everyone around to hear what was happening inside.

"You think you're smart?"

"..."

"It's no use. We already laid silence magic around this area."

Her last trick didn't work. It was obvious that they had someone who could use silence magic if they had come in with this crowd of people. They might have even bribed the guards.

"You were called the 'massacre' during hunts, but what about now?"

Janmyung's sword cut the side of Mino's thigh. It was a deep wound.

"What about 'naked', Brother?"

Janmang laughed as he saw Mino's clothes torn off from her shoulder.

This was not a fight.

Some of them were now touching the other female employees of the saloon. They knew they didn't have to fight.

She had to send a message to tell the Dark Forest Clan to hurry. The criminals of Golden Sky were now shaking the already fainted Claire by yanking her hair.

"It's not too late yet. Bring him here before that old hag dies."

Mino's patience broke at the pitiful state Claire was in.

[Seven Daggers of Akaram] Final skill, Frozen Blades.

The seven blades released a freeze with the Spirit Power that filled them. The storm covered all of them. Janmyung and Janmang were left with some wounds.

The one who stopped the skill outright was Janya.

"I will rip you apart myself."

Mino felt her legs losing strength as her Spirit Power was now close to zero. She could barely hold onto a pillar to keep herself from kneeling. She saw Janya walking closer and thought, 'Is there no salvation in this world?'

It was a world filled with criminals. Even if there were some good ones, if those criminals stood on top, then that world was hell. The humans that Jaehwan spoke of, the humans Mino spoke of, would all be left to die by those criminals.

Mino closed her eyes as she saw his blade. For the first time, she thought she wanted to go back to the past. What if she had followed him at the fork in the road? She might have been able to watch the world fall, and later tell the others about it. Mino became jealous of herself in her imagination.

However, she knew that there wasn't that kind of future. She would never meet with Jaehwan now.

After a moment, she realized something was wrong. She did not feel the cold blade on her. The surrounding air seemed to be still. She knew this feeling.

She opened her eyes and saw the Jan brothers staring weirdly in her direction. She knew that look.

She thought she hated this cliché and felt her legs finally give way. Someone kept her from falling down. The hands were rough but warm. He was tough but reassuring. Mino looked up and saw the man's face.

"...Weren't you going to destroy the world?"

Jaehwan then held up a bag. It was the bag that contained the clothes that Mino bought for him.

"They're the wrong size."

Chapter 28: Dead man (3)

Jaehwan knew everything when he and Mino stood at the fork in the road.

[Don't be foolish, witch.]

[If you don't keep to the deal, that old hag is dead.]

Whispers kept flying to Mino. Jaehwan knew what was going on. Someone was threatening her and was holding a hostage. And the criminal wanted Jaehwan.

Jaehwan thought Mino would betray him.

After [Understanding] the world through countless [Suspicious], he realized that this world was full of stats and data. It was filled with people selling even their spirits for higher stats. To Jaehwan, Mino was the same kind of dead corpse. The [Suspicion] that was never wrong warned Jaehwan that Mino would betray him. That was why Jaehwan did not listen to Mino.

-As far as I know, a 'human' is someone who lives day by day and considers it happiness for surviving. Not with some big dream.

When Mino's story ended, Jaehwan came back to his senses.

-In that sense, you don't seem like a 'human' to me.

With those words, Mino left him, with no hesitation or betrayal. His [Suspicion] was wrong. That's when Jaehwan's thoughts went blank. [Suspicion] lost power and the words that came to him from all around stopped and his world was covered in silence. He felt his heart ache.

Why did she look 'human'?

He couldn't understand. As he saw Mino walking away, he shook his head. Similar things were happening, one after another.

Mino answered that she would not go back to the past.

Meikal made the scabbard together with Jaehwan.

They became human at that moment, but only for a short time.

They soon returned to being dead bodies.

Jaehwan knew. Focusing on each of them would not change the world. No matter how many times he saved them, they would not become human. Jaehwan turned back.

That was when his [Suspicion] returned with the voices.

[The witch has betrayed us! Send the message!]

[...The [Nightmare] we brought is no use then.]

'[Nightmare]?'

That was how Jaehwan came. Mino looked up to him and asked, "...Did you really come because of the size?"

She thought Jaehwan really would've come because of that, but he did not answer.

Janya was thrilled by Jaehwan's appearance.

'I don't need to go looking for him then.'

He was sure that Jaehwan had the stone as Janya could feel the power of the Greens in him. Jaehwan asked, "Hey, you guys have a [Nightmare] right?"

Janya's face darkened. It was top-secret, even among themselves that they had a [Nightmare]. Janya sent a [Whisper] to ones working on the silence barrier outside.

[He knows about the [Nightmare]. What happened?]

[...That can't be...]

It seemed they were too shocked. Jaehwan asked again, "Where's the Nightmare?"

"...I won't tell you," Janya blurted out accidentally. He realized that he had confessed that they had a [Nightmare], but it was too late.

"Bring the [Nightmare] here."

Janya frowned.

'Is he mad?'

He appeared suddenly and asked about the [Nightmare], and now was ordering him to bring the [Nightmare] here.

'...Why am I listening to him anyway?'

Janya became angry. He was the eldest of the Jan brothers. He was the shadow of the Forest Region and the Killer of the Forest.

"I heard rumors that you mean to fight the Fortress... it seems you really are as mad as the rumors say."

Mino expression turned grim as she saw Janya pulling out two swords.

[Be careful. They are 4th stage Adapters.]

After fighting with them, she realized that Janmyung and Janmang were close to the 4th stage. But Janya was well into the 4th stage. The 3rd and 4th stages had vast differences as they were considered the beginning of high-stage Adapters. Most of the elders in the clans were at least in the 4th stage.

"Do you think I will lose?"

[...No.]

Mino was surprised that she was admitting it so easily. He was up against a 4th stage. The enemy was someone that could even fight a Garnak. He was able to wipe out the Red Fox Clan like a piece of cake. Yet she was still not worried.

The one who moved first were the brothers.

[Shadow]

The shadow swords swung at Jaehwan. It was hard to tell which was real and which was not. Jaehwan moved to dodge, but the attacks followed. Jaehwan barely managed to dodge the blades.

'That's why they say 4th stage and above are high stages.'

The skill that the man was using was very powerful. Jaehwan was planning to find the real ones by using [Suspicion], but their spiritual pattern was not easy to recognize.

Jaehwan became annoyed and decided to deflect all the blade attacks. White light filled the air as Jaehwan used 'Slight Stab' multiple times. There were so many that the attacks left traces lingering in the air.

Janya frowned.

"This can't be...!"

Chapter 29: Dead man (4)

Jaehwan had deflected every single shadow blade and aimed for Janya's head. But his attack barely missed.

'He dodged?'

It was Jaehwan who was surprised. There was no one who had dodged his 'Slight Stab' until now. No, there was one, but he killed that with his 'Normal Stab' and was now his scabbard.

"Brother!"

Janmyung was holding Janmang while he was shocked by the unexpected damage. It seemed Janmang's thighs and right arm were wounded by the stabs.

Janya was shocked. He could not believe what he had just experienced.

The man in front of him had just deflected every attack just by using [Stab] and even aimed for his head. The only reason he was able to dodge the attack was because he was lucky.

If his instincts did not warn him, he would have been killed. He messaged the members outside again.

[Isn't the man a Non-Adapter?]

[...Yes. We are sure.]

If the Golden Sky members said so, then it must be true. But how could he be that strong?

'...is he the 'Strong of the Depth?'"

No, he felt something similar but no 'Strong of the Depth' were Non-Adapters.

'Then what is he?'

Janya readied himself again. The man had no spiritual power and only used [Stab], but he was much more powerful than the three brothers.

[I can't believe it, but he's stronger than us.]

[B-brother, then...]

[Change tactics.]

Janya accepted quickly reality. If the enemy was strong, he just needed to fight accordingly. Jaehwan frowned at the change in tactics. The Jan brothers quickly grabbed the hostages and began fighting while holding onto them. It was a tactic to fight against Jaehwan, who only used [Stab].

[Stab] was quick, but it was also very simple. If the direction of the attack was blocked from the start, it was easy to deal with. It proved to be very useful in fighting Jaehwan.

However, that didn't matter.

"What...?"

Jaehwan's right hand began gathering Spirit Power. It was so powerful that the whole building was shaking. He was preparing for 'Regular Stab'.

Jaehwan did not care about the hostages. The Jan brothers, the criminals, the hostages, they were all dead bodies in his eyes.

But when he tried to [Stab], his heart ached. His sight blurred and the faces of the hostages were covered with an image.

'What is it?'

Jaehwan ignored it and tried again. His sight blurred and a voice came to him.

-I'm human. I'm not as strong or as confident as you, but I'm still human.

Jaehwan became confused. Why was he seeing those dead bodies as humans? His body was refusing to attack. His body was telling him to not use 'Regular Stab' against them.

The brothers began running rampant once Jaehwan's attacks stopped. His [Suspicion] was shaking and his [Understand] was doing the same.

He needed to kill the hostages.

He tried to use 'Regular Stab' again, but he couldn't focus. Even his [Suspicion] was now making it hard to focus. His [Suspicion], instead of being suspicious of this world, was now being suspicious of [Suspicion] itself.

He felt his spirit undergoing change. Something deep and powerful that was also warm was being born from within. It was something very old, but something he longed for. Long-lost power...

However, the problem was that it was not going to help him right now.

'Dammit.'

Jaehwan, for the first time ever, regretted that he only knew how to stab. If he had some other skills at least...

'Other skills... hmm...'

Jaehwan suddenly redirected his 'Slight Stab' at various parts of the saloon. Some attacks were aimed at the Jan brothers, while others were aimed at the roof. The attacks made the saloon look like it was full of bullet holes.

"He's gone mad!"

Janya laughed as he thought he had gained the upper hand. It was apparent that the man's Spirit Power would soon fall to zero at this rate. A few minutes later, Jaehwan stopped attacking. He had used his stab so much that the saloon roof was now full of holes and the sky was visible. Jaehwan looked up at the sky and lowered his sword.

'This should do.'

He turned his back to them and Mino became shocked.

"W-what are you doing?"

"I'll let him take care of them."

"...Him? Who are you talking about?"

"The talkative, stubborn one."

Talkative, stubborn one?

Mino thought of someone. But how...? At that moment, one of the Golden Sky members shouted in shock.

"Janya! The Silence Barrier has been broken!"

Janya was completely shocked.

"What?! WHEN?!"

He sent a message to the ones working on the Silence Barrier, but he couldn't feel their Spirit Power. He then glanced around the saloon. The holes made by the stabs. Those attacks...

Suddenly, everyone in the saloon felt powerful energy quickly approaching. It was powerful enough to confront a 4th stage Adapter with ease.

It was a powerful, yet pure energy. There was only one who had such spiritual energy. The door burst open and men in silver-white plate armor walked in. It was the guards from North Gate and...

"What is going on here!"

The silvery glow filled the saloon. Bright, blonde hair, with a silver wing coming from the back shoulder. The most stubborn Gate Captain.

Karlton the Silver Bind.

Mino swallowed as she watched. It was her first time seeing Karlton look so reliable. Karlton narrowed his eyes as he found Jaehwan in the crowd and asked, "Jaehwan? What's going on here?"

Jaehwan nodded and answered, "These are people who have disobeyed that law of yours. I'm not too familiar with your laws, but they probably did not follow Chapter 276 and Line 4."

Karlton glared his eyes and asked, "...Who are they?"

"Them."

Jaehwan pointed with his chin and Karlton turned to them. There were criminals holding hostages.

"What are they..."

"I think they are conspiring to destroy the world with this saloon as the start."

Mino was dumbfounded by the lie but Karlton pulled up the giant silver halberd in his hands.

"Destroy the world... I can't let that pass."

His face grew cold.

"Under the laws of Gorgon, I will arrest you all for illegal trespassing, destroying private property, and kidnapping."

The Jan brothers and all the Golden Sky members became pale.

Chapter 30: Dead man (5)

Silver Bind was very powerful.

All criminals could not resist his [Orders] and the brothers were having a hard time against [Silver Bind]. Karlton was living up to the reputation of the 'best of the four Guard Captains'.

"So, it wasn't a false rumor that you can kill a Garnak alone...."

Janya deflected Karlton's halberd as he gritted his teeth. To the Adapters traveling in [Chaos], the [Silver Bind] of the Sky people was the worst skill to fight against. Janya was barely resisting, but his two brothers were already bound. Karlton's halberd swung towards Janya's neck.

"Your resistance is futile."

Janya gulped.

[We should use Black Cloud.]

[Are you serious? If we do that...]

[The ones who were reinforcing the barriers are all dead. We will all die anyway.]

[...Understood.]

Janya then knelt and raised both his hands.

"I surrender."

"Wise choice."

Karlton then released the bind and approached. At that moment, Janya laughed.

"You are as naïve as rumored also."

Karlton then realized something and shouted, "Everyone! Get out of the saloon!"

Something exploded from within Janya and a black cloud began filling up the saloon. Within the smog, people moaned and coughed. Some who moved out of the smog tried to come back in, but Karlton yelled, "Don't come back inside!"

The smog did not go away and Karlton's voice disappeared. Then, the sound of flesh and bones twisting was heard.

The Janya brothers were watching it unfold at the top of the ruined building next to the saloon.

"I never imagined I would need to use Black Cloud here."

They were all covered with some kind of a mask. Janmyung spoke grimly,

"Janmang breathed in a bit of the cloud."

"...Fool. I warned him so many times."

Janya frowned as he saw Janmang's darkened face.

"If he swallowed only a bit, he might live. Hang on."

Then, they saw reinforcements from Golden Sky running towards them.

"...About time."

Their leader was the high stage Adapter and an elder of Golden Sky, Heuk Surlang. He was famous for his sexual desire in the [Great Lands] and was eventually killed by Adapters with his tongue and penis ripped out. Janya was ashamed to side with such a man.

"Janya, look at you... how pitiful."

"...Shut up."

"What happened to the witch? You need to hand her over to me."

"I didn't have time for that."

Surlang frowned. He then checked the cloud in the saloon.

"You were in a hurry, I see. Using the cloud with the Leader's permission?"

"Silver Bind was here."

"Silver Bind?"

Surlang's voice shook.

"Wait- so Silver Bind is in there right now?"

"Yes."

Surlang cackled at the world.

"HAHA! That fool swallowed up the Black Cloud? That's a sight to behold."

No criminal had a good impression of Silver Bind. Even Surlang had bad memories of Karlton.

"That's a good sight to watch," Surlang said, but Janya didn't seem too excited.

'...What happened to him?'

Silver Bind wasn't much of a problem. Under normal circumstances, he would have defeated him already. The problem was the man who cornered them with just a stab.

And he couldn't stop thinking that the man was probably not affected by Black Cloud.

"Oh, and where's the stone?"

"Not yet."

"...Don't tell me you let the Fortress take it."

"Don't worry. We just need to pick it up now."

Janya adjusted his mask and readied himself to walk back into the saloon. The saloon was covered in black smog. Even the smallest effect was enough to corrupt the spirit so he did not want to go back in. The ones inside had probably reached their limit of corruption already.

'I don't even want to think about it.'

He knew what became of the ones who reached the limit of corruption. There was no one in [Chaos] who did not know this. Suddenly, Surlang stopped Janya and asked,

"...Janya. Who is he?"

Janya turned and found a man looking at him. He had casually walked out of the smog-filled saloon. Janya was shocked. It wasn't possible. Even the Greens could not stay normal after breathing in the cloud, and he was not one of the Greens.

"...He's the one with the stone."

"Oh? Good. Get him!"

The men who came with Surlang charged as the man took out his sword.

Step by step, with each step he took, Janya felt the ground shudder. One strike equaled the death of one of his men. Surlang bellowed, "What is he?!"

Who was he? That's what Janya wanted to know. He checked and it looked like there was still about fifty 3rd stage Adapters. That was enough to wipe out mid-level clans. Janya calmed himself.

'We have enough... we have...'

Jaehwan frowned as he fought off the enemies. There were too many to stab each one and there was a chance that more bad things might happen again if he wasted any more time.

He did not use his sword because he did not like relying on an item's power, but it was time to use it now. Jaehwan drew the sword from the scabbard. It was then that Janya first realized that the man had been fighting with the scabbard on.

'So I was only fighting a scabbard?'

The sword cried out with ominous power as it was drawn. Everyone excluding Janya and Surlang froze. It was as if a giant horned monster was standing in front of them.

"G-Garnak..."

The skill within the scabbard. [Garnak's Presence] was activated.

Janya stared at it dumbfoundedly. The reinforcements were smashed like insects and when he came back to his senses, the only ones left were himself and Surlang. But Surlang was already far away, fleeing.

'...Bastard.'

Janya then looked at his brothers on the ground. He would not survive.

"There's one way for you to survive."

To survive? Janya's eyes opened wide.

"Where's the [Nightmare]?"

[Nightmare]...

"Why do you laugh?"

Jaehwan asked Janya who was laughing maniacally.

"I can't tell you."

He knew. If he told him about [Nightmare], he would die even if he survived. He thought of one man. The strongest in [Chaos] and the only one who could unite [Chaos].

The leader of Golden Sky.

Even if this man was strong, would he be stronger than the leader? He couldn't agree. He believed it was only possible for his leader to unite [Chaos] and get the [Fruit] to return to the [Great Lands].

"Ke...hahaha..."

He laughed. With the cloud out, 'IT' would start now.

'If I'm going to die here...'

Janya quickly pulled out a dark gem and swallowed it.

[Stone of Forgotten Spirit]

Chapter 31: Dead man (6)

It was only for an instant, but Jaehwan saw the stone. It was definitely the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit], but with a different energy. The energy began expanding in Janya's body and grew.

[HAHAHA! KAHAAAAHA!]

Janya's voice distorted and all his veins blackened as his muscles expanded. His power of around a 4th stage Adapter was amplified nearly twice and exceeded that of a 5th stage. Then, Janya's body cracked from his torso and a giant mouth with vicious teeth opened up as tentacles began spreading out from within.

[So this is the power of the Dead Man!]

Dead Man.

That was what one changed into when corruption reached 100%. It was feared by all who lived in [Chaos] and everyone considered it a fate worse than death. It was the form of a monster that lost all memories and was only left with desires.

[My memories...]

Janya felt his memories being wiped away as he was left with simple desires. He was now free from himself. He was now free to throw himself into temptation, into destruction. He was now in the world.

[So, this is the world's truth!]

The world where all humans looked like dead bodies. The world where stats and data ate away everything like maggots. Janya saw his tentacles and felt

like he could do anything. It was funny that he had been so afraid of becoming this being. It didn't matter if he lost his humanity if he could see this world.

"D-dead Man!"

"RUN!"

The guards began running away in terror as Janya reached out with his tentacles and began feeding the dead bodies into his mouth. He then turned to the man.

Janya laughed and tried to reach out his tentacles. But he felt something different.

Why was there a 'human' in this world?

Janya looked around, but there were no humans. They were all dead bodies. However, that man still looked human. Janya could not believe it. That being should not exist. He looked like a human, yet he felt like a dead man, but with a much greater presence than himself.

Janya tried to move his tentacles to kill the man, but they didn't move.

His tentacles were trembling. Janya, was trembling. Janya tried to attack with all his might to ease his terror and be freed from that being.

The man held up his sword and aimed. At that moment, Janya's sight became distorted. Powerful energy sped past him and he felt his entire body being torn apart while the world turned upside down. Excruciating pain filled him and he saw his reflection in the man's eyes. Ripped tentacles rained down from the sky.

'It's like the world just ended...'

And that was the last sight Janya was able to see.

[What are you... how did you acquire the power of the Dead...]

Janya's spirit lingered a little before it scattered away.

[But you will... not alone...]

Then Janya's spirit dissipated into white powder. Jaehwan rotated his shoulder and frowned.

'...I wasn't going to use 'Normal Stab' if possible.'

The trace of the stab that penetrated past Janya distorted the sky. It was as if the sky had been hammered down.

What was he?

It seemed that he had become a monster called a 'Dead Man' in this world. The monster that was born from a spirit corrupted to its limit. Jaehwan was surprised. All beings here showed him their true identity once he used [Suspicion] on them. Humans became dead bodies while monsters became tainted objects of feelings. But this 'Dead Man' did not change its shape. It meant its giant mouth and tentacles were a part of its true form.

Jaehwan decided to return to the saloon. He didn't get any information about the [Nightmare], but there was a chance that the saloon still had those that came with him. When he returned, he felt something was wrong. Karlton, Mino, and the other female employees were still on the ground. Karlton seemed to be in an especially bad condition with his silver wing that was now gone. Fortunately, he was still alive and was barely able to speak.

"Please... alert... the fortress..."

Jaehwan's expression turned grim as he saw blackened veins appear on Karlton's face. It was similar to the symptom that he just saw on Janya. It seemed that Mino was also suffering from the same thing. Jaehwan went to Mino and asked, "...What's going on?"

Mino barely opened her eyes and spoke,

"It's... spirit corruption... the worst..."

Mino's breathing was shallow. Jaehwan asked again,

"Doesn't the corruption happen because of not consuming the medicine?"

"Yes... usually..."

Spirit Corruption was a common disease in [Chaos]. It was easy to deal with by consuming medicine made from horned monsters. So Jaehwan thought it was weird. Karlton had the same symptoms and there was no way for him to have missed his medication. There was only one answer. Something had corrupted the entire saloon.

'Was it because of the black smog?'

Mino had already given up on everything. She could not use her [Interface System] anymore. It meant her spirit was corrupted and becoming a 'Dead Man' was imminent.

'So, this is how it ends...'

She then looked closely at Jaehwan's face. His distinct features and battle-worn face reflected how many trials he had faced until now. This was the first time that Mino looked closely at his face.

"What happened to them?"

"I killed them all."

"...I see." Mino answered. She could not bear to open her eyes anymore and felt her energy fading away.

"I... can't see well."

"..."

"How do I look?"

"Your veins are black."

"I see..."

Mino tried to speak. No, she did actually speak. Something in her wanted to keep speaking to him. But she could not make out what she was actually saying. She felt like she was losing her mind but she kept on talking. Her veins blackened even further.

Jaehwan looked at Mino.

"Stop. Talk no more."

Jaehwan knew what Mino would turn into. This woman would become the monster that he just killed. And Jaehwan did not know how to save her. The only thing he practiced while he climbed the tower was to kill. Mino then asked, "I know I'm not in a place to ask... but please do me a favor..."

"Yes."

Mino smiled bitterly.

"Kill me."

Chapter 32: Deadman (7)

"Understood."

Jaehwan took out his sword. This woman was a disruption. Jaehwan could not understand. Why was it when he looked at that woman, his skills were disrupted? Why did his memory try to come back? Everything wasn't going well. He didn't need feelings; they made him weak. The woman wanted him to kill her, so there was no hesitation. This was for her, and for Jaehwan.

"NO! Wait!"

Someone rushed up and held onto Jaehwan's wrist.

"There might be a chance! Please!"

It was a middle-aged woman, the owner of the saloon. She was probably the one named Claire. She had evacuated at Karlton's warning and had fortunately evaded the corruption. Just then, the paramedics from the fortress rushed into the saloon.

"This way!"

Gorgon Fortress acted quickly. The paramedics from the fortress quickly hauled Karlton and Mino outside. Jaehwan stared at Mino being carried away and asked,

"Will she live?"

"If she starts the 'Morph,' there's no chance, but..."

One of the paramedics answered hesitantly. It seemed everyone was terrified of the 'Dead Man.'

[Warning! Corruption level has reached 90%!]

It was the corruption measurement meter that Karlton had. Suddenly a siren sounded from somewhere within the fortress.

[WARNING- GORGON 4. THIS IS NOT A DRILL!]

[SMALL DEAD MAN WITHIN THE FORTRES.S]

[CITIZENS ON THE NORTHERN STREETS, EVACUATE IMMEDIATELY.]

The entire fortress plunged into chaos. Jaehwan felt it was a bit weird to be that scared.

'Is 'Dead Man' that dangerous?'

There was various information about a Dead Man coming in on his [Suspicion]. Then he felt some strange whispers. Right after, red-clothed figures appeared on the rooftops of buildings around them.

[Anti-Evil First Squadron has arrived at the scene.]

[Second Squadron has arrived as well.]

As the reports ended, the red-clothed man in the center nodded and gave an order, "We will eradicate them before they finish the 'Dead Man' morph."

Their hunt began. Most of them were higher than 3rd Stage Adapters. They were either as powerful as the Golden Sky, or even stronger. They all rushed into the saloon at once.

"Mino! Come back! Talk to me!"

Claire was feeding all the medicine in her possession into Mino's mouth. It didn't matter if what she had was valuable, whether it was uni or bihorn medicine. The doctor in the rescue team asked the paramedics, "How much medicine do we have?"

"...Not much, sir."

"Why is that? Didn't we have enough supplies?"

"It's all been used up to ease the Master's disease..."

"Dammit."

The corruption level was increasing. Something seemed to be creeping into Karlton and Mino's spirits, something so powerful that the unihorn or even bihorn powder could not stop. As they reached the hospital, the guard posted at the gate blocked them from entering as he looked at Claire.

"Karlton can enter, but the woman cannot. We do not have much..."

"I will provide the medicine! Just give us a spot!" Claire yelled.

"If you insist..."

The hospital was worse than Jaehwan thought. It was poorly equipped and the 'building' was just a tent. There were hundreds of beds with patients slumped in them, and they all seemed to be corrupted.

"Move away! Emergency!"

Doctors closed in quickly and got respirators on Karlton and Mino. It seemed that they were trying to force-feed the medicine via the respirators. Outside the tent, the saloon could be seen with smog leaking out from it. With the evacuation order, the saloon was closed down and the elites of the Anti-Evil squad stepped out to guard the saloon. From within the saloon, cries of woman employees who had turned into Dead Men were heard.

"Are you the man that Mino talked about?"

Jaehwan turned to Claire as she continued, "I sent her to hunt down the Red Fox Clan... never imagined she would come back with Death itself."

"..."

"Heard you reject all laws here. You judge the world by your standards, and you measure humans."

Jaehwan did not answer.

"I know a man like you. I've seen one."

Claire placed her hand on Mino's chest and checked her breathing before continuing. Jaehwan looked at Claire's face. He had never met her before.

"If you live long enough, you get to see all kinds of people."

Claire spoke as she looked at Mino once and then glanced around the hospital.

"People live here not because they're fools. They have no other choice."

It was voice full of lethargy. Then Jaehwan spoke for the first time,

"No, there's always a choice. You all just have no courage."

"Courage?" Claire retorted, "Why do you need courage?"

Jaehwan tried to speak, but stopped. He had seen Claire's eyes, the deep eyes with regrets over her long life. She had lived with courage all this time and now had no more courage to do so.

"You... you are the type who values a higher standard, higher justice..."

There were paramedics and doctors shouting from all around. Some with higher corruption levels were coughing black coughs. Claire continued, "It must be a wonderful thing. Too wonderful that people here cannot dare to imagine... You may be right. I may not have the courage, but because of that, I do not know what you may think. But I know one thing for sure."

Claire's eyes were similar to that of Mino's.

"I know that YOU are dangerous."

Jaehwan thought about what Mino mumbled to him before she fainted.

-I now know why I wanted to tag along with you. Why I wanted to stop you from leaving.

The words that Mino spoke earlier, and the words that Claire spoke now were mixed before it came to a conclusion.

"You must leave this place."

-You must not leave this place.

"You will bring despair to the people."

-You will bring hope to the people.

"You will make them think that nothing will change."

-You will make them think that something will change.

"The young ones like Mino will like you. They will be tempted and shaken. And then they will die like her."

-The older ones, especially those who have adapted here, will hate you. They will be jealous. And hurt. Many will die.

"I really..."

-Yet I still want to hold onto you.

Claire couldn't continue because tears had started flowing from Mino's eyes. Claire took out a handkerchief and wiped away the tears.

-Do not give up on this world.

That's when the ragged door to the hospital opened.

"Captain!"

It was Lieutenant-Captain James and the other guards. James glared at Jaehwan while a guard from before explained everything that happened. James became grim and looked at Karlton.

"Take out all the medicine we have!"

The Guards took out all their medicine, which were mostly unihorns and some bihorns. James even took out the trihorn powder he had saved.

"Even the trihorn isn't working..."

One of the doctors moaned. The corruption level wasn't going down. One of the guards then asked worryingly, "What do we do? If he becomes a Dead Man..."

"No one can stop him." James spoke clenched his fist. That was when Jaehwan asked from a distance, "Is there any way to reverse it once someone becomes a Dead Man?"

A doctor nodded and Jaehwan glanced between Karlton and Mino. Then he suddenly grabbed Karlton's collar and spoke.

"Hey, get up. I have something to ask you."

Jaehwan began slapping Karlton's cheeks. He hit so hard that Karlton's cheeks turned red and the guards became furious and ran in.

"H-how dare you do that to our Captain...!"

However, Karlton did wake up.

"C-Captain!"

The guards gathered around. Usually, guards hated their superiors, but the guards of the Northern Gate were all worried about their captain. Karlton must have been a good superior to them. Karlton murmured, "...Jaehwan."

"Yes."

"...I have a favor."

"Yes."

"Please kill me."

Everyone wanted to be killed. Jaehwan frowned.

"You should be able to do that. Please, before it's too late."

Karlton looked at Jaehwan's emotionless face.

"Isn't it time to ask to be saved instead?"

Karlton grinned. "Gorgon Special Law Chapter 1 Line 4... Once the subject reaches 95% corruption level and the Morphing begins..."

Then Karlton started coughing hard.

Jaehwan couldn't like him. He hated men like Karlton who were so devoted to the organization. But Jaehwan still respected Karlton for one thing. If the Tower of Nightmares had ten people who were like Karlton, or maybe even five, he wouldn't have had to spend thirty years within the tower. Jaehwan slapped Karlton who was about to slip into unconsciousness again.

"Hey, let me ask you one thing."

"Y-Yes..."

Karlton's lips were trembling.

"In your Gorgon Law, is there a law that prohibits one from going back into the past?"

"What do you..."

"A law that punishes those who abandon the world and flees into the past."

"I- I don't get the quest-..."

Karlton's eyes then rolled back as his body began to twist. His veins began to expand and his flesh began to swirl like worms. The morphing was imminent.

[WARNING! WARNING! Corruption level has reached 94%! Morphing IMMINENT!]

Suddenly, a group of men entered the hospital. The man in the lead was familiar. It was the leader of the group who fought the Dead Man in the saloon.

The best fighting group within the fortress.

The Anti-Dead Man group, Anti-Evil. The leader.

James' face turned grim.

"Commander..."

The commander eyed Karlton coldly. Some guards tried to hide Karlton's body by blocking it with their own, but it was pointless.

"Move out of the way."

He drew his sword.

"He is no longer the captain you know. You must know this."

The guards still did not move away and the commander resorted to force.

"By the laws of Gorgon, Special Law Chapter 1, Line 4, I will now purge Guard Captain Karlton and the other person."

It was an [Order]. Jaehwan felt it was ironic.

'Stubborn man, the world you saved has now come to kill you.'

The guards kneeled as they could not resist the [Order]. It was the most powerful skill within the fortress that no one could withstand. The sword

then swung toward Karlton's neck. It was a strike that no one could stop.

Rather, it was a strike that no one could stop, until Jaehwan's bare hand stopped it.

Jaehwan spoke.

"You can't kill him. I need to ask him a few things."

Chapter 33: Deadman (8)

'...What is this man?!'

The commander tried to pull out his sword away, but it did not budge. He was a powerful man who had almost reached the 5th stage. But the man stopped his strike bare-handedly. Even if his attack did not contain Spiritual Power, there was no one who could block his attack with their bare hands.

'[Order] doesn't work on him?'

He had lived a hundred years in this fortress but he had never seen this happen before, a man who was not affected by [Order] and could block his attack with just bare hands. Whoever he was, he was probably a powerful man.

"...I don't know who you are, but you must not block me from my duty. We're just trying to stop a bigger disaster from happening."

"Disaster?"

Jaehwan scoffed. "I don't think killing Karlton will solve the matter. Isn't your job to find the reason behind this rather than killing him?"

He was right. The commander knew what had happened. A group from the Golden Sky Clan had done something and corrupted Karlton's spirit. It seemed that he had jumped in to save the civilians, but so what? The criminals were gone and there was no evidence. And Karlton was going to become a Dead Man.

"I'm only working to uphold the law."

"The law. Yeah."

Jaehwan used [Suspicion] and examined Karlton's inventory.

'He has it.'

Jaehwan reached out and took out a book. It was a book of law.

"Let me see... Special law, Chapter 1 line 4... Once the subject reaches 95% corruption level and begins to Morph, he or she will be put to death at once. Is this it?"

"...Yes."

"So, if Karlton does not become a Dead Man, he will be saved?" Jaehwan asked as he took out a dark, black horn from his dimensional backpack.

"I think this will do."

One of the doctors immediately recognized the horn.

"A Garnak horn!"

The commander had heard that someone had brought in the horn of pentahorn, but he did not know that this man was the owner.

"We might have a chance!"

The doctors agreed and the commander sheathed his sword. The man was right. If Karlton did not become a Dead Man, he didn't need to be killed. However, the doctors didn't look too delighted.

"But there's a problem..."

The highest medicine usually sold were trihorns because it was hard to find someone who could process quadhorns or higher. The only one who might be able to do that was Meikal, the Vice Chief of [Twilight's Fall]. But it was too late to call the Vice Chief and they were not sure if the proud blacksmith would agree to make medicine with his skills. Yet, the doctors were shocked once again.

"Isn't this enough?"

The horn was crushed into turned into powder by Jaehwan. The doctors present trembled as they took the powder. They were not sure how much value this medicine held. The processed powder was sucked into the respirator and distributed to Karlton and Mino. As the horn powder was consumed, the corruption level stopped increasing and became steady. It did not purify the corruption, but it stopped the morphing.

Suddenly, the doctor tending to Mino shouted, "I-it's not working!"

The corruption level began to rise again.

"It's not stopping. Her stamina is too low to..."

A doctor quickly measured Mino's corruption level.

[WARNING! CORRUPTION LEVEL HAS EXCEEDED 95%.
MORPHING WILL START!]

The doctors became frightened.

"It's too late..."

When the corruption exceeded 95%, there was no medicine that could stop it. The commander tried to draw his sword again but Claire shouted,

"Chunghuh, call Chunghuh! He can use 'Dead Man Slash'! That will give us a chance!"

"...Are you talking about the Doctor of Despair?"

One of the doctors frowned.

Chunghuh, the Doctor of Despair.

Every doctor knew his name. He was the only doctor who could save someone who had begun morphing. His unique skill, 'Dead Man Slash', allowed him to stop the transformation.

Jaehwan heard the doctors whispering to each other.

[But, what does that 'Dead Man Slash' skill do?]

[It's what the Doctor of Despair uses. I heard it cuts down the corruption itself.]

[How is that possible?]

Claire said, "Yes! The Doctor knows her! He will certainly help her out!"

"The doctor is within the inner keep. He will not come out for such a thing."

"...For 'SUCH A THING' you said?!"

Claire became enraged and tried to speak but the commander interrupted her,

"Move out."

His powerful energy made Claire and the doctors fall to their knees while screaming. The commander measured Mino's corruption level and said to Jaehwan, "I cannot stay put this time. You should move away too."

Jaehwan drew his sword and the air turned cold. Then Jaehwan turned.

"I will kill her. She asked me to do so."

The commander moved back. The doctors moved away as Claire bit her lip and watched Jaehwan. James paled and some guards looked away. Jaehwan looked at the woman lying on the cot. With her mask skill gone, her face was pale but still beautiful. She was the first human Jaehwan had met after he came to [Chaos].

Her name was Mino.

It was a name that he had never called. He did not know much about her. He didn't know what she had done, and why she was so weak-minded the fact that she was an assassin. Yet, he didn't want to know. He raised his

sword. He was shown an imaginary line which showed Mino's death. It was only displayed when his senses reached their limits. If he followed the line, it would mean instant death for her. That was the best he could do for her now.

However, at that moment, the area began to change.

'What?'

Everything, except Mino and Jaehwan, turned white. Jaehwan used [Suspicion] and his senses grew. He had felt a similar thing when he met the succubus on the 66th floor of the Tower.

'It's a hallucination.'

Jaehwan glanced around while using [Suspicion]. There was no one other than Mino lying down. Jaehwan gripped his sword tightly, thinking to rip the space apart. Suddenly, he was surprised. There was an old man sitting next to Mino.

[My, my... little Mino. What happened to you?]

It was an old man dressed in dark clothes with a long, round hat. It seemed that the old man had not noticed Jaehwan.

[Poor girl... let me help you.]

The old man then squished Mino's cheeks this way and that, before breaking into a satisfied smile. Jaehwan looked at him quietly. After a while, the old man noticed Jaehwan and turned towards him in shock.

[HHHAA! Who are you?!]

He blushed like a man caught stealing and coughed.

[Y-you, young man, have a very noble spirit. How did you come here?]

Jaehwan did not answer and used [Suspicion], but it did not work. Many theories flashed through his mind. It was a man who suddenly appeared as

he was watching a corrupted spirit.

'Is he the reason for the corruption?'

The man also gave him the feeling like that of the Dead Man. Jaehwan then remembered the whispers among the doctors.

'Dead Man Slash, right?'

The woman might live if this old man was killed. The old man kept on speaking.

[But why is the noble spirit eager to fight like that... like a five-year-old...]

Jaehwan's sword moved.

[W-what?]

The old man opened his eyes wide in shock and yelled,

[You, young man, must be taught a lesson!]

Then, a bright sword strike flash. With the shock, Jaehwan was forced back a step, and the old man staggered three steps back. Jaehwan was shocked.

'He blocked my attack?'

It was the first time that his [Slight Stab] was blocked. There were instances where someone dodged it or didn't die, but no one was able to block it. However, that wasn't the only thing.

It was a 'Slash' that the old man had used to block the stab.

The old man moaned.

[H-how did you block my 'Normal Slash'...?!]

It was a familiar name. The old man stepped back. It seemed his wrist was sprained from the strike and his sword had a crack.

[What are you?!]

The old man shouted as the hallucination shattered. Jaehwan knew he was back in the normal world. His sword was still at Mino's neck but something around had changed. He heard a voice.

"No... my precious quadhorn sword!"

Jaehwan realized it was the same old man's voice. He turned, and there he was, on his knees and wailing. He was shaking as he held onto the broken sword. The commander and Claire shouted at once.

"D-doctor of Despair...!"

"Chunghuh!"

It was the number one doctor from Gorgon Fortress, Chunghuh, the Doctor of Despair.

Chapter 34: Doctor of Despair (1)

[That old man... because of him, everyone thought people can do that too. What did he say? Repeating same slash trillion times will make him really powerful... or something?]

-Imai Kazuki, 3rd Captain of the [Rupture]

Episode 6. Doctor of Despair

Four men sat in the inner keep office. The middle-aged man in the higher seat was a famous individual within the fortress.

Chancellor Euren Chiver

He was the one who was in charge of the keep while the master was out. The one sitting next to him did not fall behind in status.

"Doctor, are you sure that Jaehwan can use the 'Dead Man Slash'?"

"...Yeah," Chunghuh answered, obviously not happy that he had to admit that, and the Anti-Evil Commander agreed.

"I saw it too, Chancellor. It was definitely the 'Dead Man Slash.'"

"Well, to be specific, it's not [Slash]," Chunghuh added and looked at the man in front. The man was the only one who had no relation to the Gorgon Fortress.

'...Why am I here?'

Jaehwan thought as he saw Chunghuh in front of him.

Chunghuh, the Doctor of Despair.

Everyone in [Chaos] had heard about his rumors. The one who can do 'Dead Man Slash.' He was the only one who could do that. But he wasn't famous just because he was a skilled doctor.

-I heard he's as powerful as the Ten-Clan's leaders.

The doctor was extremely strong. This was a good topic to be gossip about.

-I heard he is a 'Strong from the Depth'.

-I heard he was a member of the [Rupture] also.

-I heard he cleared the [Master]'s tower.

However, no one knew what was true because Chunghuh never talked about himself. Then his rumors became much less exciting over time.

The old man who only knew how to slash.

The old man who loved women so much that he only tended to women.

The word despair was put on him because he always felt despair.

"The doctor is despairing!"

Doctors were shocked to see the rumors were true as they saw Chunghuh kneeling down. The commander approached and asked, "Doctor! Why are you here? What about the Master?"

"...This cutie is about to die. Who cares about the Master?"

"Wh-What?!"

Chunghuh then glared at Jaehwan.

"Hey! What are you going to do? You ruined my 'Dead Man Slash'! And with my sword in this state..."

His sword was crushed. The 'Dead Man Slash' could only be used by a sword made from a quadhorn or higher. That's when Chunghuh's eyes caught something interesting.

"OH! Boy, you have something good with you!" Chunghuh exclaimed.
"Horn of Garnak, eh?"

The sword with the power of a Garnak. He had seen a sword made from pentahorn's horn, but he had never seen a sword with even the scabbard being the Garnak's horn. Garnaks were vicious and violent beasts that were difficult to hunt. Chunghuh reached out toward the sword without permission Jaehwan grasped his wrist to stop him.

"...you, young man, got some skill."

He knew the man wasn't an ordinary man when his 'Normal Slash' was blocked, but it seemed the young man was more than what he had expected. That was when Jaehwan spoke up unexpectedly.

"If I let you use this sword..."

"Huh?"

"If I let you, then can you save her?"

Chunghuh blinked. "...Of course. I can do that."

Jaehwan took out the sword and handed it over with the scabbard on. Chunghuh was shocked. It was his first time meeting the man and that person just gave the weapon away. But this wasn't important right now.

"...It's a good sword, but it does fit you."

Chunghuh cackled as the sword cried as the old man held on it. Then his pupils turned white and Old man began swinging his sword in the air. The area then turned quiet.

'So this was what he did earlier.'

Jaehwan looked into the world that had turned white. As old man moved his sword, the world was being painted into a white light. Jaehwan finally realized that this was not just some hallucination.

This was the world that this old man was seeing.

Within the bright white area, was Mino as her outline was fading away. The old man then looked at Mino. He stood in front and held the sword like a paintbrush. Then he began painting the lines back in.

Jaehwan felt that it was a strange sight. It was smooth, yet violent. It was relaxed, yet rushed. But everything was accurate.

Mino's body was repainted into the world. Jaehwan felt relieved as he watched the old man at work. He painted Mino's nose, her lips, and paid more attention to her breasts. As his brush moved, the world in white danced. It was like a calm, soothing song. Then the song that the old man creating was nearing its end. The old man slumped down, losing his grip on the sword.

"Ugh, I can't do it any longer."

Chunghuh lay down on his back.

"Dammit... my Spirit Power is running out..."

Mino's painting was still unstable. But it was close to completion.

"If it wasn't for that damn Master..."

The world shook. Jaehwan knew if that picture wasn't finished, this 'Dead Man Slash' would not work. Jaehwan wondered.

He couldn't do a [Slash], but even if it was a copy of what the old man did...

Jaehwan took back his sword. He felt the people around him shouting, trying to stop him. It was noisy. Jaehwan closed his eyes. His mind always

had [Suspicion] on against the world, and the spirit wanting to [Understand] stopped. His thoughts were freed.

Yes, this was how it was supposed to feel.

Chapter 35: Doctor of Despair (2)

As he opened his eyes again, the white world was waiting with only Chunghuh who was there in shock and Mino who was asleep.

Jaehwan, for the first time ever, took up the sword to save someone. The white world accepted him. He felt like he could draw in anything in this world. Then, Jaehwan began moving.

He then remembered Mino, a weak-minded Assassin. A stubborn woman who liked to joke. A woman who always attracted trouble. A woman who did not betray. A woman who hated him. And...

The woman who trusted humans.

Jaehwan moved his hand without resting. As if he was worried that the Mino he knew would disappear, he moved and moved again.

After some time, it seemed like it was finished but something was lacking. That's when Jaehwan remembered. He had never seen it, but he came to know about it unintentionally. Jaehwan then finished by placing a small spot on Mino's right breast. It was complete. Jaehwan blinked and as he breathed in...

"...You still remember that?"

Mino smiled brightly in front of him.

When Jaehwan opened his eyes again, he thought he was still in the white world. It was because everyone was silent. James was rubbing his eyes and doctors were shaking with the measurement meter in their hands. Claire was numbly looking at Mino. The black vein was disappearing. Someone shouted.

"The morphing has stopped!"

"Corruption level is dropping!"

And the Doctor of Despair was in shock.

"How... but..."

He had used the 'Dead Man Slash'. This wasn't something that could be copied just by looking at it. This was not a skill. Many wanted to be taught, but nobody could manage to do it.

"...His eagerness disappeared a bit," Chunghuh mumbled as he eyed the man. It seemed like something changed him just now.

'But that only makes him 10 years old now.'

Chunghuh didn't seem to like it much.

"Who are you? How did you do the 'Dead Man Slash'..."

Chunghuh stopped. The man's movement was not the 'Slash.'

"No, I should call it 'Dead Man Stab'. Where did you learn that?"

The commander was then shocked as he asked, "W-wait. Did he just use the 'Dead Man Slash?'"

"...I do not want to accept that fact, but yes."

"Then..."

Chunghuh frowned as he watched the commander's expression. He was the most loyal to the Master of the Fortress. Chunghuh had lived for a thousand years. It was easy to know what the 100-year-old young man was thinking.

"Wait, Commander. Relax. We do not know about him yet."

"But didn't he just say that he could do the 'Dead Man Slash'? And didn't you mention that if there was one more who could do it, you could save the Master?"

"That's..."

Chunghuh frowned. He did say such a thing. He just didn't realize the commander would still remember it.

'How would I know that there would be another one who could do it?'

The commander sternly said, "Doctor. There's no one more valuable than the Master."

Chunghuh stopped and sighed. He then sent a [Whisper].

[...Commander. You know that I'm an Awakener, right?]

The commander became tense. Everyone knew the term 'Awakener'. These were the ones who escaped the system and earned great power in return. Even throughout the Great Lands as a whole, there weren't many 'Awakeners'. Those included the few Lords of the 12 regions and their subjects, the [Rupture]'s few captains, and the organization that the [Big Brother] considered a dangerous organization.

The commander knew there were a few more Awakeners other than them.

One was the old man in front.

He was weaker than the Lords or the Captain of [Rupture] but was still an Awakener. The fact that Chunghuh stayed within Gorgon Fortress stopped other Fortresses that were thinking about attacking Gorgon.

[What if he is an Awakener?]

Chunghuh asked, [Is that true?]

[Yes. And a suspicious one at that.]

The commander felt sweat running down his back. An Awakener appearing within the fortress was not to be taken lightly. They were powerful enough to alter the power balance.

[Is he from the [Rupture]?]

[...I don't know anything yet.]

Suddenly, the entrance opened and men in dark green clothes entered. The commander recognized them at once. It was the organization below the Chancellor himself, Shadowmoon. The man in the front was the general.

'Why are they here?'

They had nothing to do with killing the Dead Man. They only obeyed direct orders from the Master of the Fortress and the Chancellor. The general walked up to Jaehwan and bowed.

"I'm the General of the Shadowmoon. Are you the Messenger of the Greens?"

Messenger of the Greens?

Chunghuh and the commander looked at each other.

"Please, follow us to the keep. Our master's life is in..."

That's when the general felt something was strange.

"Huh? Why are you here, Commander... and... D-doctor?"

It seemed he was shocked to see them standing here. But Chunghuh and the commander did not care about the general. They were looking at Jaehwan and was thinking of the same thing.

And Chunghuh was still thinking the same thing as he watched Jaehwan in front.

'Who is this man?' he thought as he saw Jaehwan playing around with the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit] in his fingers. Chancellor Euren spoke to him.

"Mister Jaehwan, I need to make a request of you."

Chapter 36: Doctor of Despair (3)

There was a reason why Jaehwan followed them to the office of the inner keep without any protest.

-You were looking for a Nightmare, right?

Gorgon Fortress was a large place. Even if Nightmares were rare, there might be one or two if one looked very closely. That was what Meikal said.

-Go to the Registrar of the Inner Keep. Tell them my name and show the scabbard. You will then take a look at the entrance record.

It seemed like a good idea to track down possible a Nightmare who had come into the fortress. That was what he planned to do unless he encountered some other problems.

'It's getting mixed up.'

But it might be better. The middle-aged man seemed to hold a high position so it might be easier if he helped find a Nightmare. Jaehwan looked at him.

He had a clean mustache along with a wise and intelligent face. Euren looked very noble and intelligent. But it was his 211th year after he died at Great Lands. He was one of the oldest within the Gorgon Fortress.

"I will have to introduce myself first. I am Euren Chiver, Chancellor of this 'Gorgon Fortress'."

"Jaehwan."

Euren laughed. "You sure sound like the one, the doctor told me about you."

Jaehwan glanced and the doctor was mumbling, 'Look, I told you he's rude.'

"But you must know that it is not your name that we want to know."

He cut straight to the chase, but did so politely. It was interesting to see such a high ranking officer be so polite.

"Let me ask you this outright, Mister Jaehwan. Are you the Messenger of the Greens?"

"No."

"I see."

Euren didn't seem to be shocked.

"...You weren't?!"

"Didn't I say that?"

Chunghuh added, "Hey, kid. Let me ask you. If you are not from the Greens, then where did you get those stones?"

Chunghuh asked as he glared at the stone in Jaehwan's hands.

Jaehwan's answer was simple. "I picked them up."

"...and you want me to believe that? What happened to the owners?"

"They're dead."

"Dead? Who dares to kill five families..."

"I killed them."

The commander was shocked and Chunghuh stood up, but Euren stopped him.

"Please, relax, Doctor."

The Chancellor was so dignified that it even made Jaehwan astonished.

"He killed them all!"

"We do not know what happened between them and Mister Jaehwan."

"..."

"We should hear him out. He must have had his reasons."

Euren looked at Jaehwan and Jaehwan answered, "They attacked me first. They wanted my horn, so I fought them."

Jaehwan then took out the last horn from his backpack. Euren nodded.

"...I see."

The Greens were famous for their greed for materials. If a mere human was walking around with high-value material like the horn of a Garnak, there was a chance for them to launch an attack. If Jaehwan killed them to protect himself, then there was nothing to blame. Euren became curious. How did this man come all the way here?

"Mister Jaehwan, would you mind explaining your story some more?"

After a while...

"I see. Let me summarize your story."

Euren recounted the events, "One. You were 'accidentally' swept away into this [Chaos]."

Jaehwan nodded.

"Two. You 'accidentally' met the Greens and came into this fortress."

Jaehwan nodded.

"Three. You 'accidentally' ran into the trouble and met the doctor. And you copied what he did."

Jaehwan nodded.

"I see. I understand."

Chunghuh frowned as he watched them.

"...Chancellor, do you even believe him?"

"Yes, I do."

"Have you lost your mind because Master's out sick?"

Eruen smiled.

"Doctor."

"What."

"To earn the trust of someone, you must trust him first."

"..."

The doctor became dumbfounded and Euren looked back at Jaehwan.

"Mister Jaehwan, can I ask a few more questions, if it's not too much?"

"Sure."

"Then, the first question. Your body is alive right now. Is that right?"

Jaehwan's finger that played on the stone stopped cold.

"...How do you know that I didn't die?"

"Didn't you say that you were 'accidentally swept into [Chaos]'?"

"Yes."

"Did you know that no one in [Chaos] expresses their 'death' in that way?"

He was a very intelligent man. Jaehwan heightened his guard.

"Second question. Is there a reason for you to hide your identity?"

Jaehwan fell silent and answered, "Yes."

"Is it because of a certain threat?"

"Maybe, maybe not."

"It somehow is, while it's somehow not."

Euren tapped on the table and continued, "I must apologize beforehand."

"What is it?"

"To be honest, I've been watching you use my people for the past three days."

"I knew about it."

"Of course."

Jaehwan remembered the man in a dark green cloth that he knocked out near Twilight's Fall.

"It was hard as you were too powerful, but there were a few results."

"..."

"We did manage to find out a few things about you. Do you want to listen to it?"

"Go ahead."

Euren smiled. "This document summarizes what happened after you walked into the fortress."

Jaehwan looked down and read the paper in front of him.

First day

Target has clashed with Karlton.

Target took out the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit] and made the civilians feel terrified.

Target massacred local gangs.

Target trespassed the Twilight's Fall and threatened the Vice Chief.

Target took Twilight's Fall illegally. (Resulted in 180 million horuns in property loss.)

Target started processing SS-grade material 'Horn of Garnak'.

Third day

Target destroyed the northern merchant road. Estimated property loss: 40 million horuns.

Target clashed with the Janya brothers and the Golden Sky Clan. (Northern Guard Captain and 14 other guards were wounded in the process.)

Target massacred Janya brothers and the Golden Sky Clan.

Target clashed with the middle Dead Man.

Target killed the middle Dead Man. (Estimated property loss due to the damage: 30 million horuns.)

Target clashed with the Doctor of Despair.

Target used 'Dead Man Slash'.

Target's danger grade: SS

Target's physical strength: Impossible to measure

Estimated property loss: 380 million horuns

Chapter 37: Doctor of Despair (4)

"Do you know what people call a man like this?" Euren asked.

The doctor interjected, "A madman."

The commander also added, "I'm not sure if you are a hero or a villain."

Euren smiled.

"Yes, some might call you a hero, and some will call you a villain. Some might even call you a madman. Everyone will call you something different."

Euren's tapping against the table stopped.

"I call that kind of man a 'Protagonist'."

Chunghuh frowned.

"He's just a madman!"

"It's just a metaphor. One who's not bound to any rules and lives how he likes... only a 'Protagonist' can do that."

Euren continued, "There's one thing that you have that is related to a 'Protagonist'. Do you know what it is?"

"No," Jaehwan replied.

"It's that they're famous."

Jaehwan fell silent and asked, "...and after the investigation, you found out that I'm a famous 'Protagonist'?"

Euren shook his head.

"No, that's where the problem lies."

"...?"

"You are not famous at all."

Euren continued, "A powerful being considered to be a Protagonist leaks their powers. Their status, birthright, the legendary stories... even if the protagonist himself did not want the stories to be told, others will spread it anyway."

Jaehwan listened silently.

"But there was nothing about you that was known. Not here, nor in the Great Lands. Even with the Fortress' command system that can pull up all Adapter information with the search of a name, we found no information about you. Do you know what this means?"

Jaehwan did not answer, but Euren continued speaking.

"Someone is blocking your information."

"..."

"Someone is protecting you so that you will not be known, whatever the motive may be."

Jaehwan did not speak.

"And I think the one doing that is probably not friendly toward you."

"Why is that?"

"If a powerful organization who can meddle with the information is there to protect you, you wouldn't have run into trouble for a simple certification at the gate."

Jaehwan was impressed by Euren's logic.

"My conclusion is this. You are a Protagonist who fled to Chaos 'accidentally' and are in pursuit of a giant force."

Satisfied, Euren asked, "What do you think about my story?"

"It's amazing."

What Euren said matched exactly with Jaehwan's thoughts.

'It's about time for the Lord of Darkness to move.'

At this time, the Harvester did not realize that something had happened to the Cultivator and the Product. Therefore, they must have started doing something. Erasing any information would be a start. There was a chance that they would follow him into [Chaos] soon.

Jaehwan asked, "So, what do you propose?"

"My proposal is simple. Gorgon Fortress will protect you."

"Protect?"

Euren nodded.

"We will not ask for your status, nor your identity. We will not ask you to pay back the property loss and protect you. All you need to do is one thing for us."

Jaehwan was able to guess what the request would be. He had heard many whispers along the way and the powerful spiritual energy deep within the deep castle was telling him the nature of the request already.

"Please, save our Master."

Two hours later, Jaehwan was walking to the guesthouse of the Inner Keep with Chunghuh. They were guided by a Shadowmoon woman.

"You can rest here. You will be escorted by the servants inside."

"Understood."

"Oh, and we heard a report that the Guard Captain and woman are now recovering. Captain will take about two weeks and the woman will take three months to recover."

"Thank you."

"Please call me when you need anything."

The woman who introduced herself as Hekuwa disappeared into the shadows. Jaehwan turned to Chunghuh and asked, "Why aren't you going?"

"...I have a question to ask. Follow me."

Jaehwan followed Chunghuh. They were going to the underground area with the guesthouse. The fire from the candle lit the corridor as they walked down. Jaehwan thought about what his discussion with the Chancellor.

-Is Gorgon Fortress strong enough to fight the 12 Lords of the Great Lands?

-Is it the 12 Lords that are after you?

-It's a possibility.

Euren thought about it for a while and answered.

-The only one who can stand against a Lord is one of the Lords themselves.

-Does that mean you cannot protect me from them?

-No, it's much better that way.

-Why is that?

-Lords are not allowed to directly interfere what happens within [Chaos].

-What do you mean...

Then, he came back to his senses.

"We're here."

Chunghuh stopped and Jaehwan frowned.

"What are you thinking?"

There was a large training ground at the underground area of the guesthouse. Weapons hung from one wall and other wall had training dummies. It seemed that the warriors of the fortress used the equipment for training.

"Kid. From what I can see, you're not from the [Rupture]. Your energy is vicious, but it's not machinated like theirs."

Chunghuh continued, "But you don't look like the subjects of the Lords either. I don't feel any energy of those 12 regions from you."

There were some warriors that were training within corners of the training ground. They noticed Chunghuh and bowed.

"You are an Awakener but not from the [Rupture] or the Lords... and one I do not know."

Chunghuh waved to the warriors.

"Then there's only one answer."

Chunghuh looked at Jaehwan closely.

"Kid, are you the one who cleared the [Master]'s tower?"

Chunghuh grinned as he read Jaehwan's face.

"I see."

"...What do you know, old man?"

"I know."

Jaehwan tried to speak but Chunghuh pulled out a sword.

"Show me a move."

"..."

"Your stab and my slash. Let's see which one's stronger."

Jaehwan pulled out his sword too. He was also curious. For the first time, this old man was a worthy opponent. Jaehwan knew that this old man was one of his kind. Just like how he had stabbed for all his life, this old man must have slashed for his life, for an even longer time period.

"Fight me. If you win, I'll answer all your questions."

Chunghuh cackled and added, "But it's probably impossible."

Chapter 38: Doctor of Despair (5)

'Steel Region'

The 5th region of the 12 regions of the Great Lands was completely covered in steel. As such, the region was abundant in steel as well as other metals and ores. Many blacksmiths and artisans worked in the region. The 5th region's nickname was the 'Home of All Weapons'.

Since a lot of Nightmares resided within the region, its production of cultivation towers or weapons increased and the region became one of the most important regions in the Great Lands.

Recently, the ruler of the 5th region wasn't too happy. An old man with distinct features frowned.

"What did you say?"

"..."

"The Lord of Darkness did what?"

The Chief Secretary shivered in front of the old man. He was the ruler of the 5th region and had the nickname, 'Unbreakable Steel'. His name was renowned in the Great Lands. In just 80 years after he had come up to the Great Lands, he became the Lord of the 5th region and was ranked on top of the Great Ones.

Lord of Steel, Huhyou.

He looked down at his Chief Secretary and frowned.

'What was his name... Allen?'

He had been chosen to take the position since he was born in a good family with a good upbringing, but it didn't satisfy Huhyou. Allen was in charge of intelligence within the organization but all the information he brought was outdated information.

If Huhyou fired the Chief Secretary again, it would be the 24th time during this quarter. Huhyou changed his tone and asked again, "Relax and tell me. So, what is the Lord of Darkness up to?"

Jerome, the Lord of Darkness, was the ruler of the 9th region, which bordered the 5th region. Huhyou had qualms with Jerome because of Jerome's sly and vicious nature.

'Maybe it's about time for me to settle the score with him.'

The 9th region had been up to no good in recent years. The region welcomed all fugitive Adapters and for the first time, contracted middle to low-level cultivators to increase the production of Products. They were obviously increasing their army force. This was the only possible reason. They were preparing for war.

Under the current circumstances, it was apparent that their target would be the neighboring 5th and 7th regions. Allen shivered and said, "I-it seems that the Lord of Darkness is contacting [Chaos] for some reason."

"[Chaos]? What about that place?"

Huhyou was surprised. Under the 295th Great Lords Decree, all Lords of the Great Lands were forbidden from meddling with [Chaos].

"Well... it's complicated."

Allen seemed to have prepared something as he called out to [Little Brother] and showed up a hologram panel. Huhyou looked at it closely.

"What about it?"

He knew about the video. It had the Non-Adapter who killed the Frost Dragon alone. The famous [99th Floor Solo-Clear Video] with a man who

stabbed the Frost Dragon.

He remembered a former secretary who insisted on scouting him. Purchasing Products or recruiting Adapters were the secretary's job so he did not really care.

'Wasn't it proven to be fake?'

The video that topped the rankings on [Little Brother]'s network had become a problem as the Cultivator had disappeared. Even now, some were debating if the video was fake or not.

"The product... is the Product that was being created under the contract by Lord of Darkness."

"What?"

Huhyou then looked more closely.

'Wait... this one...'

As the man thrust against the Frost Dragon, there was weird energy. It was very faint, but he recognized that energy.

'Awakener... in a tutorial?'

Even the Lord of Steel himself, who was the most powerful Awakener in the Great Lands, had not succeeded in being awakened in the tutorial. Huhyou quickly asked, "Where is this Product now?"

The secretary hesitated.

"...He escaped."

Escape?

"What do you mean?"

"He... refused to clear the tutorial. He destroyed the roof of the tower and ran to [Chaos] through the Tree of Imagery. That's what I heard."

Huhyou thought he misheard it.

"What about the Cultivator waiting at the 100th floor?"

"He was killed."

"...Are you kidding me?"

"N-no, my Lord. I can't believe it myself, but Lord of Darkness seems to trust the information."

Huhyou could not speak. If that was true, the Product's value was immeasurable.

'That's why the Darkness is poking at [Chaos].'

The situation did seem complicated.

"But does the 9th region have a connection with [Chaos]?"

"I-I came across this information while I was at it... but it seems they had been meddling in [Chaos] for a long time even before this incident."

"Long time?"

"Yes, my Lord. Few among the Ten-Clan of Chaos had been in regular contact with the Lord of Darkness."

Huhyou's face sunk. It meant the Lord of Darkness had been disobeying the decree for a long time already.

'What are you up to?'

He thought about bringing this up to other Lords for a second. But doing so wouldn't really change as it wasn't a situation for the other Lords to pay much attention to. Other than the eastern region, which was comprised of

the 5th, 7th, and 9th regions, all regions of the Great Lands were battling a vicious war. It wasn't certain if the Lords of the other regions would have room to come and accuse the 9th region for its crimes.

"Who else knows this information?"

"I think it is only known within the 9th region. But 7th region would have their intel so they should know that by now."

It was very possible. The 7th region was the land of the Lord of Fire, Abraxas. Huhyou pondered for a minute and spoke.

"Go send a message to the Nightmare Union and ask for permission to use the [Narrow Door]."

Narrow Door.

The artifact that allowed 'Living' to look like 'Death'. The Five Renowned Families, or Nightmares, used this [Narrow Door] to travel to [Chaos] without dying.

"A-are you trying to go into [Chaos]?"

"No, I need an eye. We need to be on top of the situation."

"...Who should we send?"

"Send 10 people from the Gold First Class. ...and send Hyeyoung."

The warriors of the Steel Region were divided into five ranks. Adamantium, Mithril, Gold, Silver, and Bronze. Each rank was also divided from First to Fifth Class. The Gold First Class was mostly comprised of Adapters who were at least in the 5th stage.

The leader of Gold First Class, Hyeyoung, was almost as powerful as the higher-ranked Mithril. The group as a whole seemed to be overkill for [Chaos].

"We need to make sure. We do not know what might happen."

"Y-yes, my Lord."

Huhyou saw his Chief Secretary going away and dove into his thoughts.

'Chaos...'

There was an old friend in Chaos that he fought alongside during his tower days. He was called the best doctor back then and had the name, the Doctor of Despair in [Chaos].

'Chunghuh, I wonder how you're doing.'

Their pathways in Awakening divided them up, but Lord of Steel thought of his old friend from time to time. Chunghuh insisted on staying as a human before becoming a perfect Awakener, but he eventually lost his life as a human.

'He would've lived longer if it wasn't for his temper.'

Huhyou smiled at the memories that he shared with his friends.

'I hope he fixed his temper there.'

"Hey, fight me again."

Chunghuh spoke with his bruised eyes and swollen cheek. He couldn't understand. He was the Doctor of Despair, the best doctor within [Chaos]. As rumored, he was also the 'Strong of the Depth,' one of the very few within [Chaos].

It didn't end there. He had a grand past. He was born in World 12764 and was the clearer of the [Master]'s Tower. World 12764 was famous within the Great Lands. It was named the 'Middle Land' or it was also known as 'Moorim.'

Those from Moorim were automatically considered a great power, as it was the world that gave birth to the Lord of Steel and its Legendary generation. Moreover, Chunghuh was from the Legendary generation.

"I think we've done enough, old man."

Jaehwan spoke irritatingly. The Doctor of Despair was in bad shape. His clothes were ragged and his hat was destroyed. Over 20 swords were strewn out on the training ground had already destroyed and Jaehwan still hadn't pulled his sword out from the scabbard.

"I still have my final skill! Kid!"

"..."

"You will surely die if I use this! That's why I'm not using it!"

He had been saying that over and over again. He kept saying that even with 10 'Normal Slashes'.

"You can't beat me, old man."

"You never know until you try."

"You are weaker than me."

Weak? Chunghuh rubbed off blood from his nose and smiled. The blood turned into white powder and scattered.

"You insolent fool. How old are you?"

"About 50."

"How old do I look?"

"...I don't know. 200?" Jaehwan guessed.

"Wrong!"

"...then how old?"

"A thousand!" Chunghuh answered proudly. Jaehwan was a bit surprised. He had not imagined the man to be that old.

'He's like a kid for being so old.'

Jaehwan became curious about what he would be like when he turned a thousand years old.

"Do you see the difference now?"

"..."

"Even if you stabbed for over 50 years, you can't beat me when I slashed for a thousand years!"

"I only stabbed for 30 years."

"Same thing!" Chunghuh shouted. "You will not beat me!"

Jaehwan then became doubtful and asked, "Did you really slash for a thousand years?"

"YES!"

"...It looks like you only did it for 10 years."

Chunghuh exploded.

From the tower to the Great Lands to Chaos and the Depth, he only slashed over and over again. Of course, he did not do it every single day for 1000 years, but he still kept at it. For the normal slash that only took 1 second, he did 8 hours of it per day. After 100 years, he had achieved a billion slashes. His body was filled with the energy of being awakened. He left behind the power of being Adapter and moved onto a new world. Chunghuh had not forgotten that moment ever since. He didn't do as hard after he had achieved the billion slashes, but if everything he had done was counted, it would exceed 5 billion slashes.

The miracle created by all those slashes were now being focused on the blade of the old man. Jaehwan felt something and changed his stance. It seemed Chunghuh was really preparing to use a powerful skill. Chunghuh gritted his teeth and shouted.

"Let's see what you think after you take this one!"

Chapter 39: Doctor of Despair (6)

Vicious energy filled the room. Jaehwan finally felt danger for the first time.

'It's powerful.'

Chunghuh's blade moved. Quick and powerful, that one attack was enough to blow this building away. The two swords clashed and created a terrifying energy wave. Warriors ran out from the room while the building shook with the tremor. Jaehwan had to take 7 steps back from the clash and his right arm felt slightly numb after the attack. Chunghuh had taken 3 steps back.

"HAHAHAHA!"

He seemed very happy.

"SEE?! I knew you couldn't take this!"

"..."

"But kid, you're good too. I was worried that you might die."

Chunghuh seemed to be surprised that Jaehwan was unharmed. Yet it was Jaehwan who was really surprised. He had to admit that the old man was quite strong. What Jaehwan just used was [Normal Stab]. He had been pushed back this much even though it was just a normal stab.

Jaehwan asked, "What is the name of that skill? It's quite powerful."

"It's 'Powerful' slash."

Chunghuh put his hand on his waist and proclaimed the name proudly. He seemed to think that he had won.

"Your skill was good too. What was the name?"

"Normal stab."

Chunghuh's eyebrow flinched.

"Normal? What an arrogant name! It makes it sound like you have a stronger skill!"

"Yeah."

Chunghuh laughed as if he didn't hear that.

"I will give you another name for your skill. You can call it a 'Powerful Stab' from now on. So..."

"I have a stronger skill."

Chunghuh narrowed his eyes.

"What?"

"I have a stronger skill than the one I just used."

Jaehwan then fixed his stance. He had never used this skill in [Chaos] yet and Chunghuh became alert. Ominous energy began to radiate from Jaehwan.

"What..."

Chunghuh knew this kind of power. Was it from the Leaders of Ten-Clan? No. Was it the Masters of the Four Fortress? No. Then what was it?

'Dead Man!'

It was the power of Dead Man. However, it was strange since the power of Dead Man and Awakener had similar power, but they did not originate from this world's foundation. It was the intensity of the power that was the problem.

Chunghuh remembered the days of his youth when he traveled to the entrance of the [Depth] looking for [Fruit]. He then encountered the 'King of Chaos' at the [Palace of Dead Man].

The sole King of Chaos. The calamity that destroyed everything.

This man was not like the King of Chaos, but Chunghuh felt the same fear he felt when he faced the King of Chaos in the past.

Could he slash against that attack? His body shook. How could one fight against such power? He then spoke frantically.

"S-Stop! STOP!"

He could not imagine what might happen next if that skill were unleashed. Everything would be in ruins, leaving one man standing in the center.

"STOP IT!"

If the attack was unleashed, half of the palace would be left in ruins. Or even...

"DON'T USE IT!"

Jaehwan did not lower his power. Chunghuh ran to him and begged.

"I-I LOST! I LOST!"

Jaehwan then relaxed at once and Chunghuh panted.

"Ugh... what in the world..."

He could not understand. He could not believe it. This man had only stabbed for 30 years and had achieved that sort of power.

Jaehwan opened his mouth as Chunghuh seemed to be relaxed.

"Old man, you admit that I won?"

"No."

"Why?"

"You fooled me."

Jaehwan became confused and looked at Chunghuh.

"You told me you lived for 50 years."

"Yeah, I'm about 50 years old."

"And that you stabbed for 30 years."

"Yeah, for about 30 years."

Chunghuh glared and shouted, "DON'T LIE TO ME! You've probably lived for at least two thousand years!"

"You know that's not true."

Chunghuh gritted his teeth. He too knew if Jaehwan had lived for 2000 years, Chunghuh would've known him.

"How many times can you even stab in just 30 years to do that?"

Jaehwan answered, "About 10 billion times?"

"LIES!"

It didn't even make sense. Even if he took each second of his life for all 30 years without sleeping and eating, that would not have equaled 1 billion.

"That's impossible to do in 30 years!"

"You can if you try."

"LIES! IT'S ALL LIES!"

Chunghuh began calculating in his head.

'Uh...'

He couldn't calculate so he ordered one of the warriors that was watching them dumbfoundedly to calculate for him.

"I-it's done, sir!"

"Yeah, tell me."

"If you want to do 10 billion stabs in 30 years, then you would need to stab 11 times in per second for 30 years. This is considering the fact that you don't sleep or eat or rest."

The warrior spoke, thinking it was pointless to even think about it. Chunghuh asked, "So you can't do it with just 10 in one second?"

"No, it's not possible."

"Then do you think a man can do 11 stabs within 1 second for 30 years straight?"

"Absolutely not, sir."

Chunghuh then became satisfied and turned back to Jaehwan.

"SEE! It's not possible!"

Jaehwan then spoke.

"Old man."

"WHAT!"

"Can't you slash 10 times in 1 second?"

"Of course I can!"

"Then you can do it too."

"It's not as simple as that!"

"No, it's that simple."

"NO!"

"Old man, I can stab 100 times in a second."

"I just said it's not that kind of problem..."

"I can do 1000 times."

"...What? How can you stab 1000 times in a second?"

"Why do you think you need to stab it with a sword?"

Chunghuh then realized something. He then turned doubtful.

"Wait..."

There was something he felt the moment he met Jaehwan. Energy that pointed out from within him like a spike. Chunghuh just thought it was Jaehwan's character, but when he felt it more carefully, the energy was more like thousands of energy spikes. Chunghuh then placed his hands on the sharp energy radiating out from Jaehwan.

Blood came out as he was poked. That was when he realized that it was not energy.

It was a real [Stab].

The stab that had overcome the form of an image. The man, through his countless stabs, had become a stab himself.

"You... you really..."

The will against the world itself. The man's 10 billion stabs was the product of the hatred of the world. Even now, this man was stabbing the world.

"Like I said, 10 billion times."

Chunghuh felt his leg giving out and kneeled. He could not believe it. There was no way such a man could be still sane.

'Wait... this kid was...'

Chunghuh felt like he could understand everything, but he was suddenly too tired for using too much energy for the day and fell unconscious.

Chapter 40: Doctor of Despair (7)

Chunghuh opened his eyes again.

'Brat, not respecting the elders.'

His bruised eyes still hurt. Chunghuh spoke.

"I haven't lost yet. The fight always goes on if you live."

"..."

Jaehwan looked at Chunghuh. He was the old man who had lived for 1000 years with a slash. It looked like he was shocked to see that his slash had been overpowered.

"I've realized one thing after living a thousand years."

"...?"

"Survivors always win."

"Didn't you die already?"

"If you still live after 1000 years, I will accept my loss."

Jaehwan then took out a piece of paper and Chunghuh frowned. The paper was the 'Agreement' that they made before they started fighting.

-It's boring to just do it so let's make a bet with this.

This agreement was made by the Nightmare with the [Spiritual Agreement]. So when one signed it, they would be required to follow what was written

on it. If the agreement was not followed, the paper would then make the spirit disappear. It did not go through the Interface System. Instead, it directly accessed the spirit that even Jaehwan couldn't avoid.

The agreement they signed was as follows: The loser grants three wishes for a week.

Chunghuh was determined to win and deal with Jaehwan later on. He then asked in a dignified voice, "...So, what is it that you wish? Young one."

"Answer my questions to the best of your knowledge."

"Hmph. So be it."

The light shined from the paper and was absorbed into Jaehwan and Chunghuh. It was the first wish.

Jaehwan asked, "What is a [Master]'s tower?"

"Master's tower?"

Chunghuh closed his eyes.

"You know what the Tower of Nightmares is, right?"

"Yeah."

People who came into the Great Lands all knew about the tower. It was the beginning of the tragedy. The world had 'Nightmare' races and they created 'Tower of Nightmares'. The name did fit as for all beings, and the tower was nothing less than a nightmare.

"Each tower has a grade. From S to F. Most towers created from [Apprentices] to [High Artisans] are graded as such."

Titles of the artisans. Jaehwan had heard it from Meikal already. Nightmares only considered making the tower as their grand purpose of life. Their towers were evaluated by their union, [Criche], and were given grades.

"Most Nightmares strive to create an A-grade tower. If they can make an A-grade, then they will be accepted as [High Artisan] and will not need to worry about their salary just by renting out what they have made."

It looked like even Nightmares, the nobles of Great Lands, worry about money. Jaehwan thought it was ironic.

"But there are some Nightmares who are not interested in sales."

"Why?"

"It's those who have created an S-grade tower as an [Apprentice]."

Meikal also said that talent limited Nightmares. Even among them, some were born with great talents which that brought them to the top of all Nightmares in the early stages.

"They are called [Master Artisans]."

The top of all [Nightmares]. The 13 Master Artisans.

"So Master Tower just means the tower was made by them?"

"No, not all are considered that way. Only towers that were not created for [Cultivation] are called Master towers."

"Why do they make those towers?"

"I do not know. No one knows what those Masters are thinking. They are all busy unraveling the 'Truth of the World'."

Chunghuh continued, "Only two things are for certain. There are a few Master Towers spread within the Great Lands and the clearer of those towers sometimes become 'Awakener', or the one who had overcome certain things."

"So, you are from a Master Tower too."

"Yes." Chunghuh smiled. It seemed he was proud to say that he had cleared a Master's tower.

"I cleared the 4th Master Tower of Master 'Melville.' The tower is also known as [Moby Dick]."

Chunghuh's eyes became dark. It seemed he still had memories of the days when he cleared the tower.

"There was a big white whale that appeared on the 1st floor that hunted people down. It was a disaster back then. Many strong warriors of Moorim died. It was a miracle that I even cleared it."

Not all towers had similar shapes.

"And you sound like you've come here from a Master's Tower. Who made it? Melville? Jorje? Scarge?"

Chunghuh named some of the Master Artisans he knew. Jaehwan answered.

"Mulack. I think that was the name."

Jaehwan remembered the status window he saw when he first realized the tower was an [Item]. There was a description on the status window.

- Description: 2nd Creation of Nightmare [Mulack], the creator of 'Fortress of Remorse.' Traps the one who accepts the summon into its dream world.

"Mulack, you say?"

Chunghuh's expression changed.

"I never imagined that an Awakener would clear Mulack's tower..."

Jaehwan flinched at the word 'clear.' He wasn't sure if he actually cleared it.

"Do you know Mulack?"

"Of course I do."

Chunghuh thought for a second and answered grimly.

"...I met Mulack in the [Depth]."

Chapter 41: Doctor of Despair (8)

Jaehwan was surprised.

"You met Mulack?"

"Well..."

Chunghuh nodded. "I actually traveled with him."

"Traveled?"

Chunghuh seemed to be thinking of very distant memory in the past. The name Mulack was really an old name for Chunghuh to remember.

"It was way back in the day. We'll take a walk."

Cold air swept over Jaehwan as they walked out. Chunghuh did not speak for a while and Jaehwan waited. The streets were filled with the smells of various foods. Jaehwan looked at the food being sold. It seemed like the people here were farmers since some of the vendors were selling corn and other crops while most were selling meat. It felt weird. Jaehwan heard that people in [Chaos] did not need to eat. In fact, Jaehwan himself had not eaten for 30 days until he came here and he never felt hungry.

The people selling food all looked gloomy. It wasn't like the life they were living was giving them a hard time. It was as if something deep within them was empty.

"What do you think when you see this road?"

"..."

"It doesn't feel alive, does it? The people don't feel alive."

It was as Chunghuh said.

"But that's probably normal since they are all dead."

Chunghuh frowned at Jaehwan's answer.

"People are not dead until they accept their death."

Jaehwan felt the 'death' in this world was different from the 'death' he knew. These people had spirits within [Chaos]. They had their lives. Also, they also had a chance to be revived.

"This place wasn't like this from the beginning."

Gorgon Fortress wasn't this gloomy hundreds of years ago when Chunghuh first came.

"[Chaos] was the land of blessings. It was a place where war-torn spirits gathered to rest and regain energy."

People in [Chaos] did not get old. They did not die from hunger. Every being was freed from their old life and found a new life here.

"There were fewer spirit corruptions."

The weak joined forces to hunt down horned monsters and they shared the horns. Alliances were formed when it was impossible in the Great Lands and all races joined hands to survive. Everyone was satisfied with life here.

That is, until 'That Day'.

"...What happened?"

Chunghuh stopped. He then walked over to the outside drinking bar and sat down. Jaehwan hesitated but decided to sit next to him. Chunghuh ordered a beer and spoke.

"Ha, it's a shame that your store is in ruins."

The answer came back from the person who just served the beer.

"You don't say."

It was Claire, the woman who was with Mino. Jaehwan then realized he was on the road where he had fought earlier in the day. Chunghuh cackled.

"So, are you going to open up an outside bar for now?"

"Yeah, I have no choice. Someone ruined my store."

Claire glanced at Jaehwan and began to prepare the food. Then she served a skewer of unihorn meat also.

"Ha, it's good."

Chunghuh drank the beer, took a bite, and spoke.

"So, where were we?"

"That [Chaos] was a peaceful place."

"Oh, yes."

Chunghuh smiled bitterly. "It was really peaceful back then."

Peace. That was interesting. If the place was so peaceful and everyone enjoyed their eternal afterlives, what had driven this place to its current state?

"The reason is here."

Chunghuh spoke as he shook the cup of beer he was drinking. He then drank again.

"...What do you mean?"

Jaehwan could only guess that it had something to do with the beer.

"Did people begin to fight while drunk?"

Chunghuh laughed while spraying the beer out of his mouth.

"Haha! That would've been much better."

Claire shouted in disgust for spitting beer from the distance and Chunghuh continued, "You don't know anything, do you?"

Chunghuh cleaned his mouth with his cloth.

"I guess you don't know life when you've spent your entire life stabbing."

"...Life?"

"Don't you think it weird? You don't need to eat food here."

It was as he said. Even when no one needs to eat, everyone ate when it was time.

"Even the beer. You never can get drunk. It just smells and tastes like it."

Jaehwan then took a sip of the beer. It did have the distinct smell of alcohol, but that was it. It meant that the drink wasn't really a beer after all. Jaehwan became curious.

"Then what are they?"

Jaehwan turned to two men fighting each other with red faces who seemed to be drunk.

"What do you think they are?"

"Drunk men."

"Drunk? With a beer that doesn't get you boozed?"

Jaehwan felt something was off. He looked closely. Their faces were red, and their speech was slurred. But something was missing. Their eyes. Their eyes were too clear to be the eyes of drunk men. They were just pretending to be drunk.

'Why?'

Jaehwan felt like he had found an answer as he saw Chunghuh drinking a beer that couldn't give him a buzz, or the men who were fighting each other, pretending to be drunk.

Eternal life. No death, no war. Very peaceful.

"Pretending to live the 'life'."

Life, a limited time given that was set to end when death came. They were just given freedom from their limited time, but they then longed for the life with it. Jaehwan finally felt like he understood. These people wanted to relive the real 'life' again. The life where they had a body and a heart. A life where they would die if they didn't eat or get drunk when they drink beer.

Chunghuh cackled.

"Yes, life. That was the reason. People longing for the 'real' thing appeared."

Chunghuh continued, "Well, there were more people who longed for it from the old times. It's just that there weren't much."

"...Their numbers grew?"

"Yes, but slowly. Over a very long time."

The one who lived long enough usually only consisted of one or two until then. They moved out of the fortress to quietly face death, or they traveled to the center of [Chaos] looking for the entrance to the [Depth].

Then, a new group of people who chose the third option appeared.

Ones who became bored with eternal life. Men who longed for 'real' life.

"That was the 'Depth Expedition' team. The one who grouped up to find real life again."

Chunghuh's eyes sunk. Jaehwan then understood that Chunghuh was one of the team members.

"Why did you go to the Depth?"

"To find the [Fruit]."

"Fruit..."

"It's the [Fruit of Resurrection]. It's just called [Fruit] usually."

Jaehwan realized what the [Fruit] meant when he overheard from his [Suspicion] then. This was the only way that the dead of [Chaos] could be revived back into the Great Lands.

"I was only 120 years old back then. I had nothing to be afraid of."

"That's why you joined?"

"Yes."

"Then you traveling with Mulack means..."

Chunghuh nodded.

"[Nightmare] Mulack was on that team. He was the captain of the team."

Chunghuh still remembered those days. The first time he met Mulack when he joined the expedition team.

-Awakener? Interesting.

That was what Mulack first said when he saw Chunghuh.

-And with an emotion... imperfect awakening? You walk the treacherous path. It must be hard for you.

Chunghuh did not feel good. All Awakeners faced the need to abandon human ego to see the real world. But Chunghuh refused to leave it behind. That was what made him weaker than his friends. That was what got him killed and sent him to [Chaos].

-Cut your nonsense.

-I'm sorry, I didn't mean to offend you.

Offend? It wasn't only the topic that was offensive. Chunghuh was offended the moment he saw Mulack. He was a [Product] back in the days. He still had hatred toward anyone related to the Tower of [Nightmares]. In fact, he killed every Demon he met while he traveled the Great Lands, but he had never killed [Nightmares] until now.

-Why is a [Nightmare] is going to the [Depth]? Shouldn't you stay put in your room and make a tower?

Also, Mulack wasn't even dead. These [Nightmares] used [Narrow Door] to enter [Chaos] alive.

-You are not happy about me because of the [Cultivation].

Mulack thought for a second and spoke.

-I have nothing to say. It will be pointless to ask for your forgiveness in the name of all [Nightmares].

-...Shut up.

-I think it is my burden to take.

Chunghuh thought he was lying. A [Nightmare] being remorseful about making a tower. He had never heard of such a [Nightmare].

-Believe it or not, the reason I came into the Tree of Imagery and going into the [Depth] is because of that tower.

-What?

Chunghuh could not forget what he heard next even to this day.

-To end all [Cultivation]. That is why I am leading this expedition.

Chapter 42: Doctor of Despair (9)

After listening to everything, Jaehwan asked, "...End all [Cultivation]?"

"Yes, that's what he said. He was one of a kind."

Jaehwan continued asking questions. "The expedition. Was it successful?"

"You can say it was. I had to stop by the entrance of [Depth] but Mulack did manage to reach the top of Tree of Imagery."

"How do you know that?"

"Because [Fruits] began to drop from the branch."

Chunghuh remembered watching the fruit dropping from the skies. The golden meteors that would surely give hope back to the people.

"I guess you can say it was lucky. All expedition team members returned with an armful of fruits."

"I see."

But that was weird. If the expedition was successful and they acquired the [Fruit], why was this old man still in [Chaos]? That's when Claire jumped in.

"Don't lie old man. The expedition was successful?"

Chunghuh cackled. "I was wondering when you would interrupt."

"That expedition failed. You know that."

"...What do you know when you weren't even born yet?"

Claire frowned and moved to serve the other tables. Chunghuh gulped down another cup of beer.

"What do you mean?"

"It's as she said. The expedition failed."

"Didn't you just say it succeeded?"

"It succeeded in getting the [Fruit]."

It meant something happened when they returned to [Chaos].

"There were some waiting for the team at the entrance of [Chaos]."

They were the strongest who resided in the Great Lands for a long time, but they were the ones who never dared to venture into the [Depth].

"It was the Lords and the Elders of the Renowned families."

Chunghuh spoke angrily. It was hundreds of years ago but he still remembered it very clearly.

"The expedition had Masters of fortresses and leaders of Ten-Clan. However, all of them together was no match against them. Not even close."

"And your [Fruits] were taken away."

Chunghuh drank again.

"They still use the [Fruit] even to this day to be revived if they die. They even have a place called [Revival Palace] where they can revive. All of them go to that place if they die and wait for their turn to be revived."

"...I see."

"[Chaos] is only the part of the Great Lands. The ones who are allowed to a normal life are not us."

Jaehwan looked around the streets again. The world had a thing called [Fruit] and that would allow them to be revived. But it was so far from them. That was why they were all in despair, as this old man was.

"Oh, and what happened to Mulack?"

Jaehwan had forgotten about Mulack while talking so he asked. Chunghuh did not answer so Jaehwan turned to Chunghuh.

"Hey, old man."

He fell asleep on the table. Wasn't he the one who said people here could get drunk? Why did he pass out?

"It's no use. Old man really gets drunk."

Claire spoke as she cleaned the dishes.

"...Get drunk?"

"I don't know why, but he gets drunk when he drinks."

Jaehwan looked closely Chunghuh's face. It was the face of a man who had lived for thousands of years. Maybe in his thousand years of fake lives, he had found way to fake reality.

"You had a question about Mulack?"

Jaehwan became surprised at the voice.

"...You know about him too?"

"Everyone in Gorgon Fortress knows about [Depth Expedition Team]. It's the story that old man always tells when he's drunk."

Claire sighed and continued.

"That Nightmare is gone."

"Gone?"

"No one saw him after the expedition was over."

Claire paused for a moment and continued, "I think the Nightmare did say something to the old man before he disappeared..."

"What is it?"

"What was it? Hmm..."

Claire thought as she rubbed the dishes for some time and mumbled as she remembered it.

"I have failed."

The accent seemed so realistic that Jaehwan almost thought this woman was Mulack himself.

"Yeah, that was it. I have failed. That's what he said."

I have failed... Jaehwan could guess what it meant. Mulack had reached the end of the Depth and acquired [Fruits], but he failed to stop [Cultivation].

"Is that it?"

"Hm... there was one more...."

Claire didn't seem to remember and then someone slumped down on the chair next to them. It was one of the drunk men that was fighting a while ago.

"Ha, this old man is drunk again."

Jaehwan felt the face was familiar. As he looked more closely, he realized that it was the guard that he got into a quarrel with at the gate a few days ago.

'Was it James?'

Claire spoke. "Hey, drunkard."

"What."

"Do you know what Nightmare Mulack said before he disappeared?"

"Mulack? The crazy Nightmare who said he would stop the [Cultivation]?"

"Yeah."

"Wasn't that a fake story that the old man made up? There's no such Nightmare."

James was then struck with a pan then mumbled on what he knew.

"I have failed but not completely... was this what you talking about?"

"Yeah, that."

"Dammit, that hurts. So, why did you ask?"

"The one next to you was curious about it."

James then glanced at Jaehwan.

"Oh. We've met."

"..."

"I was looking for you. To think about all the trouble I went through because of you..."

James mumbled as he gritted. It looked like Jaehwan would be involved in another annoying problem, but James suddenly said something that was unexpected.

"Thank for what you did today."

James didn't look at Jaehwan as he spoke.

"It's about the captain. He would've died if it wasn't for you."

An awkward moment passed and James took the cup Chunghuh was drinking and gulped it down.

"Madam, I'll pay for him. How much is it?"

"Get lost. I wasn't thinking of getting paid by him anyway."

"Oh, you wanted to say thanks too?"

"Get lost."

James stood up as he ranted.

"Hey, whatever you do, come by the North Gate when you come into Gorgon next time. I won't ask for certification from now on."

He turned back and added with a small voice, "Oh, but don't let the Captain know."

James walked away. Claire began chopping ingredients and Chunghuh began snoring loudly. The sound of food being made to fill non-existent hunger and the sound of tasteless beer drinking filled the area.

A world with no hope. A world without real things, filled with people who pretend to be real.

'What is this feeling?'

Jaehwan could not understand what he felt. It was very strange. Then he saw someone running to him.

'The commander?'

He was sweeping the street with his men like a madman.

"Doctor! Where are you! Doctor!"

The commander then found Jaehwan and Chunghuh and ran to them while panting.

"...You were with him also?"

The commander bowed and glanced at Chunghuh.

"Dammit, that's why he didn't answer. Doctor, wake up!"

The doctor didn't wake up and Jaehwan asked, "What is it?"

"The Master went berserk all of a sudden. He only does it once a week, but..."

It seemed something had happened regarding the Master of the fortress that only Chunghuh could solve. Then, an explosion was heard within the keep and the commander turned pale.

"No...!"

The powerful and ominous energy source was stronger than Janya's. It was stronger than any force Jaehwan had faced until now. He narrowed his eyes.

'So, the master was in that state.'

He had guessed when he heard Euren asking to him to save his 'Master'.

'Below the keep... is it underground?'

Jaehwan looked into the keep with [Suspicion]. It looked weird. It felt like the keep was shaped like a giant stomach of a monster. Deep below lied something dark. It was a dark figure that his [Suspicion] could not read. A monster with tentacles and a giant mouth. Jaehwan knew what it was immediately.

'...Dead Man.'

The Master of Gorgon Fortress was morphing into a Dead Man.

Something terrible was about to be born.

Chapter 43: Master of Gorgon (1)

Episode 7. Master of Gorgon

The commander looked toward the Inner Keep that was filled with ominous energy and turned to Jaehwan.

"You, you can also do the 'Dead Man Slash' right?"

Jaehwan shook his head.

"I just copied what he did. I can never do it like this old man unless I learn it from him."

The commander turned pale at the words.

"At this rate, Master will..."

The only one he could depend on now was the doctor, but he was in deep sleep from being drunk. That was when Jaehwan felt some powers moving toward the keep. The energy was familiar.

'It's those Golden Sky people from the earlier.'

Something was going to happen. Jaehwan hauled Chunghuh onto his back and ran toward the keep with the commander. As they drew closer, the powerful energy radiated out from within. It was tens of times stronger than the power he felt from Janya. Maybe it was because it was the Master's power.

"So, what is the Master like?"

The commander seemed to be surprised to hear such an unexpected question and answered, "...He is a good man."

Jaehwan had heard that already. That he was last hope of Gorgon, or the Great Master.

"He was a living legend. He is one of the very few who joined the [Depth Expedition Team] along with the doctor."

"The expedition?"

Before Jaehwan could ask, they were blocked by someone else. The speed and their movement proved that they were not some weak ruffians. One of them stood forward and asked, "Are you the one who does 'Dead Man Slash'?"

Jaehwan then heard whispers from his [Suspicion].

[Is he the one?]

[Yes. I saw him talking with the Chancellor today.]

[He's like a Non-Adapter. Are you sure?]

[...I just think it's a rumor.]

[But we have our orders. We have to kill him.]

The commander then became confused.

"Captain of the 3rd and 5th Battalions...?"

"Long time no see."

The 3rd and 5th Battalions represented the army stationed outside the fortress. Individual soldiers were weaker than those of the Anti-Evil group, but the group itself still had good fighting prowess. These two men were the leader of such groups.

"Move out of the way. It is an urgent matter. You all know about it."

"I can't."

"...Why is that?"

"It's an order."

"An order? Who's order are you working under!"

The men did not answer and the commander realized what it meant right away.

"You betrayed us...!"

"We serve Golden Sky now."

The commander shivered in rage as he listened to them.

"The Golden Sky Clan..."

The commander pulled out his sword. The powerful energy of a 5th stage Adapter was unleashed from within. He was the most powerful man throughout the entire military organization within the Gorgon Fortress. The two men combined would not have a chance against him.

"Do you know who you're trying to fight against?"

"Commander, don't think that we are the same as before."

The spiritual energy unleashed they each unleashed made the commander frown. He knew those captains as 4th stage Adapters, but the energy they unleashed was that of the 5th stage.

"How did you..."

Jaehwan narrowed his eyes. The energy coming from them was similar to the energy from Janya. Their power was similar to the Dead Man.

The fight erupted and the commander could not stand a chance against two men who were equal in power. He stepped back quickly before he stood in front of Jaehwan and shouted.

"R-run! I will block this..."

"Hey, hold this."

"Huh?"

Commander then felt something being put on his back. It was the doctor still snoring in his sleep. Jaehwan flexed his wrist and stood forward.

"Like I said, I'm not good at saving people's lives. That's his job."

The two men paused for a second but then charged again, this time at Jaehwan. Jaehwan pulled out his sword.

"But I know a thing or two about killing."

The prison cell beneath the Inner Keep.

Chancellor Euren looked inside with concerned look.

'The doctor is late...'

The cell made out of monster horns was being destroyed and the door was letting out ominous energy from within. Euren knew what was behind the door. It was the man who was the closest to having the title of 'King' if not including the 'King of Chaos' himself. The man who was on the brink of becoming the most terrifying Dead Man in [Chaos].

That person was inside.

Euren looked around. The people gathered here were the top officers of the Fortress. Euren looked closely at them and thought, 'Why did the Master go berserk now?'

His spirit had been deeply corrupted that even the doctor's 'Dead Man Slash' did not work. But it had some effect as one 'Dead Man Slash' bought a week's worth of time. It was all thanks to the Master's great endurance. The corruption was too deep to fully recover from, but the slash allowed him to stop him from becoming a Dead Man. But now it had come to this.

'Not even a day had passed since the last slash...'

It was in the morning that the doctor had performed treatment. They checked the morphing which had subsided and the power had dissipated. But why? Euren could not understand.

'If we had a month, we might have had the chance of saving him...'

Chapter 44: Master of Gorgon (2)

The plan that was not possible had become a reality today with Jaehwan's appearance. He remembered the doctor's words.

-We can't do it now. His 'Dead Man Slash' right now is just a copy, but it will be complete in a month.

Euren thanked the miracle that had brought Jaehwan to Gorgon.

-I have never tried, but we might be able to do it with two men. Besides, he...

Euren just needed to buy more time. But all the time he had bought was not even a day. He was now being pressured by the other leaders of the Fortress who were glaring at him.

'Does some of them know about Jaehwan?'

Euren already knew there was a traitor among the fortress leaders. He knew it when Master went out on an inspection on the Outer Fortress half a year ago and returned with spiritual corruption.

"Chancellor, any word?"

Maihan, the Outer Fortress Minister, spoke. He was the second oldest one to have served the Master and the closest one to take up the position next.

"No, nothing."

Maihan nodded and spoke.

"Everyone, stand ready."

They were all powerful Adapters, but everyone seemed to be tense. Euren held on Maihan who was trying to walk into the cell.

"It's dangerous. We'll move in once the doctor arrives."

"Gorgon will end if we waste any more time."

Euren scoffed from within.

'Since when you care about Gorgon?'

Everyone knew the situation in the Outer fortress had become worse after Master had fallen ill. The North was fine where Karlton was defending, but the other three areas had increasing crime rates.

"We need the doctor to perform the treatment. Are you trying to kill Master or something?"

"Master? You know that we all don't stand a chance against him."

"Then why..."

"I have a way."

A way? Some were confused, but most of them seemed to know what was coming.

"We will proceed with [Dead Man Seal]."

"NO! That's the last resort!"

"We can't do it if we wait any longer."

[Dead Man Seal] was the final resort to seal off the spirit before the powerful spirit turned into a Dead Man. This was a legendary skill only the Greens could perform.

"But we don't even have the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit]!"

"Chancellor, we know already. Do not lie."

Maihan spoke sternly. "I know you have the stone."

Euren's face became pale.

'How?'

That was when some figures came from outside of the cell with a black box. Euren knew the box. It was the box with the [Stone of Forgotten Spirit] that he received from Jaehwan. The box was floating with its spiritual energy to avoid contacting the corruption spilling out from the stone. Euren knew who was moving the box right away.

'General...'

It was the General of Shadowmoon. He never thought that the one who worked directly under him was the traitor. The general did not look at Euren and gave the stone to Maihan.

"Gorgon's future is in question. Why did you try to hide this?"

Euren wanted to say that it was because he was suspicious of them, but he had nothing to prove. The Master went berserk and the doctor wasn't coming. The only way left was to do the [Seal].

"If the Master becomes a Dead Man, you know what will happen."

Giant Dead Man. The monster of disaster. A calamity that would sweep the land with countless Dead Men alongside him.

"W-we have to stop it!"

Some of the other officers shouted, agreeing with Maihan. Euren tried to stay calm and spoke.

"But the [Seal] can only be performed by the Greens. Having the stone doesn't mean anything."

"Don't worry." Maihan calmly spoke. "I have those who can."

Then, mysterious people came from his behind him with robes which hid their faces and bodies. They even had cloth bandages all over their faces. They were letting out dark energy.

"But they are not the Greens."

"No, but they can do the [Seal]."

Euren bit his lip.

'Something's not right.'

If they start performing the skill, the Master's spiritual energy would be absorbed into the stone. The problem would occur afterwards.

Who would take the ownership of the stone? [Chaos] did not have succession rules. People who wanted the Master's stone would appear and the people here would end up fighting against each other. Having the Master's energy didn't mean it would grant them the power.

'Having his power means he will become the Guardian Horned Monster or Gorgon's master. If it falls into the wrong hands...'

That was when the robed figure picked up the stone. People began mumbling. If one could pick up the Stone when he was not a Green, there was only one answer.

'Corruption wielder...!'

Euren then remembered Master's last words.

-There are people who can control corruption...

He was investigating them when he returned in his corrupted state. Euren looked at Maihan.

'Wait... is it him?'

Euren looked around. Other than the few officers who looked concerned, most of them looked calm. That was when he realized it was too late.

'No...'

Maihan opened the cell door and walked in with the robed figures. Maihan then used a skill to light the inside up. Bright light from the orb moved up to the ceiling and revealed the cell.

The Master of Fortress was revealed in his bony, near-dead state. His body had turned black and his veins trembled like tentacles. It was the last of the legend of Gorgon. Euren felt like crying at the sight.

'I'm sorry, Master.'

It was at that moment, that the prison cell's ceiling exploded. It was so powerful that the robed figures screamed and were thrown backward. Officers and Maihan shouted angrily. Someone came down from a big hole that was made by the explosion. Only the Chancellor knew who it was at once.

"Jaehwan!"

It was Jaehwan with Chunghuh on his back.

Chapter 45: Master of Gorgon (3)

"How dare you interrupt...!"

Maihan shook with rage as he watched his men who were on the ground from the shock. The [Seal] was about to be complete, yet some man appeared out of nowhere and ruined his plan.

"Who are you?!"

"Minister, enough with your lies."

It was the commander who came down next to Jaehwan and spoke.

"We know that you are a traitor."

The officers were surprised and began mumbling themselves, while Maihan answered calmly.

"Under what circumstances are you accusing me of such a thing?"

"Don't think you will get away with your lies."

The commander had one man in each of his arms. Maihan knew these men very well.

"These men confessed to everything."

Maihan narrowed his eyes as the commander threw down the two men in front of him.

"M-minister..."

They were badly beaten up and out of their minds. They were obviously overpowered by someone much stronger than them.

'They did this to them?'

These captains were now almost as powerful as the commander himself. In fact, with their entire battalion, it would even allow them to fight the doctor himself.

'What in the world had happened...!'

He could not know, but his plan was definitely crumbling by the second. Maihan's eyes grew cold.

"I-I'm sorry..."

One of the captains moaned, and at that time, their body exploded. The commander quickly moved to check on them, but they were dead.

"What are you doing, Minister?!"

"I didn't do it." Maihan shrugged.

"Maybe they killed themselves for their traitorous acts."

"How dare you spit out such lies!" the commander yelled.

"Don't accuse me of such nonsense. Come on! We will start the [Seal]!"

The mumbling died instantly. What was important was the Master. Some officers spoke to the commander.

"Hey, we don't know what happened but we should do the [Seal] first and..."

The commander shouted angrily.

"Clear your minds! This is treason! The minister is a traitor! He cannot continue the [Seal]!"

"Get him out."

The Shadowmoon Guards and the general circled the commander and Jaehwan. Jaehwan quietly looked at them and spoke to Euren who was next to him.

"It's a mess."

"...I'm sorry."

Euren bit his lips. He realized that Jaehwan now knew what had been going on within the keep. Jaehwan said, "You have given me false hope."

"..."

"This kind of group cannot ensure my safety."

Euren felt his heart fall at his words.

"You mean..."

Their contract was to protect Jaehwan while he saved their Master. But if Gorgon could not fulfill the promise, there was no need for Jaehwan to uphold his end. But what Jaehwan said next was out of the blue.

"We will change the contract."

"What?"

"I will save the Master and kill all those traitors."

Euren became dumbfounded at the unexpected words. Some of the Shadowmoon Guards charged at Jaehwan, but Jaehwan easily deflected their attacks and threw them at the wall like trash.

"You give me that old man in return."

Jaehwan pointed at Chunghuh whom he had thrown behind him on the floor.

"And..."

He deflected few more swords and continued, "Help me create an expedition team."

Expedition Team. Euren felt his heart pounding at that word. He didn't know why. Maybe it was because the 'Expedition Team' had special meaning to it in this fortress.

"I will recreate the [Depth Expedition Team]."

Depth Expedition Team!

Euren thought of his memories. He saw flashes of Master returning from the Expedition, which he barely survived. He had lived hundreds of years in remorse afterwards.

-Euren, these people need hope. They need greater hope to keep them alive!

That was what the Master of Gorgon said to him in the past. Euren thought as he watched Jaehwan's back. Maybe it was this back that the Master had waited for after all this time. Euren answered with a shaky voice.

"...It shall be done."

"Good. Keep the promise."

The contract was made. Jaehwan immediately struck.

"Wh-What?!"

"AAARGH!"

One stab killed three guards. The general panicked and ordered to form a new formation.

"Attack together!"

In the next moment, tens of Shadowmoon Guards vanished after Jaehwan's normal stab. An enormous black beam erupted out from the sword and almost half of the Shadowmoon Guards were gone, dissipating into white powder. The beam destroyed the ground and shot up into the sky.

The Shadowmoon General looked down at his waist, which was gone. He tried to speak, but he could not make a sound. He then disappeared into powder.

It was a terrifying attack that killed an army and a 5th stage Adapter in one move. The people were shocked. Maihan, who managed to barely protect himself from the explosion, panted.

'It was him!'

He had heard about him. There was a man who killed Janya after he had become a Dead Man. But the man who reported was Huksurlang who was infamous for lying so Maihan thought it was an exaggeration.

'He spoke the truth!'

Maihan saw how far he had been pushed out. There were traces of it on the ground. He was pushed back at least five steps. The attack killed all of Shadowmoon and had pushed him five steps back.

'He's strong as me or stronger.'

He was nearing the Adapter 7th stage, and there was no other match for him other than the Doctor of Despair within this fortress. Maihan changed his attitude immediately.

"Who are you to bother our sacred work-"

"Shut up."

Jaehwan's vicious aura made Maihan flinch and step backward.

'I'm afraid? Me, who is at end of the 6th stage?'

Jaehwan's voice was cold.

"You will all die."

"How dare you say such a thing?!"

Jaehwan caught various whispers through his [Suspicion] even now.

[Prime Elder, what should we do?! Can we proceed with our plan?]

[If we cannot proceed, we should choose the latter option...]

[We should let the Black Cloud loose right now!]

[We should rather eradicate all of Gorgon then...]

"Maihan Keldergran."

Maihan flinched at Jaehwan who spoke his full name.

"Outer Fortress Minister of Gorgon, and the Prime Elder of Golden Sky Clan."

Maihan's face turned grim. How did this man know?

"I do not know why and how you corrupt spirits."

The man approached and Maihan stepped back without realizing.

"But I know one thing. I like the ones like you."

"Y-you like us? What are you talking about?!"

Maihan shouted as he held up the sword. He instinctively knew that if he did not stop this man here, the clan's entire plan would be ruined.

"KILL HIM!"

Chapter 46: Master of Gorgon (4)

Maihan shouted and seven officers pulled out their swords. The traitors had revealed themselves willingly. At that moment, countless number of Golden Sky warriors appeared. The commander and Euren's face paled. It was impossible to defeat an army like that even with the doctor or Leader of the Ten-Clan. It was the unified attack of one 6th stage Adapter and seven 5th stage Adapters, including hundreds of 3rd stages. But why?

"It's really great-"

Jaehwan looked excited.

"The likes of you-"

His sword roared like a lion.

"Make me feel at ease to put an end to this world."

Maihan then felt something was wrong. He also knew it was too late to turn back. Something great was coming. But before he could think, he was swept away by something.

An enormous beam of light destroyed the inner fortress' ceiling and the tower. It soared through the sky and created a giant crack across the night sky. The light shined upon the dark night instantly. People of Gorgon ran out of their houses at the tremor.

Stars were falling down from the sky.

Star particles bombarded the Inner Keep. Armies approaching the inner fortress died from the falling particles and the area was filled with white powder that was blown by the winds.

The extreme of all stabs.

It was Jaehwan's first time using a 'Strong Stab.'

When the dust died down, Maihan was revealed again. Golden Sky and all the officers around him were gone. Maihan realized that he could not survive. He had lost his both arms and legs in the attack. His body was torn and he could not even speak properly because of his ripped throat.

"Ugh... he... but... it's too late! The Master... Gorgon will be..."

And before he could finish, Jaehwan thrust his sword at his face and finished him. Jaehwan then pulled out his sword from the powder and kicked Chunghuh.

"Old man, wake up. You're late."

"Nngh... what's going on? ...You've done a great mess here, kid."

At that moment, the alarm went off within the cell.

[WARNING! TARGET'S CORRUPTION LEVEL HAS REACHED 99.9%! MORPHING WILL START!]

[WARNING! TARGET'S SPIRITUAL POWER LEVEL IS EXTREMELY HIGH!]

[SYSTEM IS CALCULATING THE THREAT LEVEL OF THE TARGET-]

...

[EVALUATION FAILED!]

[SYSTEM EVALUATION: GIANT DEAD MAN!]

[ACTIVATING GORGON'S AUTOMATIC ALARM!]

A siren blared from the outside. It was sound of the 'Gorgon One' evacuation order and a voice which told the civilians to run. Chunghuh said, "You, help me out."

"..."

"Your [Stab] is too sharp to save someone right now."

Chunghuh then picked up his sword. The sword began to move like a brush on a paper.

The world turned white. It was the start of the 'Dead Man Slash'.

The Master's spirit burning in black flame was in the center. Chunghuh's sword moved quickly. Forgotten memories of the Master were being retraced and his darkness moved. Chunghuh's forehead was drenched in sweat. After some time, the Master opened his eyes. He had opaque, deep dark eyes. Chunghuh quickly took some steps back.

"What is it?"

A spirit opening its eyes meant his conscious was back. But Chunghuh did not seem glad.

"Something's wrong. Something else has been awakened..."

Jaehwan felt the being in front of them had too great of a power to be considered a human. The eyes began to glow as he stood up and looked down at his skinny body.

'No, that's not the Master.'

It was a much more powerful being that had borrowed Master's body to appear.

[I'm surprised. I didn't think I would return through this body. ...So he has fallen also.]

Jaehwan saw the Master's body quickly regenerating. Enormous energy filled the body as the flesh gained life. Jaehwan had never seen such power.

'Dead Man?'

He used [Suspicion], but all he could see was deep darkness. The being in front wasn't human, and it wasn't a Dead Man. It wasn't alive or dead but it didn't look like an object either. Jaehwan could not figure out what to say about the being.

[It brings back old memories...]

The being was like a 'world' of its own.

[I see a familiar face.]

Chunghuh was shaking, terrified. He knew that being.

[Imperfect Awakener... Why are you still in [Chaos]?]

"K-King of Chaos..."

Jaehwan looked at Chunghuh. As far as he knew, the most powerful in [Chaos] were the Masters of the Fortresses and the Leaders of the Ten-Clan. But no one had the title of 'King'. Jaehwan now knew why.

'The title was for that thing.'

The only one who had the title of 'King' in this [Chaos]. Chunghuh mumbled, "Sole-King Catastrophe..."

Chunghuh knew this being. He had faced it 900 years ago.

Sole-King Catastrophe. The King of all Dead Men and the Master of [Dead Man Palace] located at the center of [Chaos]. The only being who could open the door to the [Depth].

[Why? Why are you still here? Is it to protect this worthless world?]

The voice shook through the spirit. It was as if the voice was going to suck the spirit into it. The King reached out with his hand towards the white world that Chunghuh had created. The white turned into darkness at once.

[Did you not find what you wanted within the [Depth]?]

Chunghuh slumped down on the ground. His spirit had reached the limit in handling the situation. That's when the King turned to Jaehwan.

[Interesting. Fully awakened, but with a human heart.]

Jaehwan then realized he had been gripping his sword tightly. He was tense. Jaehwan asked, "Old man, you failed, right?"

Chunghuh looked at Jaehwan while trembling. How could that man stay calm with that thing in front in front of him? How can he be so calm?

"Then, I can kill it right?"

Chapter 47: Master of Gorgon (5)

The King looked Jaehwan weirdly. He seemed to be surprised, or amused. Or perhaps even angered.

[You wish to kill me?]

His presence was so great that it seemed like he could destroy mountains and the earth.

[ME?]

Chunghuh could not even get up. The strong presence was so overbearing that even Chunghuh, who was an Awakener, could not stand against him. His power was immeasurable, an impossible might that could not be explained.

"Give back the Master's spirit."

Chunghuh could not understand how that man can stay so calm and-

"Or I will kill you."

...Speak like that to him. The King looked at Jaehwan. Chunghuh could not even dare to look at the King even when he wasn't looking at him. But he had to do something. He barely managed to compose a whisper. Even if it meant that they would lose the Master, he could not let Jaehwan die here.

[Kid! No! You can't just kill him!]

Jaehwan wordlessly prepared for a [Stab].

[That... that thing is not something that can be killed!]

"Old man."

Chunghuh looked at Jaehwan while shivering.

"Man up."

It wasn't confidence or pride. It was just a matter of fact.

"I'm stronger."

A strange sound came. The sound was so strange that it took some time for Chunghuh to realize that it was laughter. The King was laughing.

[Amusing fool. It's the first time in 900 years after that [Nightmare] came that someone funny like you appeared.]

Chunghuh knew who that [Nightmare] was. Mulack, the legendary [Nightmare] who reached the top of the Tree of Imagery. However, even Mulack could not do anything against the King. Although Mulack fought the real King's body and the one in front was only an avatar, Chunghuh was sure that no one could fight against such a being.

[Good. We shall fight. Come, foolish Awakener.]

A cloud-like substance appeared in the King's hand and formed a dark, transparent blade.

'Void Sword!'

Chunghuh barely managed to calm himself by grabbing his own trembling shoulders. It was the terrifying weapon that made half of the Expedition Team into Dead Man in one strike. Weapons on each side moved in an instant.

"UGH!"

Chunghuh was thrown back by the wind created by the clash. The King spoke.

[I've seen eyes like yours before. You wish to go to the [Depth].]

Chunghuh was surprised.

'The kid wants to go to the [Depth]?'

He knew the man was mysterious, but he never thought Jaehwan would want to go to the [Depth].

[It's amazing that there are ones who wish to reach the end of this world, even to this day.]

Jaehwan ignored his words and readied himself. It was the start of a real fight.

[EXCITING!]

The King shouted. He seemed to be really excited.

[But not enough! It's not even close to that [Nightmare]!]

The King's movements became faster. Jaehwan had not laid a successful strike against the King yet. The King was moving much faster than Jaehwan's [Slight Stab]. Jaehwan focused his sword to concentrate the energy on his blade.

[Normal Stab]

The attack was made but the King wasn't there. Jaehwan then felt sudden danger and instinctively twisted his waist. It was a miracle that he dodged the attack. The shoulder that Void Sword touched had turned black.

[Corruption is a disease of time.]

Jaehwan quickly examined his shoulder through [Suspicion] and was shocked. Only the shoulder's time was being fast forwarded. Hundreds of years were passing by.

'So, this is how the corruption takes place.'

The phenomenon of spirit becoming aged. The corruption was with time. Jaehwan let out the aged spirit from his body. King spoke, astonished.

[Interesting. A slight touch would've made you a Dead Man... you have a great spirit.]

The King smiled, and then disappeared.

[But that's not enough!]

Ten Void Swords appeared from the King but Jaehwan did not fall back. Ten [Normal Stabs]. His stabs clashed against the ten Void Swords.

[It's great for a toy made by a [Nightmare]!]

The blade then cut Jaehwan's thigh and Jaehwan cut off part of the spirit that was starting to become corrupt.

[You will not have enough spirit left if you continue.]

That was true. If this went on, Jaehwan would lose.

'He's really strong.'

Jaehwan could not measure the opponent's strength. He could not see his weakness even through [Suspicion]. Without [Suspicion], his [Understand] would not work. All he knew was that the being had lived for countless years.

Jaehwan unleashed his energy. The white world Chunghuh created was being removed and was replaced by a new world. Chunghuh shook. It was the true power of an Awakener.

All Awakeners had their [Own Worlds]. This world came to life through the keyword they acquired when they awakened and the more powerful an Awakener was, the more beings it could bring into its world.

Chunghuh's white world was such a world. Then, Chunghuh realized something.

It was hell. Jaehwan was living in hell. His world was made of hatred and rage. A world that destroyed all worlds.

The ground had countless blades stuck in it with hot lava flowing underneath. There was an eery eye in the sky like a moon with a swarm of crows pecking away at the 'moon eye', spilling blood into the lava.

Chapter 48: Master of Gorgon (6)

[I see. This is your world! Interesting!]

The King's voice became even more excited. Their swords clashed. Jaehwan felt strange as he moved his sword. He had never felt this way. As their swords clashed, thousands of words were exchanged.

[You do not give up on your hatred even after you realize the truth and emptiness of life!]

The King was astonished.

[I have seen beings that destroyed worlds for over millions of years. All of them climbed this tree with their questions.]

King Catastrophe spoke while deflecting stabs.

[What question do you seek to be answered with such a world on your back?]

Jaehwan did not answer. But the King seemed to understand.

[I see. The world itself is your question.]

Their swords clashed again.

[A world that has fallen!]

The stab had reached its maximum power.

[Arrogant world! A mere human questioning the worth of the [Great Lands]? You ask through your words that if the [Great Lands] is worthy

enough to exist?]

Jaehwan swallowed his breath and spoke.

"I don't know what you are talking about."

[What?]

Jaehwan did not answer. Instead, he thrust his sword.

The world screamed. His [Strong Stab] was unleashed.

The light that penetrated the world stormed the area. The place that stormed left the Master's body. Only the flesh remained with the bones while the left arm and right leg were missing.

[I see... so it wasn't a question. You are not climbing the Tree to question.]

The King was enraged.

[You are an insolent fool!]

Powerful Dead Man energy quickly regenerated the Master's body. The arm and leg regenerated and all the wounds on the body had healed. Yet the King was shocked. Jaehwan had disappeared from his sight. The King then felt the pain of something being cut from the back.

[What...?]

[Strong Stab] was made to fight against an army. It wasn't a good skill to use to attack an individual. Jaehwan had not intended to kill him with [Strong Stab]. It was just a decoy to buy time.

'This being cannot be killed. Even when I'm using a stronger skill than [Strong Stab].'

The only thing that would be destroyed would be the Master's spirit. The King was using his spirit as a conduit to appear in this world. Its material

body was not here, so it was impossible to kill. The only way to fight it was to cut the link between the King and the Master.

Jaehwan had done it on Beastlain back in the tower. He was sure that he could do it again. As the King focused on defending against the Strong Stab, Jaehwan concentrated his entire focus on [Suspicion]. He was then able to see a faint line coming out from the body.

[How did you use this skill...!]

For the first time, the King was shocked.

[...Interesting. Skill of [Rupture]!]

The power of the King was being lifted and the Master's damaged spirit was coming back. The King glared at Jaehwan and spoke.

[You who live the fall. I will wait for you at the entrance of the [Depth]. Please, do not disappoint me then.]

And he was gone. Master fell down on the ground like a rag doll and Jaehwan sighed.

'It's finished.'

He wasn't sure if he could succeed. The King was a powerful enemy. He might have lost if he tried to fight it outright.

'I should get stronger.'

His stab wasn't enough anymore. He needed new skills to climb up to the [Depth]. Jaehwan then turned to Chunghuh.

"Old man."

Chunghuh had fainted. Euren and all the others also had fallen unconscious. It was then that he heard a whisper.

[You... come over here.]

Jaehwan gripped his sword tightly again.

"Still here?"

[I'm not the King.]

It was coming from the Master. There was a faint spirit power within that was holding on. Jaehwan realized who it was immediately.

"Master?"

[I was in the state of Dead Man, but I was watching you. Having the courage to fight the King... I thank you.]

The whisper barely continued.

[I do not have much time. Let me ask you a favor. If Chunghuh or Euren, any of them are near...]

"Both are here."

[Bring them over...]

"They both are knocked out."

Master moaned.

[...Please come closer.]

Jaehwan walked up to him and the Master used his remaining strength to grab Jaehwan's wrist. Jaehwan frowned.

"What is this?"

[...Maybe Gorgon needs to change... please take it.]

Jaehwan felt powerful energy flowing into him. It was the Master's spirit. But it wasn't just a normal spirit. As the power was absorbed, a drawing of a black serpent appeared on Jaehwan's left arm.

[You have a familiar energy... that brings back old memories...]

Master seemed to have felt something from Jaehwan and smiled with satisfaction.

[Please, do not lose your humanity.]

And then he was gone. The drawing squirmed as if it were alive. That was when he heard Chunghuh from the back.

"...What on earth."

He was looking at Jaehwan's arm with a dumbfounded look. Euren, the commander, and all the others were waking up. The Black Serpent let out a faint silvery glow.

"Is that...?"

Jaehwan could not understand what was going on. Euren and other officers approached Jaehwan and began to kneel. One, two, three people increased into tens and thirty... even the other officers who arrived at the scene late, saw the drawing on Jaehwan's arm and quickly kneeled.

All of Gorgon was now kneeling in front of Jaehwan.

Then the man at the front, Euren spoke.

"Euren Chiver, at the Gorgon's new Master's service."

Chapter 49: Master of Gorgon (7)

Two days passed after Jaehwan became the Master of the Gorgon Fortress.

A lot of things happened within the keep. Many people worked to prepare for the new Master and many Clan Leaders came to the keep to introduce themselves to the new Master.

Euren turned away all visitors. The problem at hand was more important.

Within the keep, the same discussion was being held again and again.

Jaehwan was sitting on the Master's chair, feeding his sword. Euren spoke.

"Hm... Master."

"I'm not your Master."

"You are now."

"No. I told you, I won't do it."

"That's not what you promised!"

"Promise? I fulfilled my promise."

"Maybe you have forgotten it. I will remind you again."

Euren took out a small paper and handed it over to Jaehwan.

[Jaehwan's promise]

-Save the Master of Gorgon's life

-Kill the traitors

[Euren's promise]

-Help Jaehwan form a Depth Expedition Team.

Jaehwan frowned.

"...Since the Master died, you want me to be one?"

"Well, I guess we can say that."

Jaehwan did fail to uphold his part of the promise. That was true.

"Wait, so am I the 'Master' of this fortress?"

"Yes."

"But if that's true... 'Master of Gorgon' still lives right?"

"That is correct."

"So I fulfilled my promise then."

Euren laughed. "Yes, you did."

Jaehwan looked confused and asked, "And?"

"And, you will keep on with the promise."

"What are you talking about?"

"Didn't you just say you are the new Master now?"

"I did."

"Look at the paper again."

- Save the Master of Gorgon's life

Jaehwan frowned.

'Dammit. So that's how it goes.'

Frankly, Jaehwan did not fulfill the promise on his part. The Master he needed to save died. That's why Jaehwan was working his way around, trying to weave himself out from his own trap. He tried to argue that even though the Master died, there was a new Master so he technically did fulfill his part. But for that to be true, Jaehwan himself now had to stay as a 'Living Master of Gorgon'. He needed to fulfill his duty as a Master.

"I don't have time to stay behind and guard this fortress."

Jaehwan wasn't interested in power or fame.

"I need to go into the [Depth]."

Settling down would make him weak, and the weak became corrupt. Corruption then strengthened the settling down process, which would prevent him from leaving.

"I will make you the new Master."

"You cannot do that." Euren shook his head. "No one besides you can be the Master."

"Why is that?"

"Because Gorgon will not accept it."

Jaehwan then realized it wasn't the keep that Euren was talking about when he mentioned Gorgon. It was the black serpent tattoo wiggled on Jaehwan's left arm. Euren once mentioned that it was 'Gorgon'.

'So, this one chose me?'

Euren added, "The Master of Gorgon changes only when the former dies. It's not a seat that can be passed down voluntarily.'

Jaehwan wanted to bust out of the keep at this moment, but he couldn't. Since he took the Seal of Gorgon, he also inherited some of the memories of the former Master. He knew that what would become of the fortress if it lost its Master.

'Dammit.'

But he couldn't just agree to stay and become a new Master. Jaehwan looked at all kinds of documents that Euren had piled up.

"You have to take care of those documents by today. And this..."

Jaehwan looked through the documents. After looking through some documents, he began looking at the manuals left by previous Masters. After a while, Jaehwan came across a book written by the 17th Master 'Arbat' with a name of [101 Ways to become a Good Master].

'It's bit thin to hold 101 ways.'

It was maybe a tad thicker than a fingernail. Jaehwan opened up the book.

-Congratulations! If you are reading this book, you are probably the new Master!

-You will have a lot of questions. You will feel burdened by your new position. Oh, how I understand your worries! You must be spending day and night thinking about how to improve Gorgon Fortress!

Jaehwan wasn't thinking about any of that.

-But don't worry. You are very lucky, because there's only one thing the Master needs to do.

Jaehwan became curious as he read through the book.

-That is, to do NOTHING!

Jaehwan became confused.

-You might be confused. But it's true! Remember, all you need to do is do NOTHING! Let your departments do the work specified for them. They will do just fine!

He couldn't understand.

-You will think that it is strange. Why is a former Master giving such strange advice? But remember. These are wise words that have been handed down from generations!

The story continued.

-Passion brings sickness in Chaos. You do not know, but half of the former Masters died by killing themselves. According to stats in [Big Brother], the job that has the highest suicide rate in [Chaos] is the Master of Fortress. What killed the other half? They died from overworking themselves. 'Spirit Corruption' occurred from the burden of work, to be precise. Working too much hastens the corruption, as you might already know.

The book was now turning more personal and emotional.

-This advice is for you, and Gorgon. Don't be greedy. Don't try to change anything. Don't overwork yourself.

Jaehwan could feel Arbat's remorse and helplessness. He felt the former Master's pain by reading it.

-[Chaos] is older than you think. You will know that change means nothing in this world. All beings in this world know that this world will not change. The thing you need in this world is no change. It's to exist.

The book was almost at its end.

-Master is the one who chooses to exist than to change. You must exist, even if it means that you do not do anything. People will thank you and be relieved that you are alive. That you are there. It will be a boring life, but that is what is needed.

The last words in the paragraph seemed to have stopped for a long time before it continued. The 17th Master must have had thought long and hard before writing it.

-So, please. I beg you, do nothing and stay alive. This is more important than you think. There are no such things as 101 ways to become a Good Master. A Good Master is a Master that does not do anything. That's the only advice I want to give.

And that was how the book ended. Jaehwan could understand what the 17th Master was trying to say.

'I see. That's the Master of Fortress.'

A being that gives up hope to stay alive. A being that stops change to exist.

'But can you call that life?'

Jaehwan thought he could perhaps understand the people's deep-rooted despair in this world a bit more. The Master of Fortress was like this. They might have had hope and passion in the beginning, but they then realized that whatever they did, a wall would block them. That made them depressed and made them want to give up.

"Uh... Master?" Euren frowned. "Master! Are you listening?"

"Yeah."

"You don't seem to be listening. What were you thinking?"

"I was thinking about what I can do for this fortress."

Euren's eyes widened in surprise.

"Are you, really?"

"Yeah."

"So, you will become the Master of the Fortress?"

"No, but I do plan on doing something for sure."

Jaehwan folded the book and continued, "I won't become the Master of Gorgon."

Euren looked at Jaehwan.

"But I will do this." Jaehwan paused and continued, "I will remove the 'Master' from Gorgon."

Euren could not understand. "...What?"

"Are you trying to commit suicide?" What kind of man would kill himself just to avoid becoming a Master?

'No, but he can...'

Euren looked at Jaehwan. He was a type of person that he had never seen throughout his entire lifetime. There was a chance that Jaehwan really would commit suicide to not do something he hated.

"What rubbish are you talking about."

"I don't understand what you are talking about."

Jaehwan looked at Euren mockingly. Euren became slightly angry and gave it a thought. What did it mean to remove the Master?

"The Master exists because 'Fortress' exists."

"What?"

Euren thought about it deeply. He then became shocked and shouted, "Are you trying to destroy Gorgon Fortress?! You're going to kill everyone?"

Jaehwan raised his eyebrows as he shook his head.

"Am I some demon?"

"But so, what is it that you're talking about?"

Jaehwan, instead of answering the question, asked, "Euren, do you know what the 'Fortress' is?"

What the Fortress is? It was a foolish question. Euren had been living in this fortress for over 200 years.

"The fortress is the place where you protect the people living in it."

"Yeah. And how do you protect it?"

"With a wall and an army."

"Right. With an army. It's a military institute that focuses to protect. But protect from what?"

Euren became confused at the additional questions, but he answered anyway.

"From enemies of course."

Jaehwan nodded and continued, "Yes, so the Fortress exists to protect the people from enemies."

"Yes... I guess so."

"Then let me ask you a question. What if those enemies cease to exist?"

"Huh?"

"What if no one invades this fortress? What do you think?"

Euren thought. There was no need for walls or armies to protect if there were no enemies attacking them. If that was true, the Fortress would lose its purpose to exist. The people living within the fortress would be freed from the boundaries and roam [Chaos] as they saw fit. Euren stopped thinking.

"But that's impossible. How can you not have enemies..."

"It's possible."

Euren looked at Jaehwan. Did he understand what he was talking about?
Jaehwan nodded and spoke.

"I will unite [Chaos]."

Chapter 50: Master of Gorgon (8)

[Chaos] had no funerals.

Funerals were for the living. It was a ceremony for the living to remember the dead and think about them. But everyone in [Chaos] was already dead. A few lucky ones would have had their funerals while most were probably left out in the fields to become rotting corpses. But it didn't matter as none of them knew what happened to their bodies.

However, [Chaos] did have ceremonies for those who perished.

On the third day after Jaehwan became the new Master, a ceremony was held for the perished spirits within Gorgon Keep. Euren stood on top of the podium and began reading out something with the help of the [Sound Amplification] skill.

"We know Aimel Groscheck. But we cannot bury him because he does not exist anywhere in this world. With the few memories given to us, he has become part of the Tree of Imagery, without his spirit nor his body."

Ceremony of Spirit Flow. It was the name to remember the dead.

"We will not forget about Aimel Groscheck. For that, we will talk about him. Talk more and more about him so that we will have nothing to talk about him anymore."

The purpose of the ceremony was to erase the trace of the perished. As the ceremony was held, they talked about the spirit, over and over again, and never mentioned it anymore once the ceremony was over.

This was the last gift that [Chaos] could give to those who had left.

Jaehwan finally knew the former Master's name after he joined the ceremony.

Aimel Grosheck. The Master of Gorgon who gave the position to Jaehwan.

'Damn old man.'

Jaehwan did not like the idea of taking part in this ceremony. It was because of the old man that he was now a Master. Euren glanced at Jaehwan time to time as he read on from the podium.

-Master! Please, you must join! You are the Master now!

Euren seemed to be satisfied that Jaehwan attended. He probably thought it was because to him that Jaehwan came down. But that wasn't it. Jaehwan had his own purpose for attending this annoying ceremony.

Jaehwan glanced around at the people who attended. Messengers from other fortresses joined while Leaders of the Ten-Clan sent horns of horned monsters as gifts. A few of them had sent their Elders and officers to attend.

Nobody cried or became sad, but all of them talked about the Master.

Chunghuh cackled. He seemed calm for a man who had lost a friend he had known for 900 years.

"It's the same as a funeral. It's copying what the living do."

"You should say that when you don't get drunk."

"What! I'm just copying the way to live life!"

Chunghuh shouted and gulped down his beer.

"If you have lived a thousand years like me, death doesn't mean much. It's rather a good thing. You are now freed from life."

Jaehwan looked at the others and Chunghuh stepped out to the group and began dancing and singing. Jaehwan then turned to Euren. Before the

ceremony started, Euren had told him the details.

-The ceremony will last for a week.

Jaehwan could already feel many looking at him.

-It's the first time a stranger has become a Master. You need to watch out.

Surely, those that were looking at him were from the Ten-Clan. Some seemed to be quite powerful among them. Jaehwan could hear all of their [Whispers] by using [Suspicion].

[I don't know what is going on. How did that young spirit become a Master?]

[I heard he's not even 100 years old.]

[A kid becoming a Master!]

[Is Euren up to something?]

There were some who were just flat out mumbling.

"...He looks like he's tempted to have a fight."

It was a lady who wore a purple dress and a veil over her face. She was glancing at Jaehwan. That was when she felt an unpleasant touch on her hips.

"Heh, the 2nd rank of the Divine Ladies is here too?"

"...Doctor, I will cut your hands off."

"I guess you're still good for a 500-year-old!"

As Chunghuh and the lady began to talk, others from the Ten-Clan were busy talking amongst themselves. They then turned to a plump middle-aged man who was moving up to the Master.

[Look at the old raccoon from the Disciples Clan.]

"Are you the new Master of Gorgon?"

A plump man with a huge belly approached. Jaehwan answered, "Yes."

"You look very young. May I ask how old you are?"

[Ugh, he's at it again.]

[What's up with those 1000-year-olds, boasting about their age?]

[Quiet. The doctor is here too.]

[Oh, right.]

The whisper told Jaehwan that the man in front of him seemed very old.

"I'm 50 years old."

"50?" The man asked back, confused.

"Yeah."

"50? He's so young! Old man, who is that guy?"

The lady next to the doctor asked and Chunghuh shook his head, rubbing his hand on the lady's hip.

"You shouldn't think about him. Don't try to go near him. Just focus on me, baby."

"...I will cut your arm off for sure."

The plump man continued, "Are you the son of the former Master?"

"Huh?"

"Oh, I was just wondering if that might be the possibility..."

The men from the Ten-Clan seemed to be annoyed at the question.

[A son? Absurd!]

[That old raccoon is crossing the line. I know he's young, but...]

[The Disciples Clan know nothing but to study. That's why they are so rude like that.]

[It's still better than just flat-out cussing.]

Jaehwan then realized that the man in front of him was being rude. The previous Master was over 900 years older than Jaehwan. There was no way that Jaehwan was a son, and even if he was, it was a problem because there was no way for the family succession of a crown to be possible.

What the man was trying to say was this: 'A kid like you can't truly become a Master unless you are a son of the Master or something.'

Chunghuh cackled. "The old raccoon might have his ceremony today too if he's not careful."

"What do you mean, Doctor?"

"You'll see."

The plump man continued, "Anyway, nice to meet you. I'm the 2nd Rank of the Disciples Clan. Jang Irhan."

Disciples Clan? Jaehwan had heard about Disciples Clan by using his [Suspicion]. It seemed they like were a middle-ranked clan within the Ten-Clan of [Chaos].

"Jaehwan."

Jaehwan shook Irhan's hand. But something started moving as Jaehwan touched Irhan's hand. Irhan smiled as he found out about Jaehwan's Spirit Power once he touched Jaehwan's hand.

'So the rumor is true. He's a Non-Adapter.'

Irhan was nervous as he attended the ceremony. He had a purpose for visiting with an order from the Clan Leader himself.

-Do whatever it takes to get permission to build our office in Gorgon. It's absurd that we do not have even one office at any of the Four Fortresses.

The reason why there was no office for the Disciples Clan in Gorgon was because of Irhan. He had run into trouble while trying to bribe Northern Gate's guards and faced Karlton. He thought giving some more bribes would solve the issue, but Karlton just reported the matter straight to the Master of the Fortress.

-How can we allow clan that openly bribes our guards and run into trouble to have an office in our fortress?

The Master of Gorgon was as strict as Guard Captain Karlton. That's why the Disciples Clan had to wait 10 long years for a chance. This was the 2nd chance for Irhan. He did not use any bribery this time.

But when he returned, he was shocked. The former Master was dead, Karlton was in hospital, and some kid was sitting on the throne as the new Master.

'Gorgon is done for.'

Irhan thought. Even if he was here to get permission to get his office, he couldn't allow himself to beg in front of such a kid. Irhan held onto Jaehwan's hand and activated a skill.

Top ranking skill – [Eight Gates of Hell]

It was a skill that only the highest-ranking officers of the Disciples Clan could use. The skill that only could be used upon skin contact. It trapped the target in a terrible prison filled with monsters gathered from the [Great Lands] and would never be freed until the caster deactivated the skill.

Irhan quickly opened it up to the third gate. The third gate was the hell full of heat in which the Red Dragon Tiamat lived. The man in front of him would probably be fleeing for his life in burning hellfire, away from Tiamat.

'Taste hell!'

Chapter 51: Master of Gorgon (9)

Irhan knew what everyone became after being entrapped in Eight Gates of Hell. The entrapped would beg to be taken out of the hallucination and end up getting their minds destroyed. The best part about this skill was the secrecy. No one other than the user and the target would know that the skill had been used.

Yet, many people in [Chaos] had gathered here. There were some who knew the skill and were suspicious about Irhan using it.

[Is he using the Eight Gates of Hell?]

[That's too much for a 50-year-old kid!]

Some even sent direct whispers to Irhan.

[Irhan, stop! He is the Master of a Fortress!]

Irhan frowned. 'Old fools are irritating.'

Irhan had no intentions of stopping. If he was successful, the permission to build the office would be easy to get. There was no need to back off now. Irhan ignored the whispers and concentrated on Jaehwan's hand.

'It's about time for a reaction.'

Something was wrong. It was the [Eight Gates of Hell] from a 6th stage Adapter. Even the powerful warriors of the Ten-Clan would have reacted by now. But this Jaehwan did not show any change.

'Is he hiding something? So the 3rd gate is okay? How about this?!'

Irhan instantly opened up the 6th gate. That was the farthest he could open up the gates before reaching Frost Dragon Velkibus.

'This will be...!'

But Jaehwan suddenly spoke out loudly.

"What are you doing? Can you let go if you're done introducing yourself?"

"Huh? Uh, y-yes. I'm sorry."

Irhan became confused. Was the skill not activated? Was he okay even after facing the Frost Dragon? That was impossible.

'Did he withstand the skill?'

That was the only possible explanation. There was no way to get out of the hallucination created by the skill other than facing the fear itself.

'That's impossible.'

As Irhan let go of the hand, he felt dizzy. He saw his field of vision changing in front of him.

'W-what!'

Irhan clearly saw the world changing in front of him for a slight second. What was it just now? Even when he faced the Leader's [Eight Gates of Hell], it wasn't like this. Where did such a place exist?

It was a place that only could be described as hell itself. When Irhan came back to his senses, he was slumped down on the ground, shaking.

[What had happened?]

[Did the skill get deactivated?]

Jaehwan warned him. "You insulted the Master so you deserve a lashing, but I will let you go for now. There won't be a next time."

"Y-you..."

Chunghuh became frustrated.

'What? Is that it? That's boring!'

Chunghuh was looking forward to something exciting as he thought Jaehwan will stab away at the man for such a transgression. But nothing serious happened. It seemed he just showed his own world and called it a day. It didn't seem to make sense for Jaehwan to stop at such a small repercussion. Chunghuh knew Jaehwan better than anyone else here. He wasn't the type to show courtesy or kindness. But he was holding back.

'...What is he up to?'

Chunghuh became concerned. That was when Euren spoke.

"Next will be the new Master's speech."

Speech? Chunghuh became amused. The ceremony did have the purpose to welcome the new Master, but even then...

'He's doing a speech? That's interesting.'

Chunghuh could not imagine Jaehwan speaking in front of people. But part of him was worried about what Jaehwan would say.

"Hmph."

Everyone turned to the newly appointed Master.

"I'm Jaehwan. I'm the new Master now."

Some scoffed while some became frustrated. There was no one who would start a speech like that. But some of the men from a few clans looked especially interested. One of them was the 2nd rank of the Divine Lady Clan.

'He's very interesting. Is he trying to act strong?'

Even if he was a Master, the ceremony was filled with a lot of powerful warriors from [Chaos]. It was weird for a Master to start a speech with such arrogance.

"I don't know who Aimel Grosheck is. I don't know what kind of man he was, and I don't care."

It was a shocking speech. Even Euren who was standing next to him became pale.

"I know you don't like me here. You do not like the fact that someone as young as me is becoming a Master. You all probably think of me like this.

'How did that young fool with such Spirit Power become a Master?'

'He must have nothing but luck that got him there!'

"...And yes, I understand. You are right. I did not want to, but became a master due to luck."

Some became angered while some scoffed. Some cackled. The one who cackled was the lady from the Divine Lady Clan. She asked Chunghuh, "Doc, what is he anyway?"

Chunghuh did not answer so the lady turned to him. Chunghuh was just awestruck.

Jaehwan continued, "So, you don't want me as a Master, and I don't want to be a Master. So I thought, we should combine all those complaints together and create something new. So after about 10 minutes of thinking, I found the answer to that."

The people became uneasy. Jaehwan waited until the murmuring died out. "I am quitting as the Master today. Gorgon Fortress will appoint a new Master."

Some gasped while some slammed their tables and rose. But they all were thinking of the same thing.

'What is he talking about?'

'Did I hear him correctly?'

Chunghuh thought to himself.

'Dammit. It was a retirement speech!'

Then people began asking questions.

"Calm down. I'll listen to one at a time. You, with the lightning-like hair."

The Elder from the Thunder King Clan rose at those words with an angry face.

"Look, Master."

"Yeah."

"Are you out of your mind?"

"No."

"Do you know what you are talking about?"

"I know."

"You mean you will 'die' to give away the Master's rights?"

The Master of a Fortress could only be changed when the former Master died. Jaehwan nodded.

"You can say that."

"What..."

Chunghuh thought, 'So, he really does not want to become the Master.'

Others were curious and asked more questions. Jaehwan decided to answer the vital questions first.

"Let's say you will appoint the new Master. How are you going to choose them?"

"Only one who can beat me in a one-on-one duel will be given the chance to become a Master. Anyone who defeats me first will become the Master."

A one-on-one fight! People were shocked by the details. Jaehwan was serious about his offer. Then, someone laughed.

"HAHAHA! What a man he is! Aimel appointed a great man!"

Everyone seemed to cower at the huge Spirit Power radiating from the man. It was Cayman, the Leader of the Southern Sea Clan.

"Cayman was here too."

"Yeah, he was friends with the former Master."

Jaehwan spoke again.

"I will give you all one month. Anyone. If anyone can beat me in a one-on-one fight, I will have to make him the new Master of Gorgon."

"Is that it? Any other conditions?" Cayman asked in place of everyone else.

"Of course there is. I don't gain anything with this deal. I will add one condition."

"What is that?"

"All who challenge me and lose will have to follow my orders."

People became outraged at the words. These people were from the Ten-Clan, the most powerful group in [Chaos]. Even if it was the Master of the fortress, it was impossible to order the Ten-Clan. But what order was he trying to make? Cayman asked again.

"What will be the order?"

Jaehwan answered, "If I win, all the challengers will have to join my [Depth Expedition Team] that is set to depart within the next two months."

Chapter 52: Last hope (1)

A week after the speech to retire from being the Master, the word spread throughout [Chaos].

-Anyone who wishes to become a Master, challenge me! But if you lose, you will go to the [Depth]!

It fueled the fire in the minds of the people of [Chaos]. Anyone powerful enough was going to have a chance to become a Master of the fortress. It was very tempting. The rumor that the new Master was a [Non-Adapter] served to fuel the fire even more.

'No way! How can the Master be a Non-Adapter?'

'It's true! The elders and officers of the Ten-Clan confirmed it!'

The rumors spread quickly.

'How did a Non-Adapter become a master?'

'Is he from the Palace of Reincarnation?'

'No way. Lords or Renowned families are not allowed to interfere in [Chaos].'

There were some who were suspicious of Jaehwan's intentions.

'What is he up to?'

He had stated a condition for when he won. Any normal man would fear death, especially when he was only 50 years old. He must have a reason for

such a gamble, and that he must be certain of his victory. Some of the Ten-Clan thought this.

'Maybe he is trying to use the Guardian Horn.'

If the Guardian Horn was called upon, even the Leaders had no way to ensure victory. However, Jaehwan clearly said that it would be fair one-on-one fight, so it didn't seem that Jaehwan would use it. Besides, the Guardian Horn, which could only be used by the Master's right, was not made to fight against individuals.

Thus, people came to one conclusion.

'This new Master is mad!'

But as always, people loved mad things.

'We'll go to Gorgon anyway!'

People did not realize that it wasn't the condition after winning that they were excited about, but the condition after losing.

Euren thought as he walked to the gate of the inner keep.

'What is going on?'

Euren trusted, not Jaehwan, but the former Master's choice. Even if Jaehwan seemed like a mad man, he would not do something that would harm Gorgon's future...

"OPEN UP!"

"We have the right to fight with the Master!"

"The Master should keep his promise!"

Or so he thought.

'Dammit.'

Euren shook his head as he watched the crowds gathering in front of the keep gate.

'Master, what are you up to?'

The people in front of the inner keep numbered over four thousand. There were reports that the people were waiting to fight Jaehwan. Including the ones outside the fortress, there was about twenty thousand. All the inns in Gorgon were fully packed, and the citizens of Gorgon were having a great time because of the sudden wave of visitors.

"Cheap room! Half a unihorn for a night!"

Half a unihorn was about 30 thousand horuns. This amount was the average cost of a week's stay in most hotels. But inns were now receiving such a price for one night.

"That's pretty cheap. I'll stay for a week."

"Thank you!"

Yet the ones coming to fight had more money. They were the most powerful warriors among [Chaos] who could easily kill unihorns with just a few skills.

Euren became confused.

'I'm not sure if this is a good thing or not.'

The profit Gorgon was earning because of such visits was very high. Through the history of [Chaos], changing of Masters meant hardships within the fortress as it normally underwent a complete change in systems.

'Did he also expect this?'

He wasn't sure if Jaehwan intended to become a Master or not. However, no one could guess what he was thinking anyway. Just then, he saw some guards holding a booklet and laughing.

"What are you doing?"

The guards quickly straightened up in fear as the Chancellor yelled. It seemed that discipline had fallen to an all-time low as four out of the five military commanders had perished in the recent events.

'This must be fixed.'

Euren began reading the [Law] to punish the guards. He then snatched the booklet guards were reading and looked at it. It was a monthly magazine.

[Chaos of this Month]

Exclusive 1. Master of Gorgon, declaration to quit!

Exclusive 2. Master of Gorgon "I can kill the Clan Leaders of the Ten-Clan with one finger!" The Truth?

Interview: "I have fought with the Master!" - From a long time slasher

Euren shook as he read.

'Kill who? With what? When did he say that?'

The magazine, [Chaos of this Month] was the most sold magazine in [Chaos]. Even if the headline was a lie, he was sure that the Ten-Clan would be outraged. And it wasn't only that. Euren quickly flipped the pages to look into the details of the interview.

'When did the Master fight...'

Euren was controlling guests to stop any unneeded trouble, so he knew Jaehwan had not fought with anyone yet. As Euren turned the page, the hologram began to float up, showing a masked man talking with the host.

-How are you doing? I'm Maishark, and welcome to the special interview! We have a special guest today! He claims that he has fought with the 'Master of Gorgon,' the most talked about figure in recent events. Nothing about the Master has been revealed by Gorgon officials. We have rumors

that he is as powerful as the Ten-Clan Leaders or that he is a Non-Adapter.
As such, we have-"

-Hey, wait. If I do this, are you really going to introduce me to the Leader of the Divine Lady Clan?

-Uh... Can we talk about that later-

The video stopped for a second.

-Haha, sorry, it seems there were some technical difficulties. Please introduce yourself.

-I am the 'Long-time Slasher'.

Euren frowned.

'...It's the doctor.'

Why is he in such an interview?

-I see! That's interesting. So the Master of Gorgon can only use [Stab]?

-That's right.

-A fight between a slash and a stab! Amazing!

-It sure is.

-So, as our investigative team have found out, you lost that battle?

-I didn't lose!

'Long-time Slasher' began to make a ruckus and the interviewer asked,

-Is it not true?

-No way! We tied!

-But how...

-No, I can say I won. I was holding back a secret skill! If we fought more, I would have won!

The doctor then began talking about different subjects, boasting about himself, so the interviewer quickly changed subjects and asked the most important question.

-Then, how strong do you think the 'Master of Gorgon' is?

The doctor then answered with certainty, as if he were waiting to answer this.

-Well, no one can beat him. Not even with all of the Ten-Clan.

-D-do you mean you can handle the Ten-Clan too?!

-Huh? Uh... M-maybe, maybe not...

Euren was infuriated and began shaking.

'What the heck are you doing, Doctor?!'

Euren knew Jaehwan was strong, but to fight the entire Ten-Clan? This was not a matter of truth or lies anymore. Euren quickly ran to the Master's room at once.

Chapter 53: Last hope (2)

"Master!"

When he walked in, someone was working on the documents seated at the desk of the Master. Euren walked up, and when he approached, the person sitting on the Master's chair was not Jaehwan.

"...Why are you here?"

Golden hair with one silver wing at the back. It was a different man, but not the one who belonged on the seat. That was when Euren remembered Jaehwan's annoyed face looking through the documents.

-What are all these laws? How can I read all this? How about you do this?

-The only ones who can process the documents are the Master or the Secretary of Law.

Jaehwan brightened up.

-Who's the Secretary of Law? Bring him here.

-You killed him a few days ago.

-Ugh.

Jaehwan then asked,

-...Who knows most about the law in this fortress?

It was a hard question. Euren started to think, but Jaehwan seemed to have found his own answer.

-Wait, he can probably do it!

And Euren knew who was 'he' now.

"...Chancellor."

It was Karlton with linen bandages all over his head and body, working on the documents.

'I hope he's doing well.'

Jaehwan thought about Karlton who he left at the office. He wasn't going to make him the Secretary of Law from the beginning as Karlton was hospitalized a few days ago.

-Wow, Karlton, you are so handsome.

-So handsome for sure!

-My next work is [Tentacle Dead Man Karlton]!

If Jaehwan did not visit the hospital room that day, Karlton would probably still be in his hospital room, enjoying his time with beautiful sculptors working on sculptures. Jaehwan thought as he stabbed the [Dead Man Karlton] sculptures that he confiscated using his rights as the Master.

'It's about time I get the feeling.'

Jaehwan was concentrating on training to stab. In the corner were the powdery debris of the various Karlton sculptures. Chunghuh spoke as he looked at the debris.

"Kid, do you know how much those cost?"

"Who cares?"

"A Master who don't have any sense of money."

Chunghuh reached down and began picking up the unharmed sculptures and putting them into his pockets.

'Fools! Young girls are crazy over these Karlton collectibles!'

Jaehwan then turned to Chunghuh and spoke.

"Old man."

"What?"

"My new skill is finished."

"...Really?"

The reason why Jaehwan and Chunghuh were at the ceremony was to create a new skill. After he had faced Catastrophe, Jaehwan felt the need for a new skill. His [Strong Stab] was powerful but its range was too large that it wasn't good to be used against an individual target.

It was the fifth day that Jaehwan and Chunghuh traded their skills with each other.

"But is it okay not to spar today?"

"It's okay now."

"Huh? Why?"

Chunghuh seemed disappointed. It had been a good time for him, as his [Slash] had also become much stronger in just a few days of training with Jaehwan.

"I've seen enough of your slash."

"Oh, really? So you can slash like your stab?"

Chunghuh spoke sarcastically, but Jaehwan nodded.

"Yeah, a bit."

Chunghuh scoffed.

'You've stabbed all your life! Slash isn't that easy!'

Jaehwan spoke.

"I can't do that strong slash, but-"

"It's not strong slash! It's 'POWERFUL' slash!"

Jaehwan continued, ignoring Chunghuh.

"I can do [Slight Slash]."

"It's not slight, it's normal slash- what?"

"It's this, your slash."

Jaehwan stepped back and slashed his sword in the air. Powerful energy ripped the space in front.

"It's not strong as yours though."

Chunghuh could not speak. It was weaker than his slash for sure, but it was a really small difference. His slash was something he earned after countless years. But this man had acquired it in just five days.

"...How did you do it?"

Jaehwan did not answer, but Chunghuh could have guessed what it was. He had felt Jaehwan changed recently. He wasn't like sharp, pointy nails anymore, but a sharp blade. Maybe Jaehwan was practicing slash against the world even now.

"Anyway, I used this slash to create a new skill."

"New skill? What kind of slash is it?"

"It's a stab."

Chunghuh became confused.

"You learned slash, but made a stab?"

"Yeah, it's something like this."

Jaehwan moved his hand casually. It was a stab but had a slashing movement. It was just a gesture but Chunghuh could feel the powerful potential in it.

"Wait! Did you name it already?"

"No."

"You stole my slash to make it, so isn't it natural for me to name it?"

"To what?"

"How about, Chunghuh Stab?"

Jaehwan narrowed his eyes.

"Do you want to me stab you first instead?"

Chunghuh frowned. He too, was proud, just like Jaehwan. He knew Jaehwan was powerful but was still too proud of himself to cower at such a threat.

"You, young fool, are crossing the line! Okay, I'll teach you a lesson today and become the Master myself!"

However, Jaehwan was faster in pulling out his sword. The stab that had the movement of a slash. Chunghuh ran at the storm of blades created by Jaehwan.

"UGH! RESPECT YOUR ELDER FOR ONCE!"

The storm blew out, destroying the training ground. Chunghuh looked at the skill in shock.

'What kind of 'single target' skill is that!'

The warriors who were training in a corner were swept away and yelled in shock. The problem did not end there. His storm did not end and put a hole in the ceiling and flew up.

Then they heard someone screaming.

In the darkness of the inner keep, Adapters wearing clothes that had the words 'Thunder King' were trying to infiltrate the basement of the keep.

[Is the Master below?]

[Yes, sir.]

It was the men from the Thunder King Clan, the 9th ranked of the Ten-Clan. The one in the center was the Leader, Yong.

'Today, I will become the Master.'

Three days ago, Yong had arrived in Gorgon. The other clan leaders should have arrived as well, but it seemed none of them had fought against the Master of Gorgon.

'Cowards.'

His elder had told him that the Master was 'Non-Adapter' for sure. Yong quickly realized that it was a trap.

'Gorgon will do something cowardly for sure.'

The Chancellor was blocking entry to everyone who wished to fight the Master. That's why Yong came by himself.

'I will attack first before they plan something.'

The Master had stated that it just needed to be a one-on-one fight.

'I will make you regret that you didn't specify how you fight.'

The Thunder King Clan, along with the Dark Forest Clan, were clans that used assassination skills. And he was the Leader of such a clan. If he tried to assassinate him, the Master of the Fortress had no way to avoid it.

'One can call me a coward, but assassinations are my true power!'

And that was how he was swept away by the storm that erupted from the ground. It was so quick that he could not put up any of his defensive skills. All of the Thunder King Clan, including the leader Yong, were knocked unconscious as they were thrown out by the storm.

Right after that, when two figures appeared. Chunghuh pulled out Yong, who was stuck in the wall and said, "Isn't this the leader of Thunder King?"

Yong's legs were trembling. Jaehwan nodded.

"So, we have the first member of the Expedition team."

Chapter 54: Last Hope (3)

The Ten-Clan of [Chaos]

The Ten-Clan of [Chaos] consisted of the clans that controlled the vast land of [Chaos]. But they were not all of equal power or presence. There were ranks within the clans. This rank was decided by the fights between the Leaders or the war between each clan.

Thunder King Clan was the 9th ranked among them. But even if it was only the 9th rank where change often occurred, the Thunder King Clan quickly rose to power, even being introduced multiple times in [Chaos of this Month] magazine.

'100 years! It took us 100 years to get here!'

Yong was the youngest of the Clan Leaders of the Ten-Clan. He was 207 years old, a former member of Five Renowned families of the [Great Lands]. He was more of a slave than an actual member, but he was lucky. Most of his friends who cleared the tower had been taken into the battlefield to serve as meatshields, while he was taken in as a slave of a Renowned family when he was a Non-Adapter. He lived for 100 years as a slave.

However, when he finally earned the trust of the Youwun family after 100 years of work, he stole a skill from them. It was only a middle-grade skill in the family, but it was one of the highest grade skills in the entire [Great Lands].

Thunder God's Energy.

The skill allowed the user to wield Thunder energy, making all cells younger, and when the proficiency exceeded the 8th level, it allowed the user to wield the power of the Thunder God freely.

He had to flee from the Youwun family Adapters for the next 20 years for stealing and was eventually killed, but the skill allowed him to become the leader of the Ten-Clan. It was a record that had not been achieved by any throughout the history of [Chaos].

However, here he was, a man who had only lived half of 100 years. And he was the 'Master of Gorgon Fortress'.

How was this possible? Yong could not believe it.

"Tsk, tsk. How did you end up becoming first?"

"..."

"I knew you would get yourself into such trouble one day."

"...Why are you here, Doctor?"

"To heal the ones like you!"

It was thanks to Chunghuh that Yong was able to get up so quickly.

"Who is that man?" Yong asked Chunghuh as he watched Jaehwan stabbing in the middle of the training ground that had a hole in the ceiling.

"Master of Gorgon."

"A man with no name suddenly became the Master? It doesn't make sense."

"No, it doesn't." Chunghuh answered. "Everything about him doesn't make any sense."

Yong was surprised. The doctor never held anyone with such high regard until now. Yong felt his pride being hurt.

"I can beat him if I fight him again."

He didn't seem to accept it. "I'm the leader of Thunder King Clan. I let my guard down but..."

"You don't even stand a chance," Chunghuh scoffed.

Yong sat down and shouted.

"NO! I was ambushed! It's not fair!"

"Wasn't it you who tried to assassinate him?"

Chunghuh spoke but Yong furiously denied it.

"Assassinate?! No way!"

That's when Jaehwan spoke.

"Sure."

Yong brightened up instantly.

"You mean...?"

"I will fight you again."

Jaehwan pulled out his sword and Yong smiled.

'That attack was definitely from the Doctor.'

He had seen the doctor's slash once. A slash that was on par with the highest grade skills of the Clan Leaders. The storm that hit him was very similar. If he was able to bring out his true power and fight, he might have a chance.

"HYAAA!"

Chunghuh saw Yong flying in towards Jaehwan and shook his head.

'Foolish clan leaders.'

Next day, the rumor that the Leader of the Thunder King Clan lost, and that the Master of Gorgon 'barely' won spread through Gorgon.

"...I spread the rumor as you ordered."

Yong reported while nursing his bruised eyes. Chunghuh cackled.

"Good."

Luckily, Jaehwan's first opponent was the 9th ranked Clan Leader. The Leader of the 9th ranked clan was considered the least powerful of the group. It would have been bad if he fought the higher ranked leaders, as the other lower ranked ones would cower away after hearing that Jaehwan had defeated them. Chunghuh asked, "Did you make sure that the Master 'barely' won?"

"Of course."

The leader of the Thunder King Clan was a 6th stage Adapter. If that man was barely defeated, it would mean that the Master only had power equal to that of a 6th stage Adapter.

A 6th stage Adapter was powerful, but it wasn't enough to fight against the Leaders of the Ten-Clan.

The 7th ranked Divine Lady Clan Leader was a 7th stage Adapter, and the other leaders were 8th stage Adapters. Yong sighed.

'I will be taken to the [Depth] then.'

Yong didn't feel good about it. The rumor itself didn't mean much if other the Leaders defeated Jaehwan, as he would not have to join the [Depth Expedition Team], but the problem was that no one came to his mind.

'Maybe the Leader of the Sky Dragon Clan or the Arms Extreme Clan?'

The Sky Dragon Clan ranked first and the Arms Extreme Clan was the 2nd. Their leaders were at least two times ahead of Yong. But were they enough to defeat Jaehwan? He wasn't sure.

'No, that is not possible. The other Leaders will defeat him for sure.'

Yong knew some of the Leaders had already entered Gorgon Fortress. They were probably on their way by the time they heard the rumors.

'Doctor, even if he is that strong, he will not be able to fight against all of Ten-Clan.'

Yong glanced at Chunghuh and was shocked.

'...Huh?'

Chapter 55: Last Hope (4)

He had only lived for 207 years, but he knew about Chunghuh well. A member of the legendary [Depth Expedition Team]. The one who traveled to get the [Fruit] to bring salvation to [Chaos]. The one who faced despair and lost everything.

There was no one who knew despair better than Chunghuh.

However, what was with that expression? Chunghuh's expression as he watched Jaehwan practicing with his stab was far from despair. Chunghuh suddenly spoke.

"Kid, you are lucky. You met him before facing real despair."

Yong wanted to ask, what was it about that man that changed Chunghuh? That's when someone burst into the training ground.

"I'm here for a duel, Master of Gorgon!"

It was Kanghwang, the leader of the 8th ranked Fire King Clan, and Cayman, leader of the 5th ranked Southern Sea Clan.

"I was wondering when he would show up."

Chunghuh mumbled as he watched Kanghwang.

"I have a lot of healing to do today."

The fight only took ten minutes to end. Kanghwang filled the area with powerful flames and charged in, but fell after a few stabs. It was Cayman that had withstood the attacks for a long time. He had exchanged over 100 blows with Jaehwan.

"I give up. I yield."

Jaehwan did not use his new skill as it was not yet controllable. All Jaehwan used were slight stabs and a normal stab.

"It was a good fight."

Jaehwan was astonished at Cayman's power. Unlike the other two leaders who were at the 6th stage, Cayman was well into his 7th stage. He was not too far behind Chunghuh.

"You have not used your full power."

"That goes for you too, Master."

Cayman laughed.

"But I can see it without fighting to the end."

Cayman bowed and moved to the other leaders. Kanghwang was letting off breaths of fire as he was being treated by Chunghuh.

"You still have the temper, Kanghwang."

"...Thank you, doctor."

Kanghwang ranted.

"Damn Yong. Jaehwan 'barely' won?"

"Don't blame him. It's you who lost."

"Dammit."

Yong had been deep in thought for a while. When the treatment was finished, the three leaders grouped together to talk, away from Jaehwan and Chunghuh. It was Yong who spoke out first.

"Do you know who else is coming?"

"The Disciples and the Divine Lady."

It was Cayman who answered.

"The 6th ranked Disciples and the 7th ranked..."

The 5th ranked Cayman had already lost. There was no way that those two would have a chance to win.

"What about the Sky Dragon or 3rd ranked Dark Forest?"

"You know them better than me."

Cayman asked weirdly. The Sky Dragon Clan and the Dark Forest Clan had their headquarters in Manticore Fortress, same as the Thunder King Clan. But Yong looked upset at those words.

"What is it?"

"...It's nothing. Anyway, what are you two going to do now?"

They lost the fight so they had to join the expedition team, but who would want to do that? That was when an unexpected answer shocked them.

"I was going to join the team from the beginning."

It was Cayman.

"Cayman, are you for real?"

Kanghwan asked suspiciously.

"Of course."

"What..."

Kanghwan then realized what kind of man Cayman was. A friend of the former master Aimel, and the one who wasn't powerful enough to join the

expedition team a long time ago. Cayman was the one who saw the end of what happened to the Expedition Team.

"I was planning to go there anyway."

Cayman had lived 954 years. It was his biggest regret that he could not join the expedition team. Kanghwang was astonished.

'I guess some things don't change even after 900 years.'

"What about you, Kanghwang."

"Well, I lost. What choice do I have?"

Kanghwan shrugged and Cayman turned to Yong.

"What about you?"

"I've made up my mind."

"Made up your mind? What are you..."

Yong quickly bowed to the other two leaders and approached Jaehwan. Kanghwang became shocked.

'Wait, is he trying to fight him again?'

Even Cayman could not defeat the Master. Then, Yong did something unexpected.

"I, Yong of the Thunder King Clan, pledge allegiance to the master of Gorgon, Jaehwan, from this day forward."

Kanghwang's eyes opened wide in shock.

'W-What!'

Jaehwan answered.

"No, I don't need your allegiance."

"No, I will!"

He was now kneeling on his knees. Chunghuh frowned.

"What are you up to, kid?"

There was no way that a leader of the Ten-Clans would do such a thing.

"Nothing, doctor. I am just astonished by the power of the Master-"

"Cut the crap."

Yong looked hurt as if he would cry. But Chunghuh was stern.

"...Hmph."

Yong realized his acting didn't work. Jaehwan then spoke again.

"I just need teammates. I don't need servants or anything like that."

"It sounds like the same thing to me."

"How is that same?"

Chunghuh interrupted. Yong looked at Chunghuh and asked.

"...Doctor, have you not heard anything yet?"

Chunghuh became confused and shook his head. Yong sighed and turned to Jaehwan again.

"Anyway, Master. Please take me in as your member."

"Member? What do you mean?"

"I won't steal anything. Oh, and if you can, please take my boys too..."

Chunghuh then shouted.

"Aren't you the leader of Thunder King?! What about your clan?!"

"...Huh? Clan? Thunder King Clan?"

Yong seemed infuriated, but also empty at the answer. He then spoke.

"The Thunder King Clan no longer exists in [Chaos]."

"...What do you mean? Who are they, then?"

Chunghuh pointed at the members of the Thunder King Clan that came together with Yong. Yong sighed and answered,

"The Thunder King Clan was wiped out a week ago. The only ones who survived are me and those seven men."

Chapter 56: Last Hope (5)

They had snuck into a fortress for an assassination with a small number of people.

This wasn't a normal thing to do for Yong. Even if the Master was a Non-Adapter, Chunghuh was around. Yong could go up against him, but there was a reason for taking such desperate measures.

"...So, your clan is gone?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"Like I said, it's been a week."

Chunghuh thought for a second and continued, "Let me summarize."

"..."

"Your clan is gone and Gorgon Fortress announced a new Master. So, you jumped in no matter the outcome."

"...Something like that."

"And you couldn't even put up a fight."

"Right."

"Your clan is gone, and you are not a Master. You have nowhere to go, so you want Jaehwan to take you in?"

"Yes."

"..."

It was a plausible reason. If Yong was kicked out of the previous fortress because his clan was destroyed, it was safer to move to another fortress. But something about that story was fishy. Chunghuh quickly pointed it out with ease.

"Why are you making up such lies?"

"Huh?"

"You said the Thunder King Clan was wiped out last week?"

"...Yes."

"Yet there are no rumors about it?"

It was one of the Ten-Clan. [Chaos] had unstable spirit movements that interfered with message skills, but a week of no rumors about it was weird.

"One week is too long considering the distance between Manticore and Gorgon," Cayman added. Yong did not raise his head and continued, "You might not believe it, but it's true. The reason why the news didn't reach here is because..."

Yong could barely continue.

"The information is being blocked."

"Nonsense!" Chunghuh answered. It wasn't simple to block out information in [Chaos]. If the Thunder King Clan really was destroyed, thousands of messages would have been sent out. How could all those messages be blocked?

"It's impossible to block such information unless the fortress itself tries to do it. Unless they interfere with the skill system itself..."

However, Yong's expression was grim. He was angry and yet sad. Then, he looked up at Chunghuh.

"Doctor, scan my body."

"Huh? What? Why?"

"You'll know once you do it."

Chunghuh reluctantly began scanning Yong's body. It was a scan that was permitted by the target, so he was able to read Yong's Spirit Corruption level, Spirit Power, and all the details of his skills.

"Wow, kid, you have some good skills... wait, what is this?"

Chunghuh had a confused expression.

"...All long-distance message skills are blocked."

Yong could not use any long distance message skills as they were blocked. He was a member of Manticore Fortress. The only one who would have such power to block the usage of skills would be the Master of Manticore Fortress.

"Is everyone in Manticore like this?"

"Yes."

"Why? Did you do something wrong to the Master of Manticore?"

One of the Ten-Clan was in danger but the fortress blocked the message skill. The reason was simple. It was to isolate the clan from getting help. It was to wipe out the Thunder King Clan from Manticore completely. It seemed that Yong was lucky to have even escaped from Manticore in one piece. Chunghuh asked, "Manticore... Sky Dragon and Dark Forest. Which one is it?"

The only ones powerful enough to wipe out a group from the Ten-Clan was another group within Ten-Clan. Cayman added, "But that's weird. I thought

the Thunder King Clan had a good relationship with the Sky Dragon Clan and Dark Forest Clans."

"No, they are not involved."

Cayman then asked again, "Is it another clan?"

However, that had a even lower probability. No such clan could could crush the 9th ranked Thunder King Clan while forcing the 1st and 3rd ranked clans to stay put while even getting help from the Master of Manticore. The only clan who might even have a slight chance of such an act would be the Arms Extreme Clan, but they were from Gorgon Fortress. If they moved, Gorgon would have known.

Kanghwang lost his patience and shouted, "Talk! For Fire King's sake!"

"..."

"Who destroyed your clan? You should tell us so we can see if we should help! Didn't you come for revenge?"

"...You have no intention of helping."

"WHAT!?"

Yong shook his head and said, "Besides, the Fire King Clan alone is not enough."

The Fire King Clan was not enough? Cayman then tested Yong, "What if the Southern Sea Clan helps?"

"That's still not enough."

That was still not enough help, even with the 5th and 8th ranked clans. Who exactly was the enemy?

"That is the reason why I want to work under the Master of Gorgon. The enemy I'm facing can't be handled with the power of the Ten-Clan alone."

Chunghuh then asked, "Is that why you tried to become a Master? Gain the power of a Master and get revenge?"

"...I'm sorry."

Yong apologized from the bottom of his heart and Chunghuh nodded in acceptance. It was then that Jaehwan spoke out for the first time.

"Is it enough if Gorgon lends you a hand?"

"...I'm not sure, to be honest."

"Who are they?"

"Would you believe me if I told you?"

"It's not the time to ask if I believe it or not!" Kanghwang shouted, interrupting him. Yong hesitated for a second and spoke, "...It's the Golden Sky Clan."

"Are you joking with me?!"

Kanghwang shouted in fury, "You should be accountable for what you say!"

The Golden Sky Clan, the 10th ranked clan of the Ten-Clan was the root of the disaster? No one could agree.

"I heard their power is growing, but I can't agree that their power is greater than my clan and the Fire King Clan combined," Cayman stated in a cold voice.

Yong then corrected himself, "The Southern Sea and Fire King Clan... I have been mistaken. Let me rephrase it."

"Are you trying to change what you said?!"

Kanghwang was already drawing his sword. He thought that he was being insulted. Yong spoke again,

"Even if the Sky Dragon and Dark Forest Clan join, they can't defeat the Golden Sky Clan."

Chapter 57: Last Hope (6)

"YOU!"

Kanghwang tried to charge at Yong, but Cayman stepped in and stopped him.

"...What do you mean?"

"I mean exactly what I said."

"You sound as if the Sky Dragon and Dark Forest Clans have already fought with them."

"They did."

Kanghwang started trembling.

"What do you mean..."

"That's why I couldn't speak up easily. You wouldn't believe me. Don't you see? Why would I not have asked Golden Sky or Dark Forest for help?! Why do you think I'm all the way here in Gorgon?"

A tear slid down Yong's cheek. Kanghwang and Cayman were shocked. A 207-year-old man was crying. Kanghwang asked in a shaky voice, "Wait... Sky Dragon and Dark Forest were wiped out?"

That was impossible. He thought it was a lie. Three of the Ten-Clan were wiped out in a matter of days?

"...It's not only them."

Yong continued, "Golden Sky now has full control of Manticore Fortress."

Within Manticore Fortress, on the throne of the Master, was a boy with a Golden Drape. At his feet was the head of the former Master of Manticore.

"...I couldn't get the Guardian Horn, but oh well."

The endurance of the former Master was stronger than expected. Even when his Spirit Power was sucked dry, he did not give up his control over the Guardian Horn. The boy then stepped and crushed the head in annoyance. The blood became white and it all vanished into white powder.

The men kneeling in front of the boy shook in fear.

Jinong, the leader of the Golden Sky Clan.

The boy who appeared in [Chaos] 30 years ago and quickly rose to power. There was a rumor that he was of the legendary generation who cleared the [Master]'s tower, but no one knew for sure.

"Can I report now, sir?"

"Go on."

"I will start with the Sky Dragon and the Dark Forest..."

"Whatever."

Jinong opened up a hologram panel to show an image within the fortress. The live video of a fight was shown, monsters with tentacles and giant mouths were massacring the warriors of the Ten-Clan.

-ARGGH!

-HELP!

"Oh, I'm sorry, sir!"

The sound was so loud that the man quickly lowered the volume. At the corner of the panel, was a chart that showed the losses of each group. Jinong glanced at the chart and nodded satisfyingly.

"It will be done by today."

"Yes, sir."

"How are the Leaders?"

"We have cut off the arms and legs of the Sky Dragon Leader and placed him in a cell. The Dark Forest Clan Leader is still putting up a fight with his crew but..."

"Who's on them?"

"The Elders."

"Then, they will be done soon."

"Right, sir."

The men bowed their head, even when Jinong did not do anything.

"Oh, and did you capture the Thunder King Leader?"

"That... I'm sorry, sir."

"I see."

Jinong frowned. That was the only failure.

'I never thought those Leaders would work together so quickly.'

As Golden Sky infiltrated and invaded the Manticore Fortress, the Leaders of the clans quickly fought back. The power of the Dark Forest Clan Leader was especially great.

-You who dares to use the power of forbidden magic! [Chaos] will not leave your atrocity unchecked!

The Dark Forest Clan Leader managed to allow Yong, the quickest of the leaders, to escape the fortress. That was a week ago.

"I'm so sorry! P-please!"

"It's alright. Do you know where he ran off to?"

"I... I heard it's Gorgon, sir."

"Gorgon?"

That complicated things. Jinong knew the recent stories of Gorgon.

'He's forming a [Depth Expedition Team]?'

That was nonsense. He didn't think that a man who thought of such things would still exist in [Chaos].

'What should I say to the Lord of Darkness?'

It was a plan that got help from the Lord of Darkness himself.

Uniting [Chaos].

If his plan was successful, Gorgon should have been under his control by now. The force he sent to take control of Gorgon was 20% of all the Golden Sky Clan. It was nothing compared to the 50% of forces that were put into Manticore, but the amount of work previously done was much more.

'I didn't think the Prime Elder would lose.'

Maihan the Prime Elder was in charge of the Gorgon issue. Maihan put in some hardwork and effort, but he eventually failed because of one man.

'...His name is Jaehwan?'

He knew the story. A man who appeared out of nowhere and killed a thousand elite warriors from Golden Sky. It seemed he was either powerful as Chunghuh or stronger. There were reports that he had used only stabs to kill everyone, which was obviously a lie, but it still meant that the man was very powerful. Jinong watched the video sent by his men. It showed Jaehwan using stab to kill Janya who had become a Dead Man.

'I think he's familiar...'

That's when the Elder in charge of the inner keep came running in.

"L-Lord of Darkness sends a message, sir!"

"The Lord of Darkness? What is it?"

The Lord of Darkness, Jerome, was the best sponsor of the Golden Sky Clan. The Elder tried to open up the message window but Jinong waved his hand.

"Just summarize it."

"The content is the same, sir."

"Oh, you mean to look for the [Product]?"

"Yes, sir."

"Ugh, why do they want us to find the runaway [Product] that they lost? Tell them we'll try."

"Yes, sir."

The Elder bowed and left. Jinong dived into his thoughts. After some time, he spoke out.

"Don't you guys think it's absurd?"

"Yes, sir?"

"A [Product] killed a [Cultivator] in the tutorial game and destroyed the tower and came out into [Chaos]. Do you think it makes sense?"

"N-no, sir. H-ha. Haha."

"Right, they're out of their minds."

The men meekly answered. It was a Lord of the [Great Lands] that they were talking down upon. Even if their leader was powerful, the Lords were different beings.

"Anyway, where were we?"

"The leader of the Thunder King Clan has escaped to Gorgon Fortress."

"Oh, right. Let him be then."

"But..."

"Aren't all the Leaders gathering there too? It's fine."

Jinong remembered the last report that Maihan left. If by any chance that their plan failed, Maihan would activate his plan.

-I will eradicate Gorgon itself.

He did not hear from Maihan after that. But Jinong knew what he did. The terrible energy of a Dead Man radiating from Gorgon. Even in Manticore Fortress, a long distance away from Gorgon, Jinong clearly felt the power. It was a power that made Jinong shake in fear, even when he was ready to become a 9th stage Adapter.

Sole King Catastrophe.

The energy of the King disappeared quickly, however, Jinong knew it wasn't the Catastrophe itself that was terrifying.

Jinong smiled ominously.

"They will see why the Sole King is named 'Catastrophe' soon enough."

Chapter 58: Last Hope (7)

Within the training ground of the Gorgon Fortress, Jaehwan, two of clan leader and Chunghuh was stood in front of the leader of Thunder King Clan, listening to his stories.

"...So, that's how it came to be."

Silence fell after the story was finished. There had been no accounts of fortress being overtaken like this in past thousand years.

"I can't believe it."

"Golden Sky had grown that quickly? Big enough to take control of Manticore itself?"

Kanghwang and Cayman spoke. Jaehwan also spoke out.

"Who are these Golden Sky Clan?"

"They are 10th rank in Ten Clan of Chaos. Weakest one."

Kanghwang answered.

"But it's unbelievable that they took down a fortress. I can't believe what he's telling me."

"I think what he says is true."

Chunghuh interrupted and Kanghwang turned to Chunghuh, in shock.

"How do you know this?"

"Because they tried to take down Gorgon also."

That's when Kanghwang's face frowned.

"Wait, the commodity happened week ago... was it because of them?"

It wasn't a week past since the attack of Golden Sky's Prime Elder Maihan was quelled. If it wasn't Jaehwan to stop it, Gorgon would've had been under control of Golden Sky also. Cayman added.

"I guess what Yong says is true. I just have received message that our office in Manticore is not responding."

"But... how did the Golden Sky gain such strength?"

That's when Yong who had been staying quiet, spoke.

"I don't know who, but they are surely getting help from someone."

Being who can be of help to Ten Clan was very limited. Yong continued.

"I am suspecting it's one of the Lords."

"Impossible! Lords cannot interfere in Chaos!"

"But I can't see any other possibility. Who can be of a help to Ten Clan if it isn't a Lord?"

Silence fell down. Cayman then added.

"I guess it's possible. Great Lands are under full scale war. There's possibility that one of Lords will try to make this chance to interfere into Chaos."

"Shouldn't we contact the [Palace of Reincarnation]?"

"You really want to get help from them?"

[Palace of Reincarnation]. The place where Lords and members of Renowned Family are reborn, and where all [Fruits] of Chaos is stored. As it was under direct control of Lords and Renowned Families, the ones that stayed there were one of them.

"If it is a Lord that's interfering, they are responsible for breaking their pact!"

900 years ago, members of Lords and Renowned Families made a pact to Chaos as they took the [Fruits] from the Depth Expedition Team that they will not interfere with the matters of Chaos from that day forward. It was known as the 295th Great Lords Agreement.

"They did break it but..."

"We must confront them of it!"

"We have no proof. Besides..."

Cayman gritted his teeth.

"I don't like asking help to them."

Kanghwang shook his head. But he understood that Cayman would rather die then get help from those in the palace.

"And what if the palace is siding with the said Lord?"

"That's..."

Kanghwang seemed he had not thought of such chance. Chunghuh turned to Jaehwan.

"I guess it's got more complicated. What do you want to do?"

"What about it?"

"Manticore is down and 3 clans are wiped out. If you continue your plans..."

"There will be a war."

Chunghuh fell silent. The last war that happened in Chaos was 900 years ago, when Depth Expedition Team fought against the Palace of Reincarnation, resulting in death of countless spirits.

"Doesn't matter. It's better that way."

"What?"

"I have to fight them soon or later."

Clan leaders then was shocked and asked.

"You mean..."

"You will go after Manticore?"

Jaehwan did not answer. He wasn't going to stop at just Manticore. Chunghuh realized what Jaehwan was really after.

"...Are you really trying to unite Chaos into one?"

"Yeah."

Cayman then bursted out of laughter.

"Hahaha! Are you serious? Are you really trying to unite Chaos?"

"I'm serious."

Cayman stopped dead in his laughter and Chunghuh's face turned grim. He had heard from Euren about it, but didn't really think Jaehwan was serious.

-Jaehwan is trying to unite Chaos and kill all enemies so he can stop being a Master of Gorgon. If fortress is not needed, then he don't have to be a master.

Uniting Chaos didn't just mean taking control of four fortresses and Ten Clans. There was stronger enemy than combined forces of fortress and clans.

[Palace of Reincarnation]

Chunghuh knew of their power all too well.

"You can't do it. Not in your current power."

"You never know until you try."

Chunghuh could not understand. He knew Jaehwan was powerful and that he was an Awakener. But-

"Kid, war is not that easy."

Chunghuh spoke in quiet voice.

"Even if you are powerful, there are things that you can't do it alone."

"Doesn't matter."

"What?"

"That's why I have you."

Chunghuh opened his eyes in shock.

"Like you think, I have no experience. But I have you."

"Wh-what! I never said I'll side with you!"

Chunghuh shouted but he was bit happy that Jaehwan had acknowledged about him. He became ashamed that he was happy for that and turned away. Jaehwan then turned to clan leaders.

"Let me ask you all too."

Leaders took a step back.

"I'm not just trying to gather the expedition team. I will unite Chaos first and destroy the palace that took [Fruits] from you 900 years ago. It's after that we will depart for the Depth. I need people who can join me in that quest."

Someone swallowed an empty throat.

"If you don't want, you can leave. Forget everything that happened here and live. Go back to your normal lives."

Leaders became silent. It was Cayman who spoke first.

"What are you going to do if none of us helps you?"

"Then I will do it alone."

"Didn't you say you can't do it alone?"

"Since when I said that?"

Jaehwan answered.

"I came all the way here alone."

Cayman then laughed and spoke.

"Good. I will follow you to wherever you go. To the Palace or to the Depth."

"C-Cayman!"

Kanghwan became shocked and shouted.

"I, Cayman, am here to let down my role as the leader of the clan. I am ready."

"So am I."

Yong also answered.

"Yong, at your service, my master."

"I don't need that."

Then everyone turned to Kanghwang.

"I... uh... have not decided yet."

Kanghwang's answer was just. He did not know anything about Jaehwan yet.

"Honestly, I'm not sure if the Master is really worthy to be the leader of Depth Expedition Team."

Kanghwang spoke.

"Enemies you spoke of is all too powerful. It might get us all killed."

Jaehwan nodded.

"What will prove my worth to you?"

"As you know, there are total of 6 clan leaders in Gorgon now."

Chunghuh asked.

"Six? Who else are there other than you three?"

"The leader of Arms Extreme who resides within this fortress, the leader of Disciples Clan, and the leader of Divine Lady Clan."

"Hah, greedy fools trying to become a Master of fortress."

Chunghuh frowned but continued.

"Get the approval of other three, and I will accept you."

"Kanghwang, I see what you're doing there."

"...It's needed. Doctor, you must know that if he wants to go to the Depth, this should be an easy task."

Jaehwan nodded.

"Good. I will do it."

Kanghwang seemed surprised but Jaehwan continued.

"But I have a condition."

"Huh?""

"If I am to get the approval of you, you all need approval of me."

"What are you talking about?"

Kanghwang didn't seem happy with the words. They were leaders of Ten Clan. What kind of approval would they need?

"I don't care if you are the leader of a clan or not. What I need is a true warrior."

Before Kanghwang can speak, Jaehwan continued.

"I will open a tournament."

Everyone became shocked.

"It's a tournament to become a Master of Gorgon. I will put this as a prize too."

Jaehwan then took out a dark horn from his backpack. It was the last remaining horn of Garnak. Cayman gasped and shouted.

"Horn of rare horned monster!"

Jaehwan continued.

"Become the remaining 8 within the tournament. That will earn my approval. I will receive your test afterwards."

Kanghwang became blushed with fury. How dare he test the leaders of Ten Clan? But Cayman seemed intrigued.

"What you say is true. Being a clan leader doesn't make us the strongest in Chaos. When will this tournament start?"

"Cayman!"

"Kanghwang, shouldn't we prove ourselves before we test others?"

Kanghwang fell silent and everyone turned to Jaehwan.

"When will it start? Well..."

That's when someone came running into the training ground. It was the one that everyone knew well.

"Master!"

It was Chancellor Euren.

Euren ran in with infuriated look on his face, with a flyer on his hand.

"What is this! Since when did you make this!!"

-Everyone who wants to become a Master of Gorgon, COME!

The 1st Gorgon Tournament

Preliminary starting 18:00 today

It was the beginning of the Gorgon Tournament.

South of Chaos.

There were no continent in south of Chaos. It was the green sea where part of surface is covered with plants. Adapters called this plants 'Sea Way.' Adapters used these plants to travel through the sea or hunt down marine horned animals. As they traveled deeper into the sea, the plants grew in size and thickness, eventually arriving to a famous fortress.

Dryad Fortress.

Its entire structure was created by plants that grown upon absorbing sea water and spirit power from the depth of the sea. Plant Horned Monster Dryad. It was one of the four guardian horns, along with Gorgon, Manticore and Garuda.

As Dryad flexed its body, huge branches soared through the skies and the seven horns stuck on Dryad's body resonated rough sonars out to the sea. As Dryad roared, giant horned monsters of the sea fled in terror. On top of the branch was a woman. She was the master of Dryad Fortress.

"Dryad... something bad is happening."

Dryad wiggled on its branch as she spoke. She was dressed in Blue Chinese Dress with pinned up hair, exposing her white skin upon her neck. She looked to the horizon, towards the far north where Gorgon Fortress was located at.

Unique Skill [Far-Sight]

It allowed user to observe enemies at thousands of miles away. With her skill, she saw terrible things moving towards Gorgon.

"No...!"

She knew what these monsterss were.

"It's Giant Dead Man..."

The Sole King Catastrophe had its followers. Widely known as Giant Dead Man, the once strongest of Chaos that became Dead Man. These were monsters that even combined forces of leaders of Ten Clan cannot defeat it.

'Upright Magrit!'

Master of Dryad knew the name of this Dead Man. Magrit, was one of Master of Fortresses once. It had face on its legs that gave its name. The Dead Man was leading other dead man into direction of Gorgon.

-No peeking, girl.

Then the skill [Far-Sight] was cut out immediately, damaging the master of Dryad a bit. The spirit power of Magrit had reached thousands of miles to this place.

'I must let the master of Gorgon know!'

Cayman and the leader of Divine Lady, whom resided in Dryad had already left to Gorgon. There was no time to waste. The master of Dryad, Aisa Lindcroft used fastest messaging skill she had to send the message.

Chapter 59: Last Hope (8)

Inner Gorgon Fortress, meeting room. Three newly appointed department heads were sitting in front of Chancellor Euren.

"Don't worry, the Master knows what he's doing!"

Jahir, the newly appointed head of the Department of Security, seemed especially excited.

"...And what would that be? Are you talking about opening up a tournament without a proper meeting with the head of departments?"

"Hmph."

"Jahir, this is serious. All warriors of [Chaos] are gathering here."

"I know that..."

Gorgon Fortress was overcrowded with visitors, from tournament attendees to just plain spectators. Teleportation stations were having a hard time and all of the four gates were packed with people trying to get into the fortress.

"Karlton, any word?"

"Yes?"

"About the situation."

Euren sighed at Karlton. The opening of the tournament, even if it was started without a proper meeting, was not illegal at all. If half of the officers in Gorgon agreed, the Master had the authority to proceed with projects that

would cost more than 300 million horuns. And surprisingly, Jaehwan had earned more than half of the approvals.

How?

It was simple. When Jaehwan became the Master, out of the five officers, four had died and one had been injured. Jaehwan then appointed three members to become the new head of Security, Law, and Finance departments. They were all people that Jaehwan knew, so it was apparent that he could get any approval he needed.

Karlton asked, "I guess the Chancellor doesn't approve of his ideas?"

"It's not about that." Euren frowned, "It's not about if I like it or not, but the principles."

"Enough with your principles."

Someone interrupted. It was the new head of the Department of Finance.

"When will you quit talking about that nonsense?"

Euren's expression turned cold.

"Everything runs on principles. I guess you wouldn't know because of your background."

Euren did not like the new head of the Finance Department. He was only okay with Karlton being the head of the Law Department and Jahir the leader of Anti-Evil taking on the head of the Security Department.

'But this is too far.'

Gorgon was under an emergency, but a 2nd stage Adapter who managed a saloon was not fit for such a job. Euren could not forget when Jaehwan first brought Claire into the fortress to appoint her as the new head of the Finance Department.

-To me, a saloon or Gorgon Fortress are all same. It's just a matter of size.

After Claire took the position, she quickly kicked out the corrupt officials and changed all the policies in Gorgon to fit the standard of the common citizens.

The result was outrage. Even now, there were a lot of high ranked Adapters complaining about the new policies being piled up at the Master's office.

"Don't think of me lightly, Chancellor," Claire said to Euren. "It seems that you don't like how Master is running things. Do you know what values he's bringing in?"

"Of course, I..."

Euren knew this, of course. There was money where people gathered. Gorgon was overcrowded with people and it surely brought good money to Gorgon itself.

"I'll give you an example. The tournament that you so hate, do you know where that is being held?"

"I am not sure." Euren replied honestly.

Claire then answered, "It's in the northern streets, in the outer fortress."

The northern streets of the outer fortress. It was where the destruction with Golden Sky Clan had occurred, leaving hundreds of citizens homeless.

"Wait, there?"

Claire nodded. "All those homeless citizens are now working as staff for the tournament."

Euren was surprised. He knew the tournament was being held, but never imagined it was being put to use in such a way.

"You must know how much we lost because of the Golden Sky attack."

"I believe it's about thirteen billion Horuns..."

"Yes. To be precise, it's twelve billion, eight hundred, and seventy-eight million horuns."

Euren looked at Claire in shock. Since when did she look into such things? But she wasn't finished.

"Then, let me ask you this. Do you know how much we have earned during these two days that the tournament has been running?"

"I... believe we are still counting that."

"A total of thirteen billion, two hundred, and eighty million horuns. That's the net profit for the past two days, and it will only keep growing."

Euren was dumbfounded. If that was true, Gorgon had already come out on top of its loss.

'But how did she know all those numbers?'

Claire scoffed at Euren's expression.

"You look surprised? I've managed a saloon for all of my life, AND my afterlife. Counting money is like breathing to me."

Claire took out a cigarette and lit it.

"I am not sure what the Master is up to, but one thing is for sure."

Claire glanced at Jahir and Karlton, then turned to Euren.

"[Chaos] WILL change."

Euren felt something in him was shake. Claire had something stirring within her eyes. An emotion that all who lived in [Chaos] had lost. Karlton and Jahir also had the same emotion in their eyes too. Euren knew the name of this emotion.

'Master... what are you trying to give to these people?'

It was something that had not happened over hundreds of years. Euren became worried. No, he was wary of the one individual that was bringing about all these changes. Yet Euren did not know that he too, was changing.

After three days of harsh schedules, the tournament was now down to 16 people. People who came late to Gorgon Fortress were able to participate in the additional matches to join in as wildcards.

"Last 16 in three days? It's too fast."

Mukeuk, the leader of Arms Extreme, was amused. His elite clan members stood behind him. Most were either 4th or 5th stage Adapters, powerful enough to wipe out weaker clans. Mukeuk, who only looked to be in his mid-40s or 50s, was actually over a thousand years old.

What's more was that he was like Chunghuh and the Lord of Steel, Huhyou from Moorim. He was also one of the five top swordsmen in Moorim. Someone then came out from the crowd and replied to Mukeuk.

"Kanghwang overdid it."

Mukeuk turned to the voice.

"He ran on a rampage with fire in the preliminary and scared all the 4th stages and lower into giving up."

"...It's you."

Mukeuk nodded. "Long time no see, Chunghuh."

"Yeah. Been a while, Mukeuk."

Chunghuh smiled by showing his teeth. Then, the two instantly released a powerful wave of energy, scaring nearby Adapters. This was the way power could be tested between two Awakeners. Chunghuh spoke in astonishment.

"You seemed to have moved onto a new level."

"And so have you."

Both smiled as the people around began to mumble among themselves.

'It's Mukeuk!'

'It's the Doctor of Despair!'

Some people seemed to even consider it an honor to see two powerful figures in [Chaos] talking to each other.

Chunghuh mentioned, "Anyway, I was surprised that you didn't decide to join this tournament."

"I like genuine competition, not this dog fight."

"Haha, Kanghwang should've heard that."

On the stage, Kanghwang was fighting against a young woman. It was the last fight of the 16. Kanghwang's fires had been thrown onto various parts of the stage, but the woman was dodging all those fires with ease using a fast movement skill. Chunghuh commented on the woman's skills.

"She's good for her age. Do you know who she is?"

"She's not from Divine Lady... but that movement skill is familiar."

"You sure got old! That's Green Wind Walk."

"Green Wind Walk?"

An old name in his memory struck Mukeuk hard. He quickly asked, "Is it the Steel's skill?"

"Yeah."

Mukeuk turned grim. By the name of 'Steel,' it meant one person. The one who cleared the tower and moved onto the [Great Lands]. The one who was once their friend, Huhyou, the Lord of Steel.

"Why is Huhyou's underling here?"

"I wouldn't know. But there are Lords who are interested in this tournament."

And the fight was over. The woman won. Kanghwang's shocking loss had created a huge sensation with the spectators.

"KANGHWANG LOST!"

Mukeuk frowned. "Fool, he was too proud."

"That's the result of laziness."

Following the match, an announcement was made that the round of 16 was over, and the round of 8 would begin right after. Jahir quickly came running out and took the microphone to announce.

-Hello everyone, we will now start the round of 8!

Mukeuk, who was ready to look around as he thought there would be an intermission, frowned at the quick pace of the matches.

"Isn't this too quick?"

"The Master of Gorgon is quick-tempered."

"I heard, but still..."

He couldn't continue as he recognized the man stepping up onto the stage.

"Leader of Disciples."

It was Jagel Meng, the leader of Disciples. He glanced at the spectators and found Mukeuk and Chunghuh. He smirked arrogantly.

"That arrogant fool and his smirk, I should teach him a lesson."

"Give him some slack. He's only 400 years old."

Meng looked around the spectators for beautiful women while his opponent stepped in. Spectators began to shout with excitement as the person who stepped up was the most-talked-about man in recent days.

"It's the new Master."

"Yeah."

"I didn't know the Master was going to join in."

Mukeuk muttered as he watched Jaehwan flexing on the stage.

"That's strange. I sense something similar in him to you, Chunghuh."

He glanced between Jaehwan and Chunghuh as he asked, "Is he your apprentice?"

"Apprentice?"

Chunghuh laughed. Then suddenly, a loud explosion came from the stage as someone was thrown into the sky. It was Meng, flying into the sky like a leaf caught up in a storm.

"AAAAAARRGH!"

As he looked upon that sight, he answered. "...There's no way that monster would be my apprentice."

Chapter 60: Last Hope (9)

Jagel Meng had been a genius since young and had been called the best tactician in [Chaos]. He always considered himself to be the brightest genius among anyone in [Chaos]. But his pride had now dwindled.

"I know of your plan."

"..."

"It's impossible. You don't even stand a chance against the Generals of those Lords."

Meng joined the annoying tournament only to give such advice.

"Do you think you are the first in [Chaos] to say such a thing? There was one like you 200 years ago, 300 years ago. Do you know what happened to all of them?"

Meng paused for a second and continued, "They're all dead."

[Chaos] had been around for countless years. Many people tried to revolutionize the place. There were heroes who wanted the greater good for the people.

All of them never returned from the [Depth].

Meng had withstood 400 years in [Chaos]. Because of that, he was entitled to say this.

"You think we're fools for leaving this world as it is?"

Meng knew why the world couldn't change. The people here were too deep into their despair. They were afraid of having hope. They were afraid of experiencing greater despair that might be waiting beyond any hope. That's why they gave up on hope. That's how they found a way to survive.

And now, there was new hope that was luring people in. It was Meng's job to quell this threat before their hope would grow into more despair.

"[Chaos] cannot change anymore."

Meng activated his reading skill [Seven Golden Line]. It was a top-grade unique skill that enabled Meng to read all the statuses of a target. Meng's 'Eye of Sky' shone red.

[System Error. Cannot read user data.]

[System Error. Cannot read user data.]

Meng frowned. 'W-what?'

And then Jaehwan spoke for the first time.

"Are you done? If you talk again, I'll kill you."

Jaehwan made a move with his sword. It had been a long time since Meng had gotten beat up. It was too late when his sight was fading. He felt pain had struck his stomach and he couldn't think. The pure pain made him astonished.

'M-maybe he might have a chance against some Generals...'

And then he realized he was shooting up into the sky.

All the spectators turned pale. They couldn't believe what they were seeing. The sheer power they were witnessing was unprecedented.

-I-it is amazing strength! The Master has defeated Jagel Meng in just one move!

The spectators realized that they were not mistaken about what they had seen. Meng fell onto the ground as people burst into cheers.

"WOW!"

"Master of Gorgon!"

What Jaehwan used was his new skill [Twisting Kill]. They were debating on the name Twisting Stab or Twisting Slash when Cayman interrupted with the new name.

-Stab or slash, they are both made to kill, so just name it Twisting Kill!

Jaehwan turned to Meng as he remembered Cayman.

'They are both the same 7th stage... but too different. Is it because he's a tactician?'

He heard Meng also a 7th stage like Cayman, but Meng was similar to Yong or Kanghwang, maybe just a bit stronger.

Chunghuh told him there were people stronger than him in the [Palace of Reincarnation]. If they traveled into the [Depth], the situation would only get worse. If the most powerful in [Chaos] was this weak, it might be better if he went alone.

When Jaehwan was about to get off the stage, Meng slowly rose up.

"...W-wait! Not yet!"

Jaehwan turned to Meng and shook his head.

"You lost."

Meng could not accept the loss. It wasn't like his usual self, but he couldn't bear to accept the loss. He knew that if he accepted this loss, he would be accepting that his 400 years of life had been nothing.

"Do you think you have won?"

Jaehwan did not answer. There was no need to. But Meng said something unexpected.

"You should keep your promise."

Promise? Jaehwan narrowed his eyes.

"...What do you mean?"

"You said that if anyone beats you within a month, you will appoint that person to be the new Master."

"I did."

Meng nodded. "Yes, you said one-on-one fight, but you did not specify in what way."

That was true. Jaehwan did not go into such details as it wasn't needed.

"So?"

"I am not here to fight you with strength. I'm here to fight you in a battle of wits. You should allow me to challenge you in my way."

It was logical, but it didn't make Meng any less of a loser. The crowds began to boo Meng.

"LOSER! GET OFF!"

"ADMIT IT!"

Chunghuh also frowned at the sight.

"I knew it."

"Meng's just being himself."

Mukeuk nodded.

"But... this might be hard to win."

Chunghuh spoke. He knew what Meng did when competing with tactics.

"He'll want to play that 'game'."

"Game?"

"You know, the one he's good at"

Chunghuh gritted his teeth. He knew which game it was.

"The one that all tacticians like to play."

"Oh... you mean that?"

Mukeuk seemed to realize what it was.

"But it will be fun."

The crowd got excited as Jaehwan accepted the challenge. Then, the stage began to change with a high-skilled illusion. Things began appearing on the surface of the stage and soon everyone could see various small landscapes such as rivers, mountains, foggy areas and such. It was like the smaller version of a giant land. When it was done, a message popped up from above.

[Welcome to the World of Battle Formations!]

And there was a message that only popped up in front of Jaehwan.

[Welcome! You are a beginner! Check the manual above and learn about the rules and how to play!]

Jaehwan pressed on the manual button. He was a bit confused. Did a battle of wits mean a battle of war tactics? Jaehwan wondered if he should just cancel the whole thing and beat up Meng. Realizing what Jaehwan was thinking, Meng hastily spoke up.

"I-it's just a kind of game! It was created by the [Master Nightmare] 'Mars.' He created this after being motivated by playing a famous game in some world. Even famous tacticians in the [Great Lands] play this..."

'...And I'm the best at this game.'

Meng did not say the last part out loud.

"But it's not hard at all. It's just to test your wits and knowledge. All you have to do is to create your army, control them, place them in the right places, and fight."

Jaehwan scanned through the manual and answered, "It's more simple than I thought."

Meng frowned.

'Let's see how far your arrogance goes.'

To Meng, he had already won. It seemed that Jaehwan was unsuspecting of it.

'This one is mine, Master. I have never lost in this game.'

However, there was one thing Meng did not know.

'A [Nightmare] got motivated to make this game after playing a game in another world?'

Jaehwan smirked. He seemed to know where this 'world' was located. He had never played this game, which was true. But in some sense, it wasn't true. He had played a similar game thousands of times. Back in his world, all people in his age range, played this game many, many times.

'What are these [Nightmares]? This is almost a copy.'

The game that the famous [Master Nightmare] 'Mars' created to motivate tacticians of the [Great Lands] had three races that fought against each other

as the main scenario, with gathering resources in real-time to create armies and destroy enemy structures to win the game.

Jaehwan knew the exact same game from his world. Everyone in his homeworld knew how to play it.

"Do you accept the current land?"

"Whatever."

Jaehwan glanced at the name of the land.

[Jagel Meng has chosen 'Lost Garden' as the battlefield].

Chapter 61: Last Hope (10)

Everyone was shocked at the results.

[YOU LOST!]

Jagel Meng was dumbfounded at the unexpected turn of events. He couldn't understand what he was seeing. The game consisted of three races: Humans, Dead Mans, and Horned Monsters to fight against each other with different strategies. Meng chose the Dead Man race as soon as he started. It grew powerful as time went on and was also very strong mid-game. Jaehwan chose the Human race. It was considered to be the weakest of all three races.

Meng thought Jaehwan picked it because he was a beginner. However, he didn't know Jaehwan chose it for a reason.

'This game really is...'

If Jaehwan did not read the manual, or use his [Suspicion] to get to the system of the game, the fight would not have even started as Jaehwan was annoyed. Also, he didn't need to compete in such a foolish game. But as soon as he realized the original game that inspired this copied version, he wanted to play. Through playing this game, he felt like he was taken back to the time when he was back home. Back to the time when he lived a normal life.

'Maybe there's a [Nightmare] who knows Earth.'

The game only differed in the name of races and small story details, while the remainder of the game was the same as the original on Earth which was called 'Starcraft'. Jaehwan had to reconsider those [Nightmares] who blatantly copied the game from his homeworld.

While Meng was busy gathering resources to create a huge army to attack with later on, Jaehwan quickly rushed in as soon as he got his basic attack units ready, along with his resource gatherers to end the game. It seemed that the people in this world who played this game were not used to such rush tactics, leaving an unprepared Meng unable to fight back.

As the game quickly ended with Jaehwan's victory, the crowd roared. Meng became infuriated.

"This is not fair! You must wait for 10 minutes before attacking! That's the rule!"

"Rule?"

"W-we wait 10 minutes to give time to collect resources and...!"

"Is there a rule that requires you to wait?"

Meng couldn't answer. There was no such rule.

"I thought so."

Meng couldn't believe it, but he had to accept the loss. This man was out of his imagination in every way.

"I lost."

As the first game of the round of 8 finished, there was an intermission. Chunghuh and Mukeuk walked over to Jaehwan.

"You're not even sweating!"

"Why would I sweat over a simple game?"

"Since when did you learn to play the game? I thought you only knew how to stab."

"I know that game from my homeworld."

Jaehwan then turned to Mukeuk.

"You, old man. You look strong."

Chunghuh cackled at the way Jaehwan spoke to Mukeuk, one of the most powerful ones in [Chaos].

"Who do you think is stronger?"

"Can't say."

Chunghuh was the strongest other than the Catastrophe that Jaehwan had met until now. But this old man also seemed just as strong.

"Should we fight?"

"That's a violent introduction," Mukeuk answered unpleasantly and Chunghuh cackled again.

"Hehe. I told you, he's not the type to respect the elderly."

Chunghuh was mocking Jaehwan, but in more a friendly way, which Mukeuk could feel. He had never seen Chunghuh this lively after the [Depth Expedition Team] had disbanded.

[Depth Expedition Team].

The word also had great meaning to Mukeuk. He was also a former member of the team.

'He reminds me of that [Nightmare].'

The [Nightmare], Mulack, the captain of the former [Depth Expedition Team].

'Can he be the next Mulack?'

It was due to Mulack that the team had managed to get their hands on the [Fruits], even if they had to give them up to the Lords. As Mukeuk watched

Jaehwan's fight, he was able to measure how strong Jaehwan was.

'As Meng said... he might be as strong as the Generals... Lesser General to be precise.'

Commanders, High Generals, and Lesser Generals. Those worked directly under the twelve Lords of the [Great Lands]. But the High Generals and above were as powerful as most Lords already. Even the Lesser Generals were powerful enough to destroy the fortress alone. And this man was as powerful as one of them.

'He has the intelligence too... but what about his character?'

Mukeuk couldn't feel any righteousness about him. The way he talked, how he treated people and everything else was the opposite of the generous and merciful Mulack.

'And this hate.'

The hate that could be felt from within this man was enough to chill Mukeuk without doing anything. Mukeuk then felt the space around Jaehwan distorting weirdly and quickly sent a whisper to Chunghuh, who surely knew the reason why.

[Is he an Awakener?]

[You only found that out now?]

Mukeuk gasped.

[...I can't believe there was another Awakener in [Chaos] other than you.]

[To be frank, I don't even come close.]

Mukeuk was shocked. He had never seen the proud Chunghuh speak like that of someone else.

[He is a true Awakener, unlike me.]

[You mean he overcame the third awakening?]

[Yeah.]

Mukeuk couldn't believe it. It wasn't because of Jaehwan's great achievement. Awakeners who had overcome the third awakening would be missing a vital part. It was the reason why Chunghuh stayed in the 2nd awakening.

[But then... he should have lost his humanity...]

Just then, the announcement sounded again, informing people of the second fight. Jaehwan then moved onto the stage and Chunghuh asked, "Where are you going? It's not your turn yet."

"I'm going to fight."

"Fight?"

"It just came to my mind that it's a waste of time to wait for all the fights to end. These remaining guys will take half a day to finish."

Other than Jaehwan, all of the remaining fighters were at a similar level. Six fighters remained, including Cayman and Yong. Jaehwan checked them using [Suspicion].

'The only ones powerful enough is her, her, and her.'

Other than Cayman and Yong, the only ones interesting enough was the Leader of Divine Lady, the woman who beat Kanghwang, and another woman who had tied her hair into a ponytail.

Among those 3, the ponytail woman was the one Jaehwan had the most interest in. She joined in as a wildcard and was hiding something that Jaehwan could not see through even using his [Suspicion].

Jaehwan then turned to Mukeuk.

'But he's the one I want most.'

Jaehwan wanted to have a duel with that old man most of all, but he didn't join the tournament so it was no use.

'I'll finish this tournament first.'

Jaehwan walked up to Jahir and took his microphone and spoke.

-Everyone, listen.

The crowd became silent.

-I have seen enough.

The crowd began to take videos and pictures, while some began to record what Jaehwan was trying to say. After all, he was the Master of Gorgon, who had created huge sensations with everything he said.

"Wait, what is the meaning of this?"

It was the leader of Divine Lady, waiting to compete in the 2nd round. The 2nd round fight was between her and the woman who joined as a wildcard. Jaehwan glanced at her and continued.

-I'm bored watching these fights, so I will change things up a bit.

"WAIT! Who said you can do such a thing!"

-I did.

"This is unfair."

-I know.

"And how, exactly, are you trying to change things up?"

Jaehwan said something unexpected.

-I will remove the one-on-one battle rule.

"...Are you saying you want to fight in a group battle?"

It was outrageous. There were seven remaining attendees. Was he playing tricks to ensure his victory?

-Well... you can say that.

"No, that can't be done. It's impossible."

-And why is that?

"How are you going to divide up groups? And..."

Her voice grew cold.

"Who will be the ultimate winner?"

Meaning, who would be the master of Gorgon? The only way to find a winner was to do a one-on-one battle. But Jaehwan smiled.

-You misunderstood. I am not talking about some little groups to fight.

"What are you talking about?"

-There's only one team. All you six people are one team.

She couldn't understand what he was saying. Then who would be on Jaehwan's team?

-I will fight alone. Against all of you.

Chapter 62: Last Hope (11)

"I promise you that if anyone of you defeats me, I will make you the new Master."

It was a battle of one Master against six, including some leaders of the Ten-Clan. It was a fight that would never normally occur. It was a chance to see how strong this Master, who claimed to be embarking on an expedition to the [Depth], was.

This was exactly what Jaehwan wanted. He knew from his experience as the leader of 'Carpediem' about group mentality.

He needed the trust of these people. But true trust could only be gained through relationships, and that was the outcome of time. However, he had no such time. So, he resorted to showing strength. Overwhelming strength that would create awe in anyone who watched.

The woman on the other end of the stage laughed. It was the woman hiding something that Jaehwan couldn't read. Jaehwan focused on his powers. All those who he could not read using [Suspicion] were powerful, like Chunghuh. It meant that she, too, was at least as powerful as Chunghuh.

"I knew something interesting was going to happen."

She then walked straight up to Jaehwan.

"I like you. To the point that I want you as my own right now."

She stopped right in front of Jaehwan, close enough that a few more inches and their lips would have met. Jaehwan did not push her back as he couldn't feel any threat from her. The woman whispered into Jaehwan's ear.

"I'll step off from here."

"Are you giving up?"

"Yeah."

She then walked off. Jahir quickly announced through an extra microphone,

-One of the attendees has suddenly given up! Does she not want to be a Master?

She shrugged as if a Master was nothing to her.

"I don't want to be caught up in any more trouble. Besides..."

Her last words were too soft to hear, but Jaehwan didn't miss her lip movements. What she said was this:

-Disaster will come soon.

Jaehwan couldn't understand what she meant, but he couldn't think of anything. That's when someone spoke up from the stage.

"Hmm. Master, I will surrender also. I know I cannot beat you in my current state."

It was Yong. He already had advanced into the round of 8 as promised, so he didn't need to fight. But this was not what Jaehwan wanted.

Then, another man came up.

"I know that I do not have a chance against you. I accept my loss."

It was Cayman. The crowd began to mumble among themselves. They did not understand why Cayman, who loved to fight with honor, would give up without even putting up a fight.

Jaehwan frowned. This was not what he had expected.

Cayman silently bowed.

"This is weird. Is it a setup?"

The crowd began to grow suspicious, and this was exactly what Jaehwan was concerned about. The remaining people were now down to three. It was the Leader and the 2nd rank from Divine Lady, and the woman who defeated Kanghwang. Jaehwan pondered what he should do next.

"That's a shame. It didn't end up as you wanted."

It was Ja Ryung, the leader of Divine Lady, who spoke first. Jaehwan shook his head.

"It sucks for you, as your chance of winning has decreased. You still want to fight?"

"...You are an arrogant man."

Her voice seemed to be full of anger.

[Leader, we should just defeat him now.]

The 2nd rank of Divine Lady whispered to Ryung. She didn't like this whole thing from the beginning.

[He can't win against the three of us.]

[Calm down.]

Ryung shook her head.

[We are not here to fight him.]

[Yes, but...]

Jaehwan, who overheard what they were saying by using [Suspicion], became intrigued.

'Not here to fight? Then what is your purpose?'

Ryung then sent whispers to the woman who beat Kanghwang. It seemed they knew each other from before.

[Hyeyoung, what will you do?]

[I will have to see further.]

The woman, who was called Hyeyoung, answered.

[What made the Lord of Steel send you anyway? Who's behind Golden Sky?]

[As I said, I cannot tell you that. You shouldn't interfere too deeply with this matter.]

Ryung's pride seemed to be hurt but nodded as she answered.

[...Sure. So, what do you want me to do?]

[I need to know his character.]

[You want to know if he will be useful as your pawn.]

Hyeyoung did not answer right away but soon replied.

[The Lord of Steel will not forget your help.]

[What if the Master of Gorgon doesn't fit your standard?]

Another moment of silence. Hyeyoung thought for a while and then answered.

[Then we will find a new individual. I trust your wisdom will do the job.]

Ryung answered satisfyingly.

[Understood.]

As their whispers ended, the three women turned to Jaehwan and Jaehwan at them.

"Master of Gorgon, we have no intention of fighting you."

"Are you surrendering?"

"Surrender? That would be the wrong word. It's different."

"What do you mean?"

"You said before that those who lost in a one-on-one battle with you must join the [Depth Expedition Team]."

It was a familiar question. Jaehwan replied, "Are you trying to play word games like that Meng?"

"No, I do not intend to do that."

"Then what?"

He could feel Ryung smiling behind the veil over her face.

"We will not lose to you."

"...What?"

She was clearly speaking of a future that had not happened yet. She continued, "We are telling you that we will join the [Depth Expedition Team] voluntarily."

At the same time, a blue messenger bird arrived at the office of the inner Gorgon fortress. As no one was there to receive the message, the bird let out a screech. Chancellor Euren quickly came into the room to check on the message.

"Who is it? I'm kind of busy right now... wait."

Euren froze. The blue bird was only used to send messages in times of emergency.

[Master of Dryad Fortress. Aisa Lindcroft]

It was from the southern fortress. Why did she send such a message?

"...Impossible."

Euren paled as he read the contents of the message. He turned to look out the window, towards the southern sky of Gorgon. It was dark. It was still very far away, but something was surely coming toward the fortress.

It was the Army of Despair that was moving toward Gorgon Fortress.

Chapter 63: Last Hope (12)

Join the [Depth Expedition Team]? What was up with them?

"What are you up to?"

"What do you mean?"

It was Ryung who was even more confused.

"I want to join the expedition to bring hope to the people of [Chaos]. Anything wrong with that?"

Jaehwan shrugged and so Ryung continued, "I guess you are forgetting the true purpose of this tournament."

"Purpose?"

"Yes."

Jaehwan wasn't sure what she was talking about.

"Let's be honest. You do not plan to give up the Master position at all. Isn't that right?"

Jaehwan couldn't answer before Ryung continued on, "It's because the tournament was to find members for your expedition team from the beginning."

The crowd began to become restless and Ryung spoke out even more strongly, "I am astonished. I really am. No one has dared start a plan like that after the first team failed 900 years ago. But you put your life on the line to start on that plan. I applaud your actions."

Ryung then turned back towards Jaehwan and towards the spectators.

"That's why I am glad that I am here. I believe all of you here share the same feeling."

Her voice was now amplified by a skill to allow everyone in the spectator seats to hear her.

"I know that if this tournament was only to find a new Master, not this many people would have gathered. There are a lot of you who are strong enough to compete, but didn't join."

She then took off her veil. The crowd fell silent as Ryung looked around the spectators. People quickly looked up to meet eyes with her.

It was Ryung's best skill, 'Eye of Righteousness'. It made the target to reflect on their inner self, against their righteousness within.

Ryung continued, "Everyone, I want to hear from all of you. Are you here because of the possible new Master of Gorgon? Or for the [Depth Expedition Team]?"

They were quiet but heavy words.

"I want to believe that we still have a last 'hope' that remains within us."

The crowd began to move. It was what they had in their minds for all this time. But it was something that they did not dare to even consider as a dream. It was now becoming a reality.

"Sh-she's right!"

"Yes! What we want to see is...!"

The crowd began to agree with Ryung and one old man spoke out.

"I agree with her. I am not here to just watch some fights."

It was a voice filled with powerful spirit power.

"Mingkhan the Sword General!"

Mingkhan, who was not in any clan, was considered as powerful as the Ten-Clan itself, with generous and merciful characteristics. However, Jaehwan did not miss the old man and Ryung exchanging eye signals.

'They are together.'

She nodded and answered Mingkhan, "He is right. What we need is unity, not to fight among ourselves!"

People began to shout, agreeing with Ryung's words.

"As such, I request that the Master of Gorgon terminate the tournament now. This tournament has fulfilled its purpose. You have enough people who are eager to join your [Depth Expedition Team]."

The crowd reached its frenzied height of reaction. Control was in Ryung's hands. She had applauded Jaehwan's purpose and pointed out the unneeded process and made the result, the [Depth Expedition Team], look like an idea that she had taken a big part of.

"But it's not too early to decide. We have one more issue."

Someone asked what it was and Ryung answered, "Who, then, will be in charge of the expedition team?"

Chunghuh, who was listening quietly, frowned.

"She's up to something."

Mukeuk also nodded. He, too, felt uneasy.

"Communication skill [Stealth Deception] and [Serpent Tongue]..."

They were skills that covered up anything that lacked logic or facts with the tone of voice and strength. The only ones who did not succumb to her skills were 7th stage or higher Adapters. Then, someone in the crowd asked. It was the Sword General.

"So who do you think is fit for the role?"

Ryung answered, "I think the Master of Gorgon Fortress fits the role best."

Some seemed shocked while others moaned in astonishment. As she was getting the most attention, she could claim herself to be the leader of the expedition team, but she did not do that.

Of course, people were oblivious that Ryung had calculated everything up to this point.

"I object that idea."

Mingkhan replied, "I do not trust the Master of Gorgon."

The crowd began to boo at Mingkhan, as Ryung asked, "Why are you saying that? He fits the role best."

"I, to a certain extent, agree."

He continued, "He is more powerful than any Ten-Clan Leader, and he has the intelligence as he outwitted Meng of the Disciples Clan. There's no one like him, even in [Chaos] history."

"That's weird. Then why are you objecting?"

"Because the leader of the expedition team needs to be something more than that."

The people fell silent. Those were the words from someone who watched the [Depth Expedition Team] depart and reach its disastrous end. Ryung then asked, with an ever-generous smile, "Then what do you think the leader needs?"

"He needs character."

It was a deliberate response.

"The leader needs character to hold powerful men in place. I think this is a must."

The crowd began to agree with what Mingkhan was saying.

"You mean, the Master does not have such character to do so?"

The people turned to Mingkhan, who changed the subject without answering, "I heard some rumors about him while on the way here."

"What kind of rumors?"

"I heard that the Master has only lived half a century and it has been only a month since he appeared in [Chaos]."

The crowd began to grow uneasy as they also had heard of such rumors. Ryung then asked Jaehwan, "Is that true? Those rumors?"

"They are."

Jaehwan replied honestly. People began to shout.

"That's a problem!"

"We cannot have a man who only lived half a century to lead the expedition team!"

Jaehwan frowned at such unease.

'Is it the number again?'

Ryung continued, "Sword General, you are right in your argument. But-"

Mingkhan nodded and Ryung continued,

"We cannot bring him down because he has only lived a 'short' life. We do not know what kind of 50 years he has lived."

People began to praise Ryung's kind words again. Mingkahn spoke, "I agree. But I still think the Master needs to prove his character."

"Prove... but how can you prove such a thing?"

"I think you can do the job very well."

"Me? But how?"

"How about you perform the 'Question of Righteousness'?"

The 'Question of Righteousness.'

Ryung's 'Question of Righteousness' was famous in [Chaos]. Many high-stage Adapters asked to do this with Ryung to gain their rating of the 'Way of Truth'. This had the potential of entrapping Adapters into self-despair, but overcoming it granted an incredible amount of ratings.

The crowd began to cheer in approval of the idea and Ryung spoke reluctantly, "If you all want it so much..."

She smiled faintly as she turned to Jaehwan.

"Mind my manners. We have not asked the Master's opinion on this matter. I am sorry. So, do you plan to take up the leadership of the expedition team?"

Jaehwan did not answer. He was looking towards the sky, at the incoming dark clouds from the distance. A faint sense of disastrous energy that Jaehwan was familiar with.

Chunghuh, without knowing where Jaehwan was looking at, groaned.

'You have been trapped by her trickery. What will you do now?'

If Jaehwan decided to pull out his sword and beat up everyone, his expedition team would be as good as gone. There was no one who would want to join the team led by a tyrant. But if he agreed, he would need to face the 'Question of Righteousness'.

Jaehwan spoke out.

Chapter 64: Last Hope (13)

"Sure."

"...You mean you will accept the 'Question of Righteousness'?" Ryung asked, to which Jaehwan nodded.

"What do I need to do?"

"It's simple. You just need to answer my questions."

She smiled as she continued, "Everyone, please close your eyes."

Everyone, including Jaehwan, closed their eyes. They felt the darkness then turn into something else.

A chill began to overcome them. It was the beginning of the question. When Jaehwan opened his eyes again, and he found himself standing on top of a vast ocean.

'Hallucination?'

The crowd buzzed with astonishment as they found themselves above a vast ocean. Ryung's voice could be heard.

"The stage of this question is the ocean region where I live. As you know, the region outside of Dryad Fortress is comprised of this rough ocean. And as you can see, it makes a lot of ships sink."

It was as she said. The sea began to rage and at the center of it was a sinking ship. The people who were on the ship were fighting desperately to keep themselves alive.

-H-help!

They were at the brink of death in the chilly water. It was too real to be considered a hallucination. A short while later, a rescue boat appeared to save the people from drowning. The boat that had an occupancy of 10 began to save those who were in the water. But there was a problem.

-We need one more spot!

The total occupancy was 10, but there was still one more in the sea.

-We can't take him in, or else we will sink!

-Let him die!

When Jaehwan came to his senses, he found himself as the captain of the rescue boat. One of the people in the boat shouted to him.

-Captain! Make a choice!

Jaehwan thought, 'I see. So this is the question.'

He saw Ryung smiling in the distance. There were choices in front of him.

[1. Give up on him! We will save the ten!]

[2. No one is left behind. We will all die together!]

There was no correct answer to either of those choices. It was a trap from the beginning to disparage Jaehwan for his ability to lead the expedition team.

"Now, Master. What will you do?"

Jaehwan looked at the two choices and stated firmly, "I will choose the third option."

"...What? There is no third option."

Jaehwan shook his head.

"Third option. I will save everyone and not sink the ship."

She then turned grim.

'Wait- did he?'

Unlike most other 'Question of Righteousness,' this one had a correct answer in hiding. This was shown only when the one being questioned found the answer himself.

[3. "We will not give up on anyone! Save him and we will take turns to jump in the water to survive until the next rescue boat comes to help!]

It was the correct answer that did not force one to lose their humanity and allowed them to save everyone. Ryung was going to disparage Jaehwan's ability if he had chosen 1 or 2, but her plan had failed.

'He found the 3rd answer?'

Ryung asked in a shaky voice, "Let me hear it. What is your 3rd option?"

Jaehwan asked, "They will die because this 'ocean' exists, right?"

"...Of course."

"Then I will destroy this 'ocean'."

Ryung became dumbfounded.

'W-what is he talking about?'

It was a foolish answer. But Jaehwan pulled out his sword.

"WAIT! What are you-!"

A powerful force of energy gathered at the end of Jaehwan's sword and was thrust outward in a stab. Then, something shocking happened. The image of

the ocean created for the 'Question of Righteousness' was divided into two.

-The ocean has opened up!

-It's a miracle!

-We are saved! Thank you, Captain!

The people on the boat began to cry in joy as they crowded around Jaehwan.

[System Error]

[Question of Righteousness is now aborting]

The hallucination was aborted and the tournament ring returned to normal. The crowd was dumbfounded by what they had just witnessed. Ryung shouted furiously with her hair in a mess from the wind created by Jaehwan's stab.

"W-what is the meaning of this?!"

Ryung and her clan members all drew their swords at Jaehwan in rage. But something was strange.

"We will stop here."

Ryung flinched as she also sensed something. Just then, an announcement sounded from Gorgon Keep.

[EMERGENCY! We are canceling all events! All gates will be closed!]

[WE ARE DECLARING GORGON 1!]

[CITIZENS! PLEASE EVACUATE TO THE NORTHERN STREETS IMMEDIATELY!]

'Gorgon 1' was the highest emergency evacuation order. The crowd began to mumble among themselves.

"What's happening?"

"I heard Dead Man appeared."

"Dead Man?"

People began to grow concerned as they moved out of the tournament area. Jaehwan received a whisper. It was from Euren.

[Master, you must come to the Southern Gate at once!]

Jaehwan quickly rushed toward the Southern Gate, and many strong warriors, including the Leaders of the Ten-Clan, followed Jaehwan to the south.

Soon, all the strong warriors of [Chaos] had gathered on the wall right next to the Southern Gate.

They all witnessed and felt the same thing.

The entire southern forest was dark. Everything in their path was destroyed, as countless Dead Men passed. It was as if a black tidal wave was crashing in. As they hit the outer wall of the fortress, they screamed. Ryung thought she was lucky that she was on top of a high wall. Then, she realized what these tall walls were made for. The walls weren't made to defend against horned monsters.

"Mukeuk, are you here?"

"Yes." Mukeuk answered.

"It reminds you of 900 years ago, doesn't it?"

"When we arrived at the Dead Man Palace?"

"Yeah."

Mukeuk remembered the old days. They had seen this 900 years ago.

"...How did 'Upright Magrit' end up here?"

It was because of one of three famous Dead Men, Upright Magrit that the fortresses had walls of that height. That was the name of the disaster that left all of [Chaos] terrified.

Chunghuh suddenly remembered Sole King Catastrophe being brought upon the fortress. Dead Men had the habit of calling other Dead Men. Medium Dead Men called upon Small Dead Men, and Large Dead Men called upon Medium Dead Men. And the King was called upon in Gorgon Keep.

"We might die out here," Yong said in a shaking voice.

"You thought of joining the expedition team if you cannot even face such a thing?"

"Your legs are shaking too, Kanghwang."

"Shut up."

Chunghuh laughed. Both Yong and Kanghwang were not even born when he was on the expedition team, but now they were leaders in [Chaos]. Chunghuh looked at all of the faces staring at the disaster.

'I never thought I would see such a sight before I died.'

A total of six clan Leaders of the Ten-Clan of [Chaos] were here, facing at least thousands of Dead Men. There were at least 10 Large Dead Men which were as powerful as 7th stage Adapters, with an Extra Large Dead Man, Upright Magrit, commanding them.

Some who were too terrified of Magrit began to run towards the north. The one called 'Sword General' was one of them. They knew. They had no chance of winning and Gorgon would perish.

Chunghuh could not blame them for choosing to live.

Upright Magrit was closing in.

At that moment, a black ray of light shot out from the ground into the sky. It distorted gravity, dragging some men up into the air. It was Magrit's power, 'Augmented Reality'.

Everyone, including the leaders of the Ten-Clan, cowered. They could not even imagine fighting against such power. As the ray dissipated, a few warriors perished into dust. The Sword General was one of them.

They were powerless.

There was no hope against such a monster.

Then, they saw the sword.

The sword passed all the cowering people and moved toward the army of Dead Men. Ryung barely raised her head to look. She tried to speak, but couldn't. She wanted to stop him, but couldn't. Then, the black ray of light again erupted toward the man.

Ryung closed her eyes to avoid watching the impending doom. When she opened her eyes, she faced a sight that she would never forget her entire life.

The black ray had been split.

A ray of light was dividing it, it was destroying that overwhelming power. Distorted senses and gravity returned to normal. Upright Magrit was screaming in agony.

-Then I will destroy this 'ocean.'

She remembered what Jaehwan had said. Everyone felt the same as Ryung at that moment. This was the answer against the world full of despair.

"It's impossible."

It was Mukeuk who had been barely withstanding the power of Magrit. Then someone answered, "It is."

"And reckless."

"It is."

Chunghuh laughed. "But it is a simple and direct answer."

Chunghuh then walked toward the black ray of light with his sword drawn.

'I see. That is what you chose.'

Mukeuk knew. That way was 'impossible'. If they were lured into it because of this moment's miracle, there was no coming back. But Mukeuk stated firmly, "Then, I will join."

His sword roared with a wave of energy as Mukeuk fired it off.

Jaehwan jumped into the wave of black disaster, closely followed by Chunghuh and Mukeuk. They made a narrow path, one that would soon be covered up by other Dead Men. However, it was kept open.

"I will not stay back and face the shame."

"I know what you mean."

Cayman and Jagel Meng stood up, as did the other Leaders of the Ten-Clan.

Now, they were creating a story. The beginning of a story that [Chaos] had waited for millions of years. Even if it was despair that awaited them at the end, it was something that had to be done. At the back was Yong who barely managed to join in.

"Hey... uh, Kanghwang."

"I'm busy. Don't talk to me."

"I know it's embarrassing, but I want to talk to someone about it."

"What?"

"Do I look cool now?"

Kanghwang did not answer but concentrated on fighting, and so did Yong. All of them kept on fighting to protect. They had to. But they were getting tired. Kanghwang grew concerned if they would really make it to the end. That was when they heard the voices of people from behind. Kanghwang turned back.

After that, he did not worry about what might happen next. He knew that they would succeed in protecting Gorgon.

The entire Gorgon was now at their back, fighting together as one.

A week later, the news of Magrit being killed had spread quickly throughout [Chaos].

Chapter 65: Triad Meeting (1)

Eastern Fortress – Manticore

Jinong, the leader of the Golden Sky Clan, thought it was a hoax when he first heard that Magrit had been killed.

"No way!"

It was an Extra-Large Dead Man that would require at least a Lesser General of the [Great Lands] to handle. One that was as powerful as a 9th stage Adapter. It was so powerful that there were only three of them in [Chaos].

"It's impossible!"

Jinong sent people out to check on it. And after the third day, he was told that all of his northern offices near Gorgon had been destroyed.

[Ten days after Magrit was killed... a lot of changes in Gorgon... biggest change is... and I interviewed an old man passing by...]

Lenius, an associate journalist from [Chaos of this Month], stopped typing with his [Emergency Memo] skill and looked up to ask, "So, what changes did you notice afterward?"

The old muscular man was carrying a huge horn on his shoulder. It seemed he was a blacksmith, as he had a chisel and a hammer on his waist belt. Since he was carrying stuff himself, he was probably not very important in Gorgon. It was a perfect individual to ask such questions.

"It got better to live."

Better to live? That was a weird answer for the young Lenius to fully grasp as he had only lived for 30 years in [Chaos].

"Sir, exactly in what way has it gotten better?"

"Well, the economy's doing good, for a start."

Gorgon's economy was booming. They now had six out of the ten Ten-Clan. They had moved into Gorgon with a large number of powerful warriors. It meant that those warriors brought in a lot of various horns and other goods that weaker individuals couldn't obtain. But that wasn't the only thing.

"I'm sure that's not enough to change the streets this much."

Gorgon was in ruins. The outer walls were decimated and a lot of people lost their homes, not to mention the countless number of spirits that perished. However, the people seemed bright. The people repairing their homes were full of joy, and those who shared horns were excited. No other place in [Chaos] was like this.

"Well, you would say that since you did not see the [Way in the Wave].

A Way that was created in the sea of Dead Men. Lenius had heard of this, but he couldn't understand. How could one man start a 'Way' in the middle of millions of Dead Men?

'Even if it was true...'

Lenius thought that might not be the only important thing. On the day of the attack, a lot of journalists were at the scene. However, all of those senior journalists left this message.

-Sometimes, some things are worth more than just a few columns.

Then, they joined the fight against the Dead Men. And died. That was why associates like Lenius were sent out to investigate.

'Just what did they see that day?'

He was curious about what they had witnessed.

"Well, I'll just say that it got better to live. I'll elave it at that."

The muscular old man walked into a small tent. It had a sign over it which said 'Emergency Healing Tent'. Lenius followed the old man inside.

"Hey, here's a new horn."

"Oh, you're here!"

Healers quickly ran to check on the horn.

"Wait, this is a quadhorn! We can't use this..."

"That's why I brought it here."

The old man then swung his hammer down on the horn and crushed it. The healers were shocked, as was Lenius. He was only an associate, but he knew how hard quadhorn horns were.

'Is he not just some old man?'

The question in his mind was quickly answered by the healers.

"Vice-Chief, you are really amazing!"

The medicine that was processed by the old man was then used to heal other patients. Lenius stared dumbfoundedly. Using a quadhorn as medicine? It was unheard of in any of the other fortresses.

'I guess this place is full of rich people.'

But Lenius' thoughts were proven wrong soon enough.

"Wait... are those medicines given away for free?"

"Huh? Yeah," the old man answered. All the patients were Non-Adapters. There was no way that Non-Adapters would have the money to afford

quadhorn horns.

"Why are you doing this? How can you afford such..."

"The Master of Gorgon hunts them down himself."

"The Master himself?"

"Yeah. He brings back hundreds when he goes out. There are plenty of these."

Lenius couldn't believe what he heard. A Master of Fortress going out to hunt down horned monsters himself?

"Don't try. You won't understand unless you live here."

The old man seemed very proud of what he was saying. Lenius realized who he was talking to.

The Vice-Chief of Twilight's Fall, Meikal Garnad.

It was the only human who could process the horn of Garnak, and the best blacksmith in Gorgon.

'And he's very proud of the change.'

Lenius, as he only lived for 30 years in [Chaos], knew what that expression was the result of. It was positive anticipation.

-Better to live.

No one who had lived over a hundred years in [Chaos] used the word 'live' easily. The word itself directly contradicted the ones in [Chaos]. But Meikal, who had lived over 150 years in [Chaos], had used that word. Lenius took out the [Emergency Memo] and checked the headlines he had chosen when he was first assigned.

[Master of Gorgon. Hope or Disaster?]

Lenius quickly erased the title. Then, he turned towards the streets. People were laughing with hope. He then quickly began writing down what he felt at the moment.

[The People of Gorgon 'live' again.]

He felt this was going to be a very important column. What he was going to say was the embodiment of something very vital to [Chaos].

Just then, an explosion startled Lenius. Smoke began to rise from within the inner keep.

"What's going on?" Lenius asked, to which Meikal shrugged as he answered, "Well, that's normal."

Lenius looked at the smoke. Explosions such as that would only occur when high-stage Adapters fight. Lenius then remembered there were now six of the Ten-Clan of [Chaos] residing in Gorgon. It seemed too quiet for that. Having just three clans in one fortress was enough to result in clan wars. And now there were six of them.

"Is there a war within the Ten-Clan?"

"A war? HAHAHA!"

Meikal laughed as if he had just heard the funniest joke ever.

"Well, you can say it's a war, I guess."

Meikal then watched as the leaders of those Ten-Clan getting thrown into the sky.

"It's five today."

Chapter 66: Triad Meeting (2)

In the training grounds of Gorgon Keep.

The leaders of the Ten-Clan, with heavily bruised faces, knelt in front of Jaehwan.

"Weak."

The leaders shook with shame. No one had ever said such a thing to them until now.

"What have you done in your hundreds of years?"

They wanted to object but couldn't find any words. They had just fought as a group, excluding the 2nd ranked Mukeuk, against a lone Jaehwan. Yong shook at the thought of Jaehwan's stab. Jaehwan turned to Yong and spoke.

"Yong, you are just fast, but that's it."

Yong bowed. Jaehwan then gave advice to everyone else.

"Kanghwang, you have power but are too slow. Ryung, you are agile and have fast reflexes, but weak in endurance. Meng, you think too much before acting. Cayman, you are the best among all here. You have no weakness. But it also means you have no strong point."

Jaehwan then faced all of them.

"And all of you have one common problem. Do you know what that is?"

The leaders waited for Jaehwan to continue.

"You're weak, but still full of yourself."

The leaders frowned at those words. And there were two old men in the distance, watching them. It was Mukeuk and Chunghuh.

"He's right about that."

"Ha! Kid, you said that right!" Chunghuh cackled. He had always wanted to teach a lesson to those Clan Leaders and his wish was now fulfilled.

"You old men are weak too, considering you lived for a thousand years."

"Dammit."

However, Jaehwan was right. By his standards, or even Chunghuh's standards, the current [Depth Expedition Team] was very weak.

'It's worse than the first team from 900 years ago.'

The Ten-Clan of [Chaos] existed 900 years ago. Those Clan Leaders were all 7th stage or higher Adapters with everyone above the 5th rank at the 8th stage. The 1st rank of that time, the former leader of Sky Dragon Clan, was a 9th stage Adapter, with the [Nightmare] Mulack who was much stronger than a 9th stage Adapter.

And they had a hard time in [Depth].

"Do you all remember the 'Hunt'?"

"I do."

By that, Jaehwan meant the operation three days ago that wiped out all of the Golden Sky Clan offices around the region.

"As you know, most of you were either badly injured or almost killed."

Yong, Kanghwang, and the other clan leaders shook at that reminder. They had been shocked by the might of the Golden Sky Clan a few days ago.

Yong almost got killed and Meng had been badly injured. They were just hunting down the regional offices and they suffered that many casualties.

Deathly Monsters.

Killing machines with only half of their spirits turning into Dead Man, resulting in a Dead Man with human intelligence. The Clan Leaders then understood how Manticore was taken over by the Golden Sky Clan. Each one of them had the power of a 6th stage Adapter. They had hundreds of those weapons that allowed them to do that.

It was rumored that the Western Fortress of Garuda was facing similar enemies.

"If you are having a hard time against just some clan, how are you going to go on the expedition?"

Jaehwan continued, "As such, you will undergo special training for one week."

The Leaders looked at each other. They understood what Jaehwan said, but they couldn't understand one thing. They knew they had to get strong and that they did not have much time left. But what would just a week of training do for them? Jagel Meng raised his hand to ask.

"Master, can I ask a question?"

Meng immediately became ashamed at raising a hand to ask a question like a little child when he was 400 years old.

"Go on."

"As you know, we are all Adapters."

It was something everyone already knew. The leaders turned to Meng.

"I know that."

"Then I guess you would know that our stage cannot just suddenly increase by themselves."

Stage. From 1 to 15. It was the number that divided Adapters within their respective ranks. Meng continued,

"It takes an average of 10 years for Non-Adapters to become 1st stage Adapters. It then takes 20 years for a 1st stage to move onto the 2nd. It takes 40 years to become 3rd, and 80 years to become 4th. Most humans then die before even reaching the 4th stage."

That was precisely why Adapters at the 4th stage or higher were called 'high-stage Adapters'. There were no humans who were able to survive as an Adapter for 150 years.

"And I believe it's only up to the 7th stage that you can climb by racking up years of training. That's why people consider the 7th stage the limit for a human."

The Leaders of the Ten-Clan were most powerful beings throughout [Chaos]. They were geniuses that reached the 6th or 7th stage faster than others, but they also knew that was their limit.

Jaehwan then asked, "And?"

"I heard that you are an Awakener."

An Awakener. The Leaders were shocked. Some seemed like they had expected it, like Cayman, and some were genuinely shocked, like Ryung. Jaehwan replied, "I don't know, but that's what people in this world call me."

He had no intention to hide it and Meng nodded.

"We do not know much about Awakeners."

They knew a lot about Adapters and Adaptation. But 'Awakening' was a completely different thing. Meng continued, "All I know is just a few

rumors. I heard that Awakeners become awakened by some kind of insight into the truth."

Jaehwan then remembered when he first became himself by breaking out of the system.

"What are you getting at?"

"You certainly are aware that we are Adapters, and that we cannot get strong all of a sudden."

"Right."

"Then there's only one answer."

Meng looked straight at Jaehwan and asked, "Are you trying to get us to become Awakeners?"

Chapter 67: Triad Meeting (3)

People of the [Great Lands] defined an 'Awakener' as the following:

One that is out of the system.

Because they were out of the system, their reputation wasn't well-perceived. It was also due to the terrorist group [Rupture] that had a significant number of Awakeners as their members. And to add on, the reputation of [Rupture] was as the following:

-Rupture? They are doomsayers who create problems.

However, Awakeners still held tremendous value because of their sheer strength and rarity.

All Lords were eager to hire Awakeners and there were cases where the Lord himself was an Awakener.

Jaehwan was one such Awakener. And he was going to train the Leaders.

"Yes, I am thinking of making you into Awakeners." Jaehwan then continued, "But I do not intend to make all of you into Awakeners."

"Why is that?"

"Because some of you might not want that." Jaehwan answered. He remembered what he talked about with Chunghuh regarding 'Awakening.'

-Kid, you would know since you went through it, but there are three steps to be 'Awakened'.

The first step was to destroy the world of 'Adaptation'. This was usually called [Disassemble]. This was what Jaehwan called [Suspicion]. It would allow one to acquire a way to [Disassemble] the world and see the truth hidden behind it.

Jaehwan then looked at the Leaders.

"Some of you have lived too long to understand the Awakening."

Too long? Yong became confused.

"I don't get what you are saying."

"...It means we are too used to this world's system."

It was Ryung who answered. She seemed to quickly understand what Jaehwan had said.

"It means we are too used to all the good things like skills or status."

"I see!"

"...I'm surprised you became a Clan Leader with your level of understanding."

Ryung spoke sarcastically, to which Yong laughed off.

"Yes, well I was 'Over-Adapted.'"

An Over-Adapter. One who had overly adapted to the interface system. It was also called 'Blessed by the System', which allowed them to quickly adapt to the system, needing less time required to train. Most of the 12 Lords were also these 'Over-Adapters'. However, they weren't as powerful as Awakeners.

"Fool, everyone here is an Over-Adapter." Kanghwang spoke, scolding Yong. As he said, everyone who had become a Leader was an Over-Adapter. That's when Cayman spoke out.

"I'm not."

Cayman did not have such a blessing. He had lived for 900 years just putting in the effort and hard work to arrive at his 7th stage. Cayman then said firmly,

"And I am ready, Master."

"To become an Awakener?"

Cayman nodded.

"It won't be easy."

"Is it because I am too used to the system?"

"That is correct."

"Don't worry," Cayman answered coldly. "If I can become more powerful, I am ready to put this 'world' behind."

"Cayman! Do you know what you are talking about?!" It was Ryung who shouted angrily.

"It means that you will give up everything you have built up! Are you really ready to throw away all of your skills and status?!"

It was the other Leaders who reacted to Ryung's words. These were Leaders who had lived 200 to 1000 years. They had spent much time and effort to reach where their current level.

"Well, that's a bit much I guess..."

Kanghwang mumbled, and Yong seemed to agree with him. Jaehwan thought as he watched them.

'I thought so.'

He had already expected such a reaction. The Way of Awakening was full of uncertainty. There was no need for high-stage Adapters to take that risk. However, Cayman turned to Ryung and calmly replied,

"I am ready to put all of that behind me. I will only bring my hate towards the Lords."

They were cold words. Ryung hesitated for a second and spoke.

"...It will not end at that. You must know how dangerous the Awakening can be."

"..."

"Don't say that you forgot about the [Great Disappearance]."

Some leaders turned grim, while others became confused. Jaehwan was also included in the latter. It was Yong who asked, "What's the [Great Disappearance]?"

He was the youngest among the leaders so he had the least amount of knowledge about history. Ryung bit on her lip and explained.

"I assume those of you older than me would know. There is a reason why the word 'Awakener' would have such a bad reputation."

"What happened?"

"It all happened with the appearance of [Rupture]."

[Rupture]. There was no one who did not know that organization in the [Great Lands]. The infamous militant group that was comprised of Awakeners. That was [Rupture].

"They appeared in the [Great Lands] 700 years ago."

The appearance of [Rupture]. It was considered a terrifying day even until now.

-We will fight against [Cultivation].

The terrorist group [Rupture] appeared, declaring such an agenda. This infuriated many Lords of the [Great Lands]. The one who was angered the most, was the then Lord of the 4th region, Mayhart. He was the one who did not believe rumors about Awakeners.

-Awakeners or not, I'll kill them with my pinky.

And the next day, he was found dead, with his pinky finger cut off and stuck in his heart.

It was then that everyone began to fear [Rupture].

Mayhart was the weakest of the 12 Lords, but he still was a Lord. Yet, this organization had the power to assassinate the Lord in his bedroom. Then [Rupture] made a declaration.

-Everyone can become an Awakener. If you are willing to try, come to the 'Forgotten Lands'.

People were shocked. Some Adapters even became hopeful that they could become Awakeners.

-Deny the world.

Countless Adapters gathered to the Forgotten Lands where the [Rupture] headquarters was rumored to be located at. However, nothing came back.

All those people who gathered in the Forgotten Lands just disappeared.

Some said they had become Awakeners, while others said they had gone mad. Some even believed they were used as test specimens by [Rupture] and were trashed. But they were all rumors and none of the people who went to the Forgotten Lands returned.

This was later called the [Great Disappearance].

"Some of my friends also went missing."

The Leaders quietly listened to Ryung. It was rare for even Leaders to hear about [Great Disappearance].

"However, there were some who managed to return as Awakeners. They said they were only at the 1st step of Awakening."

Jaehwan was also listening carefully. He asked, "What happened to them?"

"...They all killed themselves."

The Leaders gasped.

"They all had severe mental trauma. Some were literally mad, while some lost all their memories. But they all had one thing in common."

"And what was that?"

"They all said that they were not sure who they were."

Kanghwang then asked, "Fools! How can they not know?"

"Are you insulting my friends?"

"No! I'm just saying... how can you not?" Kanghwan continued, "I'm Kanghwang of the Fire King Clan! See, I know myself."

Ryung refused to answer. She felt stupid to even react to that. It was only Jaehwan who seemed to understand as he seemed to be concerned by the story.

'Maybe this man knows something about that.'

Then, Jaehwan spoke up.

"Ryung."

Ryung flinched, surprised at being called out.

"Let me tell you two things. First of all, I'm not from [Rupture]."

Ryung gasped. 'He knew what I was up to.'

Ryung intentionally mentioned [Rupture] for one reason. She wanted to know where Jaehwan had come from. Anyone in the [Great Lands] would be reminded of [Rupture] when they heard the term Awakener. [Rupture] was too dangerous to be associated with. If Jaehwan was from [Rupture], it would put their lives in jeopardy.

"Secondly, Awakening can be dangerous. That's why I have no intention of making all of you into Awakeners."

"You mean..."

"I will take volunteers."

Jaehwan then glanced at Cayman. Ryung asked again,

"What of those who refuse to become Awakeners?"

"I will make them stronger too."

"But how?"

"Increase their Adaptation stage."

Ryung became disappointed. She had expected something different, but the plan just seemed too normal. It also had a critical problem.

"In one week?"

"Yes."

"That's impossible."

"Why do you think so?"

"Let me tell you two things."

Ryung imitated Jaehwan as she spoke, "First is 'time'."

The problem of time. All Leaders understood what Ryung said. It took them hundreds of years to reach the 6th or 7th stage. But now, they only had a week.

"I can solve that problem."

"...How?"

Jaehwan then thought for a moment.

'Well, I guess it's about finished by now.'

He turned to the Leaders.

"Follow me."

It was a large empty space behind the keep. In the center was a giant circular single-story building that looked like a cut-off tree stump. There were architects and workers working on the finishing touches of the building.

"A building made of horns."

The leaders were astonished at the surface of the building. Only Chunghuh was not surprised as he knew about it being built. One of the workers came up to them. It was a muscular old man with a hammer.

"Master, you're here."

Everyone knew who he was.

"Vice-Chief?"

"Why is the Vice-Chief of Twilight's Fall working here?"

It was Meikal Garnad. Jaehwan asked, "Is it finished?"

"Almost. It's a bit crude because we only had a week, but it will work. Only..."

"Only?"

"The control of corruption isn't working out."

"That's okay. I have enough horns for that."

Jaehwan glanced at the building and asked, "Can you start it now?"

"Of course."

"Then show them."

Meikal nodded and went to the control panel outside of the building. He seemed like he was very proud of what he had built.

"I couldn't even dream of making it until now..."

"You could've done it a long time ago. You just didn't think of doing it."

"Thank you, Master."

Meikal smiled. He then activated a switch, turning on the lights in the building. A message popped up in front of Jaehwan and the other leaders.

[Will you accept the summon?]

Jaehwan's expression was cold at the sight of the message.

'I didn't think that I would see this message again.'

Jaehwan answered, as did the other Leaders. The next moment, they were in a different place. They quickly realized that they were now inside the building they had seen and that they knew the place very well. It was stored away, deep in their oldest memories, but they had not forgotten. One of them moaned.

"Tower of Nightmares...!"

They were greeted with a message window.

[Welcome to Tower of Nightmare: Carpediem]

Chapter 68: Triad Meeting (4)

Tower of Nightmare: Carpediem

It was a week ago that Jaehwan decided to create this tower of nightmares, right after he killed the Extra-Large Dead Man Magrit.

-Kid, are you serious? There have been no cases where a tower was created by a non-[Nightmare].

The Tower of Nightmares had historically only been created by [Nightmares]. Other higher races like Demons or Angels had ways to interfere in the systems, but only [Nightmares] could create and repair them.

However, a human trying to create it? It was foolish.

-It's okay. Meikal can do it. Besides, we are only making the first floor.

-First floor?

-Just enough to control time. It doesn't need to be fancy.

That was when Meikal and all the entire smiths of Twilight's Fall were called in. And one week later, it was completed.

"....I never imagined that a human could create the Tower of Nightmares."

"It only has one story, but it's still amazing."

Inside, there was only an endless amount of space and sky, but it was still a great feat. It was something that no other race had achieved in the millions of years of history. Jaehwan then thought.

'Well, we did have a really hard time.'

For a whole week, Meikal and Jaehwan put a lot of hard work into creating this tower. It would not have been possible without Jaehwan's experience as a [Product] and Meikal's skill as an experienced blacksmith. Jaehwan also came to understand a lot about the [Nightmare] race. The skills that they used were very similar to the power of an 'Awakener' that Jaehwan used. It was so similar even to the point where it seemed like [Nightmares] were the first Awakeners, as most of their skills were based on Awakening steps.

However, it also seemed only natural. One needed to know the truth of the world to make another. Maybe it was the [Nightmares] who knew the reality of this world.

And so, Carpediem was created. It was a tower to bring back lost hope to [Chaos].

Meng said in astonishment, "I am deeply touched! To be able to return to this place not to be [Cultivated] but to destroy it!"

"M-me too! I wanted to say that too!"

Yong also agreed. The Leaders turned to Jaehwan, asking for his next words.

"All training will be done in here now."

Jaehwan looked at each one of them carefully.

"As you may have guessed, the time in this tower goes a hundred times slower than in real time. A day in [Chaos] will mean a hundred days in this tower. Considering the fact that we have a week, you will have close to two years to train."

Two years. That was given time for the Leaders.

"But, as time is expedited, it has also been compacted. It means that your spirit will feel much more fatigued in this place."

The Leaders frowned. It didn't just mean that they would grow tired faster.

"You mean our corruption rate will increase as well."

Meng guessed it, and Jaehwan nodded.

"Yes. It is especially true as you are older spirits. You are not young spirits who just joined the tutorial."

Some of the Leaders who had elevated senses knew that Jaehwan was speaking the truth. They had resistance to corruption since they had powerful spirits, but their corruption rate was increasing ever so rapidly.

"As such, this tower has a mechanism to kick you out once you reach 80% corruption. I have readied horns for you to take once you log out, so you won't need to worry about corruption."

It was a very well-thought-out plan.

"I will now divide those who volunteer to become Awakeners, and those who will not."

It was now time to choose.

"Those who wish to become Awakened, stand on my right. Those who just want to increase your Adaptation stage, to my left."

It was Cayman who acted first. He moved to Jaehwan's right without hesitation.

"I will remind you. You might die."

"I will not regret it even then."

Cayman was certain of the choice he had made.

"The only possibility left in me will be an 'Awakening'."

Unlike the other Leaders who were 'Over-Adapters,' Cayman knew that he had reached his limit. He also learned this clearly in the few days that he had trained against Jaehwan.

'An Awakener is not limited by one's maximum spirit power limit.'

That was what Cayman had learned in those few days. All of the skills that Jaehwan used required a huge amount of spiritual energy, but Jaehwan's actual Spirit Power was only at the level of a Non-Adapter.

'It's impossible to achieve without at least reaching the 10th stage.'

Adapters, when they reached the 10th stage, learned a power skill called [Infinite Circuit] that allowed them to have an infinite amount of spiritual power. But Awakeners were able to wield such power at just the beginning of the 3rd step. It seemed to work differently from [Infinite Circuit], but it was the same in regards to being allowed to use Spirit Power infinitely.

Cayman did not hesitate with his choice. He knew he couldn't increase his stage any further. But becoming an Awakener was possible with Jaehwan as his support.

"If I can become powerful enough to fight against those Lords, I will do whatever it takes."

"Good."

With the first volunteer decided, the other Leaders became uncertain.

'What if I try and fail...'

The thoughts of the Leaders were so obvious that it was even shameful. Chunghuh frowned at such a sight. That was when Ryung asked, "Mind if I ask you a question?"

"Go on."

"The method that you will use for us to become 'Awakened'. Is it proven?"

The leaders turned to Jaehwan.

"It's not proven."

All the leaders, excluding Cayman, were shaken by those words.

"And you want us to take that treacherous path?"

"I, who only lived for 50 years, have walked that treacherous path. Are you saying you cannot?"

Ryung couldn't answer. Jaehwan continued, "I know the dangers and that's why I'm giving you an option. If you go into the [Depth], there will be worse things waiting for you. Isn't that right, old man?"

"The Master is correct." Chunghuh answered from a distance.

"With your level, you can't even pass the Dead Man Palace at the entrance."

Dead Man Palace.

The residence of the Sole King Catastrophe and full of Large Dead Men.

"If we succeed, how strong can we become?"

It was Meng who asked.

"If you succeed, you will become as powerful as me."

"...Is that true?"

"Yes," Jaehwan answered. Jaehwan had the power to defeat Magrit and open a way into a wave of Dead Men. He was the one who had the power of a Lesser General of the [Great Lands].

"But the percentage of you succeeding is not high. My guess is...."

"It would be a miracle if even one of you succeeds."

Chunghuh interrupted.

"I know the girl spoke of the [Great Disappearance] and all, but even [Rupture] failed at creating more Awakeners. Their project had a 0.01% chance of success. Even then, most of them died."

It seemed like Chunghuh knew it very well. It was nothing surprising as Chunghuh had lived for a thousand years and must have known about what happened seven hundred years ago.

"Even so, we want you to try to become Awakeners to have at least a chance of surviving the expedition."

The leaders became deep in thought. It was Ryung who spoke again.

"But I'm sure there's another way to become powerful. I believe a 9th stage Adapter is as powerful as a 3rd step Awakener."

Chunghuh frowned.

"Girl, aren't you smart? Yes, you are right. But the question is, how will you become the 9th stage when you are only at the 7th?"

"That's not my problem to worry about."

Ryung looked at Jaehwan.

"Well, we have solved the 'time' problem. Let me ask you the second question."

"Go on."

"How are you going to increase the stage of Adaptation?"

It was a straightforward question. Awakening was an entirely different story. The question remained on how Jaehwan would help the Adapters increase their stages.

"I heard that you Adapters require new skills or a good amount of rating in learning the truth to move on."

"Right. It's not just some new skill. It has to be the best of the best."

Jaehwan answered, "I have that solved also."

"...And what is that precisely? Have you prepared top-grade skill books or something?"

Top-grade skills were impossible to get unless from the Lords or Renowned families of the [Great Lands]. The Leaders gathered here only had about three of those skills at maximum because of that reason.

"It doesn't have to be a skill book. You can learn from a teacher."

Teacher? Ryung frowned. Skills could be taught, but there was no one who would dare teach their top-grade skills. And there was no one powerful enough to teach the Leaders of the Ten-Clan.

"Who would dare to teach us?"

"They are here."

Ryung glanced around, expecting to see some powerful individuals. However, there was no one else other than them.

"Wait, are you saying you will teach us?"

"No."

"Then, who..."

Realization suddenly struck Ryung as she froze. It was obvious at that point. Jaehwan nodded.

"You will learn skills from each other. All of you will teach."

Chapter 69: Triad Meeting (5)

It had been three days since the leaders of the Ten-Clan started training in [CarpEDIEM]. The Leaders were divided into two groups, the 'Adapter' team and 'Awakener' team. The Adapter team stayed on the first floor to train, while the Awakener team moved to the newly-built second floor to train. The one leading the Adapter team was the 8th stage Adapter Mukeuk. He sighed as he watched the Leaders teaching each other their skills while cursing non-stop.

'I hope Master knows what he's doing.'

The idea of having the Leaders teach each other was great on paper, but when the actual training began, the Leaders were too busy boasting about how their own skill was the best of all.

"Are you insulting the skill of the Divine Lady Clan?"

"Hah! You can't still be faster than my Thunder God skill!"

"Speed doesn't matter! It's all about power! And power means me, the Fire King!"

Mukeuk frowned as he watched the Leaders squabble.

'Fools... that's why you are still weak.'

The only one who was putting in any actual effort was Jagel Meng. He started out in the Awakener team but came down and was having quick success.

"Mukeuk, how long have you been training this skill? It's killing me."

"400 years."

The skill Meng was practicing was Mukeuk's Thousand Sword of the Sky. It was one of the most powerful skills in [Chaos]. It wasn't close to the skills of 9th stage Adapters or higher, but it was still one of the strongest.

"This is still doable compared to being in the Awakener team," Meng said as he kept on practicing. The Adapter team didn't start out with so many members. Even with Ryung's concerns, it was the Awakener team who had more volunteers when they started. Four of the six leaders volunteered for the Awakener team. However, even before a day in [Chaos] had passed, three of them had given up on the Awakener team. Meng was one of them.

"It's crazy up there."

In an empty space with nothing, there was only the movement of a blade. Accurate, repeated movement. An old man was repeating the same stab, over and over again.

"Cayman, speed it up."

Cayman's sword sped up at Jaehwan's order. He had been doing this countless times. Even though Cayman had tremendous amounts of Spirit Power, it was too much to handle.

After a while, Cayman grew fatigued and asked. "Can I really become strong with such a way?"

"You still ask?"

"..."

"You should know the answer to that by now."

He was right. Cayman had surpassed the 1st step of Awakening a while ago. Cayman couldn't forget the day he stepped into the changing world. He was shocked after he gained the keyword [Suspicion]. It was thanks to Jaehwan who prevented him from going mad from such an abrupt and violent change. Cayman remembered Chunghuh's words.

-Trust him. When it comes to Awakening, he is better than me.

Jaehwan asked, "Are you still worried that you will not become as powerful as the other Adapters?"

"...Yes." Cayman answered. "I know I do not have what it takes."

Cayman remembered the other Leaders downstairs. They might have already gotten close to the 8th stage by now.

"...Do you believe I have what it takes?"

"I do."

From the beginning, Jaehwan believed that Cayman would be the first Awakener. Unlike the others who were blessed with the 'Over-Adapting' talent, Cayman purely lived with his own effort. The core aspect of bringing one to the Awakening was that effort. Cayman was the best at this.

"So, you must believe me."

Cayman nodded and got back to stabbing again. The new world was waiting for him.

Deep into the night, in a tower within the inner keep of Gorgon, a woman with a chain on her waist was sitting at the edge of the tower. She was the one Jaehwan was wary of during the tournament.

"Hah, beer tastes good here."

The woman took a sip from her bottle as she stretched her leg out over the ledge. Her cheeks were flushed. It was weird. The dead of [Chaos] could not become drunk, but the woman seemed to be drunk. She was looking down at the bottom, at the weird building in the courtyard behind the keep. She laughed.

"Carpediem, eh?"

As she watched, a few Leaders came out of the building, took the medicine made from the horned monsters, and went back into the building quickly. It seemed like they were really in a hurry.

"Hah, they really think something can really change."

No one answered. But she spoke anyway.

"So, is that your new hope?"

This time, an answer came from the dark. It was the cold voice of an old man.

"Surha... what are you up to?"

"Aren't you being a bit too cold? How about a warmer greeting for an old friend?"

Surha glanced back. It was Chunghuh, the Doctor of Despair.

"Long time no see, Teacher."

"I'm not your teacher anymore."

"Oooh, cold."

"Why are you here?"

"It's business."

Chunghuh frowned. "I told you, I have no intention of returning to [Rupture]."

"Okay, okay. Relax. You're scary when you get serious, you know." Surha cackled and took another sip. "You want some too?"

"No."

"Wow, really? You love beer and women, don't you?"

Chunghuh did not answer. "How is 'he'?"

"Oh, 'he' is doing well. He still talks about you."

"Don't lie."

" I miss you too."

"Another lie."

"Haha, yeah. That's a lie."

Surha smiled. But her eyes weren't smiling at all.

"But still, come back Teacher. Everyone's waiting for you."

Chapter 70: Triad Meeting (6)

"I am not going back."

"Why?"

"I cannot stay together with you non-humans."

Surha raised her eyebrows. "You always say that."

"[Rupture] abandoned humanity."

"No, that's not true. We fight for humanity. Only we fight for humanity."

"Wrong. You use humans as your tools. [Rupture] is done for after the Great Disappearance. You have no purpose or goals anymore."

"Hmph."

Surha became silent and then continued, "But you are in no place to say that."

Her voice contained traces of anger as she continued, "You were the one of those who planned the Great Disappearance."

"...That is not true."

"Well, it didn't work out the way you intended, but you didn't stop it. No, you just watched it happen."

"..."

"Still, I thank you for that. I'm here because of you."

Chunghuh did not answer but stared at Surha's face. There was a young girl who was the survivor of the Great Disappearance in his memory.

"Oh, and did you know that there are still some who try to become Awakeners with the method you taught? They are kids who have no talent or background."

"..."

"They kill each other, again and again, only to become stronger."

"..."

"And after killing hundreds of their friends, they forget the reason why they were trying to become strong. And after more killing and swinging swords, they forget who they are. Only a tiny amount of them survive. That's when they get the first keyword [Disassemble]."

"...That was the wrong keyword."

"You still say that? What do you know about Awakeners when you aren't even one?"

"I know because I have seen those who have achieved the 3rd step with the method I taught."

"No, you don't. You are a coward."

The world around Chunghuh began to turn white. It was his own world. It was a threat.

"You and your world are still the same." Surha spoke sarcastically. "You're too scared to even draw anything in your newly-made world."

At that moment, thousands of lightning bolts rained down, destroying Chunghuh's world. It was Surha's world taking over. Chunghuh smelled the distinct smell of blood from all around.

There were mountains of corpses and blood.

Chunghuh knew where this world was derived from. It was from the place of the Great Disappearance.

"How do you like my world? It's the outcome of your teachings."

Chunghuh took a step back. He had taken huge amounts of damage just through the destruction of his world. Chunghuh gritted his teeth.

"I heard you became a captain. Are you at the 3rd step now?"

"3rd? Do you think I'm just at the 3rd?"

Powerful energy began pressuring Chunghuh, forcing him to kneel. His face turned pale. Surha's power had indeed passed the 3rd step.

"Teacher, you shouldn't pretend you're a dead one when you are not. Come back to [Rupture]."

"..."

"You know too well that nothing can be changed in [Chaos]. Even if you go into the [Depth], or hell, or get to the top of Tree of Imagery, this world will not change."

Chunghuh turned to Surha at those words.

"It can change."

"What?"

"This world can change."

Surha frowned. But at that moment, a man appeared from the weird building. Surha quickly deactivated her world. It was Jaehwan who had appeared. He walked up to the control panel to manage the time scale. He then glanced for a second at the place where Surha and Chunghuh were and then walked back into the tower.

"Is it him?"

"..."

"Did he change you?"

Chunghuh did not answer. He quietly rose up and said, "Give me that beer."

Surha handed over the bottle and Chunghuh began drinking. They didn't say a word, but Surha could read Chunghuh's expression. She couldn't believe there was something still left in Chunghuh to make him change this much.

"Let me ask you again. Why are you here?"

"To kill you."

Chunghuh looked at Surha. She was a woman with no emotion.

"Then do it."

"No, I changed my mind."

Surha turned towards Carpediem.

"I think it will get interesting."

"...Are you trying to interfere with our plan?"

"Interfere?" Surha scoffed. "You will fail. Just like how you failed 900 years ago in [Chaos], and 700 years ago in the [Great Lands]."

"No."

It was a firm but definitive answer. Surha, the 2nd Captain of [Rupture], couldn't accept how the old man who had felt despair more than anyone in a thousand years had found new hope.

"[Rupture] will have eyes on you all."

Then she disappeared. Chunghuh was left alone with the bottle of beer left by Surha.

"...This is good beer."

Cayman couldn't guess how much time had passed since he started training. But after continuous stabbing and countless duels with Jaehwan, he reached it. After passing through the 2nd keyword [Understanding], he had arrived at the 3rd step. His spirit was reborn. He couldn't remember how many times he stabbed, but he had now reached it. He had succeeded in creating his own world.

"Congratulations."

Jaehwan was in front of him as he opened his eyes. He then felt the unfathomable power of Jaehwan that he couldn't feel before.

'I can't even measure how strong he is.'

According to Chunhuh, Jaehwan was also a 3rd step Awakener. However, Cayman knew there was a huge wall between Jaehwan and himself. Cayman was unsure as to how strong he had become.

"Did I really become stronger?"

"Yes."

"But two years is not enough time to..."

"Two years? Do you really think it has only been two years?"

Cayman became confused.

"The 2nd floor has a different time scale than the 1st floor."

"T-then how many years has passed?"

Jaehwan did not answer the question but instead tapped on Cayman's shoulder.

"It's time to test out your power."

Chapter 71: Triad Meeting (7)

People were gathered in the courtyard where Carpediem was located. They were the officers and employees of Gorgon Fortress. Among them was Euren who was waiting at the door of Carpediem.

'It's today.'

It was the day Jaehwan and the other people would return from their week of training. People were curious as to how powerful they had become. It was only a week, but they knew that two years had passed within the tower. It wasn't short, but it was still long. They also had Jaehwan, their monstrous Master, with them.

'Well, we have the 'Triad Meeting' today.'

Triad Meeting.

That was the name of the event that would happen today where all the fortresses, except Manticore would gather at Gorgon for a meeting. However, it wasn't Gorgon that wanted to have the meeting.

'Master is absent at the moment.'

It seemed that the other Masters targeted this specific moment when Jaehwan was occupied within Carpediem to have the meeting. The stated purpose was to talk about how to deal with the Manticore Fortress and the Golden Sky Clan, but the real reason was obvious.

'They want to talk about the Depth Expedition Team.'

It was the first time in 900 years that [Chaos] had such a powerful group. There were six of the Ten-Clan and two Awakeners. With some

preparations, it was a group that had the power to even unite the entire [Chaos] if they wanted.

Euren tried his best to postpone the meeting, but the other fortresses kept pushing the matter.

-The peace of the entire [Chaos] is at risk! We cannot postpone it any further!

'Master... you must return quickly.'

And it was today. Euren, Karlton, Claire, Meikal, and a lot of other officials gathered at the gate of Carpediem. Some seemed to be excited but some were concerned, like Euren. However, they all had the same thought. They wanted Jaehwan to return to them, and lead them through this dire time.

The small door of the courtyard opened, and some of the gatekeepers running in. The one in the front called out to Euren.

"Chancellor!"

Euren realized what had happened right away. It was the arrival of the Masters. Just then, the gate of Carpediem also began to shine. The Leaders were back.

Training grounds of Gorgon Keep was now filled with the vicious aura of two groups of warriors glaring at each other. Euren frowned as he thought.

'Why has it come to this?'

It all started with Kanghwang.

"So, you mean you cannot accept our Master as the leader of the Depth Expedition Team?"

In the meeting room inside the keep, Kanghwang stood up, slamming the desk in the middle of the Triad Meeting.

"No- we are just saying..."

"Bullshit! I know exactly what you are saying."

Then, Yong also shouted angrily as he stood up abruptly.

"Fair selection of the leader of the team? Where were you when we first started the team?!"

"Mind your manners!"

"Manners in your !@# \$!"

Yong was enraged, but so were the other Leaders. The members of Dryad and Garuda were saying that:

-The current Depth Expedition Team's organization is too fragile.

-We cannot have a person not from [Chaos] be the leader.

-The current leader is an unidentifiable person.

-Gorgon alone cannot create the expedition team! It breaches the Four Fortress Agreement!

Whatever they said was not related to the original purpose of how to deal with the Golden Sky Clan. Euren knew the meeting would turn toward this topic, but he could only scowl.

"Let's all relax and go back to our original discussion..."

Euren tried to calm things down, but it was the claim made by the Master of Garuda that brought it to the limit.

"I'll just talk frankly. I suggest we choose the leader of the Depth Expedition Team with more careful and fair consideration from all sides."

Euren was shocked to hear this from Huidon the Cold Blood of Garuda Fortress.

'This is weird. He's not the type to say such rash things.'

Garuda Fortress was having a hard time against Golden Sky as they were the next target after Manticore. This brought about questions as Garuda should be focused on dealing with Golden Sky rather than the Depth Expedition Team at the moment. Euren glanced at him.

'Was the Golden Sky problem solved?'

That was the only possible explanation. However, Golden Sky was the most powerful organization within [Chaos] at the moment, and Golden Sky already had its headquarter within Garuda. It didn't seem to make sense.

"I don't agree with the Master of Garuda, but he still has a point."

Aisa Lindcroft, the number one beauty of [Chaos], agreed with Huidon. Euren moaned. He had suspected such a topic from the beginning, but he didn't think the two Masters would cooperate like this.

'I can't let them continue any further!'

However, before Euren could speak, Aisa turned to Euren. She hadn't finished yet.

"Also, it's weird that we do not have the Master of Gorgon in his seat. Where is he right now?"

Euren couldn't answer. Gorgon Fortress was obliged to have its Master present at the meeting. This was the biggest problem of the meeting.

'Master... why are you still not coming out?'

Everyone from the Adapter team had returned, but Jaehwan, Cayman, and Chunghuh were still not out. That was why the meeting topic had been swayed heavily by Garuda and Dryad, making the members of the Expedition Team outraged.

And that was how the current incident happened.

Kanghwang pulled out his sword, pointing it at the Master of Garuda.

So it came down to this. Two forces glaring at each other. The Master of Dryad looked at the Leaders on the side of Gorgon and warned them.

"...[Chaos] is in a dire situation as it is. This is not a wise decision."

"Dryad, it is inevitable."

It was Huidon the Cold Blood, who answered her. "We will not have 'some kid' take over [Chaos]."

"Some kid?! Did you just say that?" Kanghwang took a step forward.

"I too, have a problem with that word." Jagel Meng also spoke. Euren felt a bit weird to see those Leaders who had opposed Jaehwan just a week ago change this much.

'But they are very powerful... the training was successful.'

Euren was astonished at the Leaders. Even Yong, who was weakest among them, was now emanating with powerful energy.

"If you want to change the leader, then you will have to do it over my dead body."

Yong also stepped forward, drawing his sword. Then, Huidon took a step forward from the opposing side.

Huidon, an 8th stage Adapter.

He was too powerful an enemy for Yong, who was only at the 6th stage. Yong, however, did not back down.

"Why don't you start?"

When Yong's sword moved, Huidon was shocked. Countless lightning bolts struck him from all sides. It was a power that not possible from a 6th stage.

'7th stage!'

It was just a week, but Yong had reached the 7th stage within that timeframe.

"Hah! It's not enough!"

Huidon was at the 8th stage. He still had the power to overpower four 7th stage Adapters at the same time. He quickly used his skill to destroy Yong's lightning and Yong took a step back. Then, Yong's sword erupted in fire. Huidon was shocked yet again.

"Fire King Sword?"

Eighteen Swords of the Fire King

The skill that had power close to Huidon's skill was now being activated by Yong. What was shocking was that the owner of the skill was originally Kanghwang, not Yong.

'...They taught their skills to each other!'

Huidon realized how Yong had achieved the 7th stage in such a short period of time.

'But it was still only a week! It's not enough!'

However, Yong fought on. He then began using skills from Jagel Meng, as well as the others. When Yong began focusing energy at the tip of his blade, Huidon became pale. He knew who the owner of this skill was.

Mukeuk's Thousand Sword of Sky. Huidon knew he couldn't defend against the skill.

'Do I really need to use it?'

The tattoo on his arm which had the shape of a white bird, began to flash.

"STOP!"

A powerful voice containing Spirit Power reverberated within the training ground. Yong and Huidon stopped. It was Mukeuk.

"Huidon, are you trying to use Guardian Horn?"

"..."

"Guardian Horn is not to be used for such a reason."

It was a much-needed interference. Yong would surely have lost if Huidon had summoned the Guardian Horn Garuda.

"...I lost."

Huidon gritted his teeth as he admitted his defeat.

"Next is me!"

"No, it's me!"

Kanghwang and Meng spoke. However, they stopped as someone stepped out from the crowd.

"Let's make this quick."

It was Mukeuk, the most powerful Adapter if they excluded Jaehwan and Chunghuh. Everyone took a step back. Mukeuk turned to Garuda and Dryad and asked, "Who will face me? Huidon? Or you, Aisa?"

Huidon grimaced while Aisa became silent. They knew they could not defeat Mukeuk. He was, after all, most powerful being in one-on-one combat in [Chaos] until now. Then, someone moved.

"...Ryung? What is the meaning of this?"

Ryung had jumped into the center.

"Are you going to face me?"

"Me? Oh no, of course not."

Ryung smiled and quickly moved across to the Dryads' side. Meng frowned and asked, "What are you doing?"

"I'm changing sides, as you can see."

"Changing sides?"

It was not understandable. Even if she was originally from Dryad Fortress and was friends with Aisa, there was no chance for her to win.

"I think the chance of winning is higher on this side."

"I know you don't like the current Team Leader." Meng said, "But you know how powerful Mukeuk is. There's no chance."

"No, I don't think so."

Before Meng could continue, someone entered the training ground from outside. The man walked past Dryad and Garuda into the center of the training ground.

"Mukeuk, I will be the one to face you."

It was a handsome middle-aged man. However, some of the Leaders were shocked at the sight of the man. Even Mukeuk was surprised to see him.

"You...!"

Euren realized how the whole Triad Meeting had come to be. It wasn't Garuda or Dryad who planned it from the beginning.

He had suspected that there was someone behind them. It was weird for Garuda and Dryad, who had really a bad relationship, to work together against Gorgon. There was only one force powerful enough to save Garuda from Golden Sky, to have Dryad at its feet and come all the way to Gorgon.

'Master, it's the worst case scenario.'

A Spirit Power so powerful that it could only be from a 'General', was storming throughout the training ground.

Chapter 72: Triad Meeting (8)

Aisa Lindcroft looked at the hall with a burdened expression. She did not like this situation one bit.

'Have I made the right choice?'

She glanced at the woman who appeared along with the man. She had visited Aisa a while ago as a messenger from the [Great Lands].

-The Master of Gorgon is more dangerous than the Golden Sky. He is planning to unify [Chaos] with his Depth Expedition Team.

Her name was Hyeyoung. She was an Adapter who worked for the Lord of Steel of the [Great Lands].

-The Lord has named him as a 'Threat Point'.

A potential threat. One that would bring change to [Chaos]. Every Threat Point appearance had brought hope to [Chaos], but the result of that hope was more despair. Aisa knew this very well, as she had lived for 970 years.

-We must get rid of him or [Chaos] will be disrupted.

After Mulack was appointed as a 1st class Threat Point, hundreds died. Aisa had not forgotten.

'We can't repeat that tragedy.'

Euren frowned.

'It was the Lord of Steel...!'

There was no way that Masters would be this rude to the Depth Expedition Team that was comprised of mostly Clan Leaders. Euren looked at the woman named Hyeyoung. Euren knew a lot about her. After the tournament was over, Hyeyoung had directly contacted Euren. She offered to help with the Golden Sky Clan, but Jaehwan had rejected her offer.

-[Chaos] does not require help from the Lords.

Hyeyoung left Gorgon immediately, and it seemed that she had gone to Dryad and Garuda next. The Lord of Steel changed his target immediately as Jaehwan did not bow to his will. That was the course of events that had led to the Triad Meeting.

"It's been a long time, Mukeuk." The man spoke. "How about a hello to an old friend?"

"Bang Chunir."

Mukeuk knew the man well. He was one of the Generals that stood in front of the Depth Expedition Team 900 years ago. One of the Generals who killed countless spirits and stole the [Fruit].

Pearl General Bang Chunir. That was his name in the [Great Lands]. Mukeuk drew his sword.

"You dare return to [Chaos] after what you did?"

"Are you still bitter about that?"

Chunir shook his head. "It was 900 years ago. We're both from Moorim. How about some understanding, hmm?"

Chunir was the one who cleared [Mobydick], along with Mukeuk and Chunghuh. He reached the 9th stage and became a General.

"Same... Moorim, you said?"

Mukeuk growled. "You betrayed Moorim and dare say that?"

"Huhyou forgave easily. But you don't seem to be doing that."

Mukeuk frowned at those words.

"Wait. You now work for the Lord of Steel?"

"Yes."

"...I'm disappointed in Huhyou."

"Well, our Lord loves people from Moorim."

Chunir spoke while smiling, and turned serious all of a sudden. "The Lord wants you back, old friend."

"Friend?" Mukeuk suddenly moved. "You are no friend of mine!"

His sword flew at Chunir.

"Mukeuk, you cannot defeat me. You know this."

"Shut up!"

However, his attack was easily blocked. The difference between the 8th and 9th stage was too great.

This 9th stage Adapter was a Lesser General.

"HAAAAAAA!"

Mukeuk could not defeat Chunir 900 years ago. He had worked so hard to get revenge, but Mukeuk still could not overcome the 9th stage barrier. However, he couldn't give up now.

The two fought. Mukeuk tried his best and soon became fatigued but Chunir still seemed relaxed. After some time, Mukeuk's sword changed. It was his final attack, the most powerful of his skills, that was unleashed at his 900-year-old nemesis.

Yet the power was destroyed by the energy shield from Chunir. It even went beyond defending, as it released energy that swept away all the others on the training ground.

Mukeuk was barely standing. The other Leaders stood up, but their confidence was shaken. This was the power of a Lesser General. Not even a Greater General, or Commander, or one of the twelve Lords.

Was this the enemy they needed to face?

Euren shook. He thought even the Master had no chance against such power. Were they dreaming of the Depth Expedition Team when they could not even defeat that one man?

"You cannot defeat me." Chunir spoke. "False hope only gives you greater despair."

Mukeuk knelt. He had lost the strength to stand. Then, the door to the training ground opened. A ragged man was walking into the center. Chunir asked Hyeyoung, "...Is he the Master?"

"No."

The man went to the Leaders and spoke softly. "I'm late."

"Cayman."

Euren brightened as he was helped up.

"W-what of the Master?"

"He will be a bit late."

Late? Why would he be late? The Depth Expedition Team was at the brink of destruction. Cayman smiled, and clasped Euren's shoulder.

"It's okay."

Euren then felt something strange. Cayman's hand felt like Jaehwan's.

'Is he really the Cayman I know?'

Cayman was now a different man. He moved to the center and helped Mukeuk up.

"Cayman."

"Stand back. I'll handle him from now on."

"You can't fight him... he's too..."

"Don't worry."

The Leaders ran to help Mukeuk out as Cayman turned to Chunir.

"Long time no see, Pearl General."

"You look familiar."

"Yes. We meet again after 900 years."

"900 years? Oh, I see."

Chunir then scoffed. "You're the kid from 900 years ago."

"You are right."

"You're the kid who couldn't even join the Expedition Team 900 years ago!"

"That is also correct."

Cayman didn't bother one bit with Chunir's sarcasm. He looked very relaxed.

'He's okay against my pressure?'

Chunir asked as he increased the pressure on Cayman. "So, I guess you've been training? Seeing how you're trying to fight me."

Chapter 73: Triad Meeting (9)

"I tried."

"I don't feel much from you though."

"You will see once you fight me."

Chunir then frowned. "Good! Then we shall fight!"

Chunir charged immediately and Cayman moved. It was a speed that wasn't even visible. Chunir was shocked that Cayman could dodge his attack, so he used more serious skills against Cayman.

"Cayman! NO!" Mukeuk shouted. Chunir was using a top-grade skill that Cayman couldn't possibly withstand.

"It's finished!"

Chunir's attack approached but Cayman's sword moved weirdly. Chunir frowned.

[Stab]?

It was a stab. Cayman's stab collided against Chunir's attack. The result was unexpected, to say the least. Cayman took a step back, but Chunir had to take three steps back.

"...What is that skill?"

"It's [Harsh Stab]."

Cayman explained. "It's stronger than [Normal Stab] but weaker than [Strong Stab]."

"Are you kidding me?"

A mere stab containing such power? It was impossible. That was when something clicked in Chunir's mind.

"You- you're an Awakener?"

The Leaders brightened up.

"I see! Cayman finally..."

Chunir then spoke again.

"I didn't know there was another Awakener other than the Master and the Doctor."

"You better do your best," Cayman said. "Because you will die by my hands."

"Die? To you?"

Cayman nodded.

"Yes. You will die here."

Then, enormous energy exploded from Chunir's body. It was an energy that exceeded everyone else's combined on this training ground. Some of the crowd couldn't withstand it and even fainted.

"WITH YOUR PUNY POWER?! YOU DARE TO KILL ME?!"

He activated his extra-grade skills [Torn Depth] and [Torn Sky] at once. They were powerful skills that would destroy everything within a hundred-yard radius. The power made even Cayman hesitant.

'Do I have what it takes?'

Cayman had spoken confidently, but he was still not in a perfect state. His insides were boiling with an uncertain fire after he became an Awakener. He felt like he had become a small child. He was filled with the hope that he could do anything, but was also filled with the despair that he would fail at everything.

'Master ived in such turmoil?'

However, Cayman knew how to overcome this anxiety. Jaehwan had taught him. Cayman closed his eyes.

Humans cannot exist without a world.

A human that is out of the world of numbers and data would wane and die. That was why many Awakeners had killed themselves. But those that reached the 3rd step acquired their own 'world' to fight against the 'Adapter's world'.

That was the 'Unique World'.

When Cayman opened his eyes again, he was standing in the middle of a sea. The vast region of the sea that he lived in for 900 years. That was his 'Unique World'.

"What is this...!"

Chunir became dumbfounded. A giant wave moved together with Cayman's sword and attacked Chunir.

"This isn't enough!"

Chunir's attack collided against the wave, but he was damaged. Then, something that resembled a giant light struck Chunir. It was Jaehwan's most powerful skill that was to be used against a huge army. [Strong Stab].

Cayman wasn't used to using it, so he became dizzy after using it once.

'Again!'

Cayman stabbed again. He saw Chunir's body being torn in between his waves.

-You should attend the Triad Meeting alone.

-But there may be someone too strong for me to handle.

-It's okay. Believe in yourself.

Cayman was deep in his trance as he kept on stabbing. It was a shocking but wonderful experience.

"KAAAAAAAAA!"

The powerful Lesser General was dying. Suddenly, another person appeared through the waves. It was Ryung. She used her assassination skill on Cayman, which he deflected with his finger.

"I see. Master did tell me that it was about time for you to betray us. He wants me to teach you a lesson."

Ryung shouted in anger. "Even if you have become strong, you cannot be so strong in just two years..."

"Two years?" Cayman laughed.

"What's so funny?!"

Cayman did not answer. Chunir was attacking him yet again with his dying breath. A giant wave of energy was coming at him. But Cayman was recalling what Jaehwan said to him.

-You have trained hundreds of times more than the other Leaders.

-What?

-You have been stabbing for two hundred years.

Cayman then thrust his sword. It wasn't because he believed in himself. He believed in Jaehwan.

-You can do it.

And with that came the attack.

[Twisting Kill]

The skill that Jaehwan and Chunghuh created, and Cayman had named. It destroyed the skill from Chunir and destroyed his body as well as Ryung's. The entire training ground was destroyed and people were left groaning while covering their ears. After a while, the dust clouds settled and people moaned.

Chunir was lying on the ground, turning into a silvery powder.

They had won...

The person they never thought they could defeat, had been defeated.

Yong became teary and Kanghwang smiled. Jagel Meng was excited. Even Mukeuk seemed like he was overwhelmed with thought. His long-awaited revenge had just taken a step forward.

Cayman then understood why the Master sent him alone. The Depth Expedition Team had been relying on Jaehwan too much. That needed to be fixed.

[Chaos] must stand alone.

And that day, [Chaos] had become victorious against the Lords for the first time in history.

Chapter 74: War of Revival (1)

The Triad Meeting ended with Gorgon Fortress emerging as the victor. The news of what happened spread quickly through an associate journalist of [Chaos of this Month] who was present in Gorgon at that time.

Aisa Lindcroft felt like it was weird to be in another Master's office.

'So, this is the Gorgon Master's office.'

The room only had a table, a few chairs, and some bookcases.

'It only has the essentials.'

She was now being held in Gorgon as a hostage. However, not all were given bad treatment. To be fair, Aisa Lindcroft was the only one who was considered an official diplomat. After the meeting was over, Cayman talked to her before she was arrested. After a long talk, Aisa spoke.

-Cayman, if you truly believe him, I'll reconsider.

Aisa thought it was due to Cayman's kindness that she was treated differently. Later, she found out it was because she was the only one who changed her mind, which resulted in her better treatment.

'But I can't blame them.'

Aisa sighed as she saw the cover of [Chaos of this Month] on the table.

-SHOCKING! Pearl Lord of the 5th region LOST! Cayman of the Southern Sea Clan is the VICTOR!

-New Awakener? What is happening to [Chaos]?

The people who came with her knew how terrifying Lords were. Even if Cayman defeated a Lesser General, it wasn't enough. Aisa had the same thought, but she was curious.

'What made them change?'

Cayman had fond memories of the Depth Expedition Team, but Aisa never thought Cayman would really join.

Creating the Depth Expedition Team meant that they would fight against the Palace of Reincarnation.

If Cayman had thought of joining the expedition, then he should have already stormed the Palace of Reincarnation. However, Cayman had not done that in the last 900 years.

"Cayman, are you really going to fight 'them'?"

Could a man who had lived for 900 years change? Aisa, who had lived for 970 years, couldn't answer.

"Yes."

Cayman had changed. She used to know Cayman well, as his Southern Sea Clan used to reside in Dryad Fortress. Cayman was always the one who was envious of the other Clan Leaders. He was the one who felt like it was unfair at the difference in strength and talent. But, there was no longer any trace of that in Cayman.

"The Palace of Reincarnation is nothing like the Golden Sky Clan."

Cayman did not budge. Aisa knew he had the face of someone who was ready to fight. What gave him such hope? She had witnessed Cayman defeating the [Great Lands] Lesser General. Yet she and Cayman both knew that the Lesser General wasn't the strongest in the [Great Lands]. He was, in fact, the weakest of the Lesser Generals.

"We ran, 900 years ago. We can't do that again."

She then saw some Leaders from the 'Adapter' team log into the tower along with the new members. Karlton was included in those new members. Aisa became shocked. The way they disappeared looked exactly like when people were summoned into the Tower of Nightmares.

"You were [Cultivating] here?"

"[Cultivate]... I guess you can look at it that way." Cayman smiled. "That's not [Cultivation]."

"But that's the Tower of Nightmares..."

"No one becomes a [Product] in that tower. There's no [Cultivator]."

A Tower without a [Cultivator]. Aisa was too shocked to even think.

'So Cayman became so strong because...'

There were countless people who were entering the tower now. Aisa realized there were regular citizens who were also going in.

"[Chaos] will stand on its own now." Cayman answered. The ones who had been summoned into the tower unwillingly were now going into the tower with a purpose. Aisa noticed a man and he seemed terrified by the bad memory of the place.

'He's so afraid and yet..'

But the man did not stop. No one did. They all walked into the tower, even though it wasn't forced. They were choosing to do this.

'...To choose.'

Aisa looked at the man closely. He did not give up. And when the control panel moved, the man frowned. Aisa knew what he was seeing. There was no one in [Chaos] who would not know that damn message. The man mumbled, and he was instantly engulfed by light. When he disappeared, he was not terrified anymore.

'I see. They decided to believe in themselves again.'

When was the last time they had a choice? All of them knew. Even if they spoke of 'freedom', their true freedom had been taken away 900 years ago. And this freedom was only going to be given to them if they sought after it.

Aisa became curious about the man who had given this 'freedom' to [Chaos].

"...Where's the Master of Gorgon?"

In the wide desert region, Manticore Fortress.

Chunghuh panted as he ran.

"...Let's slow down."

They did not slow down.

"How far are we going to run?"

They had not used any teleportation station up until now. Teleportation left a trace and it had the potential danger of leaking information, which might sabotage their plans. That was what Jaehwan thought.

"The meeting is probably over by now."

"Yeah."

"Are you sure you don't have to go? They probably brought a really strong one."

"Cayman should have done well."

"Hah! He's a puny little-"

"He's stronger than you now."

"NO WAY! He should live at least 100 years more to beat me!" Chunghuh shouted. "I was an Awakener even before he was born!"

"But you started from scratch this time too."

"Yeah, but..."

Chunghuh's voice grew softer. Jaehwan was right. Chunghuh intended to throw away everything he had and he had successfully gained new keyword from Jaehwan.

"But I didn't ask."

Jaehwan turned to Chunghuh.

"Why did you start over? Weren't you right before the 3rd step?"

"Because my way was wrong."

"So, a different keyword brings you to a different path?"

"...Did you know?"

"I knew you were looking at the world differently."

The path of awakening that Jaehwan had taken was different.

[Suspicion] that led to [Understanding] that led to Awakening.

Chunghuh was an Awakener, but he wasn't suspicious, neither did he understand the world.

Chapter 75: War of Revival (2)

Chunghuh's understanding of Awakening wasn't that deep. All Awakeners of [Rupture] had acquired [Disassemble] as the keyword and gained [Assemble] as the 2nd keyword and reached Awakening in the end. Disassembly did not ask questions and assembly did not think. It didn't require much thinking at all. But the path that Jaehwan walked was full of thought. It constantly continued to question even after acquiring the unique world.

They stopped running after an hour. It was a rest area with an oasis. There were some merchants resting, glancing at Jaehwan and Chunghuh.

"Let's take a break here."

Jaehwan sat down by the oasis, took something out from his pocket, and threw it to Chunghuh.

"What is this?"

"Food."

Jaehwan answered and ripped the jerky apart. It was the dried meat of a horned monster.

"Doesn't eating make you feel 'alive'?"

Chunghuh flinched. Jaehwan didn't seem to notice and chewed on the jerky and drank water from the oasis. Chunghuh then began eating too. After he finished all the jerky, Jaehwan was now looking outwards. Chunghuh watched him silently.

After he reached the 3rd step, he was now able to see Jaehwan from a different perspective. He thought he would be able to see how strong Jaehwan was now, but it wasn't true. He couldn't see the limit of his power.

'What about compared to her?'

He thought of Surha, the 2nd Captain of [Rupture]. Chunghuh was now able to guess her power. She was probably at the 4th or 5th step in Awakening. But he wasn't too sure about Jaehwan.

'I can't guess how strong he is.'

Chunghuh had trained about 200 years in the tower. It was a long time that made Chunghuh feel a little strange, but Jaehwan was not with him all those times.

"Kid, let me ask you."

"What."

"How old are you now?"

"...Age again?"

Chunghuh did not answer and continued, "I heard from Meikal."

"What."

"That the 3rd floor was finished." Chunghuh went on. "I know that you were gone from the 2nd floor for tens of years. It was 2 day of time in Chaos."

"..."

"I heard that time on the 3rd floor is 100 times faster in time than the 2nd floor."

Jaehwan was gone for two days from the 2nd floor when the 3rd floor was finished. Where was Jaehwan then? It was so obvious.

"...How many years did you train?"

Jaehwan answered, "Two thousand."

Chunghuh opened his eyes wide in shock.

"A-are you serious?"

"What, will you respect me as an elder now?"

Chunghuh frowned. It was a lie.

"Don't joke around. How long have you been..."

"Not as long as you think."

Jaehwan spoke, but he seemed tired from saying that. Chunghuh did not ask any further. No matter how many years he trained, it was definitely not an easy time. Chunghuh had now known Jaehwan for hundreds of years.

"Ha, you're still a kid even if you lived for two thousand years. I was still born first."

"...You don't change even after two hundred years," Jaehwan answered.

"Let's move."

They both stood up and began to run again. The destination was close. Chunghuh felt the need to reconfirm the reason for coming here.

"Are you really going to the Palace of Reincarnation?"

"Yeah."

"Alone?"

"Not alone. It's the two of us."

Chunghuh still couldn't understand where his confidence was coming from.

"They are not an easy enemy. You don't know the Lord's power yet."

"..."

"It's not too late to gain more power. We can wait until we get more Awakeners."

Jaehwan had not met any 10th stage Adapters yet, but Chunghuh had. He knew how strong they were. Even if Jaehwan was strong, both of them weren't...

"We have no time."

"Time?"

"You think those Lords in the Palace will wait for us?"

If they found out that Awakeners were increasing in number, the Lords would make a move.

"They will think that we will wait until we get enough Awakeners. We should strike when they are not expecting us, when they are not yet ready."

Jaehwan was right. The current Palace should not have readied their defense. There should be some waiting to be revived, but they were probably only at the Lesser General level. Greater Generals rarely died and even if they did, they were revived instantly.

However, if things dragged on, they would change. There was a chance that the Palace of Reincarnation would bring 'living' Generals into [Chaos] to fight. The [Narrow Door] would allow them to travel into [Chaos] without dying, and the Palace was where the door was located. Jaehwan continued, "I'm not trying to fight all of them. I'll just destroy what's most important to them."

The most important things to the Palace. Chunghuh understood immediately.

"You are going to steal the [Fruits]."

Chunghuh was dumbfounded. Steal those [Fruits] again? Was it possible?

"Yeah. And there's one more thing."

One more? Chunghuh became pale.

"...Are you thinking of destroying the [Narrow Door]?"

Jaehwan nodded. "Yeah. If I destroy that, they won't be able to come into [Chaos] anymore."

"...Yeah, if we can destroy it, that is."

Taking all the [Fruits] and destroying the [Narrow Door] would surely block access to all the Lords of the [Great Lands].

"They can come by dying but... I doubt they will do that."

The [Great Lands] was at war. They needed to save the lives of their Generals so they could always fight. No Lords would send their Generals to [Chaos] if there was no way to come back.

However, this was only true if Jaehwan and Chunghuh succeeded in destroying both.

"It's the best method if we can do it. But it's not easy. The Palace is at the far east end of the desert. To go there-"

"We have to go through Manticore Fortress," Jaehwan answered. "That's why we're here."

Manticore was now in front of them. There were tall walls with lion sculptures on top looking down. There were many of them.

Manticore Fortress was much bigger than Gorgon. Chunghuh's expression turned grim. They had become strong, but they were only two against a fortress. They were trying to fight an entire fortress now.

"The Golden Sky Leader won't let us go easily. What are you going to do?"

Then, they noticed guards running towards them. Jaehwan smiled. "As always."

Chunghuh laughed. "Yeah, I thought so."

And Jaehwan's stab struck out against the wall. Chunghuh's slash also struck soon after.

The guards fled as the wall was destroyed.

It was the beginning of the [War of Revival].

Chapter 76: War of Revival (3)

Power that shook the entire fortress was felt in the very depths of Manticore.

"Is that...?"

The new Master of Manticore, Jinong, also felt this. In fact, he was watching the hologram that showed the situation outside of the fortress.

It was a sight of pure violence. Jaehwan was stabbing the wall, destroying it completely.

'It's much stronger than what I heard.'

Jinong knew something had gone wrong when his team of spies, comprised of 6th stage Adapters, were all wiped out. Yet he did manage to acquire some vital information about the Master of Gorgon.

'I didn't imagine it was him.'

Jinong then opened up another screen to check the data sent by the Lord of Darkness. It was a video of a man fighting alone against the Frost Dragon.

-Find me the [Product] that fled from this tutorial.

It was the message that came with the video.

'It's him.'

Jinong blamed himself for not checking the video sent by the Lord of Darkness sooner.

"You seemed troubled, Jinong."

Jinong frowned. He knew the owner of the voice.

"So, I see why the Darkness wants him so badly."

A woman appeared through a dimensional portal. She had tied-up pink hair with a small pair of horns protruding from her hair. She wore a black tank top and short pants. Her clothing wasn't fit for [Chaos].

"How about you wear proper clothing for once?" Jinong said, in which woman scoffed and stared at Jinong's golden robe.

"You wear that old fashioned robe and talk about my clothing?"

"..."

"Gosh, these [Chaos] people are so old fashioned. This isn't your Moorim, you fool."

Jinong's expression turned sour but the woman did not care and continued, "Wow, look at THAT! What skill is that? It's destroying everything."

"..."

"It's so COOOL!"

"...Sirwen, have you come to just make me angry?"

Jinong let out his anger, but it was a calmer version of his usual self. He wasn't in a position to be angry against the woman. She was, in fact, the one who was behind the Golden Sky Clan. She wasn't strong, but there was no one who would dare to oppose her in [Chaos]. It was because she was the rarest race in the [Great Lands].

[Nightmare] Sirwen

And she was the one of 500 [High Artisans] in the [Great Lands].

"I'm just here because I heard something interesting was going on."

She watched the screen for a while and asked, "I heard the Pearl General is here. Have you heard?"

"...Yes."

"Oh? Then you know that he's not really a free agent, right? He lies about it, but he's actually from the 5th region."

Jinong knew this very well. A few days ago, a powerful warrior appeared in the Western Fortress of Garuda and decimated the army that he sent there. Jinong later found out who was responsible.

The Lesser General of the 5th region, Bang Chunir the Pearl General.

'First Darkness and now the Steel... where are their rules?'

It seemed that the Lords now had an interest in [Chaos]. The current person working for the Lord of Darkness was Jinong himself. But who was the Lord of Steel backing? Jinong guessed it was the man who attacked his army. However, Sirwen continued, "But he was killed by a Clan Leader."

"What?"

"Oh, you didn't know this? You know, the Depth Expedition Team? The Southern Sea Clan Leader from that team killed Chunir," Sirwen casually said as she flipped through the pages of [Chaos of this Month].

"...That is impossible."

Jinong mumbled in disbelief. Chunir wasn't the strongest among the Lesser Generals, but he was second to none in [Chaos].

"That was my thought too! I mean, how dare they even touch the Lords?"

Jinong then snatched the magazine from her hands. It was today's issue. He read through the pages and found that his feelings had become complicated.

'The Lesser General was killed... and it was Cayman?'

Jinong knew about Clan Leader Cayman.

'He's not powerful enough to even have a chance.'

Even if Cayman had the power to do so, he would not have done it, knowing what might happen after killing someone of a Lord of the [Great Lands].

"Anyway, what are you going to do about that?"

Jinong looked up. Jaehwan and Chunghuh were heading directly to the inner keep as they decimated everything in their way.

"What did the Lord of Darkness say?"

"I haven't reported it yet."

If the Lord of Darkness found out that Jinong had let the [Product] roam freely until he had become a Master, it would not end pretty for him.

"Are you going to leave him be? He'll kill everything."

She was right. The story of the Pearl General's loss was a concern, but Jinong too was now a 9th stage Adapter. If he joined forces with his army of thousands, he would win.

"Sirwen."

"What?"

Sirwen looked at Jinong and shook her head.

"WAIT- Don't look at me like that. I've kept my side of the bargain. I got you the Black Cloud and even created that army of Half Dead Men."

Jinong did not answer, so Sirwen sighed and asked, "Then, will you make another deal?"

She said it as if she had been waiting for this moment all along.

"...If you won't say anything, I'll block that for you."

Half Dead Man. A monster who had acquired greater power than just being a Dead Man, as it retained a bit of intelligence to utilize the power. But these were now-

"KAKAAAAAAA!"

-Being wiped out mercilessly.

"...You've become stronger, kid."

The skill Jaehwan just used, which killed six of those Half Dead Men in one hit, was a [Normal Stab]. But it was now strong enough to kill four 6th stage Adapters at once.

'I don't think there's anyone better at stabbing than him throughout the entire [Great Lands].' Chunghuh thought.

"But we should save our energy. You know that Manticore is just a stopping point."

"Yeah."

Awakeners were unlimited in their usage of Spirit Power, as they were out of the system. But it caused them to be burdened with mental fatigue, which seemed to be the penalty of not following the system. So they needed to save from exerting themselves until they reached the Palace of Reincarnation.

"But it doesn't seem it will be easy."

They saw a few people flying at them. They were much stronger than any that they had killed so far. Most were at the 7th stage, with a few at the 8th stage. Chunghuh's expression turned grim as he looked at the one in the center.

"...Be careful. There's one as powerful as a Lesser General."

When they arrived, the man in the center, with a giant spear on his back, asked, "Are you the 'Pathfinder'?"

He was talking to Jaehwan. It was the nickname that he earned after the attack of Dead Man.

"And you are Doctor of Despair."

"...Who are you?"

The man laughed. "I had a name once."

Chunghuh then realized who it was. "Are you Heintz the Righteous?"

"You remember."

"You were a guard of Gorgon... why are you in the Golden Sky Clan?"

Heintz was a man of righteousness, unlike most people within [Chaos]. He fought for the weak and always helped those in need.

"You don't belong in Golden Sky."

Chunghuh once healed him when he was injured in a fight between the Ten-Clan.

-Doctor! Please! Teach me how to become stronger! You must know how if you're from Moorim!

However, Chunghuh did not help him. He knew what Heintz was going through. It was the despair from being weak. It was what everyone filled with justice, that had no power to keep it, had to go through.

"I remember what you said that day."

"...?"

"You told me to try."

Did he say that? Chunghuh couldn't remember.

"But Doctor, did you know that? Trying is only allowed for those who can. Most people in [Chaos] are not in the position to even try."

"...And that's why you joined the Golden Sky Clan?"

Heintz laughed. "Doctor, I tried. It might be different from what you wanted me to do, but I tried. I tried to sell the righteousness I held dear and tried to protect all I loved. That's why I'm here."

"..."

"It's been one hundred years," Heintz said. "I'm not the Righteous anymore. That weak 2nd stage Adapter Righteous died a hundred years ago."

One hundred years, enough time for weak justice to become evil.

"I'm Heintz, the 2nd rank of the Golden Sky Clan."

Chapter 77: War of Revival (4)

Master of Gorgon.

The Legend of the Way within the Waves

Pathfinder of the Impossible

Jaehwan's nicknames had changed multiple times within the month he arrived in [Chaos].

"I heard you only use [Stab]! Let's have a fight!"

Heintz did not like Jaehwan's nicknames. He had lived in [Chaos] for two hundred years but all he earned was weakness and a nickname 'the Righteous', that was just mocking him for being nosy.

'I've been lived here for two hundred years and I'm still nameless, but you who have only been here a month is WHAT?'

He swung his spear into hundreds of directions at Jaehwan.

High-Grade Skill – Eight Fangs of Valkan.

Top-grade or high-grade skills had similar names, such as the Seven Swords of Akaram, or the Eight Fangs of Valkan. These were all created by [Nightmare] Apprentices or [High Artisan] ranks, who then named the skills, but their power was more than just amusing. With the power of Dead Man, Heintz was now able to unleash the power of a top-grade skill instead of his regular high-grade skill.

However, it didn't hurt Jaehwan at all.

"S-so you know how to fight! But I've got much more than that!"

Heintz began to attack frantically. He released powerful attacks enough to be considered a 9th stage Adapter, but Jaehwan dodged them easily. It was hundreds of attacks with the power he got from throwing away everything in his life.

And yet...

'Why can't I get to him?'

His attacks did not even get close. As he attacked further, Heintz felt his entire body overwhelmed with pleasure. He was losing his mind. It was the side effect of wielding the power of Dead Man. As he used more and more of its power, it was turning him into a Dead Man.

His attacks blinded everyone's sight as it covered all possible space. It was an attack that no one could dodge.

However, someone spoke up.

"Let's stop now."

The spear stopped. Jaehwan was still watching him silently.

"But how..."

Heintz, although he thought it was impossible, knew the reason why he lost his mind was to compensate for his fear. Then, he realized.

"Ugh..."

Half of his body was gone. Pain struck him as Heintz concentrated his Spirit Power on the missing half. Tentacles began to form to recreate the missing half.

"Ugh..."

Regenerating half of a body was hard, even for the strongest Half Dead Man.

'It was a [Stab]...'

Jaehwan was looking at him curiously.

"Heintz, we should fight together."

Bant, the second strongest Half Dead Man, made a suggestion.

"Everyone! Attack!"

All of them attacked Jaehwan.

All of the citizens of Manticore were already turning into Dead Men. There were millions of them and they were sure that Jaehwan could not survive the millions of Dead Men attacking him. In fact, there were already many Dead Men coming out of the streets to attack him.

"[Chaos] is full of idiots."

Jaehwan swung his sword, destroying tens of tentacles coming at him.

"All of you think that you tried."

His second swing destroyed hundreds of tentacles.

"But none of you say you are trying."

The number of Dead Men coming in was now too great, it was like a wave, an endless wave that would never stop. Jaehwan changed his stance. He thrust his sword forward. It wasn't a normal or strong stab. It was the extreme of all stabs, powerful enough to even distort space.

The world shook at the energy, and the ground trembled.

Heintz looked on in shock.

'I-impossible.'

The sudden giant ray of light destroyed hundreds of Half Dead Men, turning them into dust. They couldn't even scream.

[Way of the Wave]

The man stabbed again and again, against a never-ending wave. And it became a Way.

Heintz ran, just like all the other Dead Men. When the light overwhelmed him, he felt his life disappearing. At that moment, he was in a different world.

The world that Jaehwan saw.

'Is this his unique world?'

There were countless corpses and a giant eye in the sky. When Heintz looked at the eye, the eye looked back. The giant eye watched over everything in the world.

The Truth of the World.

Heintz realized what that eye symbolized, what that man was fighting for. Heintz was shocked, and found hope.

If I didn't give up.

If I was still the Righteous.

Would I be on the same path, following this man's dream?

Those were his last thoughts in his dying moment.

"Just a bit longer..."

And then, the world faded.

"...You monster. You just destroyed Manticore's thousands of years of history."

Chunghuh spoke as he watched the attack penetrating into the inner keep in the distance.

"I should call it a [World Stab] now."

"Cut the nonsense and let's move."

"It's not nonsense! How did you do that just now?"

Chunghuh clearly saw that the place where the stab touched distorted into his unique world. Chunghuh never saw anyone, not even from the 4th or 5th step Awakeners from [Rupture] use such skills.

"I just did it with all my might."

The world was destroyed just because of that? Chunghuh frowned, but Jaehwan was not lying. At least it was his most powerful attack. However, Jaehwan wasn't satisfied.

'It is powerful....'

Jaehwan had stabbed continuously even after he got out of the Tower. But after a while, he realized more stabs didn't mean anything to him now.

'More stabs won't make me grow.'

His thoughts became concrete as he heard information about Awakening from Chunghuh, and by helping Cayman onto the path of being Awakened.

'There should be a next step.'

Chunghuh had mentioned that there were people who had advanced from the 3rd step, but he didn't know how. Jaehwan tried hard to find a clue on how to get there while they trained, but he just couldn't get it.

"At least it will be easy. I think the Golden Sky leader got hit by that attack too. I don't feel any power that equals a Lesser General.... Are you okay?"

Jaehwan shook his head. "It's okay. I can do it a few more times."

Jaehwan spoke as he walked forward. Then, they stopped as a voice came from the front.

"Oh, I guess I'm too late."

A woman appeared through a distorted portal. She had pink hair with horns, and a black tank top.

"...What a sight. What did you do to scare those Half Dead Men?"

Chunghuh became pale.

Dimensional Interference.

There were a lot of skills that allowed one to disappear or jump into space, but distorting space itself was not even in the list of Top-Grade Skills. This was only considering the skills of 'Top-Grade'. There were skills that were more powerful than that.

Special-Grade Skill – Warp

Chunghuh knew the only race who knew how to use this skill. He had seen it multiple times, 900 years ago.

Chapter 78: War of Revival (5)

Manticore Fortress was destroyed, leaving hundreds of Half Dead Men crying in shock at the loss they faced. But Sirwen felt nothing. She had already seen it too many times. She hadn't lived as long as the [Masters], but she recently was getting sick of living.

'Maybe I'm going through another suicidal season.'

[Nightmares] had a period of time called 'suicidal season'. It was when [Nightmares] became indifferent to everything in the world and were tempted to kill themselves to find a way out of the dullness.

However, [Nightmare] Sirwen, who had lived for two thousand years, had found something that was not dull.

Someone with enough power to destroy a fortress. She had faced many Awakeners and was even chased by them a few times, yet she had never seen such an attack with a [Stab] powerful enough to distort a world.

'...He cracked the 'Adapter World' just by using physical means. How solid is his unique world?'

Sirwen knew there were more powerful attacks that could do much more damage. The Lords over the 10th stage, or 4th step Awakeners could easily cause more destruction, but even they could not destroy a world.

Destroying it was different from just opening up a unique world. It was not vulnerable enough to be destroyed by someone's will or imagination. If one part went missing, it would be replaced with another. It was like nature or the cosmos. It wasn't something that could be fought against by a single being.

That was the 'Adapter World', or the System.

However, that man made a crack in it. Or maybe it was good to even call it a 'Way.' Sirwen felt a surge of excitement as soon as she saw it. The smell coming from the man was also familiar. He had the smell of a [Nightmare] whom she admired and was jealous of at the same time.

"...What are you?" she asked. She was flushed, and her body heated up. It was a typical trait that [Nightmares] had when they became curious.

"And what are you?"

"...Huh?" Sirwen was shocked. "You don't know me?"

"No."

Sirwen asked again, angrily, "You don't read the [Hot Ten of This Week] or [Top of the Top]?"

Jaehwan was confused as Sirwen became even angrier.

"Don't you have holograms at home?"

Sirwen couldn't believe it. Be it Adapters, Awakeners, or Lords, everyone in the [Great Lands] knew her. She was, after all, one of the most well-known [Nightmares] among the 500 [High Artisans] or [Nightmares] who often appeared on mass media, and was always the one who ranked the first in popularity polls in [Little Brother]. She was Sirwen Armelt, the Alluring Fire.

Chunghuh coughed and spoke.

"Kid, she's a [Nightmare]."

"...[Nightmare]?"

"Yeah. A famous one."

Jaehwan turned. She was nothing like the 'demon-like' figure that Jaehwan had imagined. And a black tank top and short pants? Those were clothing that he saw back on Earth during the summer. If it wasn't for the horns, he would have believed that she was a human.

"And you knew?"

"...Of course, I do."

Chunghuh spoke as he glanced at Sirwen's slender body.

"...Every man in [Chaos] knows her."

Sirwen suddenly became serious.

"Hey, old man. Thank you for introducing me, but you should watch your mouth if you want to live long."

She was fuming. "All [Nightmares] are different races. You should know that if you lived that long."

Sometimes [Nightmares] did not like being called a 'nightmare' just because they were not really a 'nightmare.' [Nightmare] was just represented the combined race of very rare races with certain similar characteristics.

"My name is Sirwen Armelt. I'm not just a [Nightmare]."

Chunghuh frowned. "All [Nightmares] are like that. They look okay outside, but they're all stuck up."

"..."

"But it's my first time seeing her in person. I guess it's true that she looks different from videos."

Jaehwan then looked at Sirwen.

'[Nightmare]...'

He did hear that Golden Sky had a [Nightmare] with them. Then he remembered he had been looking for a [Nightmare] before he became the Master of Gorgon. He needed to ask a few things. He wanted to ask how to get to the [Depth], or about the [First Nightmare] that was at the top of Tree of Imagery, but he didn't have the time right now.

"I see. It would be great if you would move out of the way now," Jaehwan commented. Sirwen flinched as it was the first time she had been treated this way and she bit her lip.

"I'm sorry but I can't do that."

"Why?"

"Because I was asked to stop you."

"Me?"

"Well, the one who asked is probably on the verge of dying."

Sirwen spoke as she glanced over at the fortress. Jaehwan readied his sword.

"Then I have no choice."

"...Wait!"

Chapter 79: War of Revival (6)

Sirwen quickly shouted as Jaehwan readied his sword. She pondered what to say, but she ended up saying what she shouldn't have.

"How about you become my [Product]?"

Jaehwan thrust forward.

The attack destroyed everything in its path, but Sirwen teleported right before she was struck. Jaehwan's eyes narrowed.

"Whoa, I almost died."

She was on the roof of the building on the left. She shouted at Jaehwan.

"Hey! Can you stop that for a second? You know what situation you are in, right?"

Jaehwan's expression became grim. There was a reason why Jaehwan was using full force in doing things. He felt terrifying energy approaching from far away, from the direction of the Palace of Reincarnation.

'The Lords have found out.'

Some of them were probably the Greater Generals that he had heard of before. Sirwen continued, "Darkness is after you. I don't know who you are, but you must know what it means to be chased after by a Lord, right?"

Sirwen continued quickly, scared of any further attacks. "But I can hide you! I'll make it so that Darkness can't touch you! You know about the decree, right? Lords can't touch [Nightmares]... no, I mean me. If you become my property, no one would dare to touch you."

It seemed that what she said was true. However, Jaehwan's reply was the same either way.

"No."

"...I see." Sirwen nodded, having already guessed the outcome.

"Oh, well. I guess I'll have to take you in by force!"

She disappeared. Jaehwan heard Chunghuh's warning. "Be careful!"

He then felt the land changing, sucking in stones and rocks. Then it all became sand, which turned into snakes made of sand which started charging quickly at Jaehwan.

'Is that a skill too?'

Jaehwan had never seen such a thing since he entered [Chaos]. He did see Beastlain do something similar with the Tower's control panel, but it wasn't on this scale.

"It's magic! It's their power!"

Jaehwan stabbed the snakes as he heard Chunghuh's shout. But the destroyed snakes that weren't alive in the first place quickly reformed themselves to attack. Jaehwan chased after Sirwen while being chased by the snakes. Jaehwan then felt his body becoming heavy all of a sudden.

All the buildings around him were being crushed down towards him. He tried to dodge it, but the debris was being pulled towards him as if Jaehwan was some kind of a magnet.

Magic.

It was a power that only [Nightmares] could use.

'She's distorting gravity!'

All the rocks were stuck against Jaehwan. The [Nightmare] was planning to imprison him within a cell of rocks.

'I won't let you do that!'

Jaehwan used all the Spirit Power coming out from his pores as stabs. The spirit energy that was released like a porcupine destroyed all the rocks. Then, a snake jumped at Jaehwan, swallowing him. He was sent down into the stomach, and in the next moment, the snake exploded as Jaehwan jumped out from it.

"Impossible...!"

Jaehwan quickly jumped between the rocks to run to Sirwen.

"...Changing imagination into reality. You're a monster."

Sirwen smiled, even with her arms and legs that had been penetrated. It was done. Gravity turned back to normal and the snakes were destroyed.

"You should surrender."

He had no intention to kill her. He knew she wasn't trying to kill him. And besides, she was a [Nightmare]. If he could take her alive, she might be a valuable asset on the way to the [Depth].

Yet Sirwen's expression looked strange..

"Surrender?"

Sirwen wasn't surprised. Before Jaehwan realized something was wrong, Sirwen disappeared and warped behind Jaehwan, hugging him strongly. Then she melted away, altering the surrounding environment. Something had started from that hug.

'...Unique world? No. It's a hallucination.'

Jaehwan then realized he had faced this before.

Eight Gates of Hell

It was the hallucination skill he had faced before. He calmly took a step into the world. It was a world that felt real, but it wasn't much to Jaehwan as he had cleared this place before. All he needed to do was to kill those who approached and destroy all the gates until it ended.

Jaehwan quickly destroyed all the gates up to the fifth one.

-Whoa, you know about this skill?

There was surprise in her voice, but she laughed before she spoke.

-But it will be different from the fake one you know.

Her next sentence faded away as it echoed.

...Eight Gates of Hell made by a [Nightmare].

Jaehwan was now at the 7th gate. However, the 7th gate was actually the last in the skill. The 8th gate remained as a kind of reward for the one who managed to go through everything. So if the 7th gate was completed, the skill would terminate automatically. Jaehwan did not know that after this skill had been created, no one had gone past the 7th gate.

The 7th Gate – Hell of Self Reflection

As he walked in, he saw the backs of many figures. It looked familiar and strange at the same time. But when they turned around, he realized why he felt it that way.

Thousands of 'Jaehwans' were looking at him.

Chapter 80: War of Revival (7)

The 7th gate of the Eight Gates of Hell.

Within the great white room were thousands of Jaehwan.

He expected to face something of this sort, but guessing and facing reality was very different. It was weird to look at himself, as Jaehwan had no chance to see himself in a mirror these days.

Did he look like that?

As he took a closer look, they all seemed to have different clothing or different features. Some seemed to be the same age while others looked younger or older.

Out of the thousands of Jaehwan, one of them asked, "Who are you?"

...Who am I?

Jaehwan felt it was weird to even answer that.

"I'm Jaehwan."

"I see."

"And so am I."

With that, voices echoed from all around.

Who are you?

I'm Jaehwan.

I see. And so am I. And so am I, and so...

All of them stared at Jaehwan. And as they kept on talking for a while, one of them turned and asked, "Who are you?"

Jaehwan pulled out his sword.

Jaehwan felt like he was getting tired. There were tens of Jaehwan on the ground behind him. He frowned as he jumped back to keep a distance.

'This is crazy.'

Nothing was working. If he used [Suspicion], they used [Suspicion]. And if he used [Understanding], they used [Understanding]. He even tried using [Strong Stab], but had to stop when he was faced with hundreds of Jaehwans posing to launch a [Strong Stab] at him.

'That would kill me.'

These enemies weren't like any he had faced so far.

Luckily, there was no Jaehwan stronger than himself, but it wasn't easy to fight against hundreds of 'Awakened' Jaehwans.

After dodging a few stabs, Jaehwan deflected dozens of other stabs from behind and used [Strong Slash] against the Jaehwan charging at him. It worked wonderfully as they all were Jaehwan who only knew how to stab. But after doing it for a few times, the Jaehwans in front seemed to have learned the pattern and immediately dodged as Jaehwan slashed.

It was another 'Jaehwan' that got struck, the one in a green military uniform. Jaehwan frowned as he saw the uniform. Out of all those Jaehwans, there was a Jaehwan from his days on Earth. A Jaehwan who did not know anything about the Tower of Nightmares.

"ARGH!"

As he slashed his old self, he felt his conscious blurring into white.

It was when he was just 20 years old. Jaehwan realized it was his memory right before he was summoned into the Tower of Nightmares.

"I'm sorry, Sergeant Jaehwan... I'm sorry... I'm sorry..."

There was a man with the rank of Private First Class. He was crying. Jaehwan realized he knew this man. He then glanced around. There were soldiers and officers lying around, bleeding from gunshot wounds.

He felt his hair rising. He knew what this memory was.

"Sarge... I tried... I really did... You know this..."

There was a rifle in his hand, with empty shells scattered around him.

"Bastards... Bastards..."

Jaehwan walked toward the man. He didn't know what to do, but he still walked forward anyway.

"D-DON'T COME CLOSER!! I don't want to kill you too!"

The man aimed at Jaehwan.

"If you were me..."

The man did not continue. It seemed that he knew the question meant nothing anymore. He then put the nozzle in his mouth.

"Thank you for everyth..."

A gun was fired, and the man fell. Blood and liquids oozed out from his skull. Jaehwan then realized that he wasn't killed by his own gun. There were soldiers approaching in the distance, with helicopter floodlights on Jaehwan. He silently raised his hands, and the memory stopped there.

Jaehwan came back to his senses. That event happened right before he entered the Tower. Jaehwan was the only one who survived the incident. All of the high-ranking officers within the battalion were terminated and

Jaehwan was put on trial. It had been proven that he wasn't involved in the bullying of the soldier so he was locked up in military detention for 15 days and then was summoned into the tower right after. It was a memory he did not want to think about.

The soldier. What was his name?

Among his thoughts, Jaehwan realized that maybe it was since then that he had come to hate the 'System.' He could have saved him. Even before coming into the tower, his world was full of 'systems'. The world oppressed each individual with a giant system.

As Jaehwan defeated each 'Jaehwan', a memory was recovered. They were all forgotten, but there were painful memories. It was the memories that he had forgotten after becoming a 3rd step Awakener.

-Jaehwan.

His parents.

-Thank you, Jae.

His friends.

-Sarge.

The soldier.

-We were lucky to have you, Jaehwan.

The friends who accompanied him until the end of the tower.

-Jaehwan...

All the memories and times that he had abandoned them.

-Save us.

"Dammit..."

Jaehwan mumbled as he looked at the thousands of remaining 'Jaehwans'. This was, after all, a real hell. He had to kill himself in order to move forward. All the memories that he recalled made him suffer. All those memories asked the same question.

"Who are you?"

Jaehwan stopped his sword for the first time.

Who am I?

He suddenly felt lonely.

"Who are you?"

He did ask the question once, but it was never this extreme that he had to face the question.

"Who are you?"

He thought it was violent.

"Who are you?"

And he thought it was sad at the same time.

It was the question to which he could not answer.

"I am..."

He felt like he was being sucked into the depths of himself. His conscious was slowly being pulled into a place where he would never escape anymore.

It was in front of him.

There was a reason why [Nightmares] were collectively called as one race, even when they were comprised of various races. It was because of their double edge. Even when they hated being called just a 'nightmare', they

were proud to be considered as a [Nightmare] when their races could be praised.

Sirwen was one such [Nightmare].

-All skills are created and owned by [Nightmares].

Most of the skills were, in fact, created by [Nightmares]. That was why skills used by a [Nightmare] had much more powerful results.

Sirwen knew she had won as soon as Jaehwan walked into the 7th gate.

The Eight Gates of Hell was an infamous skill even amongst [Nightmares]. This was a legendary skill created by one of the 13 [Master Nightmares], her godfather. This skill had a better result if the caster's mental state was more durable.

'It's a terrible skill.'

Sirwen shook as she knew the true power of this skill.

-What is the worst hell in the world?

This skill was the perfect answer to that. She once again realized how great her godfather was, and how much he knew about 'life.'

-The worst hell is 'oneself'.

[Nightmares] knew this better than anyone. They were the ones that lived the longest, if not forever, and fought against their consciousness that even made them kill themselves in many cases.

Sirwen hugged Jaehwan who had a hollow look on his face.

'Don't worry, I won't let you die.'

Awakeners were especially weak against this skill. It was because they were reminded of those memories that they had forgotten after becoming Awakened. Sirwen had experience subduing Awakeners with this skill.

But it was then that something fell from her nose.

"Huh?"

The liquid dripped from her nose down onto Jaehwan's shoulder. The blood then turned into powder and disappeared.

'...W-what?'

It was impossible. Having a nosebleed meant the caster's power while using the hallucination skill was at its limit.

'Impossible! Am I at the limit?'

The power equaled to how long the caster had lived. The longer the caster lived, the more powerful the skill would be, but these skills also had weaknesses.

Rebound.

If the target had greater power, the mental damage that was directed at the target would be directed back at the caster.

'No way! I have lived for 2000 years!'

She began to bleed profusely now, and she felt dizzy. Sirwen focused. What was happening?

When she looked inside, she couldn't help but be terrified. Thousands of consciousnesses were fighting against one.

'Thousands?'

It wasn't right. The number of consciousnesses equaled to how long the target lived. One who had lived 50 years would fight 100, and 100 years would fight 200. But thousands?

'How long did he live...?'

Sirwen realized it was her who would faint if this went on for any longer. But then, the skill changed. Something was happening to the 7th gate. It wasn't related to her power.

'Wait, how did he...?!'

The sound of destruction was heard.

The 7th gate was being destroyed.

Chapter 81: War of Revival (8)

It happened when he was teaching Cayman. Cayman had asked what 'Awakening' was, and Chunghuh answered.

-Being awakened, is like being given sight.

-What do you mean?

-The ability to see means power itself.

Cayman didn't understand, but Jaehwan did.

Being Awakened was being allowed to see the truth of the world. Awakeners looked at the 'rating', the truth of the world, and the particles that composed the world. They knew how to read the data that Adapters could not see. It even allowed them to look at themselves in a very different way.

That was the 3rd step of being Awakened.

It basically meant freedom from bodily limitations, and to see things differently. That was why it allowed them to bring energy from the world itself to grant them infinite amounts of Spirit Power.

-You have to worry about being blinded.

Chunghuh reminded Jaehwan multiple times.

-Awakeners can see all, but sometimes it does you no good.

-What do you mean?

-One who sees it all becomes blinded eventually.

-I don't get it.

Jaehwan did not understand. But now he knew.

Where am I?

He blinked his eyes, but he couldn't see anything. His body was heavy and he felt nothing. Then, he realized where he was.

This was a space.

Why was he in space? Wasn't he fighting against himself until just now? However, there was no one around. It was pitch black.

Then he saw a light.

A star? No, it wasn't a star. Jaehwan focused to see what it was. After looking at it for a long time, he finally realized what it was.

It was his memories.

-Jaehwan, are you going to try again?

The memory of meeting Jay in the Tower of Nightmares.

-Who are you, really?

The memory of meeting Mino in the forest.

-What do you think I lack?

The memory of Meikal...

All of his memories and stories were stuck together in the form of a star. It shone continuously upon Jaehwan, but it was too far for him to reach.

Jaehwan then realized what the space was.

It was his consciousness.

The memories kept sending him light and messages, but he couldn't see or hear any of them. He didn't want to. He was just too tired. That was when Jaehwan realized what Chunghuh had talked about.

One who sees too much becomes blinded.

One who hears too much becomes dull.

However, Jaehwan did not want to change anything. He quietly crouched, floating within the vast cosmos. It was comforting.

...

I did my best.

Nobody would have come this far.

...

Jaehwan was comfortable there. But then he realized he was still holding onto his sword. As he tried to let go, the silence broke from a vibration.

It was a cry. A cry from the sword. It didn't ask or force anything on Jaehwan. It just cried.

Jaehwan listened to the sound for a long time. He felt that the sound of crying would give him an answer.

Who am I?

The sword answered.

With a vibration. It wasn't even an answer, nor was it a message. It was unexplainable and unreasonable, but it was an answer. It wasn't the right answer, but a response that did not put Jaehwan into loneliness. Jaehwan held onto the sword. Then, he felt something new filling his heart.

He closed his eyes and opened them again.

Then the stars asked him.

-Who are you?

Jaehwan looked down at his sword. Who am I? He did not know the answer.

But he could still respond to it.

Jaehwan walked toward the light. The light looked at him. The sword moved.

It wasn't a stab, nor slash.

It was just a line.

Jaehwan followed the line. The stars were connected, and memories came back to its place. Jaehwan, as he traveled through stars, went through all of those memories. His memories, long forgotten with over a thousand years of stabs, were now coming back to him.

'This is me.'

Jaehwan opened his eyes again. He felt like he was full of energy.

'I've reached the next step.'

The 4th step.

His first step allowed him to find the faults of the system, the second allowed him to understand, and the third freed him from the system.

Then what was the fourth? He couldn't find the keyword that defined the 4th step yet. So, he didn't know what power it held. He just knew he had reached a new level.

'But I need to get out of here.'

It was apparent that 7th gate was finished as he couldn't find any more of himself. As the skill name suggested, however, there should've been the 8th gate. Jaehwan looked around and found a door in the corner of the room. There was another room.

'So, this is the 8th gate.'

He walked in. It was empty, other than a table in the center. On top of it was a book.

[Record of the Depth]

Jaehwan then realized the 8th gate wasn't a trial, but a place for a reward. He opened the book.

-This is a memory of my failure. I send my message to you who finished all the Gates of Hell.

Jaehwan thought, 'I guess it's the records of the [Nightmare] that created this skill.'

Jaehwan flipped through the pages. As he did so, he couldn't believe what he had read. The contents were unexpected to say the least.

-I still remember the day when the Depth Expedition Team first departed.

"This is..."

The book contained the records of the Depth Expedition Team, 900 years ago. Jaehwan flipped through the pages and turned to the end of the book. The author's name was at the bottom. As he stared at the name, he felt he was struck by a bolt of lightning. It was the name he had been looking for all this time. The being that had led him to [Chaos].

-Mulack Armelt.

A sharp slash destroyed two Dead Men. Chunghuh cursed.

"...God dammit."

He had Jaehwan in one arm, and Sirwen on his back, tied to his waist as he flew up in the sky. He swung his sword yet again. Chunghuh then stepped on the head of the Dead Man he had just killed before it disappeared and jumped towards a high building nearby. Chunghuh broke into the window and placed Jaehwan and Sirwen on the floor.

"Kid! Wake up!"

It was obvious that the skill had been broken as Sirwen fell unconscious, but Jaehwan was not waking up.

"HEY! You!"

The [Nightmare] also didn't seem to want to wake up either. He had been carrying her just in case, but it seemed that both the caster and the target were unconscious.

'We don't have time!'

The situation was dire. There were multiple beings with powerful spirit energy already at the outer walls of Manticore.

'Palace of Reincarnation.'

He had already sent an emergency message to Gorgon. If they were caught in their ambush, it had to be an all-out war. And if they didn't need to worry about being found out, they could use the teleport station and it would allow them to come within a few hours. At least there should be a few more Awakeners to fight.

'Maybe we have a chance.'

Chunghuh tried to calm his mind, but the powers that were approaching were too great. As they got closer, Chunghuh found out that the power of the enemy was greater than he imagined.

'...Impossible.'

Lesser General? No. It wasn't the power of a mere Lesser General.

Chunghuh peeked out through the broken window. There were Generals moving in. And as he looked on, Chunghuh felt his body shake in fear.

'No... why is HE in [Chaos]?'

There was a being that should not be there.

'It can't be! The Palace does not have a Greater General!'

A Greater General or higher was too important of an asset to spend time in [Chaos]. They didn't die often and was given priority to be revived if they did. However, they were here.

The 2nd rank of three General ranks.

Even among them, he was one of the top as an 11th stage Adapter and a member of the Renowned Family Sameng.

Sameng Garam.

He, two other Greater Generals, and tens of Lesser Generals were flying towards Manticore. In the next moment, Garam found Chunghuh hiding within the building.

[There you are.]

Chapter 82: King of Chaos (1)

Ten days had passed since the war that was later called the War of Revival. The meeting room within Gorgon Keep was filled with many leaders and officers of Gorgon Fortress.

Euren Chiver, the Chancellor, spoke while deeply sighing.

"Please, go ahead with your report. We'll begin with the 1st Battalion of Carpediem."

The Liberation army, [[Carpediem]]. The leader of the 1st Battalion stood. He was once called 'Karlton the Stubborn'.

Karlton Javier.

He was now a fully fledged 3rd step Awakener, after being trained for 200 years by Cayman within the Tower; he was now more powerful than anyone else other than Cayman within Gorgon.

"Yes, sir. According to our remaining troops..."

"Just the casualties please."

"Yes, sir."

Karlton then calmly prepared and projected a hologram video in the center of the meeting room.

"We have twelve 2nd step Awakeners dead... and half the battalion was killed."

"...I see."

The chart on the hologram showed the number of dead and wounded. Then, the reports went on with the other battalions. The last one to report was Shin Mukeuk. He was now a 9th stage Adapter, and the leader of the 7th Battalion.

"...And that is our current situation."

After all the reports were made, Euren was at a loss for words. He had expected it, but the number of casualties was still beyond his expectations.

'We lost half in just ten days.'

10 days ago, there were about 300 Awakeners that departed Gorgon after receiving word from Chunhuh. Among them were 12 3rd step Awakeners and 80 of 2nd step Awakeners.

They thought they would win.

Maybe it was because they saw Cayman defeat the Pearl General. They had just seen a 3rd step Awakener defeat a Lesser General. And now they had 12 of those 3rd step Awakeners.

People thought, 'We can do this!'

Even after fighting head on for the first time, they thought they were going to win. They had some struggles, but the first battle was a victory.

After that, for two days straight, the Liberation army successfully drove out the army from Palace of Reincarnation and successfully managed to drive them back up to the wall of Manticore Fortress.

The people of Gorgon thought they had already won.

Some even considered that they had defeated the Palace of Reincarnation already.

But that was it.

With the appearance of the Generals who had stayed behind in the Palace, things changed rapidly. Along with Sameng Garam, the three Greater Generals turned the tides.

-R-RUN!

On the fourth day of the war, Gorgon had lost a total of five 3rd step Awakeners. The might of the Greater Generals was just too overwhelming.

And by the 10th day, the forces of Palace of Reincarnation was right at the gates of Gorgon Fortress. They had lost many friends, but they weren't even given time to mourn.

"Chancellor, we will not be able to do this any longer."

It was Yong, the new 3rd step Awakener who had lost his left arm in previous battle. Euren turned to him and watched. He couldn't say anything. It was Aisa Lindcroft, who spoke instead.

"...We don't have anywhere else to go."

[Chaos] cannot win. Everyone had realized this already.

"Maybe if we accept the Palace's offer..."

There was an offer from Palace of Reincarnation. It was thrown at them when their forces arrived in front of Gorgon two days ago.

-Hand over your Master and the 'Tower' you are using. If you hand them over, we will not seek punishment for all your atrocities.

However, there were some who did not give up.

"We cannot do that."

It was Cayman.

"We will not give up our Master," he declared.

"We will find a way. Don't think your 'Eye' is all-powerful. Even if you can't see it, there will be a way. Do not trust your skill too much, Aisa."

"...But we have no chance. You know this very well."

Aisa then turned to Euren.

"How about we ask for help from another Lord?"

"... 'Another Lord'? Who are you talking about, exactly?"

"The Lord of Steel... for example."

The ruler of the 5th region, Huhyou, the Lord of Steel.

"As far as I know, all those Generals are from the Darkness. They're all from the 9th region."

Euren then realized what she was trying to talk about.

"As most people know, the 5th and 9th regions are longtime enemies."

"You want them to fight over us."

"Yes. Besides, we have a messenger from the Lord of Steel himself."

A messenger... Euren frowned.

"She-... is being held a prisoner in our Gorgon Keep. If you have forgotten..."

"I know. If we free her and try to talk to her..."

"It will not end that easily."

"Huhyou is not the type of Lord to retaliate for that."

"Master of Dryad. Let me remind you of the most important fact that you are forgetting."

Euren glanced over at Cayman and continued, "We have killed the Pearl General, his messenger."

"No. We did not kill him. The ones that are brought into [Chaos] by [Narrow Door] just return to their bodies when they die in [Chaos]."

"But it doesn't change anything. The Steel won't be happy that the Pearl General was defeated."

"Even then..."

"And even if the Lord of Steel has the intention to help us, we cannot ask a Lord to help us." Euren declared, "[Chaos] can only be liberated when we do it ourselves."

The people turned silent. They all had thought up of one man that gave them that very idea. Cayman spoke.

"The Master... is he not back yet?"

In the Healer room of Gorgon Keep, there were three people.

"You! Wake him up if you made him go to sleep!"

"...."

"What kind of hallucination makes him sleep for 10 days?!"

"...Ugh, can you stop the lecturing? Aren't you a doctor? Why don't YOU try waking him up then." Sirwen replied angrily as she watched Jaehwan.

Chunghuh then shouted back. "I would have done it if I could already! You worthless-"

"Worthless? Wasn't I the one who saved your ass back there?"

Chunghuh couldn't object. When the building was about to be destroyed by the Greater General's skill, Sirwen, who woke up just in time, used Warp to teleport all of them out.

'Ugh... I mean it was a dangerous situation for sure.'

It really was Sirwen who saved their lives, but Chunghuh did not want to agree to that.

"NO WAY! It is I who saved YOU!"

"....WHAT?"

"Did you forget who protected you when you fainted?"

Sirwen flinched. She certainly did faint when the skill was broken. It would have damaged her spirit if it wasn't for Chunghuh who protected her.

"...Well, I guess that makes us even then."

Sirwen agreed, and Chunghuh became awkward. He then glanced back at Jaehwan and asked, "But why did you save us? Didn't you have ties to Darkness?"

Chapter 83: King of Chaos (2)

Sirwen was a [Nightmare] who had a contract with Golden Sky. It was now obvious that Golden Sky had the Lord of Darkness as their sponsor. It also meant that Sirwen had a connection to the Lord of Darkness.

"Bah, who cares? Why would I give a crap about that stupid contract when I found a man who completed the Eight Gates of Hell?"

"Eight Gates of Hell? Was that the skill you used on him?"

"Yeah."

Chunghuh was confused.

"How did that crappy skill make him fall asleep for this long?"

"Crappy?"

Sirwen became angered.

"The Eight Gates of Hell is an epic skill!"

"Huh? Even the Disciples kids use it. What about the skill makes it 'epic'?"

"Disciples? Oh." Sirwen added, "Yeah, I remember. I taught them the skill 700 years ago."

Chunghuh became shocked. He then realized it was about 700 years ago when the Disciples Clan began using the skill.

"The skill is not made for humans to use. Only [Nightmares] can use it to its true potential."

But that didn't make sense. Why did she teach humans then?

"Why? I wanted someone to unravel the skills."

"Unravel?"

Sirwen nodded. "No one, as far as I know, had broken the skill so far."

"No way. I've seen the skill being broken many times already."

"You mean the skill 'used by humans'."

Chunghuh couldn't object.

"Like most hallucination skills, when the target has a stronger mind than the caster, the skill is destroyed. But what is destroyed is the caster's mind, not the skill itself."

Chunghuh realized immediately that meant the Eight Gates of Hell was like a sword that never broke. Even if the master who wielded the sword died from a strike, the sword itself would not break.

"If a [Master Nightmare] uses it, not even those Lords can break out of it."

Chunghuh was shocked. It meant that Jaehwan could have ended up in a far worse state. Sirwen wasn't a Master, but she was a [High Artisan].

"I know what you're thinking. Don't worry, he's safe."

"What do you mean?"

"...He broke the skill. He completed the entire trial and managed to reach the 8th gate. Oh, just so you know, the 8th gate is like a reward. It rewards you with great things if you can get there."

Chunghuh then realized why Sirwen saved them, despite breaching her contract with the Lord of Darkness, and kept visiting Jaehwan. Jagel Meng, of the Disciples Clan, once told Chunghuh about the skill.

-If someone reaches the 8th gate, that one will be the King of [Chaos].

Chunghuh asked, "What is in there?"

"A relic left by my godfather."

A relic? Chunghuh then saw Sirwen's expression change. She seemed shocked.

"What are you..."

Chunghuh realized where she was looking at.

Jaehwan was waking up.

Jaehwan heard Chunghuh recount what had happened while he was asleep.

"Wait, where are you going?"

"Meeting room."

"No, you cannot go there right now. There are people that are thinking of handing you over to the Palace."

"Handing me over?"

Chunghuh sighed and explained.

"I see. So it came down to that."

Jaehwan, ignoring Chunghuh's efforts to stop him, walked up to the meeting room. Everyone in the room was shocked to see Jaehwan.

"M-master?"

Jaehwan looked around silently, and then spoke. "I'm going."

"What? What are you talking about?"

"I'm going to the Palace of Reincarnation."

A declaration. Everyone then realized why he had said that. The Master had heard everything that had happened. Cayman immediately rose up and shouted, "NO! You cannot do that!"

"...Cayman, sit down."

Yong spoke without any energy. Some others, including Yong, couldn't bear to look up at Jaehwan. Jaehwan knew what it meant.

"It's okay. Don't blame yourselves."

No one was able to speak out. Some had put their faces into their hands, while some closed their eyes and turned away. Anger and sadness filled the room. After a while, Yong stood up, while still looking down to avoid meeting eyes with Jaehwan.

"I hate you."

He was now looking directly at Jaehwan with teary eyes.

"You gave us life, freedom, and hope."

"..."

"Do you know that many died while you were asleep? If we were not given life, freedom, or hope... they would not have died."

Jaehwan looked around. Jagel Meng wasn't there.

"I am sorry."

"Why... why..."

Why did you appear? What for?

Yong couldn't ask those questions. Jaehwan questioned himself as he watched the man's tears. Had he done the right thing? He couldn't answer.

"But still... " Yong continued, "We need you."

And that was the start. All the officers stood up.

"Don't go, Master."

"You must stay with us."

The people, who were arguing to hand over Jaehwan up until now, were standing up and shouting.

"We will fight! We will die fighting!"

Chunghuh, who was watching all this from behind, looked at Jaehwan.

'You have given them something too valuable.'

Chunghuh realized that these people would do anything to protect what they had been given. Jaehwan looked at all those people and spoke.

"I think you all are mistaken. I'm not going there to surrender."

"...Huh?"

Jaehwan laughed.

The people then realized, it was that laugh that had they wanted to see all this time. The one man who never ceased fighting however great the enemy was. The one who made miracles with his own two hands.

They had waited for Jaehwan to appear and tell them-

"I'm going to wipe them out."

Chapter 84: King of Chaos (3)

Everyone was shocked to hear Jaehwan's declaration, but he wasn't one to bluff.

'Is that possible?'

The officers knew how powerful the Great Generals were. They were beings that couldn't be fought against even with the combined power of all the Awakeners gathered. And there were three of them.

"Are you serious?"

"I'm always serious."

"You will wipe out the Palace of Reincarnation?"

"Yeah."

Everyone who gathered began to laugh hollowly. They had been discussing, thinking of how to deal with this crisis for days.

"When?"

"Now."

The Master was that kind of a man, one who was calm against the impossible. The people who were gripped with despair until just now finally had hope again. [Nightmare] Sirwen, who was watching this from the back, became curious.

'He's really interesting.'

Sirwen had seen many 'heroes' who faced the 'reality'. Many times, they were a symbol of hope, but they eventually failed against reality. Sirwen knew. This man, even if he acted like this now, he would soon be defeated by the reality. Even now, someone should be standing up to object...

"Then, we should go now! Take me with you!"

What?

"Take me!"

Huh?

"We shall kill them all, right now!"

People were rising up as the atmosphere in the meeting room grew frantic. It seemed like the entire world was standing up. Sirwen was astonished.

'They're all out of their minds!'

She heard something weird was going on in [Chaos]. The rumor that people began shouting words such as freedom, life, or liberation.

'Why now? Because of this one man?'

She couldn't understand. Maybe she would never understand as she was a [Nightmare] who had lived, and would live, for a long, long time.

'...Ugh, these humans. Well, I don't care.'

Sirwen's only purpose was to find out the secret of the 8th gate from Jaehwan. She was curious as to what her godfather had left in that place. But it was also Jaehwan who quieted down the meeting room.

"I thank you all for your enthusiasm, but only four will go, including me."

Everyone became silent.

"Me, Chunghuh, and Cayman will be going."

Cayman was overjoyed. "It's an honor, Master!"

Chunghuh ranted in annoyance, but he didn't seem to dislike it all that much.

"Hah, I guess you can't do anything without me."

The people who weren't called out were unsatisfied. Some shouted, "This is not possible!"

"Just four cannot possibly...!"

As everyone became noisy, Jaehwan quickly spoke.

"Four is enough. Besides, all of you have other duties."

Other duties?

"I think you all are mistaken. Taking out the Palace of Reincarnation isn't the end of everything," Jaehwan continued. People quieted down and began to focus.

"What do you think will happen if we destroy the Palace? [Chaos] will be united under Gorgon. But what will happen then?"

What would happen next? Everyone became confused. They had not thought about that. It was Aisa Lindcroft who answered the question.

"There will be forces that will oppose Gorgon's rule."

"Right."

Aisa felt goosebumps. Jaehwan was confident in uniting [Chaos].

'He's already thinking about what will happen after the Palace of Reincarnation...!'

Jaehwan was confident in wiping out the Palace. Aisa was shocked. It was her first time seeing Jaehwan face-to-face. Cayman had talked highly of

him multiple times, but Jaehwan was much more than that. She couldn't even read his future with her skill. Where would he eventually end up in the end?

Jaehwan said, "Gorgon will have to face many militia groups after that."

"...You are saying that we have to prepare our forces to handle that so the Depth Expedition Team can embark on their journey."

"Right. You're smart."

Smart? No one had spoken in such a way during the past 900 years to Aisa. But Aisa had unknowingly blushed at such rude words. Yong then raised his hand to ask, "Master, I don't understand! Do you propose that we prepare to fight those future militias and not fight the Palace which is right in front of us?"

"I'm not only talking about the militias. Do you think our war against the Lords will be over if we destroy the Palace?"

Yong frowned. "But, if we destroy the [Narrow Door], they can't come into..."

"[Narrow Door] is just an object that allows you to enter [Chaos] without being dead. You certainly know that it is not the true way of coming into [Chaos]."

Yong was shocked. Jaehwan was right. [Chaos] was not a place that one who enter using the [Narrow Door].

"But that... there's no chance that they would..."

"We have to prepare for everything."

There was a low possibility, but there was still a chance that the forces of the 12 Lords would kill themselves to invade [Chaos].

"...If that is your wish, I understand."

Yong agreed as Aisa asked, "Master of Gorgon, you forgot to mention one more thing."

"What is it?"

"You said you are taking four, but you only called out three names. Who is the last one?"

Everyone became silent. They were thinking that they still had a chance to be called. Aisa also seemed to be eager for that chance. However, it was someone they had not thought about.

"The last one is her."

The woman who was watching from the outside opened her eyes in shock.

"What? ME?!"

It was Sirwen Armelt.

In a room with a white floor, pink-colored walls, and various ornaments, Sirwen stood in the center while accessing a control panel in front of her.

'How did I get sucked into doing this...?!'

She thought of what happened a while ago.

"W-what? I'm not going there!"

She thought something was wrong. She just had betrayed the Lord of Darkness, yet Jaehwan wanted her to go and attack the Palace?

"Don't you want to know what was inside the 8th gate?"

Sirwen turned pale.

"I'll tell you if you help me."

It was an offer she could not refuse.

'...How did he know that is what I'm after?'

She couldn't even think because she was too shocked.

"...How should I help you then?"

"Teleport us into the Palace."

"Teleport? How?"

"Use your skill, Warp."

It was the skill that only [Nightmares] could use. The people then realized why she had been chosen.

"That's not possible. You cannot warp to a place that far. And we have too many."

Warp was a skill that allowed the user to teleport to a place where the user had been to before, but it had a limited range. Jaehwan shook his head.

"You can do it."

"No, I can't!"

Jaehwan narrowed his eyes.

"Even with your [Personal Lab]?"

Chapter 85: King of Chaos (4)

Sirwen turned grim. [Personal Lab] was a dimensional place that all [Nightmares] had. It was a place where they worked to build their creations.

"Bring us to your [Personal Lab] and then use the 'Warp Drive'. Then we can teleport."

Sirwen was shocked. He was right. The [Personal Lab] also worked as a secret hideout for [Nightmares] and had 'Warp Drive' installed to allow them to teleport to far places.

"But how could a human know such a thing..."

"It's not important 'how' I know. What's important is that you CAN do it."

However, Sirwen couldn't agree to the idea anyway.

"I can't!"

"Why?"

"B-because..."

She couldn't explain well. It was something very personal. The [Personal Lab] was a very private place. No [Nightmares] invited others to their [Personal Labs]. To Nightmares, exposing their [Personal Lab] was even more embarrassing than dancing naked in front of thousands of people.

"...Dammit. Okay."

Either way, she still had to agree. Even if it was exposing her [Personal Lab], she wanted to know what was inside the 8th gate.

And was thus the result. Sirwen finished working on her Control Panel and looked back.

"Hey, I'm done setting up. We will not be at the Palace...!!!"

Sirwen couldn't finish. The three men were now looking around the room. She was so embarrassed.

"W-what are you doing! I told you not to look at it! I don't make towers anymore!"

Her godfather Mulack once said showing others the process of making a tower was like showing others a naked butt. Having her failed creations exposed was making her even more embarrassed.

'N-no. They wouldn't know much about towers anyway.'

But that was crushed the second Chunghuh commented.

"Hey, kid! Look at this. That girl made this tower."

Everyone was now laughing at the explanation written in front of the small Tower model inside the glass box.

[Product Information]

Name: One who returned a million times!

Explanation: For you who have returned a million times, the legendary Nightmare 'Sirwen Armelt' shall bestow the power upon you to rule the Great Lands!

"D-don't laugh! I made that when I was only 1200 years old!"

Sirwen quickly covered it up with a blanket with a flushed face. A long time ago, when Mulack had been praised for creating a 'Tower of Remorse', or the first tower that contained the power to 'return', the power of returning became a trend.

-If everyone returns the [Products] to the beginning, I'll return them a million times!

And that's how it was created. It was a failure. All the towers, including hers that included a way to return had been considered a failure. It had no real positive effect on [Cultivation] and even destroyed the mental state of the [Product].

The tower 'One who returned a million times!' was, by the way, the tower that received 1 out of 5 stars in the monthly tower magazine [T.O.P].

"That one... did anyone who clear it?"

"Uh... that's..."

Sirwen couldn't speak. She couldn't say the truth: that the [Returnee of a million times] was still in process of [Cultivation] in world 9766245 and the [Cultivator] died while waiting, thus abandoning the entire process.

Chunghuh then found something else and asked, "What is this?"

[Item Description]

Name: Cultivator does not Cultivate

Description: Oh no! My friend was a cultivator?! A one of a kind tower is coming-

Sirwen then became pale and came running, screaming.

"NOOOOOO! DON'T LOOOOOK!!!!"

"HAHAHAHA! This is so funny."

"I-I can make better one if I remake it! I was young when I made these!"

"Cultivator not cultivating? HAHAHA!"

Chunghuh laughed and Sirwen felt like she wanted to find a place to hide.

'That's why I didn't want to bring them here!'

She made that tower to have the [Cultivator] not sit and relax on the top of the tower, but to start from the 1st floor along with the [Product]. However, it was obviously very unpopular amongst the [Cultivators] who wanted to do the exact opposite.

"Haha. But I guess I did get old if I don't feel anything by looking at this."

"...Still doesn't feel good though."

Sirwen, as she was covering up her creations, stopped as she heard Chunghuh and Cayman speaking.

'...Right. They were [Products] once.'

She then realized she had never faced the tower from a [Product]'s perspective. She was always too concentrated on how the Nightmare Union or the Cultivators would think of it.

To [Products], what would it feel like to be in the place that gave birth to towers?

Sirwen then went back to cover the remaining towers. She knew she couldn't say anything to them. As she covered most of them, she found Jaehwan standing in front of the last tower.

What he was looking at was the most recent, unfinished creation. She had built the base model three days ago when a sudden idea struck her.

"What is the name of this tower?"

Sirwen shook.

'Does he recognize it?'

There was a great eye in the sky. The tower was covered in darkness, its shape resembling that of a tree without any leaves.

It was made from various ideas with complicated structures. She had to work on it various times to take out unneeded stuff. It was ten days ago when she first had the idea, the first time she met Jaehwan. She didn't know why, but she was reminded of this tree when she first saw him. Sirwen said, "....World after the Fall. That's the name of that tower."

"I see."

Jaehwan kept looking at it as if he had left something within the tower. Yet he somehow looked sad, so Sirwen couldn't add onto her explanation.

That tower was made only to [Cultivate] one man.

Just then, a light began to shine from the Warp Drive.

"We're here."

It was time.

Chapter 86: King of Chaos (5)

The Far East of [Chaos] was a desert region. Within it was a narrow path that led to deep fog. Beyond the fog, was a giant lavish palace.

The Palace of Reincarnation.

A place where people who had lost their lives went to find their lives.

A man was smoking in the outer area of the Palace.

"Ugh, how can those [Chaos] bastards smoke this crap?"

The man spat the cigarette onto the ground.

'Trash.'

In front of him, or in front of the Palace, were crowds of people.

"H-hey! Don't cut in!"

"I was here first!"

There were members of Renowned families and followers of the Lords, from the 5th to 8th stages. It was the line to wait for their turn to be revived. The line was so long that where it ended wasn't visible as it stretched into the fog.

"I've waited for so long! 6 months!"

"I waited for 8 months, you asshole!"

The two men in front started fighting. It was the 8th stage Adapter McDowell and Agribba. McDowell served the 7th region, the Lord of Immortal Abraxas, and Agribba served the Lord of Darkness.

'Ugh, they're starting again.'

The man inside, Fog General Hirkmyer, frowned. He, the 72nd Prince of the Palace, knew very well that there were two species in this world. One that could be revived, and one who could not.

The ones that were fighting in front of him were the latter. The ones who could be revived weren't even in the long queue. They were just guided straight to the [Fruit] storage to be revived. Hirkmyer shouted at them.

"FOOLS! You waited for that long already. Isn't it time you give it up?!"

"No way, Prince! Even you can't be revived yet! Isn't this your 3rd year?!"

"If you are revived, the next is us!"

"...I'm 'choosing' not to be revived, you fools."

"That's the same thing!"

Hirkmyer then became furious.

"Insolent fools... Do you wish to perish?"

"HEEK! I'm sorry!"

Agribba and McDowell quickly bowed.

"I will kill you both if you two start again."

"Understood!"

Hirkmyer didn't feel good at all. They were actually right on that point, it was actually the same thing. Why was he left in the palace to guard when he

was a 9th stage Adapter? It was simple. It was because of the Neutral Treaty made 900 years ago.

-All Generals who die in battle have the responsibility to serve as Prince of the Palace. The amount of time to serve is until the next General comes along to serve.

It was because of that treaty that Hirkmyer was stuck in this remote part of [Chaos].

'Damn that Pearl General...'

It was 3 years ago when he died. There was a fight between the 5th and 7th region. To avoid the fight becoming bigger, the Generals of each region decided to resolve it with a one-on-one fight. Hirkmyer was in the 7th region, and it was Bang Chunir the Pearl General that fought against him.

'I saw him a while ago.'

He saw Chunir coming into [Chaos] a few weeks ago. He almost went up to fight him but held back. However, after a while, he heard a strange rumor.

Chunir was killed by an Awakener in Gorgon Fortress!

Hirkmyer did not believe it, but the rumor did not stop there. There were Awakeners appearing within Gorgon, and the Depth Expedition Team was created. The team was trying to attack the Palace of Reincarnation. Even then, he did not believe it.

'Bullshit.'

How dare they attack the Palace? Yet, he was shocked when the Generals of the 9th region came through the [Narrow Door].

'The Great Generals are here? What is going on?'

The Prince did not have much authority other than managing the [Fruits]. He wasn't even allowed to move out of the Palace to check on what was happening.

'Dammit...'

Hirkmyer turned back, but he felt someone with powerful spirit energy approaching from a distance.

'What?'

The being started attacking the people who were in line to be revived, and they all died immediately. Among them were Agribba and McDowell.

'What is that?'

Hirkmyer pulled out his greatsword.

"Who are you?!"

His powerful spirit energy amplified his voice and spread out.

He heard more screams. Someone with the strength enough to kill 7th and 8th stage Adapters with ease. Hirkmyer swung his sword at the fog.

The attack was deflected, letting out sparks that illuminated the man's face.

"Wait. Are you the Master of Gorgon?" he shouted. The man shook his head.

"No."

He was a middle-aged man. Hirkmyer knew him.

"You...?"

"Long time no see, Fog General. I'm here to take revenge from 900 years ago."

It was Cayman.

At the same time, a fight broke out behind the Palace of Reincarnation.

Two 9th stage Adapter Generals crouched to duck the powerful slash before them.

"You will have to fight me!"

There was an old man in front of them. They knew the man right away. He was one of the most famous figures in [Chaos].

"Doctor of Despair?"

Why was he here? What was causing the ruckus at the front gate?

"Why are you here? Have you come to die?"

"Haha! No, the opposite."

The Generals looked at each other and scoffed.

"I guess you finally have gone mad."

As they took out their weapons, Chunghuh struck them at the same time. The [Strong Slash] that Chunghuh trained for 200 years made a powerful strike.

'He's strong!'

He was now powerful enough to fight against two Lesser Generals.

"You have become strong."

Chunghuh did not respond. He wasn't all that relieved. He couldn't use too many powerful slash moves.

"Even if you can handle us two..."

The General did not continue, but Chunghuh knew what he meant. There was more powerful spirit energy coming from within the Palace.

"It's not too late. Bring the Master of Gorgon."

"He's already here."

The Generals frowned and sensed the Palace, but something was wrong. The strong presence that was coming here and to the front gate was returning back to the Palace.

'What is going on?'

In the most lavish place within the Palace of Reincarnation.

Den of Pleasure.

It was the place where [Narrow Door] and [Fruits] were stored. There were a lot of Lesser Generals. Through many transparent curtains and dim lights were the moans from men and women pressed up against each other. Ten naked Lesser Generals were surrounded by many naked women in their active involvement of vigorous activity.

There was only one Lesser General who wasn't involved.

"Something's happening at the gate. Shouldn't we go check it out?"

"Hah, hah. Let Hirkmyer handle it." The voice was out of breath.

After a while, the Lesser General gasped, shaking his body in pleasure before he laughed. "Haha! These girls are the best!"

Women in the [Great Lands] weren't good. They couldn't harass them without facing the danger of backlash from the General Women's Union of [Castration]. However, they didn't need to worry about any of that in [Chaos]. Besides, they didn't even have to worry about 'pregnancy' as it could not happen in [Chaos].

"I don't know why those bastards in [Chaos] want to leave this place. It's so good!"

"I know!"

The two Generals spoke to each other.

"Hey, cut it out. It's really weird."

The one who did not join in spoke again. His name was Laika.

"...Ugh, are you jealous because you can't enjoy it anymore?"

"WHAT?!"

Laika became angered. But it was true. He had been captured by [Castration] while trying to harass a woman General and had his genitals cut off.

"Why? You want to fight me?"

"N-no.. I'm just..."

Laika couldn't fight. They were the same rank of Lesser General, but the power difference was too large.

'Dammit.'

If they weren't going to move, he had to go alone.

'The Greater Generals might punish us.'

The Greater Generals had ordered them to watch over the Palace.

'Let's check the front gate.'

Laika did not know that he had saved himself by going out to the gate. As he tried to jump out, a corner in the Den of Pleasure distorted and a man and woman appeared through the portal. All the Generals turned to him.

"...What a mess."

It was Jaehwan.

Chapter 87: King of Chaos (6)

Jaehwan looked around. There were women in [Chaos] who had been raped, and some had died. Sirwen grimaced and mumbled, "Bastards..."

"Who are you, girl?"

"Hahaha! Is it a new girl?"

Some Generals laughed, but Laika couldn't.

'Wait. Is he...?'

Laika had heard about the features to take note of. A short-haired man with a black sword. Laika felt goosebumps rising on his skin as the man pulled out his sword.

"GET TO COVER!!"

One of the Generals shouted as the sword let out a roar. The power of the [Stab] destroyed part of the wall and the women around screamed in fear.

"YOU DARE?!"

The women ran out of the Palace and the Generals stood as they dressed themselves.

"WHO ARE YOU?!"

"The one you are looking for."

The Generals looked at each other.

"It's him!"

"He came all by himself! How lucky are we?"

The Generals spoke among themselves and one asked, "You are the Master of Gorgon?"

"Yeah."

"Have you come to fulfill the bargain?"

"No."

No? The Generals were surprised.

"I'm here to kill you all."

Silence fell for a moment, but in the next, all of them started laughing hard. One of the Generals shouted angrily, "FOOL!"

They all jumped at Jaehwan.

"KILL HIM!"

Laika gasped. With all of those Generals against him, Jaehwan had no chance.

[Twisting Kill]!

Jaehwan's stab which was mixed with a slash, fired out instantly. The Generals retreated but were unharmed.

"No use!"

The Generals then charged again, working with each other to coordinate an attack against Jaehwan.

"You have to strike them all at once," Sirwen said to Jaehwan. Jaehwan then made his move.

His attack decimated the concentrated power from the five Lesser Generals. When the bright light from the powerful clash between the attacks faded, all of the Generals were on the ground. One of them rose up limping and asked, "Wh...what are you...?!"

Jaehwan did not answer, however, he was astonished. He had unleashed the attack to kill them, but all of them had survived, even though they were unable to move.

"FOOL! You will pay for this!"

The Generals began shouting.

"We will kill you for this!"

They began to growl and the one who stood up spoke.

"...You've made a mistake."

None of them seemed like they were scared.

"We will return."

Then, they all took up their swords. But it didn't seem like they were going to fight. Jaehwan realized what they were trying to do and quickly acted.

He stabbed and disarmed all of them.

"What are you doing?"

They were all trying to kill themselves.

'Why?'

A General that was still standing up gritted his teeth and spoke.

"Are you trying to sully a General's honor?!"

Honor? Jaehwan looked at the General. Maybe he was talking about an honorable death from a fight, but he couldn't see any of that in his eyes. There was no fear of one facing true death. It was as if they were going to be revived.

'I see.'

That was the reason why they did not fear death.

"I see. You are not yet dead."

Jaehwan understood.

"YES! We will not die! Because..."

"You came here through the [Narrow Door]."

"...Huh? So, you knew! Hah!" the General exclaimed. Jaehwan focused his energy into [Suspicion] and found a thin line above each of their heads, the link that connected them to their bodies. That was what allowed them to return to their bodies.

"Whatever you do, we will not die..."

"No, you will die here," Jaehwan declared as he watched the lines.

"Stop bluffing! You foo- UGH!"

Jaehwan swung his sword. Everyone heard ripping sounds from above. The Generals closed their eyes, thinking it was aimed at them. However, they did not feel any pain and opened their eyes.

"...What? Have you given up?"

Another General stood up, reversing his sword grip. He was pointing it at his own stomach.

"Y-you wait right there. When I return..."

"W-Wait! Something's wrong!"

The General turned, and in the next moment, he felt severe pain from the top of his head.

"AAAARGH!"

The Generals all began to scream in pain and Laika shivered in fear as he watched. He had never seen such a thing after he became a General. Laika, who was standing a distance away, clearly saw what Jaehwan was doing.

'Impossible..!'

One of the Generals shouted angrily, "What have you done?!"

The General had exceptional senses and knew what had happened.

"The connection is broken...!"

The link that connected them to their bodies, or rather, the only line that allowed them to return back to their bodies... If it was broken, then...

Jaehwan asked, "How does it feel?"

The Generals felt a shiver run down their spines. It was a feeling that they had long forgotten. They knew what it was.

"Death awaits you now."

Chapter 88: King of Chaos (7)

"N-no! Don't come near me!!"

The General couldn't stay calm anymore. The rest of them had all been killed.

"W-What do you want?!"

He shouted in fear. From a distance, Laika couldn't believe what he was watching.

"P-please! Don't kill me! If you let me-"

The sword moved, and his head was cut off. Laika looked at the head fly off with eyes filled with disbelief. Then, he came back to his senses at the sudden voice of a woman.

"Huh? There's one more here."

Jaehwan walked up to him. Laika felt fear-struck; he couldn't move. The sword moved slowly in front of him. Laika felt his back drenched in sweat, maybe he was crying too. By the time he realized it, he kept repeating one phrase.

"I don't want to die."

"Do you want to live?" Jaehwan asked and Laika nodded frantically. Sirwen then spoke.

"Oh, I remember. You're Laika, right?"

"...Do you know him?"

"Yeah. He's the lowest rank of the Lesser Generals. I heard he's so weak that he even gets beaten up by the other Generals."

Laika couldn't even object to that statement. Sirwen then asked Jaehwan, "What are you doing? Aren't you going to kill him?"

"I need a witness."

"Witness?"

Jaehwan turned to Laika.

"Where are the [Fruits]?"

Laika came back to his senses. Maybe he still had a chance to live. Should he tell them the location of the [Fruits]? He felt the Greater Generals' presence far away, but the sword was in front of him.

"In that safe box..."

Laika pointed at the storage in the main hall of the Den of Pleasure.

Other Dimensional Safebox [Rebirth]

It was the second treasure, along with the [Narrow Door], of the Palace of Rebirth. Laika smirked as he watched Jaehwan and Sirwen walking over to the safe box.

'It won't be easy.'

It was made by [High Artisans] to allow the storage of an infinite amount of [Fruits].

'The password generates infinitely and...'

...

"Yay- It's open."

Laika turned pale. Opened? Without the help of the Prince?

"See? I'm THE High Artisan Sirwen."

"...The Palace security is weaker than I imagined."

"No way! It's just that I'm that amazing."

"I guess they didn't think anyone would be able to sneak in."

Laika then realized the woman was a [Nightmare]. She had pink hair with horns, and she was the [High Artisan].

'N-no...!'

Even if he survived, if they ran away with all those [Fruits], he would be a dead man.

"There isn't much. Is this all?"

There were about ten left; they had been running out. Laika managed to raise his voice to object.

"...Y-you are making a grave mistake by taking that." Laika continued, "You are making all the Lords of the [Great Lands] your enemy."

"They were my enemies from the beginning."

Jaehwan spoke and turned to the window. Something was coming.

"It's about time."

Powerful spirit energy. Laika looked toward the direction with hope, but the people that arrived were not what he expected.

"I'm here, Master."

"I'm back too, kid. My back hurts from fighting those two."

Chunghuh and Cayman were in bad shape. They threw down the Generals they had subdued onto the ground.

"They are barely breathing. I almost lost, so I had no choice."

"Good work."

Laika became pale as he checked their faces.

'...All of them?!'

Hirkmyer and the other two Generals that fought Chunghuh were slumped on the ground.

"But why did you make us bring them here?"

"To kill them."

"We could've just killed them if that was the case. Why..."

Chunghuh then froze in shock as he saw Jaehwan slicing his sword past the top of the Generals' heads. Again, Laika witnessed the skill that could cut off the link between the spirit and the body. The Generals screamed immediately, and Jaehwan silently struck them down with his sword to finish them off.

It was a massacre.

Laika couldn't believe it. He heard a rumor that the leader of [Rupture] knew how to rip away the linkage, but this man was not even a member of [Rupture].

"You don't want to believe it? But you have to."

He then realized that he was facing death himself. Who would die next?

"...Are you going to kill me?"

He felt the fear of dying.

"Don't worry. I'm not going to kill you."

"Then..."

"You will spread the fear."

Laika then realized he was being strapped. Particles of the ruins of the Den of Pleasure were binding him so he could not move. It was Sirwen's magic; she was glaring at Laika with an uncomfortable look on her face.

Spread the fear? What did that mean?

He wanted to ask.

"Are those the [Fruits]?" Cayman asked. He was looking at the golden fruits that Jaehwan had placed on the table.

"Yes."

These were the fruit that came from the top of the Tree of Imagery, the miracles that allowed one to relive life by consuming one. However, unlike Cayman who was shaking, Chunghuh was calm. He didn't seem to be interested in the fruit. Jaehwan looked at Chunghuh and turned to Cayman.

"What do you want to do?"

Greed was showing in Cayman's eyes.

"If you wish, you can have it. Do as you wish."

Cayman walked up to the fruit. It was the treasure that could bring him back to life. He asked with a shaking voice, "...Is it really okay?"

"Doesn't matter."

Cayman reached out. He held the [Fruit] and brought it up to his face.

It had been a long fight. Long and lonely.

It was the moment that a man would be rewarded for his life. But the [Fruit] did not stop at his face and was thrown up towards the sky, and dropped.

The fruit was crushed as it hit the floor, disappearing along with the tremendous spirit energy it held.

One, two, three...

Cayman did not hesitate. Jaehwan looked on without emotion, Chunghuh with slight surprise, and Sirwen and Laika in shock. The legend of the Tree of Imagery was disappearing in front of their eyes. But nobody could stop Cayman.

Jaehwan was letting it happen. When there was one left, Jaehwan asked, "Why are you destroying them?"

"...Because there was only ten of them."

Just ten. Meaning only ten people could be reborn.

"The presence of the [Fruits] is of no help to [Chaos] at this moment."

Cayman knew that those [Fruits] would bring war upon [Chaos]. Even if the Palace was gone, the people would fight over the remaining ten [Fruits]. That would inevitably hinder the [Depth Expedition Team].

With it, [Chaos] could not be saved.

It wasn't an easy choice, but Cayman, by overcoming all the hardships in his mind, made his decision. It wasn't something that anyone could do, but someone from [Chaos] had to do it. That was why Jaehwan took Cayman with him.

Cayman realized then that Jaehwan believed he would choose to do this from the start.

He picked up the last [Fruit] and threw it.

At that moment, Jaehwan frowned. There was that feeling of space distorting, air sinking, and time slowing down. It was something terrifying that only Jaehwan felt.

"Cayman, move away!"

However, a thundering sound erupted as soon as the [Fruit] was thrown up and Cayman's body was smashed the side of the wall. Chunghuh shouted in shock.

"Cayman!"

Yet, there wasn't time for that. Chunghuh couldn't even withstand the power that was flooding in. A furious voice came through with the spirit energy that rushed toward them.

"Fools, you dare to touch the [Fruits]?"

Chunghuh realized who it was immediately. It was one of the Greater Generals who came after him ten days ago, the one ranked in the top 30 Generals in the Darkness region.

The Greater General, Kanael the Storm.

But there were more.

'Dammit... all three are here.'

Behind him was Magito the Silent, the invincible swordsman who was known to place all he fought into complete silence.

Just the two of them would be too much to handle, but there was one more.

Behind them was the one who was on an entirely different level. Chunghuh shook in fear.

Sameng Garam.

He was the Greater General who was known to be most powerful in the 9th region, excluding the Lord of Darkness Gerome and his 7 Commanders. It was his second time seeing him, but Chunghuh knew him well.

The 9th rank in the 9th region.

Sameng Garam was upon them.

Chapter 89: King of Chaos (8)

Sameng Garam looked down and over to Sirwen.

"The adopted daughter of Mulack..."

Chunghuh raised his head in shock. He did not know Sirwen was related to Mulack. Sirwen replied, "So, the Lord of Darkness is in a hurry to have sent you all the way here."

"...You wish to follow your father's footsteps?" Sameng Garam spoke, ignoring Sirwen's comment. "One who comes from the dream, will return to the dream. What a pitiful race."

"...Watch your mouth," Sirwen replied, angrier than ever since she met Jaehwan.

'Can I defeat him?'

But she had not lost her mind in her rage. She knew how powerful that man was.

"Hmph. So, will you fight then? I will look forward to seeing a [Nightmare]'s trickery."

The man taunted her sarcastically. Sirwen began to concentrate Spirit Power in her hands. The magic was slowly taking form.

"Wait."

A cold voice spoke up, stopping her. Sirwen and Sameng Garam turned toward the voice. It was Jaehwan who had just finished checking up on

Cayman. Cayman was barely breathing, on the verge of death. Jaehwan rose up slowly.

"I will handle him."

Sirwen felt dumbfounded and relieved at his words. But then she came back to herself. They were facing the impossible.

'No... you can't do it alone.'

She wanted to say it, but couldn't say it out loud as she saw Jaehwan's face. He was enraged.

[Insolent fool.]

However, it wasn't Sameng Garam who stepped forward. It was Magito the Silent.

"...What's with you, Magito?"

Kanael the Storm seemed to be shocked by Magito's unexpected action. Magito glanced at Kanael, and Kanael began to cackle. It seemed like they had exchanged messages. Kanael then looked at Jaehwan.

"You already heard Magito's voice? How unfortunate."

Jaehwan then realized the voice he just heard was from Magito.

"No one survives after hearing Magito's voice."

The reason why Magito's nickname was silent was simple. No one who knew his voice, and all those who heard him had been killed. Jaehwan declared, "Then, I'll be the first."

Before Magito could act, Jaehwan was already moving. Two swords clashed.

'It's not going to be easy.'

Jaehwan felt that this wasn't an enemy he could not win against, but it wasn't going to be easy either. Magito then counterattacked with his sword, which Jaehwan dodged.

[Strong Stab]!

[Strong Stab]'s range was originally too wide, but Jaehwan had trained for 2000 to use it against a single target. However, Magito dodged it.

"That rumor wasn't even close."

Sameng Garam mumbled to himself. Magito did manage to dodge it, but his clothing was in rags and his right side was injured. It wasn't severe, but it was embarrassing. Kanael laughed.

"HA HA! What are you doing, Magito? Can you not kill an insect?"

[Shut up, Kanael.]

Fortunately, they did not fight together against Jaehwan. They were too proud to join forces to fight a mere human. However, they did not know that their pride would be their demise.

'Sameng Garam... 11th stage Adapter.'

Jaehwan glanced at Sameng Garam in the distance. The two Generals in front of him were powerful, but he was the real enemy. Jaehwan knew that Sameng Garam was twice, if not more, as powerful than those two Generals combined.

Jaehwan and Magito clashed against each other. According to Jaehwan's [Suspicion], Magito was similar to when Jaehwan first arrived in [Chaos].

'Let's not waste time.'

Jaehwan moved. He needed to finish it while the enemy least expected it. Jaehwan attacked with his [Strong Stab]. Then, from the attack that had left a scar, Jaehwan's unique world began to spread. Magito panicked. He had not expected such power from a mere human. He tried to use his best sword

skill to fight back, but Jaehwan did not give him that luxury. He had already readied a second stab.

Repeated Strong Stab!

"Impossible...!"

Magito finally spoke out loud after hundreds of years. The damage spread, destroying everything in its path. Chunghuh and Sirwen quickly grabbed Cayman and evacuated behind Jaehwan to avoid being caught up in the aftershock.

"How dare you!"

Kanael jumped in. He originally just intended to watch, but it wasn't going as they expected. Even if their pride was important, he couldn't let Magito die. He quickly flew to Magito, who was being thrown back, to grab him.

"...I'm sorry, Magito, but I will have to jump in."

"...Dammit..." Magito moaned. He had no choice, however. They were out on an official mission, and their job wasn't to compete in an honorable duel. They would not truly die as they had come here through the [Narrow Door], but they couldn't allow their spirit to be damaged as it would take days to recover.

"W-watch out!"

Magito warned as Jaehwan's sword fired again.

A third strike.

"AAAAARGH!"

Kanael then fought back, using his skill [Wings of the Storm] that allowed him to become the General of the Storm. However, hostility aside, Kanael was truly astonished. It had been a long time since he was faced with such power by a non-General.

'Three powerful attacks!'

But it wasn't over yet.

And then the fourth strike came.

The 4th strike was on a different level. Jaehwan's unique world spread from the attack, and Kanael flinched at the glimpse of the giant dark eye within.

"This... this can't...!"

His wings were ripping apart. Kanael used all his might to resist the attack, but Jaehwan made his final move.

The fifth strike.

It seemed like the world had been bombarded with a nuclear strike. Kanael and Magito were thrown into the sky like a pair of rag dolls. There was no Spirit Power from them as they were severely injured. Then, from all the scars from the previous attacks, dark matter began to seep out, covering the entire region in its picture.

The unique world.

Everyone watched as Jaehwan's world appeared. Laika, who was watching all this from behind, looked at Jaehwan's eyes. He realized that this man had let him survive to show him this moment.

[Chaos] was not weak.

'If he is here... no one will dare to enter [Chaos] with ease.'

Jaehwan's sword sliced the connections from the two Generals and they began to writhe in agony. But it wasn't over yet.

Jaehwan's unique world was now advancing to where Sameng Garam was standing. He, for the first time, had drawn his sword. The power that reached him that defeated two Generals seemed to be too great for any one man to fight back.

"You are strong."

The unique world stopped in front of him.

"A physical power that destroys the world itself."

Sameng Garam reached out for the border and held it.

"But it's not enough. You have the weapon, but you are still a child."

Then, the world began to shrink as if it was afraid of Sameng Garam.

"A unique world that has not faced 'Creation' is only a trickery."

The world faded. Jaehwan was shocked.

'He scattered the unique world.'

Sameng Garam began walking over to Jaehwan. He felt his body growing heavy and his skin tightening as Sameng Garam approached, as if Jaehwan was being taken into a unique world.

'...Unique world?'

Sameng Garam said, "There are fools who think that the unique world is only available to Awakeners."

An Adapter had his own world? That was impossible. Jaehwan's [Suspicion] had told him how the world was formed. But Sameng Garam continued with his explanation. "Everyone has their own world. Even if it's not 'unique'."

The world of Adaptation was gathering in him.

He was, in fact, the one closest to becoming a Commander as an 11th stage Adapter.

Jaehwan gripped his sword tighter. It was the first time, other than during the Sole King Catastrophe, that he faced such power. This was like-

'The power given by the world itself.'

Jaehwan was facing a 'System'.

Chapter 90: King of Chaos (9)

Jaehwan realized as he watched Sameng Garam walking up to him.

'I might lose.'

However, he already was ready for it. He didn't come because he was sure that he would win. It was just that this was not his final destination. He had to go to the top of the Tree of Imagery. If he were to be stopped here, if he avoided this fight, then he would not be able to reach the top anyway.

Sameng Garam's body began to wield a dark flame.

"W-we have to run!" Sirwen shouted frantically. "He's not a Greater General... no!"

Sirwen also realized when she saw Sameng Garam wielding his power. The most powerful Greater General? No. It was a false rumor.

"He's already at the level of a Commander!" Sirwen shouted, but her voice faded away as Sameng Garam's dark flame distorted the space to create a new space.

"We don't need disruptions."

Jaehwan looked around. The world was distorted, but this place wasn't anyone's unique world. It was a normal world with the same system. Sameng Garam spoke.

"Awakeners wish to destroy this world."

He spoke as a dark flame burst from his fist.

"That's why they- you don't see it. This world itself is a unique world to some."

The flame then was thrown at Jaehwan. Next moment, Jaehwan was being thrown away. It was the first time he couldn't dodge an attack. This was the real power of the System.

Jaehwan landed and tried to quickly dodge. But he still couldn't dodge Sameng Garam's fist. Second punch shook Jaehwan's body. Jaehwan tried to focus his power on the sword to use Strong Stab again. But the attack, powerful enough to destroy the land and sea, was being destroyed by Sameng Garam's punches.

"No matter how strong it is, you cannot fight me with just Spirit Power."

He spoke arrogantly.

'I see. So, attacks with Spirit Power don't work against him.'

Spirit Power, after all, was a resource offered by the 'System' itself. However, Sameng Garam's power was beyond that. It was something that was the world itself.

"You seem like you are on the verge of 'Creation', but do not know how to use your world yet. You wish to move up to the Depths with such a level?"

Sameng Garam stopped attacking and Jaehwan's expression darkened. It was a sign of arrogance, breathing space given to Jaehwan as mercy.

"Show me your world. Open your 'Creation'."

Creation. Jaehwan knew this word already. In the book that Mulack left, there were records of his findings about Awakeners.

-Awakening is divided into 6 steps. The first three steps allow one to destroy the current world, and the latter three allow one to create a new world. These make up the step of 'Creation'.

Jaehwan knew he was at the 4th step, meaning he had reached the 'Creation' stage. But he couldn't understand what it actually meant. He already had a unique world. What did he need to create after that?

Jaehwan thought. What did he need to create? What was the difference between a unique world that had started 'Creation' and one that didn't?

"I will not wait for too long. If you cannot open it, I will force you."

He was looking elsewhere. Jaehwan felt his heart fall. Sameng Garam charged and ran past Jaehwan.

'NO!'

His attack threw Chunghuh and Sirwen away. Cayman was barely standing now with his sword as a prop. Yet Sameng Garam smashed the quadhorn sword into pieces. Jaehwan felt Cayman's spirit energy being destroyed as Sameng Garam repeated his attack.

Jaehwan ran with all his might. And-

"M-master...!"

Cayman shouted in shock. Jaehwan was struck hard and blood began to seep from his mouth. But he stood. He then glared at Sameng Garam, panting.

'They are not like you. This life is all they have. This world is 'only one' they can live.'

...

Suddenly, Jaehwan felt as if he was struck by lightning. This world was the 'only one'? He began to see flashes of his memories. Memories of when he was born, when he went to school, when he was with his friends... all those memories had one thing in common. The world where he was in.

And when he was there, he did not grow [Suspicious] of his world. How could he? He was living in the world. The world was there because he did

not become [Suspicious]. He knew it as 'real'. The world of the system was born with that 'trust'.

'If then...'

If the world existed through 'trust'...

'What if I trust another world?'

At that moment, Jaehwan's unique world moved. All those memories began to speak to Jaehwan.

'That world is fake.'

'That is not the world we lived in.'

'Do not run from the world!'

It wasn't easy. Trusting a new world didn't just create a new one right away.

'One isn't enough.'

Jaehwan needed absolute trust to create a new world. He needed all of his memories to be changed. All of them had to yearn for the new world. But how could he persuade them? They represented all the 'Jaehwans' himself, the stubborn one that never forgave.

Jaehwan chose not to persuade them. He just glared at them, declaring silently that he would not give up.

As for the attack from Sameng Garam, Jaehwan did not do anything. All the Jaehwans from his memories were shocked. If it was left alone, their body would perish.

'Dammit.'

'...He's me after all.'

'Just for this one time.'

Soon, all the Jaehwans turned to the same world. The world that had not existed before. And in the next moment-

Jaehwan's body that was burning in dark flame began to shine. The world that Jaehwan had in his imagination was now turning into reality.

'...Ah!'

Sirwen was stared in astonishment. She who had lived for 2000 years knew what was happening.

Creation.

From the opening of the world, Jaehwan pulled out something. It was a dark sword. Jaehwan then realized the keyword for the 4th step. The 4th step was the power allowed imagination to turn into reality.

[Theory]

A dark sword was the symbol of objection to everything of this world. Jaehwan held the new sword, and his old sword in each of his hands.

"So, this is your world."

Sameng Garam spoke as he looked at the new sword.

"It is unfortunate."

Sameng Garam knew what it meant. He knew what Jaehwan's world was trying to achieve.

"A world born only to destroy another world."

Chapter 91: King of Chaos (10)

A long time ago, a [Nightmare] came to the Lords of the [Great Lands].

-I will be leaving on an expedition. Please help me climb the Tree of Imagery.

However, he was largely ignored. The fact that he was only an [Apprentice] was the reason, but that wasn't the only one. The Lords were too busy fighting in a never-ending war. Yet the [Nightmare] did not give up.

-We should not fight among ourselves. This world is wrong. Don't forget when you first came into the [Great Lands]! Think of when you were weak! This is our last chance! We have to destroy the [First Nightmare]!

It was laughable. A [Nightmare] who hadn't even lived 5000 years spoke of a 'last chance'? A [Nightmare] who hadn't experienced the [Interface System] more than 5000 years?

The Lords weren't fools. However, they were too busy preparing for tomorrow's war. Tree of Imagery? [First Nightmare]? A God who made this world? They were all but rumors. The Lords were too old and too cautious to jump on it.

But the [Nightmare] did not give up.

He even visited the 9th region, the Lord of Darkness Gerome. Instead, Gerome sent Sameng Garam to greet him. However, it was a mistake on his part. Sameng Garam was a follower of the System, but he was pure. He listened carefully to the [Nightmare]'s warning and said,

-The [Great Lands] is a place for the strong. You who dreams, show me your worth.

They fought for three full days. Sameng Garam lost, and lost again. On the 3rd day, the [Nightmare] spoke.

-It is a shame that you are an 'Adapter'.

Sameng Garam accepted the [Nightmare]'s strength. He didn't even use magic to fight. He thought this [Nightmare] had the right to mention the [Tree of Imagery]. He then returned to the Lord of Darkness to report what he had learned. The [Nightmare] had a point. [Cultivation] was at its limit and the [Great Lands] was falling apart.

However, after hearing the report from Sameng Garam, the Lord of Darkness concluded.

-Sameng Garam will be punished with 100 years of slumber.

He was sent to decline the offer, yet came back persuaded. And when Sameng Garam returned from his sleep, he heard a rumor.

[Nightmare] Mulack.

The one who was shunned by those in the [Great Lands] and went into [Chaos] to form a [Depth Expedition Team]. The one who traveled to the [Depths] to change the world and failed.

After the [Fruits] were taken by the Lords, he never heard anything about the [Nightmare] again. Even so, he thought about the [Nightmare] from time to time. What would have happened if he had followed the [Nightmare]? Or what if any of the Lords had helped him?

Would the world have changed?

Sameng Garam even secretly traveled to the [Depths] in search for the missing [Nightmare]. But he returned with nothing. The [Depths] was vast and there were beings more powerful than him. That place was, in fact, one where even the Lords had to give up on.

He decided to forget about the [Nightmare]. In turn, he followed the System more closely. If changing the world outside of the System wasn't possible,

what if he tried from within? That's why he tried.

And without realizing, he had already become a Guardian of the System.

And now, after 900 years, a man with the same dream as that [Nightmare] stood in front of him. As he stared at the man, Sameng Garam forgot all his orders.

He was told to capture this man alive and kill all the others.

But he couldn't think of that anymore.

"Jaehwan."

Sameng Garam, however, couldn't accept the man. He was now the Guardian of the system. He was the System itself, so he couldn't let Jaehwan destroy the system.

"You will never save anyone with that world!"

And their true fight began to unfold.

A sword against a fist. It was a fight for each to save their own world. Two powers clashed against each other, enough to destroy the whole place. They were on par with each other.

Sameng Garam shouted, "GOOD!"

He felt like he had been sent 1000 years back into the past, back to the time when he fought against the [Nightmare].

Jaehwan also dove deep into the fight. Both of them forgot the world. All they were focusing on was the opponent in front.

Then, Sameng Garam's fists burst into his dark flame, readying his final blow. As his two fists struck against the world, the World of the System vomited something from within.

Dark Guardian.

A being was summoned. It had the shape of an Angel but wielded a dark spear. The Dark Angel then slashed at Jaehwan. It was an attack that was the embodiment of Sameng Garam's thousands of years.

Jaehwan readied his swords. The power from his swords emerged from both his hands. Then, dark energy burst from it, like a flame tearing into the sky.

An attack that destroyed everything that existed.

The sky turned dark, and something fell from it.

It was a dark sky. The World was filled with maggots and no other living beings. At the top of the [Tree of Imagery] was an eye, and Jaehwan called it the 'Eye of Asura'. It was the one that controlled and ruled over this world. Sameng Garam watched from where he had landed after falling and spoke.

"So, that is where you are heading."

"It's my enemy."

"I see."

Sameng Garam's shoulders began to shake. It was at the top of the [Tree of Imagery], and at the end of the [Depths], the place where the [First Nightmare] was known to be located.

"It's terrible... This is the truth?"

Sameng Garam seemed to be in disbelief that the world he believed was in this state in reality.

"Your world will not be popular in the [Depths]. This is too brutal of a truth to know in replacement for losing hope."

"..."

"No one will want to see this and live. Corpses and the Eye."

As if he knew what the [Depths] was like, Sameng Garam continued, "But... even so, if there are people who trust your world... they might find 'real' salvation from within."

Jaehwan laughed. "You sound like a poet. Are all Commanders like you?"

"...Finish it."

Jaehwan raised his sword. And as he was about to swing, Sameng Garam spoke again.

"Cut my connection."

Jaehwan stopped. Sameng Garam knew that Jaehwan had no intention of severing his connection. Jaehwan was trying to let him live without him realizing. It wasn't like him.

"You made a new world. You should be ready for anything."

Sameng Garam smiled. Jaehwan asked, "Any last words?"

"If you arrive at the [Depths], find Myad. Tell him I sent you and he will help you."

"Who is he?"

"Myad Van Decklan. You will find him easily."

Jaehwan nodded. Then, he quickly cut the connection and in the next moment, penetrated Sameng Garam's heart.

He turned back. Chunghuh, Cayman, and Sirwen ran up to him. The world returned to normal, and through the ruins of the Palace, they could see the sky of [Chaos].

They had won. After the failure of the previous Depth Expedition Team, 917 years and 244 days ago-

[Chaos] was now free from the Palace of Reincarnation.

Chapter 92: Path of the Depth (1)

The War of Revival was over. It ended with [Chaos] freed from the [Great Lands]. However, that was only the beginning.

Jaehwan spoke to the pale-faced patient in the healer room of Gorgon Keep.

"You were alive."

It was Jagel Meng.

"I thought you were dead."

"...I'm the leader of a Ten-Clan. I won't die so easily."

He smiled, but his injuries were severe. It was a miracle that he even survived.

"It's all thanks to the Doctor of Despair."

When he was injured, Chunghuh had just returned to Gorgon and quickly tended to Jagel Meng. If not, he would've died.

"...I heard you defeated Sameng Garam."

Jaehwan knew it was Sameng Garam who caused Jagel Meng to be in this state. So, in some sense, Jaehwan had taken revenge for him.

"He was a Great General."

Jaehwan knew Jagel Meng meant something deeper.

"Did you know him?"

"Every member of the Jagel family knows the Sameng family."

The Sameng family was one of the Renowned Families of the [Great Lands].

"You might be aware, but 'they' will now have their eyes on us too."

"They?"

"The Renowned families. Sameng already has, for sure."

The Palace belonged to the Lords and the Renowned families. [Chaos] also killed a member of the Renowned families. Jaehwan shook his head.

"It's okay. They won't come here anymore."

Jagel Meng opened his eyes wide in shock.

"Did.... Did you acquire the [Narrow Door]?"

Jaehwan nodded and Jagel Meng heaved a sigh of relief.

"That's good... but it's too early to be relieved."

"I know."

Jaehwan understood what he was talking about. He had warned the other leaders of this in a previous meeting. There was another, normal, way of coming into [Chaos].

"I'll just kill them again."

Jagel Meng sighed. He could now believe those words to be true.

"If they are here to kill me, even at the cost of their lives, they may be worth fighting against."

"...I see."

Jagel Meng smiled, then turned to face the window. It seemed like there was finally a short peace in [Chaos].

He also realized that this peace was possible because of one person.

Someone called out to Jaehwan, and he stood up from his seat.

"Take care of yourselves."

Jagel Meng stared at Jaehwan. Where was he going now? What lay beyond the path that he would be taking? Was it a path that they could follow? Or... Was it his fate, to walk alone on that treacherous path?

"Master."

Jaehwan stopped, not looking back.

"....It's nothing."

Jaehwan walked out. Jagel Meng had the feeling that he would never get to see him again. But he couldn't stop him.

There were a lot of people who came to see Jaehwan. The first who came were Chunghuh and Cayman.

"Kid, don't think of leaving secretly."

"I will not let you go alone this time."

They were afraid Jaehwan that would travel to the [Depths] alone. However, the one that came to see Jaehwan next had an entirely different reason.

"What is it?"

It was a man with blonde hair, and a single silver wing on his back. He saluted to Jaehwan and spoke.

"I have a few matters to discuss, Master."

"Why didn't Euren come?"

"The Chancellor is busy with the work you gave him."

It was Karlton.

"Okay, go on."

"Yes, sir. The first is from the meeting..."

Karlton began to report what he had prepared as Jaehwan looked at him. In some sense, Karlton was similar to Sameng Garam. He was one who wanted to keep the order of something.

'Didn't he also become an Awakener?'

The keyword [Suspicion] allowed one to create their own unique world. Jaehwan's world was 'Fall' while Cayman's world was the 'Great Sea.' Then, what was Karlton's world? Jaehwan became curious.

"...and... Master, are you listening?"

"Oh, yes. Where were we?"

"...According to Gorgon Law, chapter 24 line 5, the behavior of not listening to the report of..."

He had not changed one bit, even after being Awakened. Karlton then smiled and stopped.

"...We were talking about the tower."

"What tower?"

"Carpediem, sir."

Jaehwan then remembered the tower he had made with Meikal. It was now more refined and stable than when it was first made.

"What about it?"

"There are complaints of the time flow being too fast."

"...I see. Understandable."

"There are increasing suicide rates among those who challenge it to become Awakened."

Time was bad for the spirit. It was punished for overusing time. Even for Jaehwan, corruption was seeping out from his body due to not consuming horns regularly.

However, Awakening required overcoming such hardships. Jaehwan then spoke.

"We do have it running too fast. Change it with Meikal."

"Yes, sir."

"They can't just become Awakened by simply repeating [Stab] or [Slash]. Order the system to create Awakeners on a constant basis, and take out those who do not want to be Awakened. Training to rise in Adaptation stages is also a solution."

"Adaptation... do you really think it's a solution?"

"People have different opinions. Awakening is not salvation. One might find life within Adaptation."

Karlton seemed to have complicated thoughts as he heard that.

"...Anything wrong?"

"There's a personal problem."

"Personal problem?"

"What is it?"

"I'm now a 3rd step Awakener. I guess you know that already."

Jaehwan nodded.

"But I don't see my unique world."

"...What?"

That was impossible. All who became 3rd step Awakeners had a unique world. It differed in shape and size, but there were no instances where one did not acquire a unique world.

'Wait, maybe his unique world is...'

Jaehwan remembered Sameng Garam's words. He told Jaehwan that every being had their 'world', even if it wasn't unique.

'Maybe Adaptation and Awakening is quite similar in some sense.'

Jaehwan reassured Karlton.

"Don't worry. Maybe your unique world is the 'System' itself."

"...Is that possible?"

"It's a possibility. I don't know everything about Awakening."

Karlton then asked, "If my unique world is the 'System,' will I have to fight you someday?"

It was an unexpected question with a hint of humor. But Jaehwan pondered it seriously.

"Maybe. If you really try to protect this world."

"You really intend to destroy this world?"

"Yes."

"Then, even if I try to protect it when the time comes, you will not change your mind?"

"Yes. Then you will be destroyed together with it."

After giving it some thought, Karlton asked, "Master, take me with you."

"To?"

"To the [Depths], sir."

Jaehwan did not answer. In fact, a lot of people had been bringing up the issue of the expedition already.

'I guess it's about time to pick who to bring to the [Depths].'

He couldn't bring everyone. The [Depths] was dangerous enough to scare off the Lords of the [Great Lands]. As Jaehwan fell silent, Karlton added, "According to Gorgon Law Chapter 3 Line 4, all Gatekeeper Captains have the responsibility to protect the Master of the Fortress in an emergency."

Jaehwan laughed. "But you are not the Captain anymore."

"..."

"And I won't be the Master when I leave."

Karlton seemed to be shocked by those last words.

"...I expected... but are you really going to quit being a Master?"

Karlton wished it was a lie. They needed a central figure to keep [Chaos] in order more than ever. The leaders were even considering asking Jaehwan to become their king.

"Yeah. I will be leaving in a week."

"But if you leave, Gorgon will fall. No, [Chaos] will..."

"Don't worry."

Jaehwan turned to the window and looked out at the sky.

"I have an idea for that."

And Karlton realized four days later how ridiculous that 'idea' was.

Chapter 93: Path of the Depth (2)

On the fourth day, after Jaehwan returned from destroying the Palace, Gorgon Fortress wasn't celebrating the victory. Too many had been injured or died. They had won, but they were tired. They were also not ready for the unexpected turn of events.

It was Jaehwan who put an end to all the uneasiness. On the fourth day, he summoned all the people of Gorgon Fortress and declared, "We will begin the Remembrance of Lost Spirits for three days."

Everyone mumbled to each other. It wasn't a strange thing to do, but it was still shocking. Too many had died to even try and mourn for everyone. But their concern was removed right after a huge cloth, that placed right below the stage where Jaehwan was standing, was uncovered.

There were thousands of caskets, dedicated to all who died in the war. The people were shocked.

When was this all prepared? They then looked up, but Jaehwan wasn't there.

Jaehwan was already descending the steps.

Everyone looked at Jaehwan silently as he walked up to the caskets. Jaehwan then stood in front of one casket and looked down.

"Isaac Kendell."

It was the name of a hero who became a 3rd step Awakener, killed one Lesser General, and died. Jaehwan did not know the name, however.

But there were a lot of such people who died.

Jaehwan laid his hand upon the casket. Within it were the belongings of those who perished. [Chaos] did not leave a body behind when one died, so it was replaced with their belongings. The caskets were to be burned when everything was done.

Jaehwan closed the casket. He then went on, reading the names of other caskets, and closing them as he did so.

"Rachel Belder."

"Kasim Hill."

It seemed that Jaehwan was talking to those lost spirits, to tell them they had done well. One by one, the caskets were closed and people moaned and cried.

And after every casket was closed, Jaehwan stood.

"You all have done well."

People were crying. Some wailed loudly, while some cried silently.

"However, you must know that it is not yet done. The war has only just begun."

Then, from the back, within the keep, something was pushed out. On the cart was a giant object that looked like a giant serpent biting its tail. People looked at the device in confusion. After a while, someone finally realized what it was.

"N-narrow door!"

"It's the Narrow Door!"

It was the device that allowed living Lords to travel into [Chaos]. It was currently deactivated.

"You are right. It is the Narrow Door."

People shook. It was the device that reigned hell for the people of [Chaos].

"D-destroy it!"

"Destroy the thing, please!"

People shouted. They were afraid that the forces of the [Great Lands] would come into [Chaos] again. Jaehwan stood there silently. Instead, he gave an order.

"Bring him out."

From behind the Narrow Door, a man was dragged out. He was bound with magic-coated chains. Many did not recognize him, but those who fought in the frontlines of the war knew who it was.

"...G-general!"

"It's a General of the [Great Lands]!"

The people panicked. Why was there a General here? Weren't they all dead?

"It's Laika!"

It was shocking. To most people, the existence of Generals was but a word. They couldn't even have had the chance to fight against them as they were too weak. But now, they knew who they were fighting against, who they had won their victory from.

Laika declared, "...You will regret this!"

His voice filled with powerful spirit energy.

"The Lord of Darkness will not forgive you!"

His voice froze the crowd. Jaehwan was right; the war was not over. People began to lose hope, which was replaced by despair. Why did they fight against those terrible Lords? Why did the Master bring that General to this place? What were they going to do with the General?

Kill him?

'But what if that angered the [Great Lands] even further?'

Let him go?

'What if he leaked information?'

They couldn't decide and asked Jaehwan to decide for them. The answer was simple.

"That's enough."

Jaehwan's sword swung at the chains binding Laika, freeing him. The crowd gasped in shock. Laika immediately charged at Jaehwan, trying to land at least one blow before being killed. But it was a false hope. His left arm that tried to strike was cut off.

"AAAARGH!!!"

Then, his right arm and both legs were cut off. Blood poured out from his body, then turned into a silvery powder. People couldn't believe what they were seeing.

"Ha...HAHAHAHA!"

Laika laughed maniacally on the ground with his limbless body.

"KILL ME!!!"

"No, you will not die."

Laika looked at Jaehwan in shock.

"W-what? If you do not kill me, you will all die! The Army of Darkness will come to end you!"

"That's why I'm letting you live."

Jaehwan declared as the crowd looked at them in silence.

"Return, and tell your Master this. If he wants war, come. I will await him on the top of the Tree of Imagery."

Laika couldn't even reply as the [Narrow Door] was activated. The device began to emit a bright light. Jaehwan then added, "Of course, that's if he has the guts to kill himself in the first place."

Jaehwan kicked Laika's body towards the [Narrow Door] and the light swallowed Laika. In the next moment, Jaehwan's stabs poured towards the [Narrow Door]. The gate that made [Chaos] cower for hundreds of years had been destroyed.

Jaehwan declared, "[Chaos] now declares war against the [Great Lands]."

"What is the meaning of this?!"

Everyone had gathered within the office of Gorgon Fortress. Chunghuh was shaking his head in shock. People were shouting at Jaehwan, to which he frowned. At that moment, the room began to change.

It was a powerful hallucination.

The officers inside became confused, as if they had forgotten why they were there, and walked out. Jaehwan then turned to the caster of the magic who just appeared from the wall.

"Thank you."

"I knew you were crazy... but you really are crazy."

It was Sirwen.

"Didn't you say you were quitting as Master? What was that for?"

"It was for war."

Sirwen yelled. "I know, I mean WHY?!"

Jaehwan replied calmly, "It's to make [Chaos] safe."

Chapter 94: Path of the Depth (3)

War for the peace of [Chaos]? What was that even supposed to mean? Sirwen suddenly realized, if there was a war that would bring peace to [Chaos] in the end, it could only mean one thing.

"Are you... are you trying to take on the Lord of Darkness in [Chaos]?"

Laika had returned, so the message should have been delivered to the Lord of Darkness by now. But, even then...

"No... no way. The Lord of Darkness won't come all the way here by himself..."

Sirwen began to mumble to herself in panic, while Jaehwan silently looked at her.

"Y-yes! A Lord cannot be absent from his seat or it will pose a great danger to him! A War of the [Great Lands] isn't that easy!"

Jaehwan nodded. "I suppose so."

"...Wait, did you already expect that?"

"Of course, but they might send a Commander or two."

A Commander or two? Sirwen was dumbfounded.

"Are you out of your mind? They won't just send one Commander. At least three... or four might come! And if we have members from the Renowned families, then it will pose an even greater danger!"

"Good. If we defeat them, then it will be the start."

Sirwen silently stared at Jaehwan. He was right in some sense as having Commanders perish in [Chaos] would mean a great change in the balance of power in the [Great Lands]. The Lord of Darkness would become too busy keeping the peace in his own region because of missing Commanders and would not bother [Chaos] for a long time.

However, this was a scenario only if Jaehwan could defeat those Commanders.

"For your information, in case you don't know, Commanders are much more powerful than Sameng Garam."

"I know."

"And in your current spiritual state, you have no chance at beating even one of them."

"I guess I can't deny that."

Jaehwan's spirit had been damaged because of the previous fight, yet he did not seem to be concerned.

"Are you here to ask that thought? I thought you weren't interested in [Chaos]."

Sirwen then glared at Jaehwan.

"...I'm here to get what I was promised."

"Promised?" Jaehwan asked in reply, and Sirwen slowly breathed out and asked, "What did you get in the 8th gate of the Eight Gates of Hell?"

Record of the Depths.

That was the book Jaehwan had found. A memory of the being that created the skill. The story from after Mulack created the expedition team, and until the team returned.

"...Really?"

"Yeah."

Sirwen trembled. It was unbeknownst to Jaehwan, but Sirwen had traveled to all parts of [Chaos] in search for any traces of her Godfather. Mulack, who was said to have reached the end of the [Depths], disappeared after.

Yet there had been no traces. The members who went with Mulack on the expedition had long perished, and she couldn't just climb up to the [Depths] and ask. The being at the entrance of the [Depths] didn't allow her to pass through either.

'I finally found it...!'

She was overjoyed. For over 900 years, she had been searching for any hint or trace. And now she had found it.

'And to think it was stored within the skill...'

Sirwen then asked Jaehwan again.

"Are you sure? Is it really from Mulack Armelt?"

"Yeah. Mulack Armelt, your Godfather."

"...And why should I trust you?"

Jaehwan closed his eyes, began searching his memory, and then started reciting.

"...It was in the tree trunk portion of the 6th region, when I found that [Egg]. In the region of harsh winters, the [Egg] was waiting for me with its precious glow."

"...?"

"I was confused. It was the first time I had found an [Egg]. My Godmother once told me about the experience, but it did not help at all as I was just too scared; being a parent wasn't something that could be followed just by listening to someone."

Sirwen felt tears flowing from her eyes. She knew what the story was about.

"How could I forget? Through the egg came a tiny life from within. The one who was born from the dream, and the one that will live on with the dream."

Sirwen silently listened to Jaehwan's story.

"Yes... the fingers that held the dream, the hands that can create the world, and the eyes that can see it... I realized my Godmother was correct...."

Jaehwan slowly opened his eyes and was faced with Sirwen's tearful eyes. Then, he finished the last sentence.

"I had fallen in love."

It was such a sweet voice as if it was from coming from a lover; Sirwen suddenly blushed and backed away.

"W-wh-what-what?!"

She slipped and fell on her hips. Jaehwan then casually asked, "Do you trust me now?"

Sirwen immediately shouted.

"D-don't read out other people's memories as if it's yours!"

Sirwen stood back up. The memory that Jaehwan had read out loud was when Mulack first found Sirwen in the 6th region.

"Hmm... so are all [Nightmares] born from [Eggs]? Besides, where is this winter tree trunk?"

"...It's in the north region of the Tree of Imagery in the [Great Lands]. All [Nightmares] are born from the dream within the Tree of Imagery and are found in [Eggs].... No, wait. This isn't what I wanted to know."

She asked Jaehwan, "What else?! Was there anything else?"

"Else?"

"Uh... like a word for me! Or something! Isn't there something?"

Jaehwan gave some thought to it and replied. "I'm not sure. Maybe, maybe not."

"What? What do you mean?"

"It's not just a simple book. It's like a complicated mixture of memories."

Jaehwan had blacked out for days because of the number of memories that rushed into his head the first time. When Jaehwan woke up, he realized it wasn't the number of memories, but the shape of it that was the problem.

"Shape of the memory?"

"Yeah."

He wasn't sure why, but the memories that Mulack left weren't in chronological order. They were short particles of scattered memories, and it was up to Jaehwan to rearrange them so that he could read and understand it fully.

"...So, I can't tell you even if I wanted to. The part of the memory I just told you was one of the very few clear ones."

"What... this is unfair!" she shouted. She had fulfilled her end of the bargain, but what she got wasn't complete in form. Jaehwan shrugged.

"So, why are you looking for Mulack? Because he's family?"

"...Why do you care?"

"Because, if you need his memories, it would be better for you to travel with me."

"...Huh?"

"Besides, it was in the [Depths] that he disappeared, so it makes sense."

Sirwen looked at Jaehwan and realized that this was his intention from the beginning. However, the [Depths] was a place where all [Nightmares] needed to visit someday, so it wasn't a bad offer. It was just that Sirwen didn't like the feeling of following whatever Jaehwan wanted to do.

Sirwen suddenly was struck by an idea. She was sure it would give Jaehwan some trouble at least.

"Wait. The memory... you said it was the 'shape of the memory' right?"

"Yeah."

"Then I have an idea."

Jaehwan was in a familiar dimensional space. A space with tiled flooring and pink-colored walls. Jaehwan asked, "Didn't you say you would never allow me to come here again?"

"...Well, I changed my mind."

"You said your privacy matters..."

"I said I changed my mind!"

It was Sirwen's [Personal Lab]. She fiddled with the hologram control panel for a while and then spoke brightly.

"Come! I'm done preparing."

Jaehwan walked to the center of the room where Sirwen was standing. Then, from the ceiling, some kind of metal device was lowered.

"...What is that?"

Jaehwan eyed the device suspiciously. The metal device was in the shape of a cross, and with straps that were surely meant to tie down someone, reminding him of old torture devices.

"It's a device that will help us connect."

"...Connect?"

"Ugh, didn't I explain already? It's the [Squeeze]!"

[Squeeze]. The definition of the word described what would happen, but in a very different way from normal. The term was used by [Nightmares] to link another spirit by force to 'squeeze' the memory out from the target.

-You can say you're a [Nightmare] only if you have done a [Squeeze].

That was a famous phrase between Nightmares. [Squeeze] was often done by [Nightmares] who had no motivation or inspiration. It was an act that gave not only the memory, but the feeling and learnings of someone experienced. Because of that, [Nightmares] who did a [Squeeze] didn't have to worry about needing inspiration. Of course, the outcome of the [Squeeze] depended on the quality of the target spirit.

'...But I didn't know he would be my first experience.'

Sirwen looked at Jaehwan. She had lived for 2000 years, but she had never done it as she objected to the idea of squeezing out another's experience. She said that it wasn't a true 'art'. However, most [Nightmares] did not care. They were too focused on making towers.

"So, I can just lie down here?"

"...Yeah." Sirwen spoke, blushing slightly. She also did not do the [Squeeze] because of the erotic nature of the behavior itself. [Nightmares] valued the spirit, and the act of [Squeeze] made a [Nightmare] connect to another spirit completely.

Sirwen shook her head to drive out those thoughts, as Jaehwan asked, "Why are your hands shaking?"

"S-shut up! I'm going to start!"

"Go on."

Sirwen bit her lip.

'Let's see if you can be so relaxed after we start this.'

The [Squeeze] involved a very painful process for the target.

In the next moment, tens of spiritual tentacles came out from Sirwen's spirit and charged at Jaehwan.

Jaehwan's spirit was bitten by the tentacles, and a loud gasp was heard. But it was Sirwen who let out the gasp, not Jaehwan.

Then the [Squeeze] started.

Chapter 95: Path of the Depth (4)

'His spiritual energy is...'

Jaehwan's spirit was enormous, beyond Sirwen's imagination. The number of memories rushing through her mind was just too much.

"Ugh..."

She tried to keep herself together. If she didn't focus, she could end up trapped within Jaehwan's spirit or be traumatized for the rest of her life.

After a while of trying to fight her way against the waves of memories, a powerful feeling struck her. A feeling of being connected.

When she opened her eyes, she was in a vast space. A dark space with countless stars. She shook in excitement. It was a feeling that she had not felt before.

'So, the other [Nightmares] were right.'

She wasn't too fond of the words that [Nightmares] used to describe the feeling of being connected. The 'feeling better than sex', or 'pleasure beyond imagination'... it all felt too racy and vulgar to her.

But this. This was much more than any of those explanations.

'So, this is the inside of an Awakener.'

In the vast space, countless stars each told their stories. Sirwen carefully avoided being sucked into their gravities and traveled through the space.

'I can't go too far or else I will fall into an [Uncanny] state. I'll just find the memories of my Godfather and get out of here.'

[Squeeze] also posed a danger. It was, after all, learning directly of another's world in the most intimate way. It wasn't uncommon that a [Nightmare] would fall in love with the target after [Squeeze] was done.

'...I don't want to fall in love with this fool.'

Her breathing became heavy and her body began to heat up. Her world was colliding with Jaehwan's. It was like mating. A feeling more powerful than any sexual desire. Sirwen fought hard against those feelings and searched.

'Godfather... please... huh?'

Then, she found it. A star that seemed to have been created recently that held a very similar feeling.

It was Mulack's energy.

Sirwen quickly approached, and surges of memory flashed at her.

'Ah...!'

Her eyes became teary. She was almost there.

'He's there!'

Mulack Armelt. One of the 13 great [Master Artisans]. The one who created legendary towers even before the age of 1000, and created even more to follow. She clearly remembered how bright her Godfather was. He even acted as if he knew the future. That's why Sirwen couldn't understand. Mulack was great in every way, whether it was making a tower or physical might. Even if it was in the [Depths], no one should've been able to harm Mulack.

Yet he disappeared, without leaving a word to his goddaughter.

'Mulack!'

Sirwen finally found a trace.

Yet, why? She couldn't approach any further. It was as if she was swimming in the sea, against the strongest tides. She then looked beyond and saw meteors flying in her direction.

'Waaaaah!'

A few particles struck her, and Sirwen was swept away. Mulack's memory disappeared from her sight, her body swept away by the sea of meteors. Then, after a while, she felt that she had stopped in a place where there was gravity. She was inside a certain star.

"....Dammit! Dammit!"

She knew.

'I'm in the [Uncanny].'

The place of unconsciousness. Mulack once told her that all hallucination skills were created with the [Uncanny] as its motivation.

'I need to find a Pathfinder.'

There was only one way to escape. The only consciousness that existed within the space, was the one who knew the way out. It was called Pathfinder. Sirwen quickly looked around. She was standing in a certain city and there were countless people walking by.

'Wait- this place...'

She knew this world. It was a famous world amongst [Nightmares]. She directly copied the fashion from this world. It was a place most visited by [Nightmares] through the root of the Tree of Imagery. It was the world that was not found by [Cultivators] for a long time because [Nightmares] had been protecting it from being found.

'World 294, Earth.'

[Uncanny] always formed with the target's homeworld as its motive.

'I see... so he was from Earth.'

She then heard people whispering.

"Did she just drop from the sky?"

"No way!"

At least she was wearing clothes that weren't weird in World 294.

'Let's act calm.'

The ruler of [Uncanny] was the unconsciousness itself. If she was found to be a being from outside, the world would turn against her and start attacking her to eradicate the uninvited guest.

She then mixed into the crowd.

"Ugh, I can't get any jobs, man..."

"Are there any unemployment benefits or something?"

People spoke of living.

"I can't even pay my school loans."

"Yeah. Well, I still have to finish school, so..."

People spoke of schools.

"Hey, she's so hot!"

"Damn, that girl's cute!"

People spoke of Sirwen.

Through all sorts of discussions, Sirwen quickly assessed what this 'Earth' was like. It was then-

"Move away!"

There was a boy in a baseball cap. It seemed like he was running away from something. As he ran past, Sirwen saw his face and was shocked. It looked like the person she knew.

"Wait... ?!"

Chapter 96: Path of the Depth (5)

She reached out and as her finger touched the boy's shoulder, she felt a spark of electricity.

"Kya!" she screamed. She then realized she found her target.

'Pathfinder!'

She began running after the boy, but there were others after him too.

"STOP! STOP RIGHT THERE!"

There were men in blue uniforms.

'Are they the peacekeepers here?'

Then came a shout from the people around them, and they were all saying the same word - Police.

"The kid's appeared again!"

"How foolish to stay as a kid."

"HEY! Get that kid, will ya?"

It was very weird. Why was it a crime to stay as a kid? Sirwen quickly followed, and soon found the boy at a dead end in the corner of an alley, surrounded by policemen.

"Give up, kid."

As she watched the police approaching the boy with a metal pipe in his hand, she felt something was wrong. Just then, a policeman guarding the entrance of the alley cautioned her.

"Hey, young lady. This place is dangerous. Move along."

"...What did he do?"

"Huh? Oh, he rejected becoming an adult," the policeman informed her as he laughed.

"It's a crime punishable by death."

Sirwen was dumbfounded. Earth seemed like a very strange place if it was real. However, it didn't seem real. She had never visited Earth, but she could see that.

"Are you all crazy? What are you doing to the boy?!"

"Ugh, lady... huh?"

The policeman then spoke to her, noticing something on her head.

"You look weird."

"Huh? Isn't that a cosplay outfit?"

They were looking at her horns.

'Dammit, I should've hidden them.'

"Young lady, can you show us your ID?"

She had to be careful not to draw attention to herself, but it was too late. She focused on activating her magic to kill off these men and save the Pathfinder, but-

'...W-what?'

The fire that was gathering in her hands immediately died out as soon as it started.

'My magic's not working!'

And that was her mistake. The policemen, who saw the fire gathering in her hands, began to change like demons.

[ALERT! ALERT!]

[FOUND NON-REGISTERED ENTITY]

[REMOVE IT!]

The policemen charged at her. Their eyes were now filled with hunger and lust as they grabbed Sirwen. She looked around for help as her mouth was covered by a policeman, but there wasn't anyone. She felt a terrible fear. This was the world that was ruled by the unconsciousness.

"...Move!"

A boy's voice was heard and one of the policemen fell.

Then, there was the sound of a pipe being swung again, each time accompanied by the sound of a skull being crushed. Someone's blood splattered over Sirwen's cheeks. And when the last policeman fell down in front of her, a boy appeared, covered in blood. Sirwen thought, 'This man doesn't change even when he's a boy.'

The boy then turned to Sirwen and asked, "Who are you?"

The Pathfinder of [Uncanny] always took the form of the target's conscious age.

'So, this boy is him?'

Sirwen was amused. That proud man actually had a mind of a boy.

'But it should have been obvious.'

As she had heard from the small Jaehwan, this world was a world that forced everyone to become an adult. Considering the fact that the world of [Uncanny] was formed to symbolize reality, it seemed that the real Earth might be quite similar in some sense.

As Sirwen organized her thoughts, small Jaehwan spoke.

"So, I guess you were swept up by the Wave of Memories?"

"Wave of Memories?"

"Yeah, sometimes there are memory particles that are swept here by meteors. This is the first time a living being like you came."

Small Jaehwan seemed to be excited by that.

"You've lived here all your life?"

"Yeah."

"And you're always being chased?"

"Yeah."

"Why do they try to make you an adult?"

The question was unexpected so small Jaehwan began thinking. There was no way he would have an answer. It was a world made out of unconsciousness. There was no way that there was a rule that had a reason...

"Because everyone else is an adult."

Sirwen was dumbfounded. It was very simple indeed. Everyone was in the world was the same in a certain way that they did not accept any differences. Jaehwan asked, "What is he like? The 'me' on the outside."

Sirwen smiled. How should she explain it? What would make this boy happy? In fact, she did not know much about Jaehwan.

"He's like you."

"Is he an adult?"

Sirwen pondered for a bit and answered, "No, he's a kid."

Jaehwan seemed to be happy at that answer. He was so cute that Sirwen felt like hugging him tightly, but the boy spoke again.

"I'll have to get you out."

"Do you know how?"

"Yeah. That's my job."

"What is your job?"

"Getting lost memories to the right place."

Sirwen understood what he meant. It was why they were called Pathfinders, after all.

"You brought some memories with you too."

"Huh?"

"Those particles on your clothing. They are memory particles."

She realized there were pieces of shining white rocks on her clothes. They looked like particles of meteors. She carefully removed them.

"I think there are emergency ones too. You see those red ones?"

"Is that even a thing?"

"The redder it is, the more serious of an emergency it is. If I don't get it back to where it was, something might be happening on the outside."

Sirwen then thought about the situation outside. There were the Lords of the [Great Lands] that could attack at any moment. What would be the most serious emergency?

'Wait...'

She became pale.

Chapter 97: Path of the Depth (6)

It had been a week since Sirwen met the small Jaehwan. She was able to watch him sleeping by the sewers and stealing food from liquor stores. Then, he went to higher ground to get the reception from the public WiFi.

"When a passage opens, the reception becomes unstable."

And when a passage did open, he went to find particles to retrieve.

Sirwen empathized with the boy. Even if she knew that this world was not real and was just a part of his imagination, she still had to ask.

"...Are you okay?"

With this life? She couldn't add the last part.

"...What about it?" the small Jaehwan asked. To him, this was the normal way of life. There was nothing else he needed.

"Do you do anything else? Other than sending back those memories."

"Hmm..."

The boy seemed like he had never even thought about it. Sirwen thought she made the wrong choice by asking that. It seemed cruel to give hope to one who did not know hope. Then the boy spoke.

"I see memories."

"Memories?"

"Yeah."

The boy pulled something out from his pocket. They were white rocks.

"I don't send all the memories back."

Sirwen realized they were particles of memories. She asked, "Can you do that? Won't it cause trouble?"

Jaehwan shook his head.

"It should be okay. It's not that important."

"How do you know that?"

"Because of the color."

According to him, memories differed in colors of white, green, blue, and red, in that order of importance. White memories weren't really important. As the boy caressed the rock, the memories shot up like a hologram image.

It was the memory where Jaehwan's mother was holding him when he was young.

[I'll read you this book today.]

It was a famous book that even Sirwen knew. It was included in the [200 recommended books to create a good tower].

'It... was... something with a prince I think...'

She then began to concentrate on the mother.

[So, did the Little Prince go to Earth?]

[Yes, he did.]

It was about a prince. A Little Prince who had lived on asteroid B612 came down to Earth.

[...So, the Little Prince said. "It is only with the heart that one can see rightly; what is essential is invisible to the eye."]

The Little Prince believed in the power of imagination, or the power of looking at the important things hidden from plain sight. But Sirwen knew the end of the story.

There was no way that the Little Prince could live on without accepting what was in front of him. So, to end the story, the Little Prince had to die. The only way that he could keep his innocence was through death.

[But what happens to the world after the Little Prince leaves?] the boy asked.

[Huh?]

His mother was surprised. It was a question that had never been asked before in a world where people did not care.

[The world that the Little Prince left behind.]

[That's...]

[Who saves that world then?]

Sirwen became silent.

[That world is...]

The young mother pondered. What would be the best way to avoid the child from being hurt?

[Of course, the Little Prince will save it.]

[But he's dead.]

[No, he is not dead.]

Then, the story came. A lie made up by an adult for the child's sake.

[He lives on Earth.]

She claimed that the Little Prince had not died, and was still living to save the planet. It was a lie, a false story. But the young child listened carefully as if he really believed in it.

Sirwen then realized that the story was the foundation of his life.

In next moment, she felt her heart sink.

Why was this memory a 'white' color? Why was this memory 'unimportant'?

This man... how far had he given up on life?

Just then, a WiFi receptor in the distance began to make noise. Small Jaehwan stood up immediately.

"We found it."

"Huh?"

"The way out for you."

At the top of a skyscraper was a strange hole. Small Jaehwan and Sirwen looked up at the hole, and then he spoke.

"I call that place a 'doggy door.'"

"Doggy door?"

It was a strange name, but it was kind of understandable. A doggy door was too small for normal adults to go through. Sirwen felt a bit bad at the thought of leaving the place. It was weird because she hated it so much when she was first trapped.

"I would've stayed longer with you if I had more time."

"I don't need it."

Sirwen then asked again, "But you liked having me around, right?"

He did not answer. However, Sirwen liked the silence. It was the best positive answer that the boy could give.

"We have to go up there. I think we have to get to the roof."

Both of them then began climbing up the stairs of the skyscraper. The 'doggy door' would not stay open for too long. Sirwen panted as she ran up.

"You're quick for being so young."

"I'm not young."

"How old are you then?"

"I forgot."

Sirwen then asked again.

"How old do you think I am?"

"About 2000."

It kind of annoying to hear, even if it was true.

"Do all the people outside live that long?"

"...Not all."

"But they become adults though, right?"

Sirwen couldn't answer; she wanted to deny it. She wanted to say that there were some who became adults on the outside but stayed young on the inside.

Chapter 98: Path of the Depth (7)

[ALERT! ALERT!]

[REMOVE INFILTRATORS!]

Adults from around the building began to chase after them. Small Jaehwan quickly killed the people blocking their way as they ran up. Sirwen wanted to ask, 'Aren't you afraid of them?'

However, she knew the answer. He would say-

'I am not afraid.' Or, 'They are only numbers. They are not real.'

"It's time we part ways."

They had arrived at the roof.

"That's your way out."

There was a hole a bit further away from the fence of the roof, just enough to be reached if one jumped. It was getting smaller by the second.

[REMOVE THEM!!]

More adults began rushing out of the door to the roof. Small Jaehwan fought to hold them back as he spoke.

"I have a question."

"Huh?"

"Do I have friends outside?"

Sirwen couldn't ask. Did he have a 'friend'? There were a lot who loved him. Chunghuh, Cayman, Euren, Karlton... leaders of Ten-Clan, and others.

But, were they his friends?

He was revered, admired, and worshiped. However, no one understood him.

He was just too powerful. Someone beyond imagination.

"Yeah. A lot."

He was just a man, after all. He would feel lonely too.

Sirwen then realized that Jaehwan had been alone for too long.

"I see."

She couldn't see small Jaehwan's face as he answered. She suddenly became teary as she looked at him. She knew it wasn't possible, but she had to ask. She tightly hugged the boy from the back.

"What?"

Small Jaehwan flinched at the sudden contact.

"Do you want to go with me? Get out of this place, together."

"Together...?"

"Yeah."

The boy answered, "No. I have to stay."

Even if there was no one around, even if the world itself was against him, the boy decided to stay. To protect this world. To never give up.

Sirwen then realized that his mother was right. That made-up story was not a lie at all. The Little Prince had not given up this world.

"Now, go."

Siren felt tears flowing down her cheeks.

"Yeah. I'm going."

Sirwen then turned back. Just like the boy, she had a job to do.

'But maybe... this isn't goodbye after all.'

She glanced back at the boy who was running against countless adults rushing in, towards his own world. Sirwen thought to herself, 'Maybe I should tell him about the boy.' When he became lonely, or when he could no longer bear the burden that had fallen on him, maybe then she would tell him.

'Goodbye, Little Prince.'

When she realized it, she was back at the Wave of Memories.

'I should give up on Godfather's memory.'

She couldn't risk falling into [Uncanny] again. Besides, she wasn't sure how long had passed since she was inside. She didn't know about the time flow yet.

'But I think I can make a good tower now.'

She couldn't find her Godfather's memories, but her level as a [Nightmare] had increased.

'I should join his expedition team. I'll have him tell me the memories slowly.'

She thought as she held onto the red particle, 'Oh, I didn't check what this memory was about.'

Red was an important memory from what she heard. She caressed it, checking to see what it was about.

'This...'

The memory came into her mind, and within it was the information from Mulack's [Record from the Depth]. It was about a being that Mulack had met before he entered [Depth].

The disaster of [Chaos] – Sole-King Catastrophe.

'Sole-King Catastrophe?'

She read the memory.

[Information]

Individual: Sole-King Catastrophe

Title: The first Awakener, Disaster of [Chaos], King of Dead Men

Approximate Power: ???

Description: Sealed away by 'Void Factory' made by the first [Masters] at the beginning of [Chaos]

Etc: Void Sword

Why was this memory red? She couldn't understand it. They had to go through Catastrophe to get to [Depth], but they didn't need to fight him. If the one who entered [Depth] was an Adapter at the stage of a General, or an Awakener with their own world, he or she had the right to enter [Depth].

Beside, Catastrophe wasn't a being that could be fought.

And there was no one powerful enough to fight him in [Chaos]. Not even the Generals...

'Wait. Is he...?'

Then, she began to puzzle out some of Jaehwan's actions that had not made any sense. Suddenly, she felt her consciousness shattering into pieces.

'No... I have to stop him!'

She hoped that she was not too late as she fell unconscious. Sirwen only woke up after two weeks, and it was after Jaehwan had faced Sole-King Catastrophe.

Chapter 99: Path of the Depth (8)

9th Region. Palace of the Lord of Darkness.

Laika barely managed to finish his report. Then came a low calm voice.

"I see... so that's what had happened."

Laika flinched at that voice. He even thought of running away instead of reporting it himself. It was that severe of a loss. They had lost three Greater Generals and ten Lesser Generals. It was too great to overlook. Besides, Sameng Garam was only a Greater General, but had the power equal to that of a Commander. And yet, he had died in [Chaos]. How did that happen?

"So... Garam died."

Laika bowed his head in fear. The man in front of him was the right-hand man of the Lord of Darkness. He was mentioned by his title.

Strategist of the Darkness.

There were a lot of strategists and advisors, but when mentioned in the [Great Lands], it usually meant this man.

Sameng Hoon.

He was the 2nd Commander of the 9th region and the Prince of the Sameng Family. He was also the older brother of Sameng Garam.

"I always thought he'll move on like that."

"..."

"How was his last moment? Was he satisfied?"

"...Y-yes, sir," Laika answered. This man was most feared not because of his sheer might, but because of his vicious methods and deep knowledge.

"Look up."

Laika looked up. He did not want to meet his eyes with the man, but he had no choice.

'Please don't kill me,' Laika thought. He couldn't understand what Sameng Hoon was thinking. Laika slowly lowered his head. He couldn't bear to look into Sameng Hoon's seemingly all-seeing eyes.

"A few days ago, I made a trip down to the [Roots]. I wanted to get some fresh air."

...Roots? What direction was this story heading in?

"It was a world hidden by those [Nightmares], so I was looking forward to it. And it really was. I did not know such a world existed."

Laika quickly thought. What was he talking about? Was he trying to send him out on a scout mission to the remote lands? No, he wasn't. Then, Laika became hopeful.

'Is he forgiving me?'

Maybe this man was thinking of forgiving him for some unknown reason.

'I mean, I couldn't do anything at all.'

Who would've guessed a [Product] could be that strong?

"And I brought that as my souvenir."

Sameng Hoon pointed at a corner of the room. There was a picture Laika had never seen before.

'What is that?'

It was a drawing with a beige background, with the crooked dark figure in the center. On the bottom, it was written [Ceci n'est pas une pipe], which he did not understand. They were not words that were used in the [Great Lands].

"Isn't it great?"

"It really is, sir!"

Laika agreed quickly. He didn't know anything about it, and Sameng Hoon had brought it back.

"That drawing, what do you think it is?"

Laika looked at it again. He didn't know.

"Is it... a cigarette pipe?"

Fortunately, it seemed the answer was close to being correct.

"Yes. It is an object that LOOKS like a cigarette pipe."

Laika felt a certain uneasiness at that emphasis.

"Laika, then, can you read the phrase below?"

"Sorry, sir. I don't understand the language..."

Sameng Hoon then waved his hand, then the phrase was translated on the space above.

Ceci n'est pas une pipe.

This is not a pipe.

Laika looked at it dumbfoundedly. It was a drawing of a pipe, but the words said that it wasn't. What was that? Sameng Hoon then spoke astonishingly.

"Isn't it great?"

"Huh? Y-yes..."

"It drew a pipe, but denied that fact. How did the creator think of that?"

Laika couldn't even understand what he was talking about now.

"Laika, do you really think that is a pipe?"

"Y-yes... it looks like..."

"No, it's not a pipe."

Laika couldn't continue.

"However, we still call it a pipe. It doesn't have the feel of a pipe, or a place where we can put stuffing to light it up. It's just a drawing after all. But we still call it a cigarette pipe. Isn't it weird?"

That was correct. That was, after all, just a drawing of a pipe. Not the pipe itself. Laika nodded.

"Y-yes! That is right sir!"

"Yeah, but that's the same with everything else. There are a lot of pipes all with different looks. But we still call them pipes. Isn't that... weird?"

"Y-yes, it is, sir!"

"So, after giving it some thought, we come to this question. What, then, is a 'real pipe'? Is there such a thing?"

Laika looked at the pipe again. It was a pipe, but it wasn't at the same time. He understood what Sameng Hoon was saying, but became uncomfortable at the same time.

Was this really about the pipe?

"It's an amazing piece of art. It's hard to think of it that way when you're an Adapter living inside a system."

Laika nodded, but he couldn't get it. He understood what kind of question the picture posed. But what about it was so important to think about it?

"Do you see why it is important now?"

"Yes, sir. It is a very amazing piece of work."

Sameng Hoon nodded.

"You know art."

"T-thank you, sir."

"Then, it's for you to answer now."

"Y-yes?"

Laika flinched. Something wasn't right.

"I had a question when I saw the drawing."

"..."

"What is a 'General'?"

Sameng Hoon looked down at Laika.

"It... it's a being, powerful and dignified, amongst all in this land."

"Is it? Really?"

"Yes, sir."

"I see. But, then..."

Silence fell.

"Who is it referring to?"

"...Y-yes?"

"Does it mean Bargas over there?"

Sameng Hoon pointed at Bargas the Frost, who was standing in a corner of the room.

"Or Masiha?"

He then pointed at Masiha the White, in the other corner.

"Or me?"

Finally, he pointed at himself. Laika wasn't sure what was going on, but he knew it wasn't going in his favor.

"Y-y-yes, sir..."

"I see. So, that's a General." Sameng Hoon smiled, "Then, what are you?"

Laika felt his heart sink.

"Are YOU a General?"

How should he answer? Laika couldn't find an answer to that.

"You failed to destroy a [Product] and lost all your comrades... and yet you still came back alive. Are you still a General, a powerful and dignified being?"

"Th-that's..."

He couldn't answer. If he claimed he was, then that meant he was a disgrace to all Generals. And yet, if he said he wasn't, then he was disgracing his rank as a General. There was only one answer to this question, after all.

Laika realized.

'....I see.'

His fate had been decided the moment he walked into this room.

Laika silently closed his eyes.

Sameng Hoon stared at Laika, stuck onto a canvas with his head cut off, and rubbed his chin.

"Hmph. We'll call this, [This is not a General]. What do you think?"

"It's wonderful, sir."

Bargas the Frost bowed his head. It seemed that he was not at all bothered by what happened, as if he had seen this many times. Sameng Hoon laughed and asked, "Where are they now?"

"We lost access to the [Narrow Door] so we are not sure, but we're guessing he has arrived at the [Void Factory] by now."

"So, they're right by the [Depths]."

Sameng Hoon nodded.

"Prepare to depart. Call in the 5th and 6th Commanders."

"We will need approval from the Lord to summon Commanders. How should we proceed, sir?"

"The Lord is busy at the moment. Don't bother him with petty issues like this."

"Yes, sir."

The Generals left the room, and Sameng Hoon looked over at his collection. Those were souvenirs he collected from World 294. There were drawings, cartoons, and even gaming consoles. He then stopped in front of the last item. It was because of this piece that he had traveled to World 294.

A living body. Pale and fragile. It seemed that it had been sleeping for a long time, so it was malnourished. This was the real body of the [Product] that was running rampant inside [Chaos]. It was the body of Jaehwan that Sameng Hoon had barely managed to acquire through a lot of bribes to the [Nightmares] of the Union.

"Courage to kill myself? Bold words." Sameng Hoon smiled, "Let's see if you have that courage too."

Then, the door to the room opened.

"Commander!"

Sameng Hoon was bothered during his 'Alone Time'.

"What is it? I told you not to bother me when I am alone."

"S-sorry, Commander. But I have a question."

"What is it?"

"We don't have the [Narrow Door] anymore. How do we go into [Chaos] now?"

Sameng Hoon scoffed, "Didn't he already say? To come after him if we have the courage to kill ourselves."

"Huh?"

Bargas was shocked by what he just realized.

"You don't mean..."

"Yeah, we'll do what he wants us to."

Sameng Hoon spoke as he drew power to his hand. The crime of bothering him during his alone time was unforgivable.

"You're the first."

Chapter 100: Catastrophe (1)

Three weeks after the war was over, Jaehwan and his Depth Expedition Team were at the Void Factory, the entrance of [Depth].

"It's here," he mumbled as he watched the building in the distance. He already had the knowledge of the place from Mulack's memories.

This half-circle building was the final door to the [Depth]. It was what surrounded the Dead Man Palace, the place of Sole King Catastrophe.

"Everyone stop!"

Euren and Cayman quickly made the forces behind them stop and line up. Jaehwan thought, 'There are too many.'

He had repeated many times that not everyone would be allowed into the [Depth] even if they followed, but they still had a total of 3,000 soldiers.

-We can still join even if we're weak!

It was [Chaos]'s oldest dream. It was everyone's dream to at least try.

'Ugh... this is a mess. And the one that NEEDS to go is still knocked out.'

He thought as he glanced at Sirwen, who was being carried on Chunghuh's back. Jaehwan had already decided to take Sirwen with him. It wasn't because of her character or anything. It was just because she was very useful. She was, after all, a [Nightmare]. However, she was knocked out while she was doing that squeeze thing and she did not wake up. Chunghuh's eyes met Jaehwan's.

"...What did you do to her?"

It seemed he was having misleading thoughts, but Jaehwan did not feel like explaining. Euren then came to him and asked, "Master, should we move in right away?"

"I'm not your Master anymore."

"You are still my Master, sir." Euren spoke sternly.

Jaehwan answered, "Let me remind you. I won't be a guardian once we're inside."

"...I know, sir."

"Good."

It was cold, but it had to be done. Euren knew this very well. Jaehwan was going to leave [Chaos] soon. [Chaos] was now on its own.

Then, the door to the Void Factory opened. From within, the roar of horned monsters filled the air.

'It's beginning.'

Within the factory, there was a conveyor belt. Some monsters walked out. Most were unihorns, but there were quad and pentahorns among them as well. All of them had that distinct factory stench.

'So, this is where those horned monsters are created.'

All the horned monsters in [Chaos] were created in this Void Factory. This was the feeling that Meikal got when he worked on the horns. The feeling of being 'made'.

'It was a factory made by [Masters].'

Jaehwan remembered Chunghuh's explanation. This factory was created to hold off Dead Men within the Dead Man Palace.

"Everyone! Ready for the battle!"

With Cayman's shout, the soldiers changed formation. Some pulled out their weapons.

"Hmph. I should switch out my weapon with their horns!"

Kanghwang and the other leaders seemed excited. There were a lot of quadhorns. Horns were best utilized when they were made to be used as weapons. They were very durable, and worked very well against Dead Men.

People began to fight. Jaehwan and the Awakeners mostly fought the quadhorns only. There were pentahorns also. There was the pentahorn Garknak, one that Jaehwan first killed when he first arrived at [Chaos], but there wasn't just one. A lot of them appeared. At the center was a huge Garnak, and there were a total of 8 horns on its head.

"Octahorn!!" someone shouted. Horned monsters beyond penta were very rare and were hard to even fight against. There was a rumor that they needed at least three 7th stage Adapters to fight one heptahorn.

But this was a octahorn.

The octahorn Garnak glanced around, checking each soldier one by one. It then found Jaehwan and his scabbard.

The Garnak immediately roared and lunged at them.

"Master, I will fight him!"

"No! Let me!"

Cayman and Karlton quickly blocked the way.

"Fools, it's seniors first!"

Chunghuh also joined in. An octahorn was very valuable. It was a good opponent to test their power against, but the reward for defeating one was just too tempting. Yet, Jaehwan ran out through them.

"M-master!"

Jaehwan would not have cared if it wasn't for a certain reason.

His sword was shaking tremendously. As he swung his sword against the charging pentahorns, his sword munched away at them right away.

'I guess it was obviously hungry.'

The sword was severely damaged during the fight against Sameng Garam. If it wasn't for the fact that the Spirit Weapon healed itself, it would be better to just replace it.

'It's about time to move up a level.'

According to Meikal, Spirit Weapons had levels. The reason Jaehwan chose to fight the octahorn was to see if his sword would move up a level because of it.

Jaehwan began to fight the monster and people stood behind him, not too far away from the scene. It was very dangerous, but they did not back away.

"What are you guys doing? It's dangerous, you fools!"

"Doctor, we must see this." Yong answered Chunghuh's shout.

Chunghuh frowned.

"WHY?"

"We might never get to see it anymore."

Everyone knew what he meant.

"Oh, I see what you mean."

Jaehwan had not chosen who to bring to the [Depth] yet. How many would be allowed to follow him? Chunghuh laughed. It seemed like he was confident that he was going to be chosen to tag along. Everyone smiled bitterly as it wasn't a case.

"Hey, why do you have such a face?"

The doctor then turned to Cayman who had the most trust from the entire team.

"Don't worry. He'll take you for sure," Cayman smiled, but he looked sad. Before Chunghuh could ask why, light burst from the front.

The power was mesmerizing to see. The world was torn in front of them, and the breath of the octahorn was decimated. The surrounding pentahorns couldn't even scream as they were destroyed.

The World Stab.

It was the attack that finally killed Sameng Garam in the end.

It was the attack made by the Awakener at the step of Creation.

The octahorn Garnak was lying on the ground, whimpering. All of its horns were consumed by Jaehwan's sword. Jaehwan then approached to put the monster out of its misery. Then, he heard a voice coming from within the factory.

[Wait. Let him live.]

Then came more voices.

[Amazing human. Smell of a General... none.]

[It's been a long time since I saw a being that can fight a Garnak at that level.]

[It's only a crude creation though.]

Jaehwan then sensed it. There were three of them on top of the building, three powerful spirit energies. They were only about the size of humans, but they were horned monsters. Everyone realized it quickly.

There were ten horns on each of their heads.

"Gods... they existed."

Some of the people moaned. Jaehwan narrowed his eyes.

'So, it's them.'

According to the record Mulack left, there was a total of four 'humanoid horned monsters' in the factory.

[They have the energy of horned monsters, but they weren't monsters. They were powerful as Generals and were as intelligent as the wisest of humans. They were the fallen disciples of God that were summoned under contract with the Master artisans...]

But there was only three. It seemed one had not come out.

"They're finally here, those Factory Overseers," Chunghuh said.

Chapter 101: Catastrophe (2)

There were three [Overseers] watching them. Each one of them had power similar to that of higher ranking Greater Generals.

"No need to fight them. They are not our enemies," Chunghuh mentioned. He had faced them 900 years ago.

[So, you wish to travel to the [Depth].]

A voice came from an Overseer with an adult-sized body covered with silver metal.

[Humans. Very. Brave.]

Another Overseer spoke. This one was small like a child with its body covered in a bronze-colored metal.

[Bah. Still a human.]

What spoke next was a woman-shaped Overseer. This one too had its body covered in a metal-like skin. Then, they turned to Jaehwan.

[So. It's you.]

It was as if they had been waiting for him.

[Come. The Administrator is waiting.]

Jaehwan walked in with Chunghuh and Karlton. Everyone wanted to come in, but the Overseers denied everyone else's access, in which Jaehwan forced to make them accept taking a few along.

"Dammit!"

"Karlton! Don't leave us!"

People shouted at the entrance, and when they turned, Cayman was looking at them. Chunghuh asked, "Why isn't Cayman coming along? The Overseers said it's okay... hey kid, do you know anything?"

Jaehwan did not answer. Chunghuh then realized that Jaehwan wasn't talking about something.

"Huh? What is it you're hiding?"

"There's something only he can do."

"Cayman?"

"Yeah, only him."

Chunghuh asked back, "What is th..."

However, the voice was overwhelmed by the sound of machine clattering as they walked to a place where machines were creating horned monsters.

"It's amazing. I never imagined horned monsters were created in such a way..."

They had arrived at 3rd stage area where almost finished horned monsters were being fine-tuned. The giant Garnak that Jaehwan fought had been taken in there. Small unihorns began gathering near the Garnak to fix it from different sides. The Garnak was glaring at Jaehwan.

[Visitor. Strong. In a while.]

The small Overseer spoke to Jaehwan at that moment.

[My. Product Name. Johniac. You?]

"Jaehwan."

[I. Johniac. You. Jaehwan.]

It seemed like his name was Johniac. Johniac then turned toward the Garnak and spoke.

[Garnaku. Valuable. Don't. Destroy. Create. One. In. 10 years.]

The Garnak's name was Garnaku.

"You make one of them every ten years?"

[Ten. Years. Hard. To make.]

Jaehwan understood. But if that was the case, there should've been a lot of these monsters lurking around. There weren't enough strong people in [Chaos] who could fight these monsters, let alone kill them. Johniac answered,

[Half Dead Man. Attack. Garnaku. Dead.]

"...Half Dead Man?"

[They. Attack. Factory.]

Jaehwan asked, "Have you fought them too?"

[Yes. We. Won.]

It seemed that the forces of the remaining Golden Sky Clan had reached this place. Jaehwan looked at Johniac. He was weaker than Sameng Garam, but stronger than other two Greater Generals.

Karlton then asked, "I did hear they were Disciples of God in the [Depth], but they are more than what I imagined."

[Blonde. You. Know. Us?]

"A bit, yes."

[What. You. Know?]

"Aren't you the Disciples of the God of Machinery, Daeus?"

[Hah, so [Chaos] has some smart ones these days?]

It was the other woman-type Overseer who spoke.

[Oh, and I think I know you. Aren't you the one who came 900 years ago?]

She then asked Chunghuh. He frowned.

[Wow, you've been through that and you still want to try to go up?]

It was then that the leading Overseer spoke in a cold voice.

[Don't be rude to the Administrator's guest, Ias.]

[What- I thought only he was the guest?]

[They are included for now.]

Ias closed her mouth. It seemed the one in the front was the highest rank of them all. That's when Jaehwan saw something on the backs of their necks. On the neck of the man Overseer were the letters:

EDSAC

'Edsac? Hmm...'

The other Overseers had it too. Ias had the word IAS on it, while Johniac had the word JOHNIAC. It was as if they were written there to show the product name.

'That's weird. They seem like more machines than those other monsters.'

Jaehwan asked, "...Where are we going?"

[To the Administrator.] Edsac answered.

'So, he's probably the fourth one.'

There were four Overseers according to the Record of the Depth. But there were only three with them right now.

[We're here.]

Edsac spoke at the front of a giant gate.

Eniac the Administrator.

The giant figure that was covered in golden metal introduced himself.

[So, it is you who opened the 'Creation'.]

He spoke politely. In fact, he used many gestures and expressions that really made him look like a human.

'Eniac...?'

Jaehwan thought for a second and asked, "Do you know the planet called 'Earth'?"

Eniac stopped.

[Earth, you say?]

"It's my home world. It's called World 294 in this place."

Eniac's expression shifted. It seemed like he was even smiling.

[And why is it that you are asking?]

Eniac, Edsac, Ias, Johniac... Jaehwan thought these names were familiar. And now he remembered. He had learned these names when he was studying computers.

ENIAC.

The name of the 'first computer' ever to be created on Earth. That's why Jaehwan thought that they had some kind of connection.

[The God who created us came from the remote place in the dimension. Maybe that remote place was the place was called Earth.]

"God?"

[Yes, God.]

Jaehwan became confused and Eniac asked,

[Do you... not know about the Depth?]

Jaehwan did manage to get a few pieces of information, but he didn't have a lot of information yet.

'Maybe I can have them explain to me.'

Jaehwan did not answer and Eniac spoke.

[I see that you do not. To put it simply, [Depth] is the Land of the Gods.]

Land of the Gods.

[If the [Great Lands] are ruled by Lords, the [Depth] is ruled by the Gods. There are a lot of Gods that control the region and rule over them.]

"So, they are like Lords?"

[Similar, but also different. Lords are 'Adapters'. Gods are different from them.]

Jaehwan analyzed what he heard and asked again, "So, what is a God?"

[If you ask me 'what'... That is a hard question.]

Eniac became silent. Jaehwan then added, "In my world, God was the word to describe the being that is almighty and all-knowing."

Eniac laughed.

[That is quite fascinating.]

"So, the Gods here aren't like that?"

[No, not at all. You can get close to it, however.]

Eniac then continued,

[So, Jaehwan. I do not have the exact word or definition to describe what Gods are, but I know what kind of beings are called Gods.]

He looked straight at Jaehwan and spoke.

[It is one such as you. Jaehwan.]

Chapter 102: Catastrophe (3)

"I'm a God?"

[Yes, you are.]

"Why?"

[Because you opened a 'Creation.']

An Awakener who created the world. Master of one distinct world.

[Awakeners who open Creation are referred to as Gods in the [Depth]. They can even be considered somewhat higher than Gods in some instances.]

Power beyond that of the Gods.

[Unlike them, an Awakener does not require a Vicegerent to do their bidding.]

"A Vicegerent?"

At that moment, a memory from the Record of the Depth was unlocked, giving him more information. As he read the memory, he also listened to Eniac's words.

[Yes. All Gods of the Depth require a Vicegerent as they cannot work alone. They exist because they lend their world to their Vicegerent or their followers.]

Jaehwan continued listening.

[The more followers they have, the more powerful they are. It is very rare for a human spirit like you to become a God.]

"Then, how were the other Gods born?"

[Most Gods represent the outcome of higher entities that obtained enough Karma over a long period of time.]

"Higher entity?"

[You must know the beings that are called [Cultivators] in the [Great Lands].]

Of course, Jaehwan knew. They were the Demons or Angels that cultivated [Products] within towers. Jaehwan then remembered they called themselves 'higher entities'.

[They acquire Karma through cultivation. You may think of it as... 'public service points'. If they have enough Karma points, they can be permitted by [[Big Brother]] to be independent and receive their own world.]

Jaehwan then realized why Beastlain was working so hard. He then realized that he had not asked an important question. He heard it from time to time, but he never cared to ask.

Big Brother.

An entity that can 'permit' one to become a God. Even the Record of the Depth did not have entries about Big Brother.

"What is [[Big Brother]]?"

All Overseers flinched at the question. The one that broke the silence was not them.

"As far as I know, they are the organization that protects the System," Karlton answered.

"That's how I know it too... but it's awkward. Are we wrong?"

Chunghuh spoke as he looked around at the Overseers. Eniac smiled bitterly.

[You can consider it that way. To most humans, [[Big Brother]] is certainly that.]

Jaehwan then thought Karlton and Chunghuh had not really informed been about the Big Brother, hence their calmness.

[Gods... but God among the Gods. Guardian of the System. That is [[Big Brother]]. But I do not want to go deeper than that.]

Eniac spoke, but it seemed like he was sad after he said that. It was an unanswered question, but Jaehwan decided to not ask any further. But then...

[Big brother~~ Scary man~~]

A song was heard. It was Johniac who was singing.

[Hide~ Hide away~ Or you will be found~]

[Keep quiet, Johniac!]

Edsac smacked Johniac's head and he became silent. It was short, but there was a hint hidden within the song.

'What if...'

Jaehwan then realized why they were so sensitive about Big Brother.

[...Johniac.] Eniac sighed.

Jaehwan asked, "Did Big Brother kill your Gods?"

[...]

"Is that the reason why you all are staying in [Chaos]?"

[...You sure have good insight.]

Johniac walked up to Eniac, and Eniac rubbed Johniac's head and spoke.

[Yes. We lost our God to Big Brother and were expelled from the [Depth]. That is why we are here.]

Then the memory was unlocked. Eniac's words had triggered some part of the Mulack's memory. Jaehwan closed his eyes to concentrate on the voices from the memory.

-We lost our God.

-But our power was still useful, so we contracted Big Brother.

-At the price of our lives, we were sent to [Chaos] to protect the living.

It was Eniac from Mulack's memory.

-If we had the Giant Golem – Machina, we wouldn't have had to...

-Mulack, please. If you can, find our Machina.

The voice was cut off from there. Jaehwan then opened his eyes.

[HEY! Let's stop chatting and cut to the chase!]

[Right, right.]

Ias was annoyed and Eniac nodded.

[Jaehwan, I called you for one reason.]

Jaehwan then realized what's to come was the real reason why they had called him up.

"What is it?"

[You must give up on going to the [Depth].]

Give it up?

"What are you talking about?"

It was Chunghuh who spoke instead. Karlton also added, "Please, explain to us."

Eniac nodded.

[To tell you the truth, you cannot go to the [Depth] right now.]

Chunghuh then shouted in anger, "What? Who are you to decide?"

[Human, if you think your insolence can...]

[Ias, back off.]

Eniac stopped Ias and spoke again.

[You are right. It is not for us to decide. But the ones who 'can decide' will not accept you.]

The one who can decide on who can enter the [Depth]. There was only one being throughout all of [Chaos].

"...The Sole-King will not let us?" Chunghuh asked.

[Oh, he will do more than just not allow you.]

Chunghuh stopped talking.

[If you are thinking of 900 years ago, things have changed. You know it as well. The King did not fight you seriously back then.]

Chunghuh's eyes shook. Eniac then added, [Besides, you had 'him' that time.]

Mulack Armelt.

He was the reason why they managed to get past the King. Mulack did not defeat Catastrophe however.

'He made a deal.'

Chunghuh remembered. He did not know the details, but Mulack made a deal with the Sole-King.

"Why will he block us?" Jaehwan asked.

Eniac turned to Jaehwan again.

[It's because of you.]

"Me?"

[He is angry at you.]

Angry? What did he do? Jaehwan then remembered what he had been involved in with the Sole-King. He fought him directly at Gorgon Keep and...

"...Is it about that Extra Large Dead Man?"

Eniac nodded.

[Yes. Magrit was one of his favorite servants.]

So the situation was simple. The only one who could open the path to the [Depth] was Sole-King Catastrophe. However, he was mad at Jaehwan for killing one of his favorite pets. So, the angered King would not open the way for Jaehwan.

"Is that right?"

[...The wording makes it seem like the situation is less serious then it actually is, but yes. You are right.]

Jaehwan nodded. Eniac then smiled. It seemed Jaehwan had understood. If he gave up...

"Open the door then."

[...Yes?]

"Open the door to the King."

[I don't think you understand...]

"No, I do." Jaehwan was determined. "I'll settle the score with him directly, so relax and open it."

The Overseers were shocked and Ias shouted angrily.

[What the heck! Did you even hear what we said?]

Chunghuh was cackling while holding his sides. Eniac then spoke coldly.

[I cannot do that.]

"Really? Then we have no choice."

The air around them became tense as Jaehwan began letting out the energy from his body. Ias also let out her energy while shouting.

[We should've done this from the beginning!]

Chunghuh and Karlton braced themselves and Eniac also began focusing his energy. He couldn't dare to open the door to the Dead Man Palace. It was better to fight Jaehwan to stop him from going in, rather than risking to open the door to the place.

Before the fight broke loose, Jaehwan spoke.

"Giant Golem, Machina."

[...?]

The air suddenly froze. Eniac was shocked to hear the unexpected name from Jaehwan.

[How did you learn...]

But what came next was even more surprising.

"If you open the door, I will find the lost Golem and bring it to you."

[H-how did you know about Machina?]

No one knew about Giant Golem Machina in [Chaos], but Jaehwan had no intention of explaining where he had learned about it.

"Will you open or not?"

Eniac turned back to the gate. On the wall of the giant room was a keyhole. Eniac looked down.

His finger was shaped like the key.

It was the key to the door, the door of disaster itself.

Chapter 103: Catastrophe (4)

The corridor was pitch dark. Jaehwan only relied on the sound of Eniac's footsteps coming from the front to walk.

'They probably have come by now. I don't have much time.'

Jaehwan was concerned, but he did not express his concerns. Eniac then spoke.

[I have never seen a human like you.]

"I hear that a lot."

Eniac laughed.

[You really think you can PERSUADE the Sole-King?]

Jaehwan did not answer. He was not sure at all. However, he was never sure about anything for all the things he had done until now.

"I'll see when I try it."

He also had his reasons for doing this.

Record of the Depth.

After he came across the memory, he had planned for this. The memory had nothing about Big Brother, but there was a lot of information about the Sole-King.

[I wish you luck.]

"Thank you."

Within the corridor, there were a lot of horned monsters, even if they weren't visible. Some growled, but some seemed to be friendly toward Jaehwan. It was because of his serpent tattoo, or the sign that he was the Master of Gorgon.

[You don't utilize your 'Seal of Daeus'. If you activate that from now on, you will never be attacked by horned monsters.]

Eniac explained.

[We gave that seal to the humans. We gave 7 Horned Guardian monsters along with it, but it seems that your guardian horn has disappeared. I am not sure where or why it's gone...]

Jaehwan remembered that when he was given the seal, the previous Master wasn't in the best state to do such a thing. It seemed that had resulted in an imperfect transfer.

Eniac examined the seal and repaired it.

[If you find any of our disciples hiding within the Depth, this seal will help you get their help.]

They walked. And after a long time, Eniac stopped.

[You will have to go alone from here.]

His voice was shaking. It was a sign of fear.

"I will be back."

[Please come back within an hour. If you cannot come within that timeframe, I will have to seal the door.]

Jaehwan nodded and walked forward. And after a while, he arrived at the door. It was made out of horns of horned monsters. Then he realized that the entire corridor was made out of the same material.

'So, these stopped Dead Men from coming out.'

Jaehwan opened the door and walked in. The power inside immediately swept up to him. Beyond him was a giant palace. There were a lot of Large Dead Men, and within them were Extra Large Dead Men. There were two of them that were as powerful as Magrit, and about 10 others who were a bit less powerful. And there were countless Large Dead Men at the level of 7th stage Adapters.

But these weren't the real enemy.

'It's coming.'

Jaehwan shivered. After he had reached the 4th step, [Theory], he could now understand.

This being was a God. Chaos itself.

[Finally, you have come.]

One sentence. It was just a voice, but blood spat out from Jaehwan. He realized he had no chance against this power. He then remembered the factory as well as its corridors and the gates. Was it made to 'seal' this being inside?

It was not possible. How could one 'seal' such a being?

[You have come to die, Human Awakener.]

Jaehwan felt like he would choke even by just being watched, but he barely spoke.

"I'm not here to die."

He raised his head to see, or tried to see. Catastrophe asked,

[...Then? Are you here to 'defeat' me again?]

Jaehwan felt his insides being damaged again as he spat out blood, which turned into silvery powder.

'Dammit, I can't even speak well.'

Jaehwan talked again.

"I'm here to make a deal."

Silence fell. In the next moment, laughter filled the Dead Man Palace. Every Dead Man was laughing. Jaehwan took a deep breath and spoke again.

"First Awakener, Catastrophe, the King of the Chaos. Once God, but now a King."

It was the information he read from the memory. Jaehwan then knew there was no going back after saying this. His plan that he thought up after getting the memory from Record of the Depth required him to overcome this moment.

"You, the once best God in the Depth, is now the mere gatekeeper. How ironic."

The laughter stopped immediately. The surrounding energy began to spike and all Dead Men began to breathe heavily. It was the anger from their master being shared to them. Jaehwan could barely fight back his fear. Jaehwan added, "Catastrophe, do you not wish to get revenge?"

Revenge?

"To the one who kicked you out of the [Depth] and sealed you into this cursed place."

The power loosened a bit at once, and Jaehwan continued.

"I know the promise you made with Mulack 900 years ago."

The atmosphere had been altered to a point where Jaehwan could feel it too.

[...How do you know?]

A deal made 900 years ago. The deal that was never made. Jaehwan spoke to him.

"I will fulfill that promise. I'll be Mulack's successor."

[Human... do you know what it means?]

Jaehwan then realized his gamble was moving in his favor.

"Yes. Catastrophe, I will bring you to the end of the [Depth]."

At the same time, outside of the factory, the one who was sleeping woke up.

"...Are you awake?"

Sirwen Armelt opened her eyes and frowned at the bright daylight. She moaned as she tried to get up, and the man next to her helped her up. Sirwen glanced around. There was a forest to the north, a desert to the east, and plains to the west. To the south was a giant factory.

Sirwen was confused. Was she back in [Uncanny]?

"You've been sleeping for too long."

Sirwen then realized it was Euren who was beside her.

"Where are we...?"

"We are in front of the Void Factory. You've been sleeping for 2 weeks."

Sirwen then relaxed. She wasn't at the Uncanny. She had finished Squeeze.

'I see. The Void Factory.'

She then realized the weird scenery of the place. This was the center of [Chaos].

'Wait- Void Factory?'

Sirwen was then struck cold. If they were at the factory, they were now right before [Depth]. That meant...

"Jaehwan! Where is he?!"

"Oh, he is..."

Sirwen became pale as she heard where Jaehwan was. It has been 2 hours since he entered the factory.

"I have to go! He should be stopped!"

"What are you..."

Euren was confused by Sirwen's panic, but before he could do anything, a member who was scouting the area came running to him.

"We're doomed!"

People turned to the man who was running and panting, but nobody was worried. This was the group of the most powerful fighters in [Chaos]. Whatever happened was not going to be much of a problem. Kanghwang, who was bored of waiting, stood up immediately.

"What are you..."

But at that moment, the man froze and disappeared into silvery powder. Everyone stood up in shock. No one had sensed any sign of attacks.

"...What?"

In the next moment, a figure appeared through the desert dust. But there were more. Someone moaned.

"N-no..."

This was the power that they knew well. They hate and feared this power. There were hundreds of such, and in front of them, all five of them were greater than any of the others.

'No! The [Great Lands] has made a move already? But how?'

Sirwen was shocked as well as she checked the face of the person who first appeared. She knew him well. He was the most feared Commander of the 9th region.

"B-bring Jaehwan!"

Nobody could hear her voice. It was the beginning of the massacre.

Chapter 104: Catastrophe (5)

After an hour passed after Jaehwan and Eniac left for the Dead Man Palace, Chunghuh and Karlton felt the presence at the same time - an earthquake powerful enough to shake the whole factory.

[What's going on?]

The Overseers seemed to be surprised.

[Humans, are they bored?]

[...This is a bit much to be considered in that way.]

Another explosion was heard. Edsac turned to Johniac.

[Johniac, connect to the outside.]

Johniac closed his eyes, and energy rose from him and flew out. It was his skill. Johniac shook.

[Scary. Men. A Lot.]

He was afraid.

[They. Scary...]

Johniac then frowned in pain. It seemed the horned monster that he connected to had been killed. Chunghuh and Karlton looked at each other.

[Hey- stop!]

Ias shouted, but Chunghuh and Karlton quickly ran out toward the entrance.

'It's them!'

It was obvious.

"Doctor, this is.."

"Dammit. So the kid was right."

Before they arrived at the factory, Jaehwan did warn them of this situation. Most of them thought he was too concerned with it. They didn't think Generals would kill themselves to come all this way.

'They want more than just Jaehwan.'

[Chaos] was now a valuable place. It was a place where powerful beings that were as powerful as Lesser Generals were being born, thanks to the tower created by Jaehwan and Meikal. If left alone, it was apparent that [Chaos] would grow strong enough to compete against the [Great Lands].

That's why they acted, to destroy and pillage as they always did.

'It won't be easy this time.'

[Chaos] was different now. They had Jaehwan. That fact made Chunghuh feel relieved.

"How many have come?"

"I don't think they will have more than 50."

But as they neared the entrance, they realized they were wrong. It was hard to count as the spirit energies were stacked against each other, but it didn't feel good.

'How many have come?'

As they opened the door, their question was answered in most horrible way possible.

The scene was horrible enough to resemble the disaster from 900 years ago.

Chunghuh glanced around. Leaders were almost on the verge of dying, with some Awakeners already dead. And...

"Cayman!"

Cayman was dangling as a Commander was holding him by the neck.

A hundred Generals. It was too large of a force to move to just capture a [Product]. Sameng Hoon smiled bitterly. The [Great Lands] would now face chaotic times.

'...Jaehwan, was it? You do not know what you have done.'

The destruction of Place of Reincarnation was that severe. The current Prince of the Palace at the 9th region was out of luck. If it was any of the other Lords, things would have been much worse.

'Well, we were almost out of [Fruits] too. I guess it was necessary.'

Sameng Hoon glanced around. There were a lot of Depth Expedition Team members lying around, barely alive. Sameng Hoon's men tried not to kill them if possible.

'They will be my offerrings. I can't let them die here.'

Sameng Hoon smiled.

"Hey, how long are we doing this? Shouldn't we enter now?"

Sameng Hoon frowned.

"I'm the one in charge this time. You should stay back."

"...I know. But it's too boring."

The one spoke was the Commander from the Green family, the Commander who as at the 13th stage of adaptation. He was the 2nd Commander, Green

Chundo.

'Damn these green insects.'

Not all Generals that joined this time were from the 9th region. Out of the 100 Generals, there were 50 9th region Generals, and the other 50 were from other regions and families.

20 from the Sameng family, 20 from the Green family, and 10 from the 7th region.

They all had different reasons for joining. The members of the Sameng family were called by Sameng Hoon himself, but the Green family said that Jaehwan had killed one of their members.

'The problem is those 7th region fools.'

There were ten Generals, with three of them at the Greater General level. Their leader was Greater General Nishimoto, the one who had power similar to Sameng Garam.

-We heard about the Palace. Shouldn't we finish it before the other Lords find out? We wish to help.

That was the message sent by the 7th region, but it was more of a threat. If the news of the destruction of Palace spread, the one who would be responsible was the Lord of Darkness who was in charge of protecting the Palace at the time.

'I can't let the other Lords find out what happened yet.'

Sameng Hoon quickly decided and accepted their offer.

'It will be our chance.'

Sameng Hoon realized that even if they had failed in invading [Chaos] through the Golden Sky Clan, the [Product] had now become much more than any of that.

'I just need to capture him, and I will take the Tower of Awakeners from him.'

There was the Awakener who opened the [Creation], and the tower created from such an Awakener.

[Sameng Hoon, is it true that there are more [Fruits]?]

It was Sameng Yuha, the 4th Commander of the Sameng family, who sent the whisper to Sameng Hoon. She was one of the five Commanders Sameng Hoon had brought over, and the strongest. She was even stronger than Sameng Hoon himself.

[Yes, Sister.]

[I had to 'die' because of you. I don't know how many [Fruits] there are, but you must give a portion to the Sameng family. Remember that you're the Prince of Sameng before you are Commander of the 9th region.]

[I know, Sister.]

Sameng Hoon scoffed inside.

'Fruits... hah.'

The reason why the other Generals had joined in this fight was because of the [Fruits] that Sameng Hoon had. Before he started this plan, he messaged the Generals that he had the leftover [Fruits] and all would be supplied to those who joined.

It was a lie.

He did not have such [Fruits]. But, he did not care.

'I'll get one if there aren't any.'

From where? There was only one place that had [Fruits]: the end of the [Depth].

'But I don't have to go to the 'end' to get it.'

Sameng Hoon and a few people knew that the beings that ruled the [Depth] were Gods. And there were some of them who had ways of getting those [Fruits]. The only problem was that they were really powerful and vicious.

So if the opponent was powerful, what did you need to do to acquire an item from them? A trade.

Until now, it was impossible to trade with those Gods. They were the Gods of the Depth after all. What would they need?

'Until now. What if I offer them an 'Awakener'?"

The one that the Gods of the Depth wanted the most was a powerful Awakener.

It was the reason why these Gods made deals with the [Cultivators] to get [Products]. A [Product] was a potential Vicegerent that they could take into their world. A [Product] was one who had talent and had not yet adapted to the System. An Awakener was the best candidate. However, Awakeners were rare and mysterious.

Until now.

'I will create Awakeners and sell to them in exchange for [Fruits].'

And with the [Fruits], he could create a new Palace of Reincarnation solely for the 9th region. That was Sameng Hoon's plan.

With that, only the 9th region would have Generals who did not fear death. And the dead Generals would have to surrender to the 9th region to be revived.

'The [Great Lands] will soon be ruled by the 9th region.'

Chapter 105: Catastrophe (6)

Sameng Hoon glanced around.

'It's time for me to clean it up.'

The group of people with a middle-aged man in the front were holding off well even after a lot of them had been subdued.

'Was it Cayman?'

It was very interesting to see an Awakener fighting against many Lesser Generals. Sameng Hoon then picked up a sword from the ground. He then walked toward him and threw it.

It was just one sword, but it made everyone turn silent for a second. Then came the scream.

"AAAAARGH!"

Yong screamed in pain as he lost two eyes, Kangwhang moaned with his one arm cut off, Mukeuk fell down with his leg cut off, and Euren knelt as he held onto his waist.

Sameng Hoon then glanced at Sirwen. She shook in fear.

"Hmph. So, the [Nightmare] girl was here too."

[Nightmares] who betrayed Darkness - even if they were rare beings and were protected by the Union, he couldn't let her live. Sameng focused his energy, but Cayman blocked her.

"Huh?"

He was heavily injured and barely standing, but his eyes were clear.

"You are brave. I like you."

Sameng Hoon walked up to Cayman.

'This is... the power of a Commander.'

Cayman felt terror striking him as he felt the energy becoming greater as Sameng Hoon walked over. He bit his lips. He had tried so hard for so long. Yet he was still too far behind.

"Where is Jaehwan?" he asked.

"Tell me, and I will let you live."

Cayman couldn't do anything. The only thing he could do was lift him up.

'He befits the title 'General' better than that fool, Laika.'

Sameng Hoon was astonished, but that was it. If men like these were left alive, they would pose a potential threat to [Great Lands].

"Kill me."

An Awakener was a valuable asset, but he didn't need all Awakeners. He didn't need one who was going to fight to the end like this one.

'I'll make him an example.'

Sameng Hoon raised his sword and Cayman saw it coming.

'I'm sorry, Master.'

Then came the voice.

"Cayman!"

Two figures came rushing against Sameng Hoon's sword. Chunghuh and Karlton's swords both broke. Even both of them combined weren't enough to fight off a Commander's sword, but it was enough to twist its direction, which allowed them to take Cayman away.

"Hmm."

Chunghuh bit his lips as he felt the power coming from Sameng Hoon.

'Cayman, how did you manage to fight that monster?'

Even Jaehwan wasn't that terrifying.

"Doctor... Where is..."

"He's not back yet."

Cayman looked disturbed.

"Two hours... have passed... did he..."

"We do not know yet."

Cayman mumbled. He then looked to the back.

"Overseers."

There were three figures that appeared from inside of the factory.

[Sameng Hoon...? What is the meaning of this?]

It was Edsac who spoke first. He glanced around at the silvery powder of the dead people and horned monsters.

"Long time no see."

[...I asked, what is the meaning of this.]

Sameng Hoon frowned. They were too arrogant. They were weak and arrogant. Sameng Hoon couldn't accept it. However, Generals and Lords weren't allowed to touch Overseers. It was because they were holding the Sole-King back.

For the most powerful God, 12 Lords and Big Brother had to join forces to seal it away. Sameng Hoon spoke.

"I'm looking for the [Product]. I will return once I find it."

[The [Product]. Are you talking about a human?]

Sameng Hoon did not answer.

[You people do not change even after thousands of years. You consider a living being as a thing.]

Sameng Hoon was shocked to hear that. He was being lectured by a machine.

"...Anyway, open the door."

[And for what reason? I cannot do that at the moment.]

"It seems that my [Product] has run off inside."

Edsac replied sternly,

[As I said, that is not possible at the moment.]

"Not possible? ... You don't understand."

Sameng Hoon then removed his smile for the first time.

"Open the f*ck up, you worthless piece of scraps!"

Sameng Hoon let out powerful energy which even cracked the side wall of the factory.

[How dare you...!]

Ias' arm shook and changed its shape into a blade. The Overseers were ready to fight. Sameng Hoon's glared at them.

'I don't know how strong that Sole-King is...'

Sole-King Catastrophe. There were a lot of rumors about him.

'A long time ago, the Lords of the 12 regions were much weaker than they are now.'

And Sameng Hoon's power was much stronger than that of those Lords from the past.

He knew he was more powerful. He was not afraid of some fallen God. That was why he was here. He quickly cut off Ias' limbs and cut down Johniac's waist. Edsac's head was sliced off.

Chunghuh looked at the sight grimly.

'...No way. We cannot defeat him.'

Chunghuh then felt someone grabbing him from behind.

"D-doctor... what's going on? Can we win?"

It was Yong who was bleeding from his both eyes.

"Doctor, please. Tell me."

Chunghuh then realized that he couldn't see. He didn't see the terror in front of them.

"W-Where's Master?"

Chunghuh then thought of Jaehwan. Jaehwan went to face Sole-King Catastrophe. Chunghuh knew that being was much more powerful then

Sameng Hoon. However, Chunghuh also knew that Jaehwan would've remained as Jaehwan even against such being.

Maybe he might've died by now. However, he would not have given up.

'You are always ahead of us.'

Chunghuh then felt his fear being lifted.

"Yong. Master has not come yet." He spoke calmly, "And we have not lost yet either."

He did not give up hope.

"We can still fight."

Jaehwan wasn't here. But so what? Was that a problem?

"...I see."

Chunghuh took Yong's hand and helped him get up. He couldn't see, but he still rose to stand. The other members slowly rose at once.

Kanghwang without his left arm, Mukeuk without his right leg, and Euren with a huge cut on his waist - they helped each other stand up.

They were [Chaos].

'I can't believe this.'

Sameng Hoon looked at them in astonishment. He had shown them the power beyond imagination. Power enough to make them cower in fear. But why?

Why were they trying to fight? Why were they looking at him like that?

Sameng Hoon was astonished, and he came to fear them at the same time.

If all Awakeners born with the tower are like this, could he really sell them to the [Depth]?

'I'll kill them all and just return with the [Product].'

He could always create Awakeners again. What's important was the [Product] and the tower that was made by the [Product]. The others were irrelevant.

Sameng Hoon then unleashed his energy. From his back, blueish pure energy came out from his body formed a giant blue lion and charged forward.

One slash threw Chunghuh and Karlton away. The other members who were barely standing were covered by the giant shadow.

The shadow of death.

It was the last, but they weren't wrong.

There was no miracle. The world did not change.

Even then, their efforts weren't in vain.

That's why they did not close their eyes. They faced their death.

Yet because they did not close their eyes, they saw it.

'Ah...'

The lonely sword that fought against despair. Bolts sparked up as the sword clashed against the claws.

And through it came the man.

"I'm sorry. I'm late."

Jaehwan was here.

Chapter 106: Catastrophe (7)

"Stay here."

Jaehwan spoke to Cayman as he swung his sword to make the Blue Lion back off.

"It's you."

Sameng Hoon looked at Jaehwan, barely standing. There was corruption seeping out from his body.

'This mere [Product] brought this...'

Because of him, the [Cultivation] failed, the years of work put into overtaking [Chaos] failed, and the Palace of Reincarnation was destroyed. Moreover, the 9th region lost many Generals.

And now, over hundreds of Generals and 5 Commander had to 'die' to come into [Chaos].

"So, is it him?"

"...We came all the way here because of 'him'?"

5th commander Migata and 6th commander Serim began expressing their complaints. They were weaker than Sameng Hoon, but they were still one of the strongest in the [Great Lands].

Sameng Yuha even added, "...Did you really need me?"

They couldn't understand needing to come all the way here because of one [Product].

"I know, but it was necessary," Sameng Hoon answered, smiling bitterly. He had to prepare for the unexpected. For example...

Sameng Hoon glanced over at the factory.

'But that's not possible.'

At that moment, Jaehwan began unleashing his energy. It was the power that killed Sameng Garam. His world began to unfold in front of the Commanders.

"So, he opened the [Creation]. Still weak though."

Chundo of the Green spat as he watched. Sameng Hoon couldn't disagree. He had faced many Awakeners throughout his 5,000 years of life with very few who were at the 4th step. Jaehwan was weaker than those people.

Jaehwan's unique world unfolded. On the top of the Tree of Imagery was 'Eye of Asura' with crows flying around. Corpses were strewn all over the place.

"...What the hell is this place?"

Sameng Yuha spoke and other the Commanders were surprised as well.

"The eye. Does that symbolize the [First Nightmare]?"

"Maybe it's [Big Brother]."

"What're those? Crows?"

"I like how he sees humans as corpses."

They all had different comments, but they had one same thought.

'He's crazy.'

No one feared Jaehwan's world. No matter how unique it was, the world did not materialize fully. The [Creation] was just the beginning of the step.

There were a few more steps to take after the world was formed, but Jaehwan did not have anything other than the way to see his world.

'So, he was their hope? They fought because of him?'

Sameng Hoon scoffed. He was disappointed at what those people trusted.

'Then what you will now see is despair.'

Jaehwan began to walk and unleashed his [World Stab]. A few of the Lesser Generals perished as they charged toward Jaehwan. The Commanders just scoffed.

"What a puny attack."

With just a few swings, [World Stab] disappeared.

"May I?" 5th Commander Migata asked. He was the weakest of the Commanders, so it was natural. But Sameng Hoon shook his head.

"No, I'm going to fight him."

"Oh? You will do it yourself?"

Chundo the Green cautiously requested, "Let me join then."

"No, I will do it alone."

"Bah." Chundo backed away as Sameng Hoon glared at him. The Green family had skills that enabled them to control the opponent's spirit and minds. There was a chance that he might steal the [Product] right in front of their eyes.

Sameng Hoon thought Jaehwan was very weak at the moment, but there was a chance for him to get stronger.

'No, maybe.'

Considering the time it took for him to grow, there was a chance for Jaehwan to become even stronger. Maybe he could grow to the point of becoming a Lord.

He then began unleashing his energy. It wasn't Spirit Power, however. It was more powerful, as the energy was from the System itself. Jaehwan's unique world diminished as the power from Sameng Hoon pushed it out. It didn't change the world, but it had made a space that trapped themselves.

'I See.'

Jaehwan then realized the difference between awakening and adaptation. If Awakeners made the 'world' use its power, then Adapters used the current 'world' and its power.

"Come. Let me see your best," Sameng Hoon taunted.

'He's strong,' Jaehwan thought as he looked at the power coming from Sameng Hoon. Then he drew another sword, the 'Fall' from his belt, and charged. The Blue Lion appeared and struck against Jaehwan. Jaehwan was struck, and made a counter attack. The lion writhed in pain as it was damaged from the attack, and Jaehwan's body bleeding.

"Good! I see how you defeated Garam!"

Jaehwan knew, however, that man was not using his best. The attack from the lion was getting harder and harder to block. The claws ripped his thighs off and the fang pierced through his stomach.

"Did you really think you got everything after you opened the [Creation]?" Sameng Hoon asked.

Had he beaten this severely after he came into the Chaos? Jaehwan began to shiver as he was being overwhelmed by the corruption. His ears, nose, and mouth were letting out dark smoke-like substances. Sameng Hoon laughed.

"Your spirit is corrupted. Have you faced the Sole-King?"

"..."

"It's disappointing how the King let you go alive."

Jaehwan then laid down his sword. He realized that the attack that was being made was very powerful but it was never meant to kill him. If it was, he should've died earlier.

"...What do you want from me?"

"Surrender. And join the 9th region."

It was an expected offer. Jaehwan asked, "...Is that it?"

"And bring the tower that you created."

That was also expected. Awakeners were very rare. If his tower was able to create a lot of Awakeners in a short amount of time, it was obvious that it would be sought over.

"What if I refuse?"

"Hmph. Refuse?"

Sameng Hoon smiled. "Let's see if you refuse even after seeing this."

With the snap of a finger, the ceiling of the space changed shape and began showing a video.

It was an unfamiliar palace. Everything was covered in black, so Jaehwan guessed it was the Land of the Darkness. The video was shaky as if it was being recorded by a handheld camera. Then the video captured a glass showcase. Inside were books, cartoons, computers...and a lot of other objects that were very familiar to Jaehwan.

'....Wait.'

It was unexpected, to say the least. The body, breathing shallowly without a word, was in deep sleep. It was the body that embodied his spirit for 20 years on Earth.

"You can 'still' re-live your life."

Life? Jaehwan couldn't believe what he was hearing.

"I will make you the 8th Commander."

The 8th Commander seat. It was too much of an offer to even consider for a being that was a [Product] until a few months ago.

"It's not only that." Sameng Hoon continued, "I will rewind your time."

And with that, the video changed. It was now showing a place with many high-story buildings, with crowds walking below. It was strange. He never imagined he would feel this way with that distinct sound.

Jaehwan knew where this place was.

Earth.

And the small country, Korea.

It was his home.

Chapter 107: Catastrophe (8)

Sameng Hoon said to Jaehwan, "I do not know why you hate this world. But I know one thing. That you hate going back in time."

Sameng Hoon had been gathering a lot of information about Jaehwan. After numerous bribes and threats against the [Nightmares] of the Union, he was able to obtain interesting videos from the Tower of Nightmares. It was the sight of Jaehwan refusing to go back in time to start the game again. So that's why Sameng Hoon knew Jaehwan was going to say this.

"You know that and you still offer me this?"

"Yeah, I thought you would say that." Sameng Hoon laughed. "I'm not offering for you to go back in time. I'm a Commander of the [Great Lands], but even I can't control time."

"...The Demon once told me that too."

Sameng Hoon laughed. "Yes, of course. I am not trying to give you your 'past'. It is different."

He continued, "Going back in time won't make all the horrors and nightmares you faced disappear. Isn't that right?"

Jaehwan did not answer, but he was right.

"You will still have traces. Scars. And all the memories that you had faced even if you go back in time. But you cannot forget it either. All of that shapes who you are. It's you."

Jaehwan couldn't object. He even agreed to his words. This enemy knew more than anyone else in this world.

"So, what I'm offering to give you is not the past. It's the 'present'."

"...Present?"

"Yes." Sameng Hoon nodded, "I looked at what you did, what you had to choose in order to stay in the 'present'. It was a noble deed, but I had a question. Was this the 'present' you really wanted?"

Sameng Hoon asked as he glanced around, "Answer me. Is this place, the 'present' you really wanted to protect?"

Jaehwan also looked around. Unfamiliar world, unfamiliar people. These were people who did not know him from his days on Earth. And Sameng Hoon added, "I am sure that this isn't your 'present'."

Sameng Hoon then pointed at the video on the ceiling.

"The time that you deserve or the one that you lost. The 'present' you seek is not here."

Jaehwan looked up. The people of Earth and the ordinary life within it.

"Become the 9th Commander, and you will be able to go there anytime you want."

Jaehwan understood what he was offering. He was really offering Jaehwan a chance to go back to his world in the present.

"Of course, you will find your family too."

Then the video showed a woman. She organized the bookshelves and took out the book titled, "The Little Prince". She smiled as she looked over the cover page silently. Jaehwan knew who she was. For the first time, there was sadness on his face.

Sameng Hoon smiled. He knew humans well. He too was a descendant of humans. All humans had 'longings', or the feeling of something that had been lost. Even Sameng Hoon felt a certain emptiness when Sameng Garam had died. He wasn't too bothered as he had lost human traits a long time

ago. But these humans were in a remote region, especially the ones who just got out of [Product] stage, were different.

Sameng Hoon had been preparing for this moment. He knew Jaehwan would not reject the offer.

Jaehwan asked, "...Let me ask you again. What if I reject?"

He still was asking of that. What an amazing [Product].

"Then you will lose your 'present' forever."

It was something that could be interpreted in many ways. Whichever it was, it wasn't good.

"What do you think? I think you have every reason to join us. And even if you go to the [Depth], you will not get what you want there. Besides, you do not have proof that you will reach the end."

Jaehwan fell silent. He then asked, "What will become of them?"

"Them?"

Sameng Hoon looked up. The people of [Chaos] were in the direction that Jaehwan was looking toward.

"Are you talking about those corpses?"

Those who died. Losers who adapted to living in this world called [Chaos]. Sameng Hoon looked at the people shouting at Jaehwan even though no sound was coming through, and then spoke.

"They will die. No matter the choice."

"...I see. So they will die."

Jaehwan then glanced at the video of a woman and closed his eyes.

'I'm sorry.'

His swords began to unleash the power and wield the flame of the fall.
Sameng Hoon narrowed his eyes.

"...What are you doing?"

Jaehwan declared, "I'm not going back. I'm going UP."

Sameng Hoon couldn't understand.

"...Why? Do you not want to go back to your home? Do you not wish to see your family?"

"..."

"Will you throw your 'present' at a trash can?"

"Trash can.."

Jaehwan smiled. Maybe he was right.

"I was in the trash can already."

"What are you..."

Sameng Hoon also began to wield himself with the blue energy.

Jaehwan wanted to go back. He wanted to see his family. But...

"Past, future, present, it doesn't matter in 'this world'." Jaehwan added, "I might be happy if I return, but then what?"

He swung his sword at Sameng Hoon's right arm. It sparked with blue fire, and Jaehwan took several steps back from the impact. But he did not give up.

"You will come back again and start the damn [Cultivation]."

Maybe he could protect it for a while. Maybe the Earth might be saved from [Cultivation] for as long as Jaehwan lives. But that was it. Nothing will

change.

Sameng Hoon said, "...You cannot stop [Cultivation]. It is the natural way of the world."

"Yeah, at least in 'this world'."

Jaehwan knew. In this world, [Cultivation] was the law of the world. It wasn't anyone's fault. It wasn't Sirwen who was born to make the world, or Angels or Demons who participated in [Cultivation]. It was the 'world' that did not specify it as a problem.

"So, I will destroy this world."

"Fool! Everything you love is a part of the world! Will you destroy all that you love? All that you consider valuable?"

"..."

"There is no system! It cannot be destroyed! It is Nature itself!"

Jaehwan did not answer and instead swung his swords. Sameng Hoon then gave up on persuading.

"You will give up."

The video disappeared. His cold voice filled the space.

"You shall die in your 'present'."

The energy was formed into a Blue Lion again.

'He's connected with his body anyway. If he dies, his spirit will find its way back to his body.'

Sameng Hoon knew Jaehwan had escaped to the Tree of Imagery without finishing his tutorial, so he was still living. It meant Sameng Hoon could drive him out to the [Great Lands] and think about it later.

'His spirit will take some damage, but I have no choice.'

The Blue lion roared and Jaehwan's ear began to bleed, which then turned to silvery powder. He felt pain throughout his whole body.

Jaehwan then saw the lion's fangs drawing closer and closed his eyes.

'I have no choice.'

'N-no! Kid no!'

Chunghuh became pale as he saw Jaehwan putting his hand into his cloth with his eyes closed. What came out was a dark stone, the one called the [Stone of the Forgotten Spirit]. Jaehwan then ate it. The blue fire then overwhelmed Jaehwan and he disappeared into the flame.

'No...'

Chunghuh did guess Jaehwan was up to something.

'So, was that why you didn't consume horns?'

Jaehwan had no other way. There were enemies at bay that were too powerful. And Jaehwan had no time to prepare. There was only one thing he could do: borrow power from stronger being.

However, it was the price that had to be paid that was the problem.

Chunghuh charged at the barrier and began swinging his sword.

"KID! Stop! Listen to me! Please! Stop!!"

The barrier was not even damaged but Chunghuh did not stop. Then, the Commanders came forward.

"Get off, insect."

Commander Serim kicked Chunghuh away, but Chunghuh did not take his eyes off. The Spirit Power was growing into something that was

unimaginable.

Serim stopped cackling and Migata frowned. Chundo also asked seriously, "What is that?"

It was Yuha who spoke first.

"Hoon! Open the barrier! We cannot let him continue! He is...!"

But she couldn't continue as the barrier began to crack and-

With an explosion, the space was destroyed. There was something terrifying inside. Some fainted even by 'sensing' the presence and some peed on themselves out of fear.

Everyone shook. A man walked through the explosion. It looked like Jaehwan, but it was no longer Jaehwan.

It was the one King who was above all in this world.

[Long time no see.]

It was Sole-King Catastrophe.

Chapter 108: Catastrophe (9)

The Five Commanders each faced the King's descension with different reactions. Commander Serim seemed to be confused. He had been told by Sameng Hoon that there was the possibility of fighting against Sole-King Catastrophe if things didn't turn out as planned.

Sole-King Catastrophe was one of the Three Ancient Gods.

However, the King didn't seem as powerful as he had imagined. He sure looked powerful, but it wasn't as much as he imagined.

"Isn't it enough to have a fight against?"

Serim spoke and turned around. But he had to change what he was thinking right away. Commander Magita was shaking severely as if he was having a seizure. He was barely standing with bubbles coming out of his mouth.

[How pitiful.]

Serim then turned to the voice. He thought it was toward Migata, but the King was looking at Serim directly.

[An insect cannot even see the true power.]

"What?"

Serim then unleashed his energy.

"No! Stop!" Sameng Yuha quickly stopped him.

"Do you not see that?!"

She too was shaking severely in fear. Serim was puzzled.

"What are you talking about?"

Then, horrifying laughter came from the King.

[You have the 11th stage as a Commander? Fools!]

Serim was the only Commander who had not reached 12th stage adaptation. Hence, he did not have the ability to see the King's true power, just like how Jaehwan couldn't see his true body clearly.

[Hmph. There's one that's quick to understand.]

Catastrophe spoke as he glanced over the direction where Chundo the Green was standing. He was already a mile away from where they were. Chundo thought, '...Impossible! Sole-King?!'

He regretted he had come. If he knew this was a possibility, he would not have joined the fight. They had a hundred Generals with 5 Commanders, but it was no use. No one could resist the disaster.

[The Green. I see... the fools that created the Spirit Stones by peeking into my world.]

Then, the huge shadow appeared behind him and reached out, extracting the time and space. At that moment, Chundo's body was held by the grasp of the shadow and from the distorted space, Chundo's body was crushed.

"Uggh...wugh....!"

All Commanders froze in place. The 3rd rank of the Green Family. 13th stage adapter. The powerful Commander was now lying in front of them.

Then, they turned to the same place. The place where Sole-King had appeared from. The place where their only 'hope' existed. They looked toward the Commander who brought them here, and the most powerful among the 5 Commanders.

There, they saw despair.

Sameng Hoon, with his remaining eye and badly injured body, was looking at Catastrophe. He was mumbling with disbelief as he barely stood.

"But how... the Lords of 12 Region sealed you..."

He gathered all the information, even the [Akashic Records] about Catastrophe. It clearly said that the Lords had sealed Catastrophe and he could not leave the Void Factory.

King looked at Sameng Hoon.

[...Lords of 12 regions?]

He spoke with a laugh.

[They sealed me?]

The laughter shook the earth, and the sky trembled. The world was laughing at him. Sameng Hoon felt as if his spirit was melting away. Then he realized it.

'I see...'

The [Akashic Records] was a lie. There was no way that Lords from the past, who were only about at today's Commander level could have managed to seal off the King. The King spoke.

[They didn't do anything. They were busy running away.]

Sameng Hoon then thought. He needed to get out of this crisis for now. They did not know what Catastrophe was up to, so the best solution was to talk things out. Catastrophe bowed and spoke.

"...O' the great King. We have no intention of fighting you."

[Hmm? Is that so?]

The King smiled.

"The only thing we want is that [Product] you used to come down to us."

[This one? Then I cannot let you have it.]

Sameng Hoon then asked, "...Wasn't it promised that you would not meddle with the Chaos? I believe you made the promise with [Big Brother]."

[Do not bring that name up ever again.]

Sameng Hoon flinched.

'I see. So, it was Big Brother. How strong is Big Brother then?'

Sameng Hoon had lived long, but he did not know much about who or what Big Brother was. But that wasn't important for now.

"I'm sorry. Anyway, I acknowledge that you do not have a 'Vicegerent' because of that."

Catastrophe then scoffed.

[This one is not my Vicegerent.]

"...Pardon?" Sameng Hoon asked back in shock.

'Not a Vicegerent? Then how...'

Then he realized something wasn't right. Gods didn't descend themselves in usual cases. They just let their Vicegerents borrow the power. But this Jaehwan had fully lost control over his body.

[This one said he will never give up his 'world.']

Being a Vicegerent meant the Awakener needed to accept the God's world. Jaehwan refused it however.

"Then you came because..."

[We made a 'deal'.]

"Deal? What is the deal?]

[You do not need to know. What you DO need to know is that you will all die.]

Then, all of [Chaos] began to shake. Storms came from the desert and waves came from the Southern Sea. The Northern Forestland was in flames and from the west came the Dead Men.

Sameng Hoon gritted his teeth.

"And by that, I assume you are not keeping the promise with [Big Brother]."

Catastrophe was angered. A mere insect, threatening the King? But a promise was a promise. It was his responsibility to answer it.

[No, the promise is still intact.]

"What!"

[The power is mine, but the will is not.]

And the world began coming down on the Commanders. Sameng Hoon then realized it was Jaehwan who called upon Catastrophe to create this disaster. He also learned that Jaehwan's body was in a very unstable state.

'It's imperfect descension. It won't take long to finish.'

The descension would not take too long. Jaehwan's spirit was too small to hold the Sole-King in place.

[Everyone, gather up!]

Sameng Hoon whispered to the Commanders.

[We have to hold for a few minutes! Then we will win!]

The world was falling down at them. Generals were powerful beings who could fight against thousands of enemies. But even then, they were used to fight against individuals, not nature itself.

Sameng Hoon then shouted, "Stay alive! 10 minutes. No, in five minutes, victory will be ours!"

And at that moment, Serim who charged at Catastrophe, blew up. It was just one blow. Then, Magita screamed as he charged at Catastrophe. He also ended up dead after getting crushed against an unknown force.

Sameng Yuha, also ran to fight against the King. She resisted the landslide, fought the sandstorm and hail of the southern ocean. And after she made it through all that, she disappeared into silvery dust just a few steps short of Catastrophe.

The last one to die was Chundo the Green. After losing his two arms, he tried to bring up insects from his mouth. He was going to let out poisonous insects, enough to kill everyone in the area. It wasn't possible to kill the King, but it should've been able to damage the body. But before he could manage to do so, a transparent sword penetrated his stomach.

[Don't take out that filth.]

It was the Void Sword, the most powerful sword that would make all beings perish.

Chundo's spirit became corrupted immediately and he turned to the Dead Man, pledging allegiance to the King. However, Catastrophe scowled and spoke.

[Explode.]

And he did explode to his death. Sameng Hoon couldn't bring himself up together. The world had turned to silver with everyone dying from left and right. Then, after a certain time, it became silent. Sameng Hoon looked around, but there was no one.

Someone was walking toward him. It only took 5 minutes for all Generals to be killed to be wiped out.

It was this day where Jaehwan's later gained the nickname, 'Commanderslayer.'

'You've won,' Sameng Hoon thought as he watched the God of Disaster.

Chapter 109: Catastrophe (10)

Jaehwan felt the power surging within him.

'This is the power of the Sole-King.'

It was power he was experiencing through his own body, but he didn't feel that it was realistic. It wasn't at the level of just destroying the lands and the world. It was controlling the world itself.

That was the power of the Master of Chaos.

Jaehwan knew that this power was the goal he had to strive for.

'...This is crazy.'

What's more important was that this power wasn't everything Catastrophe had. And even then, he lost to Big Brother and was sealed away.

'How strong do I need to become...?'

Jaehwan thought he had opened a possibility after he overcame the 4th step. But today, he saw 'impossible'. Then, as he thought, the fight was almost over. He felt Sole-King's spirit waning away, with his voice coming to him.

-You can only call me with the stone three times.

-You used it once this time, so remaining is two.

-You will need me when you meet [Big Brother] so that means you have only one chance.

-You have to thank your friend, or else your spirit could've only called me two times.

And the voice was gone. Then Jaehwan felt horrible pain gripping him. He knew his spirit was at the limit. He also saw darkness grasping him and tentacles coming out of him. He was becoming a Dead Man.

He felt the memories fading away. He was losing himself. He then wished if something could be there to kill him before he loses himself. Then he heard something touching him. Something that felt like a brush was tickling him.

Then he realized that it was that brush that made him stay.

Memories were coming back.

He then saw Jaehwan talking to Chunghuh long time ago, when he first fought Chunghuh at the training ground. Then, the other memories came back. Some were distant while some were embarrassing.

-They die because the 'ocean' exists, right?

-I guess so.

-Then I will wipe out the ocean.

Jaehwan was really embarrassed at seeing himself answering against the Question of Righteousness.

'...I was a fool.'

Reckless, foolish, and childish. He had no respect or compassion. He was a child.

But even then, Chunghuh never hated him. Then Jaehwan felt something within him: happiness. It was as if he was accepted by a world.

"Kid! Kid! Wake up!"

He felt pain searing through his body.

"KID!"

There was a voice. It was the doctor.

"KID!!!"

Kid, how long will you call me a kid?

"Jaehwan!!"

Jaehwan smiled. He opened his eyes and there was a 1200-year-old man looking down at him with teary eyes.

'You did it, old man.'

He still felt corruption within him, but since Catastrophe wasn't hostile against him, it wasn't doing anything from within.

"Why did you become a Dead Man! Do you even know what you were putting yourself into?!"

Chunghuh shouted but Jaehwan smiled.

"...I trusted you."

Jaehwan had made up his plan with Chunghuh in mind. With his 'Dead Man Slash', Jaehwan thought there was a chance for Chunghuh to reverse him from becoming a Dead Man.

He then saw Sameng Hoon panting. It seems the King had left him before giving him a final blow that allowed him to survive. But his spirit was destroyed severely, so he was going to die at any second.

Jaehwan looked around. There were no Generals anymore.

"It's done..."

Everything was done now. The Lords would not care about the Chaos anymore, as they would be busy rebuilding what they had lost.

'But something is weird.'

The Expedition Team members weren't too happy. Jaehwan then turned to where Sameng Hoon last was. Inside the space that he created earlier were the particles that showed video. It was now stuck on the ground, each particle showing the same video that was shown to Jaehwan again and again.

Everyone was watching the video of Jaehwan's body now.

Sameng Hoon looked up.

'...You will be left alone.'

The members looked weird as they watched it. It wasn't the excitement of victory that grasped them, but a different emotion. Sameng Hoon knew what it was.

Betrayal.

"...Master."

It was the North Gatekeeper Captain James who spoke first.

"What is that... video?" he asked.

"I had heard of the rumor... that you are not dead, but alive. I thought it was a false rumor..."

"W-wait! What are you talking about?"

"The Master is not dead?"

"...He is not one of us?"

People began to mumble and Cayman spoke.

"Hey, it's not important..."

"It's very important," James replied coldly.

Cayman couldn't understand. Why did it matter if Jaehwan was dead or not? Cayman then looked around at other members, but they too seemed to think the same thing. Some even asked this.

"...Come to think of it, didn't you acquire the [Fruits] when you got to the Palace of Reincarnation? What did you do with all those [Fruits]?"

"Wait! Are you accusing the Master of reviving back through the [Fruit]?" Cayman shouted angrily.

"...Then how can you prove that video!"

"He did not eat the [Fruit]! He..."

"Then WHERE ARE THOSE [FRUITS]!!"

Cayman couldn't say. He couldn't explain that he destroyed every remaining [Fruit].

'I see.'

He then realized why they were becoming angered. They did not trust Jaehwan. They did not join the Expedition Team to 'change the world'. It wasn't a noble idea that drove them. All they wanted from the beginning was only one thing.

The [Fruits].

That was the only thing they wanted. But what if their leader was one who did not want such thing at all? What if their leader was an entirely different being who did not share their pain?

Cayman looked at Jaehwan.

Suspicion began to turn into rage and began spreading among the people. Sameng Hoon smiled ominously from the distance. The reason why

people's emotion changed so quickly was also because of his Top grade skill, [Derange]. But the skill only worked when there was a spark.

It was people's darkness. It was their distrust against Jaehwan that brought this.

Chapter 110: Catastrophe (11)

"Master, did you come here through the [Narrow Door]?"

"Are you working with any of Renowned families or Lords?"

Euren tried to explain, but it wasn't easy. There were too many stories to unfold to explain everything.

'Right... that is your limitation.'

Sameng Hoon then used his final powers to control the video to deliver a final blow.

"T-this..."

"Impossible!"

People shouted angrily. They were raged. Some even ran directly at the person that was shown in the video.

"Cayman! What is THAT!"

"What have you done...!!!"

Cayman glanced at the video as people started grabbing him. He knew the scene very well. It was showing the Palace of Reincarnation where Cayman destroyed all remaining fruits.

"Why did you do that!!!"

There was no way to calm the crowds. Even Euren and the other clan leaders seemed to be in shock. Nobody knew what had happened at the

palace, but it was too late to explain. If he explained that he destroyed it because it would fuel an unnecessary fight over the [Fruits], would they believe him?

'It's done.'

Cayman closed his eyes. Maybe it wasn't because of Lords that their expedition failed 900 years ago. It was because they were human.

'Hehehe...'

Sameng Hoon smiled silently. His plan failed but at least one thing was a success. He had successfully destroyed [Chaos]. But then-

"I ordered him to destroy it."

Someone spoke up.

"I ordered Cayman to destroy those [Fruits]."

People turned at the voice. Cayman quickly whispered to Jaehwan.

[Master! What are you...!]

But it was too late.

"What is that! Why!!"

People began to shout in protest. James then asked, "Is it... because you are 'alive'?"

Silence fell. It was short but had enough impact to be transferred to everyone. Then, it was followed by a question. He is alive. He does not need the [Fruit]. Then why-

"...Master, what is your real purpose of going to the [Depth]?"

Chunghuh closed his eyes and Karlton bit his lips. Cayman clenched his fists. They knew the answer to that. That's why they wished Jaehwan would

not answer the question. They knew people will not accept his answer. Fortunately, Jaehwan did not answer. Then came another question.

"WHY! Why did you give the order to destroy the [Fruits]!"

Jaehwan did not answer. He couldn't answer.

He silently raised his sword and a few members backed away in fear. But what Jaehwan was after wasn't them.

The darkness began reaching out from him and his unique world filled the area.

"What is the meaning of this?!"

People then realized they were inside Jaehwan's unique world. What was he up to? People looked around frantically. But Jaehwan was looking from the top. Soon, people too saw something above Jaehwan faintly.

"Wait... is that?"

There was a thin line on top of his head. The link that was connected to somewhere.

"Connector...?"

Sirwen spoke in shock and people began their rage. But the rage turned into shock at Jaehwan's action. His sword moved against the connector. And with it, the link was broken.

With that, on the video, they saw Jaehwan's body inside the video losing life.

What did he just do? How could a human do that?

Jaehwan then put his sword away and spoke.

"This is the real life."

The spirit freed from the life defined by the System. The spirit spoke.

"I am going to the [Depth] to protect this life."

Silence fell. Unexpectedly, a man who broke the silence with his laughter.

"HAHAHAHA! You are crazy... you are MAD!!"

Sameng Hoon was laughing like a maniac. Everyone turned to look at him in shock. Was he still alive? But his spirit was now fading away into a silvery powder. He was at his last breath.

"I see. So, you have... even death..."

And he disappeared. People then lost energy to stand and slumped down. Mental shock struck them. Their minds calmed down as Sameng Hoon's skill was deactivated and they realized what they just had done.

Jaehwan looked at each and one of them.

Everyone was silent. No one dared to speak up. Some were even shaking. They couldn't bear to even look at the man who had just give up on his way back to move onto the [Depth].

Jaehwan turned back and began walking, limping from the damage he acquired through becoming a Dead Man.

But no one dared to run up and help him. They now knew that it was the way that only a free spirit could walk.

Soon, a few members stood and followed Jaehwan. It was those who were not suspicious of Jaehwan from the start.

Chunghuh was the first, then came Karlton. Sirwen then glanced around and quickly followed Jaehwan at last.

Then they saw the door of the Void Factory becoming distorted. Inside, was darkness. Catastrophe had accepted their entry to the [Depth].

Clan Leaders lowered their head and Euren bit his lips in sadness.

Jaehwan was now being helped by Chunghun and Karlton. Euren smiled.

'At least you are not alone now.'

Cayman also watched them walk away. He wanted to go with them badly, but he couldn't. Jaehwan had asked him to do something else.

And when Jaehwan took a step inside the [Depth], a voice came from behind.

"My King...!"

It was Euren. He was kneeling down, toward Jaehwan.

And with that, beginning with Cayman, the other Leaders started kneeling.

The Leaders were Yong who had lost two eyes, Kanghwang who had lost an arm, Mukeuk, who had lost his right leg, Aisa the Master of Dryad, and even Huidon, the Master of Garuda.

They couldn't follow the path they were walking toward, but they knew how noble it was to walk and be admired.

[Chaos] was kneeling down to him.

'Farewell, our last King.'

He did not invade, so he couldn't rule.

He did not rule, so he wasn't worshipped.

But even then, he was the King of [Chaos].

The last King that [Chaos] accepted.

The King had now left [Chaos].

Chapter 111: Kind of a fall (1)

[We still remember him.]

Euren Chiver – Chancellor of Carpediem Fortress

A woman was dreaming. It was when she was still a [Product]. Countless people died around her as they fought against monsters rushing in.

-You witch! You killed us all!

-You lured those monsters!

Hidden skill [Lure]. Her cursed passive skill made people around her dangerous. She didn't want the skill, but there was no use. Life didn't change even after she arrived at [Great Lands].

'Why do I have to go through this?'

She thought countless times of killing herself – and she really did die eventually. She just didn't know there was another life after it.

Why am I here? What did I do wrong?

And after 10 long years of training to become a 3rd stage Adapter, she finally found out. The world was twisted. Becoming more powerful didn't help her at all.

It was during the day when she woke up. Warm sunlight touched her through the window and she felt numb.

'I should get up.'

She tried hard to get up from her bed. She felt like she would not get another chance to get up next. She began to feel the pain and the first part she felt was from the right hand. She thought she was going to cry. She had been waiting for this feeling, the feeling of movement. Then she felt something weird. There was something in her right hand. It was the feeling of a cold, durable object.

'A stone?'

She felt something familiar, but a longing feeling overwhelmed her. In the next moment, when the door to the room opened, people rushed in.

"Doctor! Doctor!"

"She's awake!"

And with the excited shouts, the machine made an announcement.

[Treatment is now complete.]

[Corruption level below 1%.]

And her heart began to pound. She began to remember all that had happened.

When all doctors nearby rushed into the room, the windows to the room were opened.

"You're awake."

She was sitting on her bed.

"...Mino?"

With her long strands of hair moving about on the breeze coming through the window, her beautiful eyes turned from the window to the doctor.

"...Where am I?"

It had been 3 months since Jaehwan left Chaos. The first woman he met when he arrived had finally opened her eyes.

A few moments later, Mino was allowed to leave the hospital. It was Claire, her assigned guardian, waiting for her outside the hospital.

"...Are you kidding me?"

"No I'm not."

"YOU are the head of the finance department?"

"How many times do I have to tell you?"

Claire sighed. Mino had been sleeping for over 6 months.

"What has been going on?"

"Ugh... so..."

It was hard for Claire to explain all that had happened.

"...What do you mean? There's a King in [Chaos] now?"

"Yeah."

Claire regretted bringing that up to begin with.

"Who's the King?"

Upon hearing the answer, Mino looked at Claire dumbfoundedly and began to laugh.

"You think I'm a fool? 'HE' is the King?"

"He 'WAS' the King. Not anymore."

"...Hahaha. Why don't you just say Dead Man and horned monsters are now our friends? That would be more believable."

Mino laughed but Claire sighed. In next moment, Mino suddenly stopped.

"C-C-Claire? W-wh-what is that doing here?"

Mino began to shake. She seemed terrified and Claire looked at the direction where she was looking. There was monster walking calmly through the city.

It was a monster with 7 horns.

Mino was beyond terrified. She was within the fortress and it was under bright daylight. How was a Dead Man walking in the city like it was nothing?

"Whoa, relax."

The one-armed man who was dragging the horned monster quickly caressed the seven-horned monster a few times as if it was his pet. Mino couldn't believe what she was seeing.

"...Claire. Tell me I'm looking at an illusion. Am I being drugged?"

But it was only the start. After the monster disappeared, Mino then found tentacle monsters following her from behind. She felt like she was going to faint now.

"D-d-d-d-de-dead Man?!"

The tentacle then touched her left cheek and hours after she woke up, she fainted again.

Two hours later, Mino was sitting down on an outside bench and was talking with Claire.

"So, tell me if I understand this correctly."

"Yeah."

"A man destroyed the [Palace of Reincarnation] 3 months ago."

"Right."

"And the 4 fortresses of Gorgon were united."

"Right."

"...And the united [Chaos] then built a new fortress at the place of the old [Void Factory]."

Mino then looked around the streets and continued, "The name of the fortress is Carpediem, which is here. And in this place..."

There were Dead Men, horned monsters, and humans. Some excited Dead Men were giving high fives to passing humans. Mino continued, "Humans, horned monsters, and Dead Men are living together in harmony. Like they're friends."

"Right, you got everything right."

Claire nodded and Mino became silent. Then she stood up and yelled, "... That's not even possible!!"

And it took her a day to understand it was exactly how she understood it. [Chaos] was now an entirely different place. With the Carpediem Fortress as its symbol, the three races of Chaos were now united under one. It was all thanks to the treaty between the King of Humans, the Overseer of the Void Factory, and the Sole-King Catastrophe.

-Three races will undergo a peace treaty until our war against the Lords is finished.

And between all that was the man in the center.

'...What have you done?' Mino thought as she looked at the statue at the center of the fortress. It was a statue of Jaehwan with raising his sword up into the sky. The statue was created by the Vice Chief of Twilight's Fall. The man had become stronger than all those Clan Leaders, Masters of fortresses, and even killed the Generals of [Great Lands] and became the King of [Chaos].

'...You're now stabbing at the sky?'

Mino smiled. There was some writing beneath the statue.

-The Last King of Chaos

There were no more Kings in [Chaos]. Chancellors of Carpediem, Euren, and Cayman refused to appoint a new King. To all of the people, the only King was the one who left. Some even started calling him a 'Sole-King'.

"...Wasn't that supposed to mean Catastrophe?"

"It isn't anymore. It means 'him' now."

Chapter 112: Kind of a fall (2)

During 3 months after Jaehwan left, a lot of things changed outside of [Chaos] also. As Carpediem grew in strength, there were forces that opposed Carpediem. These were the generals and underlings of the Lords of the [Great Lands]. Mino was shocked to hear this.

"...Isn't that a problem? How can we beat them? They are at least 4th stage Adapters."

"We can beat them now."

Mino understood why Claire was so certain after she saw the 'Tower of Awakeners'. That tower had the same name as the fortress. People were training day and night within the tower.

Most people of [Chaos] did not walk the path of becoming an Adapter anymore.

'Awakening.'

It was the present that the King had left for [Chaos].

"...And we can even fight 9th stage Adapters?"

"Yeah."

She thought ones at the 5th or 6th level were untouchable, and now the 9th were considered like they were nothing. She couldn't even guess what kind of power it was.

"We can't defeat any Adapters though. The 9th is just a start. There are a lot of Generals who are over the 9th stage in [Great Lands]. Some are coming

over even now."

After Jaehwan killed hundreds of Generals, the 9th region was now in a fierce war, due to the destroyed power balance. There were hundreds and thousands of dead spirits transferring over to [Chaos]. Some were Great Generals.

"What stage are they? Great Generals?"

"10th or sometimes 11th stage."

"...How strong are they?"

"I heard they can destroy a mountain in one strike."

"God..."

Mino became pale.

"What if they attack this place? We can't defeat them."

"Yeah, at least the 'humans' can't."

Mino flinched. It seemed she was too calm for saying that it was impossible. Impossible for 'humans.' It seemed like someone other than humans was helping them. Then she realized something was off. It had been 3 months since Jaehwan left. It was enough time for those Generals to attack this place. But how was this fortress still safe?

"You know the place where the Generals are sent to when they die is different, right?"

"...A bit. I heard they are summoned into the Palace of Reincarnation."

Higher stage Adapters were summoned to the palace so they could be revived quickly. Claire nodded.

"Right. You knew."

"...What about it?"

"Well, the Overseers of Void Factory fixed it. The place that they get called into is different now."

Was that something that could be changed? But..

"Where to?"

"Here."

"...Huh?"

"Generals are called to Carpediem when they die."

Mino screamed in shock. "...HERE?!"

"Yeah."

"B-but...! We can't fight them! They're too strong!"

Mino became pale but Claire didn't seem to be concerned at all.

"Well- it's further inside to be exact."

Claire was pointing toward the inside of the fortress, deep within.

Deep inside Carpediem, a summoning circle shined brightly and a naked man appeared from within. He looked around as he was confused, and then nodded.

"...Dammit. So I was killed."

It was one of the Lesser Generals of the 9th region.

"See, I told you it was no use being loyal."

The General was surprised by another voice and turned around. It was one of his comrades who was on the battlefield until while ago.

"Wow, you're dead too, Jake?"

"You're dead too, Drake. What would make me different?"

Drake frowned. It has been 400 years since he lived as a General of 9th region. He fought and fought for the Darkness but he was abandoned like a dog in the end.

'...Maybe I should go to the 5th region next time.'

As he was thinking, Jake opened up.

"By the way, where is this place?"

"...I'm not sure." Drake mumbled as he looked around. This place wasn't familiar.

"I thought we were summoned to the Palace of Reincarnation."

"It doesn't look like it."

Drake nodded. "So the rumor was true. The palace is no more."

There was a recent rumor that a powerful force had appeared within [Chaos] and destroyed the Palace of Reincarnation. Drake did not believe the rumor to be true.

'But even then... [Chaos] couldn't have defeated the Generals of the palace. I guess those generals fought against each other for the [Fruit] or something. I heard it almost ran out.'

Drake stretched himself and spoke to Jake.

"Jake, so what will you..."

But he couldn't talk any longer. Jake's face wasn't there anymore. Instead, blood was pouring out from his neck like a fountain.

"J-jake?!"

Drake was so terrified he couldn't even make a move.

[An insect is here again.]

A voice came to him with a power that beyond anything he had felt before.

[Explode.]

And that was the last word he heard.

After a week, Mino made up her mind. Claire was looking at her with a concerned look.

"Are you really going in?"

"Yeah."

"You might go mad and die!"

Mino shrugged. She was looking at the Tower of Awakeners.

"I'm ready."

The tower wasn't big or tall. It was small and crude compared to the real Tower of Nightmares. But Mino wasn't concerned. She then looked at the people going into the tower. She heard that the training inside was like hell, but the people didn't seem to be worried at all.

"I want to know too."

Claire understood, even if she didn't specify what she wanted to know.

"Alright, go ahead. You damn girl."

Claire turned back. But her back was shaking a bit and Mino smiled.

'I'm sorry, Claire.'

Then she took a step toward the tower. As she joined the people going into the tower, she reached into her pocket and felt the stone. She knew what it was.

[Returning Stone]

Claire said that Jaehwan visited her before he left for the Void Factory and gave the stone in her hand.

'Why did he save [Chaos]?'

It was one question that was not answered. Jaehwan, as she knew him, was cold and uncaring. He didn't seem like he liked 'humans' very much. But he saved the world. He saved the world of Dead Men that he wasn't related to. Mino remembered her last words before she fainted a long time ago.

-Please don't give up on this world.

Mino then shook her head.

'I doubt it.'

Then she stopped at the entrance of the tower. She felt something filling her heart. She realized why the expression on people's faces wasn't dark as they entered. It was hope. There was hope that there was something in this world, something she could do.

She smiled. The man who was trying to make this world fall left hope in this world.

Then she thought. Maybe... just maybe. This too was kind of a fall in itself.

She then looked up to the sky. Beyond the sky, at the [Depth], Jaehwan was surely somewhere, fighting against the world.

'Maybe... I can see the same world as you.'

She couldn't understand the kind of world Jaehwan pictured, but she could imagine. And within her imagination, the world was a small tree, a lone tree

with no leaves or land to grab on to. But Mino didn't think the tree was lonely. Even if the whole world turned its back on it, the man was surely beside it to protect it.

It was the world that the one man protected and will protect.

It was the World after the Fall.

Chapter 113: Naked God (1)

[Have you become a new God?! Congratulations! You are in the top 0.0000001% percent of all beings! Sorry to spoil you though, but there's bad news. There are just too many like you in the [Depth]! Most are losers who are out of competitions and idiots who can lose Divinity at any time. Huh? Are you afraid that you'll become one of them?

Don't worry!

If you are reading my message, that means the blessing of the Goddess of Fortune, Minerva, is upon you! If you heed my advice, you will not have a hard time in [Depth]!

I guess you have a lot of things in mind that you want to do. Maybe you want to show off your newly created world, or work on [Settings] or want to collect [Parts] in your world!

Settings... Parts...

That's all good. But before you go for those luxuries, there's one important thing you must focus on. What is that, you ask?

It's to collect [Followers]!!

It's very important, so I used two exclamation marks. You, who are a newbie God, might not know why it's important.

Why do you need Followers?

That is a foolish question! I remember saying this to a newbie God once, when I was asked the same question.

-Hey, what do you think a 'God' is?

-Pierre, the God of Coquetry

From the 101 Tips for Newbie Gods

Which was the most dangerous 'Site' within [Depth]?

Gods of the [Depth] once had a heated debate on the topic. These were Gods who lived tens of thousands of years, so they needed topics to debate about. Some said that the 1st site where [Big Brother] was located at was the most dangerous, while some said the 4th site where the Mad God existed was dangerous. These two sites were definitely dangerous. The 1st site was off-limits for most and the Mad God was a disaster for ordinary Gods to even have the chance to meet. There were easier ways to get to the place where there was more 'realistic' danger.

It was the 8th site, Caspion.

Caspion was nicknamed as the Forbidden Blue Grasslands.

It was the place where all people, Vicegerents and Followers alike hated to be, had visitors.

Through the deep bushes, a boy appeared. At around the age of 17 or 18, he had exquisite beautiful facial features that some would mistake him as a girl. He glanced around and sighed multiple times before he spoke.

"Uh, Goddess?"

It was strange. He was alone, but it didn't seem like he was just calling out to some random God.

"Goddess, can you answer me please?"

Then, from nothing, a voice came.

[What.]

It sounded like an angry girl.

"Is it really here?"

[It is.]

"But... there's nothing here. I don't think there's a [Fishing Spot] around here."

There were only trees and grass. And the atmosphere... each time the bush shook with the wind, the boy flinched in fear.

"Can I get out of here... please? I'm really scared. What if the Lost Ones appear?"

[...Don't start that again.]

The girl voice, who was called a Goddess, sighed.

[Runald, Lost Ones aren't that common. It's been tens of thousands of years since the Three Ancient Gods have fallen! They did have a lot of followers, but they are probably all dead by now! And besides, you don't need to worry one bit even if they appear.]

"...Why is that?"

[It's obvious. You got me!]

"...You?"

[Yeah! If I, the Naked Andersen, am with you, you are 100% safe!]

Runald sighed.

[...Wait, why are you sighing?]

"It's nothing."

Runald just thought instead.

'To think it was she who appointed me...'

It had been three years since he arrived at the [Depth]. After barely clearing the Tower of Nightmares, the Cultivator of his tower spoke to him.

-You are not going to the [Great Lands].

-What?

-I don't know the reason, but a certain Goddess said she will buy you. You will become her Vicegerent in the [Depth].

A God, not the Lord, appointed him! Runald was excited. However, the excitement faded as soon as he realized the Goddess who purchased him was the 'Lower Rank God', the most common type of God within the [Depth].

"Goddess, I don't think there will be any [Fishing Spots] around here."

Runald spoke again.

"Even if there were, no spirit who comes up to [Caspion] can survive. Do you really have to come all the way here to get the Followers?"

That was the start of the tragedy. It all started because of the Followers.

Followers, or spirits who believed in God.

All Gods of the [Depth] required Followers. Unlike Vicegerents, who were enough with just one, the number of followers the God had contributed to their power. The more Followers, the more power the God obtained. It allowed them to make a more powerful World, or use rare Setting or Parts into its world.

-Followers are Power!

The word was famous among Gods. Because of this competition, all spirits within the [Depth] were all [Followers]. In this heavy competition, weaker Gods had only two choices to gain Followers.

First, lure the Followers of other Gods.

This method, also known as 'headhunting', was widely utilized by mid to higher ranking Gods. It was done by offering Followers better conditions to take it away. But it was difficult for weaker Gods to use as they had nothing to offer, and there was the possibility of making the opponent Gods become angry and start a war. The lower-ranking Gods were then given one remaining option.

The second option was to find a [Fishing Spot] and fish up a Follower.

This was what Runald and low-ranking God Andersen was trying to do.

"Who told you that there was a [Fishing Spot] here? Huh? Goddess, tell me. Who was it that fooled you?!"

The problem was, it wasn't going too well.

"Come on! Tell me!"

[...Minerva.]

Andersen spoke with a squeamish voice.

"...Minerva?"

Runald became scary immediately.

"Are you talking about that damn Goddess of Fortune who issues the [Monthly Fortune] magazine?"

[...Uh, it's her. Yeah.]

Runald began shouting angrily. Andersen quickly began defending herself.

[B-but Minerva said it! Today's lucky point was the West-North-North of Caspion, Blue, Forest, and water!]

"..."

[This is the only place with Blue Forest which is northwest of Caspion! And the water should indicate that it's the [Fishing Spot]!]

"...And so what did that damn Goddess say?"

[She said I will meet an important person if I go there.]

"And you think that 'important person' is a Follower..."

[Right!]

Runald stopped suddenly. Silence fell between them.

"Goddess."

[...Yeah.]

"Will you apologize?"

[...I-I'm sorry.]

"We'll return."

[...Yeah.]

Runald sighed and turned back. He seemed tired as he walked through the bush. Andersen was also silent as if she was saddened.

Chapter 114: Naked God (2)

'Maybe I overdid it.'

Runald felt a bit sorry for Andersen.

'I'm the only one she has.'

Other than her Vicegerent, no one in [Depth] that followed Andersen. Having just one Follower meant that Andersen's world could disappear at any moment.

"...Goddess, are you there?"

Andersen was quick-tempered and picky, but Runald liked her. Her voice made him remember his lost younger sister. Andersen's voice was very similar to his sister's. This was why Runald did not betray the low-ranking God Andersen. She was now the only family he had.

'Oh well. I'll play along a bit more.'

Runald then asked, "Goddess, should we look around for a bit more?"

[...Huh? Really??]

Andersen's voice brightened up and Runald smiled bitterly.

Andersen was still a God. But Gods required Followers. She, too, would want to become stronger. And the rumors said that she used to be a high-ranking God of the Depth. It was through betrayal that she was dragged down to where she was now.

'But she wouldn't have picked me if she was at a high rank.'

Runald was somewhat thankful for Andersen's unfortunate turn of events.

'And it might be good if we have one more... the Goddess should be less sad.'

Then, Runald smelled something.

He first thought he was mistaken. But as he tried again, it wasn't mistaken at all.

"Huh?"

[What is it?]

"Goddess, do you smell water nearby?"

[...I don't have the nose to smell it.]

Runald ignored her and began searching around. They neared where the smell was coming and Andersen quietly watched. And after a while, they found a small open space in the forest. Runald screamed as he looked at the center of it.

"T-there it is! Goddess! It's really there!!"

[W-whoa!]

There was a small silvery pond at the center. It was the place called [Fishing Spot] where spirits could be fished up. They had found the place.

Most famous Fishing Spots that had tens of spirits fished up the day had already occupied high-ranking Gods. Lower-ranking Gods were then forced to use public [Fishing Spots]. These spots had maybe one spirit throughout a few days and even those were competed against amongst the Gods.

Runald and Andersen had found a new [Fishing Spot].

"M-maybe we can really get a [Follower]!"

[W-what should I do if we do get it?!]

Andersen also seemed to be excited. It was known that newly found Fishing Spots had good energy in them so lost spirits were drawn to it. That was why a lot of lower-ranking Gods and their Vicegerents searched for new [Fishing Spots]. Most of them had to either return empty-handed or get killed.

[Maybe we can fish up a lot!]

"W-what should we do?!"

[I'll get a lot of [Followers] and change [Setting] and buy [Parts]....!]

"Settings? You know you have to change my setting first right?"

[Of course!]

"And don't forget my personal parts!"

[Heck yeah!]

Two of them were already dreaming about living among the high-ranking Gods.

[I can be more powerful and go up the ranks... and become top rank to...!]

After a while of daydreaming, Runald realized it had been an hour since he started fishing.

"Goddess, does it usually take this long?"

[Uh...]

After three hours...

"...Nothing's coming up."

[Let's wait. I heard spirit fishing is like fishing time itself.]

"Where did you learn that?"

[It was from the Monthly Fortune.]

Five hours.

"...Goddess."

[....]

And after a day, they decided something wasn't right.

"WHY! How come nothing's coming up!?"

[Ugh...]

"That damn Minerva! Goddess! Let's go beat her up!"

[...She's a top-ranking God. I don't even have a chance.]

"...I know."

Runald became sad. They finally found a new [Fishing Spot], but they weren't catching a mere fish. Maybe this [Fishing Spot] was found a long time ago, but was abandoned as nothing could be fished.

[Runald.]

"...Yeah."

[Didn't that... move just now?]

Runald then turned to the fishing pole. And at that moment, the pole suddenly moved and Runald felt something heavy pulling the pole.

"H-huh? HUH!?"

Something was caught. It was caught... but...

"G-Goddess! I think I caught something really big!"

Most spirits were fished up the moment they were caught, but this spirit didn't look normal.

"Where did it come from? Is it from that Moorim?"

The spirits of the [Outer Region] had a difference in power depending on where it came from. Spirits from Moorim were especially powerful and were hard fish up.

[...Something's wrong.]

Andersen also felt something off and began using Runald as a conduit to exercise her world power.

[...This spirit isn't from the [Outer Region].]

"What? Where's it coming from then?"

[[Chaos].]

"W-what do you mean?"

A spirit was being fished up from the [Fishing Spot] when they were coming from [Chaos]? Runald had never heard of such a thing.

[There's no time! Take off your clothes!]

"...Ugh."

Runald sighed and held the fishing pole on his mouth and began to unclothe himself. His scrawny body was revealed.

[You're still as scrawny as ever.]

"Ugh, hurry up with the [Setting]!"

And as his [Setting], 'Naked' was activated, Runald's scrawny body turned to that of a muscled man. But even then it wasn't easy to pull up.

'What have we got...?!'

Runald used all his might to pull it up. After a while of heavy pulling, something was dragged outside.

'...Gods!'

It was an unconscious man. He had dark hair, with wounds all over the body and blood turning into a silver powder. He was entirely naked and...

'He has a sword.'

There was a sword in his right hand a scabbard on his left hand.

'Is he from Moorim?'

Runald swallowed his throat. He was weak, but he still was a Vicegerent. Runald felt the power from within the man.

'He has a world!'

Runald became shocked and quickly asked, "What have we fished up? Goddess, is he a Vicegerent?!"

That was impossible. There was no Vicegerent in [Chaos]. Andersen answered.

[...He's not a Vicegerent.]

"Huh? Then..."

Andersen became silent for a while. It was when Runald realized the silence wasn't a good sign that Andersen spoke. Her voice was shaking.

[Runald... I... we... have fished up a 'God'.]

Chapter 115: Naked God (3)

[He is a God! I'm sure of it!]

"That's impossible!"

[No, he is. At least something close to it. You should trust your God sometimes.]

"...Are you serious?"

Runald turned to the man. The naked man was still lying on the ground unconscious. He was very well-built with his muscular body.

'...He has a beautiful spirit.'

Within [Chaos] or [Depth], the body wasn't built just through exercise. Having a well-built body was the result of a trained spirit. However, Runald had never seen a man with such a balanced build until now. This also was proof that this man cannot be a God.

"He can never be a God. No God has a spirit body."

Gods did not have spirit bodies. This was the truth of the [Depth].

"All Gods exist in 'presence' and only becomes themselves through Vicegerents. Isn't this the basic rule of the [Depth]?"

Andersen was shocked by the sudden logical explanation.

[...Uh... eh... Runald, are you trying to show off what you know?]

"You taught me this."

It was simple actually. It just meant no God could use their power without a Vicegerent. This was a fact for everyone who lived in [Depth].

[Hm... was it?]

Andersen said, "...Are you kidding me? You told me that the first day I came here."

[God] – a being that has achieved its status as the higher being ascended from their original self. These gods needed vicegerent to use their power. There was no exception in this.

Gods existed through vicegerent. They had a tremendous amount of power, but were never allowed to use it on their own. This was what Runald know.

"So, with that said. He cannot be a god. Maybe he's a follower or a vicegerent... I can send his world power too."

That's when Runald stopped. His face frowned and Andersen asked.

[Oh, so now you see?]

"...What is this man?"

[Didn't you say that he must be a [Follower] or a Vicegerent?]

"No... that can't be. He's from [Chaos]. There's no god in Chaos."

The only place where Gods existed was in [Depth]. And this man was from [Chaos]. It didn't make sense for him to be a [Follower] or a Vicegerent where there was no God. But Andersen had a different idea.

'Well, there is one in [Chaos] actually.'

There was one, terrifying god within [Chaos]. One that might be stronger and more terrifying than any of the top-ranking gods from [Depth]. But Andersen decided not to spill that part of the information.

'I doubt he would make a Vicegerent.'

As far as Andersen knew, that God was tied to [Chaos] through an unknown condition and never made a Vicegerent. So, with that put aside, there was no way that this man could be a Vicegerent or a [Follower].

Runald continued, "...Did you say he's a God because of that? Because he's not a Vicegerent nor a [Follower]?"

[Well, that was part of it.]

"But that's just a wild guess! You don't even have a logic that befits a God!"

[Runald, you learned well in insulting your own God.]

"Your logic is like this. There's an animal that looks like a rat, but it isn't. That what is this? A new animal? Then let's name this animal. This animal is now a cat!"

[...So rat is a Vicegerent and a God is a cat? What a pitiful parable.]

"Goddess, isn't it about time to tell me now?"

[Huh? What?]

"You said he was a God right the moment you saw him. You know something that I don't, right?"

A God was still a God. They were beings that had knowledge and information that no human could possibly obtain. If that God was certain, then there must be a reason, even if it was hard to explain.

[Runald, have you heard the story called the 'Strong Mouse Story'?]

"...What?" Runald asked confusingly.

'Strong Mouse Story? What is that?'

[Once upon a time, there was a mouse. He was a strange one. But as the title said, he was a strong mouse. He didn't scavenge leftover food, but he

went out to hunt. After hunting and eating, he became really strong. He was a mouse, but he refused to stay as a mouse and became something more.]

Runalld concentrated on Andersen's story.

[After a while, he was now strong enough to even fight against a cat. He also realized that other mice were afraid of him. He then saw it was those cats who saw him as equals, not the other mice. That's when finally realized...]

"W-what?" Runalld asked. Andersen continued in a dreamy voice.

[Oh... I'm not a mouse anymore....]

Runalld became silent.

"...You just made that up right now, didn't you?"

Andersen didn't answer but Runalld realized something. This wasn't just some old fairytale.

"Wait, Goddess. The story right now..."

[I call these mice Awakeners.]

Awakener.

Runalld felt a sudden jolt. He knew Awakeners very well. Rupture, the infamous terrorist group who opposed the Lords of the [Great Lands], was comprised of Awakeners.

[Those beings broke their limits as humans and became Gods. They created their own worlds and became the Vicegerent of their own worlds. These are mice that, through their hard work, had allowed them to even hunt the cats.]

It all made sense now. One that had its spirit body but also was a God. Only Awakeners were able to do that.

"I-is he an Awakener then?"

[Probably. And besides, if he's from [Chaos]...]

Andersen remembered what she heard from the [Little Brother] network that Awakeners were appearing in [Chaos]. She thought it was a hoax, but it seemed like it was true. Runald asked with a shaky voice, "Maybe he's from Rupture?"

[No, those ones never travel alone. He can't be from Rupture.]

The appearance of unaffiliated Awakener. Runald wasn't sure what change it would bring to [Depth].

"So, what are we going to do with him?"

[I don't know... It depends on if he is a God or not.]

"Depends?"

[Either he will become our ally or...]

Then Runald felt weird sensation coming up. It was similar to the urge to eat. After spending a long time with Andersen, Runald understood where this feeling came from. Vicegerents were beings who understood their Gods best. They understood them so well that they were influenced by their Gods' feelings.

"...Goddess?" Runald asked. And she answered,

[Runald, there's a way to make sure whether he will be our ally or not.]

Runald didn't want to know how, and she didn't care.

[Let's eat him.]

Chapter 116: Naked God (4)

Ten minutes later.

'Dammit.'

Runald was topless and full of sweat as he hugged the naked man. It was a weird sight, but there was no other way. This way was the only way that his Goddess, 'Naked Andersen' could 'eat' this man.

'Eating is a weird word to use.'

What it was actually doing was just diving into his spirit. Runald knew why Andersen made this horrible (to Runald of course) choice very well.

If this man was a real God, then that was good.

There were other ways for gods to increase their power rather than gathering [Followers]. If Gods had more [Parts] or had better [Settings], it would allow them to use another method.

It was to eat other Gods.

This was forbidden in many sites, but it was openly done on many illegal sites. Even in [Caspion], there were a lot of Vicegerents lurking who did this 'God eating'.

Runald watched the man's face and mumbled, "I hope you are not a God."

If Andersen determines that this man was a God, she would start eating up his spirit right away. There was no better prey than an unconscious one. Runald hoped to not lose the chance of gaining another [Follower]. He had been lonely through his time with only his Goddess.

"No. But you won't become a [Follower] so..."

With such world power, the spirit would become Andersen's new Vicegerent instead. There were rare cases where a God would have two vicegerents, but that was for those high-ranking gods. Andersen wasn't one of them.

"It's okay."

Runald thought it would still be okay even if he was degraded into a [Follower]. If this made his goddess Andersen happy, then that was good enough.

"Aren't I a good [Follower]?"

Runald smiled as he spoke. But it was the next moment when he realized something wasn't right.

"Huh?"

Something connected had been cut off, and Runald knew what this was.

"Goddess?"

Andersen's link that was connected to Runald was cut off suddenly. Runald felt lonely for a second. It made sense for Andersen to become excited, but why cut off the link so suddenly?

'So, he wasn't a God?'

If the link was broken, then it meant his Goddess had found a new Vicegerent. Andersen probably decided to make this man her new Vicegerent. But...

"Goddess?"

Something wasn't right. This wasn't just the link being cut off. This...

'She vanished?!'

He couldn't feel Andersen at all. It was as if she had been swallowed up by something.

"Goddess!"

However, Runald didn't know. There was a bigger problem than Andersen's vanishment lurking in. There was vicious energy spreading out from where they were lying down.

It was unlucky. That was the only way Jaehwan could describe the situation.

It was fine until he defeated those Generals and got help from Catastrophe to enter [Depth]. It was also good that he had Chunghuh, Karlton, and Sirwen with him. Two of them were trustworthy and one was good enough. It was a shame that he couldn't take Cayman with him, but that was for the best.

It was Jaehwan who ordered Cayman to stay behind in [Chaos]. [Chaos] still needed someone to lead them and Jaehwan thought Cayman was the best candidate.

It was all good up to this point. The problem in [Chaos] was solved and the entrance to [[Depth]] was open. He wasn't in a good state, but he had Chunghuh so it wasn't going to be much of an issue.

He just needed to head to [Depth] now.

[Follow the path, and you will be at [Depth].]

As he heard Catastrophe's voice, Jaehwan became a bit excited as he watched the entrance to [Depth]. All the work he had done up until now coming to fruition.

But when he arrived at the entrance, a voice came to them.

"Stop right there."

He knew the voice. Jaehwan then realized it was the woman who joined the tournament a while ago. Jaehwan knew who she was now as Chunghuh told

him before.

"Rupture."

"Oh, so you know about us now? The old man told you?"

Chunghuh then stepped forward.

"...Surha. Why are you here?"

2nd Captain of Rupture, Yoo Surha. That was her name. She was also infamous in the [Great Lands] with her nickname, 'Early Dawn'. Sirwen, who knew her by the name, frowned.

'She is at least a Commander.'

Captains of Rupture were at the level of Commanders. They were not as powerful as Lords, but there was no telling how much stronger they might get through time.

"Oh, I'm not here to talk to you. Let me talk to him."

And with that, a young boy's voice came from behind her.

"Captain, the firewall installation is finished."

It was a boy with headphones and a black hooded sweatshirt with a moon drawing on it. As he fiddled with the small machine, Jaehwan then realized Catastrophe's voice had disappeared. He turned back and he couldn't find his friends either. Some kind of barrier was trapping him.

"This won't long! We're up against the Sole-King!"

"Okay, it will be done quickly."

Surha waved the boy off and turned to Jaehwan.

"I saw what you did. I was curious about your intention and... whoa, it sure was amazing."

"..."

"I mean, I wasn't too keen when you united all those Clan Leaders and Masters of the fortresses. But fighting against those Generals... that was something. Even we wouldn't plan such a thing so easily. It made me reconsider you."

"...What is your point?"

"I mean, I couldn't even find a word to describe the massacre out here with the Generals. We never thought of doing that, you know? Bringing Catastrophe into it! How did you even get the idea?"

"I asked, what is your point."

Jaehwan knew Surha wasn't friendly when she had set this barrier around them. If she was coming in friendly, she wouldn't have forced it upon them like this.

"Wow, you sure are impatient. I'm not done with my story, so hear me out, will ya?"

"..."

"Anyway, it was all good up to that point. I mean, I thought we could just leave you be like this. It's not what we usually do, but I felt your goal isn't too different from us. As you know, this world is really f*cked. Don't you think so?"

Jaehwan did not answer.

"But the last skill you used. Now that was problematic."

Jaehwan thought about what skills he did use for a moment.

"Where did you learn [Perishing Slice]?"

"Perishing... what?"

"The skill that you used to cut the link. We call it [Perishing Slice]. It's the skill only Captains and the leader of Rupture uses."

"Is it?"

Jaehwan was surprised. He wasn't surprised by the name, but that there were others who can use the skill.

"That is a dangerous skill. It perishes spirits. It's not something that Awakeners who aren't from Rupture should be allowed to use."

"...I made that skill myself. I'm sure you don't have a patent on it or something."

"I'm serious."

Surha then began to move. Jaehwan realized she was opening up her own unique world. It was the power of Creation. This woman was either equal to or more powerful than Jaehwan.

"Now, do you know why I'm here?"

"...Are you going to kill me?"

Surha smiled. "That's an option, but I have a different idea."

Jaehwan then realized why this woman had come all the way here.

"Join Rupture."

Chapter 117: Naked God (5)

Would it have changed if he had accepted Surha's offer? Jaehwan didn't know.

"No."

With that said, Jaehwan and Rupture's relationship was decided. 2nd Captain Surha raised her scythe weapon named 'Thundering Imp' and the fight began.

The fight was intense. The pathway to [Depth] was destroyed through it. After Jaehwan experienced the power of Catastrophe, his spirit gained more power. It wasn't enough to have him move onto the next step, but he was now able to utilize the power of Creation at will.

'If I was in my best condition...'

With his heavily wounded body, he wasn't able to fight against Surha. Jaehwan had to use his last resort.

The skill that Rupture named as Perishing Slice.

Surha couldn't attack easily after that. She too had the linkage. If Jaehwan managed to cut her ties, she might be trapped in this part of the world.

-You'll regret this.

Jaehwan's gamble eventually paid off. After time passed, the barrier was lifted and Surha disappeared. But the problem was still there.

'Ah, dammit.'

Jaehwan thought as he looked around the area that was now pitch black.

'The path is closed.'

He couldn't find Chunghuh, Karlton, or Sirwen. It seemed they probably had moved onto [Depth] already. If they were in [Depth], he would soon meet them again. That wasn't a problem then.

The problem was Jaehwan himself.

[If the path closes before you go through, follow the closest light. If you are lucky, you might get out of [Depth] that way. It won't be a pleasant experience, however.]

Jaehwan didn't know what that meant, but he had no choice. He swam through the darkness looking for the light. It was completely dark so he didn't even know where he was going.

'Nothing's easy.'

He was too exhausted from the multiple battles and he was now losing energy. He tried to stay awake but it was no use.

After a while, something changed. The surrounding air turned into water and he felt his skin turning into scales. He began breathing through gills like a fish. As he breathed, he constantly swam.

It was then that the light appeared from above. The fish, Jaehwan, realized he should move towards it.

'I must go there.'

Nobody ordered him to go, and Jaehwan wasn't fully conscious, but he followed his instincts. And then, he finally reached the light.

He felt he was being dragged up and writhed in pain. So, this was the experience. The feeling of becoming a fish wasn't pleasant at all. And being fished up was another. Jaehwan thought it wasn't a pleasant experience before he fully lost his conscious.

Sometime later, Jaehwan realized someone was calling him.

A small hand was shaking his body.

[HEY!]

A voice.

[Wake up! Hey!]

It was the voice of a girl. Jaehwan opened his eyes. There was a young girl wearing a white one-piece skirt without shoes, crying, and wailing. She was shaking Jaehwan, panicking. Jaehwan wasn't sure what was going on.

'What is it?'

[What is it?! Is that all you have to say to me?!]

Jaehwan frowned. He looked around and only found darkness. But it wasn't like the darkness from the path to [Depth]. After he checked the Eye of Asura in the sky, he realized he was inside of his unique world, but then another question arose.

'Who is this girl?'

It was strange. No being was allowed to come into his unique world without his permission. Yet this girl was standing there as if she belonged there from the start.

[What the heck are you talking about! You ate me!]

'Ate you?'

[Yeah! Do something!]

He wasn't sure what she was talking about, but it seemed like he did something bad to her. Jaehwan asked, 'What do you want me to do?'

The girl then flung on to him.

[...Save!]

'Save? Save what?]

[Save my only [Follower]!]

'Oh, Goddess...'

He should've run when he realized someone was approaching. Runald looked at enemies in front of him. They emerged from the bushes. They had a dark cape and tattoos all over their face. Runald knew he was in danger.

"You're a fool to walk around the forbidden sites alone, kid."

Runald knew who they were.

Forbidden sites of Caspion weren't only dangerous because of the Ancient God's Lost Ones. The Lost Ones were definitely dangerous, but there were more realistic dangers lurking around.

'Hunters.'

Hunters were those who lurked forbidden sites to hunt newbie Vicegerents.

"Hey, kid."

Runald then realized their elbows were twisted weirdly, like those of a mantis.

'Followers of Belkain.'

Mid-ranking god Belkain the Furious Talon.

All of his [Followers] were infamous for being vicious and evil. Runald heard they had moved their base to Caspion, but he didn't realize it was at this Blue Forest site.

"Kid, you hear?"

"Uh, y-yes."

"What were you doing?"

Runald grew anxious. He was against Hunters and [Followers] of a mid-ranking God. If they found out what he was going through, he would be killed instantly.

"I was just examining the new [Fishing Spot] I found."

Runald thought up a quick lie.

"[Fishing Spot]?"

"Yeah. It's the one that my Goddess and I found. Do you want to see it?"

The new [Fishing Spot] was very valuable to Runald and Andresen. It held tremendous value, but nothing was more important than their lives. The men became excited.

"Whoa, it's really a [Fishing Spot]!"

"And it's an unregistered one!"

"It's a bit small but...."

"God Belkain will be pleased!"

The three men looked around the pond and soon, one who looked like he was the leader came up to Runald.

"Kid, did you tell anyone else that you found this place?"

"No, not yet. Only me and my Goddess know about it."

"I see."

Runald then realized greed was filling the man's eyes and he quickly explained, "If it's alright, I will have you take this [Fishing Spot]. My

Goddess tells me to do so too."

"Oh? Did she? Who is your Goddess anyway?"

"It's Andersen."

"...Andersen?"

The man became confused and turned to his friends.

"Hey, you know who Andersen is?"

"Andersen? What's that?"

"...Bah, there are so many of those no-names."

Runald blushed with embarrassment. But it was a common sight and it was sometimes better this way to be ashamed by someone who didn't know then...

"Wait- are we talking about that 'Naked' Andersen?"

Runald frowned.

"Naked...? Oh? You mean the one who was dropped to the lowest rank?"

"Hahaha! So she still had [Followers]?"

The men cackled while Runald silently rose up.

"I-I better get going then."

Runald then picked up the naked black-haired man and thought., 'At least we got him.'

He couldn't feel Andersen's presence, but it wasn't certain that she had disappeared until this man woke up. If Andersen was safe, then it wouldn't be bad to just get out of this situation safely. In the end, Andersen was going to get another [Follower]. That was good enough.

"Wait."

But things weren't going to end up like that so easily. Runald flinched at the voice.

"Put that down."

"...What?"

"Huh? Don't pretend you didn't hear it. Put it down. That's ours now."

The [Follower] was directly pointing at the naked man.

Chapter 118: Naked God (6)

"But we fished him out...!"

"Huh? This [Fishing Spot] now belongs to our God Belkain. Any spirit coming from it is now a [Follower] of Belkain. Isn't that right?"

It was absurd.

"Drop it and get lost, kid. Consider it lucky that we are letting you go."

Runald looked at the man's face. He couldn't give up on this man yet. His Goddess was probably still with him. If he was taken away, then Runald was going to lose Andersen too.

'Then I will become like those Lost Ones too.'

Ones who lost Gods by force would lose their consciousness and become monsters if they don't find a new God to serve quickly. This was terrifying. But what Runald worried about the most wasn't becoming a Lost One.

'I don't want to lose her.'

He didn't want to lose Andersen. She was the only Goddess he had, and Runald was her only Vicegerent.

"I said, drop it and go."

Runald carefully put down the man, but he did not make a move. His legs shook and his heart began to pound.

'Can I do it?'

He wasn't sure, but Runald still readied himself.

"Oh, look at him. He's trying to fight us."

"Haha, it was going to be boring if he didn't want to fight."

The men began approaching and Runald shouted, "I'm a Vicegerent! I will not abandon the [Follower] of my Goddess!"

This was the best threat Runald could make, but it didn't have any effect.

"YOU are a Vicegerent? HAHA!"

"Good! We'll see the [Setting] of the Naked Goddess then!"

Runald quickly checked on their faces. Fortunately, these people weren't Vicegerents. It was lucky that Vicegerent, who were able to utilize 90% of his God's power, wasn't here but followers were still powerful.

Followers too, depending on their powers, were allowed to use 30 to 70% of a God's power.

If Runald could wield Andersen's power, they were easy to deal with. However, he wasn't able to use the power right now.

Belkain's [Followers] kicked Runald away. He was getting ready for the attack, but he couldn't block it.

"What? Why are you so weak!? Are you really a Vicegerent?"

Runald stood up and there was a fist in front of him. He gasped.

"Haha! So weak! Kid, start using [Setting]! Or else you will die!"

Runald couldn't use [Setting] as his link between Andersen had been broken. Runald felt pain from his organs as he kept getting kicked. But then they stopped suddenly.

"Hey, take off his clothes."

"Clothes? Why?"

"I heard Andersen's [Followers] become strong when they take off their clothes. I think that's their [Setting]."

"Really?"

Runald then screamed, "N-NO!"

"Hah, stay still."

Runald couldn't resist the force coming from the three men, especially when they had the [Setting] that made them increase their strength. Soon, Runald was lying on the ground naked like a frog. The [Followers] began to laugh.

"He's butt naked and still weak!"

"That's weird. I heard Andersen's [Followers] increase in their muscle sizes when they get naked."

"Isn't this already increased? Hahaha!"

One of the [Followers] laughed as he poked Runald's body. Runald cried in shame. He had never been so humiliated. Even if this was [Depth] and he was a Vicegerent of a low-ranking God, this was too much.

'Ah... Goddess...'

That's when men looked at each other with a different idea.

"Hey, why don't we take him with us? It's hard to get new [Followers] these days."

"That's a good idea."

"Yeah. Hey kid. Abandon your Goddess and we will let you live."

Runald gritted his teeth. They were telling him to abandon his only Goddess, Andersen.

Runald stood up. Betray his Goddess? That was impossible.

Runald still remembered the moment when he first met Andersen in [Depth]. It was through her warm 'unique world' that Andersen showed him, that made him decide to stay in [Depth]. Runald was young, but he was old enough to choose the most valuable thing to him. Without that world, there was no Runald. He knew this very well.

"I... I won't betray my Goddess!"

It was almost an outcry, but the men scoffed.

"So, the naked Goddess trained her Vicegerent well."

"Then we will beat you up until you change your mind."

A man then threw his cape and revealed a blade from his elbow. Runald realized it was Belkain's [Setting].

[Scythe of Belkain]

It was the symbol of mid-ranking God Belkain. It was a common Setting amongst Strengthening types as it was just the mixture of an increase in muscle strength and change of skins, but it was still a huge threat to Runald right now.

The ground and trees around were destroyed as the attack was unleashed. Runald closed his eyes, thinking it might be good to rather die. The only thing that was sad was that he couldn't see Andersen's face yet. If he was a stronger Vicegerent, maybe he could've seen her face.

'Goddess...'

Runald curled himself, preparing for the incoming pain. But he couldn't feel any pain even after a while. When he opened his eyes, he saw something unbelievable. He also heard the screams of those [Followers].

"W-what are you-!"

"AAAAARGH!"

The entire forest was being blown up and men were being thrown away with naked bodies.

'Thi-this man...'

There was a naked man standing in front of him. He was covered in muscles and Runald knew what the [Setting] was.

'Naked!'

It was surely Andersen's [Setting]. Runald stood up. Was he dreaming? Was it like the fairytale that Andersen always told him?

'God...!'

He then saw the world power shining from within the man. The man's face wasn't the one Runald was waiting for, but the man did look like the Naked God that Andersen told in her story. She had told him before.

[What? You want to know how I made the 'Naked' Setting? Uh... it's not my own actually.]

'Then where did you get it?'

[I got it from some weird god. He was one of the ancient ones. Very powerful.]

'Weird? Why was he weird?'

[Well, he was violent and unmerciful. But he hated 'clothes'. He always said the beauty lies within the bare body. So anyone standing in front of him was unclothed. They had to run with their clothes in their hands. So people screamed, 'The Naked God has appeared!' whenever he was there.]

Runald thought the 'cloth' could've been some kind of a symbol, but he shook his head and asked,

'Isn't he just a pervert?'

[Well, he had his reasons. He just truly believed that the clothes were just a fake image. Like a mask. He said the most important thing starts when you throw away everything else...]

Runald couldn't understand what it meant back then. But now, he thought maybe he kind of understood. Something was stirring inside him as he stared.

The Naked God was in front of him.

The God, looked at his body and mumbled.

"...Dammit. I don't even have any clothes this time. At least I had a rag in Chaos."

The man ranted for a second, flexed, and then turned to Runald.

"Are you the [Follower] of a girl named Andersen?"

The man was clearly annoyed. "Please, get her out of my head."

Chapter 119: Naked God (7)

Jaehwan looked at his muscles.

'I feel like I've gotten stronger.'

His muscles seemed to be at least 10 times more powerful than he remembered what he was like back in [Chaos]. He knew that such power existed through Mulack's memory, but seeing it in front of his eyes was a different thing.

'...It's as he said. There's no more Spirit Power,' Jaehwan thought as he realized the Spirit Power that permeated the air around [Chaos] was no more. The [Depth] was an entirely different place from [Chaos]. Unlike [Chaos] where Spirit Power allowed one to use skills and powers, [Depth] had very limited resources. It was only through the 'unique world' that borrowed the world's power that one was able to use a skill.

That was [Depth].

Jaehwan looked at his body again. After using [Suspicion], he realized the world power was forming a complicated formula. This power was called [Setting] in [Depth]. It was through [Setting] that the world power was allowed to form.

'Increased muscle strength... so is this the [Nakedness] something Setting?'

Then, a noisy voice came to him.

[It's called 'Naked!']

Jaehwan remembered it was Andersen's voice.

[You should get the name right!]

Jaehwan ignored what she said but she continued shouting.

[Listen to me! Are you listening?!]

'....'

He felt like he was getting a headache. This girl who was hell-bent on accusing him of eating her or something didn't seem to want to leave his head. But there was another problem.

"God! God!"

Jaehwan had to peel the boy off him by grabbing his head as he kept trying to hang on to him.

"God! Why are you refusing me?!"

"I told you, I'm not your God."

"You are now!"

Jaehwan was confused.

'Ugh, what have I been put into now?'

Jaehwan sighed as he glanced at Runald.

Runald was astonished by the new God's grandeur posture.

'Big and beautiful!'

Powerful world power was coming from the naked body, and he had the power to wipe out the mid-ranking god's [Followers] with one strike! As far as he knew, that power was beyond the Andersen's limit.

The new God said his name was Jaehwan. So Runald decided how to call this new God with the name.

"God Jaehwan!"

"...I said, I'm not a God."

"Please let me be your [Follower]!"

Jaehwan became frustrated and a voice came from his head.

[Runald... I'm disappointed. He just said he wouldn't betray me and look at him now!]

"The Goddess will agree on me being your Vicegerent!"

[I will NEVER do that!]

"I'm sure of it! God Jaehwan, you are one with Goddess Andersen now! I can see it since you can use the [Naked] Setting! So it's not betraying my Goddess to follow you!"

[...Hey, never take him as your [Follower], you hear?]

Jaehwan was frustrated by Runald on the outside and Andersen from the inside.

"Hey you two, cut it out."

Runald and Andersen became silent as strong world power swept over them. Runald began to hiccup as he was surprised. Jaehwan spoke.

"Let's start from the basics."

If the [Great Lands] were owned by Lords, the [Depth] was owned by Gods. The only difference was that Gods were more detailed in their control over their regions.

These regions were called 'sites'. The size differed from very large ones to those small ones that were usually equaled the size of a small village. There was a total of 8 large sites each with different names. The ones that owned these sites were top-ranking Gods. Medium sites were controlled by high-

ranking Gods, and small sites by mid-ranking gods. Low-ranking gods had their own sites, but they were too small to be even considered as sites.

Jaehwan then stopped hearing things and asked, "So, the site is like the land?"

"A land? No! It's different!"

"Different?"

"...Uh, do you not know much about [Depth]?"

"I heard some, but I don't know much."

Jaehwan's knowledge of [Depth] was from Mulack's memory, so there were a lot of missing pieces. But he couldn't explain everything to this boy.

"Sites aren't just divided up by regions. It's like a... Divine Region or..."

"Divine Region?"

"Like you said, sites are kind of like land for the Gods. But it becomes something else for the high-ranking Gods. They can materialize their 'unique worlds' onto the 'sites'. The site is like the weapon itself for them."

Jaehwan then remembered Catastrophe from that description.

'I see. So [Chaos] was his site.'

It was clear to him that Catastrophe using almighty power within the [Chaos].

'But that means there are some who can use power like him in this place.'

Jaehwan's question was quickly answered by Runald's explanation.

"However, using world power throughout the entire site is a bit hassle even for high-ranking Gods so they use [Setting] instead. 'Naked', the one you used, is one of those Settings."

'Burdening? Then I guess there aren't much that're like Catastrophe.'

Jaehwan was now re-evaluating this boy who was thinking of him as a king.

'He's useful.'

At first, he thought the kid was a coward, but he was very knowledgeable and knew how to talk. He used the right words to explain [Depth] to Jaehwan, who didn't know much about it. Jaehwan still couldn't decide if he should take Runald with him. He had experience of getting into trouble for making a company in [Chaos].

'I don't want to make things more complicated.'

As his thoughts grew complicated, Runald stopped and asked, "Uh, God Jaehwan?"

"Take out the God part."

"Uh... Mister Jaehwan?"

"What."

"Is... Goddess Andersen okay?"

As Jaehwan looked at his eyes, he felt a weird sensation grabbing him. He realized that this boy wasn't just a cowardly innocent boy.

"You hear her voice, right?"

"Yeah."

"T-then..."

"What."

"...You're not going to kill her or anything like that, right?"

Jaehwan then realized his guess was correct. This boy had been saying that he decided to serve him, but all he did was actually for his goddess, Andersen.

Ronald was afraid of losing his Goddess, but Jaehwan knew the outcome. This boy would lose her.

[...You will kill me, right?]

Andersen spoke. Jaehwan tried to reply, but he decided not to. Besides, Andersen knew what Jaehwan was thinking even if Jaehwan didn't say anything.

[Yeah, I expected as much. I felt it when I came into you. To think you were the infamous 'Generalslayer'...]

Jaehwan now shared part of his memory with Andersen. Andersen saw Jaehwan's memory and so did he. That was how he found out some things. And few of them were some things that he couldn't let go.

Thousands, or maybe tens of thousands of years of memories. Through that, Jaehwan had read part of it clearly.

'You were a Cultivator.'

Chapter 120: Naked God (8)

Before Andersen had yet to become a 'higher being', this part of history was all the same for all Gods. It was a nightmarish time that required them to put a countless number of [Products] into a tower.

Andersen admitted to the fact.

[Yeah, I was a Cultivator. All Gods are.]

'Everyone doing it doesn't make you less guilty of it.'

[...I know.]

Andersen did not deny her wrongdoing.

[I don't intend on justifying what I did to become a God.]

Her voice did not have the slightest hint of guilt. Jaehwan grew angry, but he knew it was no use. He once read the following memory from Mulack:

-There are spirits who are born with one purpose. Demons and Angels are like that. These unfortunate 'higher beings' are born to become only 'Cultivators' and nothing else.

And unlike humans, they live solely for the purpose and are required to live for that purpose. The choice is not given to them.

So, in some sense, Jaehwan knew that there wasn't anything Andersen could do.

And Jaehwan had let Sirwen, a Nightmare, live for similar purposes. He knew it wasn't right to press moral issues on these beings and realized it

was the system that was the problem. But knowing it didn't make him less angry.

Jaehwan was human. He was a human who was once a [Product] that was cultivated.

He couldn't understand why he was angrier against Andersen than Sirwen. Maybe it was due to the interaction he had with the 'Cultivator' that made him more angry at them than the creator of the tower itself.

Andersen continued,

[I won't ask you to understand me. But... don't let the fact that I was once a Cultivator cloud your view on my relationship with my [Follower].]

'....'

[Maybe it's weird for you to see an Ex-cultivator that was once so close to the [Product].]

That was the most confusing part for Jaehwan. He could clearly feel her feelings toward Runald as he became one with Andersen.

How was this feeling possible? Andersen wasn't lying. The feeling was strong enough enough to shake Jaehwan's view on them. Andersen considered Runald as a very important person to her, and she valued him more than herself.

[You can kill me, but don't say that my feeling is a lie.]

That made Jaehwan hesitate. He knew he could kill Andersen anytime, but he couldn't do it. He knew that it would be very painful for the boy in front of him.

"Ug... argh...!"

That's when Runald began to twist and scream in pain. Jaehwan quickly grabbed Runald and found the world power within him storming around.

"...What is wrong with him?"

[Already?! NO! Runald!]

Andersen's memory quickly seeped into Jaehwan, and Jaehwan knew what was going on.

[He's becoming a Lost One!]

Lost One. After losing their Gods, they would turn into monsters. Jaehwan had heard about them from Eniac from the Void Factory. Overseers were, in fact, those Lost Ones.

-Only the ones who have a conscious as Daeus' [Followers] are us. Most became monsters. You'll meet them once you go to [Depth].

The Lost Ones felt extreme despair through the loss of their world and their Gods. Jaehwan knew that this boy would turn into a monster.

'I see... because his link between his God is broken...'

[Save him! Please!]

Andersen quickly begged him.

[You can kill me if you want! Just save him!]

'Why should I?'

[You're a human! Please!]

That was weird. A Goddess who was once a cultivator was reminding him that he was human, but Jaehwan repeated that question to himself.

Am I still a human? Is it really okay, to consider myself a human?

'What do I need to do?'

[Take him as your [Follower].]

'And what do I get?'

[...I'll get out of your head.]

Jaehwan knew what this meant and nodded.

'...Okay.'

Jaehwan then followed Andersen's explanation to accept a new [Follower]. A faint line between Jaehwan and Runald was drawn, and through it, Jaehwan felt Andersen's presence fading away.

[Followers] were allowed to see the unique world of their Gods with their own eyes. Depending on how the God saw their world, their [Followers] were forced to share their view.

When Runald came back to his senses, he knew he was inside a new world.

'New world... is this the God Jaehwan's world?'

Runald felt the linkage and looked around. The only world he knew was Andersen's fairytale-like world. What would be the new world? Young Runald looked around in excitement, and he was shocked.

"E-eye?!"

There was a gigantic bloody eye watching down from the sky. It was the Eye of Asura. Black crows circled around it, screeching eerily. Runald grabbed himself in fear. But it wasn't the end. He looked around and found something else.

"C-corpses?!"

There were corpses with maggots all over their bodies, flinching while slowly moving toward Runald. They cackled maniacally as they walked.

"I-impossible...!"

And in the new world, Runald the [Follower] fainted.

Andersen spoke as she watched Runald faint right after he woke up.

[Gosh, what have you shown him?]

'...It's his fault for coming into my world.'

[Eye of Asura, crows, and corpses... nobody will want to come in.]

Jaehwan smiled bitterly. He remembered hearing once that his world wouldn't be popular.

'I didn't ask him to become my [Follower].'

Silence fell. Jaehwan grabbed Runald and picked him up. Andersen also saw everything through Jaehwan's eyes. Her relief was shared with Jaehwan, along with her frustration.

[...Why did you stop me from perishing?]

'Prove yourself.'

[What?]

'Prove that I don't need to kill you.'

Andersen became silent, but particles of complicated feelings stormed within Jaehwan's head. Appreciation? Excitement? It was hard to describe. Andersen then spoke with a small voice.

[I will prove it.]

Jaehwan began to walk as if he didn't hear it. He felt like he could see a crying girl in front of his eyes as walked forward.

Chapter 121: God and Follower (1)

[There was a common mistake that most newbie Gods who just created their unique worlds made. It was to create a lot of [Settings]. This hit its peak in the 2nd year that those new Gods arrived in [Depth].

We're not talking about other Gods.

It's about you.

Let's be honest here.

Don't you have all these things going on in your head, like having superman-like powers, or a magical universe like Harry Potty?

...No, maybe you already have created them.

I will offer my condolences for the shame you will face two years later.

In two years, you will know that there are about 214 [Settings] that are related to having superhuman-powers and about 753 of them that are vaguely similar. (This information is from the unofficial Setting record from the [Akashic Records].)

And your unimaginative invention of the world of Harry Potty will be the 754th similar magic world.

And then, you will realize what you have done during the past years, and blame your Vicegerent while you watch other Gods scoff and smirk at you, asking why your Vicegerent did not stop you.

Then, you will change.

It is because you have learned a lot during those two years. During that time, you probably have learned that your few [Followers] are not enough to create a [Setting] that is powerful enough, and the number of [Followers] is everything in this damned world.

You will become a low-ranking God who yearns to increase your [Followers]. You will lose your innovative mind. You will aim to create safe, proven [Settings] rather than create a unique one, and choose something that will appeal to general [Followers] rather than something that will show your own traits.

After that, you will spend time and more time, creating the same [Settings] just like the other Gods, waiting to have more [Followers].

Then, maybe, after a long time, you might realize.

That there might have been something more important than this.

But, by then, it is too late. Imagination, dreams, and purpose. They will never come back. They will have left you, forever.

It is the way of a God.

To be a God in the [Depths].

-God of Mischief, Pierre

God and Follower

At the 84th Gate of [Caspion], at the border of 'Blue Grass' forbidden area and 'Red Depth Desert', a naked man and a boy were standing in front of the portal of the Gate.

The man looked down at his naked body and asked with suspicion.

"...Are you really sure that no one will become suspicious?"

"Don't worry. The [Depth] respects differences. It's a personal choice."

"Even though I'm naked?"

Jaehwan was staring at Runald doubtfully. Jaehwan wasn't really fond of any kind of 'Gate'. Even when he was at [Chaos], he had gotten into a fight with the Gatekeeper.

But if Karlton was here, he would've told him this.

'...wasn't it you who started the fight? You breached Gorgon Law, Chapter 27...'

Karlton must be here in [Depth] somewhere. Perhaps he was reciting those damn laws even now. Jaehwan spoke as he shook away the thought of Karlton's perfectly handsome face.

"In my world, walking around naked was enough to cause suspicion."

"What? What's wrong with being naked??"

[It's okay! Don't worry. Trust me.]

As he heard both the voices of the boy and girl, Jaehwan mumbled to himself that the [Depth] did seem different and shook away his thoughts. Surely, it was wrong to think that the Gods would have the same perspective as humans. Jaehwan decided to confidently enter the Gate with Runald.

Moments later, Jaehwan was arrested by the Gatekeeper.

In the Detention Center of the 84th Gate of [Caspion].

The Gatekeeper Captain, and a follower of the high-ranking God Valibar glanced between Jaehwan and Runald and spoke grumpily.

"It's suspicious enough to be naked... and what? A [Setting] that makes you stronger the more you're naked? Who uses that kind of [Setting] these days?"

As Jaehwan listened to the Gatekeeper lecture on, he mumbled quietly.

'I'm going to have a talk with you later.'

[That's weird. It's only natural! I think that Captain is just stuck up.]

'You're useless.'

[Don't worry. Just wait.]

Then, a soldier came to the Captain in distress.

"Captain, I think what he says is right. There was a Goddess named Andersen, who registered the [Naked] Setting about 8241 years ago."

The Captain's eyebrow was raised.

"Are you sure?"

"Yes, sir. I heard a rumor of such a Goddess too."

"You heard?"

"Yes, sir. I heard of a [Setting] that makes your muscles grow stronger when you take off your clothes... but...."

The soldier then glanced at Jaehwan before whispering to the Captain.

"S-she was once a high-ranking God? I see..."

It was easy to guess what they were talking about. The Captain then read through the document that the soldier brought to him and scoffed.

"Isn't that weird though? Why such a strange [Setting]..."

Jaehwan wanted to ask the same question.

"Naked Andersen, eh? ...so you're her Vicegerent and the boy next to you is her Follower. Right?"

Jaehwan wanted to answer no.

[Say that he's right. It will cause trouble if you don't.]

However, he had to change what he was going to say because of Andersen.

"Right."

The Captain seemed uncomfortable from Jaehwan's confident (arrogant to his eyes) attitude. He was the Follower of a high-ranking God and there was an unofficial caste system between Followers, depending on whose God they served was higher in rank. With that said, Jaehwan had to be polite with the Captain.

The Captain cleared his throat.

"Hmph. But this is different from the recording... The pattern of the world power is different and according to the record... Andersen only has one Follower..."

"Oh, our Goddess increased her Followers recently! We now have two!"

It was Runald who quickly intervened.

"Vicegerent, isn't it exciting? We can now create a new [Setting]! Like- uh, superman-ish powers or something! We have two Followers now!"

Jaehwan wasn't sure why Runald was being this overly excited. However, when the Captain heard the word 'superman-ish,' his eyes narrowed weirdly. Runald turned to the Captain and continued.

"Captain, you must have had days like us, right?"

"Huh? Oh, haha. Yeah, of course."

Was it because of Runald's cute look or his innocent question? The Captain didn't seem to be bothered at all from the sudden change of subject.

"Superman, huh? Yeah, I used to want one of those powers... I was foolish..."

"Captain, how was it like back then?"

"Haha, well, when I was your age..."

The Captain then began to recount his story as his mind traveled back to the time of his youth. It seemed that he thought Runald was a new Follower. Half of the Captain's story was his own feats and the other half was unneeded advice. Maybe he was once the Follower of a low-ranking God.

As he heard the Captain's boring stories, Jaehwan turned to Runald. Runald was eagerly responding to every detail of the Captain's stories.

Jaehwan was surprised. This boy knew how to deal with adults.

And after a while, the Captain finished telling his stories and stood up with a bright smile on his face.

"Hmph! I will let you go this time, so don't forget to update your records."

"Thank you, captain!"

"Yeah."

The Captain smiled at Runald and turned to Jaehwan with a cold expression.

"Don't walk around naked next time. Enjoy your [Setting] in your own unique world. Don't taint these innocent kids."

Chapter 122: God and Follower (2)

The door of the Gate closed in front of them, and Jaehwan and Runald stared at it silently. After a while, Runald spoke.

"Hah, stuck up."

Jaehwan raised his eyebrow curiously from the sudden change in Runald's attitude.

"Adults are all like that. They can't live their own life properly, and they still want to lecture you."

"..."

"What's up with all that lecturing? Do this, don't do that... Maybe he doesn't know that those kinds of lectures are forcing his 'unique world' on others."

Those were very sarcastic words to be coming from a 14 or 15-year-old boy. Jaehwan looked at Runald silently, and Runald thought that he had made a big mistake and looked down as his face darkened.

"I'm sorry. I didn't know the Captain would be like that. It's common knowledge not to mess with other God's [Settings] in [Depth]."

"Don't mind it."

Runald brightened up a little.

"Oh, and you know how to talk."

"...Hehe, thank you. But, you don't know how to talk, do you?"

Jaehwan then felt he would have no chance of winning by talking to this boy. He also thought that the boy would at least do his part through his talking skill.

'Oh, but I still have a useless one.'

[...?]

'You haven't proved that you're useful, have you?'

[What? You got through the Gate, thanks to me!]

'Huh? Let's make it clear. It was because of you that I almost couldn't go through the Gate.'

[Hell no! If it wasn't because of me, you would've ended up in [Caspion] jail.]

With Andersen's words, the main gate of the portal opened. It was another door from the small door Jaehwan and Runald had walked out of. There were lines of people walking through the portal, but they had cuffs on their hands and were escorted by Gatekeepers.

'Why put me in jail?'

[There are countless reasons that they can put you in jail. For example... your unique world.]

'What about my unique world?'

[It's bad.]

Andersen's voice came from the sky. Jaehwan turned towards the voice, and in the sky where there had been nothing, something was there. It was only in Jaehwan's sky.

[That eye.]

The Eye of Asura, in the middle of the [Depth]. Andersen was pointing at the eye.

'What about the eye?'

[That's supposed to be [Big Brother], right?]

Jaehwan looked at the eye. His world wasn't created with any kind of meaning. It was his consciousness and his will that created it. He didn't even know the existence of [Big Brother] when he created this world after all.

[Anything that makes fun of, or contains complaints about [Big Brother], is forbidden. They are like Gods among Gods. The Emperor of Gods. And you just made them out to be a disgusting eyeball. It's crazy.]

It seemed that respect for differences wasn't much after all. There was no freedom of speech here.

[But that's not the only problem.]

'What now?'

[You are an illegal God.]

'Illegal God?'

[It's what we call a God who is not recorded in [Big Brother]'s records. You usually automatically get recorded once you become a God, but you're different. The Gods of [Big Brother] never accepts 'your kind' to be a God.]

[Big Brother] did not accept 'his kind' to be a God?

Jaehwan couldn't understand what Andersen was talking about. He wanted to ask further, but a group of people walked past Jaehwan.

"MOVE! QUICKLY!"

"THE GODS ARE WAITING!"

"MOVE OR I'LL SEND YOU TO THE LABOR CAMP!"

People were being whipped as they walked hopelessly, and Jaehwan met eyes with one of them. In that second, Jaehwan felt shocked as he read the feelings of that man.

Fear.

It wasn't the fear of death or the unclear future that lay ahead. It was a fear that Jaehwan was familiar with.

Fear of being alone.

Jaehwan once read this from Runald's eyes a while ago. But it wasn't because of the fear that made Jaehwan shocked. As the man walked together with the group, Jaehwan stared at him for a long time.

It had been a long time since he was this shocked.

'But how?'

He even forgot what he was talking about with Andersen. At that moment, Jaehwan was barely able to open his mouth to ask.

"...What are they?"

"Who? Oh, them..." Runald answered, "I think they are from a Fishing Spot. It must've been a large Fishing Spot, especially with that many people. They are being put into a prison cell until they get sold in the auction house."

It was a casual explanation, as if it was a common occurrence. Jaehwan asked again.

"Fishing Spot?"

"Yeah. Uh..."

Ronald explained how a Fishing Spot worked. 'Fishing' was a way to increase the number of Followers. Andersen jumped in.

[Hey, I know it might sound inhumane to you, but there's no other way. These new spirits that were just fished out, need to find a God.]

Andersen continued carefully as she checked to see if Jaehwan was upset.

[If we don't do that, they go crazy and become the Lost Ones. The [Depth] isn't a place to be without a God.]

Andersen knew that Jaehwan still had a 'human' heart and that humans reacted sensitively to the treatment of their own. She was afraid that Jaehwan would be angry at the treatment his fellow humans were receiving. However, he wasn't angry. He asked something different.

"The Fishing Spot, where is it connected to? [Great Lands]?"

[No, the [Distant Lands] mostly. I think it's linked directly to the [Roots]. They are all from there. There aren't any that come from [Chaos] like you.]

"What kind of spirits are fished up, mostly?"

[Most are wandering spirits from the [Distant Lands]. And sometimes...]

"Sometimes?"

[Sometimes there are spirits who died in the Tower of Nightmares.]

Tower of Nightmares!

Jaehwan's mouth opened and closed. Andersen asked as she felt Jaehwan's mind was shaken.

[Why? Is there a problem?]

The man who was dragged away. Jaehwan knew his face.

He was not to be found here.

It was when Jaehwan was in the Tower of Nightmares, he had a friend who followed him to the end. The man who 'faked' going back to the past so Jaehwan could leave him without guilt. The man who was so hopeful and bright, that he got the nickname, 'Smile Knight'. Jaehwan still remembered his name.

'Why are you here, Yoonhwan...'

Chapter 123: God and Follower (3)

As the lines of people disappeared into the prison building, the door closed. The Gatekeepers joked with each other as they finished their work and passed by Jaehwan.

"What do you think?"

"They're all weaklings. Most will end up in the labor camp... I don't see any fighters in there."

"Yeah. Well, they couldn't even clear the tower after all."

After Jaehwan watched the Gatekeepers disappear, he spoke.

"Andersen."

Andersen grew tense as his voice seemed to contain a faint hint of anger.

[Yeah?]

"How many [Followers] can you take?"

In the dark, swampy insides of the jail, moans were heard everywhere. Yoonhwan looked around to check; there were people mumbling to each other.

"Uh... where are we..."

"You're from the dark clans! Where did you bring me?"

"Are we on the continent of Asterium? Please, someone tell me!"

"I- I'm from Pangea!"

The spirits began to cry and as a few of them grew too noisy, the prison guards came and punished them. After a monk who screamed 'clans' fainted, everyone became silent.

"This isn't Moorim, Pangea, nor Asterium. So, shut up and stay quiet if you want to live."

That was all that was explained by the one called the Warden. But with those words, people no longer talked. After that, guards sent the spirits to their rooms. Yoonhwan was also placed in a room.

'What is going on...?'

He couldn't understand what was going on. It had been a week since he was dragged into this unknown place. Just a week ago, it was his parents who greeted him when he came back to his senses. His parents told him that he had been unconscious for a month.

-Yoonhwan! Are you okay?

He answered that he was okay. However, he really wasn't sure. There was one question he had when he saw his parents.

'Didn't the world collapse?'

He wasn't sure why he had that question, as he felt like his head was being crushed. As he tried to remember, his memories became even more blurry. Then, he remembered a name.

'Jaehwan.'

He didn't know who that was. He didn't know anyone named 'Jaehwan'.

It felt weird.

-You really don't remember anything? We expected a bit more since you were the last to be awakened...

People asked him various questions, but there was nothing that Yoonhwan could answer. He had brief memories, but if he tried to explain, he would feel excruciating pain, so he couldn't.

He heard many things from the investigation team sent by the government.

Months ago, over 700 thousand people around the world fell unconscious, and they only began to wake up starting a week ago. They said that some became crazy and committed suicide, while others shouted, 'I've returned!! I've returned to the past!!' as they become delusional and were taken to mental institutes.

-As far as we know, you are the last. It seems that it has something to do with the 'tower' that was in the sky until a few days ago...

As he heard the word 'tower', Yoonhwan felt a chill. It was weird as he had no memory related to the tower. But, why? Why was he crying?

-Oh, I'm sorry. We'll come back tomorrow.

The investigative team left him alone as they figured there was a reason behind his tears. Yoonhwan then began to search the internet to find out what happened. There was a lot of information on the web about the 'Tower of Nightmares', or the tower that disappeared a week ago. People created all kinds of rumors regarding the tower.

The return of the Illuminati, a new military weapon from China, and so on...

Yoonhwan might have joined in on the conspiracies if it was before, but it all felt so pointless now. He instinctively knew that they were all wrong.

'The tower is connected to something greater that no one can imagine...'

Yoonhwan wanted to say that to them and he knew he was right, but he couldn't find any reasoning behind his thoughts. That made him more confused.

Why did he know such a thing?

That's when 'they' came to him.

Before he could resist, 'they' snatched him. And in the next moment, Yoonhwan realized his spirit had been taken away from his body. All he heard was a short conversation.

-Do we really have to do this? He wasn't even in the real game. He won't remember anything.

-The Union said we have to be prepared for the worst. That Generalslayer destroyed the tower as he moved up the Tree of Imagery, so there are rumors that the memory-seal might not have worked correctly because of it.

-Wow, so the rumors of the Generalslayer were true? That's crazy. How did he even think of destroying the tower and climbing up from there?

-Anyway, so that's why we have to manually collect those with impaired memory-seals.

-Ugh, does the Union think we [Apprentices] are like cleaners?

-What choice do we have?

-Ugh. So, how is the [Cultivation] going to be in this place?

-They are discarding the tower. This world is lucky. People in this world should thank the Generalslayer for that.

-But, isn't it good for us too? World 294 has a lot of fun things. Talking about that, should we stop by the PC-Bang after this one is done while we are here?

-I'm down.

And then, silence.

When Yoonhwan came back to his senses, he was in a place called [Depth]. He looked at the people in the room, and they all seemed to have empty

expressions. There was a woman who looked familiar, but he couldn't remember where he had seen her.

'It's cold...'

The cold became more severe right after he arrived at [Depth]. It was getting colder as time went by and Yoonhwan realized that it wasn't just the temperature.

He felt a corner of his world being destroyed. He also felt anxiety, as if his entire world would just be crushed, and it would squish him like an insect. Yoonhwan then crossed his hands together to pray. However, he couldn't find someone to pray to. Maybe it wasn't a coincidence that he remembered the name again.

'Jaehwan...'

Yoonhwan mumbled as if that was the name of a God, again and again. Then he felt warmth seeping into a corner of his heart. It was just a bit, but enough to protect him. He began to remember the familiar back of a man.

"294-163134."

And then, his thoughts dissipated.

"294-163134."

Yoonhwan realized that they were calling him. The Warden was standing outside the cell.

"294-163134. A God is here to take you in."

Chapter 124: God and Follower (4)

Yoonhwan looked up. God?

There was a man with gray hair standing next to the Warden.

"Is it him? The one from the tower of a [Master]?"

"Yes. The [Nightmares] from the Union assured it."

The Warden smiled.

"He couldn't clear it, but he reached the 98th floor. He also got past all the traps that the Master installed there."

"Any others?"

"There's a woman. Just like this one, she too is from Mulack's 'Tower of Regret'... oh, there she is. She made it up to the 76th floor, I heard."

The Warden commented as he scrutinized the woman in the corner of the room, "76th, hmm? That's a bit disappointing."

"Yes, but she is a beauty. She might not be fit to be a fighter, but..."

The gray-haired man seemed to be thinking as he stared at the woman.

"Is that everyone? I thought there should be more."

"The Union didn't send any others. These two are the only ones who had problems with their memory-seals."

The man then nodded.

"Okay, I'll take them both."

"And the payment..."

"I'll pay with spirit stones."

The man then handed a few stones to the Warden. He counted the number and checked the quality, then smiled.

"That's about right."

As he opened the door, he spoke.

"Oh, and I know I've reminded you of this many times, but if word gets out that I sold these spirits before they are taken to the auction house..."

"Don't worry. It's not like this is the first time."

"Right, right. Of course."

As Yoonhwan and the woman walked out of the cell, the Warden locked the cell and disappeared into the darkness. Yoonhwan looked up to the gray-haired man.

"Let's go."

With that word, a light shone upon Yoonhwan's world.

His God was in front of him.

[I see. So, you want to save that 'friend'?]

That was the first thing Andersen asked as she peeked into a part of Jaehwan's memory. As he nodded, Andersen continued.

[Let me answer your initial question. There is no limit to the number of Followers. Including your friend, I can take as many Followers I want.]

Andersen then asked Jaehwan.

[Wait, where are you going?]

Jaehwan did not answer and began to move. However, there was no hesitation or fear in his walk. When Andersen realized where he was heading, she screamed,

[NO! DON'T DO THAT! YOU CAN'T DO THAT!]

She shouted frantically, but Jaehwan asked back grumpily, "Why?"

[You're going to destroy the prison, right?]

"No, I'm just going to destroy the front gate and save my friend."

[That's the same thing! We're done for if we do that. Vicegerents of high-ranking Gods will come right for us!]

If it under normal circumstances, Jaehwan wouldn't even care.

Vicegerents of high-ranking Gods?

Since when did Jaehwan care about such things? He didn't care about all those Generals. But this time, the one he was trying to stop wasn't going to give up easily.

[Did you forget what happened by being reckless like that in [Chaos]?]

Andersen began trying to logically persuade Jaehwan after reading bits of his many memories.

[You wasted three months because of that! If it wasn't for you being so reckless, you could've found a way to get into [Depth] within a month! And without attracting needless attention from the Lords.]

Jaehwan became silent for a moment. Was he that reckless?

[I think you are trying to do something to Big Brother, but if you act like what you're trying to do right now, you will die before even getting a

glimpse of him. There are so many Vicegerents out there who are more powerful than Sameng Hoon.]

What she was saying wasn't a lie. She even showed a portion of her thousands of years of memory to Jaehwan.

[...See? Can you fight like them? Can you defeat them?]

As Jaehwan saw glimpses of the memories of those Vicegerents fighting in a war, he felt something different. He knew how powerful they were, but he couldn't feel anything. It seemed like the fights in this place had something more than just pure strength going on.

[So, you don't need to just bust in there if you're trying to save your friend. Don't do that.]

"How can I save him then?"

[We can use the auction house.]

Andresen then began to explain the auction house system of the [Depth].

[Spirits fished out from [Caspion] are placed in the Detention Center until they are taken to the auction house in the city to be sold. Meaning, we don't have to do any illegal stuff. We can just go to the auction house and buy your friend.]

If the Warden just saw this and knew about what change this caused to the [Depths], Andersen might have received the [Award of Gratitude – Caspion].

"I see. Then we'll go to the auction house."

As things seemed to work out easier than he expected, Jaehwan felt a bit better.

Unfortunately, Jaehwan had no idea.

The trial that he was to face an hour later, was in some way, much worse than all of the trials he faced in [Chaos] combined.

And about an hour later, Jaehwan was standing in the entrance to the auction house, buttnaked.

"...F*ck."

Chapter 125: God and Follower (5)

[I-I'm sorry. I forgot my official God authentication expired.]

Andersen quickly said to Jaehwan.

Exactly 30 minutes ago, Jaehwan was forbidden from entering the auction house by the employees.

-I'm sorry, but you will need valid God authentication to enter the auction house.

Jaehwan learned that there was such a thing called official God authentication and a God without it was not allowed to enter public facilities such as the auction house.

The bigger problem was that it would take a month for the authentication to be renewed.

-The law was amended a while ago, so if you can prove that you have 5 or more Followers, we will issue a temporary authentication for you to use.

At least 5 Followers. That was the least number of Followers needed to prove that the God's 'world' was safe to [Depth].

[Ugh, these top-ranking Gods and their nonsense...]

"Shut up."

[Sorry.]

So now, Jaehwan, Andersen, and Runald were looking for Followers outside the auction house.

Buttnaked, with a few parts dangling helplessly.

What was relieving was that Runald was actually rather excited. It seemed that he was excited at the thought of getting a new Follower.

-Accepting Followers! We welcome everyone! Partial payment for the penalty given, [Settings] will be at 200% for newcomers!

As Jaehwan looked at Runald holding up a hologram panel with the above written on it, and he was a bit impressed.

'He's good.'

"Hey! Lady! Please check our unique world!"

"OH! Mister, mister! Can you please check our Settings? It's one of a kind! I promise!"

However, even with Runald's overly enthusiastic recruitment efforts, there weren't any Followers volunteers. It was obvious why, but it was still disappointing to have no one even take an interest.

"Is it usually this hard to collect Followers?"

"Uh... we used to have some who would have some interest at least... why isn't there anyone now?" Runald asked as he looked down at Jaehwan and himself.

"...Is it because we're naked?"

"Probably."

[What?! NO WAY! My Settings are perfect! I think you'll be popular among girls.]

It was then that a man approached them.

"Oh, is it a new unique world?"

It was their first customer. He didn't look special, and he was obviously a Follower of a not particularly strong God. He did look a little suspicious, but he was still a potential customer. Runald quickly ran up to him and brought him to Jaehwan.

"Right! It's a new world! If you join us as a Follower, you will be high-ranking and various..."

"Hmm. But why is this Vicegerent naked? Is he..."

"That's not important! We have a cool world! You'll be impressed when you see it!"

"Really? What is it? Oh, and what [Settings] do you have?"

"Uh... hm. That's..."

Runald became silent. How should he explain the world? What about the [Setting]? As he looked up to the sky, Runald's face became pale. He then turned to Jaehwan.

Jaehwan answered first.

"It's better he sees it for himself."

And after a moment, the man who was eager to see a new world became terrified. As he pointed toward the sky with trembling hands, his eyes rolled backward and he fell.

"H-hiiiiiiik!"

As Runald explained it, he was so impressed that he passed out.

A few more spirits went by like that.

Their reactions all differed as they witnessed Jaehwan's world. However, they mostly involved passing out for a brief moment, and then leaving while cursing.

[You know, we'll never gain any Followers at this rate.]

Andersen mumbled in despair.

[Followers living in the [Depth] have a hard life. They live paycheck to paycheck and your world is too dark and gloomy. Do you think they will want to see that when their own life is already as hard as it is?]

"..."

[How about you change it to something brighter? I can let you borrow my world.]

'What is your world?'

[It's called 'Naked World'. It's a wonderful place where all Followers are naked. The only downside is that some perverts join just to get a peek but still...]

'...Didn't you say your world is like a fairytale?'

[Yeah! But an R-rated type.]

Jaehwan turned to Runald, who was still working hard on recruitment.

'So, was he an adult?'

He remembered Runald jabbering about Andersen's fairytale-like world savaging him and all.

[You really don't want to? I'm not forcing you, but we'll never gain a Follower in this rate...]

"I'm not changing it."

[...Are you sure?]

"I'll wait for a bit and if it doesn't work, I'm breaking in."

It was a casual but determined tone. Andersen felt as if she wanted to go meet Minerva, the Goddess of Fortune, for help.

[I-isn't it better to just put some flowers and trees, so it will look beautiful? If we spice it up, there will be a lot of Followers...]

It was then two women walked towards the auction house. They were beautiful girls, with lavish-looking equipment. Andersen spoke grumpily.

[Give up. I can see that they are Followers of high-ranking God.]

But Runald had already went after them. The girls cackled at Runald and spoke.

"Hehe, you're cute. Are you asking us to transfer our world?"

"Yeah! It's really amazing! You'll faint if you see it!"

"Really? I guess taking a look won't hurt."

They followed Runald towards Jaehwan. It was the blonde girl who spoke first.

"Oh, you dressed quite... extraordinarily. Like- nothing. Are you a Vicegerent?"

"Right."

"Can you show me your world, then?"

She smiled as she checked out Jaehwan's entire body. The short-haired girl standing next to the blonde girl also looked him over thoroughly, and stayed at bottom portion of his body as she spoke.

"That's disappointing."

Jaehwan had lived for two thousand years. He didn't mind sexual harassment, so he didn't hide his body. He spoke as he stood confidently.

"You can't just take a look for fun. If you are not interested in joining us, then I won't show you."

Andersen had to ask herself if Jaehwan was sane and the blonde girl seemed to be surprised.

"I don't want to waste my time on someone who's not interested in joining."

"Oh, so you knew. Haha."

The blonde girl grinned, "I can see that you're a Vicegerent of a low-ranking God. Aren't you a bit arrogant?"

"..."

"How great of a [Setting] makes you so arrogant?"

Jaehwan could see that the blonde girl was looking down on him. The short-haired girl interrupted, "Hey, aren't you a bit rude?"

"No I'm not. It's him who's being rude if he wants us to buy a product without letting us see it first."

With that, Andersen, who had been keeping silent, raged.

[A PRODUCT?! Does that girl think that a world is just created like a factory doll or something?!]

Andersen, who had been secretly planting flowers in the world, pulled the flowers out and shouted.

[I CAN'T STAND IT ANYMORE! Hey, show that girl your world. Make her faint.]

It was the first time Andersen had the same opinion as Jaehwan. Jaehwan nodded.

"I'll show you if you want it so badly."

And then his world was unleashed. It was even more tainted and distorted than usual. With the sounds of crows and dead bodies mindlessly walking up, the short-haired girl screamed in terror as she looked up to the sky and saw the giant, bloodshot eye.

"KYAAAAAA!"

And with that- she fell to the ground, unconscious. The blonde girl also seemed shocked as she looked up to the sky. However, she did not faint and spoke.

"Hey! Why are you showing such thing to a girl!"

"Didn't you want to see it?"

"I didn't ask you to show me this hideous thing!"

Runald then shouted from behind, "Hideous thing?! Apologize!"

"Shut up, kid! You dare to sell this hideous thing and..."

The blonde girl then pulled out a weapon from her waist. It was sharp rapier, pointed at Jaehwan. There was an engraving of a green leaf, a symbol of Goddess Artemis, on the weapon.

"Get it back into you! It feels like I'm going crazy!"

"What if I don't want to?"

"Then I'll make you!"

The world power of Artemis began to concentrate around the blonde girl. It was Artemis's [One Fatal Strike] Setting that shone brightly from her rapier. Andersen, who didn't think that a fight would break out, panicked.

[Wait- are you going to fight?!]

They were against the Followers of a high-ranking God.

She wasn't a Vicegerent, but just by serving a high-ranking God was enough to make her a formidable enemy.

[No! We can't win just with the [Naked] Setting! Our [Setting] is weak against hers!]

[Settings] between Gods of [Depth] had a power balance that worked like 'rock, paper, and scissors'. Law Settings were strong against Strength Settings, and Strength Settings were strong against Kinetic Settings, and Kinetic Settings were strong against Law Settings. Andersen's [Naked] Setting was a Law Setting.

However, even if [Naked] was a Strength type, this fight had to be avoided. High-ranking Gods usually had more than five thousand Followers.

The difference in world power between high and low-ranking Gods was large enough to trump the power balance of [Setting] types. Just as a pair of scissors made out of diamond would cut a rock made out of dirt.

And that's when Jaehwan took out something from his unique world. Andersen flinched.

It wasn't the power of [Naked].

Andersen then realized that she never asked what kind of [Settings] Jaehwan had. He was a God after all. He must have had his own [Settings] in place.

And in the next moment, Andersen screamed in panic as she witnessed Jaehwan hold up a sword burning with dark flames.

[W-what is that sword?!]

It was the first power Jaehwan acquired after he opened up 'Creation'. It was the dark sword that contained everything Jaehwan had.

[Fall]

The sword that could destroy the world was now revealed in [Depth].

Chapter 126: God and Follower (6)

[What kind of Setting is that?!]

Andersen was shocked by the world power she felt from Jaehwan. She knew that Jaehwan had lost a part of his memory and fought against the Generals of the [Great Lands] in [Chaos]. But, she thought he managed to do all that with pure luck. In fact, he even borrowed power from someone else when he faced those Commanders.

'What is this power then?'

As Jaehwan pulled out the sword from the world, his world power increased by a great amount. The power that equaled a Vicegerent of a low-ranking God changed to one of a high-ranking God.

[Fall]

Andersen gasped as she looked at the name shown above the sword. If it had a name like that, she was certain that it was a [Setting], but that world power didn't seem normal.

[Why... this can't be... This is unfair! What type is it?!]

All [Settings] within [Depths] were divided into types. Even if some God wanted to create a Setting that might make him twice as powerful as his enemy, it still wasn't possible because of the type.

Even with strong power, there was a weakness to it.

There was no Setting without weakness, and stronger powers had huge penalties. There were no Settings that would allow a low-ranking God to have the power that equaled a high-ranking God's.

Yet, that was now happening in front of Andersen's eyes.

The blonde girl who felt Jaehwan's power paled. His power that easily trumped her own terrified her.

'This is impossible! He is a Vicegerent of a low-ranking God!'

The blonde girl shook as she thought that, and in the next moment, charged at Jaehwan. It was as if a mouse, who was cornered, was charging at the cat. The rapier containing Artemis' Setting [One Fatal Strike] turned her sword into a giant arrow as she charged.

Jaehwan's face grew cold.

He didn't intend to fight. He just thought pulling out [Fall] would be enough of a threat for her to back off. But it didn't work.

'So, it's come down to this again.'

Jaehwan was disappointed. When he first came to [Depth] and met with Andersen and Runald, he was a bit excited. If what they said was right, [Depth] respected all kinds of worlds.

Many Followers lived in various unique worlds and enjoyed their own. It even seemed like what Jaehwan had been looking for: a world where there was no discrimination and everyone interacted with each other on even grounds.

If that was the case, Jaehwan thought that there might be some kind of a possibility.

However, it didn't take him long to realize that [Depth] was another version of [Chaos] or the [Great Lands] after all.

Weak worlds were looked down upon, and weak Gods were discriminated. There were right answers to things and people only cared for efficiency.

As Jaehwan looked at the arrow and its green world power, he heard something from deep within him. It was the voices he heard when he

opened 'Creation'. There were the voices of the countless Jaehwans who agreed with Jaehwan's creation. They were ordering him.

-Destroy that world.

-You are born only to destroy worlds.

His sword that wielded the power of 'Fall' ripped that world. The green arrow began to decompose the moment it touched the power of [Fall]. As it dissipated entirely, the blonde girl backed off.

'How...?!'

Her [Setting] was losing power. The world was leaving her, as if someone had ripped her world apart from her. She felt terrible fear. It was the fear of world loss, and she had never felt that after she became a Follower of Artemis.

She even heard Artemis' voice for the first time ever.

[Who are you?! How did you manage to pull me away from my kid... You dare...]

And with that, her presence disappeared completely from her. As if she had been struck on the head, she felt her vision turning white. The God wasn't a spirit, but a concept. How could a concept be damaged? She had never heard of a [Setting] that could do such a thing.

Jaehwan approached with his sword and her arrogance completely fled.

'N-no... I'll die...'

She couldn't understand. It was just like any other normal day. She only wanted to take a look at the world, that was all.

'No...'

She gripped her rapier tightly. But she knew it was a futile effort. The sword would come to her, and cut her head off at any second...

"Please, wait."

A voice interrupted them. Jaehwan turned to the man who had spoken. He had very thick facial lines and a well-built body. He seemed to have been well-trained. As he stood in front of Jaehwan, he looked back to the blonde girl.

"You should stop too, Benya. What have you done?"

"S-sir... but..."

"You just experienced that and you still don't get it?"

Benya gritted her teeth.

"But he is a low-ranking God's..."

"Are you still talking about ranks? I guess it was pointless to send you to Artemis."

The man spoke as he pulled the girl up to stand. Jaehwan narrowed his eyes as he looked at the man who didn't seem to be bothered by his world.

Chapter 127: God and Follower (7)

'This man...'

The man was looking around Jaehwan's unique world as if he didn't mind that Jaehwan was staring at him. That wasn't normal behavior for a person when another had a sword in front of him.

"Anyway, this really is one of a kind."

As the man looked carefully from side to side, Jaehwan's expression changed. He felt something similar when he clashed with Sameng Garam back then. But this felt more powerful.

If he felt that Sameng Garam received understanding from him, this man seemed like he just understood Jaehwan. The face of a man in front of delicious food. As the man stood looking around for a while, he finally let out a deep breath.

"Your world has a very familiar smell. There were Gods with worlds like this, a long time ago. Gods who existed before [Big Brother] came to this world, before the monster named 'System' appeared."

The man closed his eyes and continued talking, seemingly impressed.

"They didn't need Vicegerents or Followers. They created their own world, represented their world by themselves, and never forced their world upon others. They believed in their own world, and died alone. Your world is just like the world of those Ancient Gods."

A God without Vicegerents or Followers?

Jaehwan was interested in what he had to say and decided to let him continue.

"However, it's a shame. This doesn't fit the current trend. It would be really good if you fixed a few things..."

The man then opened his eyes. His golden eyes met Jaehwan's, and after a few moments, he spoke again.

"If you feel like it, how about you join our Federation of Worlds? You'll be respected within our ranks."

"..."

"We'll help you with fixing your world too. A world of this much value is worthy of respect."

Whatever it was, Jaehwan could not stop feeling disappointed after he heard everything. Jaehwan withdrew his sword as the man didn't seem like he was going to fight.

"I'm not interested."

"Really? That's a shame."

The man seemed really disappointed, but he also didn't have the intention to force his offer on Jaehwan.

"Benya, don't stand there like an idiot, apologize. I asked you to go to the auction house first, but instead, you caused trouble."

"I-I'm sorry, Sir Myad."

"You should apologize to that gentleman, not me."

"I'm sor..."

The blonde girl bowed with a reddened face and Jaehwan felt something was familiar. It wasn't because of her apology, it was the name that he just

heard.

Myad?

He thought that he heard the name somewhere before.

As he remembered, Andersen spoke in shock.

[...Myad? Myad van Deklan?!]

Myad van Deklan.

The owner of 'Myad Federation,' the 3rd Federation of Worlds, and one of the most powerful Vicegerents in [Depth]. Because of his many feats and achievements, he gained nicknames such as 'Owner of the 3rd World,' and many others. But most people in the [Depths] referred to him with this nickname.

'The Starseeker'

The reason for that name was because his world had a blue star in the sky, but more because of a very dangerous reason.

At the 274th Grand Crusade, he once declared the following in front of many high-ranking Gods,

"You can reach the stars even if you have short hands."

The Gods were shocked.

The sky in [Depth] had no stars. The only star it could mean was one.

Myad was one of few Vicegerents who did not give up on challenging [Big Brother].

'Sameng Garam told me to look for him.'

Jaehwan remembered that as he glanced at Myad explaining about the auction house. Sameng Garam had told him once that when Jaehwan got to

the [Depths], to look for Myad.

'Starseeker... maybe his purpose is similar to mine.'

"I didn't imagine one such to have had encountered such problems. There are needless and complicated rules in [Depth]. But if you join the Myad Federation..."

"I am not joining."

"Haha, you should consider it."

Myad decided to help Jaehwan gain entry to the auction house to apologize for what the blonde girl did to Jaehwan. It seemed that the authentication of a high-ranking God was enough in place of a regular God authentication.

[Be careful. You never know what he might be thinking. There's not much information about him. I don't even know what God he serves...]

Jaehwan did not need to heed Andersen's advice, as he didn't intend on sharing much with Myad anyway. It was good that he helped them enter the auction house, but that alone wasn't enough to warrant trust.

Beside, Sameng Garam, who recommended him, was one of those evil Generals after all.

And...

'This man knows I'm an Awakener.'

That was the most concerning issue. He had been under the guise of the Vicegerent of Andersen to others, but Myad seemed to have realized that Jaehwan's unique world was his own. It was as if he had known about Jaehwan.

"I see. So, you are traveling with him?"

"Yes!"

"And you are not afraid of his world?"

"...I am. But it's not just afraid. Like- isn't it scarier when you can't see it?"

"Oh, you know something, don't you?"

It seemed two girls following them had befriended Runald. The blonde girl was Benya, and the short-haired girl was Sinya. They were Followers of Goddess Aphrodite who were accompanying Myad to the auction house.

'I have to find Yoonhwan.'

As he walked at the front, together with Myad, Jaehwan was using his [Suspicion] to scan the area. He remembered seeing Yoonhwan's face an hour ago at the gate. It was definitely Yoonhwan. He seemed to be sick and fatigued, but Jaehwan was certain.

Jaehwan knew that Yoonhwan would not remember him. All [Products] who had not cleared the tutorial had their memories wiped. Jaehwan knew this from Beastlain's explanation a long time ago.

However, it didn't matter if Yoonhwan didn't remember him. He was already prepared for this.

That's when Jaehwan scanned a few powerful beings with his skill. They were at least as strong as Greater Generals, or even Commanders.

They glanced towards Jaehwan and then distanced themselves.

"Are you looking for something? Your presence is quite vicious."

Jaehwan then quickly stopped using [Suspicion] after Myad's words. This man had noticed Jaehwan using his skill. Jaehwan changed subjects.

"Is the auction house always this crowded?"

"Oh, no. It's more crowded than usual. I think it's because of the rumors..."

"Rumors?"

"I heard the [Parts] used by Ancient Gods, or the Three Divine Objects, are being sold today."

Chapter 128: God and Follower (8)

"Ancient Gods?"

Jaehwan casually asked in reply. Mayad smiled and responded, "...Hmm. So, you don't know much about them? I guess it's natural since they are beings from eons ago."

Before [Big Brother] appeared, there were three powerful Gods who were considered to be at the top of [Depth]. They were legendary Gods who had become the most powerful without anyone's help.

No Gods dared to disobey or oppose them. They were called the Ancient Three Divinities.

Godslayer Catastrophe.

Geshtalt the Illusion Breaker.

Daeus the Destroyer of the Odds.

Jaehwan's mouth twitched as he heard those familiar names.

'Catastrophe... so he is famous in [Depth] too.'

He knew this from the [Record of the Depths], but it felt different to hear it from locals. Apparently, it was normal for Catastrophe to be considered a natural disaster.

He was the one who had become the best in [Depth] where powerful beings were aplenty.

Myad continued, "As you know, equipment that has been wielded by a God for a long time will embody the God's [Setting]. This is what we call a [Part].

Jaehwan understood what Myad said.

"So, those are the equipment that the Ancient Gods used to use."

"You are right."

He nodded as he added, "Actually, their equipment is so famous that everyone in [Depth] knows about them."

According to Myad, the Ancient Three Divinities had left behind one equipment each after they were wiped out by [Big Brother]. The equipment was as follows:

The Void Sword of Catastrophe.

The Eye of Geshtalt.

The Daeus's Machina.

Myad then paused a moment before he added, "I heard that the giant robot, Machina, is going to be up on auction today."

Jaehwan then stopped.

'Machina?'

He once spoke about that particular object with the Followers of Daeus, back in the Void Factory. It was a promise he had made to the Overseers, that he would find the Machina, and thus they opened the seal for him in the first place.

-Machina is a treasure to us Followers of Daeus. It is an object with tremendous power. It will be hard to find though. If there's any chance, it would be within the [Great Forest] at the border of the 8th and 4th site,

but... there are no Followers who have ever come back alive after venturing into that place.

They had talked about it so much that Jaehwan thought it would be much later that he might come across the Machina. But for it to appear at an auction house? Jaehwan felt that something was suspicious.

"That machine thing. When is it coming up?"

"Oh, you're interested in it too? I guess it's only natural. After all, it is the most powerful of Gigantes in [Depth]..."

"I'm not interested. But I was asked."

Myad seemed interested in that, but he didn't ask Jaehwan what he was asked to do.

"Are you interested in bidding for the machine?"

"...Bid?"

It was an unexpected question. If he could acquire the machine, it would be a good thing as he did promise those Followers to return the Machina to them. Besides, he was sure it would help him greatly in his future ventures if he acquired such a powerful [Part].

[No way. We can't even buy the cheapest [Part] there is with the spirit stones we have. Forget it.]

Andersen quickly added. Jaehwan also agreed with Andersen. Whatever the case, he needed spirit stones, which were the form of currency in [Depth], to join the auction, but Jaehwan didn't have any. Just then, Runald interrupted,

"We should try! I have spirit stones here!"

"...You have spirit stones?"

[Eh... what? He didn't have any before!]

"Don't you remember? When we beat those Followers of Belkain..."

Jaehwan then remembered what happened back in the forest. It meant that Runald's spirit stones were from those Followers. Myad then asked, "You defeated Belkain's Followers?"

"Yeah! He did it in one strike!"

"One? Hm... Belkain is a middle-ranking God, right?"

Myad didn't seem surprised at all. Rather, it was a confirmation of what he knew. Jaehwan received the spirit stones from Runald. Then, Andersen spoke to him.

[No way. I think there's about 30... that will barely get us a middle-grade [Part], at best.]

Andersen was probably correct. It was foolish to even think about purchasing a legendary [Part] with the number of spirit stones that the Followers of a middle-ranking God carried.

[How about... we just... buy middle-grade... parts? Its... really... different to have... one... or not...]

Andersen's voice seemed to be dragging. Jaehwan nodded.

'Okay.'

Andersen's evaluation helped Jaehwan decide. His goal at the moment wasn't to get Machina, but to rescue Yoonhwan. Andersen spoke again.

[Ugh... this place... is strange... is it because... there are too many high-ranking Gods...? I feel... drowsy... Jaehwan, be careful... Machina... don't...]

And as she fell asleep, a thundering voice filled the entire auction house.

-THANK YOU! For visiting our Hatchnold Auction House in [Caspion]!

It came from the center of the auction house, seemingly the voice of the auctioneer. People began to shout 'Reynold! Reynold!' like a chant.

-Haha! I guess some of you know me! I am the Follower of God Hatchnold, the God of Equality and Fairness. Under the name of God Hatchnold, I swear that today's auction will be held 100% fairly and..."

It seemed that the auction for the high-ranking [Part] was going to start. Vicegerents and Followers began to gather in the center of the auction house. They were mostly Vicegerents with high-quality [Parts]. Jaehwan looked at them for a moment and then down at his naked body. And spoke-or tried to.

"If you are lacking in spirit stones, don't worry."

Jaehwan stopped and turned as Myad continued, "You don't need to pay any spirit stones."

"What do you mean?"

"I will pay for you. You just need to bid."

It was a strange offer. Jaehwan couldn't understand what Myad was talking about. Was he trying to borrow Jaehwan's name to bid? However, what he added made Jaehwan even more confused.

"Oh, and if you really do acquire Machina through the auction, it's yours."

"...What are you talking about? What about spirit stones that you lent me then?"

"Lent? No, no. It's more of a... sponsorship."

Jaehwan then understood Myad's offer. It was easy to understand actually, but it just didn't make sense, at all. His offer was the following:

First, Jaehwan would join the auction.

Second, Myad would supply Jaehwan with the needed spirit stones.

Third, if Jaehwan won, he would keep the Machina.

It didn't make sense at all. The offer had no benefits for Myad at all.

"...What do you want?"

"Haha, nothing. I'll just... say that I like you."

It was a very suspicious reason and Jaehwan frowned.

'Andersen. Are you listening?'

However, she did not respond, as if her switch was turned off. Her presence had disappeared from Jaehwan completely. She said she was going to sleep, so she would wake up later, but...

'Ugh, why now.'

Andersen spoke a lot of nonsense, but she was once a high-ranking God. She had more experience in [Depth] than Jaehwan.

"What do you say? You can refuse if you don't like it."

Jaehwan felt some uneasiness as he looked at Myad's smile. From his experience, this kind of situation was usually a trap. But it was too tempting to just refuse just for the possibility of it being a trap. Jaehwan also thought that if things went wrong, he would just destroy everything.

'Myad van Deklan. He's not in the [Record of the Depth]...'

Jaehwan had been going through the [Record of the Depth] in search of information about Myad ever since he met him. But he couldn't find anything at all. Maybe Myad appeared after Mulack wrote the [Record of the Depth].

Anyway, Jaehwan had to decide by only relying on his instincts. To Jaehwan, who acted on information gathered by using [Suspicion] and [Understanding], it was a strange feeling.

It was when the crowd disappeared towards the center of the auction house that Jaehwan decided.

Chapter 129: God and Follower (9)

"If you say so, I will consider it."

"You will?"

Myad was excited.

"But, I won't bid right now. If the Machina is as great as you say, it will come up at the end."

"...You're correct. I believe the Machina will be put last in the auction."

"I came here with a different purpose, so I'll look around first. If the central auction is not finished when I'm done, then I'll do as you say."

It was the best decision he could make without asking for advice. It was the only way that would allow him to find Yoonhwan and get Machina. Myad shrugged and nodded.

"You can do that. If Machina is about to come up, I'll come over to you."

Myad smiled and disappeared towards the center of the auction house.

Jaehwan and Runald were now moving toward the north through a small road.

"The Follower auction is this way!"

The Hatchnold Auction House was dome-shaped, with the center auction house right in the center. To the south of it was where people traded with each other, and to the north was where people bidded on low to mid-grade [Parts].

On the 7th small road to the north was where Followers were put up for sale. It was because the north road was directly connected to the Caspion Jailhouse.

That was where spirits who were fished up from the public fishing spot were brought to be sold.

As Jaehwan moved, he glanced around at all the Products on sale. The Followers of Hatchnold were bringing in [Parts] to put on auction, the place where the low to mid-high grade [Parts] were on sale.

There was a deep blue mid-high grade [Part] on auction at the moment.

-Reinholdt's Long Coat! We have the highest bid at 420! 420!

Jaehwan then found the blonde girl who came together with them into the auction house. Was her name Benya? It seemed that she did not stay together with Myad.

"480! We have 480!"

Jaehwan looked in her direction, then looked down at himself and moved on.

'Who cares?'

Jaehwan and Runald walked along the road and soon reached the 7th road. The heat of the auction house faltered and a dark, cold atmosphere surrounded the area. At the corner of the street, he could hear whispered moans from the people.

"Uhhh..."

"Nngh...."

People from within glass walls looked at Jaehwan. Some seemed desperate, while some were in despair. There were a lot who were biting their nails or drooling.

Jaehwan felt his heart grow cold. He had expected as much, but expecting it and seeing it was different.

These were the people of [Depth].

"...I hate this place." Runald said, "If I wasn't taken in by Andersen, I might've ended up in there."

Runald had complicated feelings. He felt relieved at being different from them, and at the same time, he was also disgusted at himself for being relieved. Jaehwan looked at Runald and thought, 'If I can take all of them as my Followers...'

The thought then became a question that made him grow even colder.

'But will allowing them to be my Followers make them happy?'

Jaehwan realized one thing with the recent happenings. That he would never be an appropriate [God]. His thoughts became certain as he talked with Andersen or Myad.

-Your world is too dark and gloomy. People are having a hard time as it is. Do they really need to see yours?

Jaehwan thought that maybe Andersen was right. Maybe it wasn't the truth that those people needed. People were too weak to accept the truth.

"Runald."

"Yes?"

"You regret becoming my Follower, right?"

Maybe it was fake 'comfort' that those people needed. Warm comfort, not the cold truth. Even if it was fake, it was what kept them living.

"It's not like you to say such a thing."

It felt weird to hear that from Runald, as he hadn't known Runald for long. But Jaehwan asked back calmly.

"It's not like me?"

"You didn't even ask if I am regretting it. You just assumed that I do. That's not even a question."

"..."

Jaehwan became surprised. Maybe he wasn't like himself after all. This boy was brilliant at catching onto things like this.

"Honestly, I do regret some parts. I mean, I like Goddess Andersen's world better."

He spoke honestly and continued, "I will continue to think that way. I will consider that Andersen's world is better... that it was a good time... uh, are you hurt? Your expression is..."

"No."

"Hehe, anyway yeah. Your world has no flowers, no good scenery, and no naked girls... honestly, your world has nothing. But then..."

Runald then looked up to the sky. Jaehwan could see what Runald didn't say. Runald spoke again.

"But, even then..."

He was still looking at Jaehwan's sky. Even when he fainted the first time he saw it, but Runald could now confidently look up at it. The giant eye in the sky, with the vision that could rip the boy apart at any moment, was upon him, but Runald still looked straight at it.

"When I'm in your world... I don't feel like I'm running away. I don't know what it is... but it feels like I'm standing against an enemy that I can never win without fear."

Jaehwan also looked up to the sky. The naked man and naked boy looked up at the same sky for a while. Runald then wiped his sweat from his forehead and said, "...It feels weird to talk like this when we're naked."

"Yeah," Jaehwan nodded.

Chapter 130: God and Follower (10)

As the two naked men had an awkward atmosphere between them, there was a woman watching them from a distance.

"...What the hell are they doing?"

It was the blonde woman, Benya. She quietly approached the two of them.

"Huh?"

Runald found her first. He pointed at her and spoke.

"Oh, it's the woman who peed on the ground."

"...I didn't pee," Benya retorted and glanced toward Jaehwan. She looked down when Jaehwan looked back at her. She stood there silently and hesitated for a few seconds before she handed out a shopping bag.

"H-here!"

"...What is this?"

"Clothes," she said in a shaky voice.

"Clothes?"

"It's called Reinholdt's Long Coat..."

It was the [Part] that Jaehwan saw at the lower auction house area earlier. Jaehwan reached into the bag and took it out.

[Reinholdt's Long Coat]

Description: Long coat worn by Vicegerents of High-ranking God – Reinholdt. It's durable and keeps the temperature of the wearer. It is said to wield Reinholdt's Setting – [High Speed Flying].

The hologram that contained the description popped up as soon as Jaehwan touched it. He used to have no access to anything in the [System] up until his 3rd step, but a few of them came back once he reached the 4th step of Awakening. It didn't mean he could use levels or status, but it allowed him to read descriptions or something similar. It was uncertain as to why the change happened, but Jaehwan guessed it had something to do with him opening a 'Creation'. Jaehwan looked down at the coat and felt some kind of déjà vu.

"Hey- what's the size?"

"Size?"

Asking about the size when it was free? It seemed rude, but Jaehwan did not care about manners.

"I have bad memories about getting the wrong size."

"Uh... well, you don't need to worry about sizes. It changes to fit the wearer."

"...Is that so?"

Jaehwan was surprised as he looked down at the coat again. Mino once gave him clothes when he arrived in [Chaos].

'Something bad happens when I get something like this.'

He ended up in a messy situation.

'I guess it should be alright this time.'

Jaehwan decided to receive the gift.

"But why are you giving it to me?"

Benya thought the order of the questions was wrong, but she decided to not care.

"...I felt sorry."

She couldn't even bear to look at Jaehwan.

"If it's about what happened earlier, don't worry about it. I've forgotten it already."

"Are you forgiving me?"

Jaehwan nodded and Benya's face brightened. Jaehwan then took the coat and wore it. The coat began to shrink on Jaehwan and soon changed its shape to fit Jaehwan's body. It didn't hinder his movements at all. It was truly a good [Part].

"Thank you."

Jaehwan showed his gratitude.

"It looks good on you!" Benya also added. But the other man, the only Follower of Jaehwan, did not seem to share the idea.

"...I'm disappointed, Jaehwan."

Runald, who was now naked alone, looked at him with a disappointed expression.

"Why now?"

"You have clothes! It's not beautiful! It's revolting to our 'Naked way'!"

Jaehwan was about to object and refute the fact that he never wanted to uphold that ridiculous 'Way', but Benya jumped in instead. She stood proudly in front of Runald and looked down.

"Heh, little kid. You don't know anything, don't you?"

Runald felt like he was being belittled by an older person, but he couldn't fight back. Benya scoffed, "A kid like you wouldn't know 'true beauty'. No way."

"...True beauty?"

Benya then smiled arrogantly as she continued, "True beauty doesn't show when you're naked."

"...What?"

Runald was reminded of the following words from Andersen ever since he arrived at Depth.

-True beauty lies in nakedness.

He didn't care at first, but he soon didn't mind whether it was true or not. Then when he realized it, he was fully submerged in the idea. It was true. The Goddess was right. The true beauty lies in... no. It was nakedness that was the definition of beauty!

Yet, here was this woman, a powerful foe who directly opposed the idea.

Runald became angry.

Who was she to talk about 'nakedness'?

"It's the difference between art and pornography... but you're too young to understand."

Surely, it was too difficult for Runald to understand. He fired back, "Then, what is true beauty?"

"It's only when you can barely see it that you can see true beauty."

Barely? What did she mean? Runald couldn't understand.

"No way. The true beauty of a human being lies within the nakedness!"

"Hmm... how about I put it this way- kid. A 'God' is a mysterious being, right?"

Runalld was confused by the sudden subject change, but he decided to answer anyway.

"Yeah, I suppose so."

"Then why is it mysterious? Do you know why?"

"Uh, what does that have to do with true beauty?"

"Just answer me first."

Runalld gave some thought to the question, but he couldn't find the answer. He became disappointed at himself and shook his head as he looked up to the lady.

Benya smiled.

"It's because we can't see them."

Chapter 131: God and Follower

(11)

"See...?"

"It's not that we just can't see. It feels like we can see them, but we can't."

Runald felt something beginning to puzzle together. To him, the Gods were the voices and beings that showed the world, but they never revealed themselves. Runald felt them, and he felt like he could see them, but he was never allowed to actually see. It was still not enough. Benya then placed her hand under her skirt and spoke.

"Well- it's something like this."

She began to lift her skirt up very slowly, showing her clear, white skin. And...

Runald swallowed as he watched.

More. Just a bit more...

Then, when it felt like something underneath it would show in a bit, Benya stopped. One felt like it could be seen, but couldn't. Runald became confused.

"See? Do you get it now?"

Runald felt as if he had been struck with lightning at that moment.

This was the god.

He had witnessed many naked women in Andersen's Naked World. However, in front of him was a woman whose beauty exceeded that of any naked woman he had witnessed in the world. He felt his 17-year-old runny nose and realized his life had reached another stage.

-True beauty lies at the magical point of visible and not visible.

This- this was the word that would later describe Runald as the 'Naked Saint', throughout the [Great Lands]. But for now, he was just a fool for getting a nosebleed after peeking at a pretty girl's underwear.

Jaehwan was amused.

Perhaps it was because of his new eye-opening experience, but Runald's body was shining with golden world power. The Follower's world power was evolving.

'...Becoming powerful after watching something like that? What the hell is going on here?'

It didn't seem like the surrounding world was normal at all.

'A point visible or not visible?'

Jaehwan then glanced down at his bottom. If this was Earth, he would be considered much worse than just being naked with only a coat on him. He looked at Runald for a second and then spoke to Benya.

"I don't know any about all that nonsense, but why didn't you get me a pair of pants too?"

"Huh? Oh, I thought you were naked there on purpose..."

"Why would I?"

"I'll go some pants and a shirt right now-"

"It's alright."

Jaehwan waved his hand and buttoned his coat from top to bottom. It felt weird as his shins were still exposed, but it was much better than his naked self moments ago. Benya then asked, "Are you here to find a Follower?"

"I'm looking for someone."

Jaehwan then summarized why he was here to Benya.

"Oh... it would've made things much easier if you told us earlier."

Benya quickly walked up to the guard standing at the corner of the street. After the guard exchanged a short conversation with Benya, he opened the search engine for her.

After a while-

"...No?"

"No, ma'am. There's no one named Yoonhwan on the auction house today."

"It's not just Yoonhwan. It's Kim Yoonhwan. Did you search thoroughly?"

The guard looked at Jaehwan who just interrupted with a frown and replied, apparently annoyed by the intrusion.

"I DID search thoroughly. No."

He even showed the result he found.

"These are all spirits we fished up from public Fishing Spots today. The spirit you mentioned is not on our list."

Jaehwan was disappointed, but he soon turned the suspicion at himself.

'Was I mistaken?'

But that was not possible. It was the face of a friend who had spent tens of years with him. How could he forget? It was Yoonhwan for sure. Benya noticed Jaehwan's disappointment and quickly asked the guard.

"Is... there a chance for a spirit to taken somewhere else rather than auction house?"

"Oh, uh... that's..."

The guard hesitated and Benya quickly handed over a spirit stone to him. He refused at first, but soon received it as he glanced around to check if anyone was around. He then waved at Jaehwan and Benya clandestinely and whispered.

"There are gods that take spirits from the Detention Center from time to time. It's done to capture the quality spirits before anyone else has the chance to take them."

"Who are they?"

"I don't have the names. That's all I know."

It seemed like he really didn't know since he was just a guard after all.

'I guess there's no other way but to break in and find out myself.'

Jaehwan turned at the Caspion Jailhouse at the end of the street. As he tried to walk toward it, there was the sound of a whistle and a giant dome style barrier appeared to block the way to the jailhouse.

Jaehwan tapped on the barrier with his hand. It was a powerful one; he wasn't sure if he could break it even when using his full power.

The guard spoke up from behind.

"Oh, I guess today's best auction is up."

"How do you know?"

The guard then pointed at the barrier.

"That's the highest quality barrier by God Hatchnold. It's only activated when the best auction is being held. It's just a precautionary...."

Before he can finish, the voice of the auctioneer, Reynold, was heard from the central auction house.

[Ladies and Gentlemen! The time has come!]

At once, powerful energies from various areas began to move. It was powerful energies that Jaehwan would have a hard time fighting against. It felt like the energy was very familiar to Jaehwan's as he clenched his sword's hilt.

'This energy...'

[Hey- what the hell happened?]

It was then, when Andersen who was thought to be disconnected, spoke. Before Jaehwan could answer her, Andersen shouted.

[...Why- why are 'they' here?!]

'They?'

[RUN! You can't stay here!]

But as Jaehwan asked Andersen, he was already activating the [Setting] equipped in the Long Coat.

[Wait! Where are you going! That's the wrong way!]

With [High Speed Flying], Jaehwan and Runald flew quickly toward the central auction house.

"Wait for me!"

Benya's lone voice filled the area behind them.

Chapter 132: Ancient God (1)

Recently, theories have been circulating that Three Ancient Gods weren't all removed by [Big Brother] at all.

The crater with a diameter of 248km, located near the 8th site, [Caspion], is evidence that supports the theory. According to the local recordings, the crater was created about 210 thousand years ago, around the time when the Three Ancient Gods disappeared from [Depth].

Some researchers claim that there was the 9th site of [Depth] upon this crater, and the crater is the trace of a fight between Daeus and Geshtalt, two of the Three Ancient Gods.

Few claim that the Followers of Daeus and Geshtalt continue the fight that started 210 thousand years ago even to this date at various places within [Depth], but there is no evidence that confirms this claim.

Currently, this crater is called as [The Great Forest] and are considered one of the 8 Forbidden Areas of the Depth.

-[History of War of the Depth]

Episode – Ancient God

Within the 5th site [Ragnarok], there are concentrated illegal site areas in the darkest corner of the site.

It is nicknamed as the 'Moon's shadow.'

It's the place where one trades for illegal [Parts] or smuggled [Followers]. It was illegal, but no high-ranking Gods that resided in Ragnarok interfered with the 'Moonland'.

The profit coming from the Moon's Shadow was just too great to have it removed.

And in the center of the Moonland, a beautiful woman and old man were standing there. It was the old man who spoke first.

"Dammit, this is damn hard to find. Are all your regional offices hard to find like this?"

"Don't talk like you don't know. You were a part of this before, remember?"

Yoo Surha, the 2nd Captain of the [Rupture] spoke.

'So, what came to this?'

Surha recalled the memory of that 'day' of 2 years ago. It was the day when Sole-King Catastrophe came down to [Chaos], the day when hundreds of Generals were killed and the path to the Depth was opened. That day, Surha stood in front of Jaehwan and his friends to stop them.

'That was already 2 years ago?'

It felt like time had flown by so fast.

"Teacher, I have to remind you this again, but this doesn't mean I'm working with you people. Get it?"

"Hah, I don't want you to work with us either."

"I'm staying with you all just until we find 'him'. Better watch out."

"You watch out, girl. Unless you want to get stabbed while you're asleep."

"...Hah, sure."

The old man next to Surha was Chunghuh, the Doctor of Despair. They were enemies 2 years ago, but were now traveling together as they had the same 'goal' for the current moment.

"But can't you hide it better? It's too obvious."

"What? What are you talking about?"

"That."

Chunghuh looked up to where Surha's finger was pointing. In the sky of Ragnarok, there was a giant structure barely visible through the floating clouds.

"Isn't it too crude for a creation from a Nightmare?"

It was hidden by an optical illusion, but it was enough to notice that there were distortions if one looked hard enough.

-Shut up. I can hear you too.

"Hah, Nightmares and their hearings."

Surha mumbled as she looked up to the 'Flying Ship – The Fall' hidden up in the sky.

"What kind of a name is a 'Fall'? It's stupid."

-Hey! Will you shut up?

Sirwen's voice thundered through the earpiece. Karlton's voice came after.

-Doctor, are you still looking for it? Our stealth is imperfect, so we will need to hurry."

"Be patient. And it's not me who's looking for it. It's this girl."

Surha sighed at Chunghuh who was blaming her. She would have beaten him up if it was like before, but she couldn't do it anymore. A lot of things happened between the 2 years since they arrived in [Depth].

'He's gotten stronger.'

In those 2 years, Chunghuh had achieved quite a bit of growth in strength. He was now in his 4th step, and so he could now fight as an equal with Yoo Surha.

'He really is something... making teacher become this strong....'

Surha's eyes, as she glanced at Chunghuh, met with his eyes as he turned to her side. They both looked at each other for a slight second.

"Hey, girl. I wanted to ask you something."

Chunghuh started talking awkwardly and Surha scoffed.

"Don't ask me out or something like that."

"...Why are you after Jaehwan?"

Chunghuh did not respond to the joke and asked seriously. He didn't miss Surha's face growing heavy at the moment.

"No, let me rephrase it. Why did you let him go back then?"

"...Back then- when?"

"When do you think?"

It was an obvious question. There was only one time the word 'when' applied to for them.

"I know you didn't fall behind in strength. You're the Captain of Rupture."

"..."

"Or was Jaehwan much stronger than I thought he was?"

Surha then became angry at his words.

Was he strong?

"I don't know. How should I put it..."

She frowned as she remembered the day when she fought against Jaehwan. He was strong. No, he became stronger. Much stronger than when [Rupture] first found him. He was now strong enough to fight against the Captains of the Rupture.

And Yoo Surha was the 2nd Captain of Rupture.

She was the one who killed many Generals with her weapon, 'Thunder Demon'. Her lightening rained hell as she moved her deathly scythe, and thus she got her the nickname, 'Early Dawn'. She earned 5th place in the power rank within Rupture and was the fearmonger among the Generals.

That was Yoo Surha.

She was to overpower Jaehwan. Yet, 2 years ago, she couldn't stop him.

It was Chunghuh who asked again as Surha became hesitant about continuing.

"You saw something."

"..."

"You saw something- a potential that you can't find in anyone else, or any Captains. Isn't that it?"

Surha did not answer, but she bit her lips. There was a voice that came into her mind.

-Your ways will not change the world. The cultivation is only the outcome. It is the 'reason' that needs to be dealt with.

Jaehwan spoke to her when she explained and offered Jaehwan to join Rupture. It was an obvious point and she had no way to fight against it. Although it was true, it was equally impossible as well. But Jaehwan told her the outcome of his 'impossible' story.

-I will destroy this 'world'.

Chapter 133: Ancient God (2)

How can he speak like a typical villain so seriously?

It was enough to laugh at, but Surha couldn't laugh.

"Hey- what do you think a 'world' is?"

"What are you talking about all of a sudden?"

"Just answer me."

"You mean the unique world? That is because of.."

"No-no. I'm not talking about... Never mind."

Surha shook her head. She could see that Chunghuh did recognize what Surha had asked, but the old man was just pretending that he didn't understand the question. She and Chunghuh were both 4th stage Awakener. There was one fact that all Awakeners realized after reaching the 4th step.

The 'world' they saw until now was only part of an iceberg.

The being that became a [God] went and found a new way to perceive things. Unlike the 3rd step where you could just realize the 'truth' of the [System], 4th step Awakeners were allowed to face the world itself.

Countless information came from all parts of the world.

All this information filled their minds. [Gods] were excited by the flood of information that they had not known until then. They realize that become a [God], and they feel that they are almighty all-knowing. However, they soon feel despair toward the sea of information.

It is because they realize that they can never control the information.

[Gods] then are confused and become corrupt from the influx of information. Some go crazy while some choose to make the decision.

They choose to close their eyes and ears, and refuse to take in the information.

This was called [Seclusion].

It wasn't considered bad since it was necessary to keep the ego. The Gods who fall in [Seclusion] give up on feeling the giant 'World'. Instead, they choose to stay within the small world they created and live while growing the world.

This 'small world' that the Gods created were called the following.

-Unique World.

Surha remembered the world full of corpses and the giant eye of Asura. Jaehwan's unique world.

It was a world that made her feel uneasy every time she thought about it. No other unique world contained such a hideous thing, especially the eye. She looked up to the sky. It was the eye that did not exist in her sky. She knew what that eye was supposed to mean.

'He can see [Big Brother].'

As far as Surha knew, the only one who could [Big Brother]'s presence was only one existence out of the entire [Depth]. The Master of Rupture. He had told her once before.

-Surha, fight your [Seclusion]. If you succeed, you will see the 'truth'.

But, Jaehwan was able to see [Big Brother].

It meant he also succeeded in fighting his [Seclusion].

Yoo Surha was curious.

What was the world like after getting out of [Seclusion]? The world that looked directly into the terrifying [Big Brother] — was that world still one of many [Unique Worlds] out there? No. Maybe that world is...

It was Chunghuh's voice that brought her back from her thoughts.

"Hey girl, isn't that the place?"

There was an old antique shop at the corner of the street that seemed to specialize in old [Parts] that nobody visited.

"OH! That's it! It's there!"

They walked over to the shop right away.

As they opened the door, an old man with a long mustache appeared.

"What brings you here?"

"Hey- It's me. I'm here for some information."

"What brings you here?"

"...It's me. Didn't you hear?"

"Ugh... gosh." Surha sighed and began speaking the following phrase: "So, we will be the slaves of the freedom, the blade of the rights, and the measurement of the equality."

With that, the light within the building went out and the windows were covered with blinds.

Slave of the Freedom.

Blade of the Rights.

Measurement of the Equality.

These were the metaphors that symbolized the organization. Of course, there were other names that directed this organization. The Anti-Cultivation Group, or the Worst Terrorist Group in history and such... but it was the name that was more famous than all of those nicknames.

[Rupture]

This was the 5th regional office of the worst terrorist group, [Rupture], of the [Great Lands].

The old man who appeared through the darkness was not an ordinary old man. His face and shape had been changed entirely to that of a middle-aged man. It seemed he had the [Setting] to change his physical appearance. Surha ranted, "Hey, do we really need to go through this every time?"

"It's the rule. So, who's he?"

"He's with me. He's not with [Rupture] but... he's kind of [Rupture]? Or an Ex-[Rupture]...? Don't worry about him and just show me the list."

"Here."

The man then handed over a 10-inch sized machine. It was the machine that showed information that [Rupture] gathered recently, in order of importance. Surha spoke as she scrolled down on the list.

"Hmm... what's this? There are Lost Ones rampaging at [Caspion]?"

"There's word that the Followers of the Ancient Gods are gathering at the Hatchnold Auction House. I heard that a [Part] of an Ancient God is up for bidding in the auction house..."

"What? Really?"

Surha frowned at the information.

"Hah- Machina? There's no way that it can appear at an auction house. It smells fishy... but I'll pass on the information for now. What else?"

"Next is about an Awakener."

"Awakener?"

Chunghuh and Surha's face brightened. It just might be the information they were looking for. The man continued, "There's information about an old man with the nickname 'Perverted Guru' making mess in the East. I think he killed a few Vicegerents of middle-grade Gods while leading a pirate group called [Bringer of the Fall]... it's a big issue out there."

Surha and Chunghuh's expressions turned weird at the news.

"I heard the Perverted Guru uses a very unusual unique world. What was it called... Kangho... or was it Joong..."

"Isn't it 'Moorim'?"

"Hmph, maybe it was."

Surha was barely holding back from laughing and Chunghuh's nose widened as he fought back the urge to laugh.

"Anyway, you should watch out for him too. I heard he's quite the Awakener. He's really interested in beautiful Vicegerents apparently."

"Perverted Guru... yeah- of course. I will for sure," Surha answered as she glanced at Chunghuh, in which he coughed uncomfortably. "So- any other news?"

"Nope."

"I see..."

Surha became disappointed, but that's when the machine sounded an alarm, followed by a new message.

"Oh, I guess we have a new one. There's a fight happening in the Hatchnold Auction House."

"The place with the Machina? What happened?"

"Five Vicegerents of a high-ranking God and 12 mid-ranking Gods have been killed."

"What? Five from the high-rankers?"

Vicegerents of high-ranking Gods weren't easily matched. They were powerful individuals within [Depth].

"That's close to a war. Did they fight against each other?"

"No. They were killed by a man."

"What- what kind of mad man does that in a..."

In that moment, Yoo Surha stopped speaking and Chunghuh also looked at Surha. Surha leaned closer to the table and asked.

"D-do you have a video of it?"

"...Here."

Soon, a hologram screen showed a man. The video quality was not good enough to see the face, but two things were certain. One was that the man was naked with only a coat on him, and another was that he was 'stabbing'.

-AAAAARGGH!

Vicegerents were being flown away through the vicious world power storm. As they heard the sound, Chunghuh was making a face as if he had been waiting for that sound in a long time.

Within the chaos of the video, there was a man, bare naked under his coat.

It was certain. It was the mad man. It was the mad man that they were desperately looking for the past two years. Chunghuh and Surha shook in excitement.

The man they were looking for was in the video.

"It's him, right?"

"Yeah. I knew he'd do something like that."

"Of course."

Both of them quickly jumped out of the building. Because they were too excited, they did not realize who sent the information to the regional office.

-Master of Rupture

The regional office master narrowed his eyes as he looked at who sent the video.

"So, it's the Master who sent this? Hah... I guess things aren't going to end quietly this time."

Chapter 134: Ancient God (3)

The auction was at its peak when Jaehwan arrived at the central auction house.

"Jaehwan, you're late," Myad greeted Jaehwan.

"Oh, you got some clothes? It fits you."

"...Yeah."

Jaehwan nodded and sat down on the chair that Myad saved for him. Runald also came next to Jaehwan and sat down. He had flown down here anxiously, but the atmosphere was different than he expected. There were powerful individuals within the auction house, but none of them were unleashing the uncomfortable presence that Jaehwan felt earlier.

'This is strange. I felt it for sure.'

In front was the giant hologram screen that showed the top price of the auction and Auctioneer Reynold. Jaehwan looked at the giant metal object crouched down in front of the screen.

"Is that the Machina of Daeus?"

The metal object was shaped like a man. It was probably over ten meters just based on the sight. Myad answered, "Yes. It's the best Gigantes of [Depth]."

Gigantes. Jaehwan once read the information about it in the [Record of the Depth].

Those metal giants could be controlled from the inside, created in the days when Ancient God Daeus was in full power. It allowed the rider to increase their world power by 1.2 to 3 times when riding in it. It was the [Part] that everyone from mid-ranking Gods and up wanted to have.

The Machina was the best out of all the Gigantes.

Jaehwan increased his [Suspicion] up to the limit as he examined the Machina. Surely it was a much better object than Reinholdt's Long Coat which he was wearing. But he felt that the Machina was lacking.

'Is that really it?'

Jaehwan once faced one of the three [Parts] before- no, he actually 'used it'. He didn't know it was considered so highly before, but now he could see it.

'It's nothing like the Void Sword.'

That sword that turned every being into a Dead Man. It was, of course, Catastrophe himself who wielded the sword and Jaehwan only was the vessel to hold Catastrophe in, but Jaehwan remembered how it felt to hold the sword.

He remembered the sensation of wielding the blade.

Even when he was the one wielding it, he felt like as if his spirit was being ripped apart by it. It didn't seem to be possible to control it. That was the power of such Divine Parts.

[Jaehwan, we must go back. I don't feel good about this!]

Andersen shouted with a concerned voice. She too seemed to have sensed something.

'Andersen. Who are 'they'?'

[Huh?]

'You mentioned that there are 'they' here.'

[That's...]

But in the next moment, Andersen's voice became disrupted and disappeared. It felt like something was interfering with Andersen and Jaehwan's communication.

-Whoa! We've got the new highest bidder! 11 thousand spirit stones!

Reynold's voice filled the area and Jaehwan spoke to Myad.

"So, I just need to buy that?"

"Yes. Did you make up your mind?"

"What about spirit stones?"

"Here you go."

Jaehwan took the bag of spirit stones from Myad. Runald became pale as he peeked into the bag.

"WHAT! There must be about 20 thousand spirit stones in there at least!"

"Is that a lot?"

"Of course it is! It's too much!"

One spirit stone equaled one Follower. Only one spirit stone could be acquired by processing a spirit. Of course, normal Followers didn't have much value and it was the fighter Followers who would equal to 5 to 10 spirit stones that became valuable, but 20 thousand was still a lot.

It was enough to have a low-ranking God to rise up to the bottom of the high-ranking Gods.

Jaehwan said, "Twenty thousand... it might not be enough."

"Not enough?"

"You never know what might happen."

This time, Myad became astonished at Jaehwan being so calm while holding onto so many spirit stones.

"You really are something. How can you be so calm even with that many spirit stones?"

"..."

"I don't think there's anyone- even in the [Great Lands] or [Depth]- that doesn't get carried away by the number."

"That's enough. So, do you have more? Or what?"

"I think 20 thousand is enough... but I'll give you this just in case."

Myad then began writing something down and handed it over to Jaehwan. It was a piece of paper created by the hologram. It was a personal check from the Myad Federation. The voice was heard again then.

-12 thousand! Anymore? 12 thousand!

Jaehwan looked down at the check for a while and turned to Myad again.

"You just met me for the first time today."

"Yes, I did."

"What is the meaning of all this?"

"Meaning? Oh, you mean the check? Like I said... I like you and..."

"...Never mind. I was a fool to ask."

Jaehwan stood up and shouted toward the auctioneer.

"I will bid on it."

People's eyes turned straight onto Jaehwan. Reynold then turned to Jaehwan and spoke.

-OH? I haven't seen you around! In my experience, this is the sign of a strong bid! So... your name is...

"I'm Jaehwan."

-I see! So- how much will you...

"A hundred thousand."

Chapter 135: Ancient God (4)

People began to mumbling to each other.

"What? What did he say?"

"100 thousand?"

A few Vicegerents turned to look at Jaehwan curiously. Based on their strong world powers, they were from high-ranking Gods. Jaehwan checked their power and turned to Myad.

Even when he spoke of such a large amount, Myad didn't seem to panic at all.

'Isn't this a lot?'

Jaehwan wasn't sure about what the man was thinking. Jaehwan felt like he wanted to make Myad panic.

"Reynold! Who is that man!"

"There's no way that he can pay 100 thousand!"

A few Vicegerents of mid-ranking Gods stood up with rage. The one who was most outraged was the one who offered 12 thousand — the Vicegerent of the middle-ranking God Belkain. It was then that someone stood up silently from the crowd. It was a man with a black hood over his head. After he glanced at Jaehwan and Reynold, he spoke up with a loud voice.

"200 thousand."

The people became uneasy.

"200?!"

Reynold calmly updated the highest bidder.

-200 thousand! We just might have the highest record of bids today!

Jaehwan checked the name tag of the one who called for 200 thousand. But it was hard to see as clothes covered it. Jaehwan then turned toward the hologram.

Highest Bidder – X – 200,000

X. The was the name of the man.

'It's him.'

Jaehwan looked at the hooded man again. It was the man who unleashed the energy earlier that Jaehwan.

"So, he's your target?"

Myad flinched at the sudden voice.

"...I beg your pardon?"

"You used me to bring him out."

"Haha. I'm not sure what you are talking about."

Jaehwan thought there was a certain reason why Myad couldn't join the auction. He didn't want to be seen.

Why?

Jaehwan thought the answer was because of that man named X. He wasn't sure why, but Myad was looking for him and he needed to lay low in order to find that man. Myad had now found him, so he had surely reached his goal.

"Well, if you insist."

"Insist on what? Haha."

Jaehwan then smiled, "Can I continue on with the auction then?"

As Myad felt something from Jaehwan's smile, Jaehwan shouted at Reynold.

"500 thousand!"

500 thousand? The amount increased more than double instantly.

"W-wait. Jaehwan?"

Myad now seemed to be surprised by the sudden increase. It was obvious, as Myad had no reason to continue with the auction house as he had met his goal.

-We have 500 thousand!

Reynold spoke in an excited voice. X responded immediately.

"600."

Jaehwan shouted again.

"700!"

"Wait- Jaehwan. We shouldn't..."

But poor Myad's voice was wiped away by cheer of the crowd and X spoke again.

"750..."

"800."

Jaehwan spoke again and now X was seemingly hesitant. He paused for a while and spoke.

"...850 thousand!"

The record of the highest bid of the Hatchnold Auction House had long been surpassed. Everyone now fell silent as they watched the fight go on.

-850 thousand! I've never even seen such a number in my life!

Some Vicegerents from middle-ranking Gods were now glancing at Jaehwan. To them, 850 thousand spirit stones were worth much more than the Machina itself.

'He looks weak.'

'Vicegerent of a low-ranking God?'

'I'll take him on.'

Jaehwan then spoke again in a quiet and calm voice.

"2 million."

The entire crowd became silent. People couldn't even understand what the number meant. Vicegerents and the powerful ones now looked at Jaehwan silently. Even Reynold couldn't speak at the amazing amount.

-A-are you serious? 2 million spirit stones...

2 million wasn't just a number. It was amount that only top-ranking Gods, or the 7 Gods of [Depth] could even think of paying. It was the amount for a high-ranking God to be allowed to join the 7 Gods of [Depth], to make it 8 Gods.

The amount was enough to increase world power in such a way.

2 million spirit stones represented the power itself.

But now, Jaehwan just declared that he would pay that much to purchase only a [Part]. People in the auction house were shaking just by hearing the number of 2 million as they knew what the number meant. Even Myad was looking at Jaehwan suspiciously. Jaehwan thought as he looked at everyone who was looking at him, 'So, opening a creation doesn't mean that it's out of the [System].'

They were people who lived within the system before they created their worlds to become Gods. It was obvious that they were still a part of the System. Reynold spoke.

-Okay! Do we have anymore? No? Th-then... Jaehwan has won the Machina of Daeus for 2 million spirit stones!

Jaehwan then walked up to the podium. As he was guided by Reynold, he took out the personal check that he got from Myad.

'But how can I use this? Can I just write down the number?'

He had never used a check before so he had no way of knowing. As Jaehwan became hesitant, someone from the crowd shouted, "This is nonsense! That fool can never pay 2 million spirit stones!"

It was Gerald, the Vicegerent of the middle-ranking God Belkain.

And that was the start.

"RIGHT! This can't be true!"

"We cannot accept this auction!"

"KILL HIM!!"

As Vicegerents and Followers of those middle-ranking Gods charged in, Jaehwan smiled bitterly at them.

'So, it comes down to this.'

It was the beginning of the [Hatchnold Disaster] that would be recorded as one of the five incidents revolving around Jaehwan in history.

Chapter 136: Ancient God (5)

Through the fierce battle, a single man smiled between the battle of the Gods. It was a Vicegerent with fiery red hair. He was astonished by the black blades stabbing all over the place.

"Ignis. He's one of a kind. Look at the Setting! It's crazy!"

It looked like if he was talking to himself, but there was no way Vicegerents would talk to themselves. All of their conversations would be heard by their Gods. There was no 'alone' the moment a Vicegerent decided to serve a God.

Needless to say, a voice answered from nowhere.

[Hmm... he's familiar. Wait- isn't it him?]

"...Him?"

[You know, the [Product] I tried to purchase before. Ugh, that damn Cultivator. What was his name? Lain... something?]

"Oh, did you? I don't remember."

The man's name was Karavan. Karavan the Flame. He was one of the most popular Vicegerents within the depth because his God was the one of seven Gods of [Depth].

The God with worst temper, and owner of the best [Setting], was named 'The Hell of Flame'. Every God of [Depth] called the God with this name.

Ignis, the God of Flame.

Ignis, was laughing maniacally within Karavan's head.

[HAH! LOOK! I searched [Little Brother] and this popped up! I think it's him!]

After Karavan checked on the shared image from [Little Brother], he opened his eyes wide in shock and asked, "Wait- isn't he the one who butchered all those Generals in [Chaos] while ago? The Generalslayer?"

[Yeah! Yeah! It's him!]

"Whoa, I serve the best God and I'm still called a 'flame', but he's already a 'slayer'? How unfair."

[Haha. You might get one for yourself if you kill him.]

"I would like to be called like Slayer of the Flame or something."

Karavan scratched his chin as he looked at Jaehwan fighting in the distance. The ground tore apart at one stab and the Followers of middle-ranking Gods were being ripped apart and were swept up by it. However, it wasn't enough to be considered 'strong' yet. What Karavan was focusing on was the [Setting] he was using.

"God. His [Setting] is really weird. What is that?"

The black blade stormed the air as the black aura from Jaehwan's sword destroyed all the Strength type [Settings] of the other Gods. What was weirder was that all those [Settings] that were destroyed were losing power as they were destroyed. Igniss spoke.

[I think it's a [Setting] that destroys [Settings].]

"What? Is that possible? How can such a thing exist?"

[But that's the only way to put it. Look.]

Ignis wasn't wrong. The Vicegerents who were struck by Jaehwan quickly lost their world powers, lost their linkage with their Gods, and fainted.

Unless there was a [Setting] that destroyed a [Setting], there was no other way to describe what was happening, especially when the world power difference between the others and Jaehwan was very small.

"I have never heard of such a [Setting] in [Depth]. And what type is that..."

[It's a Dual type.]

"Dual? What- were there others with Dual type too? I thought we were only ones with it."

[Of course. Remember, the Dark Dragon from Droyan is also a Dual type?]

"Oh, right."

[I think it's based off the Strength type, then mixed in with a Physics type on top of it... but he did he make it?]

"...'The Hell of Flame' is also a Dual type. Why are you so astonished?"

[... That was just coincidence.]

As they talked to each other, their astonishment just grew even further. Now, half the Vicegerents had been wiped out already. Karavan said, "I think he' gets stronger the longer he fights."

[It seems so. His world power is growing as he fights.]

"But how's that possible? Is he a Saiyan or something?"

[...Saiyan? What's that?]

"There's a thing like that," Karavan said as he remembered the comics from World 294 that he borrowed from a close Nightmare friend. Ignis seemed to be uncomfortable for a second, but then continued.

[... Anyway, so his world power grows as he destroys other [Settings]. It can't be possible but... wait. Is he?]

"What? What is it?"

[Is he killing [Gods]?]

Killing Gods in [Depth] was close to impossible, especially if the God was above middle rank. It was because Gods did not disappear as long they had at least one Follower. And even if all Followers were dead, there still was a bit time left.

"No way! Those are middle-ranking Gods... and how is it possible for a God to die after losing a Vicegerent?"

[...It's not just the increase in world power. Look at the [Setting] he's using now.]

Karavan then focused on the [Setting] that Jaehwan was using. There were a lot of things that weren't normal. Jaehwan first started out with a black blade, but he now had other Strength type Settings.

It wasn't anything special as most high-ranking Gods had all the Settings that Jaehwan was now using.

The problem was that those Settings were the ones that the Vicegerents were using that Jaehwan just killed. There was only one answer to this.

He killed a God and stole the [Setting].

"What... it's impossible!" Karavan spoke in outrage. As far as he knew, only two beings could be called 'Godslayers'.

Guardian of the System – Big Brother.

And the Godslayer himself – Catastrophe.

If what Karavan seeing was true, then he needed to add one more to the list. Karavan spoke with a tense voice.

"Should I jump in? If that man really has 2 million spirit stones, that will cause trouble down the road."

Jaehwan's current world power was about one thousand. It meant it equaled about 1000 Spirit Power. He sometimes unleashed about 10 thousand power, but even at 10 thousand, it was no match for Karavan. However, if Jaehwan consumed 2 million spirit stones, it would be different.

He used a [Setting] that could destroy another [Setting].

If he were to wield that powerful world power, then there was no stopping him.

[2 million? Haha.]

But the God laughed it off.

[Are you dumb? Do you really think he has 2 million spirit stones? He's bluffing!]

"...Bluffing?"

[Yeah. If he had 2 million, he could've just consumed it all and ambushed the auction house. Why would you pay for a [Part]?]

It was true. If the being had 2 million in world power, it was easier to just attack the auction house and take it away. There was no need to purchase it.

[He has a man behind him. I think the man ordered the others to cause trouble when he was about to pay it. There's no way that a man with such weak world power can bluff that he has 2 million.]

"Oh- I see. You're right. So, who IS behind him?"

[I don't know. What's sure is that HE will be by the Machina soon.]

It was true. The most important thing in this battle was of course, the Machina of Daeus. That's when Karavan shouted, realizing something.

"OH! Right! The man's going to try to steal Machina then?"

[...Huh?]

"Yeah! That must be it! That's probably why he caused such a ruckus!"

Karavan shouted excitedly as if he felt like he just solved a puzzle. But Ignis didn't seem to be enthusiastic at all.

[Well... it can be true, but unless the man's a fool, he's not after the Machina.]

"What are you talking about?"

[You still don't get it yet?]

"Huh? What do you mean?"

Ignis then answered in disappointment.

[You dumbass, that Machina is FAKE.]

Chapter 137: Ancient God (6)

'It's fake.'

Jaehwan realized it as soon as he saw the Machina. He hadn't been sure when he saw it from a distance, but he was sure when he saw it close up. It was well-made, but it was fake.

"How dare you do this in Hatchnold's Auction House?!"

Reynold and the other auctioneers were now jumping in to quell the fight. It wasn't easy, as all the Vicegerents and Followers were already in a huge brawl. Jaehwan was in the center.

Jaehwan frowned as he deflected storming blades from all sides. He wasn't sure why he had to go through all this for a fake product. No, maybe it wasn't because of that.

'I see. It's for the spirit stones.'

Jaehwan then remembered the check he still held. Maybe Myad had guessed this situation would occur. If so, his goal was still far from being achieved. Jaehwan looked around for Myad, but he wasn't around anymore.

"Give me the spirit stones!"

It was Gerald, the Belkain's Vicegerent, who shouted as he attacked. Belkain had 10 thousand world power which was equal to normal high-ranking Gods. Jaehwan's heightened [Suspicion] read through his [Setting].

[Vicious Claw]

'It's a Strength type.'

Low to middle-ranking Gods mostly used simple Strength type [Settings]. It focused on using brute force.

Destroy the world.

All of it.

Bring it down.

Countless Jaehwans shouted from within Jaehwan. He didn't know why, but this happened often after he opened the 'Creation'.

'Everyone shut up. It's me who's fighting.'

It confused him, but it helped his fights as the voices instantly multiplied Jaehwan's world power.

[Fall]

Powerful energy, not even comparable to when he stabbed with his world power, was unleashed from his sword. His world that destroyed other worlds filled the air. It tore apart [Vicious Claw] like paper, and Gerald was swept away.

"U-UGHH!!"

[AAAARGH! Who are you...!?!]

Middle-ranking God Belkain also seemed to be in shock at what happened. And without having a way to fight it, his world was soon swept away by Jaehwan's [Fall] and disappeared. All of his Followers instantly became Lost Ones.

'I can fight middle-ranking God Vicegerents at least.'

Jaehwan confirmed that his [Setting] was effective in [Depth]. He wasn't sure why, but it worked especially well against Gods.

'But it takes way too much energy.'

He used all his might, but a single strike made him fatigued. Jaehwan knew why.

'I need more Followers.'

He had only one Follower. In the Gods' calculation, his world power was only at 2. In that case, unleashing 1000 to 10 thousand world power was already something that was impossible. Jaehwan only could guess that him being an 'Awakener' was the reason he could do this.

"FIGHT TOGETHER!"

As a few Vicegerents died, the other Vicegerents began to work together to fight Jaehwan.

Jaehwan felt that he was running out of time. Without enough world power, his [Fall] wasn't working correctly. The speed of the opponent's world regenerating was much faster than the speed of his [Fall] destroying their world.

However, it was then that a large amount of world power was transferred from the dead Gerald. It wasn't the entire amount he had when he was alive, but it was enough to recharge Jaehwan completely. Using all of his recharged power, Jaehwan blew away a middle-ranked Vicegerent.

"AAARGH!"

And right after, Jaehwan's world power regenerated again in a similar manner.

Jaehwan realized, 'I can steal world power from the Gods I kill.'

Moreover, Jaehwan felt that his movements had gotten much lighter and easier. The [Settings] that other Vicegerents were using had now transferred over to him. He could now easily dodge attacks that were hard to avoid before. The Vicegerents' faces darkened. They weren't sure what Jaehwan's [Setting] was and yet he was now stealing [Settings] from those that he killed.

"This is mad! What is going on?!"

"This is impossible!"

The tide began to turn and as Jaehwan's total world power increased, his strikes grew more powerful. Now, one strike meant one Vicegerent's death, adding another [Setting] for Jaehwan.

'This can't be!'

Losing to a no-name like this? It was already shameful as it was. But Jaehwan's body turned and began to fly off towards someplace. The Vicegerents turned toward that direction.

"Machina of Daeus!"

"He's after the Machina!"

However, Jaehwan wasn't after the Machina.

'Him.'

In front of the Machina, there was a hooded man, X. He was swinging his metal arm at someone. It was the man who had been sitting next to Jaehwan.

Myad van Deklan, the Starseeker.

He and X were fighting. Jaehwan dodged the attacks at him from the Vicegerents and watched Myad and X fight. The unique world power being used by X reminded Jaehwan of a certain memory.

'That power...'

The energy that Jaehwan felt. It was more 'familiar' than 'uncomfortable' as he studied it. It was like the weird world power that the Overseers of the Void Factory used. It was similar to that.

'What is he...?'

His thoughts were abruptly interrupted as he felt a shockwave from behind.

...What?

It was a strike that his new Setting, [Hardened Carapace] couldn't even withstand. His body was thrown meters away towards the billboard of the auction house.

'Commander... or stronger.'

Jaehwan brushed aside the debris and stood. The damage he received from the strike was quite severe. He was bruised and some ribs were broken.

Was there someone with such world power?

Jaehwan remembered a few Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods, but he wasn't sure which one could do this much damage.

However, he had no time to think. As he stood up, he had to get out of where he was right away.

The area he stood in was destroyed as if a bomb had gone off. As the dust clouds settled, there was an 8-meter-long giant spear stuck in the ground.

It wasn't a weapon that could be used by a human.

After seeing that, Jaehwan knew what was behind the attack.

'I see.'

He saw silver giants through the dust clouds. They were crude and old, but their presence was still outstanding.

-HAHAHA! Bring it on!

-We should've done this earlier!

'Gigantes...'

The [Parts] that filled the battlefield of the [Depth].

An army of Gigantes was approaching Jaehwan.

Chapter 138: Ancient God (7)

"Wow, that's too much," Karavan commented as he saw Jaehwan being cornered by many Gigantes.

"Ignis, should I jump in?"

Even if Jaehwan was strong, there was no way he could fight his way through that many Gigantes. The man only had 10 thousand world power after all.

[...Jump in and do what? Who are you trying to help?]

"...Oh?"

Karavan was surprised. He didn't really care if Jaehwan was going to lose. His focus was to find the man behind the ruckus. It was better for him that Jaehwan, who seemed to have some kind of connection to the man behind this, to be in a pinch.

'Why was I trying to help him?'

If Ignis did not point it out, he would not have even realized it. He had gotten absorbed in watching Jaehwan fight.

[Haha. I guess you've come to like him?]

"Uh... well."

[What do you like about him? Naked man... with a coat... WAIT. Are you...?]

"Hey, I'm not interested in men."

Ignis cackled, but Karavan was confused. He wasn't sure what he was feeling towards Jaehwan. He barely knew the man named Jaehwan, but he had heard some rumors.

Generalslayer.

Pioneer of the Impossible.

Destroyer of the Tower.

They were all unconfirmed rumors. Meaning, Karavan did not know anything about this man named Jaehwan.

But why? What was with this feeling?

"It's hard to explain, but I want to cheer for him."

Karavan glanced at Jaehwan facing his enemies. It was a clean and simple battle form, but the world power being unleashed was abnormal. It was a power that threatened to sweep away the entire world. A madness that could not be weakened by any enemy. Karavan thought, How should he explain it? It was as if...

"He's fighting like a mad man."

[Haha, right.]

"Though he might die soon."

Karavan felt like he and his God were having the same thought after a long time. Ignis spoke.

[No, it's too early for us to jump in. Look- he's not even done yet.]

As Jaehwan stared at the Gigantes, he recalled information from the [Record of the Depth].

War machines of Gigantes.

As far as everyone knew, Gigantes were created by Daeus. He was the God of all machines, with an almighty power in terms of creating [Parts]. The Gigantes represented his masterpiece and legacy.

When he was gone from the [Depth], people were concerned if it was even possible for them to create new Gigantes. Fortunately, 7 of the [Masters] who worked under Daeus began creating new Gigantes, and thanks to them, the Gigantes were now a vital part of the [Depth].

-HAHAHA, he's nothing!

Jaehwan gripped his sword as he watched the Gigantes. There were more than five of them, and they were being ridden by Vicegerents who had almost died to Jaehwan.

'Multiplying power? It's mad.'

All the Gigantes came with a [Setting] to increase world power. Only the Gigantes had such power.

The Gigantes fired upon Jaehwan, and each shot created a crater. Each strike contained a powerful world power. It felt like Jaehwan was now facing a man that had become three times more powerful.

The problem didn't stop there.

'[Fall] is not working.'

Jaehwan realized this as he faced one of the Gigantes. Under normal circumstances, a Vicegerent would have to retreat with serious injuries when faced with his sword, but the Gigantes didn't seem to be damaged.

Jaehwan wasn't sure if he was weak, or it was the power of the Gigantes, but there was no way for him to win here.

"I see. So, your [Setting] doesn't work against [Parts]. I was wondering what penalty it had."

The voice came from behind him. It was Myad who had been fighting behind him.

"Not to mention the fatigue when you use it each time..."

"If you know so much, how about you help me out?" Jaehwan spoke sarcastically, but Myad continued without stopping.

"Also, your [Setting] can only be used by you. I don't think your Followers can share that [Setting] with you."

Jaehwan felt it was strange. How would Myad know that when Jaehwan himself didn't? Myad seemed to have realized that Jaehwan was curious and pointed somewhere as he dodged X's attack. Jaehwan looked in that direction.

It was Runald.

'DAMMIT!'

Runald, who had been swept by an explosion from a Gigantes, had fallen on the ground. But he was too far away for Jaehwan to save him. Also, if he jumped in to save Runald, there was no way for him to dodge the explosions from the Gigantes.

'I need more world power.'

He needed something more powerful that could destroy the Gigantes in one strike. That's when something swept in his mind. Powerful world power. He had in him. He couldn't use the check, but he still had 20 thousand world power.

'...Sh*t, let's just see how it goes.'

Chapter 139: Ancient God (8)

Jaehwan jumped toward Runald as he took out spirit stones from the bag to consume him. He felt the uncomfortable feeling of the stones being swallowed and-

-W-what!

A powerful storm of world power was unleashed from within Jaehwan. He then charged straight into the Gigantes in front of him.

The Gigantes was flung back as Jaehwan collided into it.

-What in the world...

A Gigantes being pushed away by a man? The Vicegerents were dumbfounded. But Jaehwan wasn't satisfied.

'Still not enough.'

20 thousand world power was rushing within him, but it wasn't his own yet. The enemy he was facing had also over 20 thousand world power and was immune to his [Fall]. Then how...

[Jaehwan! Take your clothes off!]

"What?"

[Take it off! Listen to me!]

Andersen's voice urgently filled Jaehwan's head.

[Come on! We don't have time!]

Jaehwan gave up on thinking and threw away his Long Coat. He stared with disappointed eyes at the coat as he threw it. It was a coat that he had just gotten...

'Why do you want me to take off my clothes?'

[So you can use my [Setting].]

'...the [Naked] Setting?'

Andersen then calmly responded,

[The [Naked] Setting was originally made to use against Gigantes.]

It was something he did not expect. Then, a bright light covered Jaehwan's entire body. His body now shone so brightly in gold that it was hard to even look at him directly.

[IT WORKED! YES! I think you can complete up until the 1st verse with this world power!]

He wasn't sure what she was excited about, but Jaehwan knew something was going to happen soon.

[Look. This is the true power of the [Naked] Setting!]

And with her voice, Jaehwan's body flew high up into the sky.

-Wh-what's up with him?!

The Vicegerents riding the Gigantes were shocked. The man threw away his clothes and soon began to shine brightly, but the Vicegerents felt untold fear. They didn't know what he was doing, but there was something definitely wrong there.

-He's an idiot! Kill him!

-He's just mad!

And in the next moment, the words of a song were heard.

A long long time ago,

A Naked God lived.

He hated clothes-

So, he lived naked for his entire life.

No one was sure who was singing or where the song was coming from, but time was slowing down and the space was being distorted. The Vicegerents looked at Jaehwan. Jaehwan, buttnaked, was walking slowly toward them, a light-footed God with an innocent voice.

Just like an old fairytale, as if they had all been pulled into, they looked at Jaehwan.

Yet, they didn't know what kind of finale was waiting for them.

One day, a naked God walked.

He was bored and walked outside.

And he met his first friend.

The page of the fairytale turned, and the riders of Gigantes now realized that they were part of the cast of this fairytale. They tried to clear their mind of this eerie terror.

It's okay. This is an illusion. It's nothing. He's human.

But the man in front of them wasn't human.

God.

A giant, naked God was watching them.

A naked God was talking to them.

Let's play.

As they heard the voice, their minds became blank. Things that were possible and not possible began to get mixed up in their heads. Nothing was done to them, but the Gigantes were backing away.

'W-what is that... what the hell is that...!'

They reassured themselves.

'It's okay. I'm inside this machine. He can't hurt me here...'

The naked God was now smiling in front of him.

Hey you, what is that?

Say, it's not CLOTHES, is it?

The Gigantes flinched. It was as if the giant metal armor was shaking in fear. The Vicegerent inside began to shake as if he was having a seizure and fell. Nobody was there to hear it, but the Vicegerent lost his mind and was mumbling something.

"No, these aren't clothes. These aren't clothes... Ha... Haaha... Go-go away... go away... GO AWAY...!!"

And soon, a voice came from the Naked God.

LIES.

Everyone turned silent. All the fights in the auction house stopped. Myad and X. The Vicegerents who were fighting each other. Hatchnold and the auctioneers who were trying to stop the fight.

The giant body of a Gigantes was ripped apart like a piece of paper.

Karavan, the Vicegerent of Ignis, who had been watching from a distance spoke.

"...God. That's not fair. It's crazy."

[...]

"What the hell is that thing? God... say something, will you? What kind of [Setting] makes you become that strong just being naked and singing like some lunatic?"

[...That [Setting] still remained. I didn't even guess, I don't think 'he' is still alive... is it preserved through another God?]

"Huh? Do you know of such a [Setting]? I've never seen it."

[Of course you've never seen it. It's a [Setting] that was created 210 thousand years ago.]

"...210 thousand years ago?"

210 thousand years ago was the time when the Three Ancient Gods were active. Who created such a [Setting] during that time?

The naked God was still busy with his act. The [Setting] unleashed a ridiculous amount of power only when facing Gigantes.

The third and fourth Gigantes were ripped apart by Jaehwan's bare hands and Ignis spoke in a bitter voice.

[It was created by a mad God who hated Daeus.]

Chapter 140: Ancient God (9)

Karavan was shocked.

"A God who hates Daeus?"

[Yeah.]

210 thousand years ago. It was long before Karavan was born, but he had heard about the legends of the Three Ancient Gods many times. However, it was actually strange for Karavan, who had lived barely 5 thousand years, to know about the stories that happened 210 thousand years ago.

Those legends were not often told within the [Depth] since they were too old; most of the Gods who had lived in that era had perished. If a rumor spread within [Depth] during the age of the Three Ancient Gods that a [Part] of the Three Ancient Gods was on auction, everyone would've scoffed and said-

'No way. There's no way their [Parts] would be up on the auction house. That's for high-ranking Gods. It's probably a hoax.'

It was only speculation and things might've turned out differently, but it was probably different than what was happening right now. People would try to see if the hoax was real, but there was no way that the fools from the middle-rank would dish out their entire savings of 12 thousand soul stones to try and purchase the [Part].

"Who was that God? Who fought Daeus?"

Karavan wasn't like those foolish Gods. He was a Vicegerent, but he knew about the legends of the Three Ancient Gods more than any high-ranking God.

It was all because of Ignis.

The God of the 7 Gods, Ignis the Flame, was one of the few Gods who existed in the age of the Three Ancient Gods. Ignis also loved to boast about his past deeds in that era.

[That's...]

However, this wasn't like him. He seemed to be hesitant, as if there was a bad memory linked to the question. This wasn't like his usual boasting self.

Karavan became more curious. What could make this hot-tempered God of Flame be this hesitant? It was only after a while that Ignis spoke.

[...Only beings that can face the Three Ancient Gods are themselves. There was this saying 210 thousand years ago, but it's all history now though.]

Rip it off. And take it off.

The naked Jaehwan only seemed to exist for those two purposes. A Gigantes's arm was pulled out like a rag doll and its armor was torn apart like paper. The Vicegerents of middle-ranking Gods were powerless against Jaehwan.

Their Gigantes were ripped away, and they became naked.

The instant the Vicegerents were brought out of their Gigantes, they were buttnaked. They did not take any damage or have wounds on them, but many fell unconscious with the frothing at their mouths. No one knew if it was caused by shame or another reason, but one thing was for sure.

They would not be the same as before. Those Vicegerents had hollow looks on their faces. They were naked, but their eyes seemed to indicate that they had lost everything.

"Ah...ahhhhhh!"

"L-let me live!"

Their screams weren't directed at Jaehwan, however. They were afraid of something invisible, as if familiar things to them had suddenly become symbols of fear.

"What are they..."

The Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods were confused. They had heard about the [Naked] Setting, but it was the first time they had truly witnessed its power. However, only a few among them realized exactly what those middle-ranking Vicegerents had faced.

'That can't be...'

The Gigantes were the best protection for any God or Vicegerent. If one was within a Gigantes, it was always guaranteed that one would avoid sudden death, no matter how powerful the attack was. Yet Jaehwan ripped them apart as if they were nothing.

He did it as if there was no such protection in this world. The 'safety' they felt was that weak.

Destroying the Gigantes was more than just the destruction of a [Part]. As the Gigantes were ripped apart, the Vicegerents inside felt something in them being ripped apart. And a few Gods had heard about this symptom before.

'...World collapse?'

World collapse.

It was the disease that made one feel distant from their God's world and they would lose the world power. It was also called the 'Geshtalt Destruction'.

'But that's impossible.'

Even when they saw the Vicegerents falling apart in front of them, they couldn't believe it. The Ancient God that could cause 'Geshtalt Destruction'

had long disappeared. The one they were seeing was a Vicegerent of about 20 thousand world power, at best.

So, instead of believing their own crude guesses, they decided to rely on their experience.

Then, it was followed by humiliation. There was a being defiling their holy crusade. There was the one who destroyed Gigantes as if they were toys and unclothed Vicegerents. This act that the man 'Jaehwan' was doing, wasn't going to end with just the middle-ranking Vicegerents.

"This is madness... what are you trying to do?!"

One of the high-ranking God's Vicegerents shouted angrily. However, it was also what Jaehwan actually wanted to ask. No, he wanted to ask Andersen.

'Tell me before doing something like this.'

For a short three minutes, it was Andersen who controlled Jaehwan's body as he wasn't familiar enough with the [Naked] Setting to use it to its full potential. There was no way that Jaehwan would know such a humiliating song either.

[Don't worry. I had to sing it. The Setting doesn't fully activate unless I finish singing. But I didn't make you sing it, did I? It's me who sang, so don't be too...]

'You sang it through me so it's the same thing!'

[...Haha. I-I think you have a good voice!]

Andersen spoke with an awkward laugh.

'Anyway. Why didn't you kill them?' Jaehwan asked as he turned to glance at the Vicegerents on the ground. 'I thought you hated them?'

As Jaehwan was connected to Andersen, he felt her hatred toward the other Gods. The high-ranking Goddess, who had lost all of her Followers due to her friends' betrayal, and fell to the lowest ranking of the Gods.

The Goddess who hated the other Gods. That was [Naked] Andersen.

[I can't kill them.]

Chapter 141: Ancient God (10)

'What?'

[They are naked. If the enemy is naked, the [Naked] Setting cannot be used against them.]

'...What do you mean?'

Andersen then briefly explained and Jaehwan understood what was going on. The [Naked] Setting only worked against enemies who had clothes on. Although Jaehwan felt intrigued that having a Gigantes equipped was considered the same as having 'clothes' on, the power worked better the more 'clothes' an enemy had on.

While it meant that no armor could withstand the [Naked] Setting after only getting ripped apart because of it, but it also meant that there was no way to kill an enemy when they were naked.

[...By the way, the song ends like this, 'Finally, all friends are naked. The naked God became happy and went back home.']

'...Without killing anyone?'

[Without killing anyone.]

Jaehwan's lips trembled with rage.

'...What is that...'

It was a weird Setting. It was invincible while an enemy had clothes on, but it was powerless when the enemy was naked. It was so twisted that it even

seemed to be some kind of weird fetish. Jaehwan felt a headache at his fate for having to fight with this Setting.

'Wait- I killed that Follower of Belkain with the [Naked] Setting before.'

[...They probably didn't die back then. I think it was Runald who finished them off.]

Jaehwan then turned to Runald in the distance. He first thought Runald was too young to do such a thing, but soon realized that it was possible. Runald already had years of experience in [Depth]. His brilliance and way of doing things were probably the result of that.

'I see. Anyway, thanks for helping me out this time.'

[...Whoa. I never thought you could say such a thing.]

'...'

Andersen seemed happy anyway. The battle was calming down after Jaehwan destroyed a total of five Gigantes. The Vicegerents and auctioneers were now backing off each other. However, it didn't mean that the fight was over, and Andersen and Jaehwan were well aware of that.

[Don't let down your guard. It's only the beginning. You mentioning two million soul stones made them go mad.]

'...Were you listening?'

[Of course, I was! I just couldn't say anything because the communication was unstable. I thought I was going nuts at what you did back there! Speaking of which, what made you do such a thing in the first place?!]

Jaehwan then glanced toward Myad.

'I just wanted to shock him.'

[...Gosh. I am not sure if you are cold or hot-headed.]

Andersen felt something superhuman about Jaehwan when she first saw him — an Awakener who killed Generals. She thought such a being would have the perception and judgment that exceeded that of a God. However, as more time she spent with Jaehwan, she had to rethink her original impression of him.

Jaehwan wasn't perfect.

He had the foresight of a God, but the heart of a human. He had thousands of years experience, but he was still swept away by what happened in the past and sometimes failed to do as planned because of his emotions. Even after living for thousands of years, he was still human.

[Oh well. I guess that's why you have such an impossible goal...]

'Cut the nonsense. What should we do now?'

Jaehwan went up to Runald and picked him up. He was able to see through it instinctively — the peace around the auction house was only temporary. He was in the eye of the storm right now.

'I used too much world power too.'

Unlike [Fall], [Naked] didn't allow Jaehwan to recover his world power. He didn't kill any Vicegerents, so he couldn't absorb their world powers. Fortunately, the Vicegerents of the middle-ranking Gods were backing away due to the shock from the previous fight, but the Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods were different.

They realized that Jaehwan's world power was waning. If given a chance, they would jump on Jaehwan.

Jaehwan made a decision. It was the best choice he could make at the moment. His body quickly moved toward where the largest world powers were moving about.

"Hey, you should help me."

Myad and X were still fighting against each other. Myad smiled and answered, "Hmm. You really do get powerful quickly."

"..."

"A Setting that destroys other Settings... and a Setting that destroys Parts? There will be no other like you throughout the entire [Depth]."

Myad spoke casually even though he was intensely fighting X.

"...Drop the flattery."

"Oh, yeah. But as you can see, I'm in quite of a pinch myself."

"Don't lie. You're not using any power yet."

"Oops- you knew?"

As his world power increased, Jaehwan saw Myad in a new light. He first thought that he could fight Myad on equal grounds, but it changed his mind. Myad had much more power than he realized at first. He was the leader of the 3rd World Federation after all. If Myad were to act, there was no way the Vicegerents and high-ranking Gods would object.

"...But I'm not lying. He's really something."

Jaehwan then turned to X who was fighting against Myad. Myad wasn't wrong. In terms of 'world power rating', X was unleashing about 150 thousand world power from his body. It was much higher than any high-ranking God Vicegerents who were eyeing Jaehwan from nearby.

'And there are some monsters that I can't see through either.'

Jaehwan also knew of a few who were watching over everything. Those were the beings that Jaehwan could barely just feel that they existed.

[Depth] sure was different from [Chaos].

The place where the best of [Chaos] came to and barely returned alive — Jaehwan now realized the power of [Depth].

[You should run. Let's not stay here.]

Andersen came to a conclusion. Jaehwan was also thinking of running away. What was happening in the auction house didn't matter to him anyway.

[Didn't Reinholdt's Long Coat have a [High Speed Flying] Setting? You should run away with that. No Vicegerents will be able to follow you if you use that Setting.]

Jaehwan had already picked up the coat, just in case.

[What are you doing? We don't have time to waste. Go!]

Jaehwan knew this already as he had already felt the Vicegerents closing in on him. However, before he ran, there was one thing he wanted to find out. He turned to Myad and asked, "Myad, it's you who put that Machina on the auction, right?"

Chapter 142: Ancient God (11)

Silence descended for a while. It wasn't too quiet as Myad was still fighting X, but he was momentarily speechless.

"...How did you know?"

For the first time, Myad seemed to be genuinely surprised. Jaehwan moved closer to Myad as he kept an eye on the Vicegerents closing in. Myad asked again, "How did you find out that it's me who sold the Machina to the auction?"

"It's only natural if you think logically."

"...Logically?"

Jaehwan did not answer right away. The Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods weren't closing in any further as Jaehwan stood next to Myad. The man was stronger than any of them. They were probably trying to guess the relationship between Myad and Jaehwan.

Jaehwan calmed his breathing and spoke again.

"If it's a [Part] from the Three Ancient Gods, anyone would be interested. However, you didn't seem to be interested at all."

"Well, that's not enough to come to that conclusion."

"What's more suspicious is that you gave away 2 million spirit stones to give that Machina to a complete stranger."

Myad smiled. "Well, I'm rich."

"No, you had ways to get back the money that you gave away from the beginning. Even if the method required you to do illegal things."

The cold and accurate analysis was making Myad's smile disappear, little by little.

"Even if that's correct, it's not important right..."

Myad tried to speak but quickly stopped. Something came into his mind. He calculated the distance between the Vicegerents and Jaehwan, between Jaehwan and himself, and smiled.

"I see. So, that's why you thought I was the one who sold the Machina to the auction house."

It was as if he knew what Jaehwan was trying to do.

"I mean, if it's me who's selling it, I will get back my money even if I have to pay some fees."

"Right."

The two of them were now back-to-back as they spoke. Just like close friends. The Vicegerents couldn't do anything other than stop attacking. A few of them had realized who Myad was: the Master of the 3rd World Federation. He was someone that should not be easily messed with.

"However, your method had a problem."

"A problem? Which is?"

"The seller cannot join the bidding."

Jaehwan spoke as he recalled the rules of the Hatchnold Auction House.

"So, what you are saying is that I asked you to bid on my auctioned item?"

"Something like that."

"I see. It is a very fascinating assumption."

"Assumption? No. It's a fact."

Myad smiled.

"I can see many flaws, but even if I let go of all that, there's still one critical point that you missed."

"What is that?"

"Even if your assumption is correct, there's one thing that's not coming back to me."

"...The fees?"

"No. The object that I sold."

That was true. If Myad sold the Machina and re-purchased it, it was only through 'Jaehwan' being a bidder.

"No matter what happens, I promised to let you keep the Machina right? That will be a loss for me."

Jaehwan then scoffed, "That Machina is fake. You think I would not know?"

Myad didn't think that Jaehwan would know that much and frowned. Jaehwan continued.

"What is your purpose? I think it's about time you tell me. And who is that X?"

Myad did not answer, and Jaehwan thought he would not answer anyway. There were certain types of people that never revealed their true selves. Myad was like the embodiment of those types.

"I guess you won't tell me."

He was curious, but didn't need to hear it. He had achieved his goal.

[...That was brilliant.]

Andersen was astonished.

[You used him to recover your world power...!]

Jaehwan's world power had recovered to a certain amount. It was enough to use [Fall] maybe two or three more times. It was still lacking, but it was enough to fend off any Followers as he ran.

'Let's go.'

Jaehwan carried Runald on his back and activated [High Speed Flying] using the Long Coat.

No- he tried to activate it, but right as he was about to, Myad's words made him stop.

"If you help me, I will help you find that 'Yoonhwan' person."

The Vicegerents were closing in and Andersen's frantic voice filled his head. But Jaehwan couldn't think of anything else.

What did just Myad say?

"The person you're looking for is probably not here, but I know where he might be," Myad continued before Jaehwan could respond.

"It's not important how I know. What's important is the choice you make."

The situation had changed in seconds. Jaehwan bit his lip as he looked at the Vicegerents in front of him charging toward him.

In the skies over the 8th site.

Between the roads to Hatchnold, there was a giant flying ship. It looked like pink cotton candy, which was the direct result of the creator's taste, but it

was named [Fall], which did not fit the ship at all.

"We have to go faster! Can't you speed up?"

"It's at full speed already," Sirwen responded in annoyance to Yoo Surha. Sirwen then shouted at Karlton who was on the key.

"HEY! Justice boy! Put in more world power! We're losing speed!"

"...I'm doing my best."

"What! Weak sauce! You think being handsome is enough?!"

Chunghuh then interrupted, "...He hasn't even unlocked his unique world yet. What do you expect?"

"Ugh. Everyone else is on creation and theory and crap. What were you doing all this time?"

Karlton had already reached the 4th step, but he still hadn't unlocked his unique world. That was why Sirwen didn't consider him much help here. Sirwen sighed and mumbled, "We finally got to [Depth] and the only men I have with me is an old man and a sissy... I miss Jaehwan."

Chunghuh became angry and tried to respond, but Surha interrupted.

"...Are you close to him?"

Chapter 143: Ancient God (12)

"Of course, I am."

Chunghuh finally exploded.

"WHAT"?! Don't lie! You've only known him for a few days, at best! You were never close with..."

"I am. Jaehwan and I are connected spiritually, you see."

They quarreled for a while and Karlton spoke a bit after.

"But why are you in such a hurry, Surha? As you know, the Master is not someone who will be struck down."

Yoo Surha couldn't answer the question as someone else intercepted it.

"Ooooh, Justice boy. Do you really need to ask that question?"

"...Do you know why, Sirwen?"

"Of course."

Sirwen shrugged and continued, "Jaehwan is naked."

Karlton ignored her and turned back to Surha. She spoke calmly.

"Something doesn't feel right."

"So, we have to go fast because something doesn't feel right?"

"Yes. It's enough of a reason."

It would not make sense at all, but for the fact that Yoo Surha had a special ability that would deem that was perfectly reasonable. Chunghuh asked, "Are you sure? You don't feel good about it?"

"No."

"On a scale of 1 to 10, how bad is it?"

"10."

"...Really?"

"Really."

If Yoo Surha didn't feel good, it was highly likely that something 'bad' was really going to happen, because she had the Law type Setting of [Premonition]. As they drew closer to Hatchnold, she felt her premonition coming true. There were strong world powers in multiple places around Hatchnold. She knew the masters of each world power. After all, they were members from her own organization.

'Rupture is on the move. But why?'

No, it wasn't only Rupture.

'Who would have such world power...'

An unbelievably huge amount of world power, that Yoo Surha herself wasn't sure she could fight off, was moving towards Hatchnold Gate.

It was X who fired first. As Jaehwan and Myad fell back from the fight, X immediately started firing at Myad. His elbow cracked open and missiles fired from the opening. It seemed that X was some kind of construct, and his entire body concealed terrifying weapons. Soon, his chest also opened and a powerful energy wave was unleashed.

Jaehwan wasn't sure what [Setting] it was, but the series of attacks by those weapons with tremendous world power was hard for Myad to fend off.

Also, the Vicegerents and auctioneers had started making their moves. Most of them were targeted at Jaehwan.

It was beginning of the 2nd fight. Jaehwan silently unleashed [Fall].

He didn't have enough world power yet, but if he somehow managed to kill a Vicegerent, he would fully recover his world power. He could then kill them one by one, and get out of the auction house. However, the Vicegerents of high-ranking Gods weren't that easy.

"Keep your distance from him!"

Surprisingly, they didn't charge in towards Jaehwan right away. He grimaced.

'I see, so you all are high-ranking Gods.'

World power-wise, high-ranking Gods did not fall behind Jaehwan at all. Their power was double, or even up to five times greater than Jaehwan's. They could have just charged in at Jaehwan, but it seemed that they were more cautious.

"His [Setting] won't work from a distance! FIRE!"

Along with the shout from a Vicegerent, world powers were fired at Jaehwan. Andersen spoke.

[They know about your Setting now.]

'...'

Jaehwan's [Fall] was meant for close combat. It required for him to get close to a [Setting] to be able to destroy it. There was no way his Setting could work against projectiles.

[You should be more careful. See? They're not even taking out their Gigantes. What are you trying to...]

Andersen was right. It seemed they were aware of the [Naked] Setting, so none of them were bringing out their Gigantes. Jaehwan was left alone, and his [Fall] and [Naked] Settings rendered useless. It was the Vicegerents' plan to reduce Jaehwan's world power while not letting him use any of his [Settings].

[What are you going to do now? Are you really going to do what he told you?]

'I guess so. There's no other way.'

Jaehwan had backed away while he avoided the continuous attacks from the high-ranking Gods. After a while, he had nowhere left to go and now Myad was right behind him. Both men had their backs against each other.

As the two world powers met each other, strong sparks flared from them. Two men against [Big Brother]. Both world powers with a goal that no other world powers had besides each other, had met for the first time. Myad spoke.

"Let's switch."

"Yeah."

With that, both traded places. The Vicegerents were shocked by the sudden change.

"W-what?!"

They just traded places, but the tide of the battle turned. The Vicegerents that Jaehwan was facing now had to face Myad. And X now faced Jaehwan.

"Good luck."

Myad charged at the Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods, and Jaehwan turned to his new opponent.

'X.'

X was still focusing on the Daeus' Machina. Jaehwan recalled what he discussed with Myad earlier.

-Please fight off X. That is my condition for this deal.

Jaehwan thought he had misheard when Myad said it the first time. It was a being that Myad himself couldn't fight off. How could he fight it off?

-You certainly can do it. To be honest, you're the only one who can right now.

Myad then glanced down at Jaehwan's naked body and grinned as he added,

-That 'X' is a Gigantes.

Chapter 144: Ancient God (13)

'...It's a Gigantes?'

However, before Jaehwan could think about his question, guided missiles fired from X's elbow streaked towards him. Jaehwan barely dodged a few of its missiles, which exploded behind him, as he used the shockwave to push him forward so he could close in on X.

'I have to fight him up close.'

All of his [Settings] were weak against ranged attacks as his fighting style was designed for close combat. Fortunately for him, unlike the Vicegerents of the high-ranking Gods, X quickly changed its stance to fight in close range. The crack in the elbow closed, and instead, a blade popped out. Soon, the blade clashed against Jaehwan's sword.

It was just a clash between blades, but something similar to an explosion occurred and Jaehwan almost lost his grip on his sword. It was just one exchange, but it dealt him damage.

'It's strong...!'

Jaehwan retreated, but X continuously attacked as it moved towards him and closed the distance. It continuously attacked as if it already knew how Jaehwan would move.

[Be careful! The movement isn't like any other!]

It had been a while since Jaehwan fought this close to an enemy. He had been pushed back ever since the first attack. The blade from X's elbow was sharper than any blade he had seen before. Jaehwan's ability to dodge

blades was one of a kind, but the X that kept up with Jaehwan's movement was much more than that. Its reflexes were beyond that of a human.

'So, it's not human after all.'

The strikes were executed in the most efficient ways. The battle kept worsening for Jaehwan the more time passed. His fighting habits had already been analyzed by X, and it was using more suitable attack patterns against Jaehwan as it had analyzed all of Jaehwan's movements.

Jaehwan had seen a similar kind of fighting before.

'Overseers of the Void Factory.'

Jaehwan then understood what Myad had said. 'Gigantes itself.' This X was probably connected to the Daeus, one of the Three Ancient Gods in some way. Like the overseers, it was one of Daeus's old Followers.

"AAARGH!"

"KAAARG!"

There were screams in the direction where Myad had charged towards. As Jaehwan dodged X's attack, he glanced towards where Myad was moving about between the Vicegerents.

The Vicegerents had been blown back on all sides. The attacks that didn't work well against X were now extremely effective against the Vicegerents. Jaehwan even wondered for a second if they were the same enemies that he had a hard time fending off.

The auction house was chaotic as time went on with powerful Vicegerents increasing in numbers. However, none of them were able to fight off Myad. Myad van Deklan, the Starseeker, was one of the strongest Vicegerents of all the high-ranking Gods.

'Why did he have such a hard time against X?'

Jaehwan became confused. Myad and X. Even with all things considered, they were far from equal. Jaehwan thought as he looked at X in front of him.

'This X doesn't have more than 150 thousand world power.'

150 thousand world power was enough to defeat any high-ranking God. It was surely a very high rating, but if Jaehwan guessed right, Myad's real power exceeded that.

'At least 2 million.'

It was only a guess, but if Jaehwan was correct, that was only the bare minimum. Jaehwan had learned one truth during the acution.

The limit of spirit stones one could pay usually equaled the limit of a Vicegerent's own world power. And Myad had the power to pay 2 million spirit stones. That meant that Myad had a world power at least 2 million. Jaehwan couldn't even guess what kind of strength 2 million world power held.

However, Myad couldn't defeat X. That was very strange.

[Fight pattern analyzed. Activating system 'Daeus'.]

Just then, a kind of strange machine-like voice came from X. Its entire body was surrounded by a bluish aura and enormous world power radiated from it.

[Ex Machina – Phase 1.]

Jaehwan suddenly felt the most danger he'd ever felt since he came to [Depth]. An attack that he couldn't even see was launched against him.

A long, long time ago.

The Naked Pervert God lived.

It was then that Jaehwan took off the coat almost instinctively.

He hated wearing clothes.

So he lived naked for his entire life.

Jaehwan's naked body collided against X's cold body. The blue world power of X was destroyed and Jaehwan barely managed to push back X's fist. With mechanical alert sounds, X jumped back quickly and Jaehwan sighed in relief.

'I almost died there... if the activation was slow...'

He felt his back drenched in sweat. Jaehwan had managed to quickly activate the [Naked] Setting at the last moment. If this [Setting] was working, X was definitely a Gigantes for sure. It was much smaller than a normal Gigantes, but it was definitely one.

[Whoa, you've learned well.]

Andersen exclaimed with pride. She seemed really happy that Jaehwan had managed to activate the [Naked] Setting without her help.

[But you've got the lyrics wrong. You should do it right.]

'...What did I get wrong?'

[There's no 'Pervert' in the lyrics. It's just 'Naked God.' Wait- did you do that on purpose?]

'It still worked, didn't it?'

Andersen began to protest, but Jaehwan ignored her. There wasn't time to joke around. X and its terrifying world power was in front of him.

'Its world power has increased almost ten times.'

X's attack just now was around 1.5 million world power. If it wasn't for the [Naked] Setting that was made to specifically counter Gigantes, Jaehwan would have been ripped apart.

'...What is going on?'

Its average world power didn't come close to Myad's, but when it activated that Phase 1 or something, its world power increased tenfold. A Gigantes that could unleash a world power of 1.5 million. It was disastrous enough to decimate middle-sized sites.

'Andersen, do you know something about it?'

[...Hmm. I think...]

'What is it?'

[I can't say it for sure. I've never seen it before, but if I'm right... it's bad.]

'What? Tell me.'

[Let's just say that I think it's a Gigantes with a mind.]

'A Gigantes with a mind?'

It was the same thing all over again. It, itself, was a Gigantes, a Gigantes with a mind... it all seemed similar. Jaehwan decided to just simplify it. That was a Gigantes, but it talked and had thoughts. That's when something occurred to Jaehwan.

'That body itself is a Gigantes, right?'

[Yeah.]

'So, doesn't it mean that it's not 'wearing' a Gigantes?'

The [Naked] Setting only worked against enemies wearing 'clothes.' In that [Setting], a Gigantes was considered the most powerful type of 'clothes' there was. But if what Andersen said was true, X was the 'clothes' itself, and it wasn't wearing anything. Then, Jaehwan's [Naked] would have a conflict with that. Could that be considered 'clothing'?

[HEY! The [Setting] is being shaken! Cut out your unneeded thoughts!]

'...'

[That thing is still clothing! It's a living piece of clothing, but yeah!]

She was right. There was no time to think about such matters.

[I'll give you the details later, just focus for now!]

As its first attack failed, the blue aura from X became denser. It then projected a coarse mechanical voice.

[...You... that Setting...?]

It seemed it had a calculation malfunction or error, as its words weren't coming out in order.

[...Geshtalt...?]

Chapter 145: Ancient God (14)

'Geshtalt?'

[Geshtalt! Geshtalt! Geshtalt!]

'What the?'

[Geshtalt! Geshtalt! Geshtalt!]

With a sound, white steam started coming out from X's head. It didn't look good.

[WATCH OUT!!!]

However, before Andersen's warning even ended, Jaehwan was swept away by an explosion of world power. 1.5 million world power was unleashed on Jaehwan. Even with his [Naked] Setting, it wasn't easy to stand against X's powerful attack.

'Ugh...!'

Jaehwan's world power usage sped up. At that rate, his [Naked] Setting would stop functioning at any second. Jaehwan made a decision.

The naked God walked over the hill.

And finally met his third friend.

As if its calculations had been turned off, X's attacks seemed to no longer follow any patterns. It was unleashing its world power, but it allowed Jaehwan an opening in between its attacks.

'Now!'

Thoughtless attacks were a waste of world power. With the power of [Naked], Jaehwan charged in and struck X's body. The durable metal skin began to crack.

With another strike, the entire armor began cracking. However, it was surely more durable than any other Gigantes. Jaehwan unleashed all of his world power. It was his last attack.

With the last bit of power he had, Jaehwan struck X's core and a powerful wave exploded from X's body.

[Ex Machina – Phase 2.]

It was a counter by X meant for this final moment.

A wave of world power that felt like it would pull all one's skin off — the power was something different than the world power that X used. It didn't hurt the body itself, but there was a kind of noise. Jaehwan had heard that before.

'Andersen?'

Andersen's voice had been cut off. It was a more definite disconnection than he had felt before. It felt as if Andersen had been erased from within him for good.

The light from X blinked out. It seemed that the core had lost its power from the strike and along with the machine powering down, X's body fell to the ground. Jaehwan also felt his world power waning and slumped. X then looked at Jaehwan's arm and mumbled.

[...Seal of our kind... but [Setting] of Geshtalt... who are you...]

And with those words, X stopped moving. However, Jaehwan felt something wasn't going right. Something felt eerie and strange.

Everywhere was silent. Why? Jaehwan stood up and looked around. All the Vicegerents were slumped on the ground, confused. They all seemed to have lost their world powers as well.

"God! God!"

"God! Where are you?!"

Jaehwan realized that the Vicegerents had lost their link to their Gods. Just like how Jaehwan lost contact with Andersen, they too had lost their connection. It was a power similar to Jaehwan's [Fall], but it had more range. Jaehwan decided it had something to do with X's Phase 2.

"Daeus' [Destruction of Linkage]... temporarily disconnects the links to the Gods. It's an amazing power. It's more than the legend itself."

Myad's voice drifted over to Jaehwan.

The Vicegerents, without their Gods' power and [Setting], were rendered helpless. Myad swung his sword and cut down countless Vicegerents' heads. Myad had not lost any of his power.

"You..."

Jaehwan's instinct told him that the man was dangerous. He was more dangerous than any enemy he had ever fought until now. He then felt regret for the first time in his life. Why didn't he listen to Andersen?

"Oh, I guess you still have the power to stand?"

He had lost his link to Andersen, but he had no link to be disconnected from himself since he was also a God. That was why he still had his [Setting]. The only problem was that he didn't have any world power.

"It's better that you sit down if you want to see something interesting."

He just pushed Jaehwan lightly on his shoulder, but Jaehwan was thrown back, rolling multiple times on the ground. World power in the millions

shook him. When he barely got back up, with his hands on the ground, he witnessed Myad pull something out from X's body.

"Hah. I finally got my hands on this. To think how far I had to go to get this... It's all thanks to you."

Jaehwan's focus then turned to the fist-sized core in Myad's hand. It was a blue core that had 'X' written on it. It was the 'heart' of X. Myad then began to walk off.

Jaehwan didn't know why, but he knew he needed to stop Myad. However, he couldn't even stand properly.

'Dammit...'

There were no more powerful individuals around. All of them just had lost their link to their Gods from X's attack.

"You don't know how excited I was when I found out that you had the [Naked] Setting."

Myad whistled while he passed by Jaehwan and stood in front of his destination. It was the 'fake' Machina.

Jaehwan became confused. Why?

Myad then turned to Jaehwan and smiled.

"Oh, there was one thing that you got wrong with your guesses just now. Uh... what was it? This is 'fake'?"

Myad then jumped up onto the 'fake' Machina's left shoulder. On the shoulder, the word 'Daeus' was inscribed. With the sound of decompression, the cockpit of the machine opened and Myad pushed the core of X into it.

"This isn't fake. Uh, at least starting from now."

When the cockpit closed, world power began to flow from the fake Machina's giant body. The world power that came from X, but much more

than before. Jaehwan then saw the writing on the shoulder and the cockpit started shining in bright blue light.

Machina of Daeus.

The machine then stood up, destroying everything around it. Everything began to explode. The Vicegerents were running away, and the auctioneers tried to defend the place to the end.

Everyone was destroyed like insects.

Jaehwan's body shook. That power. That presence. He had faced such a thing before.

The Master of [Chaos], who squished Generals like insects.

Sole-King Catastrophe.

The power coming from this Gigantes was the same as that of Catastrophe. Just then, he heard a voice from behind. Jaehwan turned.

[Jaehwan! Jaehwan! Can you hear me?]

X's body, which had laid powerless without its core, was moving about. Jaehwan flinched and stepped back. He gripped his sword tightly, as he quickly grabbed and picked up Runald's body.

[It's me! ME!]

It was a familiar voice. It was just unusual to hear it coming from X.

"Are you Anders..."

But he couldn't continue as the Machina's world power exploded, swallowing everything in its path.

[Watch out!]

In the collapsing auction house, X's body covered Jaehwan and Runald as everything turned dark.

That day, Hatchnold Auction House in Caspion disappeared from [Depth].

Three days later, rumors spread that the Machina of Daeus from the legend had appeared in [Depth], with the new Ancient Three Gods in place.

Chapter 146: The Great Forest (1)

210 thousand years ago, when the Three Ancient Gods perished, spirits became Lost Ones and had to find a way to survive on their own.

Some searched for a new God to follow, while others chose to die in order to follow their former Gods. Some were even given a second chance to assist [Big Brother].

However, most of them stayed without doing anything. They had no will to follow [Big Brother], nor did they want to seek out a new God, but they also didn't choose to die.

They moved into the Great Forest and became monsters without minds.

This was the story in the legends.

But from my own experience, this legend was different from the truth.

Within the Great Forest, there were Followers who still stood by the world even after losing their God. They were Followers who watched their world fall with their own eyes but still hung onto it. When I saw them, I felt something wasn't right.

Why?

Those who had lost their Gods-

Seem so happy?

Mulack Armelt – Record of the Depths

Episode – The Great Forest

Jaehwan was panting in the middle of a hill. He felt bitter. It had been a while since he had trouble breathing like this, it meant that his spirit had been severely damaged.

He took in a long, deep breath and continued climbing again. It became steeper from time to time, and sometimes even hard to climb without any tools, but Jaehwan did not stop.

"...Jaehwan, are we there yet?" Runald asked from behind. He, too, was panting heavily. Jaehwan did not answer and kept moving. He then felt the ground shaking, it meant the 'entrance' was near.

Jaehwan then positioned himself by a close hiding spot. It was a signal to rendezvous. Runald then asked again as he reached Jaehwan.

"Are you really going into the Great Forest?"

"Yeah."

"But why... That place is the most dangerous..."

"That was her last wish."

Jaehwan quickly responded as he did not want to prolong the conversation. However, he soon realized that he had made a mistake. Runald shook at the words 'last wish'. It seemed he was thinking about the authenticity of what Jaehwan said. Jaehwan regretted blurting that out.

"That... was real."

Jaehwan never thought that the word 'real' would have such cruelty when spoken out loud.

"She's... she's really..."

Jaehwan did not know how to calm a crying child. He did not know how to weep together either.

"Don't cry."

He used [Suspicion] on everyone and [Understood] everything. But he couldn't sympathize with this child's feeling. He couldn't even guess the gravity of the loss the boy faced.

To Jaehwan, Runald was even more difficult than Catastrophe.

All he could do was watch him shed tears.

"So... in you... she's..."

Jaehwan looked up to the sky. It was a clear blue sky, not knowing one bit of the disaster that had befallen them. Jaehwan regretted saying what he had heard.

Just like then, and now.

Regret always came after.

[Hey! Get it together!]

It was minutes after the first attack from Machina, that Jaehwan came back to his senses. He felt pain all over his body and found that he was covered by dirt, holding a small boy. It was Runald.

'What is going on...'

Heavy stones were pushing down on him. He tried to move, but he couldn't. The damage his spirit had sustained was too severe for him to use his world power. And then-

[HEY! Wake up!]

With that voice, light shone through the rocks. Jaehwan felt a force pulling him and Runald out of the dirt. With the feeling of the cold ground beneath him, he was pulled out back into the world.

[We have to run now! Get up!]

The voice was coming from the small Gigantes body. Jaehwan asked, "... Andersen?"

As he heard Andersen's voice coming from X's body, Jaehwan quickly remembered what had happened.

'...Yeah... I was attacked by him.'

X unleashed the 'Destruction of Linkage' and the Vicegerents all collapsing as their links to the Gods were forcefully disconnected. Then, Myad subdued all the Vicegerents and Jaehwan, before pulling out the core from X. He then walked up to the Machina of Daeus powered it with the core. After that came the giant explosion.

Jaehwan felt his head spin from everything that happened. Then, the anger kicked in.

'Myad, that bastard...'

It was because he was swept by Yoonhwan. Everything had been very suspicious from the beginning, but he trusted Myad. No- he did not trust him. It wasn't due to Jaehwan trusting Myad that led to this event. He lacked information and everything was against him. And the result was the worst possible outcome.

"But why are you in there?" Jaehwan asked and Andersen shrugged. Jaehwan could actually 'see' Andersen shrugging as she was inside X's body.

[...I think this happened when the [Link Destroy] was activated.]

"Wasn't it supposed to cut the link between Gods and Vicegerents?" Jaehwan asked as he thought about what he heard before he fainted. Frankly, Jaehwan and Andersen relationship wasn't of a God and Vicegerent. Andersen was absorbed into Jaehwan's world with her mind intact, and was a bit of a [Part] after all.

[Yeah, that's what I thought it was also. ...But I don't know what happened there.]

There was no way to know what exactly the power did, other than the dead Daeus at this point. Whatever the case, the power had divided Jaehwan and Andersen, and she was removed from Jaehwan.

[This guy was lying around at that point so...]

And then Andersen went into the empty X's body. Jaehwan decided to leave it at that for the moment.

The explosions were still happening around, but increasing in scale.

[The 3rd World Federation is fighting against the forces of high-ranking Gods.]

It seemed easy to understand what had happened then.

'The followers of those high-ranking Gods had also come in large numbers.'

There was no way that the high-ranking Gods would stay put when their Vicegerents were killed. They sent their Followers to the place and now the war had begun. But Myad wasn't alone either.

Chapter 147: The Great Forest (2)

The 3rd World Federation.

Jaehwan didn't really give much thought to the name, but now he was getting an idea of what it was supposed to be.

"Andersen, what is the 3rd World?"

[It refers to Gods who are not registered with [Big Brother].]

Why couldn't he think of this when he first saw Myad? No, Jaehwan expected it but he didn't have proof to confirm it. Jaehwan knew these people. He even fought one of them when he was on the way into the [Depths] to begin with.

The 3rd world was [Rupture].

Gods with their own world, but they were not registered with [Big Brother]. And with such gloomy worlds...

"HAHAHA! Kill them all!"

"I'll get more world power thanks to the Master!"

They didn't have as many Followers as the high-ranking Gods, but each of them had power close to that of Commanders. The organization that had the woman named Yoo Surha as their 2nd Captain, or the Myad Federation, was called [Rupture].

'Then is Myad the Master of [Rupture]?'

Jaehwan began to understand the strength of Myad. 2 million world power was beyond the power of the Commanders that Jaehwan had a hard time dealing with. The only beings with such power were the Lords of the [Great Lands].

'No, he's probably stronger than them now.'

As the Machina moved, tens of Gigantes was destroyed with just one swing. It was a terrifying power.

"Hey, you."

When did he approach? Jaehwan realized someone was right behind him. He quickly gripped his sword to stand up, but the man backed away as he waved his hands.

"Oh! Calm down. I'm not your enemy. I'm on your side!"

It was a man with fiery red hair. He had strong features, with scars all over his body. But he didn't seem to be hostile. The man glanced at the Machina and spoke.

"Can't you do something about him? Like by using the [Setting] that you used to destroy those Gigantes, while you were dangling your thing..."

It was Andersen who interrupted the man's question.

[You. Aren't you Karavan of Flame, Vicegerent of Ignis...?]

"Oh? I never realized someone would recognize me. Hmm? But what's going on? Weren't you guys fighting each other a while ago?"

Karavan seemed confused as he did not know Andersen was now inside X. Jaehwan said, "It's complicated. But what do you want? It doesn't seem like you've come to fight me."

"Oh... that."

Karavan was hesitant as Andersen asked,

[Did your link to your God also disconnect?]

"...H-how did you know?"

[I see... so the power of the Ancient Gods is that powerful. Didn't think that cutting the link to a top-grade God was possible.]

"Do you know something? Do you know what happened to me?"

[You won't recover for a while. You will have to live a few months like this, at least.]

"...Is that for real?"

Karavan was shocked. He was the Vicegerent of one of the highest-ranking Gods, but even he didn't know much about the [Settings] of the legendary Three Ancient Gods. Yet this Gigantes was now talking about Machina all of a sudden, so it was natural for Karavan to grow wary.

"Who are you and how can I believe... wait- are you-"

Andersen quickly waved her hand, stopping Karavan from saying something unnecessary.

[You want to know how to recover the connection?]

"...uh, yeah."

[There is a way. We can't do it here though...]

She glanced at the fighting scene. Karavan realized what she meant. They had to go through the battlefield to get to where they needed to go.

[Let's look for a chance to...]

Move. But she couldn't finish as Jaehwan began unleashing world energy. Jaehwan was walking towards the battlefield. Andersen looked at him dumbfoundedly for a few seconds and ran out to grab his shoulder.

[Hey- don't you dare.]

"That Machina-thing is a Gigantes after all, right?"

Andersen bit her lip. No, she thought she bit her lip, but the Gigantes she was now inhabiting did not have lips.

She had expected Jaehwan to do such a thing, but she was frustrated at him for doing such a thing at this time.

[In this situation, you still...]

Her voice stopped and Jaehwan's memories flashed within her. It was a certain feeling that only she, who knew Jaehwan the best, could feel.

It was very like him. This choice was definitely something that Jaehwan would make.

But...

[...I knew this all along, but you're reckless.]

Jaehwan did not answer and instead turned to look at somewhere far away. Andersen then saw a small boy within Jaehwan — an innocent boy who still had not given up on his dream. He did not know what was possible or not, so he kept on trying to achieve his goal.

Andersen was then struck with a thought. Ever since she had abandoned 'presence' to become a Goddess, it was the first time she felt such a thing. Then she accepted her realization.

This innocent man. Yes. Maybe it was good to have this kind of man around. Maybe everything would eventually...

A golden light began to shine from Jaehwan.

"I will fight. I need to get at least one smack on his face."

[...Yeah. Right. That is you.]

Why?

For the first time, Andersen answered something entirely different from her will.

"I'm counting on you."

With those words, Jaehwan charged toward Machina.

Coming back to this decision, he made the right choice. Because of this, Jaehwan and others eventually were allowed to get out of the Hatchnold disaster. However, Jaehwan did not know what he would lose as a result of his choice.

Sometimes, innocence required the help of others to be protected.

When someone needed innocence, there had to be someone who could withstand the bottom of innocence. It would be a very long time later that Jaehwan would realize this.

Chapter 148: The Great Forest (3)

The fight ended in seconds. Jaehwan didn't even know what struck him. Even when that world power exploded in front of him, Jaehwan was trying his hardest to comprehend what had happened.

'How?'

He couldn't understand. Even though he wasn't assisted by Andersen, he still had the [Naked] Setting activated, and Myad was on the Machina. The [Setting] was supposed to work against Gigantes.

-Jaehwan, you really are the same person from what I've heard. I wasn't so sure when I first heard it from Surha.

It seemed like he had said this.

No.

Maybe he said this too.

-[Naked]. That is a really good Setting. It's good especially since using Gigantes is like a requirement these days... but have you ever given it some thought? If that [Setting] was so good, why did it die out? Why did the gods who succeeded in creating that [Setting] eventually fall?

He felt a chill down his spine. Maybe he needed to get away right then. He should have accepted that something was wrong, that it was not his chance. However, Jaehwan did not have such an intention. Running away, backing off... that was something that Jaehwan did not do.

That's why he couldn't run this time.

He felt his heightened senses getting distorted and his strengthened muscles through the [Naked] setting disappearing in an instant. Then came a punch from Myad's Gigantes. And he was blown away while Myad spoke to him for the last time.

-That [Setting], it's really easy to break if you think it through.

Jaehwan wasn't sure which came first. He was only certain of the world power that grasped him at that critical moment. It wasn't there to protect him as it still covered his entire body, which had taken severe damage.

'This...'

Jaehwan moaned as he focused on the world power that covered him. Then came the realization.

'Clothes?'

Yes. That was the reason why his [Naked] setting had disappeared. He was covered in a green rag. His memory particles from Record of the Depths moved and a Setting name came to Jaehwan's mind.

[Augmented Reality]

With that, Jaehwan realized what just happened. It was an unbelievable idea.

'This is impossible...'

What Myad did was that he simply used the basic Setting to 'clothe' Jaehwan. The [Setting] required one to be naked, that was its weakness.

Jaehwan's body struck the ground and rolled a several meters away. Debris and particles on the ground penetrated his body and Jaehwan spat out silver powder.

"Jaehwan, if a [Setting] disappeared from [Depth], then there's a reason for it."

Myad's voice got closer as he walked towards Jaehwan.

"I didn't go that hard on you back there. Don't say you died."

Jaehwan spat out the dust in his mouth, he couldn't even guess the damage he had taken. He had no trace of world power left in him.

[Jaehwan!]

"Hey, are you okay?"

Andersen and Karavan quickly ran up to Jaehwan and supported him up. Jaehwan felt hard metal and human flesh hoisting him up. Jaehwan then freed himself from both of them and stood upright.

He knew the enemy was strong, but he still underestimated him. He thought of Catastrophe, but he didn't think the enemy would really be as powerful as him. Now he thought he needed to change his mindset.

'Is he really strong as him?'

Jaehwan couldn't even guess what would allow him to defeat Myad.

"Hey, Master, hold on."

It was then that a big-bodied man standing next to Myad spoke. The man, with a giant axe strapped to his back, glanced between Myad and Jaehwan and asked, "Is he the one Surha spoke of before?"

"What? That's the one Surha was talking about?"

It was a smaller, sly looking man who responded. He had long katana at his waist. He drew his sword and pointed it toward Jaehwan as he demanded, "Hey, is that true? Did you sweet talk our cute Surha?"

"Imai, what are you talking about?"

"What?! Didn't you just say he's the one Surha was talking about?"

"...Yeah, but I don't get what you're saying. What I meant was that Surha wanted to bring him into Rupture."

"That's the same thing, you mindless oaf!"

There was a very famous incident that most of the important members of Rupture knew about these days. Yoo Surha, one of the 5 Captains of Rupture, had been traveling for the last 2 years to all parts of the [Depth] in search of a man. The rumors had a lot of variations, but it was mostly about Surha looking for a man to join Rupture. The big man spoke again.

"...But how does it mean that he did 'that'?"

"Or else, why would Surha want that piece of crap in Rupture?!"

Imai Kazuki, the 3rd Captain, shouted furiously as he pointed at Jaehwan. The 4th Captain, Kashim, dumbfoundedly turned to the man.

The man was scratching his naked body. It was impossible to see it from the outside, but he was doing that to try to 'take off' the clothes. [Augmented Reality] was only an illusion on the target, so the others couldn't see the green rags on Jaehwan. Kashim scanned Jaehwan from top to bottom and stopped at one point on his body.

"So, he made out with Surha? Hmm..."

"He... He... Him...!"

Imai was shaking furiously. No one could tell what he was thinking, but his eyes were red.

'Oh sh*t, I forgot that Imai had a crush on Surha.'

Kashim shook his head. At this rate, Imai was going to smack that man down and beat him up. If Surha found out, she would go crazy and blame Kashim for not stopping him. It was highly likely that Kashim would be the one to get all the blame in the end. He then asked, "Master, how about you pass him to me?"

"NO! ME! I'll take care of him!"

Imai also jumped in. Kashim tried to speak again, but Myad spoke instead.

"No, sorry, but I'm taking care of him."

Chapter 149: The Great Forest (4)

It was a polite but solemn voice. With that, Kashim who had been quiet for the most part, Imai who had been noisy, and all the other Captains immediately stopped talking. They were all strong people. Each of them had the world power of a Commander of the [Great Lands], and each alone had the power to put the entire [Great Lands] into turmoil. That was the power of the Captains of Rupture.

Yet, they became silent at just a single statement. They had to. The world power seeping out from the Machina of Daeus pressured the entire Hatchnold region.

This was the Master of Rupture.

Myad van Deklan.

It was a power fitting for [Link Destroy]. Even without using any of the Machina's settings, Myad was unmatched in his power alone. Even Jaehwan felt faint despair seeping into his consciousness. He didn't back down against Catastrophe, but he couldn't keep his calm this time.

It had been different with Catastrophe. He had the belief that he could pull it off and had the confidence that he could make it through. However, this time, there seemed to be no other way.

Even so, he needed to fight.

Jaehwan gave up on removing the green rags. His spirit was in bad shape and there was no way to resist.

Actually, there was one way. The only possible way that he might be able to find Myad equally...

However, he couldn't use it right now. It had a clear limit to how many times he could use it, and there was no telling how many powerful enemies he might meet in the future like Myad. And above all, Jaehwan knew that he couldn't withstand the procedure in his current state.

But Jaehwan had to make a decision. His consciousness was fading. If he didn't make a choice now, then he was going to lose the chance to even make a choice. But he never thought he would ask for help right after he came to [Depth].

[Catastrophe.]

Jaehwan called the name. He called and called.

[Catastrophe?]

There was no answer. Sole King Catastrophe didn't respond. It didn't seem that he was ignoring Jaehwan, and there seemed to be another problem. It was as if the link between Jaehwan and Catastrophe had been damaged. Jaehwan then realized.

'Wait... when that [Link Destroy] was used...'

He remembered that Machina's [Link Destroy] had destroyed the links of all the Vicegerents, and Jaehwan's link to Andersen, and even the link to Catastrophe.

'Dammit.'

Jaehwan became desperate — there was no other way now. What choice did he have? Then, someone walked past Jaehwan.

[Let him go.]

The voice wasn't solemn or pressuring like Myad's. It had a lot of noise mixed in because of the broken parts, and the world power within it seemed petty at best. Even then, the voice seemed determined and ready.

[You will fight with me.]

It was Andersen, the Naked God.

"What are you..."

Jaehwan could barely move and tried to walk to her, but Karavan held onto him. Jaehwan turned and it seemed that Karavan seemed to have already discussed it with Andersen. Karavan shook his head.

"Don't go. That's her decision."

"Decision? What are you..."

And then her voice came.

[Jaehwan, I know you can't understand my decision. But you know what? I don't understand you either.]

It was Andersen, with her same usual voice.

[We will never understand each other. That's what you first learn when you become a God. Isn't it ironic? You are an all-knowing God who understands and acquires all kinds of knowledge, but you can't even understand just one spirit...]

God? Spirit? Understanding? He wasn't sure what she was trying to say.

[But even if we can't understand each other, we can still feel something from each other. Even if it's just one-sided or not. I mean what I'm saying from that.]

Jaehwan then felt his heart sink. Why? He couldn't understand, but he too had felt. All of his questions in his mind were losing power at Andersen's voice. It was because there was a 'real' one there.

[I know you hate me. You will never accept me as I was once a Cultivator. And you might think my feelings toward Runald is hypocrisy because I was a Cultivator.]

Andersen continued,

[But can you still do me one last favor?]

Jaehwan thought he needed to answer, but his voice couldn't come out. His body was now slowly being paralyzed, and his senses dying. Jaehwan barely was able to nod.

[Go to the Great Forest. And find the 'God of Madness' there.]

His sight grew dark, and he couldn't see Andersen's face anymore. Even if it wasn't her face, he had to see. He had to see what face she was making, but he couldn't. And the faint voice that came after was swept away by explosions. It was probably, 'Take care of Runald.' In his blurry sight, he saw Andersen turning her back.

[Alright then. Let's go, all you Rupture trash.]

Karavan, who had Jaehwan in one arm and Runald in another, began to run. With his sight being quickly becoming dark, Jaehwan felt his consciousness slipping away.

"HAHA! This is most entertaining! A [Naked] God in a Gigantes? I can't even..."

In the next moment, Andersen unleashed her world power and made Myad take her seriously. It wasn't huge, but it was a fierce attack made by a certain God with all of her power. It was an attack that couldn't be considered lightly.

Loud explosions broke out, with huge shockwaves crashing through. Jaehwan saw the last sight as he closed his eyes. He knew that it was a sight that he would never see again in his entire life. The sight he saw was the last memory of one who had lived an age, who was once a being. Another explosion broke out and hot air gushed from it.

As Jaehwan felt the hot air against his cheek, he felt the days Andersen had lived.

A God who had lived over tens of thousands of years. What did 'death' mean to that God? How valuable a relationship that was formed in just a few days?

Jaehwan couldn't understand anything, and couldn't say anything. But when he understood that fact, he felt he came to know what Andersen's last words were. The hot air, the naked world, was telling him this.

[You will become a good 'God'.]

Yes.

Jaehwan closed his eyes quietly.

Chapter 150: The Great Forest (5)

"...Jaehwan?"

"..."

"Jaehwan!"

It took a while for Jaehwan to realize that he had been lost deep in his thoughts. Runald had already stopped crying. As he looked at Runald, he felt like he could hear Andersen's voice from within.

"You don't look good. Is it because of the wounds..."

"No. Weren't you crying just now?"

"I can't cry for so long, I'm not a kid."

Jaehwan tried to say something to Runald, but he continued, "So don't be so gloomy. It's not like you at all."

Not like you? They were merely together for days. It wasn't long enough to say what he was like or not.

"What am I like then?"

"Hmm... that is a difficult question to answer, actually."

Runald mused, but quickly continued, "You're better off when you act like a stubborn five-year-old kid."

"..."

"You know, those persistent ones always bent on doing what they want?"

It felt weird to hear this from an actual kid. Jaehwan regretted even asking, but Runald continued in a sad tone.

"Andersen was like that too, now I think about it."

He sounded so sad, Jaehwan realized that this boy wanted to speak about her all along.

"Andersen. She always did what others said no to. I guess you learned it too since you shared her world for a few days."

Andersen never shared her stories, and Jaehwan never asked. But as Andersen read Jaehwan's memory, Jaehwan was able to read hers too.

"Everyone abandoned the [Naked] Setting but she was the only one who kept it until the end. She said if there's at least one Follower who believed in that world, then the God needed to stay for that world."

As Runald continued, Jaehwan remembered the first day when he met Andersen. She made complaints and comments about Jaehwan's barren world, but she never expressed that his world was wrong. She always had a bit of concern in her words.

Maybe she knew it all along. Because she walked a lonely path, she didn't want Jaehwan to do the same.

"Andersen then..."

Runald kept on talking about Andersen. He acted as if he was okay, but it seemed like he couldn't shake it off. Jaehwan thought, 'Could he be a better God to Runald than Andersen?'

He wasn't so sure. He wasn't the type to lead people. It was the same when he led the team back in the Tower of Nightmares, and when he became the Master of Fortress in [Chaos]. He did everything alone and just made everyone else follow him afterward.

It caused a lot of opposition, and some even betrayed him. But he didn't care.

Even without anyone's help, he always did it alone.

His life had been a one-way street. He ran and ran. He always challenged the impossible and eventually succeeded in overcoming it. He achieved great feats. The people who opposed him became awestruck, feared and distanced themselves from him.

Yet he still ran and ran. And then he came here.

And, at this moment, after Andersen had died, he finally realized something.

He had miserably failed this time. Maybe the path he had taken was wrong.

Runald was still talking.

"...Oh, I think I got off topic. So, what I'm trying to say is that it's not like you to make that kind of face. Especially that regretful face you're making right now!"

"..."

"Come back to your reckless and stubborn face! Please!"

At those words, Jaehwan felt as if he had doused in ice-cold water. It was weird. He was the one to sympathize with the boy, but Runald was comforting him.

Yes, Runald's statement that Jaehwan was not like himself was correct. It wasn't like Jaehwan at all. Even when he was facing many truths, there were still facts that did not change within him.

The fact that he would not change even then.

The fact that he would still run recklessly.

The fact that he would still be alone.

And be lonely.

Jaehwan knew all of these facts. He then remembered Andersen's last words, expecting Jaehwan to be a good God. Maybe Andersen was wrong about that. Jaehwan looked at Runald and called him, "Runald."

"...Yeah?"

"I'm not Andersen."

Runald's eyes grew wide. He then looked down and responded in a sad voice.

"...I know."

"Not only that, but it might not be a good idea for you to come with me. I can assure you that it will be really bad."

It was a declaration. Runald's eye turned to that of a puppy expecting to be abandoned.

"People will look down on you and even hate you. Even when you don't do anything, some will try to kill you for being my Follower."

"..."

"Will you still come with me?"

Runald looked up with reddened, teary eyes. It seemed that he didn't want to show his tears as he covered his eyes with his hand and smiled as he answered.

"I will."

His voice sounded like he had been waiting to say it for a long time.

"Then let's go."

Jaehwan placed his hand on Runald's head for a moment and then turned around to walk. Runald reached for the spot on his head where Jaehwan's hand had been moments ago and began following Jaehwan.

"Wait for me!"

Jaehwan thought as he glanced over at Runald who was following him. Andersen was wrong. There was no way for Jaehwan to become a good God. But...

Maybe, just maybe. He might become a faithful God at least.

A man and a boy. Both who shared the only world began walking toward the Great Forest.

It had to be the sight of determination, but it was a bit weird if other people saw it from a distance. Karavan the Vicegerent of Ignis, who had been scouting, saw both of them heading toward him and mumbled with a weird expression, "...What's with all the fuss? Whatever it is, it doesn't look good while you're naked..."

Karavan shook his head in disbelief.

Chapter 151: The Great Forest (6)

"...Anyway, I am Karavan. Vicegerent of Ignis the Flame. People call me Karavan of the Flame too."

Karavan, who decided to join to reconnect his link to Ignis, introduced himself awkwardly. Runald responded grumpily, "You introduced yourself yesterday and the day before. Why are you doing it again?"

"Oh, I thought you might not remember me, so I just did it again. People don't remember my name even after I tell them two or three times. I'm still a Vicegerent, you know..."

Karavan, unlike his well-known name, was not a man with memorable features. He had a calm face and common facial features. The only unique feature about him was his fiery hair, but it was apparent that he purposely made it so people could remember him by that feature at least.

"Don't be so suspicious, I have my business too. Oh, and Andersen asked me to help you guys..."

"But you don't seem trustworthy at all."

Karavan held back his annoyance and said solemnly, "...I swear to Ignis that I will never do that. Besides, you two are better off going with me."

"Why?"

"Because there is no other who knows more about the Great Forest than me."

The Great Forest.

One of the 8 forbidden places of the [Depth]. The Great Forest, the entrance of which was at the corner of the 4th and 8th site, had many various threats and had earned many nicknames.

Cemetery of the lost ones.

Fallen Ancients.

Forgotten 9th site.

Some said that this was the most dangerous place of all the 8 forbidden places. Some even said that the Great Forest was the 'Depth' within the [Depth]. They were all different names, but they mostly meant the same thing. However, there was one fact that everyone agreed on the Great Forest.

-Within the Great Forest lies the [Parts] left by the Three Ancient Gods.

The [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods. What it meant was too obvious.

-The best [Parts] of the [Depth]. The forgotten three legendary [Parts].

They were legendary parts that were said to allow the wielder to control the entire [Depth]. It lured all kinds of newbie gods and their Vicegerents to [Depth]. In fact, there were records that at around 100 thousand years ago, in the age of the 'God-boom', that half of all newbie gods who were born had ventured into the Great Forest. Official numbers counted about 50 thousand gods, but with Vicegerents and Followers, the numbers would have multiplied by a lot.

It was an incident that would be later named 'Component Rush'.

"A lot died back then. It's funny to say it as if I was there when I wasn't even born, but..."

Karavan recounted as he pushed away black leaves to the side. Jaehwan asked, "Any survivors?"

"Yeah. 5 including my predecessor."

"Predecessor?"

"It's actually pre-pre-pre-pre-pre-pre... but anyway. There was a Vicegerent of Ignis' long before me. Only five of them, including him, came back alive."

"I see."

"So, you've never heard of the story? About those gods who came back alive. Everyone knows about it in [Depth]."

"Huh? Is that..."

It was Runald who interrupted.

"Are you talking about the 7 gods?"

"Oh, so you knew?"

Like all places, [Depth] had powerful Gods that represented it. They were the ones who were called the 7 Gods of [Depth], or the 7 pillars of [Depth].

Big Brother of the System.

Droyan the Dragon God.

Ignis the God of Flame.

Peste the God of Disease.

Chronos the God of Time.

Budda the God of Cycle.

'Nameless' the God of Madness.

Everyone knew about them in [Depth]. They were the 7 gods of the [Depth].

"Out of those 7, 5 of them including Ignis, were the ones that traveled to the Great Forest. Droyan, Peste, Chronos, and Budda."

"Oh, they are all famous now."

"Yeah, they are the masters of the largest sites now."

"Ignis too..."

"He's the master of the 3rd site. Have you ever been there?"

"Yeah, it was an amazing place."

The 3rd site, 'Tropical', was a place with a very high average temperature within [Depth]. It was so hot that it was better to camp out in another site than to sleep in the 3rd site. Karavan smiled bitterly.

"It's not hot. It's just a bit warm."

Warm? Runald thought that was probably the reason he was made Vicegerent and asked, "Anyway, was Big Brother originally one of the 7 gods? I thought Big Brother isn't considered one of them."

"Well, you are correct in that. Big Brother is much more. There are people who don't consider Big Brother to be in that category."

Big Brother of the System. Just like Karavan said, Big Brother was much more than just a God. Some even said that Big Brother had moved onto become something more than a God, thus he was no longer a God.

"Oh, talking about Big Brother, I've been to all the other sites, but never to the 1st site where Big Brother is said to reside. I wanted to go there sometime."

"Huh? You want to go to the 1st site?"

"Yeah. I've been to all the other sites but not that one."

Karavan then burst into laughter as Runald frowned.

"Why are you laughing?"

"Because that's a funny joke."

"Joke? I'm not joking."

"Huh? Oh... I guess you really don't know then?"

Karavan then stopped walking to glance at where they were at, and then left a trace so they would not get lost, before he continued, "There are two things you got wrong there."

He broke one of the tree limbs from a nearby tree.

"The first is that Big Brother does not exist in the 1st site."

"What?"

"He's at the top of the Tree of Imagery called the [Nest]. I think it's the place where... what was it called? The First Nightmare? Where that exists. Some call the [Nest] the 1st site, but it's not. There are no Vicegerents or Followers there."

Karavan's words caught Jaehwan's attention as he had mentioned 'the First Nightmare'. Runald asked, "Then, where is the 1st site?"

"The second is that the 1st site is not in [Depth]."

"What?!" Runald shouted in shock. It was a bad joke. He just said that Big Brother was not in the 1st site, and he now was saying that the 1st site wasn't in [Depth] either. This was a strange story for Runald who had been living in [Depth] for 3 years. Of course, it was hard to hear any stories about Big Brother in the first place.

"What are you talking about? There's no 1st site in [Depth]?"

"Yeah. The site became so big it was taken out of the Tree of Imagery."

The site was taken out of the Tree of Imagery? How was that possible? Runald seemed confused but Jaehwan grimaced. He had come to a question. It was actually a question he had for quite some time.

If Big Brother was a God and if his [Setting] was the System, then what would be the range of his world? He thought about the possibility, but he never really considered it seriously. It was more than 'big'.

"Wait. Is that...?"

As if he read Jaehwan's mind, Karavan smiled and nodded.

"Yeah. The [Great Lands] IS the 1st site of [Depth]."

Chapter 152: The Great Forest (7)

There was silence. Only footsteps could be heard in the forest from time to time. After a while, Runald then asked in shock, "The [Great Lands] is the 1st site of Big Brother?!"

"Oh, so you didn't know anything then?"

Karavan spoke smugly and Runald responded.

"How would I know? I'm just a kid who's been here for 3 years."

"There's no 'kid' in [Depth]. Even a 10-year-old child is already corrupt here."

Runald then began to quarrel with Karavan. As the topic went sideways, Jaehwan thought about what Karavan had said.

'So, Big Brother is the God of Adapters.'

He had guessed it, but it was still shocking to hear. There was also another fact that he realized.

'So, the [Great Lands] is not the land of the living after all.'

Jaehwan had just considered the [Great Lands] to be a land where the 'living' lived and they went to [Chaos] when they died. But that wasn't the case.

The [Great Lands] was just one of many sites of the [Depth], after all.

'Then the [Fruit] is...'

The [Fruits] that the Depth Expedition Team wanted for so long. The miraculous fruits that gave life. Jaehwan felt bitter. If what Karavan spoke was true, then the [Fruit] wasn't the miracle fruit that they thought it was.

The [Fruit] was just another way to enter the 1st site. It didn't give life back. It was revolting to learn of this.

Runald and Karavan were now back on the original topic.

"Wait. So how strong is Big Brother?"

"Hmm... I guess he's stronger than the [Great Lands] at least."

Runald became awestruck. That comparison wasn't to another God, but the world itself.

Stronger than the [Great Lands]? What kind of a being was that? Runald was summoned into [Depth] from the beginning, so he had never gone to the [Great Lands], but he had heard a lot about it. He knew the Lords of the 12 regions had power that didn't fall behind the 7 Gods of [Depth].

If the Lords of the [Great Lands] were equal in power to the 7 Gods, except for Big Brother, it meant that Big Brother already had a 'unique world' equaled to [Depth] itself.

"I can't imagine what kind of being Big Brother is. The [System] already controls the [Great Lands] and the Tree of Imagery."

Even Karavan, the Vicegerent of Ignis, could not guess just how powerful Big Brother was.

"I've never seen Big Brother myself either. To be honest, I actually don't want to see him."

There was probably no one who could withstand the terror at facing such an almighty being. Karavan then turned to Jaehwan.

"Oh, didn't you say you were going to meet with Big Brother?"

Jaehwan nodded wordlessly and Karavan was astonished.

"I'm pretty sure you can feel Big Brother's power too, right? Are you just brave or reckless?"

Jaehwan did not answer. He remembered that Yoo Surha talking about a similar thing before.

"If that is your goal, I'm sorry about what happened this time."

"...Why? What about it?"

"You lost the Machina in front of your eyes. If you got your hands on it, it might've increased your chances against Big Brother."

"Huh? What do you mean?" Runald asked instead of Jaehwan.

"I meant what I said. He has a chance to fight against Big Brother. It's all just rumors though."

Jaehwan figured out what he was trying to say. There was no telling if [Depth] could defeat Big Brother, but there was once upon a time when [Depths] was not under the control of Big Brother. Runald asked again, "Can you defeat Big Brother if you have the Machina? Is that really that powerful?"

"The Machina alone probably isn't enough. You will need at least 2 of the 3 legendary parts to give it a try."

"Two..."

"One of them is enough to be considered as one of the 7 Gods. I'm pretty sure Myad is considered one of the 7 Gods now. Or, is it one of the 8 Gods?"

Jaehwan then spoke again.

"Therefore, if I have those 3 [Parts], I have a chance against Big Brother?"

"Yeah, but as I said, they're all just rumors. There are stories that tell of Big Brother being afraid of the Three Ancient Gods. If they joined forces against Big Brother, we might be serving different masters in [Depth] right now."

The Three Ancient Gods. They were the old masters of the [Depths] 210 thousand years ago, and the ones who could fight against Big Brother. It was understandable as to why their [Parts] were so highly valued. That was why so many Gods went into the Great Forest and were killed in the search for the [Parts].

Karavan concluded his story.

"Anyway, that's why the Great Forest is that important. It's one of the few places that still has traces of the Three Ancient Gods. Oh, and maybe your friend Andersen too..."

Andersen's reason of telling Jaehwan to head into the Great Forest of all places made sense. It was maybe... Jaehwan nodded as he pulled out his sword.

"We'll have to talk about that later."

Karavan also seemed to have noticed something as he became alert and readied his stance. Runald asked in confusion, "What's going on?"

"Something's approaching."

Runald would also be able to hear it soon. There was something coming towards them. Growling sounds filled the air as cold world power seeped out from within the forest. Runald became pale with fear.

"Is it the Lost Ones...?"

However, before he could finish his sentence, something jumped out of bushes. Runald screamed as Jaehwan's sword and Karavan's fist both swung at the same time.

The first monster was struck down by both of them. But it wasn't the only one. Tens of monsters were rushing in. Jaehwan quickly glanced at the monsters. To his surprise, he knew what they were.

'Dead Men?'

Monsters with tentacles and a terrifying mouth — they were Dead Men. And the monsters that were charging in also looked familiar.

There were monsters with horns on their heads. The monsters that the Adapters of [Chaos] would be so eager to hunt down were standing there.

'Horned monsters!'

The monsters with 8 or more horns were charging in. Some were fighting Dead Men rather than charging at Jaehwan. As he saw them both fighting with each other, he thought to himself, 'I see. That was it.'

He wasn't sure when he heard the term the 'Lost Ones', but now he realized what it was.

'The horned monsters are from Daeus and the Dead Men are from Catastrophe.'

Lost Ones. A term that was used to describe the Vicegerents and Followers who had lost their Gods. Jaehwan was curious about what they would look like, but he already knew them. It seemed the horned monsters were followers of Daeus, and the Dead Men were the followers of Catastrophe. These poor Followers who had lost all sanity were still fighting against each other. Jaehwan and Karavan placed Runald in between them and began fighting against the Lost Ones.

Karavan's flame-wielding fist broke down the horns of the monsters while Jaehwan's sword penetrated the heads of the Dead Men. However, as more powerful Lost Ones began to appear, the tide of the battle slowly turned. Jaehwan wasn't at peak condition and Karavan also was suffering a penalty.

"Dammit... I can't use [Hell Flame] right now."

Karavan was a one of a kind Vicegerent. He could use the [Fiery Fist] Setting without Ignis as it was a basic Setting, but he couldn't use [Hell Flame], which was the main [Setting] of Ignis.

"I could've wiped them out if I could use it..."

There was no way for him to unleash such a powerful world power without the help of Ignis. The only world power he could muster by himself was about 10 thousand. And his world power was now low because of the waves of Lost Ones.

"Huh?! HEY! What's going on?!"

Jaehwan felt weird. He grabbed his head as he fought to stand.

'...What?'

He was confused. He had a sudden headache and dizziness as he felt a strong sense of déjà vu. It didn't seem like he was feeling it because of the Dead Men or horned monsters. It felt like he had visited the Great Forest before.

He knew the place. He was sure.

But how? He had never come to [Depth] before. How could he know this place? It didn't make any sense at all.

'Wait, is this...?'

As he tried to make out the reason, tentacles came for him from all sides and with his depleted world power — there was no way to dodge it.

"Watch out!"

Chapter 153: The Great Forest (8)

Karavan shouted. At that moment, a torrent of arrows that contained world power struck the horned monsters and the Dead Men.

[Deusen. Castrophen. Turga!]

[Turga!]

It was a language that could not be translated. But Jaehwan understood what was said. He couldn't make out the language itself, but it seemed the meaning was being transferred to him.

'Get lost, dogs of Daeus and Catastrophe!'

'Get lost!'

That's what they meant. He saw the Lost Ones moving away, one by one. Who were these people? Jaehwan then saw them.

They looked like normal humans. They had giant bows or spears, resembling the Native Americans of World 294, Earth, but there was a large amount of world power coming from them.

[Turga!]

As the Lost Ones retreated, they now pointed their arrowheads and spears at Jaehwan. World power of at least a million was directed towards Jaehwan and his group — even Karavan flinched and stepped back.

"Wh-what the hell...?"

They seemed to be carrying ancient [Parts], but the vicious energy coming from them easily defied their archaic appearance. They were created with ages of training since a very long time ago. Karavan swallowed and Runald hid behind Jaehwan's leg as he shook in fear. As they pulled back their bows, Jaehwan and the others realized that they were not friendly.

Maybe these people were trying to kill them.

It was when those people were about to shoot their arrows, Jaehwan spoke.

"Long Living race."

He didn't know how he knew, but the words just came to his mind. After he said it, he realized why he had déjà vu earlier. He knew the place because Mulack had visited it 900 years ago.

'I see. So, Mulack met them before.'

Mulack called them the 'Long Living race' in his Record of the Depth. The people of the Long Living race looked at each other after they heard what Jaehwan had said. Their hostility waned.

"What? Do you know them?"

Karavan looked at Jaehwan, but he had no way to explain.

"No."

"Then how..."

"It's my [Setting]. I just have a way to find out sometimes."

He didn't have such a [Setting], but he didn't feel like explaining everything. He didn't technically lie about the Record of the Depth anyway.

"What kind of [Setting] is that.."

However, Karavan was cut short.

[Janshor. Nas. Merga.]

'Do you know us?'

'Who are you?'

One of them spoke to Jaehwan.

"We are..."

Jaehwan wasn't sure how to describe themselves. He realized the name of these people, but he wasn't sure what kind of people they were. The Record of the Depth didn't give him any other information.

'Daeus? Catastrophe? Geshtalt?'

Jaehwan thought about the names of the Three Ancient Gods. If they too were Lost Ones, then they must be the Followers of one of those three. It was likely that they were the Followers of Geshtalt from what they just did earlier.

[Nas. Geshtalten?]

'Are you Followers of Geshtalt?'

The voice seemed to even help Jaehwan. But he didn't feel like lying and decided to speak honestly.

"No. I don't trust the Gods. I'm not a Follower of anyone."

It was a fitting answer for Jaehwan. Karavan asked Jaehwan, "What- what did they say? Why did you say that?"

"They asked if we were Followers of Geshtalt."

"And you said no?!"

"Yeah."

Karavan turned pale.

"Are you out of your mind?! You should've answered yes to that question!"

"Why?"

"Because they chased away the Followers of Daeus and Catastrophe! They must be the Followers of Geshtalt for sure!"

Karavan spoke furiously as the people of the Long Living race talked among themselves.

[Nadach. Merlen.]

[Geshtalten. Alo. Geshtalten.]

[Hatero! A- Hatero!]

[Nahur. Geshtalten Narga?]

[Nagamaren. Nadaro. Aiharo.]

'He doesn't believe in any Gods.'

'Really? Then he must be Geshtalt.'

'Naked! Naked! It must be!'

'That one's not naked. Is he Geshtalt?'

'Doesn't matter. I like him.'

Jaehwan understood what they said but he wasn't following what they were talking about. And soon, one who looked like he was in charge spoke.

[Nas. Geshtalten. Armarelum.]

'Yes. Geshtalt doesn't believe in God.'

'I can sense the will of Geshtalt in you.'

At that moment, Karavan shouted as he ran out.

"HEY! Geshtalt! I believe in Geshtalt! I love him!"

He would've had the wrath of Ignis upon him if Ignis heard that. In fact, Karavan was scared as he saw fire land in front of his face, thinking that the link to Ignis had been restored. But as he looked again, he realized it was an arrow with world power, not fire. Those people were aiming at Karavan.

"What? Why...?!"

Jaehwan then walked up and talked with them, and their leader responded. Jaehwan then said to Karavan, "They say Runald and I are okay, but you aren't."

"What- why?"

"You are not a real Geshtalt Follower."

Karavan frowned. Arrows were still being aimed at him. Jaehwan thought for a second and talked with their leader again before speaking to Karavan.

"Hey."

"...Yeah?"

"Take off your clothes."

"W-what are you talking about?"

"Do as I say if you want to live."

Karavan realized something and looked down at himself. He then glanced at Jaehwan, Runald and at the Long Living race. Karavan was the only one wearing clothes.

Jaehwan warned him, "If you don't, they said they will kill you."

They were looking at Karavan with strange expressions.

Minutes later...

Karavan was shaking his head as he shouted.

"This is shameful. It's a travesty!"

"...Ugh."

Runald frowned as he looked at Karavan. Karavan kept on mumbling,
"No... I'm not me anymore. I'm not!"

"...Cut it out, will you? You're just naked. It's not a big deal!"

"I'm not just naked! It's like something important was also taken from me!"

With Karavan muttering by their side, Jaehwan and the others arrived at the deepest part of the Great Forest, where the Long Living race lived. One of them, Ra-hamad, stopped and turned back to them and said,

[Nas. Sakrikford. Amadar.]

It meant the following.

Welcome to the Forest of Madness.

Chapter 154: God of Madness (1)

[I will never... I repeat, I will never go back into the Great Forest.]

-Budda, the 6th god of the 7 gods of the [Depths].

Episode – God of Madness.

The center of the 8th site [Caspion] contained, multiple big to middle-sized sites grouped together. One of those sites, [Highseeker], had different masters because of repeated wars, but it had now found a more permanent master thanks to the 'Hatchnold Disaster' that happened two weeks ago.

"What's all the fuss in there?"

In the palace of [Highseeker], in front of the central office, Kashim was confused as he heard the sounds coming from within. The office was where the current master of [Highseeker] resided. Kashim had been hearing the screams of a woman from inside and also the sounds of something crashing. It shouldn't be possible. Who could possibly scream and throw stuff at the master of [Caspion], and the master of Rupture?

"Oh, Captain. Are you here, sir?"

One of the officers, who had been standing outside the office, quickly saluted Kashim. It was as much courtesy as he would extend to his own master. The tall man, Kashim was a man worthy of such respect.

One of the five Captains in Rupture. The masters of the mighty power that even high-ranking gods and the Generals of the [Great Lands] feared — that was the 'Captain' of Rupture.

"What's happening inside?" Kashim asked in a soft voice.

"Uh... the 2nd Captain is inside."

"2nd? Yoo Surha is here?" Kashim asked back in shock. "I see. So, that's what's all about."

"Yes, sir."

The officer's concern was understandable. The master of Rupture and one of the Captains were fighting inside, and there was no way a mere officer could interrupt. He seemed really happy that Kashim had arrived, he was probably expecting Kashim to do something about it.

Kashim glanced at the documents that he had brought to brief and sighed. He couldn't wait here for long, so he had to go in.

'Why did she have to come now? Ugh... it will get ugly.'

If Surha was here, 3rd Captain Imai Kazuki would soon go crazy. And with the recent event...

-You should've just kept him in custody then! You tried to kill him?!

-I had reasons to do it.

-What the hell were you thinking? It was you who told me to recruit him in the first place!

Louder shouts were heard from within. Kashim carefully placed his hand on the doorknob, but before he could turn it, the door burst open and someone charged out. The woman was so infuriated that there was lightning sparking around her entire body. It seemed her [Setting] of Lightning Chain had activated without her realizing.

Kashim stared at Surha and waved.

"Hey."

"...Kashim?"

Surha looked up at Kashim.

Moments later.

"So, you were quarreling with the master because of differing opinions?"

"You can say that."

Kashim sighed at Surha speaking casually.

"What are you thinking? Are you trying to solve it with a [Rupture Battle] or something?"

"No way. There's no way for me to win. He's a monster with a legendary [Part]."

"...Yeah."

"If only he didn't have the Machina..."

"You couldn't beat him even when he didn't have the Machina."

"That's... you never know."

Power trumped over everything in Rupture. When there was a difference in opinion, it was possible to duel in a [Rupture Battle] to see who was stronger, and the winner would be allowed to do things their way. Kashim and Surha were talking about that tradition.

"...You and the Master have a huge difference in world power. You know that."

Surha didn't answer Kashim's point. Yoo Surha's world power was at 1.5 million and as far as the Captains knew, the Master easily exceeded 7 million, even without the Machina. Surha looked grumpy and glanced at the people behind Kashim.

"Who are they?"

A man and a woman were standing a bit of a distance away behind Kashim.

"Oh, they're new recruits. I'm training them."

"Kashim the Tyrant has now become a babysitter? That's interesting."

"Don't say that."

Kashim turned and the man and woman quickly ran up to them and saluted. It was a man with a smiling face, and the woman had an alluring beauty.

"Good day, Captain. I am Kim Yoonhwan, new recruit to Rupture."

"Good day, Captain. I am Han Seoyul."

There wasn't much about the man, but the woman was something. With that kind of beauty, she was bound to draw attention even within Rupture. Surha closely studied the woman who had introduced herself as Han Seoyul.

"Hmmm. Your introduction is short."

"I-I'm sorry..."

"No, you don't need to be sorry. We might be enemies the next time we meet."

"I beg your pardon...?"

Han Seoyul became confused and Kashim quickly interrupted, "Hey, hey. Don't scare the new recruits."

"No, I'm being serious."

"What are you talking about?"

Surha didn't seem like she was joking and Kashim turned grim.

"Don't tell..."

"Yeah, I've made up my mind."

Kashim's lips trembled at that moment. Surha's words were shocking.

"...Is he that important to you?"

"To me? No, not at all."

Surha shrugged and answered in a cold voice. Kashim was relieved at those words. There was no way Surha would fall in love with someone. Such a feeling was a luxury that the Captains of Rupture could not afford.

"Then why are you protecting him? Do you have to leave for..."

"He's important to this world."

Important to this world? It didn't make sense at all. However, because it was the '2nd Captain of Rupture' who said it, it was possible that it might have a reason for it.

"Did you... look into the future? Did something show up in your [Premonition]?"

If Surha was talking about it, there was only one reason. Her [Premonition] had shown her some kind of future and the man Surha was looking for played a vital role. Kashim frowned.

"[Premonition] doesn't show a decided future. You know this better than anyone."

Even if she saw such a future, it wasn't enough reason for Surha to leave Rupture. Besides, they had the Master of Rupture. He was the one who was outside of her [Premonition].

Surha did not answer, but turned and glanced out of the window at a corner of the corridor. Outside was the clear sky of [Depth]. She looked at the sky and asked, "Kashim, do you see something in that sky?"

"What are you talking about?"

"An eye, stars... or something."

"I'm not following."

"You know what I'm talking about."

See something in the sky? There was nothing there. But Kashim realized what she was asking and smiled.

"You're talking about Big Brother, aren't you?"

"Yeah."

"There's no way I can see him."

"Right. We can't."

The only ones who could see Big Brother up in the sky and fight it were special. The Three Ancient Gods in the past were those kinds, and so was the Master of Rupture. A being only the chosen kinds could see. That was Big Brother.

Yoo Surha spoke.

"Master once told us that if you overcome [Seclusion], you can see him."

Kashim also heard this story before. The disease that every Awakener suffers. A disease that makes Awakeners close their eyes and ears to keep themselves from the flood of information.

-Kashim, you must not close your eyes or block your ears, no matter how hard it is. Accepting [Seclusion] means losing against this world.

The Master once said this. But even now, Kashim couldn't understand what he meant. There was no way for an Awakener to keep their sanity without [Seclusion].

-If you overcome your [Seclusion], then you will see the same world that I see.

Kashim's world had stalemated since a long time ago. However, Surha and Imai were the same. In fact, everyone other than the Master himself had stopped advancing since a long time ago.

They couldn't get any stronger. No matter how hard they tried, there was this wall blocking their way.

Kashim knew that the way to break that wall lay in [Seclusion]. But knowing it wasn't the same as doing it. There was no one who could overcome [Seclusion]. Other than the Master, no one in the world could overcome the wall of [Seclusion]. The one who could see Big Brother with their own eyes in this world was only...

That's when Kashim realized where the story was going.

Chapter 155: God of Madness (2)

"Wait."

As he stared at Surha, he realized his guess was correct. He had to ask the next question, "Then, has he overcome [Seclusion]? Can he see [Big Brother] like the Master?"

Yoo Surha did not answer, but it was an act of agreement. And the silence made Kashim furious.

"Did you see it?! Did you see that he saw Big Brother yourself?!"

"...Why are you so infuriated?"

"Because it's nonsense! I saw him too, and he was so weak to consider that he can overcome [Seclusion]. Maybe you were mistaken..."

Kashim wasn't sure why he was so infuriated at the moment. He was talking a lot, which wasn't like him at all, and he felt like he was trying to deny something.

"You believe that nonsense that some fool jabbered about and will leave Rupture...!"

"Kashim."

After Kashim faced Surha's cold stare, he became silent.

"If I saw something in my [Premonition], will you believe me?"

"What?"

"If I say I saw the Master killing all of you, and the man you call a fool was fighting to save us- will you believe me?"

Kashim felt his heart sink. He asked back in a shaking voice, "T-that's impossible. It's a joke, right?"

Surha did not answer but just smiled coldly. Kashim then realized she was indeed lying. But it didn't matter if what she said was a lie.

"Poor man. You won't believe me even if I say the truth."

Yoo Surha then turned and walked away, fully confident as if she was walking toward the God she trusted. And after some time...

"Captain Kashim."

"Oh, yeah."

Kashim came back to his senses at Yoonhwan's call. Surha had already disappeared. He then looked down at the document in his hands. The title of it was this:

-Project - Depth Invasion

It had been days since Jaehwan's group arrived at the place of the Long Living race. Their village was protected by larger trees than the other areas, with huge hot springs scattered around. It seemed that most of these people usually spent their entire day within the springs or at small bungalows built in front of the springs. As guests, Jaehwan's group was assigned one of those small bungalows, but there was one who wasn't treated as a guest.

"...Why am I treated like this?"

Karavan, who was naked and had a scrubbing towel in his hand, shouted. Jaehwan looked at him in sympathy and spoke.

"They said you are a criminal, not a guest."

"Criminal? I didn't do anything wrong!"

"They said that you were in violation of not being naked."

"What kind of crime is that?"

Karavan then shook his head and shouted as he scrubbed one of the warriors who just came out of the springs.

"I am Karavan, Vicegerent of Ignis! I'm not here to scrub your back! My hand exists to use [Hell Flame] and..."

[Nas. Sorel. Hatan.]

"Yes, sir. Heh heh. How does it feel? You want this place scrubbed too?"

Karavan quickly stopped shouting at the warrior's words and smiled. He couldn't understand those people's words so he had no choice but guessed that they were trying to threaten him and act accordingly. But the words that Jaehwan heard actually meant this.

'Your hand. It's hot and feels good.'

So, the Vicegerent of the god of flame was now a scrubbing servant.

"Dammit, can you ask around and find someone who can restore my link?"

Even if Karavan had been powerful, there was no way for him to defeat even one of these people without Ignis' assistance. These people easily had over a million in world power.

"Dammit...!"

Karavan was now even crying due to humiliation. His fiery hand was now more like a fiery scrubber. And because the world was full of unfairness, there was one who was enjoying the best time of his life.

It was Runald.

"Jaehwan! This... this place is like heaven!"

Runald was also crying, but it was a different kind of tears. He was looking at the beautiful women of the Long Living race who were naked and sitting nearby in the hot springs. Runald now even had a runny nose from the excitement.

"Ah-ah... Andersen was right! She said there is a naked heaven somewhere in this world...!"

Everyone was submerged in the hot springs and the steam covered most of the silhouettes, but these women all seemed to be in very good shape.

"T-they are all naked, right? They're naked! All of them! Hahaha!"

One of them noticed Runald's attention and winked at him. It was a heart-stopping wink.

"OH MY!!"

Then, after a while, the woman who had been exchanging glances with Runald stood up. She certainly was in very good shape, Jaehwan thought as he looked at her body. Someone in World 294 said 'Life is a tragedy when seen close-up, but a comedy in a long-shot.'

Step by step, the woman walked closer to Runald.

"W-what?! What is that, Jaehwan?!"

Runald's tragedy began.

"W-why! How come she has 'that' between her legs?!"

Runald was so shocked that his jaw was shaking. Yet it was understandable as the woman had something huge dangling between her legs. She smiled and talked to Runald.

[Nas. Arkama.]

Runald quickly ran to Jaehwan.

"W-What did she just say? She said something bad, right?"

"She said she's glad to meet you."

Jaehwan lied. What she really meant was...

'You, you have a cute thing.'

Runald then asked back.

"A-are you sure?"

"Yeah."

"But why is she following me?"

Soon, Runald had been captured by the many beautiful women, and they began their show of friendship towards Runald.

"W-we must get out of here fast!"

Jaehwan also had no intention to waste time, but he had a purpose. During the time they had been here, Jaehwan had already asked a few questions.

"Take me to your leader."

[La. Mir. Tus.]

'There is always time for everything.'

"Who are you people? What's up with this? Are you followers of Geshtalt?"

[Ouroboros.]

'We are Geshtalt.'

'We are not Geshtalt.'

The reply came in two different meanings to Jaehwan. These people were Geshtalt, but not Geshtalt. Jaehwan wasn't sure what it meant. But even when he kept asking, the answer wasn't clear. The only thing he could do now was to wait.

Jaehwan decided to relax and wait. He then stood up and started practicing stabbing. He didn't have to do this, but it calmed him. And after he repeated about a thousand times, someone came to him.

[Nas. Hirmu. Shurukan.]

'You do interesting training.'

It was a warrior named Ra-hamad, the one who had brought Jaehwan here. He continued before Jaehwan could answer.

[Aikamu.]

'But it's useless.'

Jaehwan felt offended, but then he had the strength to make a point. Jaehwan thought.

'How did they get so strong?'

If looked at with common sense, these people were weird perverts who walked around naked. However, they had world powers that could allow them to easily overpower most high-ranking Gods.

After a long time, Jaehwan finally finished his ten thousandth stab.

The day had turned dark. Runald, who had been having a good time with the women, had fallen asleep and Karavan, who had been scrubbing all day, was also lying down and resting.

[Nas. Ankar?]

'Are you done?'

Ra-hamad was still beside Jaehwan. He had been watching Jaehwan training the entire time. However, the number of spectators had increased. Jaehwan sheathed his swords back into his scabbards and answered, "Yeah."

Ra-hamad then stood up. He spoke.

[Ra. Ankar. Dou.]

'Let's go. The leader is waiting for you.'

Chapter 156: God of Madness (3)

Ra-hamad, the one brought Jaehwan to the village, was one of the 'Great Warriors'. Jaehwan noticed that Ra-hamad had exceptionally high world power compared to the others, and it was for a certain reason. Jaehwan was led deeper into the forest by Ra-hamad.

The hot springs were still everywhere in the forest, and many naked warriors were soaking within. A few warriors turned to Ra-hamad, who was leading Jaehwan, and asked, 'Great Warrior. Where are you going?'

'I am going to him.'

'Who is that human?'

'One who will learn the Ouroboros.'

'I see. Ouroboros.'

Jaehwan couldn't understand the discussion. The word Ouroboros especially had too many meanings so he couldn't figure out what the word actually meant.

'Hope fortune is with you.'

'It's better for you to spend your time in the hot springs.'

Some warriors then spoke to Jaehwan. There were some who laughed at Jaehwan's naked body, but most were concentrating in the springs.

They stayed in the water for a while, came out to clean it off, and then went back in.

Some seemed to drink the water, while some were sitting within the water, deep in meditation. Jaehwan asked Ra-hamad.

"Do you all bathe every day?"

[Baathee?]

Ra-hamad didn't seem to understand. It seemed there was no word that meant the same thing as 'bath' or 'bathe' in their language. That was strange as every one of them was bathing but no one used the term. Jaehwan used all of his gestures to explain, and Ra-hamad nodded and answered.

'Oh, you mean metamorphosis.'

"Metamorph... what?"

'We're taking our clothes off.'

"Clothes? What do you mean?"

Ra-hamad didn't answer right away, so Jaehwan asked again.

"Clothes- by you mean something dirty? Is it like a metaphor?"

Jaehwan was certain that it might mean something. However, Ra-hamad shook his head.

'Clothes is clothes.'

He continued, 'Spirit grows the more you take it off. Your world power grows, and you can live without a god.'

That's when Jaehwan realized something. These people said 'clothes', but he did experience some complicated thing regarding 'clothes' in recent days.

"Do you know anything about [Naked] Setting?"

Ra-hamad then smiled eerily and replied.

[Ouroboros.]

'Anyone can be naked.'

'No one can be naked.'

It was translated into two meanings again. Jaehwan frowned.

"...Ouroboros. What does that mean?"

Ra-hamad shook his head. It seemed he didn't want to answer and began to walk faster.

'Take it off, take it off, but there are always clothes underneath.'

'When you and I take each other's clothes off.'

'No world or God is important.'

It was then that a song could be heard. Jaehwan concentrated on the song as the song seemed to be coming from within the forest. He then realized the entire Long Living race was singing the song.

'A song, eh?'

He then remembered Andersen's song. The song then continued to a lyric that was very familiar.

'He took the last friend's clothes,'

'And finally returned to his home.'

'His home was full of his friend's clothing.'

'Naked God spoke as he saw those clothes.'

Jaehwan flinched as he heard the word 'Naked God'. He expected as much when he saw everyone naked, but it was shocking to hear that his guess had been right in such a strange situation. The song continued.

'Lonely.'

'I am so lonely.'

'Naked God said and put on his friend's clothes.'

'One clothes on Naked God.'

'Two clothes on Naked God.'

'Soon, Naked God was covered by clothes.'

'Lonely Naked God spoke.'

'The world is unhappy.'

'Because.'

'Everyone is wearing clothes.'

'Everyone cannot take off clothes.'

The song didn't have a steady tempo as it was crude and violent. It was sometimes sad, and sometimes gloomy.

'No one can take off clothes.'

'That is the truth.'

It was hard to see the meaning of the song. As he concentrated on the song, Jaehwan then realized Ra-hamad had stopped walking. He turned to Jaehwan and spoke.

[Nas. Akinio.]

'You. Go alone.'

[Dioblivio.]

'Remember.'

[Ouroboros.]

'Clothes exist.'

'Clothes do not exist.'

Jaehwan walked and walked in the direction Ra-hamad had told him. As he walked further, he felt the world was changing into a very familiar form.

'It wasn't just a hot spring.'

Some hot springs had vicious winds with powerful world power, while some hot springs sent an icy chill.

'I think I know something like this...'

It was in a different order, but Jaehwan had been through this kind of passage. After he passed through a few more hot springs, he realized why it was familiar.

'The 8 Gates of Hell.'

It was like the magic that Sirwen had used before on Jaehwan. The Gates were very similar to this.

'I thought it was made to resemble the regions of the [Great Lands], but it might not be the case.'

Jaehwan realized Mulack had probably walked this path before, and realized the temperature was rising.

'Is this the 'Burning Hell' phase now?'

The 2nd Gate of the 8 Gates of Hell was at the end of this hot spring. At the end of the hot spring, there was a warrior sitting in the water.

No, the word 'warrior' didn't fit him. The presence from him was so powerful that Jaehwan had never felt it before. It was probably equal or higher to Myad's real power.

'A God? Or a Vicegerent?'

It was hard to realize who he was as his world power was too high for him to comprehend.

"Are you the leader?" Jaehwan asked, but there was no answer. He couldn't see his face as the steam obscured his features. Then, the figure moved, curling his finger.

'Is it telling me to come closer?'

Jaehwan hesitantly walked closer to the hot springs where the man was at. And as he dipped in a foot, he felt sizzling pain from the water. It wasn't just hot. It felt like his entire spirit would be boiled as a whole.

However, Jaehwan did not stop and walked in.

As he walked further, the water temperature rose and Jaehwan was now fully immersed with only his head out of the water. After a while, he realized it actually wasn't the water. There was no way water could be that hot and that painful.

'I can't get close.'

He had taken maybe hundreds of steps, but his distance to the leader did not decrease. His defense against the heat was at its limit too. Jaehwan felt his conscious fading as the hot liquid began to seep into him.

It was ironic. He had done so much to come this far and yet he was going to die here. As he lost energy, his body floated into the water. Boiling water flowed into him from his nose and ears, and he couldn't think.

'It's so comfortable. I'll just let go.'

Jaehwan's body was relaxed. It was so relaxing that he was losing consciousness. But then, he heard the voices.

-Hey, he's doing that again.

-I think he's done.

-No way. We chose him because he's the most determined. Who among us can stab a million times?

-Hey! I can do that too.

Jaehwan remembered these voices. When did he hear them? Was it when he cleared the 8th Gate of Hell? Whatever the case, he had never heard their voices as clear as this time.

-You really should be careful, my man. You gonna fall unconscious in a hot spring?

-I'm not going to help you this time! You think a miracle will happen every single time you get into trouble?

-No way, man. You think this is some movie? You shouldn't just charge in like that.

Jaehwan shook his head and started breathing again. He couldn't give up now.

-Oh, he's getting up.

-Then what? What is he going to do with that world power?

-Hey, beg us! We'll give you power... or better yet, just let us take control of you.

Jaehwan shook his head.

-Oh my, this stubborn idiot! I told you it's a bad idea to have this one in charge.

-Give up, you fool!

Jaehwan did not give up. He began to move, he tried hard. His body didn't work as he intended. He was still at the brink of death. The voices came back again.

-Oh man, okay. You win. I accept you, 'me'.

-Ahh, us Jaehwans are stupid!

-Hey, who's volunteering this time?

Jaehwan then fell unconscious. Soon after, something that was covering his skin, disappeared. It turned into powder and was absorbed back into Jaehwan. He knew the feeling — it was when he absorbed the thousands of Jaehwan before.

He felt his world power multiplying by at least two times. His spirit was nourished and he regained his strength.

As he opened his eyes, a man was in front of him. But he wasn't looking at the leader. Ra-hamad was smiling in front of him. He spoke.

[Nas. Ouroboros.]

'You took off your clothes.'

'You wore your clothes.'

Chapter 157: God of Madness (4)

It had been a month since Jaehwan arrived at the Forest of Madness. He spent most of his time inside the hot springs within the forest.

Through the steam of the springs, Jaehwan saw the shadow of the leader. It had been a month, but he still couldn't find a way to get closer to him. He was now even suspicious if this leader actually existed.

"...You're always here these days."

Like today, Runald often visited Jaehwan. However, he wasn't here to look for Jaehwan as he was only here to run away from the 'ladies'. Runald was very popular with them.

"They always want to scrub my body."

Those 'ladies' always scrubbed Runald's body. Jaehwan commented, "I'm sure it's a good thing for you."

"...That's nonsense."

"You never know. Their scrubbing might have some secret trick."

"That's as stupid as the [Setting] that makes you become more powerful as you get naked."

"Yeah, right?" Runald sighed.

"Karavan says something similar nowadays. What was it? The philosophy of scrubbing or something."

"Karavan said that?"

He then realized it had been a while since he had seen the man. Karavan used to visit Jaehwan often to rant when they first came to the forest.

'I must recover my link with Ignis, and kill those sons of b*tches.'

Or-

'I will hang those bastards who I scrubbed the Hell Flame.'

He then returned hopelessly. However, it had been 2 weeks since the last time he visited. Jaehwan just thought Karavan had given up... but sharing the 'Philosophy of Scrubbing'? It was very interesting.

"What's he doing these days?"

"Same as always. Scrubbing people. I think he's come to like it now."

"...He likes it?"

"He says, 'Scrubbing is a serious business, kid. You're too young to understand.'"

Runald imitated Karavan and shrugged.

"I wasn't sure where he was going with it. He said scrubbing is 'good' and that we always have to scrub... so that we'll find the true meaning of life. And in the end, you will find the true understanding of the world through scrubbing... Something like that."

If it was months ago, Jaehwan would have burst into laughter. However, he was different now.

"I see. Clothes or scrubbing... I think it doesn't matter what you call it."

"What?"

"I guess Karavan is on the right path after all."

"...Are you serious?"

Runald frowned as he took a few steps back. It seemed like he was growing suspicious of Jaehwan.

"I think he's understanding the Unclothing."

"Unclothing?"

"These people call it Metamorphosis. I just call it the Unclothing."

Unclothing. The way of taking off the 'clothes' that covered the layers of spirit. It was the daily routine of all the warriors here had and their secret to becoming powerful.

"And what exactly is that?"

"What I'm always doing."

Runald looked at Jaehwan who was still inside the water and asked in a doubtful voice, "A bath?"

"Yeah, you can say that."

Jaehwan shrugged and looked around. The heat in the spring was very intense. Throughout the month, Jaehwan had a total of 37 moments where he could've died. He kept on walking through the boiling hot water in hopes of meeting the 'leader' on the other end of the steam.

But he couldn't get to the leader yet. The only thing he could do was to keep walking.

For hours, or sometimes for the entire day, he walked towards the 'leader' until his world power ran out. In all of those near-death experiences, he met many of his old selves from different times.

-Dammit, again?!

-Stop it already!

Sometimes he even heard voices. And as he remembered the old days, he felt his layers being taken off as his power greatly increased.

The steps were always the same. Ra-hamad appeared from somewhere and brought Jaehwan out from the spring, mumbling 'Ouroboros'. It was then that the day's 'Unclothing' had finished.

Runald asked, "Jaehwan, what are 'clothes'? I think these people really consider it seriously."

"Clothes..."

Jaehwan didn't know, but he didn't say it. He was 'unclothing' right now so he couldn't just say he wasn't sure what it was. Jaehwan even had asked Ra-hamad what 'clothes' actually were, but Ra-hamad's answer was just this:

'Ouroboros.'

Jaehwan was annoyed.

"And what is that supposed to mean? You always just say 'Ouroboros.'"

'Ouroboros is Ouroboros.'

"Can't you simplify it? It doesn't help if you make it complicated."

'It's not a matter of complicating.'

Ra-hamad then spoke to Jaehwan with a sympathetic look on his face.

'You are out of the system, but still live in the system.'

That was very striking to Jaehwan. Jaehwan then realized in the future that word was going to lead the way in the fight against Big Brother.

"Jaehwan?"

Runald was looking at Jaehwan. He answered, "Oh, what were we talking about?"

"About clothes."

Jaehwan thought. Runald wanted an answer to which he did not have.

"Ouroboros."

"What?"

"Clothes is Ouroboros."

"...And what's that supposed to mean? Oh, the warriors did say 'Ouroboros' when they pointed at my genitals."

Ouroboros while pointing at the genitals? That seemed like a very different meaning. Runald quickly covered his genitals as he realized Jaehwan was looking right at it and asked, "A-anyway. So, what is Ouroboros?"

"I don't know."

"...Are you making fun of me?"

"I don't know everything!"

Runald then shouted angrily.

"But you are doing that Unclothing thing! You are unclothing but you don't what you're taking off? It doesn't make sense!"

He was right. Jaehwan then asked, "Runald. Do you know what is life?"

"...What? Life?"

Runald couldn't answer. The question wasn't easy. He could say whatever, but he couldn't just say it out loud. Life couldn't just be described by words.

Runald shook his head.

"I'm not sure."

Jaehwan nodded. "Exactly."

"What?"

"You don't know what is life, but you're living it, right?"

Runald then became astonished. He stared at Jaehwan with an admiring look on his face.

"W-wow! That is brilliant! You are brilliant!"

"..."

"I see... Ouroboros... our life...!"

It seemed Runald was going to start talking nonsense, so Jaehwan waved his hand and stopped him from talking.

"Runald, let's end it here."

"Huh? Why?"

"Because I feel like I'm dying."

"...What?!"

Runald became frantic and Jaehwan spoke in an 'Ouroboros' kind of face.

"Take me out after about 10 minutes. Okay?"

And Jaehwan feel unconscious. It was his 38th near death experience.

And after another month, he finally was able to reach the end of the hot spring.

Chapter 158: God of Madness (5)

He was dreaming. It was a long and epic dream. It was the past he had lived, but it didn't feel real.

'Ah-ah.'

The man suffered from the stream of memories. It was too brutal. It had the terrifying tower that appeared in front of his world, and the memories within it.

Death, death, and death.

There was the stone that made everyone to return to their lives. People ran away from the harsh reality. Friends lost their lives in an effort to protect reality.

-Let's go, Yoonhwan.

-Yoonhwan?

-You... you're trying to go back?

And then, there was the friend's voice.

-...Okay. Go.

I'm sorry, Jaehwan.

-Go, before I change my mind.

His last friend walked alone toward the 99th floor. He was all alone now. Blood seeped through his cloak.

-It was good to have you in this world, Jaehwan.

And then came the fall. As his body came crashing down on the ground, he opened his eyes and screamed.

"Are you okay?"

Yoonhwan realized someone was grabbing his shoulder. He looked up and saw a familiar face. The memories were getting mixing up. A large man with a giant axe on his back... who was this guy? Where was he?

"Captain?"

"I guess you didn't go mad. Good."

Kashim the Tyrant, the 4th Captain of Rupture, smiled as he scrubbed his beard.

"The memory recall is successful. Congratulations on overcoming your first step."

Memory recall.

He then realized and glanced around. There were few recruits of Rupture within the room that resembled some kind of a lab. He knew where this place was.

Memory Recall Laboratory.

It was within the Rupture Training Facility which housed all of Rupture's high technology.

"Some go mad during the process, but you're lucky. As is she."

He turned and saw the woman. The woman named Han Seoyul had also been chosen to become a member of Rupture. He only considered her to be pretty, but he now knew who she was. She was a friend who climbed the tower with him for tens of years.

Yoonhwan tried to speak, but decided not to. He still couldn't believe it was real.

Those terrifying events... they were all true. If they were true, then what was happening to him now? Yoonhwan was confused and he felt weak with the various emotions surging within him.

"Ah..."

And Han Seoyul also seemed to be going through the same thing. She was looking at Yoonhwan with tears running down her face. It was a painful memory, but that was a memory that they should have never forgotten. However, it was also why it felt more terrifying due to the fact that it had come back.

Tower. Cultivation. Tutorial. Level. Status...

Yoonhwan remembered the words he heard from Kashim before he came into the Recall lab.

-You two are lucky. Master found a method for 'forced awakening' recently.

-Your hatred toward the world and the system. All of it is the basis to the Awakening.

-Memory Recall is mandatory for the course. It's especially important for recruits who failed while climbing the tower.

-It's to let you not forget the hatred toward 'Cultivation'.

People who had failed while clearing the tower were bound to forget the memory of 'losing' on the tower. Yoonhwan and Seoyul were examples of them, and that was why they were here.

'I feel the power.'

He felt the power of something on an entirely different level, or status, within him. Yoonhwan was confused, but he was also astonished at his newfound power. It was a power that would allow him to clear the tower in

the memory with a breeze. But Kashim didn't seem all satisfied as he looked at Yoonhwan.

"But still at the 1st step... Well, there's a way for you to get quickly get to the 3rd step."

"...Can I become stronger than this?"

"The 1st step is nothing. True power comes when you achieve on reaching the 3rd step."

"3rd..."

"Don't worry. You'll do fine. We have a new method that we got from [Chaos] recently. It won't take long and you will gain the power to get revenge against the enemy that put you into that tower."

"Hmph, a new method? What did you bring in this time?"

The words came from a man who was standing by the entrance. Yoonhwan knew him also. It was Imai Kazuki.

"Imai, what are you doing here?" Kashim asked Imai the Fast Kill, the 3rd Captain of the Rupture.

"I came to take a look at our new recruits."

"...YOU? Of all people?"

"Well, I still got to see them, right? Oh, and I do want to know about that 'new method' of yours."

Imai waved off Yoonhwan and Seoyul's salutes and spoke to Kashim.

"What skill is it? What did you bring in?"

"So, you haven't heard of it yet. The team who went with Surha to [Chaos] brought back the information. It is a method of using the 'Tower of Nightmare' to force an Adapter into an Awakening..."

"Is that the one that was created by that 'Naked' one?" Kashim frowned.

"So, you do know. Why did you ask if you knew?"

"I'm against it. We, the Rupture, only require one method. Repeating stabs and slashes? That kind of training only weakens you."

"..."

"True [Rupture] is made from the method that we have been using. We kill each other again and again. Only the strong that survive become true Awakeners. That is the only way."

"That method sacrifices too many lives..."

"Kashim, you too became an Awakener through that method. Are you saying you deny the effectiveness of the method?"

Kashim couldn't answer. He understood why Imai was so furious about this and how he felt. It was a woman who came out of the control room of the lab who stopped Imai.

"Personal complaints should remain at home, 3rd Captain."

"...If it isn't our 5th Captain. Didn't know you were here."

"This lab was MY lab from the start."

She was a blonde doctor with a white lab coat, 5th Captain, Mirel.

"And I will assure you that your concern is unnecessary."

Imai frowned.

"What do you mean? I thought you were going to use that 'naked' one's method?"

"No, the result from each method is too different. The 'Awakening' method that the Generalslayer used is very stable, but does not fit our needs. It

allows an Awakener to gain different unique worlds. Some even fail to get it."

"...Which means they do not get the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]?"

"That is right."

Yoonhwan then asked, "...If I may, can I ask what is it that you all are talking about?"

The air grew cold suddenly and Yoonhwan realized he made a mistake.

"You fool. How dare you interrupt while Captains are talking?"

"Don't be so stuck up, 3rd Captain."

Mirel then turned to Yoonhwan and smiled.

"Yes, what is the question?"

"..."

"Go ahead. It's okay."

Yoonhwan was hesitant, but started speaking as he looked at Mirel's smile.

"About the part where Awakeners get a different unique worlds..."

Mirel answered, "Yes, that is right. Usually, ordinary Awakeners have different unique worlds. Was that the question?"

"Does that mean that all Awakeners of Rupture all share the same unique world? For the ones who aren't 'ordinary'?"

Mirel seemed to be surprised to be asked such a question.

"You are right."

Chapter 159: God of Madness (6)

"But why..."

It seemed like Yoonhwan wasn't excited to hear it. Imai was annoyed and he tried to speak, but Mirel stopped him. She seemed to be intrigued.

"Yes, you might have questions if you are new to Rupture. I guess you know the basics of Awakening from the way you are asking questions?"

Yoonhwan answered while blushing, "Y-yes. I heard that it was the power that was created to fight the system."

"Right. Then do you know what the 'unique world' actually is?"

Yoonhwan then cited what he learned when he joined.

"It is the world that an Awakener creates to keep his sanity to withstand the flood of information. It is what you get eventually once you become a 3rd or higher step Awakener..."

"You've been well educated."

Mirel glanced over at Kashim, to which Kashim shrugged. Mirel then spoke.

"I guess your question can be summarized into this. If all Awakeners can create their own 'unique worlds', why does 'Rupture' force the use of the 'unique world'? Why is that necessary?"

Yoonhwan froze.

"And, you might be thinking that it's like this. You barely escaped from the System, but why is it necessary to get the 'unique world'? Isn't it same as being locked up in another System?"

"I- I didn't think to that extent."

Yoonhwan quickly responded and Mirel laughed softly.

"Don't worry. It's a natural question. All the Captains here also had the same question before."

"Count me out."

"Of course, Imai. You're an idiot."

"You...!"

Mirel ignored him and continued, "Your name was Yoonhwan?"

"Yes, ma'am. Kim Yoonhwan from World 294."

"World 294... That's good. I've recently been interested in books from World 294."

Mirel continued, "Okay, think about this. Let's say you are a 15-year-old right now."

Yoonhwan wasn't sure why age mattered, but he nodded anyway.

"You lost your parents and all of your family by accident. You cannot play the computer game that you love so much, or the books that you like to read. You cannot even go to school. Your entire life is shut off from the world."

Yoonhwan imagined himself as a 15-year-old who lost everything, including his family. It wasn't hard to imagine.

"The 'world' suddenly became very dangerous for you. The world now forces you to become an 'adult'. You now have to think and act like one."

Yoonhwan felt his heart sink.

"And, there are people who are after the will of your parents. There are people who are trying to undermine you while you are lost in your loneliness."

The Captains were now concentrating on Mirel's story.

"And you, at the age of 15, you have to fight the world with your limited wisdom. But there is a problem. You don't have much information. The only information you have is about a computer game and a book."

"..."

"What will you then? Do you think you could keep yourself together? With just a computer game and a book?"

Yoonhwan shook his head, "I probably can't."

"Right. That would be the outcome in most cases."

Mirel then became silent. Yoonhwan realized what she meant by the silence.

"You're saying that it will make me 15-year-old with more information."

Mirel smiled, "You are quick to understand. Right, that is what Rupture is doing. We are giving you 'ways' to fight against adults."

"And that is the 'unique world' from the Rupture?"

"We call it 'Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses'."

"That is a terrifying name."

"But it is fitting enough to fight against bad adults, right?"

She was right.

"Awakeners who receive a new unique world are mentally very weak. If you earn the 'Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses', however, it becomes a different story. You are still a 15-year-old, but a strong one at that. No adult will look down on you."

Yoonhwan became excited. He was going to receive the power to fight against Lords and Vicegerents. He'd receive the power to change the world. That's when Imai interrupted.

"Boring. So, what is the new method anyway?"

"I will show you now, so please don't interrupt."

"Hah, sure."

Soon, Mirel guided Yoonhwan and Seoyul to the small dome inside the lab. The dome's entrance closed and Seoyul looked at Yoonhwan with a concerned look. Mirel's voice came to them.

-Don't be afraid. Everyone within [Rupture] has gone through this.

The space around them then distorted immediately. There were now millions of people on a large, swampy land. Yoonhwan had a sword in his hand. Was this an illusion? Or was it real?

-Now, fight.

With her voice as a signal, a fight broke out. Yoonhwan frantically dodged the sword that was swung at him. There were familiar faces around him. He remembered their names. Sakamoto, the Science Teacher, Hwang Inchan the Swordpanic, Jay the Blacksmith... those were the members who fought through Tower of Nightmare with him before.

-Fight, until you kill them all.

Yoonhwan then realized where he was now. Kashim once told him that most of the members of Rupture were from what happened 700 years ago, when millions of people killed each other.

Screaming came from all sides as people killed each other. It was the repeat of what happened 700 years ago. This was worse than the Tower of Nightmares.

-If you become the last one standing, you will earn the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] and become the strongest 15-year-old.

Yoonhwan remembered Mirel's smile as she pushed him into the dome. He felt a chill from the smile as he thought about it. He felt like crying.

He wanted to say that he didn't want this. He wanted to become strong, but did not want something like this. Yet in next moment, he felt a sharp pain in his back. Thick, warm liquid was flowing down his back. He turned and there was a face that he wanted to see.

"J-Jaehwan..."

The sword penetrated deeper and Yoonhwan moaned.

"Jaehwan..."

Yoonhwan realized this was an illusion. There was no way that his only friend would try to kill him. But he wasn't so sure at the same time. Was this an illusion?

-Don't worry. You will feel pain, but you won't die. If you die, everything will start again.

Even if it was an illusion, could he forget everything he did because it was just an illusion?

-Remember. You will leave this place until you are the last one standing.

Yoonhwan fell to his knee. He thought it wasn't important if this was an illusion. There was something more important. No matter what it was, if he killed Jaehwan right now, he'd be an entirely different being from before.

He would only earn the power to get revenge by killing a friend he cared about. That was the only truth he had.

Jaehwan went on to kill others as he thought he had finished off Yoonhwan. Yoonhwan looked over to Jaehwan's back. He stood and saw Jaehwan's back clearly.

It was the back he trusted. It was the back he followed for a long, long time. Many thoughts passed by him. There were the memories of terror within the tower, and the fear of the future for being weak. Hatred toward his weak self. Despair and mourn... and the anger.

He clenched his sword as he walked forward.

Chapter 160: God of Madness (7)

Ra-hamad realized Jaehwan had not visited him for the past few weeks already. He calculated how many days had passed.

Two months.

The past two months had been busy, even for Ra-hamad when he recalled everything. After Jaehwan came to the Forest of Madness, Jaehwan had been asking Ra-hamad and the other people various questions.

"The leader that you speak of. Does he really exist?"

"Are you the Mad God?"

"Who are you? Follower of Geshtalt?"

"What is Ouroboros?"

As if he were a baby asking everything about everything, Jaehwan asked a lot of questions. There was only one answer he was able to get from all those questions.

Ouroboros.

Every question and answer started and finished with Ouroboros, and then began with Ouroboros again. It was an answer that did not explain anything. It was an answer where one couldn't tell whether it was the beginning or the end.

In fact, Ra-hamad and the other people had no way of explaining it entirely. Ouroboros was not something that could be explained. It was something

that struck at the moment of countless imagination, perception, and awakening. Or something that resembled that feeling. That was Ouroboros.

Ra-hamad never expected Jaehwan to understand. It was something even those who had metamorphosized for thousands of years could not get to.

'I didn't get to pull him out from the water recently.'

Currently, Jaehwan was at the hottest hot spring of the forest. It was the place where highly-trained warriors could barely stand for two hours. It was actually impossible for Jaehwan who had only been here for two months to even try in the first place.

The thought made Ra-hamad become more concerned.

'Did he die already?'

He shook his head.

'No, that's not possible. If he loses consciousness, I can feel it right away.'

There was no way for Ra-hamad, the Great Warrior, to not know of a powerful world power like Jaehwan disappearing. Besides, it was Ra-hamad who had been picking up Jaehwan from the spring for the past two .

'That is strange... the power does show that he is still inside that pool.'

Jaehwan's world power maintained a stable size for a few days. It wasn't possible. Even Ra-hamad could only stay at that pool for maybe a week. That's when something popped up in his mind.

'Did he finish his metamorphosis?'

No, that wasn't possible. Metamorphosis was a training that had no end. It was not meant to end.

But why? What was this feeling?

Ra-hamad began walking toward the pool. It was better to check it out for himself. At that moment, a young warrior appeared. Ra-hamad knew this young warrior who had been very popular amongst the other warriors. There was a rumor that he had huge 'Ouroboros', so Ra-hamad also knew of him.

'I think I saw this young warrior picking him up from the pool before.'

Ra-hamad called to the boy.

[Nas-.]

And Runald waved back.

"Oh, Great Warrior."

They shared a greeting. Runald was now able to speak the Long Living race's language quite a bit, so he had no problem talking with them. Ra-hamad looked at Runald's naked spirit and thought, 'What a great spirit. He will become a powerful warrior in 10 years if he is given the time.'

Spirit that could do such a thing with such talent and potential was hard to describe, but it could only be explained as Ouroboros-ish potential.

Runald answered Ra-hamad's question, "Jaehwan? I haven't seen him for the past few weeks either..."

It seemed that Runald had not visited the pool either.

"We were going there actually. How about you come with us?"

The man who had the scrubbing glove on next to Runald spoke. Ra-hamad knew about him also. He was man named Karavan, the Scrubber.

'Vicegerent of one of the 7 gods.'

Ra-hamad knew that Karavan was a Vicegerent the moment he saw him as one of the 7 Gods had visited this place a long time ago. It was very long, and the man gave up on training.

Runald grabbed Ra-hamad's hand.

"Let's go, Great Warrior."

Ra-hamad then began walking toward the pool with Runald and Karavan. After passing by countless hot springs, they were at the hottest hot spring within the area.

There he was, Jaehwan floating at the center of the spring, sitting down, meditating motionlessly. Runald screamed.

"WHAT?! Since when did he learn a floating Setting?"

"...That's weird. He doesn't have Reinholdt's Long Coat on either," Karavan also added curiously. It was only Ra-hamad who did not speak and looked carefully at Jaehwan's spirit.

'It is not a Setting.'

He was looking into Jaehwan's world power that was moving so vibrantly.

'That is amazing control of the power.'

Actually, flying in the air by using world power wasn't that hard. It just required the use of deflection against the ground. Maintaining it and staying still in the air was not easy.

'A balance between the spirit and the world... it is not possible to do without understanding the world power's characteristics.'

Ra-hamad then floated up with his world power. He felt Runald and Karavan becoming shocked at Ra-hamad floating in the air and moved toward Jaehwan slowly.

Jaehwan's world power that could be felt from the outside wasn't great. Maybe 200 thousand to 300 thousand? It was an easy target for any high-ranking God. But to Ra-hamad's eyes, Jaehwan wasn't just at the level of a high-ranking God. There was beautiful light glowing from Jaehwan's naked

body. It was a noble spirit's light that had achieved its state through endless metamorphosis. Ra-hamad asked a question in his language.

You like to take your clothes off quickly. No one's been faster than you.

Ra-hamad was not the type to complement. For the last one thousand years, Ra-hamad only complimented a certain Nightmare who visited them 900 years ago. Jaehwan looked up to Ra-hamad. A weird tension began to grow between them. Jaehwan spoke up.

"Let's fight."

[Nas. Girevia.]

You are not my match yet.

However, Jaehwan did not hesitate. His fist caused the waters to churn as he charged at Ra-hamad.

The two world powers clashing against each other as the power stormed the hot spring. Runald and Karavan jumped back while screaming. There were warriors coming to the hot spring as they felt the clash between world powers.

[Girevinok!]

Not enough!

Ra-hamad quickly waved his hands in the air and nullified Jaehwan's world power. It was an amazing movement. And the counter-attack by Ra-hamad wielded a great amount of world power.

"Jaehwan! Watch out!"

Chapter 161: God of Madness (8)

Runald shouted. There was the attack that wielded millions of world power. It was a power that Jaehwan could not handle, but he did not back down. It wasn't just some foolish pride that made him stand, but confidence that he knew he could take it.

At the moment of impact, Runald saw forming the shape of a small eye with his hands.

The water soared into the sky like an upside down waterfall as the world power pushed it up. Runald barely was able to get away from the heat with the help from the other warriors. The ground was burnt black where the water touched it. Runald watched his God fighting with a concerned look on his face. Jaehwan and Ra-hamad were now covered by the waterfall.

Soon, all the water fell and the two of them reappeared.

The warriors gasped and Runald opened his mouth dumbfoundedly.

'Oh my....'

Jaehwan was standing there with a calm look, and Ra-hamad was in the opposite direction, limping. It was apparent that Ra-hamad had taken damage.

Runald asked Karavan, "Did Jaehwan win?"

"I think he did."

"But how... Great Warrior has millions of world power."

"Didn't you see? Jaehwan instantly increased his world power, close to the Great Warrior's."

"In the millions?" Runald asked in shock. But how? Jaehwan was back to his 300 thousand world power now. Ra-hamad spoke.

[That was good.]

Jaehwan became curious. The voice wasn't the same as the usual language.

[You have learned Ouroboros.]

"Is this the Ouroboros you people speak of?"

[There are a lot of kinds in Ouroboros.]

Jaehwan frowned, expecting the usual nonsense.

"Isn't it about time we stop this nonsense trivia?" Jaehwan continued as he readied to attack again.

"I think it's time for you to tell me. Who is your leader? Why are you here?"

Ra-hamad then answered as he defended himself against Jaehwan's punch. He went back to using his language.

[Nas. Pert. Narata.]

You still have questions.

"Yeah, you will answer Ouroboros again, but I thought I would ask for the last time."

[...Ouroboros.]

"As expected."

Multiple explosions filled the air. It was as if missiles were striking each other. As the sound died down, the fighting stopped again. Jaehwan asked,

"Okay. If you will not speak, I will speak for myself. I guess you don't mind that?"

[...What do you mean?]

"I will let you listen to what I found out. It's up to you if you want to answer to that."

Jaehwan held up both hands, signaling that he had no intention to fight anymore and before Ra-hamad could say anything, he continued, "You might know already, but I reached the end of this hot spring a week ago."

[...!!]

Ra-hamad's face turned. It seemed like he had expected it, but he was still shocked to actually hear it.

"There was no leader there. There was just a short song and a drawing."

At the end of the hot spring, Jaehwan found a drawing and short song lyrics. To be exact, it was a drawing of a giant snake eating its tail, with the lyrics written at the center.

Naked God.

The place where he left.

Only left with clothes.

As he read the lyrics, Jaehwan realized this was the hidden verse of the Naked Song. And if his guess was correct, this was the last verse. The Naked God who returned home without killing anyone, left home again.

And now, Jaehwan had an idea who this Naked God was.

'Geshtalt. This is Geshtalt's song.'

One of the Three Ancient Gods, Geshtalt, was the one who fought Daeus. He was probably the Naked God that appeared in this song. This song

probably depicted Geshtalt's story and what he really did. Jaehwan touched the drawing of the snake as he read the lyrics.

And after a while, an awakening so violent struck his entire spirit.

...

With the feeling of a galaxy shooting past his entire head, Jaehwan realized a small secret of 'Ouroboros'. He also understood why these people answered everything in Ouroboros. At the end of his understanding, Ra-hamad spoke.

[I see. So you know everything now.]

The voice seemed sad. The entire race had gathered around the hot spring. They were looking at Jaehwan like a death-sentenced convict waiting for his time. Jaehwan looked at them for a moment and said, "You all once said that you are Geshtalt, but not Geshtalt."

It was actually Ouroboros that translated that for Jaehwan.

"You also said that Geshtalt does not believe in God. Right?"

Ra-hamad nodded.

"Yet, that is a strange word. You all have Geshtalt's [Setting] and dearly stick to Geshtalt's tradition called 'Metamorphosis'. But you are not his Followers, nor do you believe in Gods...."

Runald and Karavan then turned serious as if they realized something.

"I was a fool. I should've known then. There's only one kind that doesn't believe in Gods in [Depth]."

Jaehwan looked at them closely. They all had very similar features, so it was hard to tell them apart. It was as if one person had divided into many.

"You are all Gods with one name."

Beings who don't believe in Gods — it was the Gods themselves.

The problem was, who were they? And everyone already had the answer.

Silence fell. Runald and Karavan began shaking helplessly. It was the name that brought fears. One of the Three Ancient Gods that had left a deep fear within [Depth].

"Geshtalt, the Ancient God."

They were one with one of the Three Ancient Gods? Runald looked around in fear and asked, "A-are you all really Geshtalt? Every one of you?"

A God who was one, but also many. Countless heads moved in unison, and Runald became pale. But Jaehwan wasn't finished yet.

"They are all Geshtalt, but they also aren't Geshtalt."

Runald and Karavan became confused. They weren't sure what Jaehwan was talking about.

Naked God.

The place where he left.

Only left with clothes.

Jaehwan recited the lyrics with no melody. Therefore, it was easy to picture the words as well. As they listened, Runald and Karavan imagined a big, giant snake eating away at its tail, leaving many pieces of skin at the tail.

'This...'

They both understood. Yes, the word 'Ouroboros' really fit them.

Jaehwan looked at Ra-hamad with a sad expression and asked, "You all are the 'clothes' that Geshtalt took off. Isn't that right?"

Chapter 162: God of Madness (9)

That was a long-forgotten story. A forgotten history that had been hidden away for a millennia.

There was no word such as you or me, and because of that, there were no fights, competitions, or war. And because of that, there was no 'being'. It was the beginning of time where all Gods and spirits stayed naked and lived under 'one world'.

That's when 'clothes' appeared.

Nobody knew who invented it or who wore it first, but it appeared.

All the ancient Gods who lived in [Depth] a long time ago wore clothes as it was widely used. Some Gods knew that it wasn't just something for covering and protecting the body. They realized that there was more to it. Some Gods also began to say such words.

-All 'beings' appeared with the clothes.

Of course, it didn't make sense. Life or spirits existed before clothes. In fact, it was them who created those clothes. Yet the 'being' described here did not equal a life or a spirit. The Ancient Gods spoke of this.

-A being is one who calls 'me' a 'me.'

The made clothes and wore them to protect oneself from the world but also separating one from it. One realized oneself as 'one' apart from the world.

That was how clothes appeared and spirits began calling themselves 'me'.

"It's too complicated. I can't understand a thing," Runald stated with an uncomfortable look. This was too complicated for a boy who had never been educated. Karavan said, "Let me explain it easily, Runald."

Karavan smiled as he grabbed Runald's shoulder.

"Who do I look like?"

"...uh, Karavan?"

"Yeah, but what else? What do you see?"

"Uh, a naked pervert?"

Karavan was triggered, but he held up his scrubbing glove with his hand and asked, "Then, what do you think this is?"

"A scrubbing glove?"

"Do you suppose that this too is clothing?"

"I guess so."

Runald nodded and Karavan put on both gloves on his hands.

"Here. How do I look now? What do you think I am?"

Runald looked at Karavan with the scrubbing gloves but bare naked otherwise. Karavan quickly realized what Runald was thinking.

"I'm being serious. Tell me."

"A scrubber, I guess."

"Exactly."

"...What?"

"A person who's nothing becomes a scrubber if they put on a scrubbing glove. If you pick up a sickle, you become a farmer. Isn't that right?"

"Uh... Maybe?"

"That's what we are talking about."

Runald then realized. A spirit becoming an entirely different being just with the clothes they're wearing — it wasn't complicated at all.

"So, does that means that clothes make the kind of people we are?"

"Yeah, something like that," Karavan smiled. But Runald didn't seem satisfied.

"That's still flawed logic. A prince can disguise themselves as a bum, or a bum could wear a suit."

"Uh, yeah..."

Karavan became dumbfounded and Runald continued, "And there might be a naked pervert with a scrubbing glove on. But it doesn't change the fact that the person is a 'pervert'."

Some warriors laughed at the words and before Karavan could respond to it, Runald quickly concluded the subject.

"Then isn't it wrong to think that 'clothes' label a being?"

Karavan seemed to be lost for words. Runald was too smart to give a definite explanation. Besides, Karavan didn't understand everything about the 'clothes' either.

"And if that's the case, what about us? We're naked right now. Are we not even a 'being' then?"

"No, it's not like that Runald."

Jaehwan answered instead. Runald turned to Jaehwan.

"Then what? What are we?"

"We are not naked right now."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"Runald, there no being who's naked in this world."

"What are you saying? We are..."

Runald then stopped as he realized something. The 'clothes' didn't just mean physical clothes here. Jaehwan tried to continue, but Runald stopped him.

"N-no! Don't tell me anything. I think I'm catching onto something."

However, Runald wasn't sure what he was getting at. So, Runald began tracing back to the beginning of the subject.

'Why did we start talking about clothes?'

He remembered. They were talking about the Long Living race and Geshtalt.

-You all are the 'clothes' Geshtalt took off. Isn't that it?

It all started from Jaehwan's words. There was probably a hint there. Runald began concentrating on finding his answer himself. Karvan then turned to Ra-hamad and asked, "Let's continue. What happened to the clothes then?"

Clothes are being.

Clothes are ego.

Clothes...

Clothes could be defined by various terms. Gods didn't limit what the clothes were, but they concentrated on what happened to the [Depth] after the clothes appeared.

The beginning of beings with clothes — there were people who separated themselves from the world.

This meant that the world was no longer 'one'. Beings who called themselves 'me' expressed themselves with emotions that never existed before. They said-

I trust you.

I believe you.

I love you.

Love. Trust. Those were words only a 'being' could use. And with these motions, the Gods were put to a test. Beings who became 'individuals' began to believe in a certain God, or came to love and began to have 'taste'. And this brought about devastating consequences.

Gods who were liked were allowed to wield powerful 'world power', while the Gods who were abandoned met their demise.

Demise?

To the Gods who had lived for an eternity, it was a huge threat. It was natural for them to create their own worlds and become separated. They had to try hard to have others to believe themselves and the competition came naturally.

Gods could not coexist like before. The Crusade then started.

"...So, it was the clothes that made the world turn to this?"

[Yes.]

Ra-hamad answered Karavan's question. Karavan could not stop but laugh hollowly. It his first time learning about the history before Big Brother. Even Ignis hadn't told him about this.

"The world was torn apart because of such a reason...? What were these Ancient Gods?"

[We cannot blame them. They had to choose to survive.]

"Yeah, but..."

[And because they all acquired 'different worlds', there came the diversity. This did not exist before.]

"It brought war, and the spirits now try to kill each other just because we have different worlds."

[That is also the truth.]

Karavan thought it was a complicated problem.

The world turned because of 'clothes'. A being became perfectly 'me', allowing it to trust or love another. It was a good thing, but it also learned to hate and kill others.

It was all because of clothes.

Karavan then pondered on the question. Which one was better? Someone spoke then.

"It's better for everyone to have diversity without killing another."

It was Jaehwan.

"Y-yes! I know. That's the answer!"

Karavan felt it was strange as he couldn't reach that answer himself. He looked at Jaehwan.

"This man..."

Karavan knew why he couldn't think of the answer. It was because it was impossible.

Beings with different worlds were bound to be hostile against each other. The history of [Depth] itself was proof. However, it wasn't only limited to [Depth] either.

Difference meant conflict. It was the truth, but Jaehwan was resisting against that.

"Was there a God that tried to stop the war?" Jaehwan asked.

Ra-hamad answered.

[Yes.]

"And that's..."

Ra-hamad nodded.

[There were those who realized the true nature of clothes, and used it to gain the power to control this world. They were humans, but they overcame human limitations to become Gods themselves.]

It was easy to guess who they were.

[The first human Awakeners. Three Ancient Gods.]

Chapter 163: God of Madness (10)

Ancient Three Gods.

Human spirits who became Gods.

These were Gods who were born through the 'clothes' and were more sensitive toward it. That allowed them to become more powerful than any other God by using these 'clothes'. Yet, their characteristics differed from the different answers they had in regards to the clothes.

What are clothes?

Daeus' answer was this:

-Clothes are weapons.

Daeus realized clothes could be a powerful armor against other worlds, but also a powerful weapon. Therefore, he collected many clothes as possible and analyzed it all to create the 'Strongest Clothing' that could not be destroyed. Then, he created the 'Machina'.

And there was another who answered differently.

-Clothes are contagious.

It was Catastrophe. He realized that spirits were influenced by others to wear similar clothes. He utilized this characteristic to forcefully create Followers, which was the Void Sword. It was the [Part] that made all beings become 'Dead Men' by touching it, and this was the result of his idea.

And the third God answered differently.

-Clothes are something you take it off.

It was the Naked God, the creator of [Naked] Setting. Geshtalt.

Daeus hid himself underneath powerful clothes. Catastrophe plagued many to become his Followers to grow in power. Geshtalt, freely traveled through [Depth], naked.

These Three Ancient Gods were requested to end the never-ending war with the other Gods and agreed. They all gathered at the site that was called The Great Forest to discuss it.

How could they end the war? The Three Gods had different answers.

Daeus said that everyone can wear his clothes.

Geshtalt said that everyone can take off their clothes.

Catastrophe said that everyone can become his Follower.

Their opinions were different and they each unsheathed their weapons. This was what happened 210 million years ago.

Karavan spoke then.

"The Three Gods War! That was the beginning!"

[Yes.]

"I know a bit about what happened then. Big Brother appeared after that war. If only that war didn't happen..."

Jaehwan listened to Karavan and Ra-hamad silently. He didn't know anything about this war and from listening, it seemed that Three Ancient Gods were driven out from that war and Big Brother became the master of [Depth].

Ra-hamad said,

[We were pulled out from Geshtalt then. Or to be exact, we were taken off.]

Runald screamed suddenly at that moment.

"....UGH! I can't think of it!"

"What?"

"Jaehwan, what are clothes? What do you mean that anyone can't take it off?"

"Were you still stuck on that?"

Karavan sighed at Runald.

"It's important!"

"Hey, we are not talking about..."

"Yes, it's important." Jaehwan nodded toward Runald and added, "You will not understand what happened to these people if you don't understand that."

"Right! That's what I am saying!" Runald then spoke again. "Jaehwan, so what are clothes? Can you make it simple?"

"There's no point in saying it. I can explain with it something similar, but it doesn't mean the same thing. The meaning becomes useless once it is put to words."

"...I see. I get it." Runald nodded and answered, "Then let me change the question. What about the clothes we wear that changes our being?"

"Like a scrubbing glove making you become a scrubber?"

"Yeah." Runald smiled. "I see that the 'clothes' you or the Great Warrior speaks of aren't about physical clothes. But there are things that can't be explained. For example..."

Runald paused for a second before he continued, "You have a sword, but that doesn't make you a swordsman. You can cook with it, or you can chop down a tree. Then, are you a swordsman, a cook, or a lumberjack? If the clothes define who you are, then what happens with this?"

Jaehwan tried to speak, but someone interrupted.

[That is interesting Ouroboros.]

Ra-hamad's voice filled the area. Runald was surprised as he didn't expect Ra-hamad to answer. What he continued with was even more surprising.

[You are right. How can ones' clothes determine one's being?]

"...What?"

Ra-hamad's words were the exact opposite of what he had been saying before. Runald was at a loss for words and Ra-hamad continued speaking.

[But the clothes still choose who you are.]

"...What are you talking about?"

Runald began to anticipate where this was going. This man would say nonsense for a while and end with 'Ouroboros' at the end. Soon, Runald found out that his expectations were wrong. Ra-hamad said this:

[Let me say this. You are a naked boy.]

Runald became confused and answered, "...Yeah. I am a naked boy."

[And you are a Follower of Jaehwan.]

"Yes. A loyal and faithful Follower that is," Runald agreed.

[And you are a friend of the criminal, Karavan.]

"What are you talking about? I'm not a friend of this boy."

Ra-hamad continued,

[And you are a large Ouroboros of the Long Living race.]

"...Is that sexual harassment?"

Some warriors cackled as Runald answered.

[And you are...]

Ra-hamad kept on going with different descriptions. You are that, you are this... Runald stopped answering, and Ra-hamad also stopped speaking. Runald was then struck with the truth. He mumbled with a hollow voice "... I see. Why didn't I know that before?"

The reason why a prince is still a prince even if he is wearing a bum's clothes. The reason why no one can truly be naked. The reason why Ra-hamad said of all that. Runald now understood. He said, "We don't just wear 'one' piece of clothing."

Ra-hamad nodded. Runald now realized what the clothes were. It wasn't ego or a personality. Clothes were the core elements that formed beings. The clothes... were themselves.

"We are beings created with countless 'clothes'."

Ra-hamad mumbled Ouroboros.

"Then that means you are the clothes of Geshtalt..."

"They are particles of Geshtalt himself," Jahewan answered instead. Ra-hamad was looking at Jaehwan now. Runald then became pale and shook. That was the reason why these people were Geshtalt and also not Geshtalt. "Ra-hamad. Why did Geshtalt disappear after taking all of you off?"

[That's...]

"Does that have to do with Geshtalt's [Part]?"

Jaehwan didn't miss a vital point in the long story. There was one thing Ra-hamad didn't speak of in the long history of the [Depth]. There was one thing that he failed to describe.

Jaehwan now knew why Andersen sent him here. He lost to Machina two months ago, and the only thing that could fight against one of the [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods was another [Part] from them.

[You always exceed our expectations. You are right. We became this because of the [Eye of Geshtalt].]

The last [Part] of the Three Ancient Gods. A weapon that could fight against the Machina. Jaehwan realized that he had finally reached the end of the long questions. This time, Ra-hamad was the one to ask him a question.

[Let me ask you this time.]

Ask? Jaehwan felt strange. It was always him who asked. Jaehwan nodded.

[Jaehwan. What do you think 'metamorphosis' is?]

Jaehwan couldn't answer. He didn't understand metamorphosis yet. He understood everything about clothes and Ouroboros, but the metamorphosis was different.

"It's hard to explain... but isn't it taking off clothes? Dividing the being?"

Jaehwan remembered the voices he heard as he went through the process of taking off his clothes. He realized that it was the voice of his many clothes stored deep within. Ra-hamad asked,

[Then why do you think we continue doing so?]

Jaehwan hesitated and answered, "To increase world power?"

[...You do not get it yet. Then let me ask you this. Why do you think that metamorphosis increases your world power?]

Why? Jaehwan didn't have an answer to that at all. If unclothing was to remove a being from within, metamorphosis should have decreased the world power. Ra-hamad then said,

[The answer is this. 'Metamorphosis' does not increase your world power.]

"...What do you mean?"

[You are right in saying that metamorphosis just divides your being.]

"What..."

[As you know, there are only two ways to increase world power in [Depth]. Take it away from other Gods, or gain Followers who believe in you.]

That was impossible. If those were the only ways, then how did Jaehwan increase his power through metamorphosis?

"Wait. Then how did Geshtalt increase his power? He didn't kill anyone."

Jaehwan remembered what Andersen said. There was the song of a naked God who had not killed anyone. If the song was true, then Geshtalt never killed another God to steal world power.

"Did he gain the power through Followers?"

Ra-hamad did not answer. Instead, he began singing a short song along with the other warriors.

Lonely, naked God.

Without a single friend.

Without a single friend.

They were gloomy lyrics, but the melody was so bright and happy. It seemed like the striking irony was trying to say something. Jaehwan became confused.

"No Followers? Then how..."

[A faith can be there even without a Follower.]

Jaehwan then realized. Gods received 'faith' from Followers to increase their world power. The faith was something to be given by others. It was an emotion given by a being that had no relation to itself.

Then who was this being? It was simple. Someone other than me.

Jaehwan looked at Ra-hamad. Ra-hamad was smiling sadly.

Geshtalt was a God who never took a world or forced his own upon others.

What did he do to increase his power? Jaehwan knew the answer now. He looked at each one of the people here.

"...Geshtalt gave up and made himself a Follower. You are Geshtalt and a Follower of Geshtalt."

The secret of Geshtalt — that was the loneliest faith in the world.

Chapter 164: God of Madness (11)

"Making himself a Follower? What did that mean? Does he believe in himself?"

Ronald and Karavan seemed to be confused while listening. What did it mean to divide itself? Whatever it was, it was nothing like believing himself. The only one who could imagine what it was like was Jaehwan. He looked down at his hands.

'Then the reason why my world power increased is...'

Jaehwan remembered the voices of his clothes. Were they also beings that were pulled apart from him? Were they here somewhere in this world, sending him faith? If that was what happened, it was terrifying. Jaehwan became concerned if he had done something irreversible.

Ra-hamad said,

[Do not worry. You will not turn into one of us.]

It seemed like he was assuring Jaehwan.

[As you might guess, the metamorphosis doesn't divide your spirit. It just exists within you.]

"Then why..."

[The reason why spirits are divided materialistically is because they took off too many clothes to make the 'real' body disappear.]

Ra-hamad continued,

[The number of clothes increases as time passes and you gain more experience. However, Geshtalt took off more than the time he lived. His 'metamorphosis' speed had exceeded his time.]

Ra-hamad then paused and looked around. Many of his people were looking at him.

[Our number decreased as time passed, but we had a lot more before.]

Ra-hamad reminisced about the people who had disappeared. Jaehwan asked, "...Why did Geshtalt take off so many clothes?"

[Because of the war.]

It was expected, but it was hard to imagine. Geshtalt must have been at least hundreds of thousands of years old. Maybe millions. He should have had countless clothes. But if he had to take all of that off to exchange it for his world power, it meant he was that desperate. The enemy was that much stronger that he did not even realize that he himself was disappearing.

Jaehwan became unsure. If Machina was that much more powerful, than he thought he couldn't defeat Myad. He mumbled without realizing, "Machina was that strong...?"

[...What are you saying?]

Karavan interrupted, "Are you saying you became like this by fighting Daeus? You said the war..."

[I don't know what you are saying. The Three God War wasn't a war against the Three Ancient Gods.]

Jaehwan and the others became dumbfounded. What was this? Then who did they fight that resulted in a giant site to be laid in ruins?

[...So, I guess the wrong story is still being considered as the truth. That Nightmare from 900 years ago also had it wrong.]

Nightmare from 900 years ago? Jaehwan quickly asked, "Are you talking about Mulack Armelt?"

Ra-hamad nodded.

[I see, so you do know him.]

It seemed like he expected it.

[I can feel his 'clothes' within you.]

It seemed like he was talking about the [Record of the Depth] that Mulack had left. Jaehwan asked, "Why did he come here? What did he get from here?"

Ra-hamad then became curious.

[That's weird. If you have his clothes, then you must have his memory.]

"The memory is not complete."

Ra-hamad looked at Jaehwan with understanding and spoke.

[That Nightmare was the first to go through that pool. He took [Eye of Geshtalt] from there.]

Jaehwan then became dumbfounded. He expected Mulack to have visited the place, but he never thought the man had gotten something.

"The [Eye of Geshtalt] has already been taken?!"

Runald and Karavan also seemed to be shocked. Runald's expression made it look like all had been lost.

[What is going on?]

Ra-hamad asked, but no one answered. He then smiled, realizing something.

[I see. So, you all were here to get the [Eye of Geshtalt].]

"T-that's..."

Runald shook his head and tried to deny it, concerned that their intention would make Ra-hamad uncomfortable. Jaehwan answered instead.

"Yes."

It was a simple answer. Ra-hamad didn't seem to be mad either.

[Then you have nothing to be worried about.]

"What do you mean?"

[You already have the [Eye of Gehstalt].]

"...I do?"

[You do not know?]

Ra-hamad continued,

[[Eye of Geshtalt] is not a Part that has a physical form like Machina. Everyone who understands Ouroboros can use it.]

Jaehwan then looked down at himself doubtfully. His body did become much lighter and had increased world power, but he didn't feel like he had gotten the [Part]. He then unleashed his world power to look at his unique world. It was still barren and dark. Nothing changed. It looked like Ra-hamad could also see the unique world, and he turned toward Jaehwan's direction and spoke.

[You think nothing has changed. It is natural. Nothing did change.]

"What's all this nonsense?"

[I don't know why, but you already had the [Eye of Geshtalt]. You just didn't know how to use it.]

Ra-hamad then looked up to the sky — to the giant eye at the center of the dark sky. Jaehwan then suddenly felt like everything underneath his waist had disappeared.

[You see the 'eye' there. Do you not?]

Then...

[I'm not sure if you know, but the only one who can see the 'eye' is the 'eye.']

Jaehwan felt as if he was struck with lightning. Something was awakening within him.

[Open your eyes. You can now 'see'.]

Jaehwan's left eye began to shine brightly in white light. In his iris, some weird symbol was spinning there. It was not a circle, however.

A snake biting its tail. Ouroboros.

Ra-hamad then shouted.

[YES! That eye is the eye that allows you to see through every 'clothing'!
The destroyer of all laws and illusions! Eye of Geshtalt!]

Jaehwan now realized. His unclothing and questionnaires were preparation for him to understand the [Eye of Geshtalt]. He looked inside him by using the Eye of Geshtalt. He was filled with familiar voices.

-Why? What are you looking at?

-Are you taking off again?

In the next moment, his world power doubled. His clothes provided him world power through faith.

'This was the power of the Eye of Geshtalt...'

Jaehwan now was able to unclothe himself anytime he wanted increase his world power. Until his clothes were no more, he did not have to worry about running out of world power. Ra-hamad smiled satisfyingly.

[I assume you have more questions, but I won't tell you anymore. You won't need any answers.]

Jaehwan did not ask why. He knew why already as he now began to look into the [Record of the Depth] by using his [Eye of Geshtalt], looking into Mulack's 'clothes'. The clothes began to talk of the story of one who began to climb up the Tree of Imagery to stop Cultivation.

It was a long story filled with despair and sadness, but there was faint hope. Jaehwan had heard the story a long, long time ago.

Chapter 165: God of Madness (12)

In the deep darkness, there was a strange crying sound.

Every spirit of in [Chaos] knew what this crying was from. The spirits were busy running away once they heard the cries and never came back. It was because these were cries from Dead Men.

Today, their cries were different. It seemed like they were in pain. Something twisted them within the darkness and exploded. Then the cries stopped.

[It's boring.]

The darkness spoke and all the Dead Men within the darkness flinched. There was no way that they could fight against the one who spoke in this space.

'Boring?'

Sole-King Catastrophe, the master of Dead Man Palace, felt that it was strange that he had said such a thing. It had been so long since he felt this kind of feeling.

He had a guess as to why he was feeling such human-like emotion so suddenly. It was probably because of the recent link. The beings that were connected by the link shared each other's emotions. Unlike Catastrophe who had no emotion left in him, the humans had many and various emotions. That was probably what made him feel needless emotions.

'Puny human.'

Catastrophe did not like this at all.

'He made me do all this stupid work and disappeared.'

He looked at the giant summoning circle placed down in the darkness. It was not here a few months ago as it was originally at the Palace of Reincarnation instead of Dead Man Palace. Catastrophe still remembered the voice of the human who offered to install this summoning circle.

-Kill everyone that is summoned here. That's my deal. It's not much to you anyway, is it? I think you'll feel bored being stuck in this darkness all day.

Of course, that human was Jaehwan. Thinking back to it now, Catastrophe was not sure what made him accept such a deal.

'...Well, this does make it less boring,' he thought as he looked down at the summoning circle. It was quite fun to kill the Generals being summoned here as they died at the [Great Lands]. It was also fun to play interesting games with all the Generals that were summoned.

The [Great Lands] was at war because of Jaehwan's 'General Massacre' before he left [Chaos]. Darkness controlled the 9th region, and the other Lords began attacking the region. Thus, Catastrophe had fun killing all these Generals that were sent up.

However, that was over now. No Generals had been summoned for the past few weeks.

It wasn't definite, but he could only guess that the Lords of the [Great Lands] had probably realized something. As for Catastrophe, he lost his only hobby.

'And it's been a while since I lost a link with him.'

Catastrophe then looked up as he remembered the human's face. It had been three months since he lost the link with Jaehwan.

'Why did it have to break now?'

He felt something being cut, and after he realized it, it was too late. He tried to take control, but it was all too late. The link that was made by facing him

had been broken.

There was no way for it to happen. Even if Jaehwan was against an enemy who could cut the link, the link between Catastrophe and Jaehwan wasn't that easy to break. If it was broken, then there was only one possible reason, and it was also the worst possible reason.

Return of the Machina.

That was the only possible way to break Catastrophe's link, which was made by one of the Three Ancient Gods.

Of course, there was a way to recover the broken link. Actually, two. One was to use the [Eye of Geshtalt]. When using the Setting stored within the [Eye of Geshtalt], the link could be recovered right away. But it had not been long since he went up to [Depth]. There was no way for Jaehwan to get his hands on the [Eye of Geshtalt] so quickly. Then, that only left the second choice.

The second way to recover the broken link was to just wait. The way Machina destroyed the link was not permanent, and the destroyed link would be restored given enough time. The only problem was whether Jaehwan could survive until the link recovered.

'Maybe I should've taught him various things before sending him up there.'

It was too late now. Who would have thought that Jaehwan would face the enemy using Daeus' Machina?

'...He'll take care of it,' Catastrophe thought as he remembered Jaehwan's lonely unique world. Yes, he was going to find the answer. Catastrophe could feel it.

'Huh?'

That's when he felt something. The summoning circle began to shine. It was the signal that dead Generals were being summoned.

Prey.

He thought it was a good opportunity to kill time. He could enjoy killing these Generals, the link would soon return to normal, and then he'd find out what was going on.

But then, Catastrophe became tense. There were more than just one or two of them. And they were all more powerful than average.

'What are they?'

Catastrophe quickly gathered all the Dead Men within the Palace. It probably was no help considering the power of the ones being summoned, but it was better than none.

It was not like Catastrophe to become nervous at a few Generals. If it was before he was sealed away, he could have killed at least ten or twenty of them easily.

It was different now. Maybe three or four... that was his limit. They were that powerful.

'Wait, these ones...'

Catastrophe felt his guess was right as their world power became apparent. There were only a few who could have this much world power. Soon, the light turned off and a total of eleven figures appeared.

The world power of the eleven pressured the Dead Man Palace. The Dead Men panted in fear.

These were Lords, each with the power to finish [Chaos] individually. Even if Jaehwan came back, there was no way for him to face these Generals. Even if one of them escaped the Dead Man Palace, [Chaos] was done for. Their voices then came from the darkness.

"Oh, so the Palace of Reincarnation really did disappear."

"Yeah, now I realize why no one returned."

"Haha, it's been so long since I last came here by dying."

"I thought everyone would just feign death. You all succeeded in killing yourselves."

After a while, someone's voice quieted everyone down.

"Let's cut out the noise. The master of this place awaits us."

Then they appeared through the darkness. The one at the center had the most powerful world power. Catastrophe knew who he was. He was one of the Lords who sealed Catastrophe along with Big Brother, and he was the ruler of the 9th region of the [Great Lands].

"Long time no see, Catastrophe."

The Lord of Darkness, Gerome, was standing along with ten other Lords...

'I guess I might not be able to keep the promise with him.'

Catastrophe smiled within the darkness.

Chapter 166: Rupture (1)

Before the fall, every living being who lived in the [Great Lands] and [Chaos] believed that the [Great Lands] was the land of the living, and [Chaos] was the land of the dead.

Of course, this wasn't an entirely wrong assumption as the [Great Lands] did require a physical body for one to live there while spirits lived in [Chaos].

But to strictly confine the matter about the land of the living and the dead proved to be dangerous, especially by the beings that lived there.

Some said the following:

-Labeling these lands for the living and the dead is the worst deed that the Lords of the [Great Lands] had ever done.

It was true. Because of that label, countless beings considered the 'land of the living' as the ultimate land to live in, and they dreamed of revival through the [Fruits].

It was the beginning of beings who thought the [Great Lands] (Land of living) as 'true' life.

This longing for true life became the cornerstone to the Lords' petty schemes in keeping the [Great Lands] in its warring state, and they successfully utilized the longing to maintain a stable number of Generals for thousands of years.

...(skipped)...

And from what has been uncovered, most of these thoughts were the outcome of the scheme of the Lords of the 12 regions.

Their faithful followers brought many famous words from the remote lands to glorify the land of the living and its spirits.

...(skipped)...

This is the darkest part of our history. Today, we consider the body to be just a form of a 'prison'.

-From the [World before the fall]

Poet – Euphrates

Episode – Rupture

In a palace somewhere in the 8th site [Caspion]...

There had been some weird tensions brewing in [Highseeker], the newfound capital of [Rupture]. It was very apparent in the Captain's meeting room where the Captains were gathered.

"It's today."

"Yes, today."

4th Captain Kashim and 5th Captain Mirel spoke almost instantly. They seemed to be determined. Then, someone entered the room.

"4th Captain!"

Two regular members entered. The first one who came in was very handsome and had thick eyebrows. The only downside was that he had a big scar on his cheek that he seemed to have gotten recently.

"4th Captain. Is it true?"

"Why are you here?"

"Is it true, sir?"

The man ignored Kashim's question and asked again. Kashim frowned and asked back, "What are you talking about?"

"The Lords. Are they really coming here?"

"You are being rude, Yoonhwan," Mirel interrupted instead. Yoonhwan then took a step back, understanding his impolite behavior. After the [Simulation], Yoonhwan was a bit more careful around Mirel. Mirel also glanced over at the woman who came with him.

"...Seoyul. You're here too."

"Yes, 5th Captain."

Mirel was known for her beauty, but she was still no match for the woman. Han Seoyul's beauty was outstanding. Mirel read Seoyul's frustration along with Yoonhwan's concern and sighed.

"Yes, it is true. Lords are coming here today."

".....Here?"

"Yes."

Yoonhwan seemed to be troubled. The Lords were coming to the land of Rupture.

"Is it war?"

"No."

"Then...?"

"I would say that it's a treaty."

Yoonhwan shouted in disbelief.

"Impossible!"

Treaty with the Lords? That was not possible to understand, nor was it possible to accept either. They were at the top of the food chain in Cultivation, and an enemy of all [Products]. There was nothing to discuss with them. Yoonhwan gritted his teeth.

"I didn't join Rupture for this...!"

"Of course," Kashim answered this time. "I know how you feel. But the Lords are strong. We can't just fight them because we are blinded by our rage."

Kashim looked down at the tea that Mirel poured for him and continued, "Our final goal is [Big Brother]. We have to put aside our differences for the greater goal."

"What are you talking about? The Lords or Big Brother are all same thing in the end."

"....Hmm?"

Kashim looked as if he didn't hear what Yoonhwan said and Yoonhwan snapped at him.

"Are you making fun of me?"

It had been two months since he had passed the simulation. And during those two months, Yoonhwan had undergone many missions as a member of Rupture, gaining a lot of knowledge about [Depth]. And among the knowledge he gained, he learned of something that he had not even thought of before.

"I know that the Great Lands is the 1st site of the [Depth] that Big Brother controls."

The [Great lands], which everyone thought to be the center of this universe, was actually only a site of the [Depth]. There was no land of the living, and

the 'body' was the only thing that showed differences between the 1st site and the others.

"The Lords are Big Brother's Vicegerents. You are saying that we will work with them to fight their master."

Kashim smiled, "Seems like you've been busy."

"I know enough, sir."

"Yes, you are right. Lords are Vicegerents. But you see..."

Kashim sipped on the tea and continued, "It doesn't mean that the Lords and Big Brothers are 'one'."

"What are you..."

"I assume you know this already, but Yoo Surha resigned from the 2nd Captain position."

Yoo Surha left Rupture. This was a very famous incident that everyone knew. Yoonhwan also even saw her when he first joined Rupture. The woman was as beautiful as Seoyul. He just didn't realize his first meeting with her was the last.

"Why are you talking about that now?"

"I thought you pick up on it. How disappointing," Mirel answered. It seemed like she realized what Kashim was trying to say. Yoonhwan thought about it. Big Brother and the Lords weren't same, but what did that have to do with Yoo Surha leaving Rupture?

Then, Seoyul spoke.

"Sharing the same world doesn't mean you both share the same goal."

"You are right. Good job, Seoyul," Mirel answered and Yoonhwan then realized why Kashim spoke of Surha. Surha had left Rupture, but she still

had Rupture's unique world, [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]. Even if she had the same world, she decided to walk a different path.

"You mean not all Lords are fine with what Big Brother is doing?"

"Yes. You're so slow," Kashim laughed.

"It didn't seem to make sense at first."

"Of course, our master isn't like Big Brother. I was just making an example."

Whatever it was, it did seem possible. If some Lords were against Big Brother, it was better to work with them to fight against Big Brother than going at it alone.

"But I can't accept it."

Chapter 167: Rupture (2)

"...Here comes the stubborn again."

"I'm not being stubborn. It's a matter of justice."

"What are you talking about?"

"We cannot accept the smaller evil just because we are against the greater evil. Rupture is not that kind of place."

Yoonhwan spoke fiercely and Kashim became silent. Yoonhwan believed Kashim understood what he was getting at, but Kashim smiled bitterly.

"You are still young. You have not experienced enough of the world."

"No! It's not about that! I am..."

"Yes. It is."

Yoonhwan felt as if he was being trampled upon. Kashim spoke to him.

"A dream requires sacrifices for it to become real. As you know, there is no perfect justice in the world."

Yes, that he knew. Yoonhwan knew that. But...

'He would've said differently.'

Yoonhwan remembered someone else. When everyone said no. When everyone gave up on the present. The man did not give up and pursued his justice. It was Yoonhwan's best friend.

What had happened to him then? Did he clear the tower in the end?

'...No, that's not possible.'

Yoonhwan felt sad. He knew how the world worked. One man who did not give up couldn't change the world. Yoonhwan shook his head to shake away all his sad memories. Kashim was speaking.

"You are speaking of selfishness disguised by your justice. You know there's nothing you can do as a mere member, and you are pushing us to do something because of your helplessness."

Yoonhwan couldn't object. He thought maybe Kashim was right.

"If you say so, what about Seoyul? Or me and Mirel? Who here doesn't want to be just?"

Yoonhwan glanced at Seoyul. Her emotionless face didn't show any expression. She had been in that state ever since the simulation was over.

"You talking about that now will not..."

"That's enough. I'm sure Yoonhwan understands."

Mirel quickly stopped Kashim as he was beginning to get angry. Kashim shook his head and sipped the tea as he continued, "If you don't like where Rupture is going, become powerful. Grow."

"...."

"Even if you have such a noble dream, there's nothing you can do if you don't have the power to do it. No one will care about a mere member's thoughts."

Kashim then stood up and walked out of the room. Silence fell in the room and Mirel spoke up.

"Yoonhwan, I didn't think you were so stubborn."

"..."

"I know Kashim might sound pushy, but he has a point. You know that."

"...Yes."

Yoonhwan answered reluctantly and Mirel smiled.

"Everyone knows what you are talking about. We all know, but there is no other way."

Yoonhwan wanted to ask, 'Why do we have to do it if we know that it's wrong?' If they really knew, then they should not have done it. But Yoonhwan couldn't ask. Deep in his heart, he too knew why they had no other way.

He knew that not everyone could be like 'him'.

That's why Yoonhwan hated himself at this moment.

"Thank you for your understanding, Yoonhwan."

Mirel tapped on his shoulder and walked out. Even after a long time had passed, Yoonhwan stood there wordlessly, biting his lips.

Seoyul looked at him for a bit and then disappeared also.

"That is every new recruit that we have had in the past half year."

Center of [Highseeker], office of the Master. There was a man sitting across from Myad who was reading through documents in a plush chair with his legs crossed. The man's name was Imai Kazuki, the 3rd Captain.

"...12? I thought there'd be more."

"Those 12 are the only ones at the 3rd step. There are more below that."

Myad nodded and Imai thought to himself.

'Damn girl... I wonder where she went off to.'

This report was originally 2nd Captain Yoo Surha's job, but it was passed down to Imai after she left. Myad asked, "So, are there any particular ones I have to pay attention to?"

"Yeah, a few. Especially the woman on the first page."

Myad then went back to the first page. There was a name written down there: Han Seoyul.

"She's a tough one. She went through simulation 520 times and stayed to the end for 518 times. Even after she finished the 3rd stage Awakening, she never hesitated to kill faces she knew. She will become a great warrior."

"...Really?"

Myad seemed to be surprised.

The simulation was to recompose the Great Disappearance that happened 700 years ago through the tested's memory, to forcefully awaken them. It was simulation, but Myad knew how terrible it was.

It was because it was Myad who had planned it. It was fake, but it was still hard to kill people one knew in order to survive alone. Most people were mentally broken after their first 10 tries and required another 10 simulations to get used to it, and then another 10 times to get the hang of it.

Rupture referred to the 30 times as an 'adaptation' period.

The 30 repetitions were required to take the first step into getting Rupture's unique world [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]. Yet, Han Seoyul did not require an 'adaptation' period and cleared the simulation 518 times.

"That is amazing."

"Yeah. She's my favorite."

Imai smiled and glanced at Seoyul's photo. It was a very slight second, but Myad saw Imai's lust-filled eyes. Myad smiled bitterly and flipped over the next few pages. And then he stopped at some page.

"Oh, him... um..."

Imai glanced over at the name and hesitated. There was Kim Yoonhwan. Myad asked, "What happened?"

"There was a problem during the simulation."

"Problem? Why? Was there anything wrong with the simulation?"

That did not happen before. The simulation was very important within Rupture. If there were any problems, it should have been reported already.

"No. He... He was being stubborn until the end."

"Stubborn?" Myad asked.

"Yeah. He didn't kill his friend to until the last part."

"Meaning... he never cleared it?"

"No."

Myad then looked at the report again.

A total of 1954 tries, all fails.

It was an inexplicable challenge and an equally inexplicable fail count. There was no one like this before. Myad became curious.

"And why was he passed?"

"Because he was awakened. When he failed the 1954th simulation, he suddenly became a 3rd stage Awakener and opened a unique world."

"Without finishing the simulation?"

Imai nodded.

"Yeah, he did become a 3rd step... and he also got the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]... and Mirel just passed him then...

The boy was successfully awakened without finishing the simulation, and he got the unique world? It was very interesting to Myad.

'By the way, this man...'

Myad then remembered something he had been missing. He completely forgot about it because he had been very busy. Myad narrowed his eyes.

"Imai, this man..."

It was then that someone knocked on the door.

"Who is it?! I'm reporting here right now!" Imai shouted angrily, but the knocking did not stop. Imai walked over to the door and opened it. There was an officer panting at the door. He flinched at Imai's angry face but shouted,

"M-master! The Lords are here!"

Chapter 168: Rupture (3)

When the meeting first started, Yoonhwan didn't think the meeting would go well.

The [Great Lands] and [Rupture] were sworn enemies.

Former Captains of Rupture had killed many Generals and even Lords at times. Why would these Lords want to talk with Rupture then?

Yoonhwan's concerns grew to the peak once he faced the dark-caped man.

'They are the Lords!'

It was as if the meeting room itself was becoming dark. As Yoonhwan faced the dark man's eyes, he felt chilled to the bones because of his fears.

Talking with them? It was impossible. They were here to fight a war.

Yoonhwan was sure of it and didn't realize that his hand had moved over to his sword. However, the Lord seemed to be interested in Yoonhwan who was not backing down at his presence. More powerful energy was about to be unleashed but...

"That's enough, Darkness."

A voice stopped him and the Lord of Darkness Gerome smiled.

"It's been a long time since I saw you, Rupture's slut."

"I see that you still are as vulgar as ever," Mirel snapped coldly. Yoonhwan was shocked. It seemed like these two had met before. Gerome glanced

over at Yoonhwan and Seoyul standing at the corner of the room and asked, "Who are they? New Captains?"

"No. They are secretaries. They will be recording the meeting."

"I see. I thought they were too weak to be Captains."

Yoonhwan bit his lips. It was true. He was barely withstanding the energy that the Lord was unleashing.

People started sitting down within the meeting room. From the center seat to the left were Rupture's 3rd, 4th, and 5th Captains, and to the right were the four Lords of the [Great Lands].

Yoonhwan checked their names.

1st region. Lord of Forest, Illiones.

2nd region. Lord of Destruction. Siegfried.

4th region. Lord of Dragons. Varkant.

9th region. Lord of Darkness. Gerome (Leader).

'Four? I thought there were 11?'

Yoonhwan was wondering why, but Gerome began speaking.

"A while ago, I sent out my boys to find you Ruptures at the [Great Lands]. I didn't know you hid yourselves within [Depth] already."

"It's been a long time since we moved. You were too slow," Imai snapped at Gerome coldly and silence fell. Their eyes met, and they were each checking another's power. Yoonhwan realized that it was a battle of world power.

It was Varkant who broke the silence.

"Where's the sickle girl? I need to teach her a lesson."

His voice was so calm that it was hard to believe that he had been challenging the others with his powers. Yoonhwan realized the Lords had gotten the upper hand from the fight. Imai frowned and said, "...Sickle? Are you talking about Surha?"

"I heard she's the one who killed the former Lord of Dragons. He was a fool though. A Commander becoming a Lord? Pfft."

Varkant, who was a half-dragon and half-human, scoffed. He had become a Lord about 400 years ago. Kashim answered, "Surha has left Rupture."

"Really? That's a shame."

Varkant seemed to be very disappointed. Maybe he really was here to fight Surha.

'They are all terrifying. Were these the ones I tried to fight?'

Yoonhwan couldn't even guess who powerful his Captains were, but he had a rough guess through the rumors he heard. And from the rumors, Imai was the strongest, then Kashim, and then Mirel. Kashim's world power was rumored to be at about 3 million, so the other Captains should have been close to that.

'Then, just how powerful are they?'

The Captains didn't seem to be comfortable and it was likely that the meeting would lean in favor of the Lords. Yoonhwan felt like it was hard for him to breathe after the Captains had failed to overpower the Lords with their world power. Jerome looked at each Captain and asked, "Oh, and where is Myad?"

"...You should not call that name so easily."

"If he doesn't come, there is no meeting."

"The master gave us permission for this meeting."

"HAH! Nonsense," Gerome scoffed. "You all have no right to hold this meeting."

And at that moment, everyone flinched. Even Kashim and Imai became pale from the terror. Gerome's world power began to explode and Kashim gasped, "...So, that's why the war stopped. You have been hiding your powers."

"I had planned to reveal it... but not this soon. Thanks to the weird one who made a mess at [Chaos]."

"...You are talking about the General Massacre."

General Massacre?

Yoonhwan did not know what that was, and he just jotted it down in his notes. Gerome nodded.

"Yes. I had empty spots for my Commanders, and these hyenas began rushing in."

Gerome then glanced over at the three Lords next to him and smiled. His vicious smile even made the Lords look away. Yoonhwan then realized that Gerome was the strongest of all the Lords.

"It took some time to 'persuade' them. I mean, we didn't even have the [Fruits] and these fools were coming at me like crazy. Wasn't it, Siegfried?"

"Oh, uh- y-yeah. I'm sorry about what happened then." Siegfried answered frantically. It was terrifying world power.

"Who can fight him? Can Master? Or one of the 8 Gods of [Depth]?"

Yoonhwan wasn't sure.

"So, where's Myad?"

"He's not coming, Gerome. He's not here."

"Where did he go? Was he too scared to come?"

Mirel then became infuriated.

"Shut up. It's not like all of you are here either. If all of 11 came, Myad would have come. But just four? We are the ones who are offended by this rudeness."

Yoonhwan became terrified. Speaking so fiercely against that terrifying Lord? Would it not anger Gerome? However, Gerome's expression turned awkward.

"That I can explain. We were planning to come. All 11 of us."

"Explain? And what will that be?"

"Don't play games, girl. You all must know."

Mirel then closed her mouth. She blinked for a few seconds and spoke.

"So, Catastrophe did not let you guys pass easily."

Catastrophe. The Gatekeeper blocking the way from [Chaos] to [Depth], and one of Three Ancient Gods. Gerome gritted his teeth.

"No. He didn't even plan to let us pass. Why did you not tell us before?"

"We didn't think that he would try to stop you. Catastrophe normally doesn't care about letting the Lords passing through."

"Don't lie. There's no way that you all did not know."

"...So did you fight Catastrophe head-on?"

Gerome became silent, but it was not hard to guess why.

"Five out of eleven died. And two were too injured to come with us."

Chapter 169: Rupture (4)

The Captains then looked at each other. If what he said was true, that was a great loss for the [Great Lands]. Varkant added, "But we still have the power to kill all of you here."

Mirel ignored him and asked Gerome again.

"And Catastrophe?"

"He has been temporarily sealed. Eleven of us attacked him and we couldn't kill him. We still needed the Lord of Steel and the Lord of Gold to hold his seal from breaking down even then."

Yoonhwan found it hard to believe if what he was hearing was true. These Lords and Captains were so powerful beyond his imagination. As powerful as these beings were, that required eleven Lords to barely seal it off?

Gerome continued, "I believe we have paid enough to meet with you. Are you still forcing us to prove ourselves? We have taken enough losses to even ask for compensation."

"...Do you want something?"

"Give us the [Fruits]."

"That will be included in our treaty. We cannot hand them over to you just like that."

Gerome became serious.

"Just like that, you said?!"

A world power was unleashed and the Captains all pulled out their weapons. Gerome scoffed.

"Yes, this was how it should've been. I was a fool to even try to talk with you."

Yoonhwan became dizzy from the world powers filling the room. Even Seoyul was vomiting blood that turned into silver right after.

They were at the brink of war. Then, a man appeared in the meeting room. Yoonhwan glanced over at the man. He had some kind of old rag on himself. But he wasn't the Master as Yoonhwan had hoped.

"Oh, so you have no wish to talk things out?"

As he spoke, the world power disappeared from the room. The man's world power pushed everything away. Some Lords even became pale from his power. Gerome was also shocked. It proved that the man was that much more powerful.

"Why are you here, Budda?"

Budda. Yoonhwan realized that he had heard the name before. It was from one of his books he read when he joined Rupture.

'Wait, Budda, one of the 8 Gods of [[Depth]]?'

The 8 Gods of [Depth] were the most powerful Gods. The official name was the 7 Gods of [Depth], but it became 8 after Myad became the ruler of the 8th site, [Caspion].

Budda, the God of Reincarnation, was the 6th God.

'...But why is he here?'

Yoonhwan didn't know why. Whatever he was, why was a God here, at the meeting table in Rupture?

Of course, there were still a lot of empty seats around Rupture's table. From Myad's seat, the 2nd Captain's chair empty, and another one too.

Yoonhwan then became shocked from realization. Budda smiled.

"I'm an Awakener, you didn't know that?"

"Awakener?"

Gerome was also shocked.

"Wait..."

"Yeah. You're probably right."

The 2nd man in Rupture, and 2nd strongest man. The Captains all put away their weapons and greeted Budda.

"Been a while, Budda."

"Long time no see."

"You're late, Budda."

"Yeah, I'm sorry."

Budda then passed by the Captains and got to his seat. He then sat down in the 1st Captain's seat and looked at Gerome with a smile.

"So, can we begin the meeting now?"

Gerome gritted his teeth.

The 1st Captain of Rupture, Budda.

The mysterious 1st Captain that Yoonhwan did not know of. He was one of the 8 Gods of [Depth].

"Shall we begin?"

After recovering everything within the [Record of the Depth], Jaehwan finally opened his eyes. All of the history, along with its long and epic story, filled him and calmed his mind.

"You're awake."

When he opened his eyes, Runald, Karavan and the entire Long Living race surrounded him. Jaehwan asked, "How long have I been asleep?"

"...Almost a month. The Great Warrior said you would wake up today. He was right."

A month. Jaehwan realized he had spent much more than expected for reading Record of the [Depth]. But it had to be done. Just by reading all those memories, Jaehwan was able to enter an entirely different world.

Jaehwan now seemed very different. Runald, Jaehwan's Follower, felt this the most. He also noticed a certain emotion that had grown within Jaehwan.

'He seems lonely.'

It was as if he had found a secret that this world had hidden and he was the only one who could know. Runald wanted to ask what truth Jaehwan had found, but he couldn't ask. There seemed to be some kind of wall between them. Runald felt like Jaehwan was now an entirely different being.

Soon after, Jaehwan and the others were at the entrance of Forest of Madness.

Jaehwan said his goodbyes to Long Living race and Ra-hamad for the last time. What he was talking about wasn't obvious, but it seemed like he promised them something.

"I never thought I would get out of this place after 100 days," Karavan commented as he threw away his scrubbing glove. He now had recovered his link with Ignis through Jaehwan's help. His world power after recovering the link didn't fall behind Jaehwan's at all.

"You grew a lot too. Feels like my world power."

"...I just repeated Ouroboros."

"Yeah. I wonder what it actually means."

"...I don't even want to know."

Runald saw Jaehwan walking toward them and asked, "Are we going now?"

"No. We need to wait for someone."

"Who? Who are we waiting for?"

Runald became surprised. Jaehwan said, "My friends."

Runald became worried if he made a face that might've been rude, but he couldn't help it.

A friend? Jaehwan had no friends. He was alone ever since he came up to [Depth]. That's when he met Andersen and Runald. And Karavan. If he had a friend, only the two of them were here.

But other friends? Runald felt as if he had been betrayed and asked, "Who are you talking about..."

"They'll be here soon. I can feel it."

And at that moment, a giant shadow-like figure appeared from the sky. Karavan screamed.

"W-what is that!"

There was a giant ship in the air, a ship that colored in pitch black. Runald remembered he heard the name of the ship before entering the Forest of Madness. There were the pirates who called themselves the 'Fallbringers'.

"Cheesy name," Jaehwan laughed. As they saw the name, Runald remembered he was right.

The name of the ship was...

-Jaehwan!!

It was 'Fall'.

-Jaehwan!

-Master!

Voices came from the sky. Runald felt the emotions within the voices. It was the voice of longing and waiting that Runald knew very well.

The voices of ones who had waited for one person for a long time.

Jaehwan then saw the people running toward him, two men and one woman.

As he saw them running, Runald became lonely. They were in the same place, but it felt like they were in different places. Runald then realized what was most important thing in human relationships.

This was a wall of time. A wall he could never break. Was this the wall he had been feeling all along?

He wanted to meet Andersen so much. His instincts told him that he could never cross that wall. He will never... he felt as if he was being swept away into darkness, into loneliness.

And at that moment-

"What are you doing?"

A voice saved him as if it was nothing.

"Let's go."

Jaehwan's large hand grabbed his shoulder. Runald realized he was overcoming a wall so easily. He also realized something was going to begin now.

Runald looked back. He couldn't see the Long Living race saying their goodbyes anymore. They were getting further away from the forest.

He had learned a lot within the forest, and he left many things there. He turned again toward Jaehwan's people. Just like wearing clothes, one was gone and a new one had arrived.

Runald then thought he understood a bit more about Ouroboros. He wasn't sure if he was understanding it correctly, but he didn't want to hide this feeling.

He closed his eyes.

He could hear Andersen's song. It was a warm song that she sang to him before.

A poor naked God.

As he walked back home alone,

He thought about it all along.

At least one person.

At least once.

As Runald heard the song, he had mumbled the word for the last time.

"Ouroboros."

Chapter 170: Rupture (5)

After exchanging names, Jaehwan, Runald, and Karavan was taken into the ship along with Chunghuh, Karlton, and Sirwen. Jaehwan asked, "Old man, what happened while I wasn't here? How did you find me?"

"Heh, is that all you've got to say after all this time?"

"Oh, you wanted a hug?"

"Nevermind."

Chunghuh smiled and gave a short summary of what happened. He began from when they were taken apart from Jaehwan, and decided to move on their journey after waiting for Jaehwan a bit. Then they were beat up by hundreds of middle-ranking gods, and then tens of high-ranking gods. They also went to the Nightmare Union at the 5th site with Sirwen's help to build the pirate ship called the Fall. Then they traveled all parts of [Depth], killing notorious low to middle-ranking gods while gaining world power, and they ended up with a nickname of the 'Fallbringers'. Chunghuh also got his hands on one of the [Parts] from an ancient god and it increased his power by a large margin.

That's when they heard Jaehwan's news a few months ago, and finally went after him into the Great Forest.

It was short but long 2 years and 3 months. Chunghuh spoke most of the time while Jaehwan listened. Karlton and Sirwen seemed to be nervous while they listened. Jaehwan made sure he checked each of their powers while he was listening.

'They've grown in power.'

He was astonished by his friends' powers. All of them, including Sirwen, was much stronger than what they were like 2 years ago. Sirwen was a Nightmare so it was hard to tell, but at least Chunghuh and Karlton looked they could take on most high-ranking Gods.

Jaehwan realized what kind of fear they had brought upon these gods and how many they had fought. Chunghuh laughed, "...Haha. We should have a duel sometimes. You will be shocked to see my unique world."

"Oh, that would be fun."

Runald watched them talk to each other jokingly and thought,

'He looks just like an old man.'

Runald also heard about rumors about these 'Fallbringer' pirates. They were notorious pirates who had been appearing on the eastern side of [Depth]. He was curious about how scary these four people were, but they seemed to be nice.

'I heard there were four though. Is it four including Jaehwan?'

Of course, they were just not scary-looking and not close to just being ordinary men. Karlton, the blonde guy, was one of the most handsome men Runald had ever seen, and Sirwen, a Nightmare, was the most beautiful woman he had ever seen. Runald was at a loss for words at his first sight of a Nightmare.

'So, that's a Nightmare.'

Runald glanced over at Sirwen for a few seconds and then turned to Chunghuh. It seemed like they had finished talking. Runald figured it was a good time to speak up.

"Uh, so were you with Jaehwan since [Chaos]?"

"Yes, my child."

Chunghuh spoke with an unusual and dignified voice. It seemed like he was glad to see an innocent boy like Runald in [Depth]. As Runald began to speak, Sirwen and Karlton also began speaking up. They wanted to speak since a while ago, but the awkward feeling toward Jaehwan stopped them. They had longed to meet him for a long time, but they were not sure about how to start.

"J-Jaehwan..."

It was especially so with Sirwen. Unlike Chunghuh or Karlton, she was not actually Jaehwan's friend. She was more close to being an 'enemy'.

Sirwen was now realizing that the emotion she had built up during the past 2 years was not actually permitted. That's why she became afraid.

What if Jaehwan shunned her out now? What should she do with her affection that she built up alone? And why was she, a Nightmare, trapped with such emotion?

Jaehwan looked at Sirwen.

"What is it?"

"Uh, it's..."

"Go on."

His voice was cold. There was no friendliness or kindness, but Sirwen found herself feeling relieved. Relieved? How could she feel relieved by a cold voice?

"Haha... ah..."

Why did she have tears in her eyes?

"Why are you laughing?"

"No. It's nothing."

With those short words, she realized that this man was Jaehwan. No matter how the world turned, and how many years had passed, he was Jaehwan. She then realized what she had to do.

If he was Jaehwan, then she just needed to be 'Sirwen'.

She took a short breath. Her 2000 years of life made her find her calmness just by taking a breath. She smiled and said, "I was looking forward to seeing you naked, but you aren't."

She thought it was a good topic to joke around with, but Jaehwan responded seriously.

"I am naked."

"What?"

"I am naked."

Sirwen quickly scanned Jaehwan from top to bottom. To her eyes, Jaehwan was wearing a dark blue long coat. She even checked the inside of the coat, but Jaehwan had simple vest and pants on the inside.

"Are you trying to make a joke?"

She knew Jaehwan wasn't the type to joke around, but there was no other way she could think of. Jaehwan said again, "It's hard to explain. Anyway, I'm naked."

"Yeah. If I have to put it into words, he's in Ouroboros state."

It was Runald who added to Jaehwan's words. Sirwen raised her eyebrows.

"And what is that, kid?"

"Ouroboros is Ouroboros."

Sirwen smiled at the confident answer.

"Kid."

"Yeah?"

"You want to get whooped?"

Sirwen threatened expressionlessly and Runald quickly hid behind Jaehwan. Jaehwan then grabbed Runald shoulder. A black coat-looking cloth appeared upon Runald's body. It was the same design as Jaehwan's. Sirwen asked in surprise, "W-what? What did you do? How did you do that? Is it a Setting?"

"Similar, but different."

What Jaehwan did was by using the [Eye of Geshtalt]. After getting his hands on that [Part], Jaehwan had been freed from just putting on clothes. That was why he said he was naked even when he had clothes on. But he didn't want to go into the details on such a complicated issue.

Sirwen began to ask, "What happened during all this time..."

Runald interrupted her again.

"I said, it's Ouroboros!"

Chapter 171: Rupture (6)

"...Is everything Ouroboros to you?"

It was Karavan who covered his genitals at the word since he was still naked. He smiled awkwardly at Sirwen.

"Hehe, it's quite complicated. Like you said, it's kind of a Law type Setting."

"...And you are?"

"I thought I introduced myself..."

"Sorry, I wasn't interested."

Karavan was disappointed.

"I'm Karavan. Vicegerent to Ignis."

"Oh, right..."

Sirwen who seemed to be uninterested, soon turned to Karavan in shock.

"WAIT! You said Ignis?!"

"Haha, yes! So you know!"

Karavan smiled triumphantly. Sirwen tensed up at the name.

"Of course I do. Ignis..."

"Hmph!"

Karavan widened his shoulders.

'See? This is how famous Ignis the Flame is!'

Karavan then glanced over at Runald. Runald frowned as he looked back at Karavan. In the opposite direction, Chunghuh, Karlton, and Sirwen were talking amongst themselves regarding Ignis. It seemed that they were all shocked by the fact that Karavan was Ignis' Vicegerent.

"...So, you are something I guess?"

"Hah, it's too late to recognize that now, boy."

Karavan cackled but Runald pointed at Karavan's genitals.

"But you're still naked."

Karavan then saw the people's eyes looking in that direction and blushed.

"I-it doesn't matter!"

"I just said you're naked, that's all."

Runald answered with smirk and Karavan frowned. He didn't realize it when he was in the forest as everyone had clothes off, but now that they were back out, everyone had their clothes on. Karavan just forgot that it was weird to not have clothes on.

He felt ashamed. It was especially hurting to feel Sirwen's disgusted look.

'D-dammit...'

Jaehwan and Runald also had their clothes on. Karavan lowered his shoulders in disappointment. This was no way to glorify his God, Ignis.

"H-hey Jaehwan." Karavan asked for help, "Can't you clothe me with your power too?"

But the help did not come.

"You are not my Follower, so it's impossible."

"It only works for your Followers?"

"Yet."

Karavan wondered if he should abandon his God just to get out of this shameful situation when Runald cackled.

"Why are you so ashamed of being naked? Didn't you say being naked was the real way just a few days ago?"

"S-shut up!"

"You look like a naked God. It's so cool."

"..."

Karavan's body was shaking in anger with his reddened face as Runald mocked him when someone walked over. Karvan was then covered by a coat.

"Please, use this."

It was Karlton.

"T-thank you."

Karlton became so thankful that he even teared up He was wary of Karlton since he looked like a sissy, but it seemed like he was the nicest man in this group. Karlton smiled.

"It's nothing. You must have a hard time if you are a Vicegerent to Ignis."

"...What?"

"Huh?"

Karavan asked, "Did something happen to Ignis?"

"Didn't you said you were a Vicegerent...?"

It was a foolish question. If something happened to his God, Karavan would've known about it.

"Yes, I am. But..."

Karavan frowned, thinking of how he should explain what had happened.

'So, the link not having been recovered fully was...'

Karavan's link between Ignis had not fully recovered. The link to share world power and the Setting was established, but the link to communicate was still unstable. The only words he had heard from Ignis a few hours ago was this:

[You fool! Where have you been all this time!!]

He should have guessed that something was wrong back then. Karavan then thought about how surprised Chunghuh and his friends were when they found out that Karavan was Ignis' Vicegerent. Were they surprised for another reason other than the fact that Karavan was a Vicegerent of high-ranking God?

Karavan explained shortly.

His link had been broken and it was now recovering, but he cannot communicate with his God yet. That was why he did not know what happened to him.

Karlton understood what happened quickly.

"I see. So, that's why..."

"Yes."

Karavan thought this sissy was actually smarter than he thought. Karlton then said, "Then you might be shocked to hear this."

"...Did Ignis get hurt?"

Karavan thought it was a stupid question. Gods were beings above beings. There was no way to hurt Gods. No, there was a way, but that was...

"He should be fine. But this might be a bigger problem then Ignis getting hurt."

"...A bigger problem?"

"From what I know, Ignis was the ruler of the 3rd site. Is that right?"

"Yes," Karavan answered dumbfoundedly. And in the next moment, Karavan guessed what Karlton was going to say.

"The 3rd site no longer exists in [Depth]."

"Wait. Wait... are you saying..."

Karlton's calm voice turned into despair for Karavan's ears.

"Rupture attacked the 3rd site a month ago. The 3rd site has fallen."

Chapter 172: Rupture (7)

It had been 3 months since the meeting with the Lords was held. 3 months as a period of time that could be long but also short. These 3 months had been hellish for [Depth] and all living beings in it.

"Sir."

Yoonhwan couldn't hear being called upon as he looked up to the sky of Ragnarok, the 5th site.

"Sir?"

"Oh, yeah."

He then turned. His lieutenant was standing next to him.

'Am I really a squad leader now?'

Yoonhwan was still unfamiliar with the position.

24th Squad Leader, Kim Yoonhwan.

It was due to Rupture's unique system that allowed Yoonhwan to be promoted in such a short period of time. Rupture, a group of Awakeners, had a difference in ranks due to Awakening steps. It was due to having a huge power difference between different steps that 3rd step Awakeners would automatically become Squad leaders or higher.

"What have you been thinking, sir?"

It was his lieutenant, Adel, who spoke to him. Adel was a 2nd step Awakener who joined the [Depth] Invasion along with Yoonhwan.

"Just the usual," he commented as he observed the countless defeated spirits. There were spirits on the verge of being evaporated into silvery dust. They were Vicegerents to the 5th site, or the ones who followed all kinds of Gods from Norse or Greek mythology. The beings who once had the power to call thunder or drive out seas were now at the brink of becoming the nutrients for the Tree of Imagery.

"S-save me..."

A few spirits reached out to Yoonhwan in fear. Yoonhwan almost moved his hand unconsciously to help, but stopped. His men were watching.

Soldiers who had been finishing up the spirits moved on and finished them. Yoonhwan couldn't tear his eyes away until the body turned into dust.

Then came the sound of thunder.

"Those Lords are crazy," Adel mumbled in astonishment. Yoonhwan nodded.

"Yes, they are."

At the center of Ragnarok, at the palace of [Olympus], there were Gods using all of their Settings to fight to their last breath. There were two Lords and one Captain against one of the 8 Gods of [Depth].

They were against the God of the 5th site, Chronos, the God of Time.

Chronos, who had taken control of his Vicegerent, was using all of his power to control time to fight back with incredible speed. But even if he was so powerful, he was still alone.

It was impossible to win while being outnumbered.

"Don't you think it's weird?"

"What is, sir?"

"That."

They saw Olympus the Palace being destroyed from afar. The 'Forest Giant' Setting of Lord Illiones destroyed the palace, and Lord Siegfried's Setting 'Gram's Blade', destroyed Chronos' Law type Settings. It was then that Mirel struck a blow at Chronos.

Chronos screamed. The 8th God of [Depth] kneeled.

Adel said, "It's not like we're seeing that for the first time."

He was right. It wasn't their first time seeing this, but it was something that was hard to get used to.

'However, I am getting used to it.'

During the past 3 months, Yoonhwan had seen the destruction of countless sites. Beginning with the 3rd site while Ignis was vacant, they had destroyed the 4th site, 'Syndrome', which was controlled by Pest, the God of Disease. And then they came to the 5th site.

"I'm sure the 2nd site is being attacked. But I heard it's hard because the Dragon God Droyan is there."

"Droyan? The one that uses Dark Dragon Flame Setting?"

"Yes, sir. The 1st and 2nd Captain are there. I heard the 1st Captain alone isn't enough."

Yoonhwan remembered what happened in the meeting room 3 months ago.

1st Captain of the Rupture, Budda, the God of Reincarnation.

He was one of the few 8 Gods of [Depth] who could fight against two Lords alone. He was the one who had stronger power than Gerome of Darkness, the strongest Lord.

'Who would've thought that Budda was the 1st Captain...'

The appearance of Budda was shocking news for all low-ranking Awakeners of Rupture. The meeting turned upside down after Budda

appeared and every condition was in Rupture's favor.

"Oh, I heard you were a secretary at the meeting then?"

"...Yes."

Adel was curious, "Then, do you know what exactly they talked about that day?"

"I do."

Yoonhwan remembered the topics of the meeting. He could still remember it clearly. There were three main topics:

The Alliance of [Great Lands] and [Rupture].

Asking the Lords to help with Rupture's Depth Invasion attack.

Requiring the Lords' inaction when attacking Big Brother.

Adel became pale as Yoonhwan spoke of those words.

"Is-is it okay to tell me that?"

"Everyone will know soon. You are my lieutenant, so don't worry."

Adel then bowed.

"Don't thank me. It's nothing."

Adel then continued, "I heard about the alliance between the Lords. But it is surprising to hear about asking them not to fight when we fight against Big Brother."

"Actually we decided to talk to them about that."

Allying with the Lords? Yoonhwan didn't think it was right even then. But considering the Master or Captains' point of view, it was understandable.

"It's for the greater good."

Yoonhwan wasn't really sure what the 'greater good' actually meant. His only guess was that it was to destroy Big Brother.

Yes, that was important. Everything that happened was because of Big Brother after all. But was that enough to justify everything? Yoonhwan wasn't sure.

"I see, Big Brother. So that was our condition."

"Yeah."

"What did those Lords ask in return?"

If Rupture had conditions, then the Lords must have had conditions too. It was obvious, but Yoonhwan was surprised by Adel who had calmly listened to his words.

He then thought he should tell Adel about what went on that day. It was a decision that was hard to understand. Even if Adel was his lieutenant, it was against the order to tell him everything happened that day. Yoonhwan himself couldn't understand his question.

Yet, he still thought he should talk. He had to.

Thinking back now, Yoonhwan maybe guessed that something was coming. Telling Adel gave Yoonhwan an important motive to go onward.

And after a while...

Adel made a comment.

"I see. So, it was that."

Yoonhwan became nervous at the calm and careful voice. It was as if he was a kid waiting for his homework to be graded.

"Providing [Fruits], not interfering with the reconstruction of the [Palace of Reincarnation] and help cleanse [Chaos]..."

"Yeah."

Yoonhwan sighed with relief that he had given accurate information. Yoonhwan wasn't really sure what the conditions actually meant and the gravity of the situation since he did not have much knowledge about [Chaos], or the Palace of Reincarnation.

Adel added, "It's bad."

"Bad?"

"Yes, sir. It's bad."

"How bad?"

"We might not have the word 'Human' in Rupture anymore."

It was not an exact description, but Yoonhwan felt the seriousness of the Lords' conditions.

"...I didn't know it was that bad. I was more shocked by the last condition."

"Last condition?"

As the meeting progressed, Yoonhwan was most enraged by the last one. That one was something he could not just ignore. It was about the [Cultivation].

-All [Products] cultivated onward from [Cultivation] will be divided up in a 1:1 ratio between Rupture and the [Great Lands].

Yoonhwan couldn't accept this.

It made sense to get help from the Lords to fight Big Brother. It made sense to provide them whatever they required Rupture to do for the greater good.

But what was this? Divide [Products]? Didn't that mean accepting Cultivation?

Yoonhwan remembered 5th Captain Mirel talking to the enraged Yoonhwan in a low voice.

-I know what you are thinking. I know. But think about what we have to go through to defeat Big Brother and the Lords eventually.

-But... but...!

-Rupture can't just stop being Rupture. We must make sacrifices for greater change. The cost of our pride can bring the change.

Yoonhwan hated himself for not being able to speak out loud. He felt as if he had been denied everything.

Adel nodded.

"I see."

Chapter 173: Rupture (8)

It was a calm voice. It was so calm that it was hard to accept.

"I see? Is that all you have to say about this?"

"I didn't have any other things to say."

Didn't have any other things to say? Yoonhwan tried to say something, but stopped. There was someone crying in the distance.

Soldiers were gathering prisoners. These were the Lost Ones who had abandoned their Gods. They were the ones who were shaking in fear of death. They were weak spirits with merely 50ish world power. Yoonhwan spoke as he glanced over.

"I have watched this for every single day during the past 3 months."

"..."

"I believed that what I am doing what is right. Everything will be alright in the end. If I wait and wait... then the end that everyone can be proud of will come."

"You did."

"But this came to my mind one day."

A prisoner was being trampled by a soldier. Two helpless hands shook. As he watched, Yoonhwan said, "That all of this, was the actual 'end'."

"..."

"And with all of this going on, there will never be an 'ending' that I wish to see."

Yoonhwan maybe wished that Adel who was facing the outcome of Rupture losing humanity, might agree with him. But what was next was unexpected.

"No, sir. The 'end' has not come yet."

"...It hasn't come?"

"No, sir. If we defeat Big Brother, everything will be solved."

Yoonhwan opened his mouth to speak, but stopped.

'So, you were thinking of that also.'

He felt disappointed. Yoonhwan spoke again.

"But how? Can Big Brother bring back lives? Can people be healed from their wounds?"

Adel answered immediately, "Maybe so, sir. If we reach the [Beginning of the Nightmare] after defeating the Big Brother, we can control everything in this world, maybe even time."

"Time?"

"Yes, sir. We might receive the power to turn back time. The Tree of Imagery could possibly do that."

"...Turn back time?"

Yoonhwan became enraged. He recalled the memories of what happened at the Tower of Nightmares and shouted while gritting his teeth, "That doesn't solve anything! Even if we can turn back time, and it really turns people back to normal as if they were never wounded, it doesn't change the fact that they were wounded. Even if they don't remember, that period of time really existed!"

"..."

"Do you know what I'm saying? I... that people.... Those times..."

Yoonhwan stopped talking. His emotions were getting in the way of making out what he was trying to say.

"I see. So, you think of it that way, sir."

Why? Yoonhwan felt like Adel's calmness seemed to be different from a while ago. Adel took out a cigarette and lit it as he spoke.

"Sir, if it's okay, may I talk about my story from the old days?"

"...Go on."

"When I first joined Rupture, I had similar thoughts as you, sir. We didn't join the Rupture on our own will, but I thought Rupture was the only group that could change the system. Yes, I did think that back then."

"And you don't know?"

"No, sir."

"But why have you..."

"Still at Rupture?"

Yoonhwan stopped asking. It seemed it was rude to ask even if he was a superior.

"It's simple, sir. I was here for 'too long'."

Too long. Yoonhwan felt like the word meant a tragedy.

"I was in Rupture for 700 years. I saw many things and lost many things. I saw the things I valued change during those times. I saw things lose humanity, again and again."

700 years. Yoonhwan gasped at the unimaginable amount of time. He knew what happened 700 years ago. Adel was the survivor of the Great Disappearance.

Adel continued, "Maybe it could've changed. If it was before everything disappeared... before we gave up on everything."

"No. No, not yet. You... you are not yet..."

Yoonhwan stopped talking in the midst of his words. He felt it was irresponsible to say such a thing. He did not know about Adel's 700 years. He did not know one bit about his pain, suffering, and sadness. Adel smiled.

"You sound like my friend."

"...Friend?"

"I had a friend who I loved talking to. She once told me too that I'm not late, that I should go with her."

Go with her? Yoonhwan became curious.

"Is she not a friend anymore?"

"No, sir. She left Rupture while ago. She's on her way to find her own path. A great decision."

Yoonhwan felt his heart sink. There was no 'leaving' Rupture. The only way to leave was to die. But Adel didn't seem to mean that his friend had died. There was only one person who left Rupture alive.

"Wait... the friend you're talking about..."

"What nice words to hear. Not late... not yet... But I know. I know myself more than anyone. I am too late."

Adel then stopped to find his breath and added, "For someone else, it might not be too late yet."

Silence fell. Yoonhwan asked in a shaking voice, "Are you... telling me to leave the Rupture?"

"I have not said anything, sir."

Yoonhwan looked around. There were soldiers of Rupture and prisoners. Their hands reached out for help, and they were trampled upon mercilessly. Yoonhwan stuttered, "You... you should..."

"Oh, can't you do anything alone?"

Yoonhwan became silent. Can he go? Can he walk past all of those soldiers to where he wanted to go? No. Did he know where he needed to go in the first place?

Yoonhwan turned his back toward Adel. And took a step. And then another. And another.

It was terrifying. He was afraid of his world, even if it was hard to accept, being destroyed.

Even then.

Even then...

Unlike his fist that was clenched, he couldn't move any further. He turned back to Adel again. But when he turned halfway, he remembered someone. Someone's back.

'Ah...'

Yoonhwan looked at the back. He had trusted and followed that back. He began walking toward it without realizing. He kept on moving toward the back, across the battlefield.

Some soldiers glanced at Yoonhwan. Yoonhwan looked down to the ground at prisoners laying there. Hands were trampled upon. Yoonhwan looked down and knelt to grab the hand.

Everyone was looking at him now. Adel spoke from behind.

"Oh, and this is for telling me about what happened at the meeting. My 'friend' went to the 7th site."

The prisoner turned into silver dust and Yoonhwan stood up. Then he began to move. There was no more hesitation in his walk. Yoonhwan spoke without turning back.

"Goodbye, Adel."

Adel answered, "So long."

"I hope we meet again."

"I hope not, as we will be enemies then."

Both men smiled and Yoonhwan kept on walking. He saw his friend's back again, the back was talking to him. It told him that it's okay, and he should follow.

'No.'

Yoonhwan shook his head as he walked.

'This time, I will go ahead.'

And he walked past the back of his friend and left the battlefield.

Chapter 174: Rupture (9)

7th site of Depth, Eepoche.

Yoo Surha, who was leaning on the terrace of the Central Palace - [Edmund] looked down onto the site's landscape and remembered a paragraph from the book she read.

-This place's time has been stopped. Gods, spirits, and everything else. Just like the name, beings who gave up on thinking have gathered here....

It was a paragraph from the book written by the God of Mischief, Pierre: [Assuring Despair].

God of Mischief Pierre. He was a weird God who spent his entire life helping the low-ranking

Gods of [Depth].

Yoo Surha knew Pierre. Almost all gods who had lived long enough within [Depth] knew him. He had written many books that helped many new Gods.

The book, [Assuring Despair], was the last book Pierre wrote, and it was about the 7th site, Eepoche.

As the rumors said, Pierre found the 7th site and wrote his last book here before facing his last moment. The last paragraph in the book said this:

-Where the hope of [Depth] falls.

Yoo Surha thought about what it meant as she watched. People talking to themselves amongst the quiet scenery came to her ears. Two men were

talking to each other.

"Hey, you know it too right? [Depth] is crazy right now."

"It is, it is crazy."

"I wonder where the world is heading."

"It's over."

"The world will end."

"Yes, it will."

"Then, goodbye."

"And to you too."

The two men parted ways, and after five minutes, they returned to where they met again and started over.

"Hey, you know it too right? [Depth] is crazy right now."

"It is, it is crazy."

"I wonder where the world is heading."

"It's over."

"The world will end."

"Yes, it will."

"Then, goodbye."

"And to you too."

They spoke the same way and parted ways, only to return after 5 minutes again. It was a never-ending discussion.

Yoo Surha felt sadness as she heard the words. There was a certain emotion that was long lost from these men, a despair that was very old, or a shadow of something that was once called despair.

The 7th site. Eepoche.

Every being that lived within this place was like those two men. The discussion that Surha witnessed now was happening in all places within the 7th region. These beings repeated the same thing at the same time every day as if they were mentally ill.

And, they actually were patients.

Eepoche — the name came from the disease that these spirits and Gods were suffering from.

Eepoche was a disease that made one stop thinking and refuse the future.

Gods and spirits who had gotten the disease, Eepoche, notwithstanding the thousands of years of their lives, wandered around for a long time until they gathered in one place. Hence, the name came afterward.

'Eepoche.... It's similar to the [Isolation] of Awakeners, but also different.'

If [Isolation] was a disease where Awakeners closed their ears and eyes against the influx of information, Eepoche was a disease where one would lose oneself in an influx of despair because not closing their eyes and ears.

Surha then turned to the last page of [Assuring Despair].

-Eepoche. -Where the hope of [Depth] falls.

This was the last sentence Pierre wrote, and the sentence that Surha had to refuse. She was here to find the 'last hope' of [Depth] that still existed within the 7th region.

That was why she was here for the past three months for that very hope.

'It's time.'

Surha then moved to the throne room, to the ruler of the 7th site.

He wore white clothes and had pale skin from top to bottom. He was even white from his hairs to his eyebrows. Surha frowned when the man spoke.

"It's been a while, Surha."

"Been a while? I saw you yesterday. Stop giving me that bullsh*t."

"Still. It's been a while."

"You said that yesterday too."

"Good to see you again."

"I think I heard that a hundred times during the past 3 months already."

"I see."

"...Ugh, you're giving me a headache. When will you stop repeating yourself?"

The man laughed but Surha did not even smile.

"Anonymous. Are you copying your people? You are not suffering from Eepoche."

She knew about the man. Actually, there was almost no one did not know about this man. The [Depth] called him-

God of Madness, Anonymous.

He was one of the 8 Gods of [Depth], the ruler of Eepoche.

'I have to gain his support.'

When Surha left Rupture and parted ways with the 'Fallbringers' temporarily, she came directly to this site. Anonymous was the only one who had the power to fight against Rupture at the moment. Surha was sure

of it. If he put his hand in, there was a chance at this unfair fight. But it was hard to persuade this man. Surha was getting stressed talking to Anonymous who had been avoiding her request for three months.

"Whew...."

Surha took a deep breath and decided to be patient. This needed time and she knew it.

"I talked yesterday too, but I'll tell you this for last time."

"Go on."

"Rupture has started invading [Depth] along with the Lords. You know this right?"

"Yes."

"Three sites have been attacked. The 3rd, 4th, and 5th. And from my intel, the 2nd site is on the brink of collapse too."

"I see."

"No, you don't see! Don't you get what is going on here?"

Surha's voice filled the empty room loudly.

"Who do you think Rupture will go after?! It's here! Your 7th site!"

"They will not come here."

Surha's expression changed.

"Why? Why do you think that?"

Anonymous did not answer and Surha scoffed, "Oh, because you were part of Rupture once?"

"..."

"No, I should say, because you were the founder of Rupture?"

There were three men who started the Rupture. Myad, the Master, and 1st Captain Budda. And there was one more. It was Anonymous.

"They are not coming."

"No, they will. They will destroy your site and take you back to Rupture."

"..."

"Aren't you even worried? It was you who took me out of Rupture in the first place! Wasn't it to fight against them?"

It was one of the top secrets of Rupture, but Surha, who was a Captain, knew this. She was not the first one to leave Rupture alone. There was a powerful Awakener who had done it long before her. The man abandoned his name as he left the Rupture and became Anonymous. Yet, he was still so strong that he became one of the 8 Gods of [Depth].

Yoo Surha shouted angrily, "We have to form an alliance now! I have a crew! There are a few Gods and Awakeners who will oppose Rupture! And I've gotten into contact with the 2nd site's Followers too! If it's with you, not even Rupture can..."

"It's pointless."

"It's not pointless!"

Anonymous then slowly closed his eyes and opened them again.

"That is strange, Surha."

Chapter 175: Rupture (10)

"What is?"

"Why are you against Rupture? They are still bent on defeating Big Brother. It doesn't change even if they are working with the Lords right now. You have no reason to stop them."

Surha flinched. Those words were something she had not heard from Anonymous during the past 3 months. He was asking a new kind of 'question' to her. She felt anticipation and concern at the same time and answered, "...The master cannot defeat Big Brother."

Anonymous then realized something quickly.

"Is that your [Premonition]?"

"Yes. The one you created for me."

"You know it's not certain."

"...But it's usually right."

Anonymous then thought for a bit.

"Even if you are right, that's not enough."

"...Not enough?"

"Even if Master cannot defeat the Big Brother, that doesn't give you a reason to leave Rupture."

"..."

"The Master is one of the only few beings who can see Big Brother. Even if you have seen the Premonition... he is the only chance against Big Brother..."

That's when Anonymous glanced at her. For the first time, he laughed.

"You saw a different hope."

"...Don't change the subject."

"Who is it? The new hope?"

"It's not important. What's important is to stop Rupture. We cannot have unnecessary sacrifices."

"Unnecessary sacrifice..."

Anonymous said, "You sound very 'human' like."

"Yeah, I was surprised that I was still a human."

"Interesting."

Anonymous chuckled and said, "I knew that the Master will not defeat Big Brother. I too have the Premonition. He will instead choose to become a ruler of [Depth] instead of defeating Big Brother."

"You knew! Then why..."

"But we have no reason to stop him from doing that."

"What?"

"If we don't destroy Big Brother and the System, nothing will change. As you know, Big Brother is a monster that not even the Master can defeat. I am not sure what 'hope' you have seen, but no one can defeat Big Brother. No one."

Surha flinched at the certainty of Anonymous's words and what despair it held. He continued, "And whether it be the Master, the 8 Gods of [Depth], or anyone else... the Master of [Depth] always changes. It's just a part of a great cycle. It's not the first time a mass massacre has happened within [Depth]. It is just another incident from history."

"And you will just watch it happen?"

"Nothing will change anyway."

"It will! As long as we don't give up, the world can change! It's not too late! We stop Rupture and grow stronger. And when we do, we fight Big Brother, and...!"

Surha was shocked by her own voice — she was surprised that she had such passion within her still. How had she found such hope, when was she always trapped within her despair? Surha knew the answer but tried to not think about it. Anonymous laughed.

"Seems like your 700 years wasn't long enough."

"..."

"But you will know if you live tens of thousands of years. There is despair too long to hope for a change."

"Dammit. You sound like my friend."

Surha remembered her friend Adel who she met for the last time when she left Rupture — a friend who refused to leave with her. He too had the same eyes as Anonymous right now. But Anonymous' expression turned weird.

"Friend? Friend..."

"...Huh?"

Surha became confused and Anonymous smiled, "Actually, I had a friend who talked exactly like you."

"Me? Like me?"

"Yes. There was a friend."

Did he have a friend? Surha did not ask, but she listened to his story.

"There was a Nightmare who came to me once. We wanted a similar world and became good friends. He was a unique one, however. He was a Nightmare, but he talked against the [Cultivation]. He also considered himself a criminal who made a tower."

"...A Nightmare who was against Cultivation?"

"He talked just like you. That the world can change if we don't give up..."

Surha realized who this 'Nightmare' probably was. Before she could speak, Anonymous continued, "He was a Nightmare, but he was more powerful than any of the Gods I knew. He was only one who collected two [Parts] of Three Ancient Gods.

Two of them? Was he such a powerful Nightmare? Surha couldn't believe it.

"This part is not widely known. Hundreds of years ago, he had the same goal as what Myad has now. And he left for the [Nest] to Big Brother alone."

"So? What happened then?"

"Don't you know what happened? It happened hundreds of years ago. No one heard of him coming back. The world did not change."

The world did not change. It was apparent what that meant. Even the being who had hands on two [Parts] of the Ancient Three Gods failed to hunt Big Brother. Surha then suddenly came to realize the depth of the despair that Anonymous faced. This poor old God had given up on all hope when the Nightmare failed. He had accepted the fact that nobody could change this world forever.

"But... but..."

"If no one can defeat Big Brother, then it doesn't matter who becomes the master of [Depth]. It doesn't matter."

Surha became hopeless at the voice. She couldn't fight back her hopes against such giant despair. She felt like her hopes were nothing against such failures and foresight.

He was right. No matter who became the master of [Depth], it wasn't going to change anything if the System was still there. History would repeat and she was just a small particle within the history.

"But..."

But she was human. She existed here as a human and stood here as a human.

That's why she had to defend herself. However, she couldn't think of what she had to say.

That's when an explosion came from outside. Powerful world power was pressing down on the entire palace. Surha became pale.

"I told you! They are here already! They..."

But it was faster than expected. She heard that the 2nd site was going to go down soon, but she guessed it might take more time for Rupture to come to the 7th site. She took out her weapon, Thunder Demon. There was no choice but to fight.

At next moment, the door to the Throne Room burst open and a man and a boy appeared.

"Whoa, Jaehwan you're so bomb!"

There was the voice of a noisy boy and the man. Surha was shocked.

"You... You... How did you...?!"

It was impossible for him to be here. No, he couldn't be here. Why was he here?

"It's been a while."

And there was her hope.

Chapter 176: Rupture (11)

"I think we have things to settle later."

"H-huh?"

"Wait outside," Jaehwan snapped coldly and Surha backed away toward the door. Why? Why was she afraid of him? Surha shouted in objection, "Wait! What are you...!"

"Be quiet, Miss! It's important now!"

It was Runald. Surha was shocked by the powerful world power within the boy. Who was this boy? Then she heard a familiar voice from behind.

"Ugh, he started again."

"Jaehwan! I told you to go slower!"

"...He hasn't changed a bit."

Three people were walking over the Vicegerents of Eepoche that had fallen behind the door. Surha frowned.

"Teacher?"

"Surha, I didn't know you were here," Chunghuh smiled. He was followed by Karlton and Sirwen. These were pirates who were called the 'Fallbringers' and the people whom Surha had spent the last 2 years with. She then found the ship outside the window.

'By the Gods... did they bring that giant thing all the way here?'

Surha became angry.

"Why are you all here?! Didn't I say I can persuade Anonymous?"

"It's not up to us. We just followed him."

"Then you should've stopped him! He can't come here and just destroy everything like..."

But Surha couldn't continue as Jaehwan began talking as he walked over to Anonymous.

"Are you Pierre?"

Anonymous was shocked.

"...Who are you?"

"Pierre, the God of Mischief. Right? I know your face."

Surha became dumbfounded. She glanced between Anonymous and Jaehwan and thought, 'Pierre?' What was he talking about? There was no way...

Anonymous then asked, "...How do you know my real name?"

Surha screamed in shock, "PIERRE?! Anonymous, you were 'that' Pierre?!"

"What? Who's Pierre?"

"Teacher, don't you know? The God of Mischief? The one who wrote the..."

As Surha and Chunghuh began to shout frantically, Anonymous asked Jaehwan again.

"I asked how you know my name."

"Your 'friend' told me."

Jaehwan tapped on his head as he spoke.

"Mulack Armelt."

Anonymous was shocked once again. It had been so long since he was this shocked after he had earned [Premonition]. Every future event was shown to him and he just needed to choose the best or sometimes, the least worst.

Yet none of the futures he read showed this man appearing in front of him

And Mulack? How long had it been since he heard the name? Anonymous, no Pierre, mumbled in reminisce.

"...Do you know Mulack?"

"I've never met him, but he's the one I know best in this world."

Pierre narrowed his eyes as he glared at Jaehwan. He was the most powerful God in terms of Law type Settings, but he couldn't read this man. Nothing came up on his [Premontion] and nothing came through his [Eye of the Truth].

'Is he outside the System? But that's impossible...'

Pierre asked, "So, the one who knows Mulack. Why are you here?"

"I thought about getting help from you."

"...Are you a friend of Surha's?"

Pierre glanced over to Surha. She was startled.

"As I've already said to her, I have no intention to..."

"I didn't ask you to help me yet."

"What? You just said..."

"I need to see if you are worthy enough before asking for your help."

Pierre opened his eyes wide and laughed. The maniacal laughter made Surha and others flinch.

"What an arrogant..."

But Pierre couldn't finish his words as Jaehwan's powerful world power swept away his voice. Pierre felt he had felt this world power a long time ago.

'Is this true?'

A long lost memory came back to him.

Budda. Mulack. And the naked Gods...

The Great Forest and the hot springs.

Memory of going through Metamorphosis.

"Great Warrior Ra-hamad sends his greetings also."

"Ra-hamad!"

Pierre shook with shock. Jaehwan continued, "He wanted me to ask if you are still doing metamorphosis. And..."

From Jaehwan's left eye, the shadow of a giant snowstorm was spinning.

"If you were lazy in your training, you must pay the price."

The energy began to fill the room. It was the energy of the Fall. Pierre quickly stood up with a pale face. He was no longer able to just stand aside. Soon, his eyes turned also. The bright shine of world power filled the entire room.

Moments later, Jaehwan and his friends were outside the Edmunt. Surha, who was still dumbfounded, asked, "...So what happened back there? Can anyone explain?"

Chunghuh answered, "Do you want a long version? Or the short version?"

"Short."

"Hmph. It's hard to make it short."

"...Then why the hell did you give me a choice?"

Chunghuh laughed and began to speak. It was the long version. After hearing the long story, Surha stopped Chunghuh since she was annoyed, "Okay. I see that you are glad to see Jaehwan again."

"Hmph."

"But listen if I understood correctly."

Chunghuh nodded and Surha explained what she understood.

"So, what you're saying is that all of you went to the Great Forest just to find him?"

"Yes."

"And you met Geshtalt, one of the Three Ancient Gods?"

"It's Jaehwan who met him, not me."

"And what are you talking about, having power from Geshtalt? And the [Part]?"

"I don't know exactly. I just heard from Karavan."

Surha turned in shock.

"Karavan? Vicegerent of Ignis?"

"Yeah."

"When did you find him? I have been looking everywhere for him."

"He was with Jaehwan."

"...What? Ugh, is this all true?"

Chapter 177: Rupture (12)

Surha became dumbfounded and Chunghuh shrugged. Surha asked again, "So, where's Karavan now?"

"He went to the 2nd site. He said he needed to save his site."

"What? And you just let him go? He can be a great help to us! Ignis only has one Vicegerent...!"

"Don't worry. We promised to meet again."

Surha grabbed her forehead at Chunghuh's words.

"Do you really know what's going on here? Do you know how powerful Rupture is right now? There are 4 Lords and 3 Captains, and 2 of the 8 Gods of [Depth]... and the other Gods who might be helping..."

"I know, we're desperate."

"Then...!"

"But we are not doomed," Chunghuh smiled. "Here he comes. Ask him yourself."

And people turned to the entrance of Edmunt. Jaehwan was walking out of the palace just like how he appeared. Surha mumbled to herself.

'Dammit. So, he's the only one I can trust after all?'

Surha hesitated for a bit but spoke to Jaehwan carefully.

"Hey, what happened?"

"We fought."

"...Are you serious?"

She guessed that when she felt the world power storming from within. A fight against Anonymous? It was easy to guess the outcome for Surha, but they were teleported out of the room by Pierre as he kicked out everyone except Jaehwan from his palace.

'Fought?'

Surha checked Jaehwan's body. There was no trace of any fierce battle.

"Jaehwan, you don't seem hurt. Did you really fight?"

"We didn't fight to the end."

"Oh, I see. So?"

"It seems he will be of help."

The subject seemed to have changed, so Surha frowned. She dumbfoundedly looked at Jaehwan. She just realized something impossible had happened.

"...Wait. What do you mean? Did Anonymous say he will help us?"

"Under a certain condition."

Surha bit her lips after counting how many times she had been shocked today.

"W-what did you just do there? I was in this damn place for 3 months trying to persuade him!"

"I told you. I fought him."

"Fought him and then what? Did you win? Even if you became strong, you can't..."

Then, a boy appeared from behind Jaehwan. He smiled.

"He can't win?"

"Huh?"

Surha knew the boy right away. It was the brat that talked back to her earlier.

"Runald, were you with him?"

"Yes, Sirwen. I am not sure why, but Pierre's Setting did not work against me. Maybe it's because I am Jaehwan's Follower. So you all were outside..."

Everyone realized it from Runald's boastful words.

"Hah. It's a shame you all didn't see that. Really a shame."

Karlton jumped up to him immediately.

"Runald! Did you see him fight?!"

"What? You saw it?!"

"Kid, did you really see?!"

Sirwen and Chunghuh also joined in with their questions and Runald became really proud.

"Of course I did!"

"Okay, go on! Explain. That stuck up bastard doesn't talk much..."

Runald began to explain excitedly what he had seen. Surha then felt something.

'Wait...'

Jaehwan was looking at something beyond the region. In that sight, Surha felt as if Jaehwan had gone very far.

"Hey. Did you defeat Anonymous..."

Runald was still talking, "So, Naked Jaehwans came out, mixed themselves all over and thrust.."

"Naked Jaehwans?"

"What are you talking about, Runald?"

Chunghuh and Karlton were confused. Sirwen also spoke with excitement.

"So? So? What happened next? So what did those naked Jaehwans do? What did he thrust with?!"

"So, uh it was.."

Runald was very excited and he went over all his descriptions.

"So the clothes shot this way and that way and the Naked Jaehwans went to that naked man and..."

"A man's fight!"

Sirwen gasped in astonishment and Runald nodded proudly.

"Yeah, sort of."

"So, Pierre could only be persuaded."

"Hell yeah!"

Surha narrowed her eyes. She couldn't get half of that nonsense. Clothes flying around? Naked what?

'Did he see some illusions? He does have good imagination I guess. And what is that stupid Nightmare girl doing... saying she understood...'

Surha shook her head as she sighed and turned to Jaehwan. Jaehwan was still looking far out. Surha called out to him, "Hey. You said Anonymous will help us under a certain condition, right?"

"Yeah."

"And what is that?"

"That."

"That?"

Jaehwan pointed his finger toward a place and Surha turned to the direction.

"What do you mean that. That's... huh?"

She felt as if she had been struck down by lightning. She felt like she was shivering. It was one with the most powerful world power she had ever faced until now, world power so hostile that it seemed to have spikes protruding everywhere.

"Oh no... that's..."

Surha felt the other friends coming toward her. They too were now was looking toward the direction Surha was looking.

"So the rumor was true. Rupture really is working with them."

"...We have to run."

They knew it instinctively. The enemies that were approaching weren't beings that they could face. They were the Vicegerents of the 'Strongest God' in the Tree of Imagery.

Lords of the 12 Regions. And there was the most powerful one among them.

"Jaehwan. Even if you have become powerful, you cannot fight them now..." Chunghuh said as he saw giant world power approaching,

destroying everything in its path from the far border of the outer 7th region. Jaehwan shook his head.

"No, I am not running."

"What?"

"Pierre promised to help us if I defeat them."

Jaehwan pulled out his sword. Chunghuh became silent as he looked at the lone sword that was pulled out.

'I see. So it has come down to this now.'

Everyone realized the silent determination. There was no running anymore. It was not an option. It was...

"Old man. It's time to fight now."

And at that moment, Chunghuh realized he had been waiting for these words for the last 1200 years.

'I can't call him kid anymore.'

Chunghuh felt like he was going to cry, but he held back.

"Yeah. Let's go, Jaehwan."

Chapter 178: Rupture (13)

Pierre looked down at his left hand as he looked at the world power approaching from outside the window of his throne room. His left hand was burnt to black soot by Jaehwan's world power. It was the first wound he had ever gotten since he had become one of the 8 Gods of [Depth]. It had been so long since he met an opponent who could harm him in any way.

He looked up to the sky.

In the sky of the 7th site where hope had crouched away, a faint 'moon' hung up in the sky.

But that moon was not always a moon. It was a star to someone and a sun to another. And to someone else, it was an eye.

'Big Brother.'

People called that a star, a sun, a moon, and an eye. Nobody knew what it was actually like, but the only thing that was known was that only a few awakened ones could see them.

'It was a star to Myad and a sun to Budda.'

The shape in which Big Brother appeared was as the individual's personal feelings toward it. When Pierre found out that Myad saw it as a 'star', he realized that Myad had no intention of fighting Big Brother at all. And did was Budda. A sun? It was worse than a star.

Those two didn't consider Big Brother negatively at all. Pierre then asked himself, 'What about him?'

'I'm the same.'

He had to admit it bitterly. A star, a sun, and a moon. All the founders of Rupture called to fight Big Brother, but they understood the need more than anyone. With them as leadership, it was impossible for a true revolution to happen. What they wanted was not the destruction of the System, but a creation of another.

Pierre checked his left hand.

The pain came to him, bringing back his old memories. There was the feeling he had when he didn't see Big Brother as a star, a sun, or a moon.

And it was the shape that Jaehwan saw Big Brother as. The disgusting shape was striking. To see that there was an Awakener who considered Big Brother in such a way even to this day...

It was weird.

Pierre wasn't sure of the small fire that had started within his heart. Just to earn such feeling by peeking into someone else's world... just by knowing that there was someone who had not given up on this world yet.

'You have found a good hope, Surha.'

Pierre smiled as he laughed.

Dust was kicked up from the plains. Countless soldiers appeared through the large portals. Vicegerents from all kind of gods appeared, but they had fatigued expressions. It wasn't certain if this advance was due to their own will or others.

No, they knew very well that this was no one's will. This war was filled with void and emptiness to an unfathomable point.

Yet, they had no language to talk about their emptiness. They were just prisoners in this long war. They fought as prisoners and fought until they died.

And the march did not stop.

At the forefront of the war were the Awakeners of Rupture. They were the warriors who had fought against various sites, defeating any enemies that got in the way. Maybe it was because of them that many of the Vicegerents who surrendered were able to move on.

Rupture's goal was so clear and determined that it even persuaded their enemies.

If believed by many, it became the truth.

And the truth gave power. Power formed the world.

And there it was, Rupture only had the last site of [Depth] left. The World of Cinabro was waiting.

"Is that the place?" Gerome asked. Imai answered, "Yeah."

Epoche appeared in front of them. Gerome looked around the quiet scenery of Epoche and spoke disappointingly.

"So, it was true then. It's a loser's site."

"..."

"I heard the God that rules this place is an old member of Rupture. You couldn't get to him?"

"He is not Rupture anymore."

Imai answered coldly and Gerome cackled.

"Really? So your proud, bloody unique world isn't so perfect after all. You already have two leavers."

Imai cursed to himself, but held back from speaking out loud. He couldn't argue with the Lord right now to hinder the operation. Gerome glanced over at the soldiers moving into the city and asked, "Are we going in also?"

"No, we'll wait."

"Why?"

"Anonymous is a formidable foe. We wait until reinforcements arrive from the 2nd site..."

Lord Varkant interrupted them.

"Bah! How can a God be that strong?"

"...You don't know about Anonymous."

"We have two Lords! No Gods can fight us. Besides, we have..."

Varkant became silent as he looked at Gerome. Imai understood what he was trying to say. The Lord of Darkness Gerome was the most powerful Lord among all 12 lords.

'Darkness the Strongest.'

It was him who put an end to the war on the [Great Lands] quickly and played a vital role in re-sealing Catastrophe. He was the best Vicegerent of Big Brother and the most powerful Lord of all.

Gerome agreed. "Hmph. No, he's right. We better wait."

"...Huh?"

Varkant became curious and Gerome cackled.

"I think we can have some fun here. It might be better to watch what's about to happen before we go."

Gerome was looking toward one of the areas at the outer region of the 7th site. Imai turned and grimaced. Gerome laughed.

"You guys at Rupture are so amusing."

How many could a man kill without becoming insane? 10? 100? 1000? Yoonhwan thought he would never know as he could not find out himself.

Nobody spilled blood, but he felt like he could smell the blood even now.

He could never forget the moment he was awakened.

[Great Disappearance Simulation]

In that simulation, Yoonhwan saw countless faces. They were those who climbed the tower with him. Some betrayed him while some died before they got to know Yoonhwan. But they all had one goal at some point. They were all walkers who tried to save humanity.

But in that simulation, they were no longer his friends. They tried killing each other and also attacked Yoonhwan. Yoonhwan watched these people trying to kill him and...

'Ahhhhhh!'

Sometimes they cried in agony.

'Please! Please!'

Sometimes they begged.

'F*CK YOUUUUUU!'

Sometimes they were enraged.

He fought them time after time. He killed them again and again. He knew they were fake and that they were recreated by his memories, but he felt his mind changing as he killed them over and over. It was as if the world he knew was breaking down.

Ethics, justice, and all that within him had been crushed and thrown away.

And what was left in him was madness. That madness told him this:

-The 'human' you believe in is the remnant of the System.

-The humanity you were forced into is just a shell.

As he repeated all the unethical things he could imagine, he got out of the shell called human. He overcame the System that surrounded him. Repeating it 1954 times in the simulation allowed him to achieve that.

Killed, killed, and killed.

Yoonhwan then stopped at some point.

'No. This is not right. It's not right.'

It was when he saw one of his friends that he stopped killing, the friend he trusted the most. A human who was closest to being justice. That friend was charging at Yoonhwan with a sword in his hand.

'If I need to go through this much to gain power...'

Yoonhwan gritted his teeth.

'I will give up on becoming an Awakener...'

The sword struck his stomach.

That was the 1954th simulation. It was a terrible, and painful memory. He felt his sight being distorted and in next moment, he woke up with a sharp scream.

"UGH!"

His entire body ached. He got up and looked around. The lands were barren and there was the shape of a giant site that was faintly visible from afar.

'I was knocked out.'

He looked down at himself. He could still walk and fight. He still felt that the people trying to hunt him down were still around.

'I didn't know they would come this fast.'

A week ago, he left Rupture after he spoke with Adel at the 5th site. He got away from the battleground as fast as he could and avoided doing any suspicious activity after he got out of the war zone. He didn't even use large portals conceal where he was going.

But Rupture quickly came after him as if they knew where he was heading. It was different then what they did to Yoo Surha.

Originally, it was equally as hard to get out of Rupture as hard it was to get in. Rupture killed without mercy if there was a traitor. That allowed them to keep complete secrecy within Rupture.

'If I can only meet up with Yoo Surha...'

If it wasn't for Adel, he would not have taken the chance. He would have hidden somewhere to seek out another chance, but he couldn't. Yoo Surha was at the 7th site. It meant that his destination was already set.

Yoo Surha and the Fallbringers. Those were the forces that opposed Rupture. That was the only hope Yoonhwan had in this world now. Yoonhwan wanted to know what the person who left Rupture before him was thinking.

He wanted to ask why she left Rupture. Was it because of the same reason? Was she thinking of justice? Do they still have hope to ask about what is right or wrong?

After walking for a while, Yoonhwan saw the 7th site coming into his view. But the excitement soon turned into despair.

'I am too late.'

Walls were being destroyed, sending particles everywhere.

The Rupture army was already in the city.

Chapter 179: Rupture (14)

Yoonhwan became desperate as he saw the city being destroyed. He should have come faster because he needed to give the information he knew...

'Dammit.'

Yet his efforts seemed to have been in vain. He then felt people approaching from the surroundings. They were the people who attacked Yoonhwan before.

Swords were unleashed as they charged against him. Yoonhwan quickly turned.

"Why, why do you have to do this!"

Enemies appeared from the darkness. They were from Rupture. Yoonhwan even knew some of them.

"Let me go! Please!"

Nobody cared about Yoonhwan's words. There was no sense of sympathy in their eyes. They too had overcome the [Great Disappearance Simulation] and some of them had been in Rupture longer than Yoonhwan.

'I'm sorry.'

Yoonhwan realized these people will not back off and readied himself. He couldn't just back down yet.

[Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]

The unique world spread out from Yoonhwan along with the world power. The power was one of the reasons why Rupture was after Yoonhwan. Rupture never allowed their unique world to be leaked out.

Powerful energy swept through some of the Awakeners, pushing them back with a scream.

'I'm sorry.'

Yoonhwan quickly turned, but he couldn't go.

"Stop, Yoonhwan."

A cold voice came with the world power that was attacking him. Yoonhwan barely was able to defend himself by using a huge amount of his power.

'Ugh...'

His wrist became painful from the force. The energy was that powerful. A Captain? No, it wasn't that strong. Then it was...

"Yoonhwan. Stop this and let's go back."

"Seoyul."

Han Seoyul was standing there. Yoonhwan couldn't say anything. He understood why Seoyul was stopping him and why Rupture had sent Seoyul to track him down.

However, he had to say something, even if he couldn't go back.

"It's not right."

He wasn't sure where he was and why he was standing here, but he had to say something. He had to speak for himself so he could exist.

"This is not right..."

There were many emotions behind his words, but Yoonhwan wasn't hopeful. That wasn't enough to persuade or make one understand.

Seoyul answered, "I know."

"What?"

"I know."

It was their first time communicating like this after they had come to [Depth]. Their first exchange was when they had overcome the trauma from the past. Yoonhwan realized that Seoyul was telling the truth. She seemed to feel something. She continued, "I know, and that's why I'm here."

"Meaning..."

Yoonhwan became hopeful. Maybe things were going to end well. Maybe the question was going to be answered in the right way. The world was fairer than he thought...

"Let's return to Rupture."

And with the voice, Yoonhwan's dream shattered.

"I heard from the Captains that you have dangerous ideas."

"..."

"I'm sure they have spoken to you already, but they know and I know it too. What is wrong and right. We all know."

"...Enough."

Seoyul ignored him and continued to persuade him, "Listen to me, Yoonhwan. Did you forget what happened back in the tower? There's nothing you can do from where you are trying to go. It's just like how we could never clear the tower no matter how hard we tried."

That word was painful. She also thought the same way. Yoonhwan remembered her death in the tower. She died on the 76th floor.

"There's something that can't be done."

There was the memory of climbing up the tower with only the two of them, him and Jaehwan. It was the dream that he never achieved. Yoonhwan felt a severe headache. Seoyul spoke again.

"Justice without power is pointless. A dream without possibility is just an illusion. You know this. How do you not see this?"

No. Yoonhwan did not know this. But there was one thing he knew.

"Seoyul."

"...?"

"Do you know up to what floor I climbed up to?"

"...No."

"I got up to the 98th floor."

Seoyul seemed to surprised, but she turned cold in the next moment.

"Doesn't matter. You still..."

"And Jaehwan went up to the 99th floor."

And with that, Seoyul was shocked for the first time. It was the first time she changed her expression ever since they had arrived at [Depth].

Yoonhwan continued, "You must remember how hard we tried and how many trials we fought against. And, how much time we put into it."

"..."

"Are you going to say that it was all pointless? Are you really trying to say that? All of that was just nothing?"

Seoyul bit her lips.

"I know what you are talking about! But...!"

"No, you don't know," Yoonhwan declared. "You don't know. And that's why you are still standing there."

Seoyul became silent. Her shaking lips were proof that she was shaken by the word, 'Jaehwan'. Yoonhwan thought maybe there was still hope in there.

"Kill me. If you want to take me back to Rupture, just kill me instead."

It was a gamble, hoping that she still had some humanity within her. Seoyul became quiet. And then...

"You think I can't do it?"

Yoonhwan's gamble was moving toward failure. Seoyul raised her sword and wielded world power. Seoyul icily said, "How many times do you think I've killed you?"

Yoonhwan felt a chill running down his spine. This woman was no longer the Han Seoyul he knew. He knew this, but it never came to his mind until now. She was the woman who succeeded in clearing everything 518 times out of 520 simulations. She threw away everything and killed all of her memories to become strong. She then stood on top of all the new recruits in Rupture.

That was the current day Seoyul. She laughed at Yoonhwan.

"I'm sure you have killed me too."

It was true. Yoonhwan did kill Seoyul in the simulation.

"You are a hypocrite."

Her sword began to explode with red world power, or the unique world of Rupture. It was as if a rain of blood was pouring down. Yoonhwan deflected the world power being unleashed against him, but it was too much.

"I heard from the 5th Captain. That you did not kill 'one man' until the end of the simulation."

"..."

"So what? You killed everyone else anyway. You're the same. You're still an Awakener of Rupture. So don't think you are just. Don't think you are different!"

Her sword cut out a chunk of Yoonhwan's thigh and waist.

She was right. Maybe he did not have the right to discuss what was right or wrong. But... even if he gave up on everything... and gave up on being human, then what would happen next?

Where was 'Yoonhwan'?

Yoonhwan's body was destroyed against Seoyul's world power. And as his conscious was fading away, he kept on looking for something.

"I... I..."

He remembered a name in his fading sights. Then, a back of a certain someone appeared. An illusion. Yoonhwan mumbled to himself.

'I see... so I still couldn't move ahead of you.'

The only person Yoonhwan looked towards when he gave up on everything. The only one who kept him human.

'I wanted to be like you...'

And the illusion was destroyed and then came Seoyul's sword — a cold, final blow to end his life.

"DIE!"

Silence fell. Yoonhwan felt his life being sucked away inside pitch black. Blood poured out from his waist, taking away his life. Death was near.

It was long but terrible. And then it was finally over. The silence fell around them.

Then, the sound of a sword dropping onto the ground was heard.

"How... but how..."

The woman was baffled.

Yoonhwan was still alive. He opened his eyes and saw Seoyul who was backing away in fear. It was something she had never seen. He never thought Seoyul would make such a face even if the world was about to fall. Who was it that made her make such a face?

"ATTACK!"

With a fierce voice, the other fighters charged toward Yoonhwan. Tens of Awakeners charged in with their unique worlds. And in next moment...

The world was ripped apart. It was destroyed. Awakeners were thrown away as dark world power covered the area from behind. It felt strange. Why was this sight a relief to him?

Yoonhwan then dropped back. As he dropped, he saw someone in his eyes. There was pain in his shoulder as someone grabbed it. Yoonhwan laughed.

This is an illusion. It's a dream. Or else...

Else... how can...

How can Jaehwan be here?

If it's not an illusion, it is the world of the dead. Or...

"Yoonhwan."

And with the voice, Yoonhwan realized that it wasn't an illusion or a dream. Nor was Yoonhwan dead. It was real.

Yoonhwan couldn't speak. He couldn't find the words to speak, nor did he have the energy to voice it out.

"You've done a good job."

It was a short praise, but Yoonhwan understood him, a best friend with whom he had spent years together with. He was telling Yoonhwan that he had done a great job, that he wasn't wrong.

Yoonhwan tried to speak with his last bit of energy. And Jaehwan listened.

"Jaehwan. I... I saw your back a thousand times... but I never... I never... I..."

"Yeah, I know."

Yoonhwan was then relieved. It was the voice he had been waiting for all along. The voice that understood everything.

I am here.

Yoonhwan was then welcomed into the world. His finger touched Jaehwan's face and Yoonhwan closed his eyes.

Chapter 180: Rupture (15)

As the dust settled, the scene was revealed around Jaehwan. Fighters of Rupture were on the ground, coughing blood from their mouths. Jaehwan looked down at Yoonhwan who had lost consciousness. It was easy to guess what he had gone through. Jaehwan felt someone landing behind him — a familiar world power. He put Yoonhwan on the ground and spoke without turning back.

"Old man. Take care of him."

"Bah. We've got another man in our group?"

Chunghuh came over, picked up Yoonhwan's body carefully, and checked his vitals.

"He's alive."

Jaehwan answered, "I'm counting on you."

"Yeah. Don't worry."

Although Chunghuh spoke as if it was okay, Jaehwan knew that Yoonhwan was on verge of dying. But he also trusted Chunghuh as well.

He was, after all, the best doctor in [Chaos]. He was the Doctor of Despair, who could turn a Dead Man back into a human.

And with the sound of another landing, his other friends appeared as well.

"Jaehwan! You already..."

"Quiet!"

Sirwen tried to run up to Jaehwan but Runald held her back.

"What! You brat, let me..."

"Be quiet!"

Runald scolded Sirwen who tried to fight back in anger and Sirwen became surprised. Runald shook his head and turned toward Jaehwan.

'Jaehwan...'

Runald knew he was just a boy. He didn't have the full life experience to put complicated emotions into words. Also, he didn't know about his God, Jaehwan either.

Even then, there was something he could feel. Jaehwan was really different right now. Maybe it was a feeling only Jaehwan's Followers could sense.

Jaehwan walked over to a woman who was slumped on the ground.

"Impossible... but how..."

Seoyul looked back at Jaehwan as she crouched. It doesn't seem like she understood what was going on.

"You... are you really...?"

"Yes. It's me."

Hearing the clear voice, Seoyul realized it was real. But that wasn't the end of her string of questions.

How could this be real? How could Jaehwan stand here in front of her?

The world power surrounding Jaehwan was getting in her way of thinking as it was too powerful.

'He's strong...'

She had only felt this type of power from the Captains, and that power was now coming from Jaehwan. It was impossible. If Jaehwan was pulled up through the Fishing Spot like her and Yoonhwan, there was no way Jaehwan could be that strong already. Transitioning from a Vicegerent to a strong God didn't grant that kind of power.

Then something popped up in her head. Yoonhwan told her that Jaehwan had gone up to the 99th floor. If then...

"Did you... really clear..."

Seoyul's heart began to race. Many theories began rushing through her head. Did Jaehwan really clear the tower after everyone left him? It was impossible, but what if Jaehwan succeeded in doing the impossible? What if he went into the [Great Lands], and gained the power to move up to [Depth]?

Seoyul felt like she was going crazy. Everything Yoonhwan said to her came back. There was always something that was impossible in the world, but the man who denied it was here. He was the man who protected hopes and dreams. The man who she once loved...

"No. I did not clear the tower."

Seoyul understood the words a bit after.

"Oh... r-really?"

And with the answer, her heart began to calm down.

'I knew it! It's not possible!'

Clearing the tower alone? It was unimaginable. She was relieved. She wasn't wrong. There were things that were impossible in this world. Seoyul replied, "I see. So you failed too. That's how you came to [Depth]!"

She continued, "I knew it wasn't possible. Clearing the tower..."

"No. I did not fail."

Seoyul couldn't understand what Jaehwan said next.

"I destroyed the tower and got out."

She gasped. It felt like everything had become quiet. Then, she recalled the few rumors she had heard.

There was the irregular who came out of the tower by destroying it. She did come across such information a while ago. There wasn't enough detail, but she knew that man was shaking up [Depth] right now. He was the most wanted fugitive in Rupture and the [Great Lands]. She remembered the man's nickname.

"G-generalslayer?!"

And with that, she began realizing everything.

Jaehwan was the Generalslayer. The man who protected her world to the end. The man who only strived on climbing up. He was the Generalslayer. Jaehwan nodded.

"Yes. That's what everyone calls me."

"Ah..."

Seoyul couldn't believe it. She felt her breathing becoming shallow and looked up to the sky. It almost made her scream, however, as there was no sky. There was the pitch dark ceiling above. She knew it was an illusion, but it made her think of this:

What if she was still inside the Tower of Nightmares? What if Yoonhwan was right, and there was still a next floor to climb up to?

Seoyul mumbled, "You... after all you've been through... you still haven't given up..."

"Yes. Because of all that I've been through."

And Jaehwan walked closer as Seoyul crawled backwards.

"Because of all that I've been through, I can't give up."

His voice and his eyes... Seoyul realized for a short moment what kind of world Jaehwan had lived in.

How lonely he must have been. And even then, he was here. He was now trying to move onto the next floor. His world was not done yet. He still needed to see the end of the Tower.

Seoyul shouted, "I-I didn't do anything wrong!"

Jaehwan did not say anything. The silence made it more painful for her.

"It's... it's all because of you! If you hadn't shown up..."

"..."

"Why... why did you show up now? Why now! WHY! Why now..."

Jaehwan stopped. He looked down at Seoyul's eyes who couldn't look up to meet Jaehwan's eyes.

The face of a woman he once loved — Jaehwan looked closely. She now had lost everything. It was full of despair and self-hatred. There was no confident woman that Jaehwan once loved.

After a while, Jaehwan moved his sword. And with the sound of something being cut out, Seoyul's world disappeared into dust. It was the power of Jaehwan's [Fall] Setting. The unique world [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] was destroyed into dust.

Jaehwan said, "You can cry now."

Seoyul then broke down. The world that suppressed her emotions were gone and the emotions rushed to her. She mumbled continuously, not knowing who she was speaking to.

"I'm sorry... I'm sorry... I'm sorry..."

Jaehwan did not answer, but he walked past her. As if his destination wasn't her from the beginning, he kept walking. And after at some point, he stopped.

"Come out now."

From the red mist that the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] left, three figures appeared. They each had unmatched power. There was a man with a long katana on his waist, a man wearing a dragon embroidered robe, and a man with a dark cape.

"...Useless girl."

The one who spoke first was the katana man, Imai Kazuki. The Lord of Dragons, Varkant, also added.

"Well well, that was boring. Humans are so dramatic."

The world power they unleashed was as if they were competing against each other. But Jaehwan did not look at them. The only one he looked at from the beginning was one man. The man in the dark cape. Jaehwan did not avert his eyes away him as if the man was his only enemy.

The man opened his mouth.

"So, you're the Generalslayer."

Jaehwan did not answer. If the voice had a color, the man's voice was probably 'black'.

"Do you know who I am?"

He had never seen the man, but Jaehwan felt like he knew. His senses told him.

He finally met him.

The man represented one of the starting points of his tragedy — the trigger that brought his world to destruction. Surha, who had walked up to

Jaehwan, mumbled, "Lord of Darkness. Gerome."

The strongest Lord of all Lords. The being who had achieved the last stage Adaptation was here.

Chapter 181: Rupture (16)

Who pulled the sword, or who attacked first — Surha couldn't remember. Maybe she was the first, or maybe it was one of the Lords. But it didn't matter. What mattered was that the fight had begun and there was no going back.

And...

"Surha, you cannot defeat us."

The situation wasn't going well for them.

"You'll never know until the end," Surha replied as she deflected Imai's sword. Imai's Katana, 'Blade Fury', wasn't an easy weapon to deal with, especially with Surha's 'Thunder Demon'.

Surha's weapon left many afterimages in the air, confusing the enemy while Imai's sword changed its shape flexibly to attack or defend at will.

Therefore, no matter how many images Surha's weapon left, Imai's sword would easily adapt to deal with every situation.

"This is disappointing. I thought you might have found a great ally when you left Rupture."

Imai charged, utilizing his ever-changing sword to make room for his attack. Surha was pushed back. They didn't use their unique worlds yet, so the traits of their weapons hadn't played a vital role yet.

"So, the 'hope' you spoke of was that fool?"

Imai felt anguished.

"Surha! I can't understand. Why...!"

Surha did not answer. There was no way she could explain. Imai Kazuki, the 3rd Captain of Rupture, was the man who was devoted to Myad's will.

"I trusted you..."

Imai's disappointment wasn't just from she leaving the Rupture. Surha knew about Imai's feelings toward her. After all, she had been in Rupture long enough. Yet, she had to act if she did not know — that was the last bit of respect she held for her old friend.

Thunder struck her chained scythe and Imai quickly jumped back from the raining world power. Surha quickly glanced around.

There were three enemies. Captain Imai was fighting her, so two were left.

'Varkant is there.'

The Lord of Dragons was fighting against Karlton, Sirwen, and Runald. Chunghuh, who was the 3rd most powerful after Jaehwan and Surha, was busy healing a certain Awakener.

Varkant dodged the attack from two enemies and spat, "Nightmare girl, you are quite fast. I'll look forward to how far you can run."

"SHUT UP!"

"HAHAHA!"

"Run! Sirwen!"

"This way, Miss!"

But the attack was too fast. Varkant's long claw ripped Sirwen's sleeveless top from her breasts to her stomach. The wound was merely a scratch, but the clothes were ripped open. Sirwen bit her lips as she covered her chest. She knew Varkant didn't kill her on purpose.

"Dammit!"

They had no chance. Karlton was a 4th step Awakener with no unique world, Sirwen wasn't used to fighting, and Runald was only a boy had no chance against Varkant. He was the stronger enemy even if Surha joined them.

'The bigger problem is that I'm not sure if I can defeat Imai.'

Surha frowned as she saw Imai charging in. His world power had increased greatly since the last time she had seen him.

'Ugh, we've got no choice.'

Surha then unleashed her unique world and glanced at the center of the fight.

'It's all up to you now.'

"Interesting."

Gerome became intrigued as he stood against Jaehwan's [Fall]. The [Fall] constantly tried to strike down Gerome's unique world [[System]].

It was a Setting that destroyed worlds. It was obvious that his Generals had lost.

If the master of the System wasn't the ruler of [Depth], Big Brother, or Gerome's world power which was a bit weaker, Jaehwan's [Fall] would have decimated his spirit and destroyed the unique world.

It was amazing — a human who could fight against a Lord on the same level. There was no one else who had such power except the Master of Rupture until now.

Even after countless exchanges with world power attacks, the destruction around them wasn't too severe as both powers canceled each other out. It was the sort of a fight where they were checking each other's capabilities

before going into a real fight. After they exchanged a few more blows, Jaehwan made a comment.

"You're weaker than you look."

"Weak?"

Gerome smiled at the unexpected claim. Jaehwan continued, "I thought you were the Vicegerent of Big Brother."

"Yes. I am his Vicegerent. What's the problem?"

"Your world power isn't that great considering that fact."

Vicegerents shared world power with their Gods. Big Brother's unique world was the System. If all 'Adapters' who used the System within the [Great Lands] were considered his Followers, Big Brother was the god with the most Followers in this world. It was apparent that the world power should have been far greater.

"I see. That's what you meant," Gerome commented as he understood. "I'm sorry to disappoint you, but Big Brother's world power isn't something that a mere Vicegerent can hold. Your spirit will explode if you try that."

"Really? That is disappointing," Jaehwan spoke disappointingly and it seemed like Gerome became a bit uncomfortable.

"I don't need the world power from that thing to crush you down."

"That thing? Can you talk to your God like that?"

"A God whose face and voice that I don't know of. I don't need to be careful about such a thing."

Those words seemed to be wrong. Big Brother's Vicegerent didn't know what Big Brother looked like? Jaehwan couldn't continue his thoughts however as his sword began to cry loudly when Gerome pulled something out from his cape. It was a sword, a sword that looked very cold. Yet, it looked very similar to Jaehwan's sword as if they were a pair from the beginning.

Gerome laughed.

"So, the swords recognize each other. Yes. This is the real 'Frost Dragon Sword'."

Frost Dragon Sword. Jaehwan then remembered his sword's name again. His sword started off as a replica of the sword. He then remembered that the real sword didn't exist since no one had hunted down Frost Dragon Velkibus yet.

"I went down to the Forgotten Region and got my hands on this. My sword has the spirit of Frost Dragon King Velkibus in it. Your fake sword seems to hold some weird thing too."

Jaehwan looked down at his sword. Both swords roared at each other. It looked like the real Frost Dragon Sword was saying this:

"You are fake. Your 'reality' is fake."

Jaehwan's sword shook and he clenched it. Gerome said, "I heard your goal is to destroy the System. It's an interesting thought."

Jaehwan realized Gerome was going to charge in soon. The real fight was about to begin.

World power exploded. Jaehwan was certain that this being was stronger than any other opponent Jaehwan had fought until now. He felt it throughout his body.

"When I heard it at first, I thought it was foolish. To have everything turn out this way because of such a foolish thought..."

Gerome recalled the memories as he looked at Jaehwan.

He'd seen the video that Cultivator Beastlain had sent him. He heard Jaehwan had escaped the tower. He learned that his [Chaos] Invasion plan had failed. He heard the rumor that the Palace of Reincarnation had been destroyed. He learned that many of his Generals, including Sameng Hoon, had been killed.

Who would have thought that this man was going to do all that?

"You became Awakened by just repeating your stabs, right?"

Jaehwan did not answer. Gerome continued, "You must be proud of yourself. You must think that you have achieved something, that you have overcome the System."

Gerome's voice had rage in it. Jaehwan saw dark energy surrounding Gerome's sword. Jaehwan activated his [Suspicion] to its limit and realized that the energy was not a world power. It was a certain [Setting] — a Setting that Jaehwan was very used to.

"You think you have overcome the System, but you must know this. You don't even know what the system 'really is'."

The energy from Gerome's sword, was the [Skill].

Skill was what countless Adapters who shared the System Interface used. Gerome's skill wasn't a 'top-grade skill' that Generals liked to use. Jaehwan knew this skill well as it was the first skill that every newcomer to the Tower of Nightmares had to learn.

'Bash?'

A skill to forcefully strike one down. The energy was focused onto Gerome's sword.

'But that's a bash?'

World power that was being gathered in shook the air around. How long one must have trained to achieve... how far... That's when Jaehwan realized-

What if there was a being, unlike Jaehwan who trained 'stab' that was outside of the System, trained bash, a [Skill] inside the system? And what if that being trained only that for thousands of years?

"Awakening? There is no such thing in this world. No being, not one, can move out of this System."

The skill that had been trained for thousands of years — the dark, red world power that could destroy the site with one blow charged toward Jaehwan.

Chapter 182: Rupture (17)

The bash exploded out, destroying everything around it. A dust cloud was kicked up and the entire land area was torn apart. The bash had perished many souls with it.

It was the power of the strongest Lord, Gerome.

Jaehwan appeared through the dust cloud.

'He's powerful.'

Jaehwan felt as if he had been struck by a giant hammer. He barely succeeded in turning the bash's direction, but his entire left arm was numb and his wrist was painful as if it was broken.

'Getting to this level of power by Adaptation...'

Jaehwan understood that Adaptation and Awakening were very similar after he fought Sameng Garam before. Just like how a human can overcome their limit through Awakening, they can reach a certain point through Adaptation too.

One blow from the bash destroyed about 10% of the 7th site. It seemed like its power made a few people feel dumbfounded also. Yoo Surha couldn't hold back her shock.

"You were lucky."

Even after such a powerful strike, Gerome's world power had not decreased at all.

"I never knew you could gain this much of power through the System."

"Through the System? You still speak of that?"

Gerome continued, "You can only gain such power through the 'System' only! Awakening and Adaptation are no different. It's just a different world and a different system!"

Jaehwan then realized that Gerome's System wasn't just a System as a unique world. Jaehwan answered, "Maybe you are right. Perhaps I am a part of the system."

Jaehwan also had a similar question for the longest time. If Awakening was really outside the System, it had to be an entirely different thing. Of course, there was a difference to Adaptation as it did not show any stats. But it wasn't enough. Awakening did have steps, and if they were counted, then there was a certain number of stats that could show their power.

"No, you are in the System. There is nothing that's outside the System."

"I can't agree with that."

"...And why not?"

"Just because you have not traveled outside your planet doesn't mean there's no one out there."

Gerome glared, "No. There is nothing outside the System. Even if there is something, no 'being' can live out there!"

It was a very solid and confident statement. Jaehwan felt sad as he heard that. He felt this from all the Generals too. Why did they despise being outside the System? Jaehwan couldn't understand.

They all had lived for thousands of years. They must have experienced a lot of things in the world and seen a lot of the unsightly, filthy part of the System. But why weren't they changing it?

Jaehwan declared, "I will find the way."

Gerome laughed.

"Alone?"

He began splitting his body into multiple clones. The number of Geromes increased, and after it exceeded 50, Gerome stopped.

It was a skill to make a copy of himself. It was also a skill that all newcomers learned at the tower. Jaehan knew this skill.

[Shadow Substitute]

Of course, this wasn't the effect of the skill he knew. The skill he knew only made one copy, with 10% of the original's power. However, these copies of Gerome wasn't that. They had at least half of the original's power.

-You cannot do anything alone.

50 Geromes spoke in unison. It was so scary that all the spirits in the vicinity shook in fear.

But why? Jaehwan wasn't afraid. He wasn't afraid when Gerome destroyed the site either. He knew Gerome was strong, but that was it. Jaehwan wasn't shaken. "I'm not alone. There are people who're with me."

-PEOPLE!

All the Geromes smirked.

-And who that might be? The girl from Rupture? Or that naked Nightmare? Or...

And at that moment, a few of the Geromes disappeared and Jaehwan quickly took a few steps back to prepare. Multiple bash attacks struck him. World power exploded like fireworks and threw Jaehwan into the air.

-Or is it all the trash you left behind in [Chaos]?!

Jaehwan stopped in the mid-air. Gerome scoffed.

-How funny. Do you think they still live?

Jaehwan turned serious at that moment.

"What do you mean?"

-I see you have built an empire in [Chaos]. And to think you used Catastrophe...

"I asked you what you meant."

50 Gerome cackled at once.

-You made a pact with Catastrophe, did you not? I believe you realize your pact has been broken.

Jaehwan did not speak for a second.

"What did you do to [Chaos]?"

There was one thing he could guess. A while ago, Jaehwan tried to recover the link between him and Catastrophe after he acquired the [Eye of Geshtalt], but Catastrophe did not answer as if he had disappeared. Geromes laughed again.

-Fool! Do you think we would let those traitors live?

So the Lords attacked Catastrophe. If Catastrophe was defeated, then [Chaos] was done for. The forces of [Chaos] were no match against even few Commanders. Jaehwan knew Gerome knew this as well.

-It should be done by now. No beings will be left to live in your dream world. You will dream in your own world alone, and die.

Geromes laughed.

'I see.'

He did hear the rumors, that Rupture and the [Great Lands] had signed a treaty. If so, there was a condition about [Chaos] too. They did not want

[Chaos] to become a force, and probably decided to send their forces out there also.

Chaos would be in a devastating state by now.

-I'm sorry I can't show you the sight.

Jaehwan then realized Gerome's intention. That Lord was intent on killing Jaehwan in the most horrible way. Jaehwan looked at all 50 Geromes. Moments later, a few Geromes had weird expressions. They asked Jaehwan,

-Why are you laughing?

The Palace of Dead Men located within Fortress Carpediem of [Chaos]... a group of people appeared within the darkness. There were hundreds of them.

"Is it here?"

"It's been a while since I came to [Chaos]."

There were two groups each with distinct world power.

"Long time no see, bastard Lords."

"Ah, so insects of Rupture."

Commanders from the [Great Lands] stood on one side, and the leaders of Rupture stood on the other.

"It's only a temporary co-op."

"Bah. I will hate every second of it."

They were here to clean out [Chaos]. One of the Commander spoke.

"So, this is the palace of Catastrophe. It's a bit empty."

They began exploring the summoning circle to prepare themselves against an unknown threat. But there was nothing in particular.

That's when a few of the scouts screamed.

"T-there's something here!"

Chapter 183: Rupture (18)

Generals and members of Rupture gathered in. There, they found traces of what they had been looking for. It was the remnants of the weapons used by the Lords in the craters all around them.

"I heard five Lords had been killed here..."

"So, Catastrophe has been sealed?"

"He won't be coming back in at least in 100 years."

People gasped. It was hard to guess how powerful he was.

"Be quiet. There should be Lords around somewhere."

"They're here?"

"The Lord of Steel and the Lord of Gold are guarding the seal of Catastrophe. We'll meet up with them and proceed on with our plan."

They agreed. That was the same order they had gotten, but after ten minutes, they realized they were in trouble. There were no signs of Steel and Gold. There was no way they couldn't be detected with their world powers.

"I don't think they're here. Maybe we should search outside..."

One of the Commanders shouted and the leader among the Commanders frowned.

"But the order..."

However, the other Commanders were already leaning toward another direction.

"We've waited too long. I didn't die to waste time here."

"The final order is to 'clean up' anyway. Maybe Steel and Gold are out there somewhere too."

They spoke those words, but their goal was to relieve their stress. Kill, destroy, and take. Unleash their desire upon the weak. It was then that a bright light appeared from afar, and the space began to distort.

"Oh! This energy!"

It was the world power of those Lords. And there they were, on the ground, on the brink of death.

"Lord!"

The Commanders quickly ran up to them, but it was almost too late.

'Who did this?'

Someone began to walk up. There was more than one. The hundreds of people each had more world power than Commanders. The one at the front had a world power that was as strong as the Lords' themselves. But were they even men?

"What are they!"

Someone shouted in shock. No Generals or Rupture could find the words to describe these people. They had not seen such people at all.

"Wh-who are you! Why are you naked?!"

And the man in the front with a very muscular body nodded.

[Ouroboros.]

And after a while, Generals and agents of Rupture were lying down on the ground, moaning after the 'Ouroboros', or Long Living race, attacked them.

"Uhg.... What have..."

And after the last General perished, the Palace of Dead Men filled with red energy again. Ra-hamad, the Great Warrior, stood and glared at it. The voice came from the red energy.

[...Who are you.]

It was a dark but weak voice. The voice asked again.

[Who are you? Are you Geshtalt?]

Ra-hamad looked and answered.

[Ouroboros.]

The voice came back again.

[You are not Geshtalt. One of his clothes.]

A voice referred to many meanings. Ra-hamad looked on silently. He felt Catastrophe's surprise. There was the emotion of an old god reminiscing about his oldest friend. Ra-hamad answered,

[Ouroboros. Thank you.]

Thank you? For what? Ra-hamad was shocked by him for using a word that was so 'human' like. Was he influenced by someone? Ra-hamad wasn't sure. Catastrophe spoke.

[How did you get here?]

Ra-hamad decided to go back to his normal self.

[Ouroboros.]

[...You speak just like your original.]

[Ouroboros.]

Catastrophe seemed like he was thinking of something. And he soon spoke.

[I see. So he asked for you to come. So... he got hands on the [Eye of Geshtalt].]

Ra-hamad smiled. He and his race's world power began overwhelming the palace. The seal of Catastrophe faded out and the destroyed link began to be restored. Catastrophe was finally free.

[So, a lot of things have happened.]

[Ouroboros.]

[How strong has he become? Is it enough to fight against one of those Gods?]

[Ouro..]

[If you speak Ouroboros one more time, I will kill you all.]

Ra-hamad answered,

[He will achieve something none of us could have.]

And the voice came back with disbelief.

[Do you really think so?]

[Catastrophe. Isn't it why you made a pact with him in the beginning?]

[...]

[He can do it. He can destroy it. The worst 'Creation' we ever made.]

Creation. Many memories came back to him. The end of the Three Gods War. The beginning of all tragedy.

[Does he know?]

[Probably.]

Catastrophe laughed sadly.

[What a fool I've become to count on a mere human.]

Ra-hamad smiled.

[Catastrophe. We were once human too.]

[Yes. Once.]

Jaehwan blinked his eyes as he felt world power filling him. The preparation was done. His clothes from within him spoke. Jaehwan looked up.

-Catastrophe is sealed. Do you think I'm lying?

"Of course, that's not a lie."

A few Geromes smiled.

-I see. So you just checked the link."

"Yes."

Geromes laughed out loud.

-Then you must know I'm right! We did it so that you will not use the [Void Sword]! That will complicate things.

The Geromes continued,

-We have enough information about you through [[Little Brother]]. You were stronger than the expected data, but if you cannot use the Void Sword, you cannot defeat me.

It was wisely planned out. There was a reason why he was a Lord. But Jaehwan seemed to be calm.

"Void Sword? You mean this?"

It was quite a sight to see all fifty faces of Gerome turn pale. The Void Sword that appeared out of nowhere was unleashing terrible energy within Jaehwan's hand.

-Impossible!

Jaehwan wasn't sure how it happened. The link was suddenly restored and he realized he could use this sword. It was weird for him to be able to use it even without Catastrophe controlling him. This usually required Catastrophe's special permission.

'Ra-hamad kept his promise.'

Jaehwan then threw Void Sword into the air and it disappeared.

"Don't worry. I'm not using this now. I don't know how to use it yet."

It was more accurate to say that the link wasn't stable enough to use it. But the Geromes began turning red with anger.

-This bastard... how dare you...

Jaehwan's taunt by acting as if he didn't even need the sword to fight Gerome had angered him. 50 Geromes all prepared for their bash as they charged.

Jaehwan did not back down.

'Only thing he can use is Bash and the Shadow Substitute.'

Of course, that was enough to make him extremely powerful. He was within the three strongest foes he had ever faced. Jaehwan closed his eyes.

"I didn't train this to fight one like you... but who cares."

-DIE!!

-SHUT UP!!

-DESTROY HIM!!

50 Geromes all shouted in different words as they charged. Jaehwan had no way to go.

And as the dark world power covered the space around him, Jaehwan blinked his left eye. The shadow of a snake twisted inside and shined in bright light.

Eye of Geshtalt.

Time slowed down, and Jaehwan heard his clothes shouting from within.

'No! Too dangerous!'

'There are too many!'

'What are you thinking!'

And through those negative shoutings, Jaehwan shook his head.

'No, it's possible. Trust me.'

And the voice of the clothes that agreed spoke.

'Yes.'

'it should work'.

'Of course, it will work.'

'I trust me.'

And from that, something was born. With a storm of world power, all those Geromes were thrown back. Gerome opened his eyes in shock as he rolled on the ground.

What was that? What was going on? Jaehwan's world power that was merely a million or 2 million, was multiplying. 3... 4... 5 million...

It was increasing endlessly. Since when he did he have such power? He only had one Follower. Then Gerome noticed the spinning Ouroboros in Jaehwan's eyes.

...Wait.

Jaehwan said, "Gerome. You are right. Maybe I will be the only one living in this world."

6... 7... 8 million.

"But it doesn't matter."

Gerome backed away and realized all of his copies were pale from the fear. He rubbed his eyes. There was no way this could be true. He was the strongest Lord of all. He then saw clearly — thousands of Jaehwan standing behind Jaehwan.

That... that was the world in itself alone.

The thousands of Jaehwans brandished their swords. Over 10 million world power had finished reloading.

Go.

The wave of the Fall swept across Gerome. Everything turned dark.

Chapter 184: Fallen star (1)

Episode. Fallen Star

[The fall of one star will not change the world.]

-4th Captain of Rupture. Kashim.

Lieutenant Adel looked up to the sky. Dark clouds loomed the borders of the sites. It seemed like it was going to rain soon.

The small particles began to drop. The rain in [Depth] consisted of small particles of world power. It was so small that it didn't make one get soaked in it to increase in the world power, but it had restorative abilities. Because of that, the rain slowed down the war. Rain did not discriminate. All Vicegerents and Followers alike stopped fighting to enjoy the rain.

The peace was short while the rain was upon them.

"It's the raining season, Adel," Mirel said from the side. Adel looked at her long blonde hair becoming wet from the rain and nodded. "Yes, ma'am."

"We will have peace for a while."

"A deceiving peace at that."

"...Deceiving?"

Mirel raised her eyebrow and Adel continued, "I will fix the word if you don't like it. Peace in the eye of the storm."

"...Adel, that's the same thing."

Adel did not answer. Instead, he looked at the dark clouds.

Giant world power had the power to attract other world powers. The rain clouds were also in response to the giant world power. But even so, it was difficult for the 8 Gods of [Depth] to bring about climate change like this one. If this were to happen, it required at least two or more Gods to fight someone who had appeared with such power.

Whatever it was, it wasn't a good sign. If Gods were opposing each other, it meant a fight. And if another being was born, it meant all hell will let loose in [Depth].

That's why people respected the rain. It was their last chance to rest before the fight.

"It's been 700 years since I've known you."

"Yes, ma'am."

"I always thought it was a mistake to force a man like you to stay in your rank for that long."

"No, ma'am."

"I thought it was good that you were their lieutenant. I believed they will learn enough from you."

"...Is that so?"

Adel didn't seem to be pleased by the compliment. Mirel continued, "You seem very sentimental today. It's unlike you."

"It's the rain."

"That's for ordinary people."

"I was an ordinary man once. Maybe so, even now."

Mirel became silent for a second.

"Normal men cannot become Awakened."

"Do you really think so, ma'am?"

"..."

"Look at them. They are all normal people."

They saw fighters of Rupture enjoying the rain. Most were young spirits who joined Rupture only recently.

"Yes, and they might die soon."

Everyone went through the Great Disappearance Simulation. They had killed their memories time and time again, but they still had glimpses of their memories and emotions.

Adel wasn't sure if they could still be considered humans, but he hoped that they might not die. Or even if they did die, they'd die as humans.

"You don't seem like your usual self today."

"A man cannot stay the same every day. Just like how one who was [Rupture] becomes something else tomorrow."

"Are you influenced by the Squad Leader you served recently?"

"Squad Leader... You're talking about Yoonhwan."

Yoonhwan. He was a man who didn't belong in Rupture. He was a being who had too beautiful a spirit to be used in Rupture.

Why?

Adel couldn't stop but smile when he thought of him.

"Maybe."

"Maybe..."

"Yes, ma'am. Maybe I have gotten the energy from the young spirit."

"Hah. Adel, are you serious..."

"And I'm sure you're not in the place to tell me that, Captain."

Mirel frowned, "What is that supposed to mean?"

"Wasn't it you who stopped Yoonhwan's simulation?"

"That's.."

"He did not clear his simulation."

"He was Awakened anyway."

"Awakened? Since when we, Rupture, accept imperfect Awakening?"

Mirel couldn't answer. Adel continued, "Things are changing, Captain. You, me, and the others."

Mirel became silent for a while. Rain kept falling down upon them. After a while, Mirel spoke.

"...Yes. Maybe so."

Mirel knew it too. Something was changing. She wasn't sure what it was, but it was happening. But...

"But the time of revolution will come faster than the change itself."

"...Time of revolution? What do you mean?"

The rain began to grow heavier. Mirel and Adel had never seen rain like this in 700 years. There was no world power equal to the Gods around them. Therefore, this meant that a powerful being was coming down to [Depth].

Mirel looked up to the skies and the rain. There was something there that could control all of [Depth]. Or rather, it was known to be there. Mirel did

not have the 'eyes' to see it even if it wasn't for the dark clouds covering the sky.

Maybe someone will say this: How can one believe when it cannot be seen? But that wasn't believing at all. It was just something to be realized naturally.

Because without such a thing, there was no way the world could be like that. Adel realized and asked, "So... the rumor was true?"

"..."

"And when is it? When..."

"Tomorrow."

Thunder tore through the air. Mirel shook, but she did not look down, imagining the being beyond the dark cloud.

"Tomorrow, Master will go fight Big Brother. The 210 thousand years of [Depth] is now over."

And with the voice, Adel also looked up. The organization that came all the way for just one purpose — the conclusion was upon them. Adel asked, "Do you think the world will change, Captain?"

Can the world change? If it changes, then how will it be changed? Mirel did not answer and shook her head. She didn't say for sure that she believed that the world would change; she did not know. Maybe they were too old to even think about those things.

Chapter 185: Fallen star (2)

At the same time, in the sky of the 2nd site, lightning came down from the skies. As he felt the rain coming down at him, Budda looked out to the front.

'It's tomorrow. I don't have much time.'

He was looking upon the inner castle of the 2nd site that should have been invaded three days ago according to the plan. The fight went on for a week. Followers and Vicegerents of the 2nd site fought valiantly and even when they only had a slight chance of winning, it seemed like they had no fear.

Budda spat on the ground and looked at Kashim who stood next to him.

"Hey. How much world power does Master have now? Do you have a recording?"

Kashim answered, "25 thousand middle-ranking Gods and 12 hundred high-ranking Gods. He also absorbed two of the 8 Gods of [Depth]. Do you need records of the low-ranking Gods too?"

"No. They don't change a thing."

Budda didn't look away from the front and calculated.

'25 thousand middle-ranking Gods, 12 hundred high-ranking Gods and two of the 8 Gods.'

If the average world power was correct, it was not enough to open the Great Realm yet. They needed at least two more out of the 8 Gods of [Depth] to complete their plans. If everything went as planned, Droyan of the 2nd Site and Anonymous of the 7th site should've worked, but...

'Gerome is unreachable from the 7th site.'

Budda knew Anonymous well. Two Lords and one Captain were enough to take him out. And Gerome had power not too far behind Budda himself. However, he couldn't get into contact with Gerome right now.

'Did he betray us?'

Budda bit his lips. If Gerome betrayed them, things might change. Even if Budda defeated the God of Dragons, they still needed one more.

'That damn God of Dragons is still... huh?'

Budda suddenly frowned. It seemed like he had sensed something bad, and his eyes began to shake. Budda spoke with a heavy voice.

"I'm going in."

"...Now? But the rain..."

"I know it's the raining season."

It was an unspoken rule to not fight during the raining season, but...

"It's not important right now. I must go now."

Kashim became silent and nodded.

"Okay. I'm going in with you."

"No. You all go back."

Kashim frowned, "What are you..."

"It's an order. Go back to headquarters. Or just stay as far as you can from this site."

There was no such thing as order between Captains. Order? Kashim then realized Budda's desperation. 1st Captain Budda was a powerful man that

could handle all the Captains at once. If he was this serious, then there must be a reason.

"GO ON! I can't let you all become mixed up in this!"

"...Okay. I will move as far as I can and stay on guard."

Kashim then began to move out with the rest of Rupture. The place they left was barren, or the lands of war. Soon, someone walked out from the fortress of the 2nd site.

He had an unforgettable and unique fashion sense. From the thick cosmetics and an eyepatch over one eye, he had a black vest that revealed the entire chest while his arms were filled with dragon tattoos and he also had gloves with studs. Behind him was a giant pillow with a drawing on it.

It was the master of the 2nd site who had been through hell while fighting against Budda for the past week.

Depth called him Droyan, the God of Dragons.

Droyan, who had finished taking control of his Vicegerent, shouted toward Budda.

"HAHAHA! What? You're still hiding in your shack? I'm here! Cowards!"

"...You're finally here to die, Dragon God."

"Oh, there's one left. So you've waited for me to come down? Kekeke."

Budda didn't feel good that he had fought this fool for a week. He could defeat him if he tried hard, but that would have resulted in huge casualties. Besides, his [Dark Dragon Flame] was the Setting that was considered to be the best.

Doryan took out the pillow where a girl with cat ears was drawn on it, and began to talk.

"Hehe, Mimi, don't you think so too?"

"Yes, Droyan! Everyone's been waiting for you to make a grand entrance!"

"Hehe. Of course. Of course."

"Oh, look. That stupid monk is still looking savagely at you!"

"Yeah, he's a dumbass."

"How about you use the Dark Dragon Flame to destroy that stupid monk?"

"Yeah! Of course! COME! Power closer to the legend than the legend itself! Master of Darkness, darker than destiny itself...!"

He was crazy. And this crazy man needed a beating. Budda focused the world power onto his hands. It was the beginning of his Setting.

[Thousand-armed and Thousand-eyed]

The giant Buddha statue appeared behind Budda with a thousand hands. All of its hands wielded world power as it struck down toward Droyan. Budda thought, 'I will use all my power! Even if I lose, I will get rid of him now or else...'

Against the raining hands, Droyan frowned as he couldn't activate his Setting yet.

"...From the hell of the west... UGH! I'm not done with my enchantment!"

The Setting was now barely making its appearance. Taking time to activate was the weakness of Droyan's Setting. The Dark Dragon Flame began to crumble against Budda's attack. Droyan frowned.

"I'm sorry, Mimi!"

"It's okay Droyan! I loved you..!"

"M-me too, Mimi!"

Budda increased his power. Droyan's body twisted weirdly as the hands struck him down again and again.

"Kek, kek, ugh, UGH!"

Droyan gasped with a voice that was hard to tell if it was laughing or moaning. The God who was known to be strongest once was now facing the end.

[You are in a terrible state.]

A voice came to Droyan's ears. It only came to his ears. Droyan shouted as he realized the owner of the voice.

"HEH- HEHEHEHE! This voice! Is it my best comrade, Flame of the Fire?"

[I'm not your friend.]

"Mimi! Our love has brought a miracle upon us!"

[...Ugh. Are you still doing that?]

"Of course, Droyan! You and our love is invinc.... UGH. EGH."

[So, Mimi seems to be well also.]

And the flame exploded in the air. Hellfire was unleashed, raining down all over the site. Budda quickly protected himself by using his hands, but the heat was impossible to block even with his thousand hands.

[Flame of Hell]

It was one of the strongest Settings in [Depth] that had destructive power equal to Droyan's Dark Dragon Flame.

[Hmph. The power has grown strong. Is it the outcome of your training in the forest?]

"Are you envious? You can become like this if you become naked and scrub them."

[No, I'll pass.]

Ignis laughed and the man appeared from the flames.

"Hey, monk. Are you Budda?"

The man had fiery red hair.

"So, you left my site in that state?"

[You'll pay with your death.]

And there he was, the Vicegerent of Ignis, Karavan.

Chapter 186: Fallen star (3)

'Ugh... That's why I tried to end him fast.'

Budda smiled bitterly. He knew powerful world power equal to his and Droyan was approaching. He just didn't know it was Ignis, the God of Flame.

Now, there were two Gods of the 8 Gods of [Depth].

If they were together, no one had a chance against them. Karavan shouted valiantly, "Hah! I will finish you!"

Ignis spoke to Karavan.

[...Karavan. That's a cheesy line.]

"Oh, I'm just fired up. I was pushed around too much in that forest..."

Fire began to explode around Karavan and went straight to Budda's hands. The hands that were struck down by the fire were left with holes. Budda became serious. The flame was so intense that it burned all of Budda's remaining clothes.

[What? Why are you burning down his clothes? Don't tell me you got that weird taste in that forest.]

"Heh, Why would I take off a man's clothes?"

But Budda was becoming naked. The hands were now increasing against the flames. The fight tilting toward Ignis and Karavan. Budda's spirit began melting as it couldn't fight back all the heat. Budda gritted his teeth.

'Was Ignis always this powerful?'

The flame was beyond the data he had before.

[That monk is something. I've never seen anyone take our flame for that long other than Droyan.]

Karavan nodded.

"Ra-hamad also talked about him too. There was one who was hiding power within the 8 Gods. He said Budda was one of them."

The voice was loud and Budda heard it also. With many hands clapping at once, the flame was pushed away. Budda asked, "Ra-hamad? Did you just say Ra-hamad?"

"Oh, did you hear?" Karavan cackled. Budda seemed to have realized something.

"I see. So you've been to the Forest of Madness. That's why you weren't at the 3rd site."

"Yeah. I heard about you there. God of Reincarnation, Budda. The being who went the closest to the [Eye of Geshtalt]."

[What? He went to the Eye of Geshtalt?]

Ignis was shocked. He didn't know the story either.

"Oh, yeah. He couldn't get it because he didn't understand Ouroboros... but he was close."

[What? What is Ouroboros?]

"Oh, that's hard to explain..."

And fortunately, Karavan couldn't explain as Budda interrupted.

"So you've met them."

After they exchanged a large blow, the fight came to a stop. Budda smiled.

"I see. So you also tried that training."

"Tried?"

"Yes."

Karavan laughed hard, "HAHA! You ran away during the training. You can hardly call that a try."

"..."

"They told me so many times that you and Anonymous ran away before the training was finished."

"...They spilled needless information."

Budda became cold. He didn't guess they would speak to that extent.

"Ra-hamad's training can never be finished. You would know if you tried."

"No, it can. I know a man who finished it and got his hands on the [Eye of Geshtalt]."

"Finished?"

Budda knew more than anyone how hard Ra-hamad's training was. He also had to give up on metamorphosis and had to come back out. But to find one who was successful in getting their hands on the 'eye'... it was hard to believe. Budda thought it was impossible.

"And who is that exactly?"

"That's..."

Budda's question went unanswered as the powerful world power charged at him.

"HAHAHAHA! Move out! Flame of Fire!"

The dark flame moved from the air as the living, dark dragon-like shape shot past. Droyan, who was holding his right arm with his left shouted, "HAHAHA! I never thought the day would come for me to use this power! You will fall! The humans are now done for!"

"N-no Droyan! You should leave the humans alone! And that monk is a God!"

"HAHAHA PUNY HUMANS!"

As Ignis looked at Droyan's self discussion, he spoke.

[It's been a while since I've launched a joint attack with him.]

"...You're doing WHAT with him?"

[Joint attack. That's the only way to finish him at once.]

"POWER SURGES THROUGH ME! POWER OF THE WEST, TO THE SOUTH! TO THE NORTH! THE GREAT POWER OF DARK DRAGON FLAME!"

Karavan and Ignis wanted to point out all the nonsense he was blabbering about, but decided not to. The giant body of the Dark Dragon soared through the air. It circled the air once and began charging toward Budda. Karavan then sent his world power to Ignis too.

The flame engulfed the Dark Dragon and fastened it.

"THIS IS THE DESTRUCTION! THE CHAOS! THE HELL!"

The hands were destroyed against the charge of the Dark Dragon, and Budda screamed.

"AAAAARGH"

A giant explosion filled the area with world power heavily raining down from the sky.

"Oooh, look at him screaming."

Karavan landed on the ground as he tapped on his body. There was no Budda anymore. He had perished instantly against the huge power. Karavan panted and said, "I did what I could do, Jaehwan."

Droyan's body seemed to be drained of energy and he slumped down to the ground.

"Heh, heh... My victory... heh..."

Karavan looked down at Droyan with a sympathetic look. One eye that had no eyepatch had tears falling down.

"Ugh, poor Vicegerent. Why was he mixed up with this God..."

[Poor guy. You should thank me.]

"Yeah. So, what should we do with him now?"

[Take him. He'll still be of help.]

"...Right."

[So, when are you meeting those Fallbringers? You can let them take him.]

"Fallbringers? Hmm... Let me contact Jaehwan then..."

As Karavan began to control the long communication setting, Ignis felt weird. He had never seen Karavan that excited when he was with him. Ignis advised Karavan.

[Karavan. It's good that you're fighting Rupture, but don't befriend that Jaehwan too much...]

But then, Karavan suddenly became pale and as Ignis shouted alarmingly, Karavan jumped up into the air. In that instant, countless hands slammed the ground.

And unfortunately, there was a being that was struck. It was Droyan.

"Ugh... Mi... Mimi... I was happy too.."

"M-me too... Droyan..."

Droyan's body that lost energy perished into dust. Droyan's world power was then sucked somewhere. It was hard to explain what had happened.

From the air where the world power sucked in, a flower appeared. And from the flower, Budda, who had perished moments ago, appeared in naked form.

"Argh.. agh...."

Budda vomited as he dropped down and looked down at himself. Karavan frowned, "Go-God. What is going on? How did he..."

[...Don't ask. It's my first time seeing it. I did hear the rumors, but I guess they were true then.]

"Rumor? What rumor?!"

[...That he doesn't die.]

Budda said, "I see. So it's come down to this again. The 1617th one died... it always feels uncomfortable."

Karavan looked at Budda standing up in disbelief.

'Wait... is that...?'

Karavan saw something similar in the forest. The Long Living race often showed that through Ouroboros, as if they had come out of their own shells.

Process of taking off their clothes.

Metamorphosis.

"So, you are the one that killed me. The one that was trained by Ra-hamad."

"You... but how..."

Budda smiled as he saw Karavan looked at him in disbelief.

"I see. So, you know about the 'clothes'."

Karavan flinched. He felt his hairs rise at the sight of the eye of Budda.

'That eye! That's...'

There was the form of a snake spinning within the eye. Karavan had seen something similar before. Jaehwan's eye, after earning the Eye of Geshtalt, looked like that. The only difference was that Budda's snake did not bite its tail. It wasn't a perfect Ouroboros.

-He has not gotten to the [Eye of Geshtalt], but he had gained another [Setting] using the power of Metamorphosis.

Karavan then realized this power was what he got from the forest. He should've asked Ra-hamad more about that Setting. It was a mistake.

With world power that decreased by very little, Budda looked the same. One layer of clothes disappeared and he was revived like magic.

Karavan widened his eyes in shock.

"...How can this be?"

"So, you understand."

Budda shouted, "All beings are the collection of many clothes! If one is ripped apart, you just have to throw it away."

A Setting that allowed one to come back to life just by sacrificing one layer of clothing.

[Reincarnation]

It was the Setting that allowed Budda to be considered one of the 8 Gods of [Depth].

"I am immortal."

Karavan stepped back. Disbelief and fear came together.

"That's impossible.."

Ignis shouted within him.

[Calm down, Karavan!]

World power began to storm within Karavan. The flame exploded and heat filled the air. The hand began to melt down, but Budda smiled.

"Go on. Come as much as you can."

Chapter 187: Fallen star (4)

7th Site of the Depth, Eepoche.

Eepoche was now recovering after the battle was finished between the Lords. Pierre, who had been long silent, rose up.

'Hope found from the place where hope had been lost.'

That was the phrase that explained the recent events within Eepoche. The word Eepoche meant to stop every thought. It was considered as the 'stop of all hope' within the 7th site, but it was now being given a different meaning.

"Shouldn't we change the nickname now? We should change it from the place where hope falls to the place where the fall dies."

"Maybe."

People had already begun to spread rumors. Hope was now being found. And in the center of it was a man. Everyone who knew of his battle realized that within a week, he would be the most famous man in [Depth]. But that was a story that was going to take place a week later. He was still in the process of becoming 'famous'.

'Dammit. Where is he now? It's not like he's all that popular or anything!'

Surha, who had been looking after the armies of the 7th site with Pierre's permission, was walking down Fortress [Edmund] with a frown. She noticed Chunghuh who was flirting with the woman Followers nearby.

"Hey! Did you see Jaehwan?"

"H-huh? Oh, I didn't see him."

Chunghuh flinched and began to act if he wasn't doing anything and the women Followers ran away at the chance. Surha felt anger rushing up but held back to ask, "Hey, aren't you too relaxed? We've won the battle, but the war is not over yet. It's just the beginning."

"I know."

"You know and you were just..."

"Can we take some time to rest? It's been a while since we've won with such ease."

"..."

It was natural to think that way. Surha remembered the fight that happened two days ago, the fight between Jaehwan and Gerome.

'But since when did he become so strong? I'm no match against him now.'

A thousand swords ripped apart Gerome's spirit. Surha grabbed her shoulders from shaking. It was terrifying enough to even think about it. Chunghuh grinned.

"Isn't it amazing? I didn't know Jaehwan became that powerful either."

Chunghuh seemed excited while just thinking about the fight. There was no one who wasn't excited.

That power. That brutality. It was the hope they had been waiting for. If Jaehwan wasn't their hope, then there was no hope.

"Hah. He's not hope..."

"Heh, girl. Wasn't it you who spoke of all that hope before?"

"..."

"That your [Premonition] showed Jaehwan and came running to me..."

"Shut up."

"Oh, and did you apologize to him? You did some wrong things to him, didn't you?"

Surha then blushed and shouted, "...Forget it! Have you heard anything about Varkant yet?"

"Oh, the one we couldn't capture? No. Nothing's come in after we missed him at the portal."

That was the only mistake they made in the battle that day. Varkant ran from the battlefield the moment Gerome was killed and they chased him to the portal unsuccessfully.

"What can we do? Forget about him. It's not like we're the only ones who suffered a loss."

"Yes, but..."

"We defeated Gerome, the strongest of the Lords, and captured Imai Kazuki. This is the best outcome there is."

Surha couldn't help but accept it. They were so desperate. It wasn't a matter of winning or losing, but a matter of survival. And they were successful. They also gained a foothold to fight against Rupture as Pierre and the 7th site decided to back them up.

'Yeah. I guess it's good for now,' Surha thought as she sighed.

"So, did you contact Karavan?"

"Oh, him. We can't get ahold of him."

"Huh? Why?"

"I dunno. Jaehwan tried earlier, but the communication Setting was a mess."

"...Something might be up. I heard the 2nd site's war is almost over."

Chunghuh shrugged at the concerned voice.

"Well, he should be okay. If Droyan and Ignis are together, there will no one to fight against them in [Depth]."

"Who knows? We are lacking hands. Karavan can be a great help. If something happened to him..."

"Hey."

"...What."

"You're too worried. Are you putting all the pressure on yourself even after you left Rupture?"

"..."

"Take time to rest. Take a breath. Rushing things doesn't always work out."

Chunghuh spoke and they went out of their way to find more women Followers to flirt with. Surha bit her lips as she looked at Chunghuh going off with his stupid smile.

Chunghuh was right. She knew he was right, but that didn't mean it made her feel relieved. Take a breath? That was impossible. She was even more concerned and worried than when she was in Rupture.

It was maybe because she found a sign of hope that wasn't ready.

She knew her choice was right, but that made her become concerned. She was afraid that hope will be lost, and that she would mess it up.

"Hey, Surha," Chunghuh called out to her. "Isn't that Jaehwan?"

There was Jaehwan, standing with a few of the 'Fallbringers' outside the corridor. Surha became curious.

"What? Why are they gathered..."

"Oh, come to think of it, today was..."

Chunghuh spoke next, but Surha couldn't hear. Her thought process made her freeze in shock.

"W-W-What are they doing right now!"

Outside of [Edmunt].

"Jaehwan, are you really okay?" Runald asked Jaehwan. The question wasn't solely coming from Runald alone. Karlton and Sirwen who were standing next to them also wanted to ask the same question. Jaehwan nodded.

"It doesn't matter."

Jaehwan looked at the man in front of him.

"Go."

As he said that, people turned to the man. Everyone knew who he was. This man was the one who came to this site and massacred countless Vicegerents.

The one who was holding onto the broken katana. 3rd Captain of Rupture. Imai Kazuki.

"Heh... hehe..."

The man laughed hollowly with his empty self without world power. A few Vicegerents taunted him from afar, and some even threw rocks. A rock struck his forehead, making him bleed with silver powder.

"What are you doing! Why are you letting him go?!"

Surha came with a shout. Imai's disappointed look turned toward Surha momentarily and Surha swallowed as she faced Imai. And in the next moment, Surha pulled out her weapon.

"I'll kill him then."

"No. Don't."

Jaehwan stopped her.

"Why?! We have to kill him! He'll become a powerful foe if he returns to Myad!"

It was a cold decision, making it hard to believe that he was once Surha's comrade. As Jaehwan tried to speak, someone interrupted, "No, Surha. Imai can't fight anymore."

It was Chunghuh.

"He has lost his world."

Surha then increased her senses to check upon Imai. The world power that was hard to even be considered a power was felt. It did not contain the familiar energy that she knew.

"Imai... you..."

Imai looked away. Everything was certain now.

'He's lost [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]!'

Imai's unique world had been destroyed. It was probably Jaehwan and his [Fall].

So... Imai could no longer fight. Chunghuh was right. An Awakener without a unique world couldn't fight anymore. That's when Jaehwan spoke.

"You're wrong, old man."

"What? What do you mean?"

"He can fight."

"...What?"

Chapter 188: Fallen star (5)

It was Surha who was shocked next.

"If he acquires another unique world, he can become an Awakener again."

Surha realized what Jaehwan was talking about and what his intentions were. Jaehwan was offering him something right now: to leave Rupture and create his own world. Imai spoke with a shaking voice.

"I... I did what was right. I fought for what is right. I..."

"Yes, of course. That's why I'm letting you go."

Imai frowned. It was hard to describe the feeling of being accepted by the enemy he had fought.

"Leave. And find your own world."

The solemn voice shook Imai's spirit. The small amount of suspicion he had toward Rupture exploded out. Imai looked at it with another perspective. Maybe this was another chance, a chance to forget everything and start over again. It was a chance to fight against things he couldn't fix, even when he knew it was wrong.

Imai glanced at Surha again. Surha wasn't sure what Imai would choose to do.

"F-find my own world...?"

"..."

"He... hehe... that's foolish!"

It was the man's final pride.

"Rupture was my everything! Whether it is right or wrong, it is my life and my history! You tell me to betray it now? There's no way!"

Imai pointed at Jaehwan with his broken sword. Was he trying to fight with that? Even when people knew he had no world power left, they grew tense. Imai was that fierce.

"Hah. Yes, you are right. Maybe Rupture is wrong. Maybe we... I was going on the wrong path. But... There's something that you don't know."

"..."

"Even if the world is sick and destroyed.. there's a person who loves the world."

And with a laugh, Imai's katana moved. Someone gasped. The sword struck Imai's heart as he fell down onto the ground.

"You are cursed... someday... you will pay for destroying this entire world... You... you... and you..."

His last sight turned to Surha.

"I... I will... in my world..."

The breathing stopped and Imai perished. Silence fell among them, silence close to the curse.

"Why did you do this...?"

Surha felt her eyes becoming hot. Maybe her eyes were now red. She didn't like Imai. She didn't like him when she was in Rupture either. But what was this?

It was a shame, but she couldn't hold back her emotions. She hated Jaehwan for showing this to her and she hated Jaehwan for making Imai choose to do

this. She knew it wasn't Jaehwan's fault, but Surha couldn't hide her emotions.

"...I wanted to see."

"And exactly what did you want to see..!"

However, Surha couldn't continue. Maybe it was because she'd seen Jaehwan with that expression for the first time — an expression of a man that was loneliest one in the world. There was no need to ask what he wanted to see. Surha knew. Maybe Jaehwan was the person in the most pain here.

Surha then thought Jaehwan was very 'human'.

He was human. He was strong and more reliable than anyone else, but he was still human.

The mind of a human who could destroy the entire world no matter what... she did not know what it was like. Despite the many years she had lived, it wasn't enough to know what it was like.

She then felt loneliness grasping her. She couldn't fight the emotion even if she knew it wasn't her loneliness.

"Don't be depressed."

"..."

"I don't want to see you being shaken by such a thing."

Surha turned and walked into the fortress. People then began to move. Sirwen walked over to Jaehwan and spoke.

"Hah... that witch. Don't worry Jaehwan, I'll take care of her..."

"Y-yes, Jaehwan. You didn't do anything bad..."

People began to reassure Jaehwan, but he couldn't hear anything. Did he do something wrong? Did he think everything would go fine because it had been solved without problems? He couldn't forget Imai's words.

It was then that the sky turned colors.

It wasn't just the sky that was covered by a dark cloud. It turned pitch black, just like space.

"Huh? What?!"

And with that, screams came from all over. It seemed like something was going to happen in [Depth].

"NO! My link is broken!"

"M-me too!"

"NO WAY!"

With some shouts from the Vicegerents, people began to become uneasy. There was the sudden loss of the link, and only one being had the power to sever links on such a large scale.

Machina of the Daeus.

With the explosion of world power, Vicegerents and Followers who became Lost Ones screamed. Jaehwan realized this wasn't only happening within the 7th region. The world power was spreading across all areas within [Depth].

It wasn't certain as to how this was possible, but Jaehwan knew who was behind this. There was only one person who could do this in [Depth].

'Myad.'

The influence of power increased as time passed. It now made Awakeners grab their heads from the pain. Everyone except Jaehwan was now kneeling down on the ground in pain.

After a while, darkness began to swirl within the air.

People realized that it wasn't just darkness. It was...

"Oh no... A unique world?" Surha was in awe. It was a unique world. Someone's enormous world power had swept the entire [Depth] into their own unique world.

"Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses!"

People screamed at the presence of the terrifying massacre appearing from all around them. Surha knew that this was part of the unique world. It was different from hers, but...

"W-what is that?"

And with someone's voice, every living being of the [Depth] looked up to the sky. There was a shining star.

The giant star shined brighter than anything else.

As everyone looked up, they shook in fear. They all realized what the star was supposed to be.

"That- that's it!"

"No way..."

"That's the big..."

"It was shape of a star!"

And in that moment, something soared against the star. A giant robot flew toward it.

It was a Gigantes. The Gigantes pulled out its sword, unleashing its own world power as it flew toward the star. Bright light filled the sky with a loud explosion and the world turned into white. Something broke down. Something appeared from where the star was at. And everyone saw.

The star was falling down.

"Ah..."

"No way..."

The emotion that overcame the fear swept the people. It was madness. People realized what they were witnessing.

It was the revolution, the fall of one world. The fall of a world contributing to the beginning of a new one.

"It was true! Rupture..."

"Finally...!"

As every being was in astonishment as they looked up, only two beings were distant as they looked up to the sky.

"...Jaehwan?" Runald asked in confusion. Jaehwan glanced at Runald and placed his hand on his head. Runald felt relieved by the warmth of the hand. At least nothing had changed for him.

The debris of the destroyed star was falling down. Today was the day when the world turned dark and countless spirits perished.

[Big Brother] had fallen from the sky.

Chapter 189: Fallen star (6)

The fall of the star.

Rumors spread quickly on what every being within Depth saw.

"Myad was right!"

"He claimed Big Brother was in shape of a star for hundreds of years and finally..."

"So, he did everything just to destroy Big Brother after all!"

Myad's fight began to become glorified and it became the truth, influencing the entire [Depth]. After a week, there was another truth that everyone came to accept.

-[Big Brother] has fallen.

It was the most shocking incident out of the 210 thousand years of history of the [Depth].

"Dammit. That damn thing buried Jaehwan and the 7th site!"

7th site, Throne Room of Edmunt...

Surha, who was the strategist of the 'Fallbringers', was discussing matters with Pierre. She mumbled as she paced around the room endlessly, "Ugh, this is crazy. We should've had enemies running to the 7th site by now..."

The incident made Jaehwan become an instant star. The incident named [Return of the Hope] was the only chance for the 7th site and the Fallbringers to grow in power. Surha knew this. That's why she used every

ounce of her power to spread Jaehwan's name and to have him act a symbol to fight against Rupture.

But a week ago, on the [Day of Revolution], her plans turned to dust.

Everyone's attention was now on Myad and Rupture. Even within the 7th site, Rupture and Big Brother were bigger issues than Jaehwan himself.

"...Ugh. Pierre, talk to me. What should we do now? What do you think?"

In the midst of all the questions, Pierre just looked out to the window dumbfoundedly. Surha didn't expect an answer so she didn't care.

'I didn't know Rupture was going to do that... so what really happened?'

She felt like her head was going to explode just by thinking about all the questions she had.

"Pierre. Did Master really defeat Big Brother?"

She was confused. Her head refused to believe it, but she saw it with her own eyes. The star. She still remembered the face Myad made whenever he pointed at the star.

-Surha, that is where our goal lies.

It was certain. The star that was destroyed was the star that Myad showed her before.

'But there's no way. I didn't see that future. Master didn't plan on fighting Big Brother..!'

Surha bit her lips as she remembered the [Premonition] she saw before.

[Depth] in blood red. Rupture that had fallen, and the gods who were destroyed. Myad, stood upon everything he had finished, declaring a new world.

Was it really Myad?

It was one of the strongest and clearest premonitions, and she had to believe it. Yet every bit of reality was opposing her premonition right now.

Myad suddenly flew up into the sky and took the star down.

Myad, who had been accused by everyone, was now becoming the savior of the [Depth]. There were now forces agreeing to his Depth Invasion as a whole.

The fall of Big Brother had that much significance. Surha asked again, "Pierre. Did Big Brother really fall? Do you think so?"

Pierre glanced over at Surha and turned back to the sky. He had been looking into the sky increasingly lately.

"Maybe. Maybe not."

Surha became curious.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean what I said. Maybe and maybe not."

"...Is it a trend to make things difficult? That brat did it while ago."

Surha frowned at the thought of a boy mumbling 'Ouroboros'.

"You told me before that Myad can't defeat Big Brother."

"Yes."

"So, how did Myad defeat Big Brother?"

"I don't know."

"...What?"

Surha barely held back from screaming. Her discussions with Pierre were always like this. She remembered that Ouroboros boy explaining that 'It's

all because of Ouroboros.'

'Pierre also went to the forest too.'

Jaehwan, Runald, and Pierre. Those were the ones who had visited the Forest of Madness. She realized they all shared similarities in how they discussed things. To them, important things were never clearly said.

Surha wasn't sure what Jaehwan was thinking right now. She knew he was trying to go up to the top of Tree of Imagery to destroy the System, but she wasn't sure what made him want to do that and what was driving him. Runald once spoke to Surha who was frustrated.

'The problem is the question.'

'Question?'

'You have to ask the right question.'

She didn't pay much attention, but she thought maybe, maybe it was true. What was important was the question... Surha looked at Pierre. Something came to her mind.

"Pierre. You said Big Brother is a 'moon' to you."

Pierre stopped and slowly nodded.

"Do you still see that 'moon'?"

Pierre became hesitant and answered, "No."

"..Oh. Dammit."

Surha answered with disappointment. This time, Pierre turned against Surha. It was the right question.

"I don't see the moon anymore, so you think Big Brother has disappeared."

"...I won't deny that."

Surha thought if Big Brother really disappeared, every being who could see Big Brother could no longer see him. And in [Depth], only four people could see Big Brother.

Myad, Budda, Pierre, and Jaehwan.

Surha had two questions to ask. But maybe she didn't need to ask both. Asking one was enough.

"Pierre, if you can't see Big Brother, I guess Master defeated Big Brother. It must be true."

"Truth..."

Surha was surprised to see Pierre looking so lonely.

"The moon did disappear from my unique world." Pierre started, "I'm pretty sure it's the same for Budda. The founders of Rupture share the unique world in some way."

"Huh? You mean.."

"If Myad's world lost the 'star', then my 'moon' will disappear also. It will be the same as the 'star' in Budda's world."

Surha didn't know the founders of Rupture shared their unique world. However, it made sense as they were the ones who created Rupture's unique world too. They were just looking at the same world in different ways.

This meant something had to be certain.

"...Then, Big Brother is dead?"

Surha wasn't sure of her despair. If Big Brother was dead, it was a good thing. She wasn't sure why she didn't feel so good about it.

"I'm not sure."

"Why?"

"Because no one knows what Big Brother actually is."

It was another question as an answer. Surha tried to shout angrily when Pierre spoke.

"Surha, you are from a [Remote Region], right?"

It was so sudden that Surha lost her chance to shout angrily.

"...Yeah."

"What was the place like?"

"It was a small planet. Ordinary. Enough living beings... That kind of a planet."

"Planet..."

Pierre smiled and asked, "How can you be so certain?"

"Huh? What?"

"That it was a planet. How can you be certain?"

"...What is this nonsense?"

Surha felt as if she was being treated as stupid.

"It's common knowledge. We had a thing called science. We studied planets and whatnot..."

"Science... so, did they prove your world to be a 'planet'?"

"Yeah, pretty much."

"Then, you trust them and think that your world is a planet."

"...What are you trying to say? Isn't it common sense that the remote regions are just planets?"

"And wasn't it told by ones who studied science?"

"Yeah... I mean it's a fact. It's obvious."

"Obvious? What's obvious? How can it be a fact when you never moved out to space to see your world with your own eyes?"

Surha became dumbfounded.

"I haven't, but there are scientists who have done that!"

"So you just trust their words."

"NO! I mean... UGH!"

Surha became frustrated. She didn't need to look with her own eyes to really know. People learned it to be true, and there was no need to doubt it.

"Did you ever wonder if the scientists were maybe lying?"

"I mean.. huh? What?"

"Lie. Have you ever thought that they might be manipulating the truth?"

"And why would they..."

Surha gasped in the middle of the sentence. She now realized that this discussion wasn't actually about a planet or her own homeworld. Pierre had been talking about Big Brother all along.

"Y-you are saying that Big Brother is fake? There was no such thing from the beginning?"

"..."

"Wait, did you not see the 'moon' from the beginning? You..."

"I didn't say that."

Pierre looked up to the skies again.

"There was a star. It's the 'truth'."

"But why..."

"But there is no way to prove that the 'truth' I saw was an actual 'fact.'"

Pierre looked into the skies. There was no more that used to exist above.
The one he longed for and hoped for was no longer there.

That's when Pierre looked at the man outside the window. Below, there was a man looking up to the sky. Jaehwan.

It was weird. How could he look in such a way? They were looking at the same skies, but they looked at it so differently. Unlike Pierre who had lost what to see, Jaehwan was clearly glaring at something.

'I see...'

Pierre smiled.

'So, that's why they call you hope.'

Pierre thought he could finally understand humans a little more.

A month passed.

-Big Brother is dead. We will now live in a world without him.

Myad's declaration spread across entire Tree of Imagery within a month.

It was the beginning of the time of Rupture.

Chapter 190: Fallen star (7)

"It's bad."

"..."

"Sorry to say this, but I don't know what to do anymore."

Surha confessed to everyone in the Fallbringers. Chunghuh and Karlton looked at each other. It was weird to see Surha, who was so full of pride, to be that sullen.

"I heard they got Karavan. And Droyan, the God of Dragons."

"It is as I figured..."

"Yeah."

They had expected it, so it wasn't surprising. The biggest problem now was not about Karavan. No one dared to say it out loud, but they all knew very well. Rupture had already won this war.

"As you all know, this is really bad."

"..."

"Apart from the fact that all the other sites are under Rupture's control, we are losing men in our 7th site too. It will get worse as time goes by."

It was as she said. The forces of the 7th site were getting weaker as the days passed.

It was due to the Lost Ones created from Machina's [Link Destroy]. Jaehwan went out to restore each individual's link manually, but there was a limit as many beings refused to return back to their Gods.

These people all walked out of the 7th site to join Rupture. Vicegerents were hesitant on what was right, and the Followers who were bent of their own good all succumbed to astonishing feat by Myad.

But how couldn't they? They just witnessed the strongest God in [Depth] perish.

The Fallbringers' expressions darkened. It didn't fit the 'Fallbringers' who had been charging recklessly no matter the outcome until now. Sirwen opened her mouth in annoyance.

"What's up with you all? We're not done yet."

"..."

"Why are you so down? Are we giving up before we even fight?"

Surha then became furious at her words.

"Don't you get the situation?"

"NO."

"Big Brother is dead!"

"So what!"

Two women shouted at each other like children. Sirwen continued angrily, "Who cares! Who cares about Big Brother! It doesn't matter!"

"...No, you're wrong, Nightmare girl."

Chunghuh interrupted them.

"Contrary to that, the death of Big Brother isn't a simple thing."

"Then what is it?"

"That's... hmph."

Chunghuh did interrupt to stop the arguing, but it seemed like he could not find the words to explain himself. Besides, he wasn't good at explaining things anyway.

"If it's okay, can I share a word?"

"H-huh? You are..."

Chunghuh and Sirwen turned to the voice. A man limped out with a helping stick to the front.

It was Yoonhwan. He had volunteered to join the Fallbringers after the battle with Gerome. He hadn't fully recovered yet, but he had recent information about Rupture. Sirwen almost snapped for letting some sissy interrupt them, but she remembered this sissy had a close relationship with Jaehwan.

'Oh, he's a friend of Jaehwan.'

If Jaehwan moved out to rescue him, he should have been a really close friend. Sirwen remembered Yoonhwan falling unconscious as he tried to touch Jaehwan's cheek. It was a sight that brought her an awkward imagination. Sirwen let him talk although she was slightly annoyed.

"Well... you can talk."

Yoonhwan nodded.

"To put it simply, we've lost our justification now."

"Justification?"

Sirwen didn't understand where he was going, but she didn't respond as the mood began to change due to Yoonhwan. He was smiling at each and every one of the members. It was a good smile. He did share a bit of character

with Karlton, but unlike Karlton who had a more cold, formal side, Yoonhwan's smile was very heartwarming and friendly.

He had a smile that calmed just by looking.

This alone changed the mood of the meeting room. It was the power of Yoonhwan, the Smile Knight. Sirwen frowned.

'What? Has everyone gone mad? What the heck is going on? It's just some sissy smiling!'

Sirwen didn't know, but Yoonhwan's ability had been developing since the days at the tower. He had the power to ease friends who were tense. Jaehwan knew this also and allowed Yoonhwan to join the meeting. Yoonhwan's ability now even became a [Setting] after he came to [Depth].

[Increase Morale]

It worked to increase friendliness toward Yoonhwan while increasing the morale of the people around him, but it did not work against Sirwen. Therefore, she just became more annoyed by Yoonhwan's smile.

"What is a justification?"

"I will have to go into detail, if it's not too much..."

"It is too much."

"Oh, don't worry. It won't be way too much though."

Some people laughed at Yoonhwan's words. They were becoming relaxed. Sirwen did not laugh.

'Is he making fun of me?'

Yoonhwan began to speak.

"You all know what Rupture did in [Depth] recently. They started a war without warning and invaded many sites illegally, killing Vicegerents and

Followers. You too must know what happened then, Sirwen."

"Rupture became the public enemy of [Depth]."

"Yes. [Depth] began to criticize Rupture. It was because what they did was wrong."

Yoonhwan spoke as he smiled like an elementary school teacher. Sirwen quickly understood what he meant.

"Right. So is that the justification? That Rupture was bad?"

"Yes, if put simply."

"But isn't that still in effect? It doesn't change the fact that they attacked all those sites."

"They did, logically speaking. But it's the feeling that says otherwise."

"What are you getting at?"

"Sirwen. Do you have certain concerns?"

"Concerns?"

"Yes. Let's say... about a romantic relationship?"

"R-romantic?"

Sirwen glanced around and her eyes met with Jaehwan's. She raised her voice.

"I- I don't have such concerns!"

Yoonhwan seemed to recognize something.

"Well, let's just assume you have for now."

"W-what?!"

Sirwen blushed, but Yoonhwan continued before she can start.

"How about we put it this way. Sirwen, you hate me. Don't you?"

"...Yeah. I hate you. I hate you the most right now."

Yoonhwan smiled as if he expected it.

"Of course, you do. I was a part of [Rupture] until recently after all."

"...Well, that's not the reason," Sirwen mumbled with a small voice.

"Anyway. So?"

"And what if I become a great help to you?"

"Help?"

"Yes. I will help you accomplish... something so great that you can forget about all the bad emotions you have about me... such as your life goal."

Sirwen scoffed, "There's no way you can be of such help."

"Why not? I can have you and Jaehwan to get together, for example."

"W-what-what-what?!"

Chapter 191: Fallen star (8)

Sirwen frantically raised her voice.

"W-why are you talking about Jaehwan! What's up with that?!"

"Oh, I am assuming you are interested in Jaehwan. I guess I forgot to mention it."

"W-why are you assuming such...!"

"Anyway, let's just assume for the sake of things. Even if you hate me so much, if I help you to get together with Jaehwan... wouldn't you change your thoughts of me?"

"Th-that's... uh..." Sirwen stuttered.

"Just answer me. Yes or no. It's just an example."

"W-well... I guess, yes."

"What is yes? You mean you are thankful for me helping you and Jaehwan get together?"

"Y-yeah. You're right."

Sirwen answered as she gave up. Yoonhwan clapped satisfyingly and the others clapped also.

"You are right. It's exactly that."

"What is that exactly?!"

She felt she had been made a fool. She glanced over at Jaehwan, but he didn't seem to care. Chunghuh and Runald cackled while Sirwen just glared.

Yoonhwan said, "The feeling you will have toward me, is the same feeling these Vicegerents currently have toward Rupture."

"Huh?"

"They are thankful."

Sirwen became confused. Her 2,400 years of consciousness came back to her. The story that took a long detour finally came back to the original topic.

"Wait... You mean... Vicegerents are..."

"They are thankful for Rupture."

"Even after all they've been through?"

"Yes, although it's hard to understand."

"But why! That's impossible!"

"Like I said, it doesn't make sense. But it's an emotional aspect."

Yoonhwan continued explaining, "The fall of Big Brother so significant that the people don't care about what Rupture did to [Depth] anymore."

Sirwen then began to think. Actually, she kind of understood. Big Brother was the most terrifying being in [Depth] until now.

Big Brother was the being that controlled the System and started all the [Settings]. He was a being who could kill anyone at any time for any reason. Big Brother was such a being. A tyrant who could do anything. And it was Rupture who freed [Depth] from that terror.

'I see...'

Sirwen then understood.

"So, that's what you mean. We have no justification."

"Yes. Rupture is not the enemy, but the hero of [Depth]."

Myad appeared suddenly and took down the tyrant on the day of the Revolution. Yoonwan continued, "And Myad's recent proclamation is reinforcing Rupture into its frame."

"Proclamation? What was it?"

"He is claiming that he will unite all unique worlds into one to create a world with no wars, no Big Brother."

"That's impossible.."

"Yes, but that's what everyone believes in now. There are rumors that the sites under Rupture are better to live in. Regardless, I believe that it's a false rumor."

Sirwen felt a shiver, "But that's wrong."

Defeated Big Brother? It might be a good thing if it was true. But what about all those spirits that were killed before destroying Big Brother? How could killing Big Brother justify all those evil deeds?

Sirwen felt like it was strange to think about all this. It wasn't like her who was not interested in any ethical issues before she met Jaehwan.

"It's hard to explain, but it's wrong."

"Yes, it's wrong, but who can blame Rupture for it?"

"..."

"Justice is equality, and there is no greater justice to say that you are wrong. Who can say that to Myad at this point?"

"...So what? Give up now?"

"No," Yoonhwan answered with a smile. "We have to find the person. The person who can question Myad. Well, I think there's only one person who can do that though."

And everyone turned to the same place. Yes, it didn't need to be mentioned from the beginning. The reason they were able to gather here was because of one person.

But...

"Huh? Where did he go?"

"He was here just until a moment ago."

"Jaehwan?"

Jaehwan wasn't here.

Fortress of Caspion, the 8th site. Office of the Master of Rupture.

Kashim was reporting to Myad who was looking out the window silently. He had a pale face with an unshaven mustache. Myad's face was pale and it sunk as days passed by. Kashim held back from asking out of concern and continued with his reports.

"We have increased the number of Lost Ones requesting to join us. The numbers from each site are..."

The report indicated that it was hard to control the influx of volunteers. Myad answered in a coarse and tired voice.

"Use the simulation to filter them out. Kill those without potential."

"...Is that okay, sir?"

"We've been doing that since forever. Why is it a problem now?"

"Y-yes, but..."

Kashim became hesitant but he eventually answered, "Understood, sir."

Kashim then walked out of the room. Everything was going fine, but it didn't feel so good for Kashim. Why was that? That's when a man ran up to him.

"4th Captain."

"Oh, Adel."

Adel was now a lieutenant of Kashim. They began to walk down the corridor.

"Have you finished the report, sir?"

"Yeah. You?"

"I've finished the resupplying of our troops. We can advance toward the 7th site tomorrow."

"Good."

"You seemed tired, sir."

"No, it's okay."

"..."

"Do you have something to say?"

Adel then asked, "If I may, can I ask a question?"

"Yeah. Anything's fine unless it's about leaving Rupture."

Both men smiled at the joke and Adel continued, "There are words spreading among our members."

"Words?"

"About Big Brother, sir."

Kashim realized where the story was going already.

"There are members who are curious as to why the System still exists when we defeated Big Brother."

"...You are well aware that killing a God doesn't remove everything."

"Not only that, the [Little Brother] network is still intact and there isn't any change within the [Great Lands]. The members are..."

Kashim then raised his hand to stop and spoke.

"Adel. Is it really our members who are curious? Or is it yours?"

"...To be honest sir, it's both."

"Adel."

"Yes, sir."

They were now outside the corridor. Adel wasn't sure if this coldness was from the outside weather or from his feelings. Kashim asked, "Didn't I tell you before?"

"About...?"

"A mere fall of a star doesn't change the world."

Kashim looked up to the sky. It wasn't only Kashim. Most beings of [Depth] recently began looking up to the skies often. As if they just realized that there was a sky, people kept looking up. They kept looking up as if something will appear if they just kept doing that.

Adel asked, "...Do you know anything about it, sir?"

"No. I'm just an 'ordinary' Awakener."

"Ordinary..."

"Yes. What would I know?"

They both looked up to the skies without words. They were looking at the same sky, but it didn't feel that way. Adel felt a bit lonely.

What was it in that sky? What did they do wrong, or what was wanted from them that this world existed?

And in this world, what did the Master of Rupture want to achieve?

"I don't know much, but I know one thing." Kashim spoke bitterly, "It is only beginning of the war."

Next day, news of Rupture's forces advancing toward the 7th site, Eepoche, spread all over [Depth]. And it wasn't explained, but the Fortress of Rupture in the 8th site exploded at the same time.

It was beginning of the last war of the [Depth].

Chapter 192: A lone world (1)

[Fact that only one exists also means that none exists.]

-Pierre, the God of Mischief

Episode. A lone world.

Heavy rain was falling. Lightning struck from the sky with thunder roaring down to the ground. All people of [Depth] walked out to the streets to soak themselves in the rain of world power. They all said the same thing.

There had never been a rainy season for this long. If this was over, the world was going to change into an entirely different world.

There were soldiers advancing through the rain. People of [Depth] did not know what lied beyond the end of the advance but they just guessed that there was something.

'Is there really something though?'

Mirel, the 5th Captain of Rupture, thought grimly as she saw the 7th site coming to sight over the horizon. Yoo Surha, her old friend, was probably within the site.

'Surha. It's time for your decision.'

Jaehwan's footsteps were covered in the area. The 8th site, Caspion, seemed to be very different since his return after four months. He did hear the rumors that the land had been prosperous after Rupture took over, but it all seemed like false rumors. As Jaehwan took another small portal, he stepped into the blue forestland of the 8th site.

As it was a forbidden place, there were the Lost Ones who became monsters or broken down [Parts] attacking him, but they were no match against Jaehwan. As he walked further, he smelled water from the distance. Jaehwan followed and reached a familiar place.

He had reached a Fishing Spot, or the place where spirits were being fished up to [Depth].

Jaehwan stopped right there. This Fishing Spot was special to him. There was someone who had taught him many things when he just got to [Depth]. Maybe he could call her a 'friend' now. She had given him so many significant things. He remembered her name. It was Andersen.

-Andersen? I remember her.

Pierre knew her.

-She is the only god I inherited the [Naked] Setting from when I disguised myself as a God of Madness.

-YOU were the God of Madness?

-Yes, I was. It was 100 thousand years ago though.

-I see.

-Technically, the God of Madness didn't specify just one God. It was supposed to mean all of the Long Living race. Everything they did in their region was considered to be the work of the God of Madness. The God of Madness that Andersen mentioned is probably me. I was the one who taught her.

Jaehwan remembered Andersen as he came back here. He hoped she was alive somewhere since she was a God, but it was just false hope. He wasn't the only one who could kill a God. Myad also had such power.

Jaehwan clenched his hands and opened them. Faint silver powder was thrown up into the air. Jaehwan looked up to it and turned.

Soon, the forbidden area was gone and Jaehwan was up on the hill toward the place where Hatchnold auction house used to be. Nothing was there anymore. The auctioneers and gatekeepers weren't there. They had all been killed in that clash.

Maybe it was Jaehwan's fault. Perhaps it was his mistake, choice, or determination that made people die along with countless worlds and their potentials. Jaehwan knew this, but it didn't stop him from moving forward. It actually made him move forward.

Jaehwan stopped all of a sudden.

"How far are you going to follow me?"

Behind Jaehwan, the air distorted and revealed one man. There was a silver wing on the back of the man. Jaehwan knew the man. His blonde hair shook against the wind and rain.

"Since when did you know?"

"Since when you began following me."

Karlton nodded. He was just lucky that he found Jaehwan quietly moving out of the meeting room. He snuck away without letting anyone notice. If Karlton hadn't kept looking at Jaehwan, he too would not have noticed. Jaehwan couldn't let others know as he had to follow Jaehwan quickly. It took him hours of running to not fall behind Jaehwan. Finally, he looked back.

"...Why did you not stop then?"

"Because I had no reason to then."

"Which means you have reason to now?"

"Yeah."

"Why..."

"It's dangerous from here onward."

Karlton then glanced over at the fog beyond Hatchnold. He knew what lied between their current location and the end of that fog. For the first time, the word 'danger' came so clearly to him. There was that much terrifying world power.

[Highseeker], the headquarters of Rupture.

The most powerful beings who were on the precipice of uniting [Depth] was in there. Just looking at it from afar was enough to feel its power. Karlton knew. If he went closer to it, he would be crushed instantly.

"You are no help. I know that you don't even have a unique world right now," Jaehwan answered. Karlton couldn't object or deny it.

"Did you know?"

"How would I not know?"

Karlton had achieved the 4th step Awakening, but he still did not have his unique world. Of course, not having a unique world was the point here. It was impossible for an Awakener to reach the 3rd step without a unique world. So, Karlton probably had a unique world, but he just couldn't realize that he had one. He probably had a powerful world within him, which he was drawing his power from, but he wasn't sure what it was.

If he put in the effort and looked carefully within him, he would become a powerful 4th step Awakener. But that was in the future, not now. Karlton couldn't even handle a high-ranking God's Vicegerent right now, let alone the Master of Rupture.

"I know I am of no help."

"You do? You don't seem to know that based on what you are doing."

"Yes, I do," Karlton answered and Jaehwan frowned.

"Let me rephrase it. You will be getting in the way."

"I know."

"..."

"But what will you do if I still will follow you?"

Karlton's determination shook Jaehwan's eyes. He closed his eyes to hide it. He thought about it. This was why he tried to come alone.

It was the same in the Tower of Nightmares, in [Chaos], and in [Depth].

Jaehwan always lost something. He knew this very well and refused to make friends if possible. The only thing promised that stood in his way was a loss. He'd have to pay the price of something he valued for something else. He even wished for someone to walk the path together with him. Honestly, he was so lonely and tired that he felt weak.

After he realized Ouroboros and acquired the [Eye of Geshtalt], Jaehwan realized that he had to walk this path alone. No one was allowed to walk together or behind him. The one who walked this path will...

"You will die."

Jaehwan opened his eyes and spoke coldly. He knew this would hurt Karlton, but he still did it anyway. Karlton just smiled.

"Yes, I will die. I will not be able to protect myself, Master."

Karlton did not back down and Jaehwan frowned.

"Why are you still calling me Master?"

"Because you are the Master."

"We aren't at [Chaos]."

"I know, sir."

"You don't need to serve me anymore."

"I know."

"And why are you following me?"

Karlton smiled, "Master, do you remember the first day we met?"

"Yeah."

Of course, he remembered. How could he forget the first day he entered Gorgon Fortress? Karlton the Stubborn was the one who memorized all laws of Gorgon and scanned for any illegal entries.

"I told you then that our justice might have a chance to fight against each other."

He remembered when Karlton accepted Jaehwan to come in. The day when no one was hurt, no one's justice was ruined. When Jaehwan asked Karlton for the change of mind, Karlton spoke then.

"And this is the moment."

And Karlton was now continuing on with those words.

"You want to go alone, but I can't let you go alone. So, the day has come at last. The day our justice clashes."

Chapter 193: A lone world (2)

Jaehwan became silent. He didn't realize Karlton of all people would joke in such a way.

"You don't want to let me go alone? Can you call THAT your justice?"

"That is my justice, sir."

Justice was fair. There was no greater nor lesser — that was justice. It was something that could not be compromised. Jaehwan realized that just like how Karlton changed his mind back then, it was time for him to change his mind. Jaehwan sighed, "Do what you want. I've warned you."

"...Thank you."

Jaehwan turned and began moving toward the Highseeker. Karlton walked closer to follow. It seemed like he was happy to get the chance to walk beside Jaehwan.

"I don't have world power, but I can share mine with you. I've helped our friends with that until now."

"Share the world power?"

"Yes, sir. I have more world power than what I can share with most people and I don't lose much in doing so. I'm not sure how it came to be."

"Is that so?"

Jaehwan looked at Karlton with an astonished look. A Setting to share world power? He had not heard of such a Setting that existed in [Depth]. It was because the world power could've been divided without using the

Setting. Considering the fact that Settings were deeply connected with unique worlds, it was possible that Karlton's power was somehow related to his hidden unique world.

As he looked at the Highseeker, Karlton continued, "I knew you would do something like this moment you left the meeting back then."

"..."

"You always did these types of things since the [Chaos] days. Our morale has gone down, we have no options left, and we have no chance against head-on collisions. There's only one choice for you to make in that case."

Jaehwan did not answer as there was no need to. Karlton knew everything already.

"I heard forces were on the move toward the 7th site in the morning. They must have arrived by now."

"...Probably."

Jaehwan also knew this. Rupture was gathering all armies throughout all the sites to advance toward Pierre's 7th site. It was a plan to destroy any last remaining resistance against Rupture. Any surviving Lords or high step Awakeners were probably sent out to the war.

Therefore, that meant that headquarters was vulnerable.

It was a matter of time. Who will cling on, and who will take the flag first?

Jaehwan's flag was at the top of the Highseeker. With the presence of terrifying world power, it was obvious that Myad was staying within the headquarters. If Jaehwan wasn't lucky, he might have a few Captains around or limited forces.

But that was all things considered. Karlton asked, "Are you going straight to Myad?"

"Yeah. I'm going right to him."

"...I see."

Rupture was controlled by one being. If he who created the unique world were to fall, Rupture would have no choice but to fall. And that was the only plan Jaehwan had right now. Karlton asked again, "He defeated Big Brother. Do you really have a chance against him?"

Jaehwan then smiled for the first time. Or was it a smirk?

"Big Brother..."

It was a brief moment, but Karlton found some possibility in there. Jaehwan was someone who could see Big Brother too. Surha once said that Big Brother disappeared in Pierre's unique world.

The rumor spread too quickly so no one asked Jaehwan about it. They either forgot about it, or they were just afraid. If Jaehwan couldn't see Big Brother either, then the amount of despair was too big to handle. They just waited for Jaehwan to mention it himself.

'That smile...'

It was natural for Karlton to wish for something as he looked at Jaehwan smiling while looking up into the sky.

"Ugh, this is annoying."

"Huh?"

"The tail is too long."

Karlton looked up to the sky. There, the shadow of a giant ship appeared from the back with the roar of an old man's voice.

-Jaehwan, you fool! Don't leave me behind!

Karlton smiled, "I guess you will never be left alone, Master."

"We sent Mirel and three Lords with 200 3rd step Awakeners. They don't stand a chance."

"...Pierre isn't easy to deal with."

"I know, but I don't think he's stronger than you."

In the outer castle of the Highseeker-

Kashim finished his briefing as they both looked far out at the scenery from the terrace.

"Maybe in a direct head-on fight, but he trained with me. Don't let our forces underestimate him."

"Understood."

Kashim nodded as he was surprised by Budda's concern. Budda defeated two of the 8 Gods of [Depth]. It was a power that can he could be prideful about, but he didn't overestimate his power.

"How's Myad?"

"He looks tired ever since the Day of the Revolution."

"Yeah. It was that big of a deal."

Budda cackled. He also remembered what Myad showed.

'I mean, he did put up a great show.'

Nobody would ever see such sight again — the fall of a star. Budda remembered his excitement as he saw the sight. His excitement was different from the emotions that other beings had felt. Budda was the one who was mostly responsible for what happened that day. Budda was the one who played the biggest part in making the Day of the Revolution become a reality.

'If it wasn't for those bastards...'

He gritted his teeth as he remembered Ignis the God of Flame and Droyan the God of Dragons. As he fought them, Budda died 1412 times and reincarnated 1412 times. He had died 1617 times throughout his thousands of years of life, but he had died close to that amount in just one day.

And the Vicegerent of Ignis was so powerful that Budda almost lost his energy.

'If this time passes, the new world will come.'

And then it would be the end of their journey. The world power of the Gods were taken and their grand plan -A lone world- only had one final step left.

"Captain, can I ask..."

"What?"

"Do you have the same thoughts as Master?"

Budda turned cold. He became suspicious if the Master had spoken to Kashim about their grand plan, but before his suspicion could take form, Kashim continued, "About... that, he will be coming."

"Oh, that."

Budda smiled viciously.

"He will."

It had been a while since he last heard about the man from Myad. It was surprising to know there was another being who could see Big Brother.

"If Myad said he'll come, then he'll come. That's why we kept him alive."

Budda glanced at Karavan who was laying on the floor of the terrace. He had now become a Lost One with most of his spirit having been destroyed. They tried to accept him as a member because his spirit had great potential, but he refused strongly.

'Poor guy.'

A report then came in from the watchtower. There were busy movements from all sides and members were swept away by a world power. Budda smiled.

The only one who knew about the truth of this world had finally appeared at [Highseeker].

Myad mumbled silently as he looked out the window, "You are here, Jaehwan."

Chapter 194: A lone world (3)

Multiple explosions came from outside the window. It was a fitting sight for a man with the nickname of the Pioneer of the Impossible. Awakeners of Rupture were torn apart by Jaehwan's world power. There was the sight of a giant wave sweeping through the city. The power was disastrous.

He was the same type of Awakener, but what made him different? Maybe it was because the goal was different.

Awakening was the beginning of another way, not the end. The ones who tried to stay faltered while the ones who tried to advance got stronger. Awakening was the power that allowed them to do this.

'It's not infinite.'

Myad remembered his old memories as he watched Jaehwan sweeping through everything from the outside. He had fought many things for a long time. There was a day when he was like that. He had fought for humans, and later fought for 'being'. He did not know what it was, but he proudly claimed he fought for them.

-Let's do it! We can do this!

A lot of things happened then. Myad remembered countless Vicegerents who shared the same thought with him. A fight to regain their right against the Gods. But they never succeeded.

-Right? What is that? Does that make you stronger?

To Gods, spirits were just consumables to increase their world power. They didn't care about 'beings'. Beings were worthless. As Myad realized he couldn't change anything with his power, someone came to him.

-Are you the one who can see the star in the sky?

Budda and Pierre were Awakeners who had lived much longer than Myad. Myad couldn't forget the day he created Rupture along with them. Budda spoke then.

-It's good for 3 thousand years. But we can't go beyond 5 thousand or even 10. There's no coming back even if they're Humans or Gods. No one will try to climb up.

The ones who were the closest were the Ancient Three Gods, the first Awakeners, and ones who taught him about the Nightmare of the Beginning. They were the ones who taught him the secrets of the System and gave him dreams about the sky.

Through the smog of the explosions, he saw the shadow of his friend. 1st Captain Budda was fighting against Jaehwan. Budda screaming and unleashing his world power was like the figure of a devil rather the benevolent God that his Setting depicted.

As he watched, Myad realized the amount of time that had passed.

There were no longer the friends he remembered. The time was as such. Pierre who felt despair toward the wall that they never could climb left the Rupture and Budda who fought on the frontlines for countless years had his personality destroyed from all those deaths.

-Myad. You can still do it. We are too old, but you still can. You are the one with the strongest and healthiest spirit among all the Awakeners. That's why you are the Master of Rupture.

It was thousands of years ago when he heard this. The determination and the dream had all faded away. The only thing left was the desire and stubbornness. Despair over despair. Anger toward the dream that could never be accomplished.

Myad looked up to the sky.

It was cruel. A sky no one was allowed to climb. When was it that he gave up on that sky?

'Well, it's not important anymore.'

Myad smiled bitterly.

'If I can't take that sky, I'll create a new one.'

Myad brought his world power up and the entire sky of [Depth] turned red.

It was now a matter of time. A Lone World was about to start now.

Chunghuh frowned as he looked at Jaehwan cutting through all the Awakeners at the front.

"...I came out alone for a reason."

"Don't say that. Only I came. The rest are at the 7th site," Chunghuh said as he glanced at the ship that had struck against the wall of the 8th site. It was due to Chunghuh's bad driving.

"You and Karlton should've left too. That would've given them more time."

"Surha and Pierre are there. They can buy enough time."

Chunghuh then ran up to slash his sword. Awakeners were cut down into pieces. Chunghuh's world power was now over 1.5 million. Through the dead Awakeners, two men jumped down. One of the men had with a giant axe on his back and the other was a topless bald man.

"Long time no see, Chunghuh."

"Kashim? You've grown old."

Kashim frowned, "...How's Surha?"

"She's well."

It looked like a casual exchange, but it wasn't. Chunghuh realized what Kashim was thinking as he saw Kashim's glaring eyes.

"How did Imai go?"

"It was the end he wanted."

"Was it an honorable death?"

"Maybe it was in your shoes," Chunghuh answered. Hundreds of years ago, they were in very different shoes back then.

"I learned the sword from you once."

"Sword? You use an axe now."

"...Was it you who talked Surha out of it?"

"No. It's her decision."

"Rupture always pays back. You must know this if you were part of Rupture."

"Heh, how scary."

"You won't leave here alive."

"I see that you are so proud about your axe now then? How many times have you swung that thing?"

"Swung?"

Kashim recalled a long last memory then. Millions of slashes. It was when all the Captains of Rupture were alive. And they were not Captains yet.

"...Your fake Awakening method is no longer viable. Everyone uses [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] now."

Kashim then charged out. His muscles exploded as he charged in. He was now clenching his giant axe, the [Blood Wolf]. Dark red world power was unleashed from it.

The power made the ground crack up. The speed and power were very powerful indeed, it was an attack that none other than a Lord could take.

Jaehwan said, "Old man. Move..."

"Leave him with me."

Chunghuh disappeared in the next moment. The speed was equal with Kashims. Jaehwan then became curious. How did Chunghuh become this strong in the past few years? And how strong had he become?

A few attacks were exchanged with the shorter clashing sounds. The exchanges were now being made endlessly. Kashim seemed to be shocked by Chunghuh's world power that was not pushed back. Even if he was the weaker of the Captains, that was only between Captains.

He was still much stronger than ordinary Awakeners.

A man who had trained forever because he had no potential — that was Kashim.

Kashim unleashed his attack with his world power at full force. Chunghuh grimaced as he responded to the attack.

Another explosion came about. There were now giant holes in the ground due to the powerful clash between world powers. It was a close fight. Kashim spoke in shock from the smoke that was left from the explosion.

"...I can't believe this. You didn't even have a solid unique world when you left."

"That was back then."

"Did you earn a unique world? In a new Awakening way?"

"Yeah."

"But how..."

The debris died down and Chunghuh appeared with blue world power surrounding him. There were twelve swords floating around him.

"That's...!"

"Heh, did you notice now?"

"Sovereignty of Swords!"

It was a skill that Kashim knew very well. It was known that people from Moorim, World 12764, had high fighting prowess even without help from the System. The Sovereignty of Swords was the skill that most highly-skilled swordsmen used. The Lord of Steel Huhyou was the one who used the skill to become a Lord. Kashim even fought him before.

"...Chunghuh, did you return to become an Adapter?"

"Why would I?"

"But how... wait. Is it not a skill?"

Kashim became confused. Sovereignty of Swords was not being used as a skill? Of course, it was possible to use the skill without using the 'skill' from the System, but it was still a mere sword trick. If it was that powerful, there was no way Cultivators could've gone to Moorim.

"Are you really seeing it? Do you think this is just the Sovereignty of Swords?"

Kashim narrowed his eyes. All twelve swords with beautiful embroidery were readying themselves with different sword techniques.

'Different sword techniques?'

He then caught the glimpse of the unique world surrounding Chunghuh. Kashim gasped.

"No way..."

Chunghuh's swords then began unleashing different sword attacks. It was amazing to see twelve swords each moving on their own will with complicated attack paths.

Was it because he was mesmerized? Kashim didn't notice one of the swords charging at him. It was a strike with powerful world power.

Kashim moaned as he was barely was able to block the world power. It was as if a giant lion had charged into him. He had heard about this sword skill when he studied various materials to increase his power.

'The Emperor's Sword?'

It was the sword that many Moorim people used, but it was the one with the heaviest strikes of all. Kashim learned that people who used this had all died a long time ago. But so how did Chunghuh recover it?

'No, it's as if he created something entirely new...'

He couldn't continue his thoughts because second attack was coming. It was as if a flower was being unleashed in his eyes. He felt he even smelled the scent of a flower.

'This!'

Twenty-four Plums Sword

Kashim couldn't stand still. He then heard Chunghuh's voice.

"I got my hands on these books when I was looking up [Parts] of the Ancient Gods. It seems like there had been a lot of people from my world in the past Depth Expedition teams."

"I see, so your world is...!!"

All the sword skills from Moorim were unleashed upon Kashim, and Kashim had no way to retaliate. He had to concentrate on deflecting the attacks. After a while, he saw the shadow of the unique world behind Chunghuh. He should have realized it.

The unique world usually started from what the person could do best. Chunghuh's world was the world created by the dead people from Moorim.

Unique world – Moorim.

It was an amazing world and it was impossible to believe that it was created by one person. If given time, it could overcome the unique world of Rupture.

How much time did he put into opening the world? Kashim was astonished as he increased his world power.

'I shouldn't underestimate him.'

His axe exploded in red.

As Kashim and Chunghuh fought head-on, Jaehwan looked straight at the man in front of him. He knew who this topless man was. It was probably Budda.

"Shall we start then?"

Budda smiled as he gathered his hands.

[Thousand Hands]

Chapter 195: A lone world (4)

Screaming was heard throughout the 7th site. There was the sound of agony, writhing, and begging. The most desperate sound was the screaming. Was it for 30 minutes? An hour? Or maybe a few hours had passed already.

Runald didn't feel like they were screams anymore.

The screams were only there when other sounds were around. If every sound in the world was a scream, then the scream itself would lose its characteristics.

There was no more screaming coming to Runald's ears. There were countless Awakeners lying on the ground, and Vicegerents disappearing after a valiant fight. At the center of all battlefield, there were powerful beings exchanging blows of world power. Runald looked at them.

There was the God of Mischief Pierre, and two other Lords. And on top of that were Yoo Surha and 5th Captain Mirel delivering deadly blows to each other, destroying the landscape. It seemed like an equal fight for now, but it was evident as to where the fight was going now. Even if the strongest figures were equal in strength, the sheer number difference was just too great.

"Be careful!"

Many Vicegerents were swept away by Rupture's unique world that was unleashed by Awakeners. Runald was barely able to dodge it with the help of Sirwen who was fighting alongside him.

"Ugh, this is crazy."

Her eyes showed that Sirwen was fatigued due to her extreme use of magic.

There were metal giants fighting all around. They were the reason why the 7th site was still holding on. Tens of Gigantes were fighting against Awakeners. It was Nightmare Sirwen's creation and she was on the verge of becoming a [Master] craftsman. She had received parts from the [Nightmare Union] of the 5th site to create as many Gigantes as she could. They had been hastily created and thus they weren't very durable, but having the Vicegerents use the Gigantes to fight was helpful.

"Dammit, if only the old man didn't take the ship...!"

Sirwen controlled one of the Gigantes remotely to push away the Awakeners chasing at her. It would have made the fight easier if they had the ship, but Chunghuh had taken it away.

"You're good at controlling that thing."

"Heh, yeah. I'm experienced in Combat Gaming in World 294, you see."

"...Can a Nightmare travel freely to the [Remote Regions]?"

"Yeah, it's a privilege for Nightmares."

Sirwen was controlling them all with three controllers to fight against the Awakeners. It was astonishing indeed. Runald asked, "Did you really train through games?"

"Hey, I'm busy now. Stop interrupting me."

Nonetheless, Runald wasn't the type to listen to adults.

"So World 294 must be a terrible place... making a game to control Gigantes like that."

"Terrible? Hm... peaceful? It's called Earth. It's where Jaehwan came from."

Runald then remembered Jaehwan. He must be at the 8th site by now, or he was probably fighting again. However, Jaehwan was also an ordinary human once upon a time. What was he like back then? Wouldn't he miss his

homeworld? Once everything was over, what would happen to him? Runald became sad.

"Will he be okay?"

"What the heck? You're his Follower. You need to trust him."

"...Yeah."

Runald trusted his God of course. Who else could he trust if he didn't? But Runald couldn't hold back his concerns. He wasn't sure why he felt concerned, however.

There was no time to think. They needed to hold their ground until Jaehwan finished what he went to do...

That's when the strange sound of metals being ripped apart could be heard. There was a world power approaching as it destroyed the Gigantes like paper. Sirwen turned pale. Once of the Gigantes was lying in ruins. There were only a few with such world power left in [Depth] now.

"Dammit... there was another Lord?"

A sharp piece of debris was thrown toward Sirwen's left hand. She screamed as she dropped one of the controllers.

"Hehe... you and I have unfinished business, Nightmare girl."

It was Lord Varkant that was approaching. Pierre and Surha were busy fighting their opponents. The only ones who could fight against Varkant were Sirwen and Runald. Runald bit his lips.

"Give me that!"

"What?"

"That thing with a stick! Give me that! I can help!"

"NO! It's not something a kid like you can handle!"

A few more Gigantes exploded in unison. Even if the Gigantes could increase world power by a large margin, it was no match against a Lord.

"An interesting toy."

Varkant, who had been destroying the Gigantes, thought of an idea and began getting on one of the Gigantes.

"N-no!"

Sirwen turned pale. It was impossible to stop Varkant at this rate, but if he started using a Gigantes? It was obvious that they had no chance. Sirwen looked to Runald. If she couldn't live, she needed to save the boy at least. In the next moment, she was shocked beyond imagination.

"W-W-WHAT!! Why are you taking off your clothes?!"

Runald, who had become naked, was flinging his Ouroboros and stretching.

"Maybe I can fight him."

"What are you talking about! You can't even fight a single Awakener..."

"He just put on some powerful clothes."

"What?"

"I probably can fight him now."

A Gigantes was charging directly toward them. Runald bit his lips. He couldn't stay weak forever. He couldn't run. After all, he was Jaehwan's only Follower.

'Jaehwan, please give me strength...!'

Runald's naked body began to shine in gold.

Chapter 196: A lone world (5)

Swords thrust from all sides.

"UGH!"

Budda was amazed that he was gasping in pain. He was always on the side of listening to it, not the one letting out the sound. As he looked at silver powder coming out of his mouth, he had to accept the fact that he had underestimated the man.

This man wasn't just strong.

It was to the point where Budda thought if he met Jaehwan instead of Myad, their plan might have gone different ways. It was a young spirit that was barely 2 thousand years old. But how could such a spirit hold such power?

Budda, who had reincarnated thousands of times, couldn't see through all of moments this man had withstood. If he were to measure it in years, in maybe 100 or 200 years... this man might overtake Myad.

'But not yet...!'

Budda unleashed world power from his body. It consisted of all the power of his countless lives. Budda smiled.

'Even if you defeated Gerome... you can't...!'

Even if the young man was powerful, there was no way that he could defeat the time Budda had spent alive. Budda's world power soared to prove his confidence. It was now over 10 million.

It was enough to choke Jaehwan with the power pressing down on him, but Jaehwan didn't seem to be bothered. He seemed relaxed even. And it wasn't long when Budda became shocked.

"YOU! That EYE!!!"

He was referring to the spinning snake inside Jaehwan's left eye. Ouroboros, the snake that was biting its tail — Budda pointed to it with his shaking finger. It was similar to the snake in his eyes, but Budda's snake didn't bite on its tail.

"I-I see! So you were the one that Vicegerent of Ignis spoke of! You are the one who obtained the Eye of Geshtalt!"

"..."

"How did you get your hands on that! I couldn't get it even after tens of thousands of years...!"

Budda's eyes were filled with anger, and now he was suspicious. How did this young man get ahold of the tail of a snake that he could never achieve? Jaehwan asked, "I heard you can [Reincarnate]?"

Budda's eyes shook. Did he know about the [Reincarnation]? Well, Pierre knew about it so...

"That's why you couldn't get it."

"What?"

It was strange. Come to think of it, Ra-hamad did speak of similar things when Budda first created the [Reincarnation]. Using such way would never allow him to take the Eye of Geshtalt.

"You will never catch the 'tail' anymore. You can't."

It was very vague, but the vagueness angered Budda even further. Even if he couldn't finish his Ouroboros because of [Reincarnation], what was he to talk about it as if he knew it all?

"Cut the nonsense. Just DIE!"

Giant hands charged at Jaehwan. It was the powerful skill that he used against Karavan. Thousands of hands were rushing in. It was now faster, but they covered all the sides Jaehwan could avoid. Jaehwan did not try to avoid them. Instead, he changed his stance. The Ouroboros began to spin more violently in his eyes.

The world power began to storm.

'W-what is going on?!'

Jaehwan's world power began to soar. As it surged past 10 million, it seemed to be painful for Jaehwan, but it was just for a short moment.

11 million...

It was now long past Budda's world power. He now realized the secret behind Jaehwan's power.

'So that's the power of the Eye of Geshtalt...'

It was the [Setting] that Geshtalt used who had no Followers. His Setting allowed him to use his own clothes to become his Followers. The Setting granted more power if there were more clothes within him. It was the loneliest world power in this world.

[Fall]

Jaehwan's stabs that destroyed worlds ripped apart the thousands of hands. Budda knew he could [Reincarnate], but it was still terrifying. Budda felt as if he had seen a snake's tail-like thing.

Thousands of stabs swept away everything from Budda. It was absolute decimation.

And after a while...

The space distorted and began to peel itself like an onion. It was where Budda had perished. There was a flower that bloomed from it and Karavan had also seen it before.

Budda panted as he walked out of the flower leaves. He rubbed his eyes and spat, "...Ugh, this is disgusting."

A dead spirit coming back alive? This was a terrifying miracle. How was this possible? Jaehwan, however, didn't seem surprised. He simply stated, "So, that's the [Reincarnation]."

"Yes."

"You are not the one I fought."

Budda flinched.

"...How did you know?"

"You feel different."

Jaehwan glared at Budda and continued, "You are 'different clothes'. So, the different clothes take control of the spirit."

"..."

"That is not [Reincarnation]. The Budda that was here before is dead."

Budda shook at Jaehwan's declaration. He had reincarnated countless times and defeated countless enemies, but it was the first time that his secret had been revealed.

[Reincarnation]

It was far from a real 'resurrection' as the name suggested. When it was used, the previous personality perished instead. It then gave birth to one of the countless 'clothes' deep within the consciousness. A new set of 'clothes' then received the previous Budda's memory to be born from the flower.

Giving birth to a new self in place of his former self — that was the secret to Budda's [Reincarnation].

"You are no Budda. Budda died long ago."

Jaehwan's words pierced Budda's mind. This was what countless Buddas had thought about. They continued the memories and reshaped them in the same way, but it didn't change the fact that the previous Budda wasn't the exact same as the current one.

Budda knew this. Every time the reincarnation happened, his personality was changing. And he felt his core character that existed within him falling apart every time.

"SHUT UP! I am BUDDA!"

Budda couldn't accept it. Even if he knew, even if he accepted it, he was no longer 'Budda'.

"I am Budda! God of Invincibility, the God who has not lost once!"

Budda unleashed his world power. His thousands of years of his anger shot out to avoid his death.

Budda was certain that his path was not wrong. Even if he was no longer 'Budda' at the end of the path, he still would not lose. His self would keep coming back to life and...

Jaehwan's eye turned cold as he looked into the world power charging upon him.

"I see. Maybe we can try to see how many times you can return."

Budda's spirit was shaking. He had felt this feeling a while ago.

Fear? Did he feel scared?

Death. The fear of perishing. A feeling that he had long forgotten. As he faced Jaehwan's thousands of swords ready to be fired, Budda felt like he

was going through déjà vu. It was the sight of his future 'self' being killed mercilessly.

"You must know this if you have trained Ouroboros..."

Jaehwan's sword roared as he said, "Clothes are not infinite."

Budda charged while screaming.

Chapter 197: A lone world (6)

"W-what is this kid!"

The golden boy was charging through the battlefield, paralyzing various parts of the 7th site. Everyone who had been standing where boy passed by had their clothes ripped apart and their weapons thrown away.

'So, this is what Jaehwan must have felt!'

Runald realized this as he had become powerful. He didn't train hard like Jaehwan back in the Forest of Madness, but he didn't just waste time either. At least when he had his [Naked] Setting on, he was as strong as any other strong being in [Depth].

"AAARGH! MY CLOTHES!"

"NOO!"

"That damn kid!"

Awakeners screamed in shock as their clothes were forcefully ripped from them. Even the Lords who were fighting Pierre looked at Runald in disbelief.

"What kind of Setting is that..."

"AAARGH!"

"KILL HIM! DON'T STAND THERE TRYING TO HIDE YOUR THING!"

"DAMMIT!"

Awakeners who were now naked were busy trying to cover themselves and they were thrown away by Sirwen's Gigantes. She had brightened up due to Runald's unexpected power.

"Way to go, kid! Get their clothes off!"

But things didn't go all that well. Runald's feats made Lord Varkant become angry.

-Damn fool!

Varkant controlled the Gigantes from within by making it swing its fist. The strong world power charged at them. The ground was torn apart as millions of world power destroyed it. But Runald was already far away from the range of destruction.

-You are good for your age! But not enough!

Runald thought, 'Their lines are all cheesy.'

Every enemy of his always said something along those lines. Maybe the 'adults' who had survived in this world for a long had all become similar. They spoke of the same thing, cursed with the same words, and shared the same stories to live another day.

The Gigantes' fist struck against Runald's fist. With the explosion, Runald felt as if he was going to faint as he was thrown to the back.

'Goddammit.'

Runald hated adults. The reason why he chose Andersen who had a naked world and became Jaehwan's Follower who opposed the System, was probably based on that.

-HAHAHA! Come're, boy! I will teach you a lesson that world isn't so easy like you...

"SHUT UP!"

-What did you say?

As the world power began to seep out from the unique world, Runald's mind began to grow stronger. The hatred toward the world and hatred toward the system were rooted in his mind. But there was something that couldn't be solved with the anger.

As they exchanged another set of blows, Runald's right shoulder was dislocated. He quickly popped it back in place as he stood up.

'It's not enough.'

The enemy he was facing was not an ordinary 'adult'. It was a being who had reigned for thousands of years in the [Great Lands], Lord Varkant.

'It's not enough. Not at all!'

Runald had used the [Naked] Setting, but it wasn't enough to fight against Varkant. It was obvious. Varkant had about 5 million world power gained through thousands of years. Runald, on the other hand, only had about 100 thousand world power at most. It was thanks to his [Naked] Setting that allowed him to even survive.

-HAHAHAHAHA! GOOD!

With his laughter, the Gigantes punched Runald's body. Sirwen quickly threw her Gigantes to push away Varkant's attack and Runald backed away. He felt like he was going to faint. There weren't many forces left from the 7th site anymore. Pierre and Surha were still busy and there were still countless Awakeners left.

And now there was Varkant too. The fight was already almost over.

'Is it over?'

Runald felt angry. Was it okay to be finished like this? After all, that hey had gone through? After they survived until today? Was it okay to let it all end now?

No. That was not okay. That wasn't acceptable.

If there was just a bit more...

If there was just a bit more power...

Then, Runald heard a voice in his ears.

-Do you need power?

Runald was filled with disbelief. Maybe he finally had gone crazy. It was natural as he was in the middle of such a crazy war. The voice came to him again. It had turned into 'voices'.

-Hm... should we let him borrow our powers?

-Yeah, but he's still our only Follower.

-Follower? He's weak.

-But...

-Hmm? This is something new. You don't even lend your power to our original owner.

-Just a change in mind. He's kind of cute too.

-CUTE? Did you even look at his hideous thing?

Runald became dizzy. It was as if one man was speaking to act like different people. But Runald smiled. He wasn't sure, but he had an idea who this 'original' was. Runald asked them for help.

'Please give me power.'

-Huh? Do you really want it?

-HEY. Are you really...?

'Yes.'

Runald became desperate. If he was crazy, that was okay. If that was going to give him power, he was ready to give his everything.

-Whoa, he's determined. Good.

-What? Are you crazy? He's just a kid!

-Let's give him a try. See what happens.

-But...

The voice began to decrease in number.

-Good. I will give you power. But the price will be dire, so be ready for this. There is always a price to be paid.

The dark power began to surround Runald's body. It was as if it was based on the hatred itself.

More power. More time. If there was more potential...

Sirwen turned pale as she looked at Runald being surrounded by darkness. She realized something wasn't going right.

"Runald! STOP!"

And Pierre, the God of Mischief, witnessed Runald also.

"That is...!"

Pierre realized what was happening to Runald's body as he had lived in [Depth] for thousands of years. It was the most famous disease in [Depth] after.

'Newbie God Disease!'

Chapter 198: A lone world (7)

It was a disease that new Gods who had spent less than 2 years in [Depth] contracted, but it was unknown as to why it was happening to the boy. Nonetheless, Pierre was sure. His experience was telling him that it was the disease.

Pierre even wrote a book about it before. The black energy seeping out from Runald was a famous symptom of that disease.

'That is a top quality disease also...'

Most Gods considered the disease to be a mental type. It was because Gods who got the disease seemed to be mad. However, Pierre thought differently. He thought in this way:

That disease was the only 'hope' against the System. It was a disease that gave birth to Settings that had no efficiency or popularity, but it gave something that was unique to itself. The mind was the only thing that could save a 'being' in this stubborn world.

'The disease mostly fell under humility but...'

Pierre felt weird as he watched Runald walking toward Varkant. That was different. That didn't seem it was going to succumb or fall against anything. It seemed like it was willing to stand up to any oppression in the world.

Runald was now like Jaehwan.

That's why Pierre knew. He was now looking into the possibility of a different world. That's when he remembered a line he wrote in the book.

-The disease starts from [Copying].

Runald's right fist soared into the air. His fist was thrown up like a sword. As Pierre felt the concentrated world power within it, he was astonished.

That boy put everything he had in there. Not only his past or present, but the future. The spirit with countless potential put every bit of potential on the line to earn the power.

It was Runald's [Eye of Geshtalt].

Runald's world power struck against Varkant's Gigantes. Varkant gasped in shock as Runald's two eyes burned in golden light. The knowledge that Jaehwan gained was now being shared to Runald through the unique world.

'Ah-ah...'

In the excitement that seemed to explode his spirit, Runald threw his fist again and again. He thought maybe this could be his last fight in life, but he didn't stop. The Gigantes was being destroyed and he heard Sirwen's desperate voice.

'Jaehwan, please give me more power!'

Runald felt the pain coming from his bones melting away. His head felt like they had been burnt away. Varkant appeared through the destroyed cockpit. Runald focused all his power into his right fist. The concentrated world power shined brightly and Runald punched the cockpit.

It was Runald's version of the [Fall].

The dark power of the Fall penetrated the Gigantes, and the powerful explosion shook the battlefield. Varkant's screaming could faintly be heard from the explosion.

787 times. Budda figured Jaehwan was going to give up soon.

Jaehwan's sword penetrated Budda's heart.

"AAAARGH!"

1,862 times. Budda thought it was almost time. Jaehwan's sword destroyed his face.

"UGHGHGHGHH!"

2,763 times. Budda thought, 'This one's demon! He's a demon!'

Budda died as he felt the swords ripping his entire body apart.

3,971 times. Budda now gave up on thinking. He could only moan along with the mixture of laughter and tears.

"Ka... kahh.... Ah..."

The sword cut the spirit in half.

And finally, 5,487 times.

Jaehwan was holding Budda up with his hands. He didn't think it would last this long, but Budda was certainly at his limit.

"Reincarnation, are you going to try it again?"

Budda couldn't answer. No, maybe he couldn't even think now. There was no dignity of a God or a 1st Captain in Budda's shaking body. His empty face no longer held the will of life. Jaehwan then thought maybe Budda could finally get a hint of Ouroboros in this state, but it was too late.

"So you tried to take Karavan as a hostage."

Jaehwan found Karavan as he moved through with Budda in his hands.

"Jaehwan...?"

It seemed like Karavan had regained his senses. He tried to reach out for Jaehwan but fainted. He had traces of wounds all over his body. Jaehwan controlled the ship remotely to put Karavan inside. He seemed to be weak without a God, but they had Chunghuh to take care of him.

Chunghuh was almost done too. Jaehwan looked around in the dust and stopped in one direction.

"When will you stop watching?"

Jaehwan then threw Budda's body into the dust and heard someone grab him. The sound was as if flesh had struck against metal.

-You are one of a kind, for sure.

"..."

-I didn't think you could force Budda into such a state. Haha... you only have one set of clothes now. Are you okay? Don't say you've died already.

It was hard to tell if he was joking or not. Jaehwan knew whose voice it was.

"Myad."

-Jaehwan.

The dust cloud died and the giant Gigantes body appeared from within. A blood red giant that stood over ten meters looked down at Jaehwan.

There was the best Gigantes of [Depth], Machina of Daeus.

Jaehwan's [Eye of Geshtalt] was resonating. It seemed like the [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods recognized each other. Myad's voice came from the cockpit.

-If you have come all this way, you must know everything. We won't need to talk about it then.

"Yeah."

-Then, come.

Machina and Jaehwan took a step toward each other instantly. A fight between a human and a giant. There was a huge size difference, but it was hard to tell whose world power was greater.

Jaehwan's [Fall] exploded out as Myad's [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] spread through the world. Jaehwan's sword roared and Machina growled.

It was the final battle to decide the fate of [Depth].

Chapter 199: A lone world (8)

It was a breathtaking fight to behold. Karlton couldn't find a better word to describe it as he watched the scene unfolding in front of him. However, as Karlton watched on, he realized even that wasn't enough to describe the fight.

'I am not sure if any word is sufficient to describe that...'

He couldn't take his eyes off the fight between the human and the Gigantes. A single aftershock from one of those exchanges was powerful enough to kill Karlton instantly. It was dangerous for Karlton to stay so close to him, but he just couldn't leave like that.

[Fall]

The dark wave of the Fall poured out from Jaehwan's sword and...

[Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]

A dark red wave exploded out from Myad's Gigantes. The two waves clashed against each other, exploding as it struck. The air exploded and the landscape was left with craters all around. Among those craters, the biggest one was the one from Jaehwan's stabs against Myad. Within the hole, an amplified voice came out.

-Splendid.

"..."

-If I knew you were going to get this strong, I would have changed my plans to focus on recruiting you.

Machina, which was buried in the ground from Jaehwan's attack, pulled itself up again. Its movement to brush the dirt off its body resembled the actions of a human.

-I know it's pointless to ask you this again right now...

"Then don't ask."

-But I still have to ask you this.

"....."

-Jaehwan. You can still join Rupture and start a new world.

And in the next moment, Myad began to cackle at his own words.

-Hah, it feels like I've become some evil villain. This is what the bad guys usually say at the end.

"Maybe it's because you are in those shoes right now."

-Haha. Am I?

Myad burst into laughter. A metal giant laughing hard with a hand on its stomach looked very friendly. Jaehwan thought maybe Myad was putting that into consideration. That's why his metal armor looked so friendly. Myad van Deklan, as Jaehwan knew him, was such a man.

"In my old world, there is a word to describe those who are like you. A dreamer."

-Dreamer? Hmm. Is that a compliment?

"You could take it that way," Jaehwan answered coldly.

-Hah, but isn't it ironic? To hear that from you? From you whose unique world is similar to mine?

Machina straightened itself from laughter. Its head with two large horns then looked up into the sky. A metal giant looking up to the sky? Jaehwan thought it was too dramatic.

-You have been misled, Jaehwan. You must know that much if you are an Awakener. Your resistance has no effect on the start of the new world.

Maybe it was because Gigantes had no physical eyes, but the Machina looking up into the sky with its giant sword planted in the ground made it look like a warrior who had finished their task after many trials and hardships. Jaehwan smiled bitterly.

'How touching.'

-Look up to the sky. The sky no longer bears the arrogant being that used to look down upon us. The old world is now finished. It's the era of a new world. The age of Gods or Lords is over. It's happening. Soon, everything will change.

It was a voice that trembled with excitement. It was the voice of a revolutionary on the brink of success. Once would cry with tears of joy if they also walked the path of such a grand vision like Myad. It wasn't just because of the content. The voice, how it was spoken, and how it was portrayed — everything about Myad made him the person he was. He was the one who led Rupture all this time, and Jaehwan realized it. This was what made everything possible.

Just a little more. Just a bit more and...

The voice was tempting to anyone who listened to it, especially for anyone who exhibited hatred against this world. Jaehwan narrowed his eyes.

'Little more?'

Jaehwan was from the world where the danger of 'a little more' was widely known.

Just a little more.

This 'little' sometimes was an amount that had no end. No new world was coming. The world that was to come was forever in its slumber. People dreamed of a reality 'little' after. And a few of the people who stood above all the others in their dreams controlled the 'present'. That was also the System.

"Myad, stop the act now."

-Act? What do you mean?

"Big Brother is not dead. Are you going to lie to me also?"

-Big Brother is dead.

"No, he's not. I can see it."

Jaehwan looked up to the skies as he spoke. It was still there with the horrible bloodshot eyes with crows flying around it — the giant eye that was always looking down at Jaehwan. Ever since Jaehwan found the eye, Big Brother never disappeared from his world. Even after Myad dropped the star from the skies, it was still there. Myad laughed.

-Oh, is it? Then let me rephrase it. Big Brother perished from all worlds, except yours.

"..."

-Or if you don't like that, how about if I rephrase it this way? There was no such thing as 'Big Brother' from the beginning.

Jaehwan then spoke in disbelief, "...Do you really mean what you're saying?"

-Yes, I mean it.

Jaehwan was even disappointed by the word.

"You know that I can see Big Brother."

-Of course, you probably see Big Brother. But even if you can see it, is it 'proof' that Big Brother exists? Can you be certain that the eye you see is actually Big Brother?

"...Let's cut the nonsense."

-Nonsense? No. It's a logical conclusion. The unique world is a world full of 'theories'. It's a fictional world where nothing about it can be considered as 'reality', even today.

Jaehwan became silent. Talking about philosophies or beliefs like this wasn't what Jaehwan liked to do in between fights. But he couldn't stop. Was it because he felt compelled to defeat Myad logically? Or was it because he wanted to defend the lives of people Myad killed with his blasphemies? Jaehwan couldn't figure out his intentions.

"Okay. Let's say what you said is true. But your words contain contradictions."

-And that is?

"If the Big Brother I see is fake, then why did you spread words about Big Brother all this time? You even went so far as to make all of [Depth] witness you taking down Big Brother. If Big Brother did not exist, then why did you have to do that? What for?"

Myad became silent. It wasn't silence due to him being lost for words. It was more like the silence was there to add suspense to answer the question he had been waiting for.

-Sometimes, the things that do not exist have more power.

"What?"

Chapter 200: A lone world (9)

-I'm sure you are aware that there are various rumors about Big Brother.

Myad began with a story.

-Some say that Big Brother is a group that controls the world from underneath, while some claim that Big Brother is a sole God that governs the entire dimension. Some say they are victims of Big Brother and some claim that Big Brother is behind a lot of disasters. It is amusing to see all these conspiracies floating about. They speak as if Big Brother is behind everything that happens in this world.

"...And what's your point?"

-Do you think all those conspiracies have values? Are they true? Or even some of them?

Myad continued without waiting for Jaehwan to answer.

-Do you want to know one more interesting fact? No one, including me, not even any of the Gods in [Depth] have confirmed the existence of Big Brother.

Jaehwan did hear this before. Gerome, a Lord who was considered to be the strongest of all Lords, told him that he had never seen Big Brother.

-Everything about Big Brother is that every 'fact' is not a fact. It's all but a hoax. Rumors. Big Brother, a threat to [Depth], master of the System, God of Adapters... it's all a fluke.

"So, you claim that there is no Big Brother?"

-That is what I am trying to describe. Yes.

Jaehwan scoffed, "I'm pretty sure you did a great job in creating such a hoax and spreading the rumors."

-Yes, I did. Big Brother was the best public enemy.

Jaehwan grimaced, "Are you claiming that YOU created Big Brother to maintain your organization?"

-Yes, that is right. Big Brother. The enemy of all. Evil of all worlds. Isn't it convenient? It relates to everything.

Jaehwan felt like Myad was being quite serious in what he said. It was realistic if he thought about it. Having an enemy was a good way to increase unity among groups.

It was always an enemy that would jeopardize safety, and if that enemy was a being so powerful and relatively unknown, that was much better. However...

-Jaehwan, you must get rid of your illusions. There is no Big Brother. Everything about it is a 'lie' created by works of Gods. And the world needs to wake up from it.

Jaehwan did not answer. Instead, he looked into the unique world that spread out behind Myad. There was an empty sky, a sky that probably had something up in it for thousands of years.

It was then when Machina moved slightly to cover Jaehwan's sight. It was impeccable timing to say that it was a coincidence. The action was completed as if he wanted to cover the skies. Jaehwan felt a certain sadness.

"Are you okay with that?"

-Why am I not okay?

"For saying such things."

Silence fell. They did not exchange any more words, but Jaehwan knew Myad was deeply hurt at that moment. Of course, Myad would never agree to being hurt since agreeing to it would destroy him, just like how it destroyed Budda and Pierre.

"I heard from Pierre. By saying everything you have said, you are denying the entire life that's behind you."

Budda, Pierre, and Myad. The story of the three men, the founders of Rupture. The story of their dream of hunting down Big Brother. Jaehwan was looking at that shadow of a dream from Myad's world. The one that fell from Myad's world was probably not Big Brother. How long did it take for a star to fall? Jaehwan didn't know.

...Pierre must have given you useless information.

Myad smiled softly.

-If people gather together and claim that the same thing is not true, then it becomes the truth. That's what we did.

Created a false truth? Jaehwan shook his head.

"No. To me, I think you look like you rather destroyed about something that existed before."

However, Jaehwan's voice was swept away by an explosion as Machina shot up to the sky while unleashing world power. It was an action that showed that Myad was done talking.

-I heard you have gained the Eye of Geshtalt. You better use it otherwise the fight will quickly be over.

The voice had faint anger in it. Machina's wide wings were spread out.

Machina – Phase 1.

Activating Setting [Daeus]

The ground trembled as if the entire [Depth] was shaking from the first Setting of Machina, [Daeus]. Jaehwan also activated his [Eye of Geshtalt].

The two world powers began to increase rapidly, but the situation wasn't going well for Jaehwan. Increasing world power was much more efficient for Daeus at this point as Daeus just 'multiplied' the user's world power while Eye of Geshtalt just 'added' more world power to the current power.

Myad's world power now exceeded 70 million.

The entire 8th site was overwhelmed by the giant world power. The power equaled that of the Three Ancient Gods from the old times. It was a world power that not even the 8 Gods of [Depth] together could withstand.

Jaehwan's world power did not increase past 14 million, however. He heard the shouts of his clothes in his head.

-Are you serious? There's no way we can win against that!

-It's the limit! We can't give you any more power than this!

The world power was at the limit, but Jaehwan did not grow concerned. He had a secret weapon for this problem now.

A long, long time ago.

Naked God lived.

He hated clothes.

And lived naked for his entire life.

Myad laughed as he realized what Jaehwan was trying to do.

-Are you going to use 'that' again? You know it doesn't work anymore.

Machina quickly used the Setting, [Augmented Reality], to clothe Jaehwan. Myad was exploiting the weakness of the [Naked] Setting, or the power

where one needed to become naked in order to use the power. However, Jaehwan did not stop singing.

Finally, the naked God was surrounded by clothes.

The lonely naked God said-

The reason why this world so unfortunate.

Is...

Because we all wear clothes.

Because we all can't take off our clothes.

Jaehwan's body began to shine in golden light even with the clothes on. It meant that the [Naked] Setting was taking effect. But how? Myad was shocked.

No one can take off the clothes.

That is the truth.

And Jaehwan moved. Myad couldn't believe what he was seeing. Jaehwan had his clothes on. But why did it look like he was naked now?

Naked while wearing clothes at the same time? It didn't make sense.

Was it because the thousands of Jaehwans were giving him power? Myad saw the illusion of thousands of naked Jaehwans running at him in a wave of golden light.

The Naked Gods were unleashing their dream. Jaehwan mumbled, "Ouroboros."

I am wearing clothes.

I am not wearing clothes.

Chapter 201: A lone world (10)

The tremor that shook [Depth] spread across the trunk and into the roots of the Tree of Imagery. The world power was strong enough to make the entire Tree of Imagery tremble.

[It has begun.]

Sole-King Catastrophe spoke as he looked up into the darkness from the Palace of Dead Men. If he could, he wanted to travel across that sky to help, but he couldn't. There was still an old seal in place that entrapped him and he was still recovering from the damage he had received from the battle between him and the Lords.

[Who is Jaehwan fighting? The Master of Rupture?]

[Probably so.]

[So, that one knows about what happened 210 thousand years ago too? Who told him that? Was it the monk you trained? Or the bookworm?]

[...Are you talking about Budda and Pierre?]

[I don't care about their names.]

Ra-hamad did not answer and Catastrophe spoke annoyingly.

[You should've left them alone. Your effort to train them left them in this mess. Do you think anyone can kill Big Brother?]

[...Ouroboros.]

[Damn you and your Ouroboros.]

From the darkness, Myad could be seen through the vision that Jaehwan shared. Catastrophe spoke as he looked upon what was happening the vision.

[So that fool wanted to become the star himself.]

[...]

[Pity. I knew he was spreading words about Big Brother, but to think that he wanted to recreate what happened 210 thousand years ago...]

The events of the past, 210 thousand years ago. In silence, Ra-hamad and Catastrophe realized that they were thinking of the same day. The Three God War. It was the day when Daeus died, Geshtalt's presence was ripped apart, and Catastrophe was sealed. A day when the plan of 'A Lone World' started to stop the war between Gods. A day of tragedy. Catastrophe spoke while reminiscing.

[Gods and humans alike, it's all same when all three are gathered.]

Ra-hamad answered,

[Maybe it's all same after all whether it's today or 210 thousand years in the past.]

Thousands of Jaehwans began unleashing relentless attacks at Machina's armor mercilessly. Machina did not budge however. It was one of the [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods after all. The Part that was most durable in all of [Depth]. That was Machina.

Although it was that durable, it was still vulnerable against attacks that were aimed at its weak points, which were the joints. Jaehwan's sword stabbed the joints between the pieces of armor and he unleashed world power into the Gigantes. It was amplified through the [Naked] Setting that worked best against Gigantes.

The Machina's joints were then paralyzed and it fell onto its knees. Thousands of stabs then attacked against connection areas of the cockpit at

that moment. Soon, the sound of metal being ripped apart was heard.

It was astonishing. The cockpit of Machina was cracking up. Myad's disbelief could be seen between cracks of the cockpit.

Jaehwan did not hesitate. Machina could still recover from all the damage through the user's world power. Considering the huge difference in power, it was Jaehwan who was going to lose if the fight dragged on. The time was now.

As thousands of blades were unleashed to distract Myad, Jaehwan pulled out his final weapon.

Darkness fell upon the sky of the 8th site. Eerie energy swept through the lands and the sound of Dead Men screaming erupted from all sides. Jaehwan's left hand had the most powerful sword that existed in [Depth].

[Void Sword]

The sword that cut spirits down. It was Sole-King Catastrophe's Void Sword.

-HAHAHAHAHA! That is great!

But Myad didn't seem to be that concerned even with the appearance of the Void Sword.

-Come get it!

The Void Sword was a weapon that worked best against beings. Whoever touched the sword was tainted with the sword's Setting of [Time Contamination], thus starting the Dead Man process to make one become a Follower of Catastrophe. The greater the world power, the stronger the [Time Contamination]. For the Void Sword, Myad was the best prey there was.

Machina's hand reached out to grab the Void Sword, but the sword avoided the grasp and was thrust into the cockpit. At the same time, Machina

quickly moved out of the attack range. However, Jaehwan felt something that was slightly promising.

'I got him.'

The sword had successfully stabbed Myad inside the cockpit. Even if it wasn't a critical strike, it was enough. [Time Contamination] was going to destroy Myad's mind rapidly and even if he did fight it off, it would destroy a huge chunk of his world power.

Machina froze, thus showing Jaehwan's success. However, a question came into Jaehwan's mind.

'Why is he not using [Link Destroy]?'

Myad knew that Jaehwan had a pact with Catastrophe. If so, then he had the power to use [Link Destroy] to cut the link between Jaehwan and Catastrophe so that Jaehwan couldn't use the Void Sword. Yet, Myad did not do this. There was no way Myad would've forgotten about it. And then, the unexpected happened.

Machina's cockpit opened. Myad was sitting inside with dark veins popping out of his skin. He coughed black particles out from his mouth. Jaehwan knew Myad had been damaged far more than he had hoped. Myad opened his mouth, and the voice came, not through the amplification of Machina, but from himself.

"You really are one of a kind... collecting two of three Parts. There was only one being who could do that in the last millenium."

He was probably referring to Mulack. Myad smiled with a dark face.

"I was right in not killing you back then. If it wasn't for you, 'A Lone World' could have never been realized."

Something definitely was wrong. Myad was on brink of losing and he seemed to be calm. It was then that a giant blade appeared from Machina's hand. It was a sword that didn't seem to have a handle. Jaehwan's eyes

shook. He looked down at the sword he was holding and looked back at the sword the Machina was holding. And then he confirmed it.

Void Sword. That was the Void Sword.

Karlton gasped in shock as he watched it all from afar.

"But how...!"

It wasn't over. Inside the cockpit, Myad's eye shined brightly in green as it spun. The symbol of a snake was storming within his eyes.

Ouroboros was inside Myad's eyes.

Chapter 202: A lone world (11)

Thunder struck [Depth] and a few Awakeners crouched. The storm of world power blasted throughout various parts of the world. It was menacing enough for Followers with low world power. The sky turned dark as if night had fallen.

"Surha, give up."

"Don't steal my line."

Mirel, the 5th Captain of Rupture, and Surha were facing each other with their swords. They were out of breath from their fight. Surha was close to winning the fight. Unlike Mirel who had spent most of her time in controlling the simulation at the lab, Surha had experience in frontline battles since the days she was in Rupture.

'That kid. He's amazing,' Surha thought as she glanced over at Runald who was lying down on the ground at a distance. She was thinking of taking care of Mirel as fast as possible so she could go help with dealing with Varkant. However, Runald unexpectedly released his powers and killed Varkant.

'Killing the Lord...'

The boy was not in good shape as he lost most of his world power, but if the war were over soon, there was a good chance that the boy could be saved. Pierre didn't seem to be in trouble against the two Lords either. It was a close fight, but Pierre had a slight advantage. If Surha joined after dealing with Mirel, the fight would certainly be theirs.

'We've won.'

Surha felt it was premature. It seemed like her [Premonition] wasn't wrong after all. There was no future of Myad controlling the world. They were going to win today, and there was no chance of tragedy.

It was certain.

Was it because of excitement? It wasn't like her to not notice the change of color in the rain. Even if she did notice, things would not have changed. It was beyond her ability to stop it from happening anyway.

The dark clouds were turning into bloody clouds now.

Next, bodies began to arise from the blood. An illusion began to form with corpses all around the world. There was no way this world could leave corpses.

And there was the dead Imai standing there without his head.

'Surha.'

There was also Kashim with only his head.

'Surha.'

There was no way they could be there, but they were looking at Surha. There was no way, but their blood was clearly 'red'. Then she saw Mirel bleeding and Budda with his organs gushing out. And...

She saw herself, with her heart penetrated.

Surha backed away from the terrifying illusion. Everything was blood red. The world was changing. And in next moment, Surha felt her world power waning.

"This... YOU!"

Mirel also became pale. She smiled faintly as she looked at herself and Surha realized they both might be the same.

"W-what is going on?!"

Awakeners from various places in the battle seemed to show similar symptoms. It seemed like Sirwen became excited since it was now easier to fight these Awakeners, but things weren't going so well. Even Pierre who had been fighting the Lords was losing power. Every being who shared the same world with Rupture was losing their power.

"Dammit... the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] was actually...."

She felt dizzy and fell onto the ground. Soon, she became unconscious.

Even after Myad had shown his collection of all the [Parts], Jaehwan was not concerned. The Void Sword and the Eye of Geshtalt that Myad held were imperfect.

"Is that your [Setting]?"

"Yes, it is."

Just like how Jaehwan had [Fall], he expected Myad to have something also. [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] was more like a unique world rather than a Setting after all. Then what was Myad's setting? Pierre once said this:

-He didn't have the Setting in the beginning. It was after I left Rupture that he created that Setting. I am not sure what he went through, but he created it with the 'Ouroboros' we taught him to create an entirely different Setting. Since the Ouroboros was incomplete, it is far from the actual Eye of Geshtalt. Yet, it has power equal to Budda's [Reincarnation].

And Jaehwan now realized what Myad's Setting was.

Setting – [Mocking Truth]

Myad's Setting was to copy Settings or Parts he had experienced or seen.

"You don't seem surprised."

"It's not that surprising."

"Haha, yes, of course. It is still fake."

That was why Jaehwan wasn't concerned. The copied Setting was a fake that could only have half of the power of the original.

"That alone isn't enough to defeat me."

Jaehwan spoke as he swung his void sword against the Machina.

"Yes, this alone cannot do."

Jaehwan's Void Sword and Myad's Void Sword clashed against each other, creating a distortion. Myad then dodged Jaehwan's stab and taunted, "Oh, will you stop that? You will break it. I didn't create this to fight. The [Parts] are only the key after all."

"A key?"

"Yes, a key. And it doesn't matter if the key is fake or real as long as it can do what it's required to do."

Machina's hand that held the sword pointed it to the sky. The fake Eye of Geshtalt began spinning in Myad's eyes.

"If the door can be opened, it doesn't matter if the key underperforms."

Machina began to shine in a variety of colors. It wasn't something that happened before. Jaehwan felt like something was not right. He quickly charged against Machina with both his swords. And in the next moment, he saw Myad smiling brightly. It was the smile of a man who had witnessed the world he had long wished for.

"You will never understand how long I have waited for this moment! How happy I was when you acquired the rest of the [Parts]!!"

Jaehwan felt strange. Myad's smile was real. His actions were fake and his life was a lie. But why? Why did it feel as if the eye was looking into

genuine 'salvation'?

Machina – Hidden Phase

System Operation

With a powerful explosion, Jaehwan's body was thrown backward. As he was being thrown away, Jaehwan saw the color change in the sky — the blood red clouds were dripping with blood.

It was once someone's unique world, but it was no longer a unique world.

It had now become a reality. The bloody reality destroyed all the other worlds and contaminated everything else. Screams came from the countless worlds as they were all ripped apart.

Soon, there was only one world. There was no more fighting or screaming.

[A lone world.]

Machina was up in the sky, shining brightly like a red star.

Chapter 203: A lone world (12)

There was a young man.

The man had been taken away from his world because of the Cultivators' lust for power and the Nightmares' lust for fame. The Tower of Nightmares created by Master Craftsman Jan-Pol-[Being and Emptiness] was cleared by the man. He was taken to [Depth] by the Gods and became 'Awakened' through his hatred and anger toward the world.

It was now a story of thousands of years ago.

He fought the Lords of the [Great Lands] and resisted the Gods of [Depth]. He massacred countless Cultivators and Nightmares.

He created Rupture.

He imagined Big Brother every time he went to sleep. He believed the star he saw was Big Brother who was the start of the tragedy and the reason for this world. He believed that he would someday pull down the star from that sky.

The young man then grew old. Then he became an old man. He still looked like a young man from the outside, but on the inside, he was very old.

Lots of things happened.

He didn't know when the war stopped or when it was unlikely for him to look up into the sky. He couldn't remember when he began to feel despair instead of anger against the bright star hanging in the sky.

Myad couldn't remember when he had poked his two eyes which could see the light up there.

Jaehwan knew a lot about the secret of the War of the Three Gods. The recovered [Record of the Depth] had most of the histories that Mulack knew about [Depth]. Most recordings just described the war to be a fight between the Three Ancient Gods, but it was different from what it actually was.

The Three Ancient Gods met that day to end the war forever, and then start another one.

Their meeting was foretold a long time ago when the three of them found 'clothes', utilized them, and realized what the 'clothes' were.

-So, you mean this is the power of the one called the [System]?

It was young Catastrophe who spoke up first when he still had his body.

-Clothes are not the power of the System. It is a power that was created because the System exists.

Young Daeus, who had metal armor covering his body, answered.

-Isn't that the same thing?

-No.

-What is the System anyway?

-The basic law of the universe. The reason of control over everything.

-What the hell are you saying? So are you saying that it's stronger than us?

-It's not a being where strength matters. The System is the world as a whole. There's no power involved.

Catastrophe then said,

-I will destroy it then. We are Gods. Whatever it is, I can't let it control me.

-The System has no will. It controls, but it does not reign. It just exists.

Catastrophe frowned at the words.

-And what are you exactly getting at? System or not, haven't we all gathered here to stop the war? Why are you bringing this up?

Daeus then smiled mechanically.

-Because we can use the System to end it.

Daeus then explained his plan. He explained the logic between the power of the 'clothes' that all three of them were using and how they could use it to take control of the [System]. It was Geshtalt who objected after listening to Daeus for a while.

-I am against it. We do not know what this System is yet.

Even with Geshtalt's objection, Catastrophe and Daeus proceeded with their plan. Maybe it was due to their boredom from a long-lasting war or from the boredom of their long, immortal life.

Or maybe, it was actually from a sense of justice.

Either way, nobody knew for certain why they made such a decision. What was certain was the result.

That day, the 'thing' everyone knew about was born.

210 thousand years later... Jaehwan was looking directly at the 'recreation' of what happened 210 thousand years ago. Jaehwan knew it wasn't in its perfect form right now. Surely the being created 210 thousand years ago was much stronger.

The sun burned fiercely. Myad was like the sun now.

[Hah... so, this is what it feels like to be a real 'God'.]

Those words seemed to deny the existed of all the Gods that existed in [Depth]. It was quite true, however, as all Gods scattered within [Depth] were rapidly losing their power as Myad appeared.

The hidden phase of the Machina was the power to change user's unique world into a System.

The way of doing it was quite simple. Daeus' [Link Destroy] destroyed the link between Gods and Followers while Catastrophe's [Time Contamination] corrupted Followers within the 'System'. Then, the Eye of Geshtalt worked to control the will of those who were corrupt.

Vicegerents and Followers were shaking in pain as they were thrown into a whole new reality. The only world they were left to believe in was the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses]. In that violence, they began to accept the new world one by one, becoming slaves to the new System.

World power gathered from all parts of [Depth] began funneling into Machina. Jaehwan couldn't even guess how many world powers were being collected.

The [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] that had now evolved into a System was not the unique world that Jaehwan knew of. It was no longer a 'theory'. Jaehwan looked around. He saw Kashim and Chunghuh grasping their chests as they trembled while experiencing a seizure. Myad spoke.

[That is strange. How are you still okay? Not even Awakeners can withstand this.]

Kashim and Chunghuh seemed to be in pain because of a different reason. Kashim, who was a member of Rupture, was having his world power sucked from him, and Chunghuh was being attacked by the corruption of the System.

The [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] that had become a reality did not permit the existence of other unique worlds. It was a power that rejected all other possibilities. It was the power of a lone world, or the power of the System.

But even then, [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] couldn't destroy Jaehwan's world.

Jaehwan wasn't sure why it was possible. Maybe it was because of his Eye of Geshtalt. Or maybe...

[This is interesting. The world that did not perish in the end is yours.]

Jaehwan's unique world was born only to destroy other worlds. That's why his world required 'other worlds'. His world never disappeared as long as there was 'another world' that existed.

That was Jaehwan's unique world.

Jaehwan and Myad exchanged glances. One looked like he had everything while one had the look of pity toward everything that the other had. Myad asked,

[Why are you looking at me like that?]

"Because I feel sorry for you."

Chapter 204: A lone world (13)

[Sorry? For me?]

Myad burst into laughter, but Jaehwan did not laugh or smile.

"You destroyed your eyes just because you couldn't lay your hand on the star."

[...]

"It's as if... your eyes were the problem because you can see the star."

Jaehwan looked up to the sky. Red clouds were covering the sky as if they were trying to hide the fact that there was a sky up there. But the harder the clouds tried to hide it, the more it conveyed that there was something hiding behind it.

[Are you a poet or something now? I am not sure what you are talking about.]

"Don't pretend."

[...Haha. Jaehwan, I am the 'star'. The star is within me now.]

"No, there is no star anymore. You've lost it forever."

[...Well, this is getting boring. I will finish this once and for all.]

The world suddenly charged toward Jaehwan. Red blades popped from nowhere and the part of the sky struck down against Jaehwan. Hands shot out from the ground to grab Jaehwan's legs and the light that Machina unleashed was fired against Jaehwan.

Jaehwan used all of his might to get out of the grasp of the world power.

[Naked]

Golden light exploded against Machina's ray of light.

[Fall]

His swords fought against the countless red blades flying in against him. But even after all this, Jaehwan's spirit was struck mercilessly.

The power of the Parts that Myad was using was a much weaker version of the Eye of Geshtalt or the Void Sword. But the sheer amount of world power made up for the loss of power. Jaehwan's entire body was now filled with wounds. His muscles were ripped and his shoulder had been pulled apart. But even then, Jaehwan did not stop.

He destroyed, slashed, and stabbed. He fell and rose again.

He was a naked man resisting against a world. All of [Depth] was now watching his fight.

-Dammit!

-If we only had more time...

-I'm sorry.

It was Jaehwan's clothes that perished instead of Jaehwan. They were losing power. Even at 20 million world power, it was impossible to fight against the entire [Depth].

The last battle of [Depth] was running straight into a tragic end.

Was it a 100 million? Or maybe a billion?

Karlton felt his spirit being torn down as he watched the fight unfold in front of him. It was a world power that a single spirit could not withstand.

Jaehwan fighting back was a miracle in itself. The enemy really represented one true world, and Jaehwan was fighting against that.

'Master.'

Karlton felt ashamed of himself. Unlike Chunghuh, he was still conscious. If it wasn't for the link he made to send his world power to Jaehwan, and if it wasn't for Jaehwan who recovered the link when it was being destroyed by the [Link Destroy], Karlton would have been on the ground with a seizure.

The only reason Karlton was himself now was because Jaehwan was fighting against that world. The link that was in place to help Jaehwan was actually saving his life now.

'This is shameful...'

Karlton provided the last of his world power to Jaehwan, a world power of merely a 100 thousand. It was a weak power which provided no help in changing the situation.

'We came so far for this...'

Karlton felt his eyes becoming hot from tears as he watched Jaehwan falling down. He had guessed that it was over. The days that he lived had passed through him.

A boy who had been abandoned as a half breed between a human and an angel. One who had to be a part of Gorgon Fortress to survive. It was 'justice' that kept Karlton alive, or the laws set in place to govern Gorgon.

-Only justice could save a being.

The former Master of Gorgon Aimel, who raised Karlton, taught him that. Karlton remembered the days of when he first learned to use the word of law.

Those were the invincible words that enforced justice.

Karlton used it to protect the Gorgon. He had memorized it all to be a protector of justice. And thus, he became the Silver Bind of Gorgon.

His justice created righteousness, and protected justice.

He thought that it was enough.

"Dammit..."

But it was useless. There was no justice.

Justice was about to fall in front of his eyes. The man who represented justice more than anyone else was about to die. Why did he have to die?

Karlton couldn't understand the unfairness of this world as he looked at Jaehwan. Karlton then fell onto the ground. The book of law that he treasured fell out from his pocket. He smiled grimly.

The power he trusted most had no use anymore.

No laws were here to protect that man, and no laws were able to fight against the world.

His tears turned silver as they trailed down his cheek. The book turned into silver as the drops touched the cover. Karlton thought as he looked down.

If this world was fair, and if there were law and order in this world, then why wasn't Jaehwan being rewarded for his past?

Even the being who deceived everyone and massacred countless of people was given a world despite the fact that the being had to acquire powerful faith to open up a world.

Why did Jaehan have no Followers? Why — did no one believe in him?

That's when something popped up in his head.

'No one believes in him?'

Karlton immediately stood still in his place. And then he began to walk toward Jaehwan. He walked through the storm of blood, and even when the debris destroyed his body, he did not stop. Jaehwan found Karlton approaching and tried to stop him.

The unique world was based off one's 'dream.'

Karlton's body began to shine in silver. All this time, the justice inside him was now born.

Karlton was always curious. Why didn't his unique world appear? Was it because his 'dream' was not certain? If then... what was a dream?

To Chunghuh, his dream was his longing for his homeworld, and to Myad, it was the hatred and anger that had lost direction.

Then what about Karlton? He closed his eyes to find the answer. And he then he saw a familiar place.

He saw the giant fortress with walls. It was the place he had lived in for so long, the place he had protected against Dead Men and horned monsters. It was the place where people had lost 'death' but still had 'life'. The place of small justice and life.

It was far from being grandeur, but it was the most precious thing to Karlton.

Karlton opened his eyes. They shined in silver. Myad spoke.

[And what the hell...]

The silver light exploded out from Karlton, and an entrance to a giant world was opened.

The grand wall of the outer fortress extended hundreds of miles. The shape of guardian horns were engraved on all the spires. The inner fortress was tucked away inside like a giant monster.

[Gorgon Fortress]

One of the four fortresses of [Chaos]. It appeared in the shape of Karlton's unique world.

Chapter 205: A lone world (14)

Due to the recent large scale renovation, Fortress Carpediem was merged with Gorgon Fortress, thus exceeding the 10 billion population within the fortress. There were various towns and regions within the fortress and at the entrance of all the towns, there were sculptures of Jaehwan with his sword pointing up into the sky. It was a common sight to see a young man who dreamed of becoming the next 'Sole-King' to be practicing their stabs in front of those sculptures.

"One-two! One-two!"

People shouted while training. Some had put down their swords while taking a break from the hard training.

"Hey, how many times did you stab today?"

"Me? I think about 100 thousand..."

"What? Don't lie!"

"...No, I'm not."

"If you stab once per one second without eating or sleeping, that's still not enough to reach 100 thousand! Don't even try."

"...I heard Master Jaehwan did that."

"And you are him?"

Young men quarreled and the instructor shouted angrily at them. And then the shouts came again.

"Slight Stab! Normal Stab! Strong Stab!"

Some of these 'stab trainees' were very into Jaehwan's stories that they shouted the skill name that Jaehwan used with their mouths.

"But aren't the names a bit cheesy? Who names it like that? 'Slight stab'?"

"...I heard an old man named Chung-something named them for him."

"No. I heard Master Jaehwan named them like that because he was lazy."

And the gossip was swept away by another set of shouts.

"World stab! World stab!"

A bit later, one of the trainees who had been shouting screamed as he looked up into the sky.

"WAAAH!"

Then, everyone turned to the man. The man yelped, "I-I did the world stab! The world ripped!!"

"Huh?"

"What the hell?"

The man pointed to the sky. Some of the trainees gasped as they turned toward the direction. People were shocked. Even the instructor was shocked.

"The sky...!"

The sky was tearing apart.

Chancellor Euren Chiver of Carpediem Fortress was having a headache as he tapped on his pen on the table.

"It is just a name... why does it matter?"

"It matters! The name is the only thing left for all of us!"

It had been a long time since all four fortresses had been united, but there were still various minor fights happening within [Chaos]. It was apparent based on what was happening in this meeting room.

"We must name it Gorgon!"

"No, Garuda!"

"It must be Dryad."

"D-don't forget that Manticore is there too!"

Leaders of the Four Fortresses were quarreling with different matters after the fortress had united with Carpediem. This became more fierce due to the recent change in policies that required them to rename the fortress. The problem was as follows:

"Doesn't Carpediem-Garuda fit the best?"

"No. Carpediem-Dryad is the best there is."

"I think Carpediem-Manticore is more..."

"Hey, you were destroyed by Golden Sky croons. Don't even try."

They all agreed on leaving Carpediem as the first part of the name, but the problem was the latter portion. Everyone wanted to name it the fortress they came from. Euren looked at each of them and frowned.

They were all good people individually. They all agreed to Jaehwan's will and trained hard on the tower that Jaehwan had left behind to become Awakeners.

It wasn't only them however.

Now, there were more than a million Awakeners within the Carpediem Fortress. Millions of Awakeners. It was a number that can protect them

from most Lords, but since there were no enemies on the outside, they were fighting internally instead.

Euren thought as he scratched his mustache.

'It was good when we had the Master.'

If Jaehwan were here now, they probably would've all been 'stabbed'. Or maybe he might have opened a tournament of some kind to decide the name of the fortress. Of course, it will end up with Jaehwan charging into the tournament, making everybody fight him at once only to beat them all up.

Since everyone will lay there beaten down, the problem will naturally be solved.

And...

'I miss those times.'

Euren smiled. He did not like violence or tyranny. Even so, Euren still missed Jaehwan's such fierce attitude. The world needed a man like Jaehwan. Cayman spoke from the side.

"I miss Master Jaehwan."

Cayman seemed to think the same way. He was now a Minister of the Fortress and the most powerful being of [Chaos]. Euren asked, "Cayman, how about you take care of this?"

"...And how would I do that?"

"Uh, hmph. You know how Master used to do?"

"...You mean destroy everything?"

"Well, I'm not exactly saying that but..."

Euren was trying to put it in a more indirect way or a softened description of what Cayman said when the door to the meeting room burst open.

"C-chancellor!"

Euren then realized something had happened as he looked at the man with a pale face. At the same time, some of the officials pulled the window curtains open.

"What is that...!"

Gasps and screams came from all over the fortress. There was a giant screen-looking thing swirling above the sky.

"Is... is that...?!"

Soon people realized what they were seeing. They saw a world that was filled with blood and corpses. And in that horrible world...

Someone was fighting.

A man was bleeding in silver. There was a man who was still holding back against it. He was countlessly swinging his sword at something as if he was fighting an entire world.

"He's..."

They weren't sure about the enemy he was fighting against, but they could see the determination and desperation of the man fighting it.

"Ah..."

Some remembered his face and cried. Some grabbed other people's shoulders in joy. The ones who did not know him personally recognized who he was. There were sculptures of the man all over the fortress after all.

'Jaehwan...'

Chapter 206: A lone world (15)

Euren looked up at the fight while biting on his lips. There was nothing that helped him understand what was going on, but Euren could tell that it was an important fight. It was a fight they had to see. That's why they watched no matter how horrible it was.

"Is that [Depth]?"

"But how..."

"He is fighting against such an enemy...?"

People mumbled and they felt mostly the same emotions. However, they weren't sure about what they should do with their feelings. It was then that the voice came from the sky.

-I thought of Gorgon, but I guess Gorgon doesn't exist anymore.

Euren recognized the owner of the voice right away.

'Karlton! It's him!'

Karlton's voice came after a short moment.

-It doesn't matter. Please help.

People began glancing at each other. Help? But how? Some shouted toward the sky. The answer they needed soon came.

-Please trust in Jaehwan.

They looked at each other. Trust? Some smiled and some shook their heads. Some even laughed out loud. Trusting didn't seem like it would be helpful.

-Please. Give him trust.

Some responded to Karlton's words. It was the people who had no power or wealth, people who finally gained their unique worlds through their Awakening. These people who had gotten Jaehwan's help reached out toward the sky. Only one woman reached out to the sky first.

"I trust you."

Mino shouted loudly so people could hear her.

"I trust you, Jaehwan!"

Soon, something that resembled a silver ball of ropes popped up from her hands. It then shot up into the sky. Was it because there was something so beautiful hidden within her? Mino gasped in surprise.

It was so beautiful and precious. It soared into the sky, toward the area where Jaehwan was fighting.

'I see. So I still had such a thing within me.'

Mino held back her tears and shouted, "Goddammit! What are you people waiting for?!"

People were shocked by Mino's shout. And then they began.

"M-me too!"

"I trust!"

"I trust you!"

"Here I am!"

People began to reach out into the sky from entire the Fortress. Silver balls soared upwards. It was as if snow was falling backward.

The materialization of people's trust was floating up into [Depth], beyond the sky. After a while, Euren spoke as he looked outside the window.

"We should forget about the name for now. There's a more important matter at hand."

The officials all gathered by the window and Euren looked at each of them. They looked back at Euren, and Cayman nodded. Euren then smiled and reached out to the sky.

"Master Jaehwan. We trust you."

He felt world power covering his entire body softly. He felt as if he could take any type of damage. There was the power of the people that trusted him. Countless spirits were now with him. He saw Karlton who was barely able to stand from the distance.

'You finally opened your unique world.'

But the unique world as Gorgon Fortress? It was so like Karlton.

[Gorgon Fortress]

Karlton was able to open passageway between [Depth] and [Chaos] through his unique world. The giant portal behind him showed the landscape of [Chaos]. A chunk of powerful world power traveled through it to pour into Jaehwan.

[This- this is...!]

The voice screamed while gritting its teeth.

[This can't be...! How can it exceed the population of [Depth]...!]

It was the first time Jaehwan heard Myad in such shock. The concentration of world power was almost about to explode within the 8th site. Jaehwan

looked at his hands that were now all silver as they were covered in light. It seemed like the power wasn't only coming from the fortress. The entire spirit of [Chaos] was sending him world power.

'There's no world with more population than [Chaos].'

Even if [Depth] had many spirits, [Depth] was where only the chosen ones were allowed to come. In contrast, [Chaos] was where everyone ended after they died. It was natural for [Chaos] to have a larger population. Jaehwan wasn't sure how many spirits were sending him power.

Myad continued attacking Jaehwan but he was no longer being damaged by any of the attacks. He smiled bitterly as he charged against the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses].

'I see. So I couldn't do this alone from the beginning.'

Mulcak mentioned that there were three steps to [Creation] at the end of Awakening. Jaehwan now realized the second answer and the second step to the Awakening.

Awakening – 5th step

-Proof

The world became real because countless people believed in it. Jaehwan brought his sword up into the sky. Proof? It was the perfect name. It was time to prove himself.

The sky covered in red was torn apart. The red clouds exploded out and it revealed the pitch-black sky of the [Fall] from within. The giant eye appeared in the sky and was looking directly at Myad.

[Ah... ah-ah....!]

With the sound of crows screeching, Myad moaned in terror. Jaehwan's unique world that had become a reality was running rampant. A world was attacking another world. The giant mouth of the [Fall] was biting away at

the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] while it resisted like prey captured by a predator.

Skies were torn and the ground trembled. And within the heavy pressure of the world power, Jaehwan stabbed.

Once. Twice... hundred... thousands... millions... billions...

The [Fall] that was unleashed by the stab swallowed and chewed away at the [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses].

And the System of [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] began to be destroyed. Myad's disbelief could be seen and Jaehwan's sword charged against it. The red light covered the lands of [Depth].

There were the ones who had been fighting against, the ones who were in agony after losing their world, and ones who were betrayed by their own world while losing power... they all forgot what they were doing and looked up into the sky. They felt that it was the end of an age.

And it was for real this time.

The red sky was falling.

Chapter 207: Big Brother (1)

[Nobody knows what the Fall actually is. No one has lived to experience what it is like after the Fall. But why are you afraid of something you have not even experienced yet?]

-Runald the Naked Saint.

Episode. Big Brother.

A year had passed since the red star fell from the sky. People stopped talking about the 'star' and instead talked about the 'eye'. It referred to the same thing in the end, but there was a difference. The star and the eye were very different after all.

What was Big Brother?

The Little Brother Network of [Depth] was bursting with these issues recently. From the debates on the existence of Big Brother to all kinds of testimonies relating to it. It was within this anonymous chatroom that people were debating most heatedly.

Guest15321: Big Brother exists! Did you forget about the Authentication?! It's Big Brother who issued them!

Guest8264: What are you talking about? It was revealed that they were created by the Masters of the fortresses in [Chaos].

Guest624124: Then what about the System? It's the Setting of the Big Brother, remember?

Guest8264: There's no proof of that either. It's just a hoax.

Guest55243: What about the Adapters in the [Great Lands]? They are followers of Big Brother. How can you deny the existence of a God when there are Followers?

Guest8264: And those Adapters have never seen nor heard their Gods. What proof do they have?

Guest3581: What about Little Brother Network? It's created by Big Brother!

Guest8264: OMG, if Big Brother really created it, then I would've been banned already.

Guest55243: Yeah. As a matter of fact, who are you to claim all that? Reveal your name if you want to back your claims.

Guest624124: I know. Stop blabbering unless if you don't want your ass kicked outta here.

It was followed by insults. Soon, Guest8264's message popped up in reply.

Guest8264: Ugh, that's why I don't talk with retards. I will prove that Big Brother does not exist.

Guest3581: ????

Guest55243: Gogogogo!

[Guest8264 has changed their nickname to 'Slasherking'.]

The chatroom became silent. Slasherking? As far as they knew, there was only one person who used such a nickname.

Slasherking: Hey, Big Brother, you son of a b*tch! Fight me if you are alive! I'm here! Send down lightning or something!

And the chatroom exploded.

Guest3581: SH*T!!

Guest624124: Old man, are you crazy?!

Slasherking's taunts continued for a while. It was so fierce and grand that the 'guests' even believed it was proof of Big Brother's non-existence. And after a while...

[Slasherking is banned from chat for 10 minutes due to excessive use of violent language.]

Many followed up with words like 'LOL' or 'LMAO'. Chunghuh looked at those messages for a while and turned off the network with a scoff.

"Hah, what a useless bunch."

He then yawned in a relaxed manner as he laid back.

"It's a good day."

He was lying down on a net hammock installed outside of Edmunt fortress to enjoy surfing through the Little Brother network. He then smiled as he heard Followers walking below the fortress. Chunghuh was killing time while glancing at the female followers passing by.

He did not look for anyone, nor did anyone come for him.

It had been three months since he killed time like this. Three months. It didn't feel too long for him. Maybe it was because it was peace found after a long time.

He wanted to stay lazy for a while. People wanted time to themselves.

Maybe it was okay to say that he had lost his purpose. Chunghuh now was very different from the Chunghuh when he had reached the [Depth]. The Depth Expedition Team had lost its purpose. They did not have to gain access to the [Fruits].

He could always return to [Chaos] with the [Fruits], but the problem was after that. The [Fruits] the people used to know about wasn't the key to bring back life. It was only a guaranteed passageway to the [Great Lands].

With the [Great Lands] revealed as one of the sites, there were no more fantasies towards 'real life'. And Chunghuh had the duty to explain this to the people in [Chaos].

But how could he? How could he tell them that the life they had longed for was all but a lie and their miserable life was actually real?

The truth was always right. But if that truth would destroy the people, maybe it needed to be hidden. It was better for them to live without knowing the truth, yearning for a 'real life' that did not exist. And besides, [Chaos] was a much better place to live in now.

"Ugh, it's giving me a headache."

Chunghuh frowned as he looked up into the sky. Then he noticed a small white bird flying toward him. It was a message sent by the Council. He received the message and read it.

"...What are they up to?"

The Council was the governing organization of the [Depth] now. It was an organization that Surha created after Rupture fell. However, it wasn't an organization to create a new form of power.

A year after the 'Fall of a star'-

There had been many changes in [Depth]. The largest change was the ranking of the Gods. The Council implemented mandatory participation of work for Followers, which changed the ranking of the Gods. The former rank was due to the world power of each God, and now they were ranked according to the rating of happiness of the Followers. If Followers were given better lives and became happier, it raised the rank of that God.

And that was not the end.

Followers were no longer bound by one unique world. They were given the choice of any unique world and were able to leave at will. There were

people who were now developing unique [Settings] together with their Gods.

It was a success of the 'Follower-based' system.

Some Gods were opposed to such a decision, but the Council's enforcement made all the Gods of [Depth] agree to the new system. And this included the Gods within the Council as well.

"Nngh. So, it's evaluation time already."

Chunghuh frowned.

Rank Evaluation.

It was a bi-yearly event after it started a year ago. If a happiness rating fell beneath the required level, the God was penalized. And Chunghuh was one who was penalized last time because of it. The female Followers of Chunghuh's [Moorim] had reported him for his [Setting].

-How can you have such a world now?! A [Polygamy] setting?! Are you out of your mind? Your world power increases the more wives you have?!

And because of that incident, Chunghuh lost many female Followers and now his male Followers were complaining. He might even be pushed down to middle-ranking God after this evaluation.

'Ugh, damn Surha and her policies... Well, I guess I can pay her a visit anyway.'

Chunghuh stretched as he got up from the hammock. As he looked at the clear empty sky, he remembered Jaehwan. It has been months since he had seen Jaehwan.

'I wonder where he went off to?'

Jaehwan was still in [Depth] even after a year. Chunghuh didn't know what made Jaehwan stay when he was always moving. He couldn't ask. Maybe Chunghuh was afraid to ask.

They were tired.

They still knew that Big Brother was out there. But as Myad and Gerome spoke, Big Brother was a being with no certainty. No one knew about Big Brother even when everyone talked about it.

And maybe because of that, Chunghuh thought it might be better for Jaehwan to give up.

Chapter 208: Big Brother (2)

The inner fortress of Edmunt was crowded with the Council for the evaluation. They were all so busy with their work that if it wasn't for the evaluation, it would be hard for them to gather in one place like this.

"What? He didn't come again?"

"Well, he's very busy."

"He's not the only one who's busy!"

Surha and Runald were quarreling. Surha was especially mad as she was now the leader of the Council.

"We barely managed to put it in place! There's no use if we don't keep it going!"

Surha snapped and glared at Chunghuh.

"And Teacher!"

"H-huh?"

"You broke the [Setting] rule again! Didn't I say not to create such a stupid [Setting]? You created a [Three Wives] Setting after [Polygamy]? Are you kidding me?"

"Uh, it was to answer my male Follower's needs... Surha, you know 80% of my Followers are men, right?"

"Don't use them as an excuse. It's all because you want it that way!"

"..."

"You already have mostly men! Why don't you try making a multiple husbands [Setting] instead?!"

Chunghuh became silent. He was actually having problems because of his [Settings]. It was Runald who suggested a different idea.

"Well, you can have the men marry each other. Why would you restrict a woman as a 'wife'?"

Karlton then cackled while he was organizing the documents. Chunghuh paled as people around them laughed. Surha sighed.

"Ugh, that's enough. Runald, go get Jaehwan. It's all his fault that teacher is like that."

"...Why is it his fault?"

"Don't you know? You know what Jaehwan's rank is now?"

Surha pushed Karlton away and pulled out a piece of paper from the pile. Everyone turned to that paper. There was the thick word for the rank.

Lowest.

Runald said, "...It probably means something else."

"No, it is exactly what you see. He's the lowest rank right now."

"But how can he be the lowest?"

"See for yourself."

Everyone looked closely at the document.

Name: Jaehwan

World name: World after the fall

Follower: 1

Happiness rating: 1

Evaluated rank – Lowest

Chunghuh commented, "So, he only has one Follower."

"Yeah. And that's me," Runald said. "How is that happiness-rating evaluated? I guess it only counts me since I'm the only Follower, but why is it 1?"

"Because the only Follower is depressed and always talks about nonsense? You always walk around saying an eye is looking down on you or something like a maniac. How can you be happy like that?"

Chunghuh's words made Runald dumbfounded. Chunghuh continued, "I'm surprised Jaehwan is still in the rankings. How did he survive last time? Isn't there a rule to expel a God from the rankings if the happiness drops below 10?"

It was Karlton who replied, "Oh, I opened [Gorgon Fortress] back then. If I use my unique world, Master's Followers increase greatly while my world is maintained."

[Gorgon Fortress] had an effect on removing the borders of [Chaos] and [Depth]. Even if [Chaos] did not have Gods, there was a lot of trust toward Jaehwan within [Chaos]. So if Karlton opened his unique world, Jaehwan's Followers increased greatly. Chunghuh frowned.

"That's cheating."

"Yes, but we can't expel him."

"Yeah..."

"If it doesn't work out, I will do it again this time."

Surha interrupted, "You can't. Jaehwan should be evaluated fairly this time. We can't always make exceptions for him."

"Are you saying you will expel him from being a God?"

"...Why would I do that? I will give him a penalty of serving as a public volunteer or something... and fix his unique world so he can increase his Followers. What's important is that he needs to follow the rules now."

Surha and a few members of the Council nodded. What she said was right. The policy only worked when there were no exceptions in place. Even if Jaehwan was the hero of [Depth], he couldn't be treated differently forever without the other Gods objecting.

Everyone's eyes all turned to Runald. Runald, the only Follower of Jaehwan. He was the only one who could communicate directly with Jaehwan.

"Runald, you know where he is right now, don't you?"

Runald was staring closely at the document from Surha. They then realized Runald was looking at the 'happiness rating'. Everyone felt sympathetic at that moment. A few were looking at the scar on Runald's shoulder. Everyone who had fought in the war knew what the scar was.

From his shoulder to his thigh. It was the result of spirit exploding.

Runald was injured to the point where his spirit had no chance of surviving. It was a miracle that he even made it through. If it wasn't for Jaehwan's [Eye of Geshtalt] and Chunghuh, Runald would've died.

'If he wasn't there, the 7th site would have perished that day.'

Everyone thought as they looked at the boy. He was a great hero. The boy gave up everything to kill the Lord. He had the right to be 'happy'.

"You didn't answer my question yet."

Was it because they were deep in their thoughts? People didn't realize Runald had asked something. Surha blinked her eyes dumbfoundedly and asked back, "Huh? What question?"

"This."

Runald pointed at the 'Happiness rating: 1' as he continued.

"This happiness rating... who and how was this evaluated?"

"Oh, I did that from..."

And before she could finish, Runald interrupted, "YOU did this?"

"...Uh, yeah."

"HOW DARE YOU?"

Surha's face turned cold. The air quickly became tense, however, Runald's face became colder.

"How can you judge another person's happiness? What are you to rate that?"

"Runald, that's...!"

"What difference is that from the System?!"

Surha couldn't say.

"Yes, Chunghuh's right. Jaehwan's world is depressing. It makes me go crazy if I look up at the eyeball in the sky. It even makes me feel like I want to die. But... that doesn't mean I'm not happy."

Some gasped. They didn't expect to hear that from a young boy.

"I determine my own happiness. So if you are trying to restrict Jaehwan with such nonsense, give up."

Some council members were shocked by the declaration. Maybe it was Runald who saw reality clearly. But they were adults and they had their pride. They could not agree with the young boy's words. And the one who represented that pride was one person. Surha declared as people turned to her, "We need him."

Runald grimaced.

"Why? Why do you need him?"

"To create a fair world..."

"For that reason? Are you certain?"

Surha couldn't answer as minutes passed. Runald stood up from his seat and walked over to the window, opening it. A breeze entered the window and cooled the room.

There was the smell of the wind. There were many windows inside the room, but none of them were large enough to contain the entire sky. There was always a part of the sky that they couldn't see. Runald spoke as he looked at the squared sky from the window.

"You already know where Jaehwan is and what he is doing right now. Don't you?"

Surha didn't speak but answered with a look.

"You're just afraid."

"..."

"WE are afraid about what we don't know."

People shook, seemingly from the cold... but there were no weak spirits within the council that could feel 'cold' from the weather. It was the year of peace that had given them comfort that made them feel cold against the reality.

"We... we just want to bind Jaehwan to us."

'It's here.'

The 3rd site of [Depth], in the hottest region named 'Musfelheim'...

Jaehwan was looking around as he checked the direction of the sky. Karavan asked Jaehwan, "Are we really here? Is there really an entrance in my site?"

Karavan, after a year of training, had inherited Ignis' [Setting] and became the new God of the 3rd site. He wasn't strong as Ignis during his best days, but everyone agreed that Karavan would be a great God in the future.

"Yeah."

"I was suspicious when [Fruits] were dropping here, but... did you hear it from Myad?"

"Something like that."

Jaehwan looked up at the sky, at the giant eye that was always looking down on him. The eye was closing slowly. Jaehwan narrowed his eyes as he spoke.

"It's about time."

Chapter 209: Big Brother (3)

Jaehwan remembered the last battle that happened a year ago.

As the power waned and the unique world [Sea of Blood, Mountain of Corpses] perished, Myad fell to the ground. The Machina creaked as almost every part except the cockpit was destroyed, facing the sky.

-A General called Sameng Garam spoke of you before. To look for you when I got to reached the [Depth].

Jaehwan had been thinking while he was fighting Myad. If only he had come to [Depth] earlier. If only they met a few hundred years earlier, things could have turned out differently. Myad would have never needed to betray his own dream, and felt despair at his hopelessness. But it was all too late now.

-Sameng Garam... yes, I remember that name.

Myad seemed to recognize the name. It was before he gave up on defeating [Big Brother] when he met a General with such a name. A General and an Adapter who was suspicious of the System... to think of how many people there were in the world with all those differences.

Myad felt his power waning as he stared into the quiet night sky. There was the sky of Jaehwan's dark world. He reached out for the sky; it was the sky that he had always wanted to reach, but he never could. In that place he sought, there was now a giant eye. The giant eye that Jaehwan always looked up at. Myad laughed.

-127 times.

-What?

-127 times... I've tried that many times against that sky.

Jaehwan felt the depths of despair deep within that number. This man did not give up easily. He tried so hard to reach the sky, and then tried again. He did everything he could in his power as a human being, but it did not work.

There was just no being that could defeat the System.

Myad looked at Jaehwan. It was a complicated look — it contained sympathy, pity, envy, and longing. It also contained all those long years he spent in his eyes.

-Once in a thousand days, there is a moment when the 'star' blanks. I guess in your case, it will close its lids since it's an 'eye'. It's a short moment, but it might be enough time for you to climb up to the sky.

Jaehwan realized what Myad was talking about. The story went on for a while and Jaehwan focused as best as he could to get every word Myad was trying to say.

-I can only say one thing. Be careful of 'time'. The biggest enemy a being can have is 'time'.

He was a man who had challenged [Big Brother] alone for thousands of years. Jaehwan wasn't sure what Myad thought in his last moments as he closed his eyes with those last words.

A cold winter wind blew. The winter started within [Depth] a year ago. According to the Gods who had a fortune telling-type [Setting], this winter was a temporary weather shift that happened because of the clash between powerful world powers.

"And that 'temporary' weather shift is going on after a year. I think those fortune telling Gods aren't very popular these days," Yoonhwan commented as he looked out at the thick snow falling into the region of [Musfelheim], the 3rd site. The snow, however, melted right away as it touched the ground because of the hea.

"Seoyul has still not recovered. But if you can use your skill from the [Eye of Geshtalt]..."

"I can't make everyone my Follower."

Yoonhwan smiled at the cold answer and asked, "Why? Because your world isn't happy?"

"No, a person has to stand on their own."

"Haha. Not everyone is like you."

Jaehwan did not respond. Instead, he just looked up at the sky. It was enough of an answer. Yoonhwan felt a pang of sadness in his heart. He looked around and saw Runald and Sirwen standing a distance away. They too had the same look as Yoonhwan. They looked at each other, and Yoonhwan realized it was up to him to say 'those words'.

"You saw, felt, and learned enough all this time that you can't do it alone. And still... are you trying to do it alone?"

Jaehwan did not answer. Yoonhwan thought that maybe it was because of him that made Jaehwan turn out this way. Jaehwan wasn't like this when they were in the Tower of Nightmares. He was brighter and eager to discuss his opinions with people. But as those people disappeared, Jaehwan talked less and less. He lost a lot of things such a long time ago.

Yoonhwan did not know what kind of life Jaehwan lived after he fell from the 98th floor. He did not know how much he had lost since then and how much despair he felt. He did not even know a glimpse of Jaehwan's pain. However, there was one thing Yoonhwan knew.

'After all that changed, you are still the Jaehwan I know.'

His personality had changed and he became very quiet, but something did not change. It was the core character of Jaehwan as a person.

"You are leaving today?"

Jaehwan nodded without turning to him. The giant eye in the sky was almost closing its eyelids. It even seemed like it was going to fall asleep. Yoonhwan smiled bitterly.

"I am still looking at your back again."

"..."

"I know. I know it's not a place I can go to, even if I want to. I can only hope for the best for you from here."

"That is more than enough."

"I know that too. But not everyone will think like me."

"What do you mean?"

"People are afraid. Afraid of what you are trying to do."

"They don't understand what I'm trying to do."

"Yes, they don't, that's why they are afraid. It's what you don't understand that makes you terrified."

Jaehwan realized what Yoonhwan was trying to say.

"But they all still think dearly of you. They just have a different way of treating someone they value. So, don't blame them, Jaehwan."

And as Yoonhwan finished talking, people began to appear over the horizon. It was the members of the Council. With Yoo Surha as the leader, Chunghuh, Karlton, and the other members began to appear. It seemed that the guards of the Council also came. There was enough world power gathered to fill the plains. Yoonhwan spoke as he felt their hostility.

"It doesn't seem like they're here to say goodbye."

"...I see."

The members of the Council surrounded Jaehwan as they closed in. Surha was the first to speak.

"Jaehwan. You can't go."

Chapter 210: Big Brother (4)

Surha wasn't sure what happened in the next moment. She only remembered that darkness fell from the sky and the ground trembled. However, she wasn't sure why she and everyone else had fallen to their knees. No, maybe it was wrong to say that she wasn't sure.

She knew. She knew that it was impossible to stop Jaehwan. She knew that this day would come.

'This is the power of an Awakener at the [Proof] step...'

But knowing didn't mean she had to give up.

"You are going to meet [Big Brother], aren't you?"

Surha barely got up from the ground as she spoke.

"ANSWER ME!"

"Yes."

Jaehwan replied for the first time. It was his declaration that he would leave and go to the end of the Tree of Imagery. Some people turned grim at the declaration while others seemed disappointed. People who had come all the way here all trusted and followed Jaehwan.

Jaehwan waved his hand and deactivated his unique world as it was pressing down too hard on the people. As the air became normal again, Surha panted, "You don't know if Big Brother really exists or not. What you are trying to do might be pointless."

"Big Brother exists. You know it."

"Even if he exists!"

Surha stood still in place as she shouted angrily.

"Big Brother did not appear when Myad tried to create his new System. Big Brother did not appear when all the Lords were killed!"

"I know."

"I know? Do you really know what I'm talking about?! Don't you know what that means?"

"..."

"It means that even if Big Brother exists, he doesn't interfere with this world!"

There was a point to what Surha was saying. If Big Brother was interested in the matters of [Depth], what happened between Myad or Jaehwan would've never been allowed. There was no God that would let their Vicegerent get killed. Big Brother ignored all that.

"We have a new world now. [Depth] is now stronger than the [Great Lands]."

Surha reasoned as she looked back at the members of the Council.

"The [Depth] does not oppress anyone now! We do not compete for the strength of the Gods! Do you know what it means? We can start a new world here! We can start living in peace and harmony! We don't need to destroy Big Brother to..."

Surha kept on going, she claimed that hope could be found, and that Jaehwan's way wasn't the only way. There were still stories to unfold and paths to be found. And...

Surha's voice became quieter and quieter. Everyone's eyes turned to Surha in sadness. Everyone, including Surha, knew that there was no point to all

of this. Whatever they said was not enough. They couldn't stand there and be proud of what they said against the man's justice.

And after a while, Jaehwan finally said, "[Cultivation] will still continue."

It was a calm voice, but some shook as they heard it. Jaehwan continued, "People from the [Remote regions] will keep moving up the Tree of Imagery by going through the Tower of Nightmares. They will come to [Depth] if they are lucky, but most will go to the [Great Lands]. And those that die that will be locked up in [Chaos]."

"That's...!"

"We can't stop that from happening."

Did Jaehwan always speak so logically? Surha couldn't answer Jaehwan's words.

"No matter how strong the Council or [Depth] become, it cannot be stopped. The [Depth] cannot stop [Cultivation]. If [Cultivation] disappears, [Depth] too will perish in the future."

It was true. Even if [Depth] became powerful and the Council implemented the right policies, they could not solve the core problem. Surha knew this. But she also knew that there were things that had to happen.

"I can. I will stop it."

Surha became angered at Jaehwan's words.

"That's easy for you to say! You..."

But Surha couldn't continue.

-You are trying to destroy the world! You want to destroy everything, every part of this world without exception!

She knew that her action, expression, and all other possible languages had been read by Jaehwan, enough to understand what she wanted to say.

She was ashamed of her fear, but she had to. Her life and the lives of all other beings were at stake depending on her actions here. Considering that Big Brother really existed and Jaehwan was off to meet Big Brother, that would be fine. But what if Jaehwan tried to fight Big Brother? And what if Big Brother became angered, killed Jaehwan, and came down to [Depth] to destroy it?

Surha shook her head. Maybe that wasn't what she feared the most. What she truly feared was...

"Surha, let him go."

It was Chunghuh's voice.

"You will have to go through me if you want to stop him."

Chunghuh walked out from the Council and stood against them. Karlton also walked out.

"We should let him go."

They weren't the only ones. Runald, Yoonhwan, and even Sirwen, who was beside Jaehwan, came out to block the path to him. Surha felt herself lose the will to fight.

Why? Why was everyone...

"I know what you are thinking. But we must let him go," Chunghuh said without looking back at Jaehwan.

"Go, Jaehwan. Do what you need to do. Kill Big Brother, destroy the System... whatever. Do what you want."

"..."

"I'm satisfied that I've come all the way here, I already owe you a lot. Because of you, I'm here."

Everyone all nodded at that. They had different thoughts and ideas, but they all agreed on one point.

"Thank you, Jaehwan."

Everyone around became silent. Jaehwan was silent too. Some closed their eyes, and some bit on their lips. They all felt the depth of the silence that had fallen.

The sky became completely dark. The giant eye in Jaehwan's world was closing its eye completely. As the 'God' eye stopped looking down, Jaehwan reached up to the sky with his swords. Then, the sky of [Depth] cracked open. It was like a giant mouth, with ominous energy coming from within.

Step by step. Footsteps were heard walking up the stairs created by world power. The people who had their backs turned to Jaehwan did not look around, but they heard it. The sound was getting further away. And after a while, they looked back and up to the sky.

"He didn't even say goodbye."

"Yeah."

The council members and the others were now looking at Jaehwan's back, walking into a giant mouth in the sky. Maybe it would be their last time seeing him. Some were teary, and Yoonhwan was one of them. He had been running all this time, following that back.

The mouth began to close and Jaehwan disappeared.

The eye opened back up again as the sky began to brighten. Soon, the sky became normal again as if nothing had happened. Karlton asked, "Did we do the right thing?"

"I don't know."

"I hoped Master would stop. I even thought he had given up since he spent a year here."

"Haha, I hoped for that too," Chunghuh answered with a laugh.

"What will happen if he defeats Big Brother and destroys the System? Will something change?"

"Everything might change, or maybe everything will stay the same."

Ronald also added, "Or the world really will fall this time."

People laughed and Sirwen said, "I guess the joke will become real then. We really have become 'Fallbringers'. I should tell the Nightmares to stop creating towers now."

"Haha, it certainly will be if the fall really comes. Then I'll say this beforehand — it's been an honor knowing you all."

"Good. How about we drink a toast to the coming of the fall?"

"That is a good idea. Are you treating us?"

"Count me in!"

"No kids are allowed, boy."

"...I'm a child on the outside, but I'm grown up!"

People laughed as they began to walk away. Chunghuh looked at the people helping each other walk back to where they come from as he thought. They were weak, but also very strong.

'Yes, Jaehwan. This is what you created.'

Chunghuh waved to the people as they called out to him. Chunghuh then looked at Surha, still slumped down on the ground, silent.

"Stop crying and stand up, girl."

Chunghuh pulled her up from the ground and brushed the dirt off of her. Surha cleaned herself up with a reddened face as Chunghuh patted her on

her back. The clear sky was above them now. Chunghuh spoke with a smile.

"It is a good day to fall."

Chapter 211: Big Brother (5)

He walked in darkness. He walked and walked and walked. He sometimes ran and swung his sword at emptiness, but he knew everything was pointless. Unleashing his world power, walking or running. Nothing worked. He could not get out of this space. Maybe Jaehwan had realized this too late.

A space of endless darkness. Maybe the space at the beginning of time was like this. Jaehwan had just walked a few steps into this space when he felt everything was upon him now. He would meet Big Brother, defeat him, and everything would be over.

However, the darkness did not stop no matter how far he walked. The darkness was so complete that he did not know where he was walking. The only sound inside of this empty darkness were his footsteps and his own voice when he shouted.

"Big Brother!"

He also looked for any signs of people, but no one replied to his presence. He was completely alone in this giant space.

A month passed. The only reason Jaehwan was certain of how much time had passed was that he used his unique world to keep track of time. And after a month of investigation, he found out many things about this place.

First, there was no way of getting out. The only possible way might be using the entrance he used, but he had long forgotten where it was. It was possible that he might exit when the eye 'blinked' again but...

'I can't go back.'

He couldn't go back to [Depth]. That was not an option. The only option left was to move forward, but the problem was that he did not know which way was 'forward'. Jaehwan wasn't sure how big this place was as it seemed to span infinitely. Maybe this space was something that Big Brother created, that seemed like the only possible answer.

'Dammit.'

Jaehwan had no choice but to walk aimlessly, and like that, a month had passed.

"Hey, is anyone there?"

It was quite painful that there was no one to answer his call.

Painful? What was painful? Painful that he was alone?

Jaehwan felt like he had become weak. He had stabbed alone for years in the Tower of Nightmares and did not need anyone to talk to him. But maybe it was those stabs that allowed him to endure being alone. His goal and the change that came from all those stabs allowed him to endure everything, but what about now?

'If I stab like before...'

He thought about it. He had given up on wishing that his 'stab' would become powerful by repeatedly practicing, but there was a possibility that he might come to some kind of realization through stabs and find a way out of this place by ripping it apart.

Jaehwan then decided to think simply. If Big Brother did not come to meet him, then he needed to cause enough trouble for Big Brother to come. He began to stab into emptiness.

Once, twice....

They were precise and powerful stabs. Stabs that did not care about how many times he repeated. Stabs only made for the sake of stabbing. Jaehwan focused on his stab, and repeated it, again and again.

Three years passed. Jaehwan threw down his sword to the ground as he scratched his long, messy hair. His stab, as expected, had no growth. It did allow him to use the power of [Fall] more precisely, but there weren't that many results for three years of stabbing.

'Has it really been three years?'

He was losing his sense of time. Maybe it was because he was in the darkness, or maybe there was some other reason.

'Time flows differently here.'

Jaehwan remembered the strange feeling when he first came here. It was a similar feeling to how he felt when he stepped into the Tower of Nightmares with its concentrated time flow. It seemed that time flow here was much more concentrated than the Tower of Nightmares at its maximum.

He was certain that three years and two months had passed here, but it had probably only been a short moment in [Depth].

'How did Myad challenge this place 127 times?'

He had challenged it 127 times and failed, but he still lived. It meant that he found a way to go back down to [Depth].

'I guess the exit back to [Depth] will reappear after a certain amount of time.'

However, the exit did not appear, at least for the last 3 years. Jaehwan remembered that Myad had never seen Big Brother himself. It meant that Myad had failed in this space without being able to move forward. He had given up in this exact space. For a moment, Jaehwan felt everything was pointless, but quickly came back to his senses.

'How did I train for two thousand years back in [Carpediem]?'

That was quite strange. He had once stabbed for two thousand years back in [Chaos]. It didn't feel like he had spent two thousand years, but the time

flow was so concentrated so it felt as though it had.

However, after coming here, he wasn't sure if the time flow was really expedited back then. It was hard to think that he was able to stab for 2 thousand years without going mad.

Jaehwan shook his head, this was not a time to think. It was better to just stab at least once more. It was the only way out of here.

10 years passed.

He wasn't afraid of the darkness anymore. His heightened senses now allowed him to see through the darkness as if it was bright daylight. However, Jaehwan felt mentally fatigued. He saw Cayman or Chunghuh from time to time when he trained in [Carpediem]. But there was no one here.

Maybe he had really become weak now. In the process of saving people, and after fighting many enemies, his 'human' mind had grown bigger.

As he heard the sound of his sword thrust, he realized he was alone. Many thoughts came to his mind as he heard the sound. He thought of all those people he met in [Depth]. Andersen, Runald... he also remembered Chunghuh and Karlton who he met in [Chaos]. Sirwen, Euren Chiver, and Cayman... he also remembered Mino. And when he was tired of remembering them, he went back through the [Record of the Depth] again, slowly. Of course, the records did not have anything about this space.

However, it was obvious. The records were created before Mulack had challenged Big Brother.

But that was reassuring. Mulack was certainly able to get through this space and met Big Brother. Jaehwan wasn't sure what happened to him then, but he was certain that this path was definitely a way to reach Big Brother.

He then recalled his memories of Earth. He didn't have many memories, but still had some such as of his parents. He wasn't very close to his parents though. His father left Jaehwan and his mother when he was young to

create another family. And after that, Jaehwan's mother was busy working to feed Jaehwan. So it was the sea of the internet that raised him, and the anonymous people in there. It was also hundreds of books, movies, and animations that raised him. And also himself.

...The little prince said, "It is only with the heart that one can see rightly; what is essential is invisible to the eye..."

Even then, he remembered something as he closed his eyes from time to time. It was a faint and distant voice. A voice that seemed to come from far deep within his memory. The days of peaceful times before his parents divorced, before Jaehwan's 'world' was completed.

...Then, what happens to the world that the little prince left?

...Oh, that world is...

Jaehwan realized it was his mother's voice. What was she doing now? Was she still working part-time jobs? Was she still alive? Jaehwan remembered the voice as he fell asleep quietly.

50 years passed. That was absurd. 50 years?

Was it really so short to shoot past just like that? 50 years was a lifetime on Earth. However, 50 years really did pass. It didn't feel like it, but Jaehwan's unique world was telling him that.

You have spent 50 years here.

His stab did not show any signs of growth, and his [Setting] did not have any changes either. But, there was a slight change in Jaehwan's daily routine. It was the space where one could not tell if it was night or day, but Jaehwan used the space in 24-hour routines.

He stabbed for 18 hours of the day, spent 5 hours meditating, and slept for one hour.

He did not need to sleep, but he still slept. The short amount of sleep helped him endure the long days. It was on one of those days, that Jaehwan opened

his eyes during his meditation.

He felt like he needed to say it, but he also felt like he didn't want to speak with such a thing. However, he felt like he would go crazy if he didn't talk.

"It's about time you talk now," Jaehwan declared and then he heard the sound of something moving. But it wasn't coming from afar. It was from very close, next to Jaehwan.

"Say something before I break you in half."

Something shook. It was like it was fearful or hesitant. Then, it opened its mouth while it was in the grip of Jaehwan's hand.

[...Since when did you know?]

It was his sword, speaking for the first time.

Chapter 212: Big Brother (6)

A noisy voice sounded within the quiet darkness. The voice made it seem like they had been waiting for this day, holding back from talking for thousands of years. And surprisingly, the voice was coming from the dark blade that had cracked open.

[So, you should've listened to me from the beginning and we wouldn't have been caught here like this.]

"..."

[Big Brother, my ass! What are you going to do after you destroy the System? Does it give you money? Does it bring back your youth? Or does it even compliment you or something? You already saw all those people! They didn't want you to do this! I'm pretty sure they're all afraid by now. That perverted old man, the half-angel sissy boy... They are all probably scared sh*tless of you destroying the world! Oh, but of course I think you might die before you destroy the world though.]

It felt like he was really noisy before, but not a thing had changed since then. Jaehwan regretted talking to it.

[Hah, I really feel sad for you, Jaehwan. I feel like I will cry now. I will shed sad tears.]

"You don't have eyes."

[Bah! It's a metaphor! Don't you get it? How can a sword cry? For crying out loud!]

The sword shook violently as the voice continued.

[So, back to where we left off.... How can you not know when everyone else knows?! You should've just moved to the [Great Lands] just like I told you to back then, and you would've been the most powerful Lord there by now! You could've finished the war in the [Great Lands] and live a lavish, luxurious life there! Now look what you've become! You are...]

Jaehwan yawned as he listened to the sword go on and on and thought about what its name was.

'Beastlain.'

Yes. That was his name. The Cultivator that Jaehwan met on the 100th floor of the Tower of Nightmares. He was the one with the head of a lion, wearing a black suit with the nickname, 'Gentleman of Mischief'? Or something like that. However, it was ironic for one who merely had the strength of a 3rd stage Adapter to have such a nickname.

[....What? What are you laughing at?]

"Nothing."

Jaehwan expected this when his sword began to evolve after he smashed his way out of the tower, and when Meikal from [Twilight's Fall] told him that a certain spirit of a higher being had possessed the sword. But he did not have proof back then, and the sword was still a sword.

Jaehwan had fought every battle with this sword. He had it since the beginning, and he was still with it now.

"You haven't changed a bit."

[I haven't changed a bit?! You're the one who ended my career! Look at what I've become!]

If he heard this the second he got out of the tower, he would've destroyed the sword immediately. However, Jaehwan had changed and he still liked the sword.

"But hasn't it been quite fun?"

[FUN? FUN you say?! What are you...]

Jaehwan knew. This demon had paid enough of a price for his sins. He had faced many dangerous moments together with the sword while making his way here.

[It was....]

The voice became quiet. If the sword had eyes, it would probably show complicated feelings.

Fun? Was it fun?

Was that enough to describe all that had happened? The sword vibrated erratically. It might even have been viewed as being hesitant if he was a human.

[You can't just describe it as fun. How rude of you to say that...]

Yet, it seemed that Beastlain was thinking of what he had experienced. 'Fun' didn't seem to fit how he felt, perhaps it was more 'astonishing'. The journey he experienced together with Jaehwan was an astonishing one that he had never experienced before in his 784 years of life as a demon.

No, there was no demon that could have experienced what Beastlain went through

Before he was placed in the sword, he was just an ordinary Cultivator. He was a middle-grade demon, a being that was looked down upon by Lords and Generals. That was Beastlain, the 8,152nd demon. All he could hope for in his life was to become a 'Public Cultivator' of Big Brother or become a God through countless Cultivation. And that would only happen if he was lucky since any incident could have killed him.

However, he became a sword and fought against those terrifying Lords.

He killed those Lords that he was so terrified of even mentioning their names, and massacred the Gods he was too scared of talking to.

It was a pleasure he hadn't felt when he lived within the System. Of course, he had to endure the pain of being destroyed first, but it turned out to be astonishing.

It was the pleasure of fighting against the world.

He reached the peak of excitement when he destroyed Lord Gerome. Killing Gerome, who had long oppressed all the Cultivators, was the one moment he would never forget.

Time passed and Jaehwan spoke to the sword that had fallen silent.

"Hey."

Beastlain came back from his thoughts and shook his sword body.

"Do you think I should still start the 'real game'?"

Beastlain did not answer. He just vibrated and refused to answer. Jaehwan then remembered Myad telling Jaehwan to be cautious of 'time'. To think that this demon could change... It seemed that 'time' really was terrifying.

There was nothing that was permanent in the world.

No. Maybe there was something that didn't change after all.

[So, Jaehwan. Why are you trying to meet Big Brother anyway? Justice? Ethics? Ugh, don't tell me that that's the only reason you want to meet him? Let's not fall into a cliché here, alright?]

Jaehwan frowned with his eyes closed as he heard Beastlain's lecture. He had gone on for five hours straight.

[Justice won't feed you! Ethics? Throw that sh*t out in the trash can. All of that is just the result of education! In some worlds, justice is to kill your parents before they get old and suffer, and in other worlds, ethics is where you lend your wife to a friend! It's an illusion! It's all created by humans! Ideas that were all created by human perspectives!]

Chapter 213: Big Brother (7)

According to Beastlain, it was within the one year that Jaehwan spent in [Depth] that he gained the ability to speak. The sword had gone through the 3rd evolution from the enormous world power and was now able to use its mouth not only to eat, but to speak as well.

However, the problem was 'when'. He had been silent all this time, so it felt strange to speak; he also feared that Jaehwan would destroy him if he knew. Then, Jaehwan walked into the darkness and 50 years passed.

After all that time, Beastlain forgot that he could speak. If Jaehwan hadn't asked, he would never have spoken. After hearing all that, Jaehwan felt sorry for Beastlain and let him speak. And... this was the result.

"So, are you done expressing your pent-up fifty years worth of chatter?"

[N-no! I still have far more!]

They were all just boring stories, but Beastlain was really helpful to Jaehwan. At least he wasn't alone anymore. Whatever Beastlain said was better than complete silence. Of course, there was some rubbish that was hard to listen to.

[Yeah! This world is all about you looking out for yourself! How about you start now? It's still not too late. You can even become the King of the [Depth]!]

"Are you still talking about that?"

[I'm worried about you! I mean, we've become good friends after all this time! You can always choose a path that's more comfortable for you. Why...]

It really was nonsense.

"Aren't you just afraid of being destroyed in a fight against Big Brother?"

[N-no! I mean... uh.]

Beastlain was quite simple-minded.

"Why are you so afraid of it? I thought nobody knows what Big Brother actually is."

[That's why everyone's afraid of him. You don't know what Big Brother is, even when it is the most powerful thing in the world. Isn't that terrifying enough?]

Jaehwan listened to Beastlain. He realized that it was the first time he was listening about Big Brother from a Cultivator's point of view.

[Big Brother is an organization that controls all cultivation. That's what we think.]

"An organization?"

[At least that's what I think. It is impossible to manage all those dimensions or approve all those Cultivations unless you are a big organization. I think the Gods from [Depth] think otherwise though...]

"Weren't there people called 'Public Cultivators' among you? They don't know about Big Brother either?"

[...They're still Cultivators. I heard that they are associated with Big Brother, but they only receive work. They don't know what Big Brother actually is.]

"But they receive work from Big Brother. Doesn't that mean that they communicate?"

Jaehwan then wondered why he didn't think of that. If demons were able to communicate with Big Brother for Cultivation, he could have utilized that

to gather information about Big Brother.

[We just receive work through the Little Brother network system. It's not like I can send a message and get a response. And it's not even a message anyway.]

"What do you mean?"

[We don't send messages to specific entities. We just choose a Cultivation region, ask for approval, and then we receive the approval. We cannot use private messages.]

"Are public cultivators the same too?"

[Yeah. I heard they receive it in the form of a 'Quest' to choose where to cultivate.]

It was easy to understand. Big Brother had cut down all possible channels of communication, assuming there were any. But that was good to know. At least Jaehwan wasn't wrong about what he did and his efforts.

There was something up there, and it was controlling Cultivation.

That alone was enough for Jaehwan to continue going up. Beastlain then asked.

[I am actually curious about what you think. Do you not have any thoughts on what Big Brother is?]

"Me?"

[Yeah. You, as an Awakener, are in a better position to find information than me. You also know stories about the Three Ancient Gods...]

"I have a guess. It's just a guess though."

[Oh? Can you tell me what it...]

"It's just a guess. And in my case, what Big Brother is might not really matter."

That confused Beastlain. They had been talking about what Big Brother was all this time and he was now saying that it didn't matter.

[What? Why is that?]

"What matters now is whether I can get out of this place or not."

Beastlain understood right away. They had already been locked in this space for 50 years. And this space was thought to be created by Big Brother. Whatever Big Brother was, it would be useless unless they got out of this space.

"We have time. I'm not worried."

Jaehwan shrugged and began to stab in the air again.

[Hey, uh, can you go a bit slower? It's making me nauseous. I've always wanted to say this...]

Jaehwan ignored it and kept on stabbing.

'Gosh. This human...'

He stabbed and stabbed again as if he would stab forever, or as if he would stab away this darkness. And the sword's mouth moved to make a cracking noise. It was as close to a laugh as he could make.

'I see. So this human will never give up.'

It was the same thing when they were in the tower. Even when everyone gave up on clearing and gave up on the presence, this human did not give up. This man stood and fought.

Was it because of that? Beastlain felt that Jaehwan would succeed again, even if the enemy wasn't a Cultivator but the ruler of the world. Maybe he

too had been influenced by Jaehwan. The sword shot out dark flames as its voice declared arrogantly,

[Dammit, okay! I won't die twice anyway. Let's go!]

It was after a very long time that Beastlain regretted his thoughts. Dying twice... Beastlain did not know that there was something far more terrifying than death. The trial that was upon Jaehwan wasn't just something he could overcome with effort.

Stab and stab. Talk for a while. Stab again.

Jaehwan's stab kept on growing and the sword became sharper. They talked about a lot of things. They talked so much that their differences in race, or the hatred between a Cultivator and a Product, disappeared.

They expressed glee at simple things and argued about simple things. They withstood time. And nothing changed.

Even then, they repeated the same thing day in and day out. The days when they did not say anything increased, but they did not give up.

And like that, two hundred thousand years passed.

Chapter 214: Big Brother (8)

"Hey. Am I still alive?"

[Yeah. You're fine.]

That was an inside joke they shared. It had already been 28765 years since they created this joke, but they couldn't think of anything better.

[Am I still in good shape?]

"Yeah. You're in good shape."

Maybe it wasn't a joke anymore. It was more like a ritual to ensure that they still existed.

[But I feel like I won't be in good shape soon.]

"Yeah. I feel like I'm dying also."

Jaehwan answered and crossed a line in the air. It was added to his unique world. But there wasn't just one line — there were countless lines made within the space of his unique world. There was a total of 9,624 lines. It meant that they had repeated the conversation 9,624 times.

[How about we do the truth game again?]

"...You've talked for two hundred thousand years and you still got more to say?"

[Are you up for it or not?]

"Yeah. Okay."

And Beastlain began to speak rapidly.

[Hey Jaehwan, let me tell you as a senior who's lived 784 years more than you. You can't do this to me. You see? You see, you son of a b*tch? Just kill me for god's sake!]

This conversation... was it 654 times? Jaehwan answered as he struck through another line.

"What are you talking about? I was inside the tower for two thousand years in [Chaos]. I'm probably older than you now."

[The tower? I was in there too, remember?]

"...Oh."

[And you didn't stay for two thousand years in there. It was probably like a few hundred years.]

Jaehwan's hand stopped drawing the line; instead, he created a new colored line. It meant that they were talking about this for the first time.

"How do you know?"

[I am still a demon, remember? I have a way of keeping track of things. There's a limit to how far you can speed up the time within the Tower of Nightmares. I'm sure it wasn't two thousand years. I think you felt like you lived there for two thousand years only because your mind believed it to be so.]

"...I see."

Jaehwan realized his sense of time was off when he was in that tower. Two thousand years was only considering if the tower sped up time like it was supposed to.

"Then maybe this place too..."

[No. Two hundred thousand years have passed here.]

"Right."

[Yeah. Look at your clock.]

Jaehwan turned to his 'clock' within his unique world.

200,001 years 113 days 11 hours 27 minutes 39 seconds... 40 seconds...

It was a [Part] that Jaehwan created after 150 years as he didn't want to continue counting time. But that wasn't the only [Part] he created. He also created a television-like [Part] and a bed-like [Part]. However, the place was outside the Little Brother network, so the only thing the television displayed was Jaehwan's memory.

It currently showed Jaehwan fighting against the Frost Dragon King alone on the 99th floor.

[It was fun back then.]

"..."

[Would you return to that time if you could?]

"No."

[Heh.]

The television was turned off and darkness fell again. Jaehwan laid down and mumbled, "I sometimes think that."

[Huh? What?]

"That maybe I'm still inside the tower."

[Haha...]

"So I used the stone along with my friends back on the 77th floor. And now I'm trapped in a dream world created by a Nightmare. [Chaos], [Depth],

they're all illusions that I created. And you are watching over me on the 100th floor, even now."

Beastlain laughed hollowly.

[Yes. You used the stone, unfortunately. You are still in your dream world.]

"...Are you serious?"

[...Why do you ask when you know I'm not?]

Jaehwan did not answer but added another line again. This was their 42nd conversation. It was a lesser variant.

[But didn't you hate that kind of thing?]

"What kind?"

[Counting. I thought you hated numbers.]

Jaehwan's hand stopped midair, not knowing where to go.

"Yeah. I used to."

Yes. He used to hate it, and he still did in some sense. He hated levels and statuses. He hated numbers. Yet now he was counting numbers to live on.

Maybe the System had no sins. Maybe it was like money. It was humans that used it in the wrong way that created problems. But if so, why was he here? Jaehwan commented, "Time is too long."

[Yes, it's long.]

"Maybe that's why I became what I am now."

[...Do you want to give up?]

"No. Not yet."

Jaehwan still did not give up. He recounted his determination every single day so that he would not give up during the entire two hundred thousand years.

What would have it been like if this was on Earth? Or [Chaos]? Or [Depth]? Would it have been that long?

There had been two chances to get out of this space. It happened once at 100 years, and once when it reached 10 thousand years. It seemed like the exit opened in exponential increments of 100. The only problem was that the exit was not a way to Big Brother but back to [Depth].

At least the opening of the entrance allowed Jaehwan to determine the time flow in [Depth].

Surprisingly, 200 thousand years in this place was less than a day in [Depth]. Jaehwan was even allowed to get a glimpse of his friends going back to where they were through the opening. There was the scene where they were going back after saying goodbye to Jaehwan. Additionally, there was a time when Jaehwan had even felt the urge to get out.

He always had the chance to return.

Jaehwan realized why Myad had failed and why he said to be wary of time. What did Myad think throughout the 127 times he challenged this?

"I should get some sleep," Jaehwan said as he added another line. Beastlain answered.

[Yeah. But no longer than an hour.]

Jaehwan did not answer as he fell asleep right away.

A million years passed. The stabs continued, but the routine had already been broken. Beastlain spoke sometimes, but Jaehwan did not respond. And so there was a long silence.

A few days ago, the exit to [Depth] opened once more and they quarreled.

Jaehwan did not give up. And the exit closed. If their guess was right, the next exit would be after 99 million years.

[...Jaehwan. I'm at my limit.]

There was a limit to how long a being could withstand time. Nobody knew what that limit was because no being lived for that long. However, Beastlain knew. He was at the limit now.

[I am thinking of going into hibernation.]

Hibernation. Jaehwan knew this ability that demons had. The ones that had long lives always had ways of falling asleep to keep their consciousness intact, and hibernation was such an ability.

"...And what about me?"

[Heh. You're on your own.]

"That's cold."

[I'm a demon, remember?]

However, Beastlain wasn't all that happy about his choice either.

[You can do it too though, can't you? You can create a hibernation Setting to...]

"There's no point if I fall asleep. Besides, you don't know when you will wake up from hibernation."

[Right...]

Jaehwan wasn't here to fall asleep. He had to find a way to get to Big Brother.

[You really are amazing. I really hope you will be alive when I wake up again.]

"Yeah."

[If you think you died 100 thousand times and you can hold on no more, you can wake me up then.]

"Get lost."

Beastlain did not answer.

In the 1.3 millionth year, Jaehwan stopped stabbing. Instead, he began researching [Settings]. If the strongest stab wasn't going to destroy this space, the answer had to lie in the [Settings]. He studied everything about [Settings] slowly and carefully.

1.5 million years. Jaehwan thought maybe he wasn't smart after all. He created countless [Settings] and created astonishing [Parts]. He now had more knowledge of [Settings] than the Three Ancient Gods. 1.5 million years was enough time to achieve that. He was successful in repairing a good amount of Machina and he learned how to resist the time-concentration through the Eye of Geshtalt. He was also able to replicate ten Void Swords at once.

Even so, Jaehwan wasn't sure what the space was.

He had his guesses. One guess was that he might be able to control this space when he achieved the last step of Awakening. Another guess was that from the concentration of time, the Tower of Nightmares was created with this space as its basic form.

But those were all just guesses.

1.7 million years. Jaehwan looked down at his hands. He couldn't think and didn't want to. He felt his cheeks wet from his tears.

Jaehwan realized he had become too tired.

1.8 million years. 1,802,532nd year, 167th day.

Jaehwan stopped doing anything.

Chapter 215: Big Brother (9)

It had been a long time since he stopped researching [Settings]. It was much harder to live through every second of this madness. As he stopped stabbing and researching [Settings], countless thoughts that were pushed away by his repeated routines came rushing back into his mind.

What was he doing here? Why did he need to go through this?

AAAAAAAAAAHHHHH!

Jaehwan unleashed his world power against the darkness. He did it again and again until there was no world power left within him. The world power did not come back. Jaehwan felt his 'humanity' crumbling.

Why did he need to destroy the System? Was it really necessary? Everyone hated it. Everyone was afraid. No, actually, he was already a part of the System.

Jaehwan cried at the countless lines in his unique world. The crying went on for a while.

-Isn't it dangerous now?

-Yeah.

-It's too much even for him. 1.8 million years. Are you serious? How can a man withstand 1.8 million years?

-So what are you going to do? There's no going back if he goes mad.

Silence fell between the countless shadows. Then a voice came.

-Let's wait a bit more.

1 million, 850 thousand years.

Jaehwan could only think of one thing.

Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill
me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me. Kill me.
Kill me....

And at some point, he stopped.

1.9 million years.

...

1 million, 950 thousand years.

Was it real? A voice came from somewhere.

-Hey. Get some rest.

-We'll help you from here on out.

And then Jaehwan fell unconscious.

He wasn't sure what happened from then on.

7.6 million years. The clock kept on tracking time. Jaehwan lost consciousness very often. It all felt like a long dream. He sometimes came back to his senses and heard voices talking to him.

-Hey, it's okay. Go back to sleep.

"Uh, what? Uh..."

And Jaehwan fell back into his slumber.

11 million years.

25 million...

36 million...

Time went on. Even when he was asleep, Jaehwan felt and heard a lot of information. He was able to acquire a lot of information in his faint consciousness. It was valuable information that he never would have come across within [Depth].

46 million...

In his long dream, Jaehwan was swimming through a sea of consciousness. What was a being? What was consciousness? What was death? What was a world? What was a universe?

Many questions floated inside his head.

'Maybe everything is a dream after all?'

The time he had lived inside this darkness was 3,000 times more than all the time he had spent on Earth, in the Tower, in [Chaos], and in the [Depth]. Jaehwan wasn't sure where his 'world' was, the one that he was supposed to live in.

'What is reality?'

Everything seemed like a daydream. Everything that he held dear seemed pointless now. Maybe Beastlain was right. Jaehwan now realized the truth.

Justice? Value? Reasons?

It all became pointless. All his fights and the trials he faced were all pointless.

Large questions attacked his consciousness, and he succumbed to them every time. Yes. That was a human being. A mere, powerless, and pitiful human.

A speck of dust in a universe.

And yet, every time he succumbed to the questions, there were voices that brought him back up.

-Don't think stupid, stupid!

-We will think for you!

-We'll take care of your thoughts.

-Just shut up and think about how you will kick that bastard's ass!

Jaehwan wasn't sure who they were, but he knew that they were trying to save him. Who were they? Why were they helping him out in such a way?

The only thing Jaehwan could do was close his eyes again before his mind was destroyed.

150 million years passed.

In a deep dream, Jaehwan felt that he was inside a great cycle of Ouroboros. A giant circle that repeated everything. An endless cycle.

Within that cycle, little by little, Jaehwan understood more of this universe. For example, he understood what 'clothes' were.

It was the power from the System. It had a way to show itself and cover itself. The power was created through the looks. Another consciousness would be created when the world and the System collided.

Realization swept through Jaehwan's spirit. He felt like he would understand the System. It felt like he would understand the meaning of its existence and the point of this space. The universe was about to give birth from within him. And then the voice came.

-That's enough.

"What? What do you mean?"

-That's where you stop thinking.

"Why?"

-If you go past that, you will never come back.

"Never come back?"

-You will no longer be human.

"Human... am I still human?"

-Yes. You are still human.

Jaehwan felt like he was crying. The voice continued,

-If you go past that, you cannot stay as a 'being' anymore. Crossing the boundary of a 'being' is different. When you go beyond that point, you will lose your 'humanity' and will be unrecognizable from then on.

Jaehwan felt like he could barely understand. It probably had to do with Myad's warning to be wary of time. However, Jaehwan wanted to know. He came all the way here, so he wanted to see what was beyond. The truth beyond that universe. The secret behind this vast world.

And the end of everything...

The voice came again.

-You will deny all those times you lived. Is that what you want to do?

Jaehwan's thoughts stopped at the voice. Deny his existence?

-Yes. You will lose your purpose. You will lose the reason for coming here, and all those times you endured will be lost. You will leave this world without a purpose.

There was a universe telling him to come from afar. He just needed to go a bit closer. Just a bit more and everything was going to be over. But he couldn't move. Every part of him was telling him to not go there.

-Don't worry. Let us handle it.

The voice spoke with most assuring and soothing voice possible. It was really reassuring. Jaehwan did not walk towards it anymore and the universe began to fade away.

-And you stay human.

Chapter 216: Big Brother (10)

He wasn't sure how many years had passed since then. Was it 100 million years? Or a billion? Maybe even 10 billion years had passed.

Now, Jaehwan clearly knew what state he was in. He was still in that damned space, but his consciousness was not awake. Yet, it was also awake in some way. It was possible that someone had endured all that time by sacrificing its own spirit in place of Jaehwan's.

Who? And why?

Jaehwan heard countless universes exploding in his faint consciousness and screaming. He also heard people going mad and dying because of the violence of endless time. They were all voices he had heard before.

He felt like crying.

He wanted to stop them. Why would they? Why would they need to do that?

He then heard the birth of a new universe. A total of 16 universes died and were reborn. It was that long of a time period. Then came silence. No one spoke and no one answered.

In the midst of his dream, a voice spoke from time to time. Jaehwan was able to relax because of it.

But now silence? Jaehwan became terrified.

"Hey, is anyone there? Is there no one? Don't tell me you all died!"

Jaehwan then remembered the countless screams he had heard. So they had all died. All those beings. All of them had...

Just then, he heard a voice.

-Hey, had a good sleep? You can wake up now.

And with it, a bright light shone on Jaehwan's closed eyes. He felt his consciousness and spirit coming back together as one and felt nauseous. He was awakening from his slumber.

Jaehwan opened his eyes and shook his entire body like a sick man. It had been so long since he had moved his body that all parts of his body felt clunky. His mouth let out a strange moan. It was his voice that he had not heard in a very long time.

He calmly took a deep breath and stood up. Then, he sat on the ground for a long time and began to rub his eyes. He also pinched his cheeks. He even tried to laugh or let out a tear. And after a long time, Jaehwan was able to accept that this was 'reality'.

A light shone on him. It was from an exit in the shape of Ouroboros. An entrance to a new world, and an exit from this space he was in.

Ah....

As he looked up at the light, Jaehwan realized where that entrance led to.

It wasn't to the [Depth].

An old memory that had faded after a long time began coming back piece by piece. All those stories that Jaehwan had preserved so precious for a long time were coming back to him.

Yes. He had lived all this time just to go there.

Jaehwan stood up and took one step after another. His walking gait looked weird and his sword swung helplessly from his waist. But Jaehwan did not stop walking.

-Yes. You go on ahead.

The voice egged him on. Jaehwan looked around but there was no sound from the outside. He then realized the voice had been coming from within him all this time. Jaehwan asked loudly, "Who are you all?"

The voice did not reply.

The darkness ended.

As he stood under the light shining down on his body, he opened his arms wide. He stood there, absorbing all the light particles into his spirit. Just like a baby that was born into a world, or a seed that sprouted from the ground, he stood there for a long time under the blessing of the light.

The pressure of time was fading away.

The pressure that kept eating away the spirit like rotten water was vanishing. It felt like he had been inside a dirty trench and he had finally dived into a bathtub full of clean, warm water. Jaehwan felt amused that he still remembered such a metaphor.

No, it was weird that he was still using 'language'. He had to abandon this 'inefficient way of communication' a long time ago. He even tried to abandon it multiple times.

Yet, he didn't abandon his language and carried it all the way here. It was this 'language' that kept him human.

The space seemed like it had overcome 'time' itself.

Jaehwan looked around as he walked along the pure white corridor. It gave him a weird sense of déjà vu. There were giant tanks placed on either side of the corridor with spirits that barely fit encased within.

Jaehwan didn't know who those spirits were. He had never seen them before. All of those spirits within the tank were curled up in fetal positions and were in stasis. It was a bit later that Jaehwan found the name tags placed at the corner of each tank.

God of Wander, Kairos.

Lord of Dignity, Sindler.

God of Journey, Beheet.

Lord of Slumber, Gaynach.

They were names Jaehwan had never heard of. Maybe they were Gods before the time of the Three Ancient Gods. They all had complicated expressions. Some seemed like wise men who had realized the truth of the world while some also looked like beggars who had lost everything.

Jaehwan looked closely at all of the tanks as if he was trying to memorize each and every one of those faces. And after some time, he stopped.

'This...'

He had found a much larger tank. The spirit had metal around its entire body. Jaehwan had never seen this spirit before, but he felt like he knew it. He had seen this similar shape in the [Record of the Depth]. After Jaehwan checked the name tag, he knew he was right.

'God of Machines, Daeus.'

It was one of the Three Ancient Gods, Daeus.

'Why is Daeus here?'

Jaehwan then felt goosebumps rise from his entire body.

Maybe Big Brother was entirely different from what people thought it was. Maybe the Three Ancient Gods, who thought that they invented it, were wrong.

So, this Big Brother was maybe...

Jaehwan's thoughts were interrupted by a voice.

[Congratulation on clearing your tutorial.]

A voice spread across the white space. Jaehwan turned in the direction of the voice.

[-or is that a bad joke?]

Jaehwan realized who it was. Just like Daeus, he had never seen this spirit, but he recognized him right away. How could he not? This being was the one that Jaehwan knew the best in this world.

Jaehwan destroyed the tower, came out from it, and reached this place with this man's journal. Every part of Jaehwan's journey had shadows of that being in it.

"Mulack Armelt."

The legendary Master of Nightmares, Mulack Armelt, was here.

Chapter 217: Big Brother (11)

[You took longer than I thought. I expected you to come 16 times earlier than this.]

Jaehwan had only seen Sirwen, but he knew exactly what Nightmares looked like. They had a small pair of horns on their heads and small wings on their back, but they looked just like humans otherwise. The being in front of him was definitely a Nightmare.

Nightmare Mulack Armelt.

One of the 13 Master Craftsmen, and the being who created the Tower of Remorse. He was here.

[Haha, haven't you looked enough? Or do I have something on my face?]

Even with Mulack's words, Jaehwan couldn't take his eyes off him. Jaehwan recognized the presence however. Mulack wasn't just a Nightmare. He was now something beyond a Nightmare.

[I know you must have a lot of questions.]

"Are you Big Brother?"

[Big Brother? OH! Big Brother...]

As if he had forgotten that word for a long time, Mulack laughed.

[I didn't think you would be curious about that. Didn't you come through the 'Fall of time' to get here?]

"I asked if you are Big Brother."

[Haha... so you haven't changed even though you came all the way here. It's about time you lose your stubbornness...]

Mulack narrowed his eyes.

[Well, I guess acquiring understanding beyond that of a normal being doesn't get you all that you need to know.]

Mulack then turned away from Jaehwan and began to wander around the corridor.

[Big Brother... yes. That's the name that's been used recently.]

A coldness then struck. Jaehwan asked, "...Are there other names?"

[Of course, there are many names. Big Brother, Invisible Hand, God of Gods, The Beginning One.... You know all this, don't you?]

Jaehwan wasn't sure why Mulack insisted that he knew all of it, but it seemed like the Nightmare was going to say it anyway so Jaehwan decided to listen first.

[Big Brother was created 210 thousand years ago. But it existed long before that.]

Mulack then turned to the corner of the corridor. There was the tank Jaehwan had been looking at. It was the tank that contained Daeus. Mulack reached out and touched the surface. Daeus' eye opened instantly. Before Jaehwan could put his hand on his sword, some kind of music began filling the air. Then, there was a screen in the air where the voice had come from.

-That power is dangerous. It is not something we can control.

It wasn't Daeus' voice. Jaehwan had heard a voice very similar to this one in the Forest of Madness.

'Ra-hamad.'

However, the being on the screen wasn't Ra-hamad.

-No, we must use it. Only we have the right to wield the power.

Catastrophe's voice came after, and Jaehwan soon confirmed that the voice was Geshtalt's. He then realized what the image was about.

-Let's start.

With Daeus' mechanical voice, the world powers of the Three Ancient God gathered together. Jaehwan watched the powerful conversion of world powers. The Three Gods were resonating with each other.

'Three God War.'

It was certainly the war that he saw in the [Record of the Depth]. Powerful world power began to resonate with each other and began to create a reality. It was a much larger world entering reality than what Myad tried to do.

It was the lone world that the Three Gods wanted, and the name of salvation to end all wars.

[System]

Jaehwan bit his lips. If he had a choice, he would have asked if that was the best decision. But he couldn't ask that question 210 thousand years later.

The light stormed on the screen. World power that gathered became a pillar of light that penetrated the sky of [Depth]. It was the light of a new world. Jaehwan could see how excited the Three Gods were because of such an achievement.

But they did not know that something was coming down from the destroyed skies above, something that they had brought down was going to ruin their plan.

Jaehwan then saw the one, the thing coming down from the sky. It contained dark, terrifying energy. It was too late when the Three Gods realized something wasn't right. The darkness completely swept Daeus' Machina which was standing in the center of the light.

'That's...'

Jaehwan glared at the darkness that looked very familiar. It was certain. It was the space that he had spent almost an eternity in.

-W-what's going on...!!

Catastrophe and Gesthalt screamed in panic, and then there was a loud scream. It was an agonized scream worth billions of years.

Then came an explosion. It was not a physical explosion, but the explosion of a being. Jaehwan had seen such explosions countless times within the darkness. It was like a big bang of consciousness, an explosion that gave birth to new laws and the truth of a universe.

Jaehwan did not know what the explosion was since the voice inside did not allow him to go any closer. But if it wasn't for the voice, Jaehwan would have been the same as Daeus.

It was a bit after the explosion died that Catastrophe's voice came back.

-Daeus? What's going on?

Within the destroyed Machina, Daeus walked out from it. There was a sense of a being that was more than a being in the lenses of Daeus' machine.

-I see. So it was all pointless.

A fight broke out. There was no reason for it. Daeus started attacking Catastrophe and Geshtalt all of a sudden and they had to fight back. But they were no match against Daeus who had become a new being. Jaehwan then remembered Ra-hamad's story as he saw Geshtalt being ripped apart and Catastrophe being kicked out of [Depth].

The Three God War wasn't a fight between the Three Ancient Gods.

Ra-hamad mentioned that it was wrong as it wasn't an actual war between the Three Gods. In a deeper sense, it was correct however. Jaehwan finally realized what Ra-hamad had meant.

'That is not Daeus.'

Daeus had become something entirely different after coming out from the darkness. He had become something totally different.

After Daeus finished his work, he flew up to the sky of [Depth] and disappeared. The video ended there. Jaehwan felt chill crawl up his back. It wasn't because of the story. Daeus' eye was closing back again and Mulack asked,

[How was it?]

"..."

[It's probably your first time witnessing another being that 'Transcended'. How is it compared to when you 'Transcended'?]

Jaehwan wasn't sure what Mulack was talking about.

[Daeus was lucky. He didn't need to come through the 'Fall of time' like you and me due to the Big Bang of world power. But of course, he too would have come across the same amount of pain...]

Many thoughts were rushing past Jaehwan's head.

[But he's still the luckiest of us all. Haha.]

Daeus was considered a dead God within [Depth], a God that was known to have perished completely in the Three God War. However, Jaehwan now realized that it was different.

Daeus died and became Big Brother.

Maybe that wasn't all that surprising as Jaehwan had expected as much. He was surprised about something else.

"Mulack."

[Yes?]

"What is that 'darkness'?"

[...What do you mean?]

"The 'darkness' that appeared in Daeus' memory. That's the same space that I walked past."

[Oh, you mean the 'Fall of time'. Yes, you are right. That led him to 'Transcendence'.]

"And what is that? Tell me. This... what is this place? What were you doing all this time?"

And then, Mulack's face distorted weirdly. His friendly face turned to something ominous and it soon disappeared.

[...Are you asking because you really don't know?]

Jaehwan felt fear for a short moment as he met Mulack's eyes. It was the strongest fear he had ever felt in his entire life. An expression of a human looking at disgusting insect — that was what Mulack had on his face.

[Haha... you must be joking. That is strange. There's no way you cannot know if you came here... Didn't you get all your answers through 'Transcendence'?]

It was after a slight second that Mulack found his friendliness. He grinned at Jaehwan.

[....I see! So you wanted to play 'a being game'!]

Mulack's face brightened instantly.

[Well well, you are a trickster! Good. I'll play along... what should I do? Oh, how about this? Let's play a version of 'Demon embracing the hero that came up to the top of Tree of Imagery to stop the world from its doom'?]

And the corridor began to change shape. It began to destroy itself and was creating an entirely new background. So this was the déjà vu he felt. This

place was similar to the 100th floor of the Tower of Nightmares, only much bigger.

Within a giant circular space, there were screens all over. It showed the Cultivation sites of the [Remote Regions] of the [Great Lands], [Chaos], and even [Depth].

[Well, you must know if you've seen it all this time.]

Jaehwan now realized what this place was. This was like the eye that saw everything.

[Welcome, new Big Brother. To the Nest of the Tree of Imagery, [Panopticon].]

Chapter 218: Big Brother (12)

If there was the greatest despair one could feel, it probably started here. Jaehwan thought as he saw all those screens packed within the space.

[Let me introduce our friends who lead this [Panopticon] with me!]

There were tanks that contained spirits placed in front of the many screens. Jaehwan then realized that the tanks were connected to all of those screens as if the spirits were given control of the screens.

Jaehwan then read the names.

Jan-Pol of Reality

Horhay of Imagery

Scarge of Space

Mars of Plays

Melville of Unfairness

He then recalled a certain memory at the mention of the name 'Melville'. It was the name of the Master Craftsman who created the tower Moby Dick that Chunghuh cleared.

[Yes. They are [Masters]. They are given the important task of maintaining [Panopticon].]

Jaehwan kept on reading the names. Another familiar name came up.

Ignel of the Deep Fall.

He remembered the blacksmith he visited in [Chaos]. [Twilight's Fall] was where he created the scabbard with Meikal. Ignel was the owner of the blacksmith workshop. He was known to have left for a journey and it seemed like he too had come up to [Depth]. Mulack tapped on the tank Ignel was in and spoke.

[This friend barely became a [Master] a while ago so I just added him. He's a bit clumsy for now, but he'll become useful soon.]

"...Do all Nightmares come here in the end?"

[Yes, of course. All Nightmares become curious about what the 'Nightmare of the Beginning' is and why they exist. All Nightmares are bound to come here when they become [Masters]. They all go through the 'Fall of time' like you did. Yes, the space that you called 'darkness'. But they go mad before coming here, so I have to go down and collect them.]

Jaehwan felt his head aching. So many questions were filling his head, but he wasn't sure what question would get him the answer he wanted. Jaehwan asked, "Are they Big Brother too?"

[You've been asking that strange question all along. They are not Big Brother. Don't you feel that they have not achieved 'Transcendence' like you, me, or Daeus? They are only consumables.]

"But why..."

[Because they are the only ones who can control Cultivation.]

...Cultivation? Jaehwan became dumbfounded. Cultivation, didn't that only exist in the towers? But these screens were...

[I can't control the Cultivations alone even though I've become a Big Brother.]

Jaehwan closed his mouth. Instead, he turned to all screens that were looking down. Why didn't he know? He now realized what was behind all this and the meaning of [Cultivation].

He always thought it was a plan for Big Brother to maintain the cycle of the [Great Lands] and [Depth], but he never thought about why Big Brother would want to do such a thing. Jaehwan looked at those screens.

There were the Roots of the Tree of Imagery and Towers of Nightmares.

-AAAAARGH!

-SAVE ME!!!

People were screaming inside, and although there were no sounds coming from the screen, Jaehwan felt like he could still hear it. It was the beginning of all tragedies with the Cultivation of the tower. Jaehwan then turned to the other group of screens.

There was the [Great Lands], a place where Adapters who cleared the tower strived to reach greater Adaptation. These people were now killing each other with more efficient and powerful ways.

-KILL THEM! Or you will be killed!

-HAHAHAHA!

It was full of people fighting to become stronger. Cultivation was not over. It just turned from forced Cultivation to voluntary Cultivation.

7th... 8th... 9th stage Adaptation...

The Generals on top of all Adaptation led the frontline of the war, killing all people. Jaehwan turned away. But he saw 'death' in the place he turned to.

It was [Chaos].

The screen showed Fortress Carpediem. [Chaos] created a central government surrounding Carpediem. They had become far more powerful, and they strived to become even stronger. Jaehwan then felt it was wrong.

-You're only a 1st step Awakener!

-Try harder!

-Everyone did it!

The Lords once said Adaptation and Awakening were almost the same thing. They were the same after all. The dead spirits strived to become powerful and yearned to become higher beings. They wanted to walk the path Jaehwan had walked. Jaehwan turned even though he knew what was waiting for him. He had to.

And there it was: [Depth].

It was a place where people who were at the peak of each Adaptation and Awakening step became 'Gods'. It seemed like some time had passed in [Depth] too, and [Depth] was now back in a chaotic state. Gods that gathered objected the rules of the Council and fought them. [Depth] was now being overturned. Gods who had acquired enough Followers began to exercise their rights and the Followers stood behind a 'stronger God's side than the side of justice.

Jaehwan saw all those beings. They were all looking up to the sky, imagining the eye of Panopticon somewhere.

Jaehwan then realized that people did not hate Big Brother. They wanted to become Big Brother.

After Jaehwan closed and opened his eyes, he saw himself. Jaehwan, walking into the darkness. The Jaehwan that everyone of Tree of Imagery wanted to become — there he was.

There he was, and he had become Big Brother himself.

Jaehwan felt his legs giving way. Awakening, Adaptation, it was all part of the story. Cultivation took place to raise a new king, and Cultivation was needed when a king was born.

Jaehwan shifted his eyes toward Mulack.

[Hahah. I'll welcome you again, Jaehwan. No, our 1131st Big Brother.]

How many worlds had to be sacrificed to create just one Big Brother? Jaehwan thought as he looked at the 1,131 tanks within the corridor. If this was the truth of this world, what meaning did beings have? Or what value did 'meaning' hold?

Even after he found out all the secrets of the world, Jaehwan felt like he didn't know anything anymore.

[Since you are here, my job here is done. It's only for about 900 years in [Chaos] standards, so my time is short compared to other Big Brothers. I'll consider it lucky.]

"Are you going into that tank?"

[I will, soon. When you can do your job.]

"My job..."

[Yes. Your job. You must know if you Transcended. How pointless the life of a being is, and the grand story that's awaiting you from now on...]

With that voice, Jaehwan felt something crumbling down. Maybe 'Mulack' had much more meaning to him than he thought. Someone had gone ahead of him on the same path and never gave up. Jaehwan realized how reassured he felt because of that fact.

It didn't take a long time for that emptiness to be replaced with sadness and rage.

"Mulack. You came here to kill Big Brother. You came here to stop all Cultivation in the world. What made you become such a thing?"

[...What?]

"You created the Tower of Remorse. You denied the System and came here. Then why...!"

His voice was barely able to hold back the anger. However, Jaehwan's anger came back with confusion.

[...What are you talking about? Denial? Remorse? That's a long lost... oh, wait a second. It's another one of your jokes isn't it?]

"No. I'm not joking."

[Then what are you....? Wait. Were you serious about everything until now?]

Mulack's eye then turned to disgust. Jaehwan took a step back without even realizing.

[That is strange. How did you manage to come here with such a weak mind? It was probably 10 billion years in that Fall of time...]

Mulack's expression turned cold.

Chapter 219: Big Brother (13)

Jaehwan's body became tense. It wasn't only because of Mulack's presence, but his words. 10 billion years? Had it really been that long?

'How am I even alive?'

Mulack began to scan Jaehwan's entire spirit with his eyes. It seemed as if he was looking deep into entire cells that comprised the spirit. Mulack's expression turned serious.

[Wait... what is this? Huh? Why are you still at the 5th step of Awakening? Still at the [Proof] step? You should have gotten to the 6th step [Edit] if you moved up the stream of the Fall of time...]

"..."

[You are still a 'being' but you still got here? Hey, Jaehwan. What happened inside the Fall?!]

Jaehwan did not answer. Instead, he pulled out the sword quietly and spoke.

"You awake?"

The sword spoke up.

[Yeah. I've been awake for a while now.]

"What do you think of this?"

[What do I think of what? Just do what we always used to do. I felt as bored as hell listening to him saying all that crap.]

"Yeah. I guess we don't need to listen anymore."

[You bet we don't.]

Jaehwan nodded. With the power of the [Fall] wielding the sword, [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods began to take form in a bright light. Machina covered Jaehwan's entire body and the Eye of Geshtalt increased Jaehwan's world power as the Void Sword began to replicate itself in the air, trying to make an attack. But whatever Jaehwan did, Mulack didn't seem to be that interested.

[How can this be... how can a lesser being like that manage to come here...]

Mulack seemed to be in distress. Jaehwan thought this was the only chance. Without him knowing how strong Mulack was, attacking first seemed like only chance to claim victory.

The wave of the [Fall] swept across Panopticon.

It didn't unleash enough world power for Jaehwan to be satisfied with as he had been resting in the Fall of time for too long, but it was still much powerful than the Three Ancient Gods in their prime. The Eye of Geshtalt began to spin, Machina increased Jaehwan's defense, and the Void Sword exploded in blades.

And in the next moment...

Jaehwan felt the shock of being pounded throughout his entire body as he was thrown back. The entire space was pounding on him. Time was going slow to fast, back and forth.

'What is going on...!'

Beastlain began screaming. The sword was being destroyed. Wave of the [Fall] perished instantly, Machina was scrapped to pieces, the Eye of Geshtalt stopped spinning and lost its shine. The Void Sword cracked, evaporating into the air.

And then Mulack appeared through everything.

[It's a shame. I guess I'll have to wait for the next Big Brother then.]

As he looked at Mulack raising his hand, Jaehwan felt the feeling of facing a universe and that he was just dust. It was the first time he felt death so close. In the terrifying fear, Jaehwan begged to an unknown someone.

'Help me. Please help. Give me strength.'

But no voice came back. The space of Panopticon was eating away his spirit.

'It's being erased.' The time he had fought, his determination, will, precious memories... they were all fading away.

There were no words to describe this death. Jaehwan became afraid. But he still felt that he was 'alive'. He feared his death, but death only existed when there was life. It had been a long fight, but in the end, Jaehwan finally faced his existence.

'Yes, I will die. But I will die as a 'being'. I would rather die than become a Big Brother to...'

And at some point, it stopped. Jaehwan thought he finally had died. But he just thought if he had died. That wasn't possible if he really did.

Mulack was right in front of Jaehwan with his eyes opened in shock.

[...What is that?]

Mulack was glaring at the world protecting Jaehwan. A mysterious power was protecting his body. It was his unique world. But it was actually Jaehwan who wanted to ask the same question. He looked around and saw his unique world surrounding his entire body.

But how?

Even if he was at the [Proof] step, Mulack's power just wiped out the [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods. But how could his unique world... Jaehwan then stopped at one point of the unique world. There were countless scribbles written. It looked a lot like Jaehwan's own writing, but it looked like someone else had written on it. It looked like a conversation, but it was actually a proof of extreme loneliness.

87 millionth year.

-HAHA Dammit. I'm done now. Next up, I'm counting on you.

-Yeah. Leave it to me.

125 millionth year.

-I feel like dying.

-Me too. Save me. Please.

-Ugh. How did the other guys do this?

-Hey, anyone who's going to come later, write down a novel or something so I can read it. Oh, wait. I won't be here then...

-You fellas are going wacko.

570 millionth year.

-I should've gotten laid with Sirwen back then... or Surha... no. I think Runald would've been good too...

-This one became mad after 2.3 million years! Look at what he said!

-Just think you're in the military again.

-F*ck you. There's no military service that lasts this long. I don't even know when I'll be done with this sh*t.

-Haha if you are reading this, you've gotten through 500 thousand years.
Congrats.

1 billion, 530 million years.

-Who's next? I feel like I'm going crazy for 1 million years alone.

-1 million is where it gets serious, Pops.

-Rest in peace.

Chapter 220: Big Brother (14)

Jaehwan kept on going through the scribbles. There were the scribbles left from ones that were here for the ones that were to come. It was quite humorous at the beginning, but the scribbles became darker as time passed.

3 billion 200 million years.

-The original one, you motherf*cking bastard! Why did you f*cking have to come here?!

-Ah f*ck... f..ck....

-1974th. I'm out.

4 billion 980 million years.

-Please.

-Come on.

6 billion 780 million years.

-SH*T SH*T SH*T SH*T

-....

-aaaAAaAaAAaaaAAAahaAAA...

7 billion 920 million years.

.....

9 billion 830 million years.

...

And finally, 10 billion 14 million 210 thousand years.

The scribbles quickly decreased in number at some point and disappeared. But there were so many scribbles that it might take a lifetime to read it all. However, scribbles were the only things that were there.

To the side of the scribbles were truths of the universe. There were some Jaehwan knew, but most were what Jaehwan did not know which ranged from various Settings, theories, Awakening, Adaptation, as well as magic to creation. The information seemed to be the collection of all knowledge of the entire world. There was 10 billion years worth of history written in there. It was protecting him.

Jaehwan realized he was crying. He understood the meaning of time, how he had withstood 10 billion years, and who these voices were that lived those years in his place.

'It was them. They lived those times for me.'

Countless screams and moans... they all came from his conscious, or his 'clothes'.

Go to sleep because it was okay? What was okay? It was not okay.

Jaehwan realized there weren't that many 'clothes' left within him now. Jaehwan couldn't even imagine the burden of time that his clothes had to take on.

[I see. So it was your 'clothes' that Transcended, not you.]

It seemed like Mulack also realized something after looking at Jaehwan's unique world.

[But how did that happen... giving other 'clothes' control of your spirit might drive you out of your spirit forever. How did you trust the clothes to

do such...]

Mulack mumbled for a while and suddenly burst into laughter. After a while, the laughter stopped as suddenly as it started.

[...You are a pitiful man. Sacrificed your 'clothes' to maintain your 'being'? Did you really need to go that far to make this world fall? What made you become such a monster?]

"This 'universe', including you," Jaehwan said while gritting his teeth. His voice cracked because of his cries. The clothes that were Jaehwan himself but also weren't Jaehwan died for him. They died to let Jaehwan stay as a being, to have him keep up the reason for starting this journey.

Yet, even if those sacrifices saved him, Jaehwan couldn't defeat Mulack.

The 'beings' that had a reason to destroy the System did not have enough power to do it. The 'Transcended' ones who had the power to destroy the System did not have a reason to destroy the System because they understood there was no point in the end.

Jaehwan stood up with his broken sword.

"I am..."

He couldn't give up now. Even if he hadn't Transcended, even if he didn't have the power to do it, he had to stand. He never gave up just because he did not have power. Even if he lost here, he would not give up. That was the least amount of respect he could pay for his clothes that died for him.

"I am...!"

It was then that a voice came.

-Hey, you want help?

Jaehwan became dumbfounded. It was one of the voices he heard in the 'Fall of time'.

-I mean, I don't want to, but I think it'll be stupid if you die here.

'You are...'

-Oh, right. You must be curious about who I am. I am, uh... let's just say I stabbed for 100 million years.

'What...?'

-Note that it's 100 million years. Not 100 million times.

Jaehwan's right hand began to shake. Something was taking place in his right hand.

-HEY! You all should help out here! You all want to play dumb because you Transcended? I hope you all don't want to become Big Brother! ...Dammit, assh*les. They don't answer.

The voice kept on going alone.

-I think I'm the weakest among the remaining 16, but even then... wait. You should be the one begging. Hey, original body. Beg me to take control of you to fight instead.

But Jaehwan couldn't. The space was now pressing him down.

'This...!'

Jaehwan realized this power originated from the 'Fall of time'. It was the power that had entrapped him for 10 billion years. The power of the 'Fall of time' was crushing down on his unique world. As Jaehwan moaned in resistance, an annoyed voice came.

-Ah, dammit! This is not what I imagined.

Something came into his hand, and the hand began to move on its own. With some kind of light shining brightly, a dimension in front had ripped apart horizontally. It was the level that Jaehwan could not get to even after

millions of years of stabbing. Part of Panopticon was destroyed and the spirits of the Master Craftsmen were sucked away. Mulack was shocked.

Awakening 6th step: [Edit]

It was the ultimate stab that had been repeated for 100 million years.

Chapter 221: Big Brother (15)

[This is impossible...!!]

With Mulack's shout of disbelief, Jaehwan saw his hand unleashing countless stabs that swept through the space.

What was it like to live for 100 million years? Jaehwan never even thought about that long of a time period. He couldn't even clearly think of the 1 million and 800 thousand years that he had to face. But a man who lived for 100 million years and stabbed for all that time? And that man was a part of his 'clothes'?

[HAHAHAHAHAHAHA!!]

A storm of stabs exploded all parts of Panopticon. Jaehwan couldn't follow his own hand moving about to attack. It was not a matter of speed. An attack that relied on speed had no way to penetrate through the power of the 'Fall of time'. It was a proven fact from the near 2 million years that Jaehwan had lived. 'speed' was the cost of distance divided by time and thus it was under the control of time.

But this stab was not influenced by time at all.

Jaehwan couldn't understand how that could possibly work. Maybe it was outside physics that enabled it to perform like this. Maybe this stab that his right hand was unleashing was not physical but instead more like an ideology.

[HAHAHAHAHA! DIE! DIE! DIE!]

Mulack's expression became grim as he saw space he created being scrapped.

'It's painful.'

Jaehwan felt that it was also becoming hard to endure. It wasn't because of his right hand eating away at his spirit. He was actually suffering from mental pain.

'This one...'

One man's memory was entering his head.

-Let's do it. I can do this.

It was the memory of a man who had stabbed for 100 million years.

-Stab. Stab. Stab. Stab. Stab. Stab.

A man who looked just like Jaehwan was named 3751. But the name didn't have much meaning to it.

The 3751th Jaehwan. His interest was only in stabbing. After he took control of the spirit body, he stabbed the entire time. He loved stabbing so much that he stabbed for hundreds and millions of years and still loved doing it. It was certain that he loved stabs and was better at it than any of the other 'clothes' that Jaehwan had.

It was as if a 'stab' had been taken out from man Jaehwan. That was 3751.

3751 kept on stabbing. He stabbed straight and stabbed in weird ways. He stabbed slow, and he sometimes stabbed fast. He stabbed all over the place, while sometimes he stabbed one point.

He stabbed all kinds of stabs in the world. That was 3751's sword move.

Of course, 3751 sometimes took time to think. A human needed to do other things than stabbing sometimes.

Why? Why did he keep stabbing? Why did he repeat this senseless act? For what? For whom?

3751 looked into the darkness and sometimes looked at scribbles left by his former 'clothes' and asked questions.

-Who am 'I'?

It was the question asked by many 'clothes' throughout the 10 billion years and a question that was never answered. Some 'clothes' succeeded in answering the question and were able to survive.

-I am the act of living itself.

3751 one of those 'clothes'. But this question led to another question.

-Then why am I doing this 'act'?

The additional question was answered differently depending on the personality of the 'clothes'.

There was an answer that said 'for justice' like the hero of a legend while there was an answer like 'for honesty'. There was also an answer that said, 'I don't like having something up there,' or an answer that said, 'The original wants it.' There was also an answer that said, 'I just want to get out,' and there were other answers that were extremely philosophical.

But most clothes could not get to the answer and died. And at the end of all the answers, the one remaining answer was this:

'I don't know. It's just like that?'

That was the answer that 3751 reached. So, he 'just' stabbed repeatedly. He had no desire to be saved and no desire to die. He just stabbed and stabbed. That was the only way he could prove himself. He just kept on stabbing.

-Uh...ah... uhhh....

And with that process, he made it through the countless years.

-HAHAHAHA! HAHAHAHAHAHA!

And he was always mad.

-I WILL KILL ALL! KILL YOU ALL!

He was always mesmerized by his own consciousness.

-HAHA... HAHAHAHA!! HA.. H..... hng..

And every day, when the day was over, he cried. He cried and cried. It was after his stab had overcome the 'space' that he stopped crying. It was probably after 50 million years.

His stab shined and the darkness was ripped apart.

It wasn't complete, but it was enough to be called a scratch. 3751 was overjoyed. He shook his body and cried for the last time. The scratch was proof that his effort was not in vain. His way was not wrong. This small trace was going to prove his existence.

He finally knew who he was.

It was then that his stab changed. He still stabbed and stabbed, but something important has changed. As he stabbed through the days, his heart became filled with something warm.

He was happy that the 'stab' existed in this world, and he was happy that there was something he could stab. He was happy to stab.

It was a stab of thankfulness.

And 3751 then realized the infinite circle of truth. Within it, he felt the giant power of fate. He understood the universe through his stab. So the universe had started from the stab. The beginning when everything collided together was also the result of something 'stabbing' something else. He finally understood it all.

Then, 3751 saw a giant explosion.

The giant explosion held every truth of the universe. 3751 felt a giant universe exploding inside him, and he felt his world that living through the Fall. It was the Big Bang of the conscious.

'I see. So this memory was...'

Jaehwan realized the Big Bang that 3751 experienced was the moment of 'Transcension' that Mulack spoke of. It was also the moment that Jaehwan almost experienced. 3751 had also experienced this.

It was the ultimate stage of being able to control time and space.

It was the ultimate step beyond the [Proof] stage. That was 'Transcendence'. A question then filled Jaehwan's mind. He looked down at his right hand that was still stabbing madly and asked,

'Why did you not escape the 'Fall of time' then?'

Chapter 222: Big Brother (16)

If Mulack was right, Jaehwan had been trapped inside that place for 10 billion years. But 3751 had 'Transcended' in just 100 million years and had the power to get out of the 'Fall of time'. If so, then why did Jaehwan's spirit have to be trapped in that place for 10 billion years?

[Because- I can get out of that place anytime I want.]

'So, you could've escaped anytime?'

[It's not an escape. Nothing can trap me.]

Jaehwan couldn't understand the meaning behind his words.

[Escape doesn't exist in my case.]

Jaehwan finally understood what he meant after 3751 showed him a part of the memory. There was no 'escape' because he was not trapped. A 'Transcended' one was never locked in a place and never bound anywhere.

[I think the other 15 probably have the same idea. You won't understand, but that's what Transcendence is. I didn't find a reason to get out of that darkness.]

Didn't find a reason to get out from it? Why was he locked up in that place for 10 billion years? Why did these ones...

'Then why did we come out now?'

[I don't know. It's not me who dragged you out from it. It's probably one of the other 15.]

And at that moment, the space ripped apart and powerful explosion of space blew up in front of Jaehwan. He felt his body being pushed away in the opposite direction as he withstood the explosion. He spat out silver blood. 3751 cursed.

[Dammit, f*ck! That fool is crazy!]

Mulack's attack was the space itself concentrated into a bomb. The distorted and concentrated space came down on Jaehwan and exploded, and the damage directly hit the right hand.

[That bastard's cheap! HEY! Why don't you fight with stabs! Let's fight fair and square!]

And it seemed like Mulack could also hear the voice. The answer came through the distorted space.

[...Cheap? So, you are still bound by mediocre language even after Transcendence! You sure are not worthy of becoming Big Brother!]

[Big Brother MY ASS!]

[Your language is not worthy also!]

With the help of 3751, Jaehwan stabbed away at the countless concentrations of space flying in. But the number was growing too large for a simple stab to handle. Just like how he stabbed to overcome the time, the opponent was throwing spaces to overpower the time.

The line of victory would be drawn based on the time difference that the Transcended withstood. They barely got through the time, but they were being bound by time again.

Jaehwan asked,

'Stab doesn't work well in this situation. Did you not practice slash?'

[Damn, boy! You greedy assh*le. I only know how to stab!]

'What about others? Aren't there 15 more? There has to be one who slashed for millions of years.'

[...Uh, yeah. But I wouldn't count on him if I were you.]

And they couldn't speak anymore as countless explosions blasted upon them. Pressure distorted Jaehwan's sense of time and the explosions kept on cranking up the damage inside.

[...HAHAHA! You are doing pretty well, but is that all? It sure is entertaining!]

Jaehwan bit his lips. Big Brother was surely a powerful foe. He still didn't have enough power.

[I see that you invested 100 million years into Transcendence! But that's not enough!]

100 million years worth of stabs wasn't enough to fight Mulack. Then what did he need to defeat that monster? Jaehwan felt the 3751's diminishing.

[Hey- dammit. ...We're gonna all die here! Can anyone help out?!]

3751 shouted and stabbed away angrily with no gratitude whatsoever. But the situation didn't get any better. And when all hope seemed to be lost...

[Kek. How about you beg for help? C'mon. Beg.]

It was someone else other than 3751. 3751 shouted,

[Dammit, where have you been?! What's your name, ass*le?! 9974? 11753?]

[Kek, you still got your tongue. So, are you gonna beg or not?]

[To hell with you! I won't beg!]

[Well, then you can die.]

A shout of annoyance could be heard in the air.

[GGGGGRRRRRAARGH! DAMMIT! You bastard... you'll die too if I die! Did you forget that this spirit is the only 'bind' we couldn't 'Transcend' from?]

[Of course I know. And I know that I Transcended from the fear of death.]

[AAAAAARGH MOTHER F*CKER!!!!!!]

[So, it seems you haven't Transcended from your 'fear'? HAHAAHAHA!]

Jaehwan thought that a man who stabbed for 100 million years was going to lose the argument.

[....HEY! Original one! How about you beg him? Ask him to help!]

Jaehwan did not answer and the cackle came through again.

[I guess you forgot, 3751. If you are the 'Jaehwan who stabs best', then the original one is the 'Jaehwan who is the most proud.' He'd rather die than beg. He begs to no one.]

[...]

They saw concentrated spaces being thrown in their direction again. The number of spaces was exceeding the number that could be wiped away with a few stabs. But 3751 kept on stabbing without giving up. It was when there was no other way to get out of this bombardment of spaces when 3751 spoke up.

[Hah... F*CK! HELP! No. PLEASE HELP ME! SAVE ME!]

And with that, Jaehwan's left hand began to shine. Something was taking control of it. Jaehwan did not hesitate and quickly approved it.

[Kek. You should've said that earlier.]

In his left hand, the Void Sword that had crashed was regenerating. The Void Sword that quickly found back its shape then increased its length so much that it was hard to see the end. Then the left hand moved.

It wasn't just an ordinary swing. It was an infinite line that was impossible to distinguish the beginning and the end. It was a skill that slashed the entire history of the beginning and end of the universe.

All spaces that were being thrown at Jaehwan disappeared as if they didn't exist from the start.

The voice spoke as they saw the spaces perishing.

[Kek. What do you think of my power, you stab maniac?]

[Wait... 8741! It was you!]

With the cackle, Jaehwan was able to read the memory of the voice.

His name was 8741. It was the Jaehwan who had 'slashed' for 320 million years.

Chapter 223: Big Brother (17)

There was the 320 million years worth of slashes from his left hand, and the 100 million years worth of stabs from his right hand.

A point and line that were not bound by time and space continued onward. It was like a shapeless masterpiece. It was more like art rather than an arc from a sword fight. There was no space for Mulack's 'space bomb' to come in between the two swords dancing through the air. Mulack was becoming pale as he realized his bomb was not working.

[This is really unexpected. I did not expect you to have 2 of your 'clothes' Transcend!]

But even when Mulack continued to throw the concentrated spaces frantically, he did not stop talking. 8741, who had slashed for 320 million years, answered him.

[Kek. It looks like you lived just as long as me, or a bit more. You should just give up now.]

[Yeah! Combined, we've lived longer than you!]

Jaehwan, however, couldn't be more astonished by the fact that Mulack was holding on. The stab that was being unleashed in his right hand was on a level that he would barely achieve after 100 million years of training, and the slash coming from his left was at a level where Chunghuh who had slashed for his entire life would need to slash for millions of years hoping to get there.

Nonetheless, Mulack managed to defend himself from those attacks.

Of course, he was barely holding on and it seemed like the fight was going to be over soon, but Jaehwan knew how powerful Mulack was. He then felt slight regret. If he only trained a bit harder, if he had withstood that time a bit more, what would've happened? Would he be allowed to become strong like them too?

[Hey, don't go there. If you changed like us, you would never act like how you are right now.]

'But...'

[You will never achieve your goal if you become like us. You know this.]

'Still...'

8741 answered instead.

[Kek. There's no 'but' or 'still'. You have to live as a human. You have to.]

Jaehwan then remembered the voice that got him out of the darkness of the 'Fall of time'. That voice also told him similar things. Stay human.

[It's a shame. If you became Big Brother, you probably would be the strongest Big Brother in history.]

Mulack's bitter voice came from the countless sword attacks. He was wounded badly.

[I am really sad. That will not be possible anymore.]

3751 then laughed maniacally.

[HAHAHAHA! Cut that nonsense. Just die!]

3751 unleashed his concentrated stab on Mulack. However, in the next moment, a powerful shield-like barrier appeared around Mulack. A spark fired out as the sword clashed with the barrier. Jaehwan felt the energy was not Mulack's.

[Did you forget? Like you, Big Brother is not alone either.]

His left and right hand suddenly felt chills. It seemed like the Transcended ones were able to feel something much quicker. Jaehwan looked to the back and saw the white corridor opening up again. And within that corridor, the [Big Brothers] who were sleeping inside the tanks were waking up.

'Dammit...'

Were they all being awoken?

Big Brothers.

It was the power of the ruler of the universe.

[World Breaker] was a lance used by the Lord of Slumber.

[Kaiser Wing] was a wing used by Kairos the God of Wander.

[Spirit that doesn't return] was a Part used by Beheet the God of Journey.

[Guardian Wall] was a shield used by Sindler the Lord of Dignity.

Fortunately, they weren't 'really' awake. What was awakened were their weapons and armor. But in the larger perspective of things, that was still very troubling.

[Even you cannot face the power of all the Big Brothers.]

These weapons far exceeded the power of the [Parts] of the Three Ancient Gods. And all of those weapons had the power of Transcended ones that equaled Mulack's power.

[World Breaker]'s thunder got in the way of Jaehwan's movement and [Kaiser Wing]'s fire restricted Jaehwan's movements. The [Spirit that doesn't return] affected Jaehwan's sense of time and space and the [Guardian Wall] created a strong barrier that withstood stabs and slashes.

All of those weapons had complicated mechanics. Mulack even had Daeus' Machina in his hand.

Machina's cannon fired an energy bullet out from its opening. Jaehwan was thrown to the back as he was struck by it.

[Whoa, those are all the Transcended ones? It's crazy. How many are there?]

[...Kek. That's too many.]

[Yeah.]

[But I'm not sure if the others will help.]

[Of course. They are all like you.]

[...kek kek.]

[Stop 'kek'ing you ass*le! We might all die!]

Jaehwan felt like he wanted to plug his ears, but the conversation continued.

[Kek. You want to try 'that'?]

['That'? Wait... no. They won't like that.]

[I think some are sleeping. In fact, I think everyone's sleeping except for you and me.]

[So, you are going to wake them all up? We might even wake 'him' up in the process.]

Silence fell as they mentioned the word 'him'.

[Kek, kek. Maybe it will become more interesting then.]

[HEY! NO, WAIT!]

But with that shout, the left hand began to shine brightly.

[Dammit. I'm not sure if we're making the right choice.]

And with that, the right hand also began to shine. Both hands that met each other then began to make a weird sound as if they were playing an instrument. It wasn't a sound that a living being could create. It was a sound that had no rule or form and it was even painful to even listen to. Then Jaehwan was swept away by the sea of sounds without even being able to moan in pain.

[...What are you doing!]

Mulack also shouted as he noticed something strange was going on. And after a while, voices began to flood in from somewhere.

[GOD-DAMMIT! WHO TURNED ON THE ALARM!]

[...I was having a sweet dream. Why are you calling me?]

[Oh, were you fighting already?]

[You should've called me earlier if this was going on!]

A violent amount of information began rushing into Jaehwan's head. If the brain had the capacity to hold all of it, it was enough to make it explode.

Jaehwan lost consciousness.

Chapter 224: Big Brother (18)

....

6981.

9612

11471.

12753

17831.

54121.

59812

61010.

63123.

....

Those were the names that were only called by numbers. 10 billion years worth of memories that these names had come rushing through Jaehwan's head.

[W-what is this...!]

Mulack shouted in disbelief. When Jaehwan came back to his senses, there was an indescribable disaster. But of course, that disaster was happening within Jaehwan's spirit also.

[Hey! That's my left leg! I got here first!]

[Lemme take the right then.]

[I'm taking the right!]

[Get off. Just go there... uh. By the nipple.]

[You wanna die?!]

[HUH? Come get it!]

Jaehwan looked down at his right foot trying to pinch on his nipple dumbfoundedly. From his pinky toe to the top of his head, something was within him. As he looked down, he saw his nipple squirming as it started talking.

[What are you looking at?! I'll pick your eyeballs out!]

A kick came from his left leg with a complicated [Setting] and his right hand unleashed fascinating [Magic]. His left eye unleashed an energy beam that exceeded the power of Machina's beam and the right eye was spinning more fiercely than the Eye of Geshtalt, thus expanding the world. And even in his armpit, there was enough world power to compress the entire space coming out from it.

[Nnngh.... Aaaargh..... GAAAARGH!]

Jaehwan saw Mulack swinging aimlessly in the air in disbelief. An attack that the Big Brothers could not defend with their arsenal was pressing down on him.

There was the Jaehwan who had studied [Settings] for 200 million years and another Jaehwan who had kicked for 400 million years. In addition, there was also a Jaehwan who studied Machina for all those years, and a Jaehwan who studied the Eye of Geshtalt. They were all Jaehwan with their separate specialties in their Transcendence.

[Who else is there? Is there still someone who hasn't taken control yet?]

[F*ck. I need still need to find a space!]

There was another Transcended one. The 63123th Jaehwan. He was the one who trained the [Naked] setting throughout all his time.

[You took control down to the armpit hairs! Where can I get in?!]

In his shout of frustration, 8741 cackled.

[Don't worry. We left a space for you.]

[Huh? Where is it?]

Jaehwan then felt powerful energy coming from his genital area.

[Isn't it a fitting place for you?]

[Y-you assh*les!]

Jaehwan became dumbfounded as he looked down on his genital shining brilliantly in gold. These fools... was this really necessary? Transcended ones each had their own comments.

[Just stay there alright?]

[Kek, you look good there.]

But it seemed like 63123 was actually happy to be there. Jaehwan felt his genital squirming awkwardly.

'Dammit.'

Jaehwan gave up on everything and wondered why it was up to him to take all the shame and gave up on his thoughts.

[HAHAHA! I'll blast you all to the end of the universe! This is the power of true [Naked]!!]

The cannon that was fired wielded the [Naked] Setting. Golden world power shot out toward Mulack and all of Panopticon. A golden storm swept through the entire time and space.

[T-this is vulgar! How dare you make such attack...!]

[Vulgar? Oh, so are you starting the 'mediocre language' battle now?]

[SHUT UP!]

[Master] Craftsmen were coming back to their senses inside the tank, trying to come out of them. The tanks were all destroyed, including all the screens. 63123 burst into hearty laughter.

[N-NO!!!!]

Mulack paled in disbelief like a rich merchant who had lost all his cargo in the sea.

[Why are you doing this! You are all Transcended ones! Why are you clinging onto a "being's" pointless purpose?!]

At that moment, Jaehwan's attack stopped. Mulack's words had stopped the Transcended ones from moving. Why were they doing this? They weren't human anymore. They weren't even beings now.

[You have no reason to help him! You have no purpose! Then why...!]

Purpose? Reason? They forgot it all. They had forgotten every word that held such meaning. Then why were they helping Jaehwan? Why were they helping the original's purpose?

Was it because the original was their master? No. They never listened to the original one's orders.

Was it because they would die too when the original died? No. They had long forgotten the fear of death. Even then, they were helping Jaehwan instinctively.

But why?

Jaehwan then felt like every part of his body was looking at himself. It felt like the 16 Transcended ones were looking straight at him. Jaehwan wasn't sure what it meant, but he felt a faint feeling. It was something close to Transcended sadness.

All the Transcended ones were not beings. However, these beings weren't actually 'beings' in the first place. They were just Jaehwan's 'clothes' to begin with. They were never 'beings'.

[Don't think like that.]

[You never considered us only as 'clothes'.]

[You always asked us for advice.]

[You always asked us to help.]

[And we helped you on our terms. Our will.]

Jaehwan tried to shake his head, but his neck didn't move. There was another Jaehwan on his neck also.

[We met friends because of you.]

[We received memories because of you.]

[We were brought to life because of you.]

[That's why we became you.]

He felt like crying, but Jaehwan couldn't cry. There were other Jaehwans in both his eyes. They kept on talking.

[We are you.]

[We transcended.]

[We lost our purpose.]

[We lost our feelings.]

[We are no longer human.]

[We abandoned our justice.]

[But we are still you.]

The 16 Jaehwans then turned at once. They turned directly to where Mulack was.

[You asked why are we helping him?]

Mulack was terrified as he backed away. There was enough pressure to reinstate the feeling of 'fear' into a Transcended one. The sixteen Jaehwans made such a thing possible.

[That is because we are Jaehwan.]

The sound of a drum came from somewhere and something melted away within the spirit. They were always Jaehwan. He cried soundlessly. Yes, this was the reason. This reason was truly fitting for Jaehwan himself. The Jaehwans then spoke in unison.

[That is the only thing that makes us a 'being'.]

Chapter 225: Big Brother (19)

"Block that area!"

"This area's fine!"

Runald shouted as he blocked the Vicegerents trying to rush in from all four doors of the Great Arena.

"We got it here too!"

One year ago, when Jaehwan disappeared and left for the [Nest], a lot of things changed within [Depth]. The battle between the Gods that seemed to have solved was starting again, and it was hard to enforce the rules upon the powerful Gods that appeared with just the power of Council.

"Move out! Council dogs!"

Runald recognized the Vicegerent trying to break into the gate of the Great Arena right away. It was Vicegerent of God Bergetz, who was ranked second at the 2nd site next to Droyan, the God of Dragons. He was not powerful like the Three Ancient Gods, but he quickly gained his power while the others were weak. Now, he had power equal to the former 8 Gods of [Depth]. His organization [White Revolutionaries] in particular was an organization with Gods who opposed the Council that worked to oppose all policies that the Council tried to enforce.

"Dammit! There's too many of them!"

Runald shouted as he gritted his teeth. They attacked just when Yoo Surha, Pierre, and the most powerful members of the Council were out. Karlton shouted from the west.

"Runald! Hang in there! Leader will be here within 30 minutes!"

"Hang on there, kid!"

Chunghuh also shouted from the east. They were all trying hard to block entry. But the situation wasn't all that hopeful. 30 minutes was enough time to give in and have them take control of this Great Arena. Runald frowned as he deflected the world power being thrown at him.

'Dammit! They are trying to make a new [Giant Setting] after taking control of this place!'

The Great Arena was a place the Council created to place a law in effect in [Depth]. If a certain number of Gods were to enter the Giant Arena, an automatic [Great Meeting] would start to place a new law in effect.

'We have to stop them from starting a [Great Meeting] at all costs!'

The [Giant Setting] that was placed within the [Great Meeting] was allowed to influence the entire [Depth]. It was a system that was in place to have the Council as the most influential organization but also keep the freedom of power within. That was what Yoo Surha and the Council tried to achieve through this Great Arena.

But it was now trying to be used to achieve an adverse effect.

If the [White Revolutionaries] who claimed the power-based world were to enter, it was evident as to what might come next. It was the return to the world of power. They would reset every Setting that the Council had placed and change [Depth] back to a place where Gods had absolute power.

'Dammit... Jaehwan...'

Runald remembered the familiar name as he saw waves of Vicegerents. It was the only name he remembered in a situation like this. It had only been one year after he left. Everyone in [Depth] expected Jaehwan to fail. Mulack failed, and so did Myad. They all thought Jaehwan also would never come back. But Runald did not think that way.

'The signal became weak, but the link between me and Jaehwan has not been broken yet.'

A year had passed, but even if it was 10 years, Runald still trusted Jaehwan. He believed Jaehwan would accomplish what he set out to do and would never give up. Even if he was wrong, however, even if this world did not change, Jaehwan would never give up.

That's why Runald longed for Jaehwan.

'If only he didn't go up...' Runald thought. If Jaehwan was here, this world might have been more peaceful. If Jaehwan stayed in [Depth], this absurd organization that only sought power and fulfilling their desires would not have appeared.

It was when it was hard to fight against world power any longer that Runald stopped thinking. He placed his back on the gate and bit his lips.

'If Jaehwan was only here, these fools would've been swept by a stab...'

It was then that Runald looked up to the sky. Something flashed in the sky and fell, then came a thundering sound that penetrated the sky and the ground.

Screaming followed from all sides.

"AAAAAARGH!"

Then Runald heard Chunghuh and Karlton's shouts.

"Runald! Get down!"

But Runald couldn't get down. All he could do was to look up to the sky in dumbfoundedly. The sky was blinking as if it wasn't sure whether it was night or day, or a giant light bulb flashing. And after a few more thundering sounds, Runald came back to his senses.

Everywhere around him was laid in ruins. The powerful God Bergetz and his thousands of Followers were no more. They all were killed by just a few

claps of thunder.

"...What is going on? What happened?"

"Runald!"

Chunghuh and Karlton were running toward Runald at the north gate. They too seemed shocked by what just happened. They were looking around in disbelief at the result. They found Bergetz's spirit turning into dust due to the lightning that struck down from the sky.

A flash of lightning striking down all of a sudden? It wasn't possible unless someone made a hole in the sky.

...Wait. A hole?

"Wait! Is this him? Is it HIM?!"

"Are you serious...?!"

Chunghuh, Karlton, and Runald looked up into the sky. But the sky didn't have any difference other than having a weird ominous feeling within it. Chunghuh and Karlton shrugged and looked at each other. But Runald was still looking up to the sky.

"Hey, kid. Do you see something?"

"Runald. What do you see? Is there something up there?"

It was only Runald who had a direct link with Jaehwan here. His eyes were shaking violently. Chunghuh realized that something serious was happening so he tried to shake Runald back, but Karlton shook his head and held his shoulder. This wasn't a good time to rush.

Runald seemed completely out of his mind right now. And after a while, Runald spoke slowly.

"The eye...."

"Eye? What's with the eye?"

But even with Chunghuh's frantic voice, Runald wasn't sure what word could describe the sight he was seeing. It was unbelievable.

There was a giant eye bleeding painfully all over. And within it, there was a giant hole all over the place, shooting lightning out from within the hole.

And it was falling down.

Runald tried hard to explain what he was seeing but he couldn't make the words out of his mouth. And after a while, he was barely able to speak.

"He did it."

Chapter 226: Big Brother (20)

Jaehwan couldn't hear anymore. Both his arms were numb and his legs didn't feel like standing. Rather, he was floating in the air. He wasn't certain if what he was seeing was real and he couldn't trust his sense of smell. There was the debris of exploded dimensions floating around him.

[He's amazing.]

[I didn't expect him to withstand all of our power...]

The Transcended ones that took control of Jaehwan's body seemed tired as well. They used Jaehwan's spirit to the point where they squeezed every drop out of it and in the end, it made them extremely tired. Jaehwan couldn't even stand by himself if it wasn't for them.

[Kek. We'll all die in this case.]

8741 from Jaehwan's left hand cackled and 3751 from the right hand answered,

[You don't know that. He is not in good condition either.]

Mulack's body was almost destroyed. His spirit was like a torn rag right now. His left hand was replaced with Daeus' [Parts] and his legs had been replaced with Parts created by former Big Brothers. Something kept seeping out from the ripped stomach and his one eye was blinded.

But Mulack was still powerful.

There were still hundreds of former Big Brother weapons floating behind him, and the power surrounding him was still prominent. He even had a smile on his face. Mulack raised his mech arm slowly. Was it the start of the

'space bomb' again? Jaehwan tried to bring up his power again, but Mulack spoke.

[Jaehwan. Why don't we make a truce?]

It was an unexpected offer.

[I think you've unleashed enough anger now. I've also experienced enough of your power.]

"What are you saying?"

[I will accept you as a new Big Brother. You, and all the Transcended ones within you.]

Silence fell. It was the first silence after the fight began. Jaehwan became shocked when all of his Transcended ones became quiet. Maybe they were agreeing to Mulack's words. If they were to both perish, it was better to agree with Mulack. But Jaehwan's thought didn't last long.

"No."

And the voices exploded within him.

[I KNEW IT!]

[God-dammit! Again?!]

[I told you. See?]

[I thought it would be different this time...]

[10 billion years! You still don't know what kind of 'clothes' the original is?]

And they even...

[Hey, if you lost the bet, change places with me! YOU take control of this 'hard' place!]

[Ugh, dammit...]

[HAHAHA! Good for you! You really look hard!]

They seemed to have made bets. Were they all 'Jaehwan'? Jaehwan shook his head. He saw Mulack's lips moving in the distance.

[...and why is that?]

"Because I don't like it."

[You haven't become a Big Brother yet. You don't even know what Big Brother does. You can refuse it after you try it at least...]

"No."

[Just saying no doesn't make sense.]

Mulack's eyes began to be filled with rage.

[Let me ask you again. Why?]

Jaehwan did not answer. He couldn't. He had many reasons, and it was too complicated to explain. And Jaehwan now had the answer to all those reasons.

[Just because you want to destroy the System? Is that it? Are you still holding on to such childish and violent thoughts?]

"..."

[Listen to me. If you Transcended, it would've been different. You don't understand anything. You don't know what Big Brother is, what Panopticon is, and the purpose of the System!]

"But I know one thing. If I Transcend, I will be like you."

He heard Transcended ones saying, "Whoa, he owned it!" within his head. Mulack became silent for a while. Maybe it had touched a part of his 'being'

deep inside his spirit.

[...You don't know anything about Transcendence. If you don't know anything, you shouldn't speak like that.]

It was a voice full of deep rage. Jaehwan felt his voice was real this time. He 'truly' was thinking in that way.

[It's the same for the System. This world that was created to efficiently 'Cultivate Big Brothers'. They are created after countless former Big Brothers were created and changed it to achieve greatness. It is more stable than any other world and has no chance of being destroyed. All beings are well adapted to this System and they live happily. Destroy the System? What you are trying to do is trample on all their achievements!]

Jaehwan thought for a bit and answered, "Maybe."

['Maybe'? You don't know a thing! Do you know what happens if the System is destroyed?!]

And in the next moment, voices spread across Jaehwan's head at once.

[Fall.]

[Fall.]

[Fall.]

[Fall.]

Jaehwan said, 'Shut up,' in his mind. Mulack also spoke.

[The world will fall!]

It was a voice that sounded like it came from a drama.

[And you still will destroy the System?]

"Yeah."

[Hah... and why are you still thinking of that!]

"It's because I am human."

Human. The Transcended ones began to speak to themselves noisily again. Good, Crazy, Stupid, He's mad, etc, etc...

[Human... is it?]

Mulack's expression turned complicated. It seemed like he was scoffing at Jaehwan, or he also seemed to pity him.

[Human... do you really consider yourself human still?]

His narrowed eyes pierced into Jaehwan's mind.

[Even if you didn't go through Transcendence, you lived over million years alone. How can a man do such a thing? There's no human who could've withstood that time while still being 'human'.]

"..."

[You are already a 'System' yourself. You created your mind to be one of the 'Systems' to withstand all that time. There is a power that is equivalent to a universe within you. Why are you trying to act as if you are still a human? What is a human anyway?]

That question pierced Jaehwan's heart. He too had been asking himself the same question thousands of times. Was he really still human? And what was a human anyway?

Jaehwan thought about this question in the darkness many times. Many hours. He first tried to answer it with scientific knowledge he had.

Human. A highly intelligent animal who uses language and tools. Part of homo sapiens that walk on two legs and...

However, that wasn't a good answer. So Jaehwan changed his perspective.

Many philosophies came through him. The Fall of time gave him enough time to think about all the possible ways of thinking that existed within all of mankind. Jaehwan even went over the philosophy and replaced it with his language and thoughts to answer it.

Yet he couldn't find the answer. And with the empty answer, the answer came suddenly.

"I don't know what humans are."

It was the truth.

"But I am thinking of what humans are."

At the end of those words, Jaehwan realized he was 'human'.

"That is why I am human."

Humans are the ones who question what human is. That was the answer that Jaehwan had gotten to after living 10 billion years with his clothes. Mulack burst into laughter.

[Hahahaha! ...Was that the answer you got after 10 billion years? In your words, even the 'Transcended' can become humans! It's foolish!]

But it was only Mulack who laughed. All other Jaehwan's clothes only spoke ill of Jaehwan's answer, let alone laugh at it.

[Thank you.]

A short answer came back after a short and heavy silence. Jaehwan felt emotion from his 'clothes'. Mulack then gritted his teeth after realizing what happened.

[I see. That's why you made such an answer. You...]

And a fight erupted again.

Mulack now was doing all he could to unleash everything in his power. The Transcended ones tried their best to fight back, but the attack was too powerful now. One of the Transcended ones spoke.

[Hey original, there's one way we can possibly win. It might kill us all but...]

[Wait, you can't-]

[Let's just tell him! He considers us as human.]

[Don't be fooled by...]

People kept on talking, but the voice continued.

[There is one who doesn't have control over your body yet. We didn't want to tell you until the end... but this is our way of thanking you.]

Jaehwan tried to ask who it was, but before he can ask, a voice came. It sounded like that of a young boy.

-If you want, I can help you.

Unlike the other Transcended ones, that voice seemed like it was shaking up the entire brain.

[D-dammit! He's here!]

[WAAAAAGH!]

[66666!]

Jaehwan felt the Transcended ones shaking frantically. Were there ranks between them? Why were they so afraid? And at that point, Jaehwan felt memories rushing in.

It was a memory that lasted over 3 billion years.

'I felt there were lots of parts missing throughout the 10 billion years... it was him.'

Jaehwan felt becoming dizzy due to the length of the memory coming in.

66666.

That was the name of the Jaehwan that lived for 3 billion years. He lived for 3 billion years alone. How was that possible? Just like the other Jaehwans, 66666 also trained in only one thing for all of the 3 billion years. It was easy to see what [Setting] he trained. In fact, Jaehwan thought it strange that there was no one who trained that [Setting] after all.

'He probably can...'

Jaehwan was certain that if he helped, they might win. No. They will actually...

-Let me ask you. You want help?

'I do. Can you help me?'

-There is a price.'

It wasn't expected. Jaehwan then felt an eerie feeling as he experienced 3 billion years worth of loneliness. What was he like if he endured 3 billion years by himself? What would be the price he would have to pay?

'What is it?'

-I want your spirit.

Spirit? Jaehwan became confused. Was it some kind of a devilish pact from a book?

'What do you mean?'

66666 then answered,

-I want to be you.

Chapter 227: Big Brother (21)

"A world where ones who face the Fall gather. Yes. That was what [Chaos] was just until a few years ago."

An instructor shouted out to the hundreds of trainees. They were eager to start on their training and the instructor felt that the world had really changed.

[Chaos] was a world full of losers, a world filled with people oppressed by the [Great Lands], at least until a few years ago.

"It's different now."

He repeated this so many times, but the instructor was still proud of saying this. He looked at every trainee in the eyes.

"It is because we have you all who follow his will."

Some trainees seemed to become touched. It was natural as they now were given a new chance. They were at the verge of a different world. The instructor spoke again.

"Even if the world falls tomorrow, I will stab. That's what Jaehwan said when he left [Chaos]."

A few trainees mumbled to each other.

"Did Sole-King really say that?"

"I dunno. Who cares?"

"That instructor is known for making things up."

"Ugh, I'm sick and tired of it."

Most of the trainees were touched again. It wasn't strange as [Chaos] was full of people who were astonished by the name, 'Jaehwan'.

"So, we will stab today again! Gentlemen! In what way did I say to stab?"

"World-destroying way!"

"Exactly!"

Then the training began. It was the start of training now. With the shout of hundreds of trainees, they began to stab. The power of stabs also became different as the main instructor shouted out different stabs.

Slight Stab.

Normal Stab.

Strong Stab.

Those were the basic 'Jaehwan's Three Stabs' that everyone trained. It was basic, but there weren't that many Awakeners who could master the moves.

The experienced instructor showed his strong stab in the air. With an explosion, a faint streak was left in the sky, ripping through the clouds. It was too weak to be a 'strong stab' but it had enough power to astonish these trainees.

"You see? This is how you do it."

Instructor shrugged and added, "For the record, Jaehwan was said to destroy the entire sky through a normal stab."

People began to mumble. Normal stab to destroy the sky? Is it the work of a human? Training started again. But there were some who wanted to train further because of their own greed.

"Hey, you! Don't do that! I told you to practice slight stab, not the world stab!"

World Stab was the ultimate stab that enabled one to rip the sky open temporarily. Trainees became curious about who was trying to practice such a move and...

"Ugh, it's him again."

They all shook their heads. A peculiar thing happened then. Jaehwan appeared through the giant screen in the sky. That trainee spoke as he was stabbing toward the sky.

-I-I did it! The world was torn apart!

Instructor slapped trainee and shouted, "I told you to practice slight stab!"

"But I did it! Look! I stabbed the world again!"

"Shut up! You said that before and..."

However, the trainees started screaming.

"W-what is that?!"

And with the sound of something being destroyed, everyone looked up to the sky. Maybe the sky would turn like that if it was hit with thousands of world stabs. There was an ominous crack in the entire sky. Then, something fell down.

"T-that's!"

Beyond the sky, there was something that resembled a branch. The branch shook and small particles began to drop. And everyone in [Chaos] realized what it was a bit later.

It was golden rain.

Some were seeing this for the first time, and some had experienced this 900 years ago. Whichever the case, they all thought of the same thing.

'It's beautiful.'

It was the treasure they longed for their entire life. [Fruits] were falling down like rain.

Everyone looked at it with a dumbfounded expression and some were jumping up and down. But there was one thing that all of them did not realize.

The crack in the sky was growing larger.

At the same time, people in Carpediem were looking up at the same sight. As they looked up into the sky that was about to fall, Euren and Cayman both realized Jaehwan had finally achieved what he set out to do.

'Master...'

That's why they became fearful. If that stubborn man succeeded, there was only one outcome waiting for them in this world. They prayed that Jaehwan's purpose wasn't what they thought it would be.

They prayed and prayed.

Jaehwan saw Big Brothers' weapons all turn into dust instantly. Mulack was screaming and the dark energy that came out from the sword swept through the entire place.

It was like if giant and dark night had come down upon the world.

The entire region of the Tree of Imagery turned into darkness and when the darkness was lifted, everything was over. It was the power of [Fall] that had been trained for 3 billion years.

[Ugh... uh... g...]

He saw Mulack's spirit being dismantled. There were no more weapons from Big Brother. It was the same for Panopticon. The tanks all had dead silver specks of dust of Master Craftsmen and all of the screens were either destroyed or not working.

[You... you don't know. You don't know what you just did. What the world will become...]

Mulack was crying. What was weird wasn't the fact that he was crying.

"That is strange."

[What is strange?]

"You look happy."

[...Does it?]

And Jaehwan felt gravity changing. The gravity control of Panopticon had been damaged.

'Are we falling down?'

Mulack crawled to the corner of Panopticon. He looked so weak as the strongest one in the world.

[...Isn't it beautiful? You can only see this from here.]

Jaehwan walked toward Mulack. Through the shattered Panopticon, there was the entire region of Tree of Imagery. It wasn't a size that one could see with the eye, so it was better to say that he 'felt' it.

'I see. So the tree that I climbed had this shape.'

Jaehwan looked down like a man who had just witnessed the planet he lived in for the first time. There was a giant tree that stretched through the entire universe. And that tree was now being destroyed.

From the roots to the branches, everything that formed the Tree of Imagery perished.

[I've seen this tree for a long, long time. I've seen it for too long, and I tried too long to climb it.]

"Mulack."

Jaehwan tried to say something but held back. He felt like Mulack was going to say what he wanted to know.

[And at the final moment, I finally got here. I thought I would find the answer I was looking for. I thought I would know everything once I got here.]

Jaehwan then thought the 'Transcended' ones had not really Transcended. If they did, then Mulack wouldn't have this feeling right now.

Maybe at least, they shared one feeling within him.

3751, who stabbed for 100 million years had 'fear' and 8741 who slashed for 320 million years had sullen jokes. And for 66666, who trained the [Fall] for 3 billion years had the desire to become 'real'.

And for Mulack, it was...

[I wanted to create a better world. That was all. You must know this too.]

Chapter 228: Big Brother (22)

Jaehwan did not answer. Instead, he thought of Myad and the other Ancient Three Gods. All beings head for the same goal, but they walk different paths. This was also the same. Just like they had different reasons for bringing reaching Transcendence, they all had different feelings at the same destination.

But when he lost everything at the end of the journey, Mulack looked like he was free.

Was it because he gave up? Or was he really free? Jaehwan wasn't sure what Mulack found at the end of his road.

"Mulack. Let me ask you one thing."

At the end of the road, Jaehwan found a question he had forgotten, the question that no one could answer until now. It was a question only Mulack could answer.

"What is the [Nightmare of the Beginning]?"

It was the word that Mulack left on his tower.

Even when he was answered all of his questions, Jaehwan couldn't find out what the Nightmare of the Beginning was. He thought it was meant for [Panopticon] and still thought it was so in some sense. But he wasn't sure yet. It felt like it wasn't enough. Panopticon controlled the world, but it had no way to create it. Then, what was there in the beginning?

[Haha... ha... Nightmare of the Beginning?]

Jaehwan saw madness flashing through Mulack's eyes. The Nightmare who was on the verge of death was on fire for the last time.

[That is the home of all 'Towers'. It's a terrible place, worse than any nightmare. It's the source of all Towers of Nightmares.]

'Is it a place?'

Mulack continued,

[That is not as easy as this world.]

"Not easy?"

[Yes. That doesn't have specific 'eye' like this place, and you don't know who leads the world. The System cannot be shown. Everything is unfair and illogical, but nobody senses it. Besides, there's no Jaehwan there.]

Jaehwan wasn't sure what he was talking about. The maniacal voice even sounded eerie. Mulack raised his voice as blood began to seep out from his mouth.

[Soon... soon, you too will know. I- I wanted to stop that Nightmare from coming down. Keep this flawed System, continue Cultivation, and increase accentuated unique world... to be drunk in those dreams so I can stop the coming fa-....]

Mulack's spirit then began to dissipate. Mulack's eyes turned into disbelief and shock. Jaehwan was also shocked. Mulack was almost on the verge of perishing, but it wasn't consuming him.

But why...?

"He talks too much."

Jaehwan felt his lips moving on its own. Someone else was speaking with his. Jaehwan then looked down at the Void Sword penetrating Mulack's heart. He had killed Mulack. Mulack tried to move his mouth, but he turned into dust.

"...What are you doing?!"

Jaehwan shouted angrily. He hadn't gotten a chance to listen to the important part yet, which made him angrier. Only Mulack could answer his question. Jaehwan then spoke again on his own.

"You promised. I am becoming you now."

So it was him. The time of keeping the promise was coming.

"You have to keep your promise. I waited long enough. I waited 3 billion years."

66666. The clothes that trained the [Fall] for 3 billion years. Jaehwan promised him that if he helped, he would fulfill his request.

"Okay. Take it."

Jaehwan closed his eyes. He felt his conscious being pushed back. He then realized he was no longer 'Jaehwan' anymore. Maybe he was 66667. But he was still Jaehwan and lived as Jaehwan. He felt that was enough. That's when 66666 spoke.

"Is this enough? Are you giving up already?"

Giving up?

"You haven't fulfilled your purpose yet."

Jaehwan wondered if this Jaehwan was making of him, but he answered, 'What are you talking about? It's you who made me give up. You took my spirit and...'

"What are you talking about? I need you. You're the only one who knows the world that the Little Prince traveled in. That lady told me."

Jaehwan was confused. Little Prince? And who was this lady?

"...Was it too difficult? Well, adult languages are difficult. Let me put it this way. You have not gotten to the Nightmare of the Beginning yet. Right?"

Jaehwan felt tense. He shouted frantically, 'Do you know what the Nightmare of the Beginning is-?'

"I need you to get there. Let's say it's a travel partner. Or shall I say, I need a 'fox'?"

'What do you mean?'

"I'm taming you. Just like you tamed me once, I'm taming you now."

'Stop this nonsense.'

Jaehwan shouted in an angry voice.

'I'm just clothes now.'

"No, you are not. You call me Jaehwan and I call you Jaehwan. You are still Jaehwan."

And Jaehwan felt his vision coming back again. His senses were coming back now just like when he had control over his body.

"I told you I wanted to be you, but I didn't ask you to become my 'clothes'. I'm just telling you to have me as part of you. I will never take the spirit away from you. I'm still you, remember?"

He continued, "A man without clothes is not a man. A man is just a collection of clothes."

Jaehwan then looked around. Why? Jaehwan then finally was able to see Transcended ones through his own eyes. He able to see them clearly for the first time. He looked at all 15 of them in their eyes.

[Yes. It's us.]

He felt his heart ache. It was them. These were the ones who fought with him throughout all those times.

[Goodbye Jaehwan.]

[That boy fulfilled his wishes, so this is where we part ways.]

Jaehwan wanted to ask what was that supposed to mean.

[The place you'll be going is like that. We can't go to that world. Only you and that boy can go.]

They answered as if they knew what Jaehwan wanted to say. It was obvious as they were 'Jaehwan' too.

[Don't look at us like that. We've lived too long.]

[Long enough that we cannot stay human anymore.]

Jaehwan tried to say something but he couldn't. He held back his feelings and listened to his clothes.

[I envy you.]

[Beings are sometimes very precious things.]

[Don't lose your heart.]

[Even if you don't have power.]

[Even if you don't have knowledge.]

[Even if you don't have hope.]

[Even if you feel despair.]

[Don't lose your heart.]

Jaehwan had no way to press his feelings. Even if he couldn't understand everything, he heard what they were trying to say.

That he did well.

Jaehwan felt the space being dismantled. The power of [Fall] now was coming up to the top of the Tree of Imagery. It also applied to Jaehwan himself. 10 billion memories were fading away.

Wait, there's more. I have more questions. Where am I going now? What do you guys know? You...

The Nightmare of the Beginning is...

But the time came like death. The time that the clothes gave him was taking away those clothes now.

Jaehwan's body became small, as if he was going back from adulthood to a child. Soon, Jaehwan was a ten-year-old boy, as if that was his original self. Jaehwan heard his voice coming out of his mouth.

"Isn't it weird? The end of the [Branch] that holds all the secrets to this world is really similar to the [Roots] of those remote regions... as if its hard to tell which is the branch and which is the root."

Jaehwan saw Tree of Imagery and its barren branches. A lone tree that stood in its bareness.

It was lonely. It really was a lonely tree.

In that loneliness, Jaehwan closed his eyes. There was no world anymore. His job was done. But why did it feel like it wasn't the end?

His world then reached its fall.

Chapter 229: World after the fall

(1)

[I wanted to see the impossible story unfold. I wanted to see that impossible story become a reality. Maybe this is why I consider this novel to be within the modern fantasy genre.]

-Author's thought on [The World After the Fall]

Episode – World after the fall

The Fall always comes from everywhere.

Only a few people witness the Fall and warn people around them to ask for help. But in most cases, there is no help because to most people, such a Fall is not a Fall at all.

To hell with a Fall.

To the people of the world, just any kind of a Fall is not a Fall. But people do not know. Most 'falls' that people face are results of their death that comes from 'any Fall'. And the ten-year-old Jaehwan was also a victim of such a Fall.

"Stop it! I will call the police if you don't stop!"

"I'm taking him! What makes you have the right?! Do you even have a job?
Or-"

"Jaehwan is MY kid!"

Jaehwan felt a headache as he heard the shouts.

'...Where am I?'

He brought his ten-year-old self up. His cheek that had slumped over a small desk was pulled out from the surface. There were dirty, used notebooks with scribbles and formulas.

As Jaehwan looked closely, it was more of a drawing than a scribble. It was hard to tell at first but after looking at it for a while, it became clear. It was a stick man figure holding something that looked like a knife, and it was ripping apart Jaehwan's homework and formulas with its sword.

It was then that many memories shot past his head. It was way too long in the past that it shook his ten-year-old head and made him fall into a seizure-like state.

'What?'

'Why am I here? Where is Big Brother?'

'Mulack?'

'Where is this place?'

...

I see. So this place is... this is the Nightmare of the Beginning.

...

Nightmare of the Beginning? What was that?

He became confused from all kinds of memory. His ten-year-old lungs moved quickly as he felt dizzy. It felt like as if he saw something floating around, and he came to realize that there were various objects being thrown. And with the sound of some clash, he heard a woman's sharp scream. Jaehwan looked down at the broken dish. As he saw the shattered sharp piece of the dish, one word came to his mind.

Stab.

Jaehwan held the piece without realizing. It made a small cut on his small ten-year-old palm. It hurt him, but it was not painful.

"AAAAAH! Let go of me! LET GO!"

He heard the woman's screaming again. Jaehwan turned to the scream and saw a woman he did not know. ...a woman?

"Mom."

Jaehwan spoke the word without knowing, and became shocked that he had said such a word.

'Mom? Did I have a mom? I... I was alone for 10 billion years. How can I even have a...'

And with the painful headache, Jaehwan walked over to the woman with the shard of a dish in his hand. Jaehwan then saw a man threatening the woman by raising up a small chair against her. Jaehwan couldn't see the man's face. He walked closer and was able to see the man's face more clearly.

'Ah-ah.'

Young Jaehwan stopped on the spot as he felt some kind of jolt through his body.

'That's...'

He felt another sharp pain in his head as he clenched the shattered piece.

The man did not have eyes, a nose, or a mouth.

As if it was covered by something, the thing that covered the face was small numbers that was really small. Jaehwan then remembered scribbles and formulas written in the notebook. That face had the formulas. That face was...

The System.

As the word popped up in his mind, Jaehwan shouted as he charged. He saw the pale, fear-stricken woman's face and the man backing away in shock. He then moved his right hand in powerful motion and heard someone's screaming. He smiled faintly.

'I did it. I DID IT! I killed [Big Brother]!!'

And in next moment, Jaehwan's body became rigid.

'Big Brother? What is that anyway?'

The scream was then mixed up with another person's scream. It felt like the world had flipped and in the next moment, Jaehwan felt someone hugging him from his back. It was his mother. He was in his mother's embrace after all these years. Jaehwan's body swung helplessly like a doll within his mother's embrace.

He saw a man down on the ground, bleeding from his arm.

The man was screaming. The man was... Jaehwan saw the man's wounds. There was blood flowing out from the wound.

Jaehwan then looked down onto his hand where he had been holding on to the shattered dish piece. His ten-year-old hand was bloody. Why? The question gripped him.

'Why? Why is it not a silver color?'

"Jaehwan... Jaehwan...!"

The woman kept on calling her son's name without knowing what to do. Jaehwan looked up.

"Mom..."

And as she met her son's eyes, she became pale.

"Ah... ah-ah..."

At that moment, Jaehwan was not her son. To her eyes, Jaehwan looked like a monster, a demon that was not from this world. That demon was smiling weirdly.

"Mom. The blood is red."

"It's a delusional disorder."

The doctor with a white lab coat and silver eyeglasses spoke.

"It can happen with a kid at this age with a combination of Schizophrenia, but I think it is a bit severe in Jaehwan's case. It might even lead to a developmental disorder."

It was a bit lacking as a description, but it sounded convincing enough to a woman who did not have any knowledge regarding psychology. It was also reassuring to see many awards and plaques showing various achievements and researches made by the professional doctor.

Whatever he said, it must mean that the kid was in serious condition.

That was the only thing she can make out of in his description. She wished her choice of words met the professionalism of the doctor and asked, "I-is Jaehwan in that serious condition?"

"We can say that. Haven't you seen it with your own eyes? The incident itself is..."

The doctor stopped talking but she understood what he did not say. Sometimes, it was more effective to not say things out loud.

Jaehwan felt faint shaking in his mother's hand that touched his shoulder. If Jaehwan was a bit more of his self, it was enough to make him get angry. It was enough to argue with the doctor for treating the patient in such a demeaning way. But Jaehwan was in no state to do such a thing. Besides, he was only a ten-year-old kid.

Chapter 230: World after the fall

(2)

'10 year old?'

Jaehwan frowned as he brought his finger up to his head. 10 year-old? Why was he a 10 year-old? How was his mother here? Why was HE here?

Why... am I... who am I?

"...What did I do wrong to him?"

"I never said you have done anything wrong."

"My kid is fine. He's good at school, he has many friends... and even his teachers..."

"Some delusional disorders are hard to notice as the symptoms are the same as regular activities."

"NO! He is fine! He was just... he was just triggered! It's all his fault... because of him... my kid... he just..."

"I'll show you, Ma'am."

The doctor then brought Jaehwan to the small table at the corner of the room and pulled the curtains. It was very thin and simple that it had no effect on cutting the sounds out. The sound of a woman's tense breathing came through. The doctor spoke to Jaehwan.

"Jaehwan. Can you answer a few questions for me?"

Jaehwan nodded.

"How old are you?"

"...I forgot."

"Forgot? And why is that?"

"I've lived too long for that."

"Too long? How long is that?"

"10 billion years."

A woman gasping could be heard beyond the curtain. The doctor glanced toward the curtain and continued with his questions.

"So what have you been doing until now Jaehwan?"

"I was fighting with Big Brother."

"Is Big Brother your 'father'?"

Jaehwan did not answer. The doctor wrote something on his paper and continued to ask.

"So why did you fight with Big Brother?"

"To destroy the System."

"System? And what is that? Can you explain it to me?"

Jaehwan felt a heavy headache as he tried to remember what System was, but it didn't work. The doctor then nodded knowingly and gave a pen and piece of paper to Jaehwan.

"Jaehwan, can you draw it on here?"

Jaehwan began drawing something on the paper. It didn't take him long to finish his picture. The doctor received the paper back from Jaehwan.

It was a giant tree. A giant tree with dried roots and branches. The doctor looked at it intriguingly.

"Is this tree the 'System'?"

Jaehwan did not answer as he became dizzy. He could hardly breathe, but the doctor kept on asking his questions.

"...So, there's a thing called a 'tower' at the root of this tree and it kidnaps people from Earth to send them up the tree?"

"Yes."

"And that is [Cultivation]?"

"Right."

"And you survived the [Cultivation] and moved up to the top of the tower?"

The questions kept coming and Jaehwan kept answering. Adapters and Awakeners. [Chaos] and [Depth]. Gods and Followers. Jaehwan wasn't sure why he knew all that, but he focused on answering the doctor's questions.

"I see. So, the 'unique world' is some form of imaginary space that is created by one's dream. Is that right?"

"Similar."

"And when you get many to believe in it, then it becomes a 'reality'?"

Jaehwan nodded. He then saw a figure dwindling beyond the curtain. Every time he answered a question, he felt his mother's breathing growing shallower.

It was a strange feeling. Each time Jaehwan answered to make his world more detailed, the history he had lived on was being trampled upon, but

Jaehwan wasn't sure what it was.

As doctor kept on asking, Jaehwan saw him changing eerily. It wasn't his expression, but his face was covered by complicated words and numbers. It was those that Jaehwan saw from the man that he stabbed.

Voices kept on speaking to him.

Stab. Stab him and kill him.

Jaehwan shook his head as he bit on his lips.

'No- I cannot do that. Mom will become sad.'

Jaehwan crouched to hide from the voices arguing over him. The questioning stopped. Blood dripped from his lips and the doctor was shocked, dragging Jaehwan up.

"Oh, no! Nurse!"

The doctor quickly picked up Jaehwan and laid him down on a bed. He then called a nurse to look over Jaehwan's wound. The doctor then called Jaehwan's mother to a separate room. She was pale as ever and was barely breathing.

Doctor sighed. He saw the woman's world tearing apart from what she just witnessed.

"J-Jaehwan loves reading... he reads all kinds of novels and comics. That probably..."

"Ma'am."

"He's just too smart! He can't..."

"Ma'am."

She burst into wails. The doctor waited until she calmed down a bit.

"I will have to ask you to excuse me for asking such questions."

"...Yes."

"Was Jaehwan ever harmed by his father in any way?"

The woman gasped for a second and answered, "N-no."

"Is that true? You have to be honest with me, ma'am."

"...NO! I'm telling the truth. He never laid hands on his son!"

The mother's denial even felt desperate.

"But I can see traces of violence that his father inflicted on Jaehwan. All of his symbols depict his father."

The doctor spoke as he showed drawings and the records that he obtained from Jaehwan. There was a tree, a tower, and a stick man stabbing toward the sky.

"Tree and the tower. All the images point to 'heightening.' And the 'stab'... don't you think they all have a similar image?"

"...I am not sure."

"In psychology, these are all symbols of a male penis."

"P-penis?"

"Yes. I am shocked to see such a perfect example of a case that depicts it all with one image."

The doctor scratched his head as he continued to explain. The woman quietly listened to the doctor. He described with countless words and psychological theories. The woman couldn't understand even half of what the doctor said but barely managed to understand that the situation was very serious.

"Do you think he had harmed Jaehwan when I was not aware?"

"We cannot say for sure, but we are seeing a trace of such violence from Jaehwan and it will directly impact his mental growth."

"What should we do..."

The doctor then tapped on his desk and spoke reassuringly to the desperate woman.

"But don't worry too much. Not everything about Jaehwan's current diagnosis is bad."

The woman was surprised.

"What do you mean?"

"Jaehwan's symbolic images are more vivid and specific than any other patient or research records that I have ever seen and they are interconnected with each other. It's not just matter of his imagination... it's even to the point of literary..."

The doctor then tried to find the words to describe and continued.

"It feels like such a world really did exist when I hear his stories. He's just a 10-year-old kid and..."

The woman frowned angrily.

"Are you mocking me?"

"No, it's not that. Jaehwan is in serious condition, but if he can overcome this, his disorder might even help him in an artistic way."

"Artistic way?"

"Some think that delusional disorder and the savant syndrome are closely related."

"...Savant... what? What is that?"

The doctor shook his head. He understood that the woman did not understand any of the professional terms that he just used.

"Ah, it's a disorder that is common with geniuses. I'm just letting you know so you can rest assured."

The doctor then folded his patient file in a folder and concluded the meeting. "We'll have to have Jaehwan stay away from his father. I suggest you visit us for further treatment. Jaehwan needs it for his future."

Chapter 231: World after the fall

(3)

It had been 2 weeks since Jaehwan returned to his 10-year-old body. Jaehwan was now able to realize where he had come back to and in what era.

This was the Earth in 2008, 10 years before the Tower of Nightmare appeared.

This was strange. He came to a place where the [Nightmare of Beginning] was supposed to be, but why was he back on Earth?

'Did go back in time? That is impossible.'

Even with the power of the 'Transcended' ones that could control time and space, even with the power of Big Brother, it was impossible to rewind time. Beastlain once said to him that there was no way for a being to return to the past.

'Is it an illusion then?'

Jaehwan then remembered the [Stone of Nightmare] at the Tower of Nightmares. Maybe all of this was an illusion. As far as Jaehwan knew, there was no 'dream' that could trap him. Even if it was the [Nightmare of the Beginning], there was no way to fool him.

'What is this place?'

It went nowhere however long he had thought about it. The only thing Jaehwan could do was think. Everything he could've done had no power here anymore.

[Suspicion]

[Understand]

[Forget]

[Theory]

[Proof]

[Edit]

All of his powers had no use in this place. Not only that, he did not have his unique world, and he had lost his Settings such as [Fall] or [Naked]. Not to mention, he did not have any of his equipment either.

The only thing left in him were uncertain memories, answers without proof, and his weak 10-year-old body.

"Haha, Jaehwan. It's only natural. This is 'reality'."

The doctor seemed to be very happy that Jaehwan was beginning to think.

"You might not know because you are young, but there's a clash between your imagination and your conscious within you. It's very normal for you to have such thoughts. I even want to congratulate you."

The memories calmed down during the past two weeks and the shattered memories went back to their respective places. However, Jaehwan still couldn't find his real self. Rather, it was the opposite. As he became his self more, he was considered 'not his self.' Jaehwan couldn't accept the doctor's explanation.

A delusion? All those memories were just an imagination? All of those memories and all of those times were just a creation of his imagination?

Jaehwan sometimes had a seizure, he sometimes tried to fight with the doctor, and he became violent. But the doctor did not panic and easily pressed Jaehwan down and whispered to him.

"Jaehwan. Your 'world' does not exist."

Jaehwan heard the doctor's hand pressing him down against a cold linoleum surface.

"Think about your mother. You must return to reality."

Another two weeks passed by and the doctor changed his methods as Jaehwan didn't seem to be getting any better. The doctor raised his both arms and declared, "Good, Jaehwan. I understand how unfair it feels to you. Let's change the perspective."

The doctor walked around Jaehwan's chair and brought up a whiteboard at the back of the room and began drawing something on it. It was the tree that Jaehwan had drawn the first time.

Tree of Imagery.

That was the name of that tree. The doctor smiled satisfyingly as he watched Jaehwan shudder.

"Is this how it's supposed to be?"

"Similar."

"Jaehwan, you must use full sentences. That's how you speak."

"Doesn't matter."

"It does matter in our world. I have told you multiple times."

"I..."

Jaehwan tried to fight back, but stopped. It was apparent that the doctor was going to argue with all sorts of psychological, and ethical reasoning to teach Jaehwan.

"It is a beautiful tree, but it is lonely."

"..."

"Tree of Imagery... I think your name is wonderful. It is hard to believe that a 10-year-old boy can think of such a thing."

"...I didn't name it. And besides, I'm not 10 years old."

"Jaehwan..."

The doctor smiled. It was a warm and soft smile. But as Jaehwan looked at the smile, he felt like he was being dropped onto the cold floor.

"Jaehwan, do you know the worth of your own world?"

"...Worth?"

"Your world is very valuable. If the day comes where you can see your world in unbiased perspective, people will pay you everything to peek into your world."

The doctor peered at Jaehwan's eyes and continued, "But if you have yourself trapped within your world and do not look around, your world will just put you and your life into darkness."

Jaehwan opened his mouth to object, but the doctor did not let him start.

"Jaehwan. You have to get out of yourself to use your world to its true value. You have to accept that the world you created is not 'real'."

However, perhaps the doctor should not have said that word. Jaehwan's eyes seemed to blaze with cold fire within them.

"It's not fake."

Jaehwan looked straight back into the doctor's eyes and continued, "I was definitely there."

The voice, the expression, and the eyes. Everything showed such angry determination that the doctor was soon at a for words.

'Haha... it is...'

How could a 10-year-old speak like that? The doctor gasped. Even the ones from a large criminal group would easily be overwhelmed by the doctor's authority within the hospital. But this kid...

'He really is something.'

Of course, if it wasn't, he would not have added an extra hour to the appointment to meet with this kid. He came back to his senses as he saw Jaehwan's lips moving again. He must have lost the short words, but if his guess was right, Jaehwan probably said 'You don't know anything.' The doctor smiled.

"I don't know, huh? What do I not know?"

"10 years from now, this world will fall. I cannot explain my words in science or logic. But I know. In 10 years, it will..."

"Oh, that is something new. You sound like you are from the future. Is that right?"

"That's..."

Doctor asked intriguingly. It seemed as if he had 'caught' Jaehwan in a trap.

"So, everything you have said until now is a story that will happen in the future?"

Jaehwan became silent. He couldn't answer. He wasn't sure if this was really in the 'past' or another dream that the Nightmare of the Beginning created.

"Yes. It will happen in the future."

Jaehwan nodded anyway. He thought he needed to accept it to go further. However, the doctor smiled decisively.

"Jaehwan, can I ask a few questions then?"

And with that smile, Jaehwan felt like he had made a wrong choice. But there was no going back.

"Go on."

"Can you explain the future that you came across?"

"I explained enough. The tower appeared in 2018 and..."

"Oh, not about that. I want to know what you did until 2018."

Jaehwan became dumbfounded. Things that he did until 2018? What did he do? Most of the memories were faint and had been destroyed. Maybe it was because his memories were divided and the Transcended ones left him. As he became silent, the doctor spoke again.

"Did you meet me in your future?"

"That's..."

Chapter 232: World after the fall

(4)

The doctor smiled again as Jaehwan became silent.

"Hmmm. So, you never met with me in the future?"

"...There's a reason for that. I was different from now and..."

Jaehwan became confused and the doctor raised his hand to stop Jaehwan.

"Okay. Let me ask you another question. Do you remember anything about your high school or college perhaps?"

Jaehwan became silent again. After a long time, he admitted, "...I don't remember."

Jaehwan bit his lips. He surely attended all of high school and he even went college. He also went to the military. That's when the Tower of Nightmares appeared. He knew that everything then was 'reality'.

But Jaehwan couldn't remember those times. Maybe it had been too long, or maybe it was because his memories had been destroyed when the Transcended ones left him.

"Haha. It's not like you. You don't remember, huh...?"

"I don't. But I really was there..."

Jaehwan then closed his mouth. His words were true, but there was no proof to back up his claims. Not remembering it proved that Jaehwan was just lying. The doctor was still smiling.

There was no more game. Jaehwan will not protect his world. He will not prove anything.

Why? The 10-year-old Jaehwan became frustrated. He felt like he was going to cry. He had proof of all those times, but why did he need to prove everything again? And how could he prove it anyway?

That's when a certain memory came to him. It was when he arrived at a certain 'fortress' when he just got to [Chaos]. That fortress also forced Jaehwan to prove himself.

-Prove yourself. Prove who you are.

What did Jaehwan answer then? Jaehwan looked up to the doctor. He felt like his sight was going blurry. The white lab coat looked like the wall of a strong fortress and the silver eyeglasses looked like spires. Was it because of that? Jaehwan spoke without realizing.

"I will not prove myself."

It was the voice of a 10-year-old boy, but not from a 10-year-old boy. It was a voice that one world answered to another world. The doctor became speechless by the voice. He then realized he was overwhelmed yet again and gasped, "Ugh..."

He seemed to be very frustrated.

'This kid really is something. But there is no way to control him. Then what can we do?'

The doctor sighed after a long time passed.

"Okay. Maybe the world you say does exist."

Jaehwan's eyes shook. What did he just say?

"I accept the possibility."

Was that something a doctor from a mental institute could say? A cold theory-like thing shot past Jaehwan's head then. Everything he had faced until now had some kind of a gate. Maybe this doctor was some form of a gate placed by the Nightmare of Beginning. Even as Jaehwan was lost in his thoughts, the doctor continued speaking.

"But no matter the circumstances, you must know this."

"About what?"

"If you try to protect your world, the ones who love you will be sad."

Sad? Because of his world? Why? And in the next moment, Jaehwan felt goosebumps on his body.

Did he just ask himself 'Why?' He was in no place to ask such a question. He had seen it throughout all his life. In his faint memories, faces came about. They were just faces with no names.

An old man who loved to slash and tried to quarrel with Jaehwan.

A good-looking blonde young man who always carried a law book.

A woman who betrayed her own kind to trust Jaehwan.

A young boy who trusted Jaehwan more than anyone in the world.

Jaehwan reminisced about them and was grasped with a question. Were they happy then? They trusted Jaehwan's unique world and stayed by his side all the time, but Jaehwan never thought about their happiness even once.

They must have been afraid at the Fall. Afraid about the System being destroyed. How could Jaehwan be certain that what he wanted was what everyone else wanted?

Jaehwan then remembered his mother's face who should be standing beyond the door of this room. He felt confused.

"Jaehwan. You said that the tower will appear in 10 years."

Was it because he was too deep in thought? It took some time for Jaehwan to understand what the Doctor said.

"Why don't we do this? You keep coming to my clinic for those 10 years."

Jaehwan answered in annoyance.

"And why do I need to do that?"

"If the 'Tower of Night' appears ten years later like you-"

"Tower of Nightmares."

"Hmph, Tower of Nightmares. If it appears, I will trust your words. I will do whatever you say."

It was an unexpected offer. The doctor quickly added, "Oh, and I will waive all consultation fees during those 10 years."

"...And why do you want to do that?"

Jaehwan couldn't understand. There seemed to be no reason for the doctor to do such a thing for him. Toward Jaehwan's suspicion, the doctor spoke with a warm voice.

"I should say that I don't want to see a boy's future being destroyed."

"..."

"Besides, it's not entirely free. I have conditions of my own."

"Condition?"

"If the tower does not appear after 10 years, you have to give up on your world."

That too was unexpected. Jaehwan's eyes shook.

"What do you think?"

Jaehwan looked at the doctor's eyes. They seemed to have no hostility whatsoever. The doctor even seemed very caring and concerned about Jaehwan. Jaehwan became confused. And that made him face a certain question that he tried to not ask until now.

What if he was wrong? What if this man was right?

What if the Tree of Imagery never existed in the first place and all of his memories were his creation? What if there was a 'reality' and he was just running away from it? If that was true, then what will happen to him now?

Jaehwan crouched. Like a king trying to protect his fallen kingdom, he crouched for a long time. And after a while, a small voice came out from the ruined, fallen kingdom.

"...Okay."

The doctor smiled.

"Good. It's a promise."

10 years quickly passed by and Jaehwan made a few more promises with the doctor.

First, Jaehwan was never to talk about Tree of Imagery or Big Brother to anyone else during those 10 years.

Second, if Jaehwan wanted to talk about the Tree of Imagery badly, he could only talk about it with the doctor.

Third, he had to visit the doctor at least once a month during those 10 years.

Jaehwan then moved onto middle school, and then high school. He also went to college and he lived an ordinary life. He listened to classes as if he were climbing the tower, and aimed for higher grades like he was increasing his stats.

But no matter how long had passed, the memories of the Tree of Imagery did not go away. On the other hand, thinking of it would make him lose consciousness, so Jaehwan tried hard to not think about it. He just kept on not thinking about it at least 10 years.

His mother became happy. And through it, Jaehwan felt reassured. He felt like he was living to the fullest, and when he thought that, he also felt strong hatred toward himself. When he couldn't bear it any longer, he visited the doctor to talk about Tree of Imagery. It made him feel a bit better.

Those 10 years felt like 10 billion years had passed.

Jaehwan was now a college student. He was now 20 years old.

Finally, it was 2018.

Chapter 233: World after the fall

(5)

A lot of things happened during those 10 years.

Ordinary life? That never occurred to Jaehwan until now, but Jaehwan managed it. He studied hard, and made friends like a normal kid. He usually spent his time alone reading novels. He read all kinds of novels from old classics to educational books. But what Jaehwan read the most were fantasy novels.

Sword and magic. Reincarnation and time traveling. Monsters and various superhumans...

As he read those novels, it felt like he had gone back in time like when he was at the Tree of Imagery. As he read through those novels, he was able to forget the tragedy of reality. It felt like it was the Tree of Imagery where he should have lived, and this 'reality' felt more unreal.

A world without Adapters or Awakeners? How did such a world exist?

This unrealistic place he lived in was the 'reality'. Or a place where people called it reality. It was pleasant to read through those novels but it was painful when he finished reading one and was pulled out from the sea of reminiscence. Jaehwan often felt like he had broken out of his dream and was on top trash bags, searching desperately for other novels to dive into. That was the only way he could stay true to himself.

Because of this, maybe it was wrong that Jaehwan made friends like a normal kid. He was mostly alone and always sullen wherever he was. But he still had friends. There were friends who approached him first.

Yoonhwan and Seoyul.

"Jaehwan sometimes is too imaginative."

"That's his charming point."

When Jaehwan met them for the first time in high school, he thought he was dreaming. Jaehwan called out Yoonhwan's name without realizing it.

"Huh? How did you know my name? Did you know me from somewhere?"

"Silly. You introduced yourself in the class already. He probably remembered."

"No way. I don't remember his name!"

Yoonhwan and Seoyul. It was inside the Tower of Nightmares that Jaehwan met them in his memory. He had never met them outside the tower even once. Becoming friends with Yoonhwan and making out with Seoyul... it all happened inside the tower, or that's what it should have been.

"Huh? Tower of Nightmares? What is that? Oh, are you talking about the novel that you wrote back in that literature class?"

"Oh, right. Your name was in that novel."

"You were there too Seoyul."

"Yeah. I was so surprised."

"Heh. Yeah, well, to think there's a guy writing a novel with his classmates dying... but you know, I felt it right away when I read that novel."

"Huh? What?"

"A premonition, even?"

"...What premonition?"

"That he and I will be good friends."

"...I think Jaehwan has gotten you too."

And Jaehwan became friends with Yoonhwan and Seoyul. Of course, they did not remember anything. They did not know anything about Tower of Nightmares, the Tree of Imagery, or Rupture...

Every one of them was a story within the 'novel' that Jaehwan once wrote for the class. But they still walked the streets, studied together, and talked about their future. It felt like Jaehwan had gone back to the days at the Tower of Nightmares.

Maybe he was still inside the tower. Nothing was finished and maybe he was still trapped within it.

That thought became even stronger when Yoonhwan often spoke teasingly.

"Anyway, you and I are the ones who climbed towers together. We will climb it again soon."

"...You remember?"

"Hahaha! No, man. I'm just joking. We will climb the tower of education, remember?"

"..."

"College, man! College! Gosh, what a stuck up.Argh! Hey, don't stab me there!"

It was a strange thing to live through with a living body. Memories of the Tree of Imagery came creeping back to Jaehwan when he least expected it. But as time had passed, the number of nightmares decreased.

Forgetting. The blessing of living beings.

Jaehwan's memory of the Tree of Imagery decreased slowly. But as those memories faded away, Jaehwan became frustrated. He was afraid that he

would truly forget all those times. As he looked at Yoonhwan wrestling against him playfully or Seoyul blushing at him, he became numb but quickly came back.

Is it okay? Is Jaehwan okay? Are Yoonhwan and Seoyul okay?

What was this nightmare? If Jaehwan didn't have memories about it...

And the year 2018 came and Jaehwan started attending college. It was just an average college located in the city of Seoul. He was majoring in a Korean Literature but he didn't have any purpose in doing so. It was a choice influenced by the doctor.

"I think Literature will fit you best."

"Why is that?"

During those 10 years, the relationship between the doctor and Jaehwan also changed. The doctor now cared for Jaehwan like his own son and Jaehwan spoke politely in full sentences. Whatever purpose the doctor had, Jaehwan knew that the doctor's care toward him wasn't a lie. 10 years was enough time to know the man's heart.

"Didn't I say it before? You have an artistic sense."

"...Are you making fun of me again?"

"No, I'm being serious."

The doctor smiled teasingly.

"Think about it. Think about the countless people paying to see the world you created. You can do many things with that money. That money will even make your world become 'reality'."

"...I don't need money."

"Haha, Jaehwan. You are too young to understand, but money is everything in this world."

Jaehwan then laughed and asked, "Can a psychiatrist say such a thing to a patient?"

"I am still an ordinary person."

The doctor also smiled.

Chapter 234: World after the fall

(6)

It was now the summer of 2018. Inside the lecture room at the college, Jaehwan looked out at the window at the green tree outside.

'It's about half a year left now.'

If the memory was right, the Tower of Nightmares was supposed to appear in the sky during the winter. It was probably right. In the past, he had gone to the military after the 1st semester of his college, and the tower appeared when he was just promoted to Private First Class.

'Now that I think about it, I didn't even finish my military service back then.'

Jaehwan smiled bitterly as he saw the novel on his smartphone.

-HAHA! I am back to the past! Finally! I will start all over again!

As he read through the novel, Jaehwan scrolled quickly down. He was reading it, but it was too cheesy. Even then, the reason why he read it was because of his fond memories of the past.

Did he like reading novels that took place in the past also? He didn't remember.

Just like a tree without any leaves, Jaehwan's memory was now vague and empty. Most of the details were all gone and it was those unimportant memories that were more detailed.

"You, the one with looking down at your cell phone. Can you KINDLY explain the parallel universe theory that I just explained to the class again?"

And those detailed memories sometimes collided with the reality that Jaehwan was currently living in. Such an example was the presence of the professor angrily calling him out right now.

"Uh... so your name was... yes. Jaehwan."

"Yes, Professor Sakamoto."

"Please, explain what the Parallel Universe Theory is."

Sakamoto, who was a middle-school science teacher in the Tower of Nightmares, was now a professor at the college, teaching Jaehwan in this new world.

Sakamoto Seiji – Understanding of modern science

When Jaehwan first saw the name 'Sakamoto' on his schedule, he was not certain but he quickly found out that it was THE Sakamoto he knew. It didn't match his memory, but Jaehwan was happy to see his friend from the tower and asked a few questions when he met Sakamoto. But as expected, he did not remember anything. It was fortunate that Sakamoto's interest in science allowed him to not think weirdly about Jaehwan's question.

Jaehwan sighed and stood up.

"Can I explain how I understood?"

"Go on."

"Uh, so the Parallel Universe Theory is..."

As he began explaining, Jaehwan felt nostalgic. He had listened to Sakamoto's explanation a long time ago. Sakamoto even explained it again when they found the [Stone of Return] on the 77th floor of the tower.

-I think this stone will bring all of us back to another dimension back in time. But this is all a theory, and we might even all drop in the same dimension. These items exceed our knowledge after all.

'Sakamoto, you might not have even guessed it, but I am just telling everything I heard from you back then. I am explaining the exact same thing.'

"...So, to summarize, the Parallel Universe Theory is a theory that a world takes many turns with different choices and there are multiple universes that are present that we do not realize. For example..."

Jaehwan then stopped and looked out the window. A sudden illusion came into his vision. A giant tower swept through the sky. A tragedy that came after the tower appeared. Jaehwan spoke.

"Maybe in a parallel universe, Earth might be on the brink of destruction. Because I just imagined it happening right now."

Some students became dumbfounded. Jaehwan came back to his senses but it was too late. Sakamoto quickly resolved the confusion.

"Good work, Jaehwan. Your example surely fits you as a literature major."

Jaehwan wasn't sure what part of it had to do with being a literature major, but Jaehwan sat down anyway. It was now about time to end the class and Sakamoto's lecture was now nearing its end.

"...The theory has not yet been proven. But it still is a theory that will make our lives more satisfying."

Sakamoto continued, "To think that every 'imagination' we have might be what is really happening in another universe. This theory will make our choices more sincere and careful. According to this theory, we are creating a new universe every second we live."

Jaehwan found himself concentrating on Sakamoto's story now.

"Maybe, an 'imagination' or a 'delusion' doesn't exist in this universe. All of those parallel universes do exist after all, in terms of imagination, a dream, metaphors, symbols, and so forth. We live once and die once, but we are living multiple parallel universes at the same time... oh, look at the time! This will wrap up today's class!"

Students began rushing out of the lecture room as Sakamoto kept going.

"H-hey! I'm not done yet! Next week's assignment is..."

After that lecture, Jaehwan became a bit more interested in other classes. He was especially interested in 'writing' classes. He first enrolled himself in many literature classes but found out that they weren't interesting when he found out that the literature classes did not teach 'writing'. Yoonhwan spoke to him.

"Huh? Literature major? The only way you can make money is to become a professor. Who writes books these days? You'll starve to death before you can..."

Because of this, Jaehwan enrolled in 'Literature Writing' classes instead. And while he attended those classes, he wrote novels every chance he got. It was through novels that was he was determined to create a universe.

-Your story has no reality.

-You cut out too much in between, too many metaphors... and what's this? What's with these incomplete paragraphs? Do you think it looks cool to write in this way?

-I told you to write a novel, not some scribbles.

But his universe was quickly dismantled by merciless criticism. Only one thing was certain. Even within the category of 'novel', his stories were 'unrealistic' at best.

As Jaehwan kept on writing against all those criticism from professors and assistants, he despaired. The doctor laughed as he heard Jaehwan's

complaints.

"But your stories are fun."

Jaehwan replied, "Shut up."

And then came the winter of 2018.

Chapter 235: World after the fall

(7)

Only two more weeks until the expected tower appearance. Jaehwan was spending time talking with the doctor. They did not talk about the Tree of Imagery anymore.

"Oh, Jaehwan. Why don't you participate in a writing contest? I think the big contest is about to start."

The doctor made the suggestion as he knew that Jaehwan had been attending writing classes in college already. There was a contest that would soon finish receiving novels.

Jaehwan asked back in annoyance, "...Are you serious?"

"Huh? What's wrong?"

"You're making fun of me, aren't you?"

"Haha, I am not."

Jaehwan thought as he looked at the doctor's face. 'This doctor, he must know all about it and still says this.'

Jaehwan answered, "Contest... you would not say that if you've listened to my criticisms. I wrote those novels because you told me to and..."

"Haha. What did the others say to you?"

Jaehwan stopped talking. He didn't want to repeat what he had heard in class, merciless criticism that was too much.

"You have talent. I love your stories."

"How about you write it instead then? I'm sure you are good at writing too."

"Well, if you give me a story, maybe I will try someday."

Jaehwan then laughed.

"Well, how about you use all my stories that you've collected until now?"

Of course, Jaehwan did not mean what he said. The doctor must have known it too. Jaehwan was always serious about his stories. Delusion or not, Jaehwan trusted his world no matter what people said. There was no way that Jaehwan would agree to using his stories for entertainment purposes.

But why? The doctor's face froze for a slight second at Jaehwan's words. It was only for a slight second and Jaehwan did not realize. The doctor laughed awkwardly.

"Haha..."

Silence fell. The doctor looked down at the table and Jaehwan looked out the window.

"The day's coming soon, Jaehwan."

"..."

"Are you ready for it?"

"So-so."

"So-so?"

"It's what it is. It just feels so-so."

The window was foggy from the coldness outside. Jaehwan approached the window and used his finger to draw a spiral tower. The tower drawing

looked pretty good with the snow falling beyond the window.

Fear?

Jaehwan had been thinking about it for a while, but he wasn't that certain. What if the tower didn't appear? He was living life here now. Jaehwan smiled. Maybe the doctor had won at last.

"Jaehwan."

"Yeah."

"It's been ten years since I first met you."

Some of the doctor's hair was becoming white. Jaehwan felt the flow of time as he looked at those strands of hair. He had forgotten about it after living for millions of years, but ten years was a long time for ordinary humans.

"Can I tell you what is ironic?"

"What is it?"

"I actually believe in your world. It's not about the possibility. I really do believe that the world exists."

Jaehwan was stunned for a second and scoffed.

"Is that a new joke?"

The doctor shook his head seriously.

"Even if the tower does not appear, I believe that your world existed- no. Exists."

The doctor was serious. He was looking at thick pile charts in a cabinet near the wall. Jaehwan also turned to look in the same direction. There were countless charts with various patient names.

"Recently, I think my treatments were all wrong after all. Treating and fixing other people's worlds... I just thought maybe it was too arrogant of me. How can a man fix another's world?"

"...Are you kidding? Or are you serious?"

"I am serious."

Jaehwan was at a loss for words. The doctor continued, "Maybe it's all thanks to you."

"What do you mean?"

"Maybe I was the one who was persuaded by you during our 10 years."

Why now? Why? Jaehwan felt dizzy. He barely was able to adapt to this world and why was he saying that now? Wasn't it his wish for Jaehwan to give up on that world? He had been...

"I am serious, Jaehwan. I believe in that world."

"But why... the tower hasn't even appeared yet."

"I just think that it's not important anymore, whether the tower appears or not."

The doctor was smiling. And from that smile, Jaehwan felt his last 10 years being shaken terribly.

'No. Please don't. Don't speak anymore.'

The doctor kept going.

"As I recorded all your stories and read them... it just came to my mind. Maybe the tower that you are waiting for is..."

Jaehwan then lost his balance and fell, grabbing the corner of the table. The clash then shook the table, dropping piles of charts onto the ground. It was patient charts for Jaehwan. And with the dizziness, Jaehwan slumped down

on the ground. The doctor's voice became muddy as if Jaehwan was underwater.

"Jaehwan! Are you okay?"

Jaehwan threw the doctor's hand away. He was looking down at the charts. There were various numbers showing the rate of depression. There were graphs that showed the potential amount of suicide, and graphs that showed inability to adapt to society.

Jaehwan looked down dumbfoundedly.

Graphs and numbers. All those distorted informations began swirling around him. It spun and spun and continued talking to him.

Jaehwan. Jaehwan. Jaehwan. Jaehwan.

It was proving himself. Jaehwan, who couldn't be proven, was now only being proven from those numbers. It made him felt nauseous. He felt like he was going to throw up.

What was this feeling?

Jaehwan then began to vomit. The doctor kept on speaking, but Jaehwan couldn't hear anything anymore. And with the sound of calling a nurse, Jaehwan grabbed one of the charts and began ripping it down.

"Jaehwan!"

The harts were ripped. And from the openings of various numbers and graphs, a certain emptiness began to swirl out. A void that could not be described by any number or graph was there. As Jaehwan ripped those charts, he glared at those empty spaces.

'That was me. I was there.'

It was like an illusion. Jaehwan even forgot the name of that place.

That is... uniq....

Uni...

u...

...

Chapter 236: World after the fall

(8)

Jaehwan then realized he had lived in that space a long time ago. He also realized he will never return to that space anymore. His cheeks became wet.

"Jaehwan! Jaehwan!"

The doctor was shaking him by the shoulders but Jaehwan couldn't feel it. The twenty-year-old Jaehwan was now stronger than the young doctor. Jaehwan's struggle threw the doctor to the ground and Jaehwan kept on ripping the charts. He screamed like a mad man as he ripped them.

And in the midst of the ripped charts, he found something.

There was a document that was full of words. Jaehwan picked it up.

"J-Jaehwan! Wait! That is...!"

Even though the doctor was trying to stop him, Jaehwan read it through. Soon, Jaehwan realized that the document wasn't an ordinary recording. The document had a very familiar story in it and started with the following:

-The Fall always starts everywhere.

Familiar sentences. Jaehwan read a few more paragraphs.

-Ten-year-old Jaehwan was also a victim of such a Fall.

The doctor was now looking at Jaehwan as if he had given up now. Page after page, Jaehwan kept on reading the stories. It was only after he went through most of the pages that Jaehwan's shaking hand stopped.

"...Doctor. What is this?"

"Jaehwan."

"Answer me. What is this?"

"I-I'm sorry. I was going to tell you... I mean- I was going to ask for your permission to..."

What Jaehwan read was a short novel. A cleanly written short novel. It had Jaehwan's story in it. A ten-year-old boy who was being consulted because of domestic violence. A boy who denied reality, who eventually created a delusional world, and had to live in it....

Doctor's word shot past Jaehwan's head then.

-If the day comes when you can see your world with an unbiased view, people will pay to peek into your world.

That was the reason why the doctor talked about the writing contest, and his suggestion for Jaehwan to major in literature. Everything came together like a puzzle. Jaehwan's hand began to shiver in anger again.

Was this the reason for all that?

Jaehwan was filled with rage. He felt like everything in the world was worthless and he felt stupid. Jaehwan looked at the doctor. The doctor couldn't even bear to look at Jaehwan anymore. Jaehwan asked, "Was this reason you cared for me all this time?"

"Jaehwan, please. Listen to-"

"To write this?! Was that the reason for the free consultations? To listen to my stories?!"

"Jaehwan! No! That's not it!"

"What is it then]!"

"It's..."

"My story was just a 'novel' to you then?!"

The doctor shook his head strongly. It was an innocent shake, making it hard to believe that it had come from a middle aged man. Jaehwan did not stop shouting however.

"You've been writing this behind my back all this time! You've been trying to use my stories for your money! And you DARE claim that you believe my world?! HOW DARE YOU SAY THAT!"

The doctor tried to speak in shock multiple times, but he eventually looked down. Jaehwan then ripped the novel into pieces in front of the doctor and burst out of the room. He heard a nurse calling him from the back, but Jaehwan did not look back and left the hospital.

He ran and ran. He ran for a long time and realized he couldn't see the hospital anymore. There wasn't anyone following him either.

And through the snowing sky, Jaehwan puffed white breaths. As the cold snow touched his cheek, his destroyed heart slowly came back to itself.

'Why did I share my story with that kind of man?'

Deep regret filled Jaehwan's heart.

'He believes my story?'

'He really believes that my world — that the Tree of Imagery really exists?'

Jaehwan was filled with tears of rage. He should not have trusted anyone. He knew that trust could only return in such a way and still he did it. He was too naïve. Was it becoming young that made him think that he had really become young again? Memories of the past 10 years quickly flashed past him.

He had been stupid all along. He gritted his teeth as he thought about the doctor being friendly for all those years.

'Trust? I don't need your trust. My world is real. Even without any trust, it will be proven naturally.' Jaehwan thought as he looked up to the white sky.

Time was coming. The tower was going to appear soon, the tower that will save him from this world. That Fall will come for him soon.

Jaehwan slowly walked home. Jaehwan's footprints was covered by the new snow that fell onto it. Jaehwan swore to never go back to the hospital anymore.

Two weeks later...

The day came silently during the midst of a snowy winter day.

Jaehwan was looking up to the sky. He was in the military in the past, but he did not enlist in the military this time. He knew it was pointless if the tower appeared again. Instead, Jaehwan climbed up a high mountain every day to look up into the sky.

He looked and looked.

He looked at the snowy sky, a rainy sky, and a clear sky.

The tower did not appear, but Jaehwan waited.

It was late. The tower had to appear.

But then the next day came, and the next day. The tower did not appear.

And then came the last day of 2018. Jaehwan stood still and looked at the sky where the new year's sun was coming up. It was an unbelievably glorious and beautiful sight. Lovers held their hands and families hugged each other as they cheered for the coming of the new year.

In the middle of everyone cheering and blessing the new year, only Jaehwan waited for the Fall. He believed that the tower was going to appear soon. However, people left one by one, and even after lovers went down the mountain while holding their hands, the Fall still did not come.

The tower did not appear.

Jaehwan stood there, looking directly at the peaceful sky for a long time.

And then Jaehwan turned twenty-one years old.

Chapter 237: World after the fall

(9)

In the new year, Jaehwan applied for the military right away.

It was decided on a whim. If he had taken the necessary steps, he would have been waived for military duty due to his ten years of mental consultations, but Jaehwan did not choose that route. Besides, his medical records were all free sessions that did not count as medical issues. He could have gotten help from the doctor if needed, but Jaehwan didn't want to. He didn't want to see the man's face anymore. And above all else, Jaehwan needed a place to trap himself.

He needed a place with strict rules, a place where he did not need to think deeply, and a place where he can push his body to the limit.

Jaehwan was soon dispatched to the farthest region, the DMZ where it was known to be harshest of all military branches and began his military life there. He memorized his duties and stood on patrol. He cleaned places that weren't his to clean, volunteered first to shovel out the snow, and always came back last.

He worked out continuously or read books alone after completing the tasks for the day. He mostly stayed in quiet spaces and lived peacefully. Officers loved him since he was quiet and obeyed all rules. He was also loved by others.

"Huh? Are you cleaning those rifles again? It's your free time, man!"

"Yes, sir. I am doing what I like."

"Hah... I think you should make this your career. I think you were born to be in the military."

Jaehwan smiled bitterly at the sergeant.

"No, sir."

"No, my ass. How about you apply for it, huh?"

"Haha."

Jaehwan just laughed and responded to the sergeant starting to talk about his life story again.

Born to be in the military? Jaehwan? There was no way that Jaehwan was born to be military. He was born to destroy and decimate the system.

The sergeant soon left when he got bored of talking and Jaehwan was left alone. He became scared at the sudden silence and quickly returned the rifles to their original place before moving out for another job.

He constantly needed to be on the move so he'd be busy. Therefore, he could not have false hope.

Jaehwan cleaned off the other soldier's shoes one by one, and brought wet rags to wipe down corners along with the insides of narrow windows that were not usually cleaned. A song from a young girl group came from a TV, the only thing keeping silence out of the room. Jaehwan kept on rubbing and cleaning.

One song soon finished and the next song started. The girls sang and sang.

Jaehwan then stopped his cleaning and turned to the television screen dumbfoundedly. There were girls singing on the screen. And at that moment, Jaehwan felt like the world was talking to him.

'I knew you would come. I waited. You were just a human too after all.'

The girls sang and Jaehwan looked at them. Lust overshadowed Jaehwan. And in that lust, Jaehwan took the girls, raped, wounded, and controlled them. In the end, he was controlled by them. And the girls kept singing. They kept singing again and again as if it was never going to end, as if no 'Fall' would ever come.

It was as if that song was the only reality they could take.

After some time, people came back to the room. One of Jaehwan's superiors started teasing him.

"Hey, you've been watching the Seven Pink? I knew you would like... Huh? What? Are you crying?"

The man became shocked and others quickly gathered around Jaehwan.

"Hey! Who made him cry?"

"Who is it?! Was it you? Huh?"

Jaehwan then turned around to look at his superior with an awkward look. Was he crying?

Jaehwan brought his hand up to his cheek. It was very wet from his tears. Men shouted around him but he felt the voices becoming distant. And through those voices, he heard the song again. It was so beautiful, but beautifully doomed. Then Jaehwan realized he had to accept a certain fact.

'I see.'

'So my world fell.'

Just like a tower falling down, Jaehwan felt his body crumbling.

'That world doesn't exist anymore. Because that world...'

Jaehwan fell down to the ground. And with the sound of calling a medic, he lost consciousness.

That world.... Jaehwan destroyed it with his own hands.

That night, Jaehwan had a long dream. He heard distant voices. Soon, Jaehwan realized that the voices were very familiar; it was his own voice.

-Was this the ending you wanted?

-...

-Was living in this nightmare the reason why you brought me here?

One was Jaehwan in his twenties, and one Jaehwan was ten years old. Both of them were Jaehwan. They were arguing, no, the twenty-year-old Jaehwan was pressing on. The ten-year-old Jaehwan answered,

-I thought it would be different. The world you used to live in.

-Now you know that it's not.

-Yeah. It's different from the fairytale mom told me.

Jaehwan was puzzled. He wanted to join the discussion. He wanted to talk. He too, needed to talk. But where was he? Where was he while looking at those two? The twenty-year-old Jaehwan spoke.

-Our powers don't work here.

-Of course. There's no Adaptation or Awakening. There's no unique world, so no Transcendence. Or Big Brother.

-No danger, no opportunity. Then what should we do now?

-Do what? There's nothing we can do here.

The two Jaehwans seemed to have given up. Jaehwan wanted to speak to them, but he didn't know what to say.

-Maybe we have to disappear in order for 'Jaehwan' to live happily. If he's to live here, he needs to abandon all the history that we lived as 'Jaehwan'.

It is not allowed here.

-...Yes. I see.

-Yeah. It all ends here then.

The two Jaehwans then looked at each other. As they looked at each other, Jaehwan realized who he was. He was nowhere, and he was both of them at once. The two Jaehwan was himself. The two of them were now fusing back to one.

Jaehwan was becoming himself.

Jaehwan felt his longings and memories fading away. Like new clothes turning into old clothes, the memories disappeared.

'No, don't disappear.'

Jaehwan cried in the midst of the fading memories. Was everything all real? What did mean for it to be real anyway?

The darkness fell and the dream was over. After that, Jaehwan never dreamed of such a thing anymore.

Jaehwan was now almost at the end of his military service. He had adapted to the military during those times. He endured the boring days and became a boring man.

"You are amazing, sir."

But people in the military liked him and respected him. He was even awarded for being a leader to the future military, free of violence and oppression. But Jaehwan didn't seem excited.

"I just do what I need to do."

"Yeah, yeah. But you know it's really hard to do that."

"It's annoying, but it's not hard."

"That's what it is. I'm not sure if I can do things like you. I can't be that..."

Others also praised Jaehwan for his dedication and his work ethic. With that, Jaehwan remembered the days of stabbing. He remembered a day where he kept on stabbing until he completed the count and never rested.

"It's easy compared to stabbing 100 thousand times a day."

"Huh?"

"...Just saying."

"Oh- yeah. Haha. I see."

People laughed without giving much thought.

'Stabbing, huh?'

Jaehwan now didn't feel anything even when he thought about those memories. It was all dull now. Jaehwan was such a man now and he wasn't mad or depressed anymore.

Chapter 238: World after the fall

(10)

Not too long after, Jaehwan completed his military duty. Yoonhwan also finished his military service around the same time and they began attending college again.

"Hey, how come you guys never replied to my letters while you were in the military? Did you get my letters?"

Seoyul snapped angrily and Yoonhwan teased, "Oh, of course. I got it. I should thank you for your picture though. I lied that you are my sister and my superiors treated me well for it."

"Ugh, was it you?! I wondered why I was getting these messages from some men that I didn't even know..."

Jaehwan was back to listening to those ordinary conversations again. It wasn't hard like before. He still read books and trained alone, but he didn't fall into lonely delusions like before. He accepted his new body and his new life.

In this place, a human would die soon or later.

'Reality' was a different world from the [Great Lands] or the [Tree of Imagery]. Jaehwan now had a body that would age slowly, and die when the time comes. Whether he wanted it or not, he was going to spend a short time in this life and die.

Then what did his life mean? For the first time, Jaehwan was facing a mortal life. And that made him think differently.

'Human lives are too short to change something.'

That thought helped him greatly when Jaehwan had to justify his actions or distance him from uncertain questions or ethical problems. He remembered Sakamoto's lecture.

'If it were the parallel universe...'

If this world had skills, and if he could stab to overcome himself... if this world had a giant and clear evil... he would have been different.

'But this universe does not have such a thing. There is no skill, Setting, or unique world. There's none of that.'

Even if the parallel universe did exist somewhere, it wasn't here.

And it was here that Jaehwan had to live.

It was a place where no miracles took place. A place where not everything was able to be done through trials. A place where life ends before knowing what might be at the end of everything.

It was reality.

It was the Nightmare of the Beginning.

Jaehwan got a job right away after he graduated. It was a small company that managed small websites with novels. It was Professor Sakamoto who recommended Jaehwan to the company, and the reason was quite amusing.

-He always reads web novels in my class. But he knows all about the parallel universe. He will be a valuable asset to your company.

It was shocking when Jaehwan came to the company for the first day of work.

"Haha, Jaehwan, was it? Welcome. I am Hwang Inchan. I am the Editorial Manager here."

Jaehwan almost screamed in shock. Hwang Inchan from Swordpanic! It was one of those few people that Jaehwan remembered clearly from his fading memories.

He was the one who formed the Expeditionary force [Blade Walkers] at the Tower of Nightmares, and was the one of the best until the 77th floor.

Jaehwan tried to speak but held back. There was no point in asking. Inchan would not have any memory of it anyway. Everything was his delusion. Inchan asked Jaehwan with a large smile, "Why? Do you have a question?"

"N-no."

"Oh, okay. I thought you had questions just by the way you looked."

"I'm sorry."

"No, don't be."

Inchan smiled as he waved it off. Jaehwan felt a slight headache after a long time. Was his world really 'fake' even with this? He still remembered everything about him so clearly.

The doctor once told him that his delusions were just the creation of images he was seeing. It will manipulate him as if he had known the person he saw for the first time, and strengthen his delusions.

"You wrote in your resume that you love web novels... which one do you like most?"

Jaehwan came back to his senses.

"Uh, it's hard to specify. It's..."

Maybe it wasn't a great answer as a rookie, but Inchan smiled in satisfaction.

"Oh? I see. So, you must have read many of them then. It's hard to pick out good ones when you read a good amount. I guess we have a good one this

time."

Jaehwan smiled awkwardly.

"Then what about the genre? What do you like? Fantasy? Game-fantasy? Or..."

Jaehwan hesitated a bit and answered, "...Uh, ones that return."

Inchan opened his eyes in surprise.

"Oh? Is that it?"

"Yeah."

Jaehwan did not like them of course. It was actually what he hated. But he only answered that way to check on Inchan. Needless to say, Inchan became excited.

"I love them too! It's really fun, isn't it?"

"Uh..."

"There are people who say its too overused and boring now, but I think there's still potential. People just have that basic desire to return back to the past and change their lives, you know? People want to succeed in life in the easiest way after all. Haha."

Jaehwan was astonished by Inchan's perspective. Jaehwan had never thought about it that way.

'It's a good answer for a man who went to the past first when the [Returning Stone] appeared.'

Jaehwan then gasped at himself for diving into his delusions.

'...What am I doing again?'

Was it because he had met a person that brought memories? Jaehwan was shaken. He glanced around the office to calm himself down. The office was very small. There were a few desks divided by partitions and a 40-inch television on another wall. The TV was showing a news channel.

It was showing a group of demonstrators fighting against a giant company. It was filled with men around Jaehwan's age. Inchan glanced at Jaehwan and said, "Your seat is that one. We don't have many employees though. But don't worry. Our wage isn't high either but-"

It was then that an incident happened on the news.

-Wait! What are you- HEY!

With the voice of the reporter, the camera shook and a man appeared.

-EVERYONE! You must realize! We all must realize!

The TV's volume wasn't loud, but the voice roared throughout the office. Inchan turned to the TV with an annoyed expression. The man's continued speaking.

-Everyone! Please open your eyes!

"Wow, what's going on there? Haha."

Inchan laughed as he looked at the man fighting against the reporter for the microphone.

"Jaehwan, look at that. You must look into everything if you want to be a good editor."

But before Jaehwan could answer, the man shouted as he snatched the microphone again.

-We must all know this. We are trapped inside the tower! We are being cultivated inside the Tower of Nightmares!

Inchan burst into laughter.

"Hahahaha! Tower of Nightmares? What's with that man? Maybe he's one of our customers!"

The man shouted desperately. Maybe the voice of a man facing a Fall would sound like that. It was so desperate. Everyone in the world laughed at the man, but the man did not hold back.

-Everyone, this world... it's not... it's not the life... the Fall... the tower...!

And with that voice, the screen changed and the person on TV apologized for the unexpected incident. Inchan was still laughing.

"Haha, the world is more fun than fantasy these days. We should be alert, don't you think?"

Jaehwan felt Inchan's hand tapping his shoulder but he couldn't tear his eyes from the screen. He didn't see the man anymore, but he looked at it still. After a short while, Jaehwan answered, "Yeah, you're right."

"Good. Now, let's get to it!"

Jaehwan then sat down at his table. There were files left by the person who worked there before for Jaehwan to catch up on. But Jaehwan couldn't focus on any of them. He was looking at the computer, but he was thinking of something else. He couldn't stop thinking about the man.

He had a full beard, a dirtied lab coat, and more prominent white hair.

Jaehwan knew the man. It had been a while since then, but he couldn't forget him. How could he?

'No way. Why...'

The man's voice was still clear in Jaehwan's mind.

-Even if the tower doesn't appear, I still believe that your world existed- no. Exists.

It was the man that Jaehwan spent the most time with after he came back to 'reality.' The man who would understand Jaehwan more than anyone else in this world. And he was the man who declared Jaehwan's world as a 'delusion' more clearly than anyone else.

The man on TV was the doctor.

Chapter 239: World after the fall

(11)

The doctor kept appearing on television.

Whenever news came up regarding various demonstrations and places, the doctor was there. The doctor was always shown in between the people protesting out on the streets.

The doctor was more famous than what Jaehwan had known. He was widely known for his teachings on Germany and France and his smart ideas. He was also a psychiatrist for many famous politicians in the country.

Fall of the Genius.

The media quickly spread news of the doctor's change and created rumors regarding his words. Politicians who were known to have connections with the doctor quickly denied that they had anything to do with him. But even with all that, the doctor kept pressing on.

-Everyone! We must realize we are trapped! We are inside the tower!

Jaehwan wasn't sure what the doctor was trying to do. Why was he promoting all that madness after all this time? Wasn't he the one who said that money was everything in the world? And that Jaehwan must accept this world for his family?

Wasn't he the one who spent 10 years persuading Jaehwan in any way he could?

Why?

What changed him during this short period of time? Or was there another intention to all that?

-Recently, I think my treatments were all wrong after all. Maybe it's your influence.

-...Are you kidding?

-No, I'm serious. Maybe it's me who was persuaded during these 10 years.

Jaehwan then looked up to see if the doctor had written a novel recently, but there was no sign of the novel that he ripped apart that day. He tried to meet with the doctor a few times, and he even saw the doctor within the group of protesters while he was passing by, but Jaehwan never went up to talk to him.

Maybe he was afraid.

Maybe he was afraid to bring out the emotions he had been holding back. Maybe he was afraid that it would bring him greater despair...

-Please! Open your eyes!

Fortunately, the doctor's news quickly died on media as other bigger issues had come up. Besides, the doctor did not change his stance and that soon bored people. He was always at protesting sites but he never backed any politicians or any organizations.

"Hmph. It's him again."

Hwang Inchan, who was watching the news together with him, spoke.

"You know, there are folks like him that don't know how the world revolves. He doesn't know that life depends on 15 minutes. That man's 15 minutes are long gone."

Hwang Inchan scratched his beard and turned to Jaehwan.

"15 minutes... Oh, Jaehwan. Did I ever tell you this?"

"Do you mean 15 Minutes of Fame by Andy Warhol?"

"Right! You know then!"

Inchan loved to quote "15 Minutes of Fame" all the time. It seemed like that was the only famous quote he knew as he repeated it so many times that it annoyed Jaehwan every 15 minutes of the hour.

"Authors are the same too. The ones that we work with. You see, modern fantasy is a very popular genre right now, but how long do you think it will last? You never know what's coming up next. You might be a popular author right now, but you never know where you will end up."

Jaehwan knew exactly how to respond each time now.

"So, you mean everyone has their 15 minutes of fame?"

"Exactly! There's the best 15 minutes for everyone and you never know when it will end! I think your 15 minutes is right now, Jaehwan. I see that you've done some good work this quarter."

"...Thank you."

"Yeah! That's how you should be. Seoyul, you must learn from Jaehwan too."

There had been a small change to the company, and one of them was that Han Seoyul had been hired into Jaehwan's company.

"Oh... yeah."

Jaehwan would have stopped it if he had known, but it all happened before he could do anything about it.

"Don't just give me an answer. Show results. Look at Jaehwan! He's not good looking or very humorous, but he pulls it off!"

Jaehwan became uncomfortable as he saw Seoyul's face becoming depressed. There was a precedent where a former employee had quit

because of Inchan's criticism.

"Seoyul, you've got weapons of your own. You see, you are on your '15 minutes' you know? You know that women are done after you're over 25 years old, right? You see, a woman should-"

And Jaehwan couldn't hold back any longer and opened his mouth.

"Inchan."

"Huh?"

He did cut off Inchan, but he wasn't sure about what to say.

"Oh-oh. Lemme see. Are you-? R-r-right. Seoyul is quite cute, isn't she? Hey, Seoyul. I see that you've got a knight in shining armor for yourself."

Inchan grinned teasingly but Jaehwan shook his head.

"No, it's not like that."

"Huh? What?"

Jaehwan did not answer and Inchan's face slowly turned cold.

"Wait. Are you that? Are you a feminist or something that's popular these days?"

"Huh?"

"You know. The one on SNS these days."

"No, it's not like..."

"You know how dangerous that kind of thought process can be, right? You have to get yourself up! Don't you know who our readers are? Huh?"

Jaehwan let out a small sigh.

'Ugh, he'll be on me for a while now.'

It was too late to regret it now. But there was a moment where Jaehwan needed to say something. Even after he lost his world, his justice and most of his memories were fading away, but there were certain emotions that still lingered.

Jaehwan knew that he wasn't all that smart.

He forgot most of the knowledge that the Transcended ones had passed onto him. He had no knowledge of human rights or feminism. He wasn't very knowledgeable regarding gender equality either. But Jaehwan knew what was right and wrong in this world at least.

"Think about it, Jaehwan. Think about all of our readers who are suffering at work."

"...."

"What do you think they will want to read? About human rights? About justice? Ethical problems? Feminism? It's all great. It is. But think about reality. They don't sell! Not to mention, they don't even get published!"

Jaehwan knew this well.

"Do you think people don't read it because they don't know it's good? No! They do know! They know it already and that's why don't want to see it!"

It felt like déjà vu. Jaehwan had heard similar words from somewhere. Where was it? Was it in Tree of Imagery? Was it Yoo Surha? Myad? Or Chunghuh? He wasn't sure. Maybe Jaehwan didn't want to remember.

"You don't know because you're still young. You haven't lived a life yet."

Life... Could he still say that if he knew about Jaehwan's 10 billion years? Jaehwan became curious.

"Do you think people don't want justice in their lives? There's no other way! That's why they live like that! They all have their families! Jaehwan. You

have a mother too, don't you?"

Mother. Jaehwan stopped at the sudden word.

"...Yeah."

"See? Think about it. Everyone lives for the loved ones that are around them! We live and die each day to support them! How can justice criticize those lives? What they need is not justice! It's reassurance! And we are finding novels that can reassure them!"

"I... is it?"

Jaehwan then glanced at his computer monitor. There was a novel that he had been editing, a novel full of simple battle scenes, women side characters and main characters with greater desires. And Jaehwan thought about the readers who would read such characters.

"Of course! Jaehwan, you should take some time to relax sometimes. Listen carefully to my words. It's from experience."

'I see.' If that was what life was like, then maybe Inchan was more experienced. Jaehwan couldn't hold back from thinking.

After Inchan's lecture was over, Jaehwan sat down at his desk. He nodded at Seoyul apologizing to him with her eyes. At the corner of his monitor was a Youtube video that was still playing. It was the doctor. From the video that was muted, the doctor's words showed up as subtitles.

-We must change! We must change this tower that holds our loved ones as hostages! We must change this world where we hold each other hostage...!

Jaehwan turned off the video. The document window was all that was left now.

BOOM! BBBAAAAAM!

-"Argh. Ugh. That is amazing strength!"

- "HAHAHAHA! How do u like that?!"

As Jaehwan looked at those document window, he felt strange. Would reading these really reassure people and help them live a new day? Was the world really created that way?

Jaehwan looked at the window for a long time and began typing away. He changed 'BBBAAAAAM' to 'BAAAM' and changed 'u' to 'You' emotionlessly. This was the life in this world after all.

It was the world he decided to accept in order to protect what was precious to him.

Jaehwan maintained his decision for exactly a month.

After one month, Jaehwan got a call from the hospital while he was at work.

His mother died.

Chapter 240: World after the fall

(12)

As Jaehwan saw his mother's body being sent to be cremated, Jaehwan felt hollow.

Was this it? Was this how life was supposed to be?

Jaehwan was in deep sadness as he looked at Yoonhwan and Seoyul holding back their tears, not to mention his father who did not even visit. His mother died three days ago.

If he hadn't visited the hospital right away, he wouldn't even have had the chance to say goodbye.

'She'd been hiding it all along. It was already too late when the ambulance brought her here.'

Wasn't cancer a disease often appeared in novels? Jaehwan couldn't adapt to the sudden tragedy.

'Mother.'

His mother's presence was the reason and the purpose for him to become normal in this world. He adapted to this world only for his mother and lived in this world only for her.

-Jaehwan.

-Yeah, Mom.

-I was just worried about you... I'm sorry.

His mother left him words that he couldn't understand.

-It was a mistake to have that doctor treat you. I was just...

-I'm okay, Mom.

-Your father never laid hands on you. The doctor was wrong. You are not unhappy. You are...

After the funeral, Jaehwan lost all will to do anything. He took a break from work and stayed at his mother's lone home to clean it out. At the house, Jaehwan found a lot of things that he didn't even think were there.

The Little Prince book that his mother used to read to him was one of those things.

Jaehwan read the book from the beginning again. He was able to understand a lot of things that he did not understand when he was younger. He now knew that this wasn't just a child's fairytale and it was clear what the author was trying to tell.

But that was it.

'It's just a novel after all.'

Reality and imagination were different. Even with a good metaphor and explanation, there was no way for it to trump reality. At the last page of the Little Prince, there were letters. Jaehwan was surprised to see who sent those letters.

It was from the doctor.

It was letters that came to him while Jaehwan was in the military. His mother kept all of them in here.

-Jaehwan. You are right and I was wrong.

-You are mistaken. There is a misunderstanding.

-Jaehwan, I know now. The tower is real. Please, let's talk one more time.

-Jaehwan...

Jaehwan read the letters throughout the entire night.

"Are you serious? You took a break from work for a week!"

It was Inchan who greeted him angrily on his first day back at work. Inchan snapped at Jaehwan for the entire day and Jaehwan kept his silence. When the day was over, Inchan became a bit apologetic and forced Jaehwan to go to dinner with the other coworkers.

"I'm sorry about your mother."

Inchan drank a cup of liquor and patted Jaehwan's back.

"Everyone loses their mother some day. I did too. Everyone experiences it if you live for about 40 to 50 years. It's like the military. It will all pass though. Wasn't the military like that too?"

Inchan's face was red. The smell of alcohol filled the entire pub. Jaehwan felt nauseous.

"Here! Drink! Drink for Jaehwan!"

And to Jaehwan's disdain, the drinking kept going.

"So when I was your age..."

As some time passed, Inchan began his usual routine of lecturing. Jaehwan looked at Inchan silently. Inchan always loved to talk about the past as if that was the best time in his life. It was as if that was the only time when his 'real' self was there. But it wasn't only Inchan who did that anyway. That was the characteristic of every old man in this world.

"HMPH! Look at your face! The death of your mother is not the end of your world! Think about the others around you! You still live another day for

them! Then you get a good day, and you get energy from it to live another! HERE! Have another drink!"

Inchan poured beer in Jaehwan's empty cup and held up his own empty cup. He then glanced over to Seoyul who was sitting next to him. Seoyul flinched at the glance.

"OH! Seoyul, I forgot you were here too. Come. Get me a beer."

"...Okay."

"You seem to be doing nicely these days. Do you know that there's going to be a promotion soon? You know that I am quite close to the HR manager these days..."

Inchan's hand that was on Seoyul's shoulder began crawling down. It would have never been possible under normal circumstances, but the atmosphere allowed for it to happen. Seoyul bit her lip and glanced around for help. There were so many people but none tried to come out to help.

Seoyul met Jaehwan's eyes at last. They both looked at each other for a short amount of time. And during that moment, Jaehwan understood everything that was happening within Seoyul's mind.

Jaehwan felt the world shaking.

A rebellious thought popped up against this horrifying authority and it was a thought that he shouldn't fight back. Seoyul was tied deep within herself and there was the future that she had to withstand. There was the sadness crumbled down, which resulted in giving up in the end.

Why?

Why did it need to be given up?

Jaehwan felt like he couldn't hold onto something that was coming up. As if time space was being ripped apart, something inside him snapped.

"Huh? Jaehwan. What are you doing?"

Inchan had said some words about telling him to endure reality for loved ones, and his current action shook Jaehwan's head in turn. Jaehwan glared at Inchan coldly. Inchan frowned as he tried to shake his hand off from Jaehwan's grasp, and he soon smiled awkwardly.

"Oh, J-Jaehwan. It's a misunderstanding. I was just..."

"Misunderstanding? What misunderstanding?" Jaehwan asked back in a cold voice.

"I didn't misunderstand anything."

He felt Inchan's hand trembling.

"W-what.... Let go of my hand! What are you...!"

The turmoil quickly expanded to the people. Even the executives sitting at the other tables were now looking at them. Inchan frantically raised his voice.

"AH! You must be drunk! Haha! Yeah, I understand. You are sad! I understand! Drink! Here! Come on! Everyone, don't worry. This is nothing. It's nothing!"

Jaehwan saw Inchan's awkward and cowardly smile, Seoyul who couldn't bring up her face, and the people who quickly became bored. Inchan who succeeded in calming the situation which was now turning cold.

"Jaehwan, we will talk later. There are executives here. If you don't act up... you know what's going to happen, right? I will just let you go since this time you..."

Jaehwan closed his eyes slowly. His senses were cut off like magic.

Why was he still living in this world? He had lost his loved one, and so why was he still living in this world? An emotion he had been holding back exploded from the silence. Yes, he should have done this from the beginning. He couldn't understand why he didn't do this from the start.

"Jaehwan. I will just give you a warning, but if you do this again next time....mmmmmmughh!!! AAAARGH!"

Every cup on the table was thrown to the ground as beer and liquor splattered all over the place. Inchan was on the table after being thrown down onto it, squirming like an insect.

"UUgh.... Uh..."

People screamed. Seoyul's eyes widened in shock.

And in the midst of people who were shocked, Jaehwan alone was standing against all the eyes around him. Inchan was barely looking up at Jaehwan, gasping. His mouth, that world, was still talking to Jaehwan.

'Everyone lives like that. They all live for their loved ones.'

But in Jaehwan's ear, those words did not come anymore. Jaehwan opened his mouth with an emotionless voice.

"Loved one? I don't have one anymore."

Chapter 241: World after the fall

(13)

Three days later, Jaehwan was at Sakamoto's laboratory.

"I'm sorry, Professor. You recommended me to the company and..."

"No, it's alright. I heard about what happened from Seoyul. I should be the one to apologize."

Sakamoto waved his hands and smiled bitterly.

"I didn't know Inchan would have changed that much. He wasn't like that before. I don't know what to say."

Jaehwan glanced around the lab and found a pile of books about parallel universes on the table. It felt weird to know that Sakamoto had not changed after all this time. Sakamoto smiled as he noticed that Jaehwan was looking at the pile of books.

"It might not be in this universe, but Inchan might be a good friend in some other universe out there. Try to understand him in that regard."

"...Is it the parallel universe again?"

"Haha, yeah. You know my research is related to that."

Sakamoto laughed but Jaehwan wanted to say that Inchan was probably not a good man in another universe.

-Use it in small particles... I'm sure we can have many people use this item if that's the case.

'He will probably be an asshole in that universe...'

-But it might not work, so I'll try it out first and let you guys know after!

And a bastard that would give nightmares to everyone into a nightmare for his own greed.

However, Sakamoto did not know anything. He just smiled and sipped his coffee. As Jaehwan heard the sound of a sip and looked at all theory books on the bookshelves, he felt weird.

"Professor. Do you really believe in a 'parallel universe'?"

Sakamoto seemed to be surprised by the question as he spat out some of the coffee. He quickly reached for a tissue to clean it off and answered, "Why are you asking? It's just a theory."

"So, you don't believe in it?"

"Hmm... How should I say it?"

"You told me once that there is no imagination or delusion in this world. Imagination will exist as another world in another universe. That's what you said."

Sakamoto became silent for a while because of Jaehwan's words. The clock on the wall ticked and regulated time. After the ticking rotated for one full cycle, Sakamoto finally broke the silence.

"Jaehwan. I can't answer your question. It is a question that I have no answer to. But I can tell you another story."

The professor's eyes shined brightly.

"Have you heard of something called 'classical mechanics'?"

"Yes. Isn't it about the Newton era and the laws of physics at the time?"

"Oh, so you did listen to my lectures after all?"

"I know that the gravity is beyond just pulling down the apple from the tree."

Sakamoto laughed, "Right. To the people of Newton's age, the world was just that. If gravity affects the tree, the apple will drop. It was an easy world. People believed that the world could be understood through numbers and calculations."

"Of course. But why are you..."

Sakamoto kept on smiling and continued, "Those people believed that they were looking at the 'same thing' and lived in the 'same time'. Think about it. Think about how simple the world was to them, and think about how shocking it was for them to face theories like the theory of relativity or quantum mechanics."

"...Hmm."

Jaehwan thought about it for a second. Maybe it was very similar to how Adapters became Awakeners.

"The people who lived in the world of classical mechanics did not know that time and movement changed depending on the viewer. They also did not know that the apple that dropped because of gravity had a 'possibility' of disappearing somewhere unknown, or penetrate into the ground after millions, or even billions of tests."

"...I guess so."

"To them, the theory of relativity or quantum mechanics are considered to be a complicated magical formula. Haha. Didn't Arthur C. Clarke say this too? That 'Any type of sufficient advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic'?"

Jaehwan listened carefully to Sakamoto but it was hard to understand the point he was trying to make. However, he didn't need to ask as Sakamoto wasn't the type to ask a question and not give an answer. As expected, Sakamoto quickly gave the answer.

"Jaehwan. We are living in an age of classical mechanics."

"....What?"

But even after the answer, Jaehwan was still confused. 'We are still living in an age of classical mechanics?' What was that supposed to mean? Sakamoto took a sip on the coffee again and continued, "Classical mechanics in Newton's era. Theory of relativity in Einstein's era. And quantum mechanics and grand unified theory now... Theories to understand and analyze the world kept evolving. But look at the people now. Most of the people do not care about what those theories are and don't even know it exists. To most people, this world is a simple one where apples still drop from trees and you can pick them up to eat."

Jaehwan then realized what Sakamoto was trying to say. He imagined the Tree of Imagery and the people of [Chaos] who tried hard to get the fruits. He then thought about the people in reality.

"Even with such grand theories, the people's world only exists within their sights -- in their narrow sights where we are not even allowed to examine even an atom."

"..."

"We will never know how the 'real world' looks like. This world is going damn well even with the classical mechanics after all! Quantum mechanics and all that... you don't need to know that to eat, earn money, or have sex!"

Sakamoto then stopped as he got heated up and took a few more sips of coffee.

"I was too fired up there. I'm sorry."

"No. It was great."

"No-no. I'm sure this wasn't what you wanted to hear. ... You're concerned, aren't you?"

Jaehwan answered, "How did you know?"

"People who are interested in parallel universes usually have problems with real life."

Sakamoto smiled as he answered, "Was it because you asked me a strange question? It reminds me of my dream."

"A dream?"

Sakamoto laughed embarrassingly.

"I never told anyone, but I often have strange dreams."

"...What kind of dreams do you have?"

"Can you promise that you will not laugh?"

"I promise."

Sakamoto then scratched his face in embarrassment and started, "Dual swords."

"Huh?"

"I am a warrior that uses dual swords in that dream."

It felt like the air had become rigid.

"That world is a world where everything had been destroyed. There was a weird tower over in the sky, and people needed to climb up that tower. I was one of those climbers. Haha, isn't it weird?"

Jaehwan didn't think it was weird. It wasn't weird at all. Because he knew the story already.

"And there, I level up and increase my stats, trying hard to clear the tower. It's funny, but people call me Sakamoto even in that tower. And there are people I know who comes out in that dream. Say for example, Inchan. Isn't it foolish? And..."

Sakamoto's story continued and Jaehwan listened quietly. Just like a man who had been waiting for a long time, or a kid who wished for the story to never end, he kept on listening.

"So, like that... and... huh? Hey! What's going on! Jaehwan!"

Sakamoto pulled out multiple tissues from the box and quickly came up to Jaehwan and waved at him. Jaehwan realized the reason after a short while. He quickly lowered his head and rubbed his eyes.

"Jaehwan... you promised not to laugh so you are crying instead? Are you trying to make fun of me?"

"N-no. It's not that. It's..."

Jaehwan was facing a strange face as if he didn't know whether to cry or laugh. How should this be explained? How should he explain the feeling of facing something he had waited for so long? Without explaining his feelings, Jaehwan asked a different question instead.

"Professor Sakamoto. Do you believe in that dream?"

"Huh?"

"Do you really believe that the dream is happening in another universe? That it really exists?"

Was it an unexpected question? Sakamoto looked down on the ground for a moment at Jaehwan's question. After a while, he spoke.

"Honestly... I think it might be."

Jaehwan wanted to answer. That it might not be a dream. That it existed. In that world, he climbed the tower together with him and tried to protect the world.

In that world. In that world, you...

Sakamoto then rose up from his seat with embarrassment and Jaehwan couldn't say it. Sakamoto coughed toward the window and turned to Jaehwan.

"Anyway, what I want to say is this. It's not important what the world looks like to people after all. A revolution is something that happens inside a small, narrow, and twisty tunnel box, not outside."

Sakamoto tapped on his head as he spoke and Jaehwan couldn't forget that sight for a long time after that.

"Huh? Where are you going now?"

"I'm sorry! I have to go somewhere!"

Jaehwan then ran out of the lab and Sakamoto scratched his face as he turned to the door that Jaehwan had left through.

"...Hmph. You look like you've found evidence to prove the parallel universe theory."

Chapter 242: World after the fall

(14)

It had been a while since he last visited Gwanghwamun.

He visited the area when he was there to buy books for his college classes and work, but that was it. Instead, Jaehwan saw the place on TV and various news stations. It used to be full of people with candles and people shouting to protect something.

But none of them were here anymore.

People went back to their normal lives. To their original lives. The only ones left here were the ones who did not have anywhere to return. Jaehwan saw people sitting inside the tent in front of General Lee's statue eating cup noodles. Some fought for the dead people while some fought for the living. Some fought for the greater good while some fought for their organization.

And in the middle of all of them, Jaehwan had not fought for anything yet.

"Hey, why did you bring me out here? You two have jobs but I'm still unemployed."

Yoonhwan spoke grumpily and Seoyul scolded him.

"We were fired, remember?"

After Jaehwan quit the job, Seoyul also quit working for the company. It was after an incident as it was bound to happen. Jaehwan felt apologetic for Seoyul who tried hard to get a job, but Seoyul seemed happy. Yoonhwan added, "Oh, right? Haha, we're all in the same boat then."

"Yoonhwan, you look too happy."

Yoonhwan laughed and Seoyul snapped at him.

"Huh? What's that? What's the crowd there?"

As they walked past the tent area toward the King Sejong statue, the number of people increased. Some organizations were shouting something in protest.

"Ugh. This place is always too noisy."

Yoonhwan frowned and looked around.

"Huh? Hey, isn't it him? The doctor?"

Yoonhwan then pointed at a giant object installed next to the statue. It looked like a tower. It was a strange tower to most people, but to Jaehwan, it looked familiar. The tower was created by various trash and abandoned furniture, but Jaehwan had a strange feeling about it.

"Oh, I saw him too! I saw it on the news that he was creating that there."

"Really?"

They then approached the tower. It was a very high tower, and it was hard to believe that it was created by one man. There was metal reinforcements and cement holding it in place in various places.

The height was probably was a taller than ten meters.

It was lower than the other high buildings, but it was tall enough to kill a man if they fell off. The doctor was on top of it.

-Everyone! We must realize! We are trapped inside the tower!

The doctor who said the same thing every time was there. People murmured as they passed by.

"Whoa, he's still doing that?"

"How did he even make that?"

But the protesters who were always here didn't seem to be interested in the doctor. Some of their leaders even came to confront the doctor, saying that the doctor was in the way of their protests.

"I heard he's getting paid to do that," someone said. But Jaehwan couldn't understand. Who would pay him? He wasn't representing anyone. Why? For what reason?

"Really? Yeah, I guess he wouldn't do that otherwise."

"It's all for show. It's just politics. If he becomes famous, the politicians will..."

Jaehwan wanted to burst in anger. He wanted to shout to the people or at the doctor himself.

'Why are you still here? You had everything in this world and you adapted better than anyone in this world. Why are you being treated like that there?'

But Jaehwan did not speak. He couldn't. He didn't know why. Maybe there was still something missing within him. Instead, he just looked silently at the doctor. He shouted and kept on reinforcing the tower.

The cold winter laid shallow ice on the floor. He saw Seoyul blowing on her hands. Yoonhwan, who had a light jacket, spoke grumpily.

"Hey, how long are you going to stay here? I'm sure you aren't here to look at that."

"I'm here to look at that."

"Huh? Why?"

"There's something I need to know."

Yoonhwan looked confused but Jaehwan did not answer. He didn't have any answer. He didn't know what he wanted to know, or what he didn't know. Time passed and the weather got colder. But strangely, enough, the number of protesters was increasing. Was it a large protest day? There were protests surrounding Jaehwan and his friends now.

"WAAAAAH!"

"PUSH THEM!"

Jaehwan was then pushed by people coming from the back. Yoonhwan and Seoyul screamed as they were pulled away. Shouts came from everywhere. It became even more serious as police came against to block the protesters from advancing.

Jaehwan couldn't understand any word that anyone said. There were too many shouts from all over the place. Police were barely holding back the line and fights broke out everywhere, with reporters busily trying to capture what is going on.

And in the middle of everything, the doctor was shouting alone.

"Everyone! You must realize it!"

It was a strange sight. The doctor continuously shouted words that no one listened to. Why? What meaning did it have? Jaehwan found himself shouting at the doctor.

Stop! Stop it now!

No one listens to you anymore!

No matter how hard you try, the voice will not be heard by the people!

However, Jaehwan's voice was swept away by the protesters shouting. As the protesting became intense, the number of people bumping into the tower increased. The cement began to crack and the old rugged metal construct began to twist.

The tower was falling down.

Some people were shocked, but that was it. Most only cared about advancing. The doctor was barely holding onto the tower, trying to keep himself from falling down. But it looked helpless, as if he would fall in any second.

Why? Why wasn't anyone trying to help?

Jaehwan shouted at the people. But no one looked at him. No one saved the doctor.

People stood there like trees that had deep roots in the ground. They were like trees that just stood there, waiting for the sun to come. Trees with slight movement would kill themselves.

Jaehwan bit his lips.

Why?

A group of women shouted for women rights, a group of laborers who shouted for labor rights, college organizations protested to lower the tuition costs, and the police blocked all of them. No one looked at the doctor. They acted as if the doctor did not even exist.

That's when Jaehwan realized.

'Ah...'

It was a sad and powerful realization.

The reason why no one was trying to save the doctor was because the doctor was not a 'man of this world'.

To them, the doctor was beyond their understanding and was cast out. To them, the doctor was invisible. They were together, but as if the doctor was in a parallel universe, he wasn't here.

Only Jaehwan was looking at the doctor.

Jaehwan then began to move.

"Jaehwan! NO!"

He saw Yoonhwan who caught up, trying to stop Jaehwan from moving out, but Jaehwan pulled Yoonhwan's hand away and walked forward.

Just a little more.

Just as if he pushed away into an impossible way, he pushed past the people. He pushed and pushed. There were people cursing or hitting him, but Jaehwan took in everything to walk forward.

And finally.

He was at the place where the doctor had fallen.

Jaehwan brought the doctor up. He was opening his eye faintly. His eye shook for a second and faintly smiled.

"...Jaehwan. You finally came."

Jaehwan looked down at the doctor. What should he say? After many tries, Jaehwan was barely able to speak. But it wasn't what he wanted to ask.

"Who are you?"

Jaehwan still asked anyway.

"You knew about the tower from the beginning, didn't you?"

"..."

"Chunghuh? Cayman? Karlton? Runald? Or Jay? Who are you? WHO ARE YOU! Why did you do all this..."

Doctor shook his head silently.

"If I tell you who I am, will you believe me?"

Jaehwan became lost for words. Doctor laughed as he bled from his mouth.

"Yes. Maybe I am Chunghuh. He was a doctor there, so maybe I am Chunghuh."

"..."

"Or maybe I am Karlton. Just like he had law book, I always had books with me."

"Wait..."

"Maybe I am Runald. Because I may be your only Follower right now."

Chapter 243: World after the fall

(15)

Jaehwan shook his head in confusion.

'What is he trying to say?'

"Or if I am not one of them, I don't have the right to believe in your world?"

The doctor's head was bleeding. It seemed like he struck his head as he fell. Before Jaehwan could say anything about it, the doctor spoke again.

"I'm sorry Jaehwan. It's all because of me. I ruined you. I destroyed your world and I dared to try to analyze it."

"Hey! Don't say anything! You are..."

The doctor continued however.

"But Jaehwan, in some way, that wasn't me. I wasn't the one who declared your world to be a delusion and connected it to your 'father' without consent. It wasn't my will..."

Jaehwan wanted to ask, 'Then what was it? If it wasn't your will, then what?'

"That is..."

The doctor's voice began fading as shouts erupted around them. Jaehwan shook the doctor's body so that he wouldn't faint and tried to listen to his voice. The doctor then came back to his senses. This time, Jaehwan asked the question he really wanted to ask.

"What should I do now?"

"..."

"There's nothing I can do in this world! I... what is this world? The reality... what is..."

"Jaehwan. You came here because you already know the answer."

The doctor smiled and looked up at the sky over Jaehwan's shoulder. It seemed like he was looking at something.

"It's a beautiful sky."

Jaehwan became dumbfounded for a second and asked in shock, "Do you see something?!"

"Huh? Yes. I see a sky."

"No, I mean... an eye for example or..."

"Eye? Haha, Jaehwan. There's nothing in this world's sky."

The doctor's mouth was shaking now.

"There is no Big Brother in this world."

A calm voice came with the despair but also faced the despair straight on.

"But there are others."

'Others?'

"Jaehwan. It's you who taught me the world. Chunghuh, Karlton, Runald, Cayman, Sirwen, Yoo Surha... all those people and the stories. It was you who told me that."

"..."

"Open your eyes. Your world still exists. It did not go anywhere. It stays within you."

The doctor bit his lips with a painful look on his face.

"Don't look at the world in other people's eyes. Use your own eyes. Look at it with your own eyes!"

My eyes.

"It's not a metaphor or symbolic words! It really exists! Jaehwan. That world really exists."

Jaehwan's body began to shake. The jolt started creeping up from the ends of his fingers to his body. With a familiar sensation, heat began to gather in his eyes.

Jaehwan closed his eyes.

Every sight within the world disappeared and only Jaehwan remained. In that silent darkness, Jaehwan focused.

'My sight. My lost eyes.'

And in the next moment, Jaehwan saw a strange circle-like shape appearing in his line of sight. It was a snake eating away at its own tail. Jaehwan knew that snake.

Ouroboros.

He heard the sound of something spinning fiercely. It was an old and familiar sensation.

-Yes.

-It's about time to start again.

Jaehwan opened his eyes slowly. Something was exploding inside him. Something was being born. It felt like the moment of his first Awakening

when he was pulled away from the system.

The different universes began to overlap each other. This world was connecting to another world.

The doctor was right.

"Do you see it, Jaehwan? Are you seeing it?"

The doctor looked up to Jaehwan. The doctor who gave him confidence was now asking him again.

"Your world... it really existed. Doesn't it? Haha... I.. I wasn't wrong."

And then the doctor fainted. Jaehwan hauled the doctor up on his shoulder and looked around. The world was different now. There was no shouting, but there were hollow moans. It was all too familiar to Jaehwan.

'I see. So, you were protecting this world all this time after I abandoned it.'

And in the middle of the unique world where everything seemed to have fallen, Jaehwan finally felt deep relief. Yes, this was his world. It was the world that he had protected for 10 billion years. The world that declared the fall of every world. The world that brought salvation by giving up salvation.

This was the World After the Fall.

Chapter 244: World after the fall

(16)

Jaehwan saw the people. Or rather, he saw those who were once 'human' just until a while ago. Unlike in [Chaos], they didn't look like corpses. Rather, they were replaced by trees, rotten and dried up trees. Trees that knew that the land had no nutrients but couldn't leave the land. They were looking at Jaehwan.

'I see it now. I finally see it.'

Jaehwan then remembered Mulack's words. He said there was no Big Brother in the Nightmare of the Beginning.

This world did not have eyes because eyes were everywhere. They all looked directly at Jaehwan. Jaehwan looked back at them and smiled.

'If I can see them, I can fight them.'

There were countless eyes within those trees, and Jaehwan looked at them. There was the sound of roots being uprooted, just like a tree pulling out its own roots. Jaehwan walked and walked. The other trees were horrified.

How? How can this be?

How can a tree... walk on its own?

Trees were shaking — specifically their roots, trunks, and branches. They were terrified by Jaehwan who was not afraid of facing all these eyes. They wished that someone would punish that walking tree and burn it down. However, nobody volunteered and just moved out of the way. And Yoonhwan was among those trees.

'Ah...'

He wasn't sure why Jaehwan looked like he was shining in between all this chaos. He just saved a man and was walking back. That was it.

But why did it feel like he had witnessed that scene multiple times?

Yoonhwan teared up with an emotion that he could not understand or explain. He turned and there Seoyul was, crying. They smiled at each other as if they knew something like this had happened before. And then they looked at Jaehwan again.

"Well, have we become weird too?"

"...Maybe."

"It reminds me of that. The novel that he wrote once..."

Through the trees, Jaehwan was walking toward them.

Just like people who found the exit out of a long nightmare, Yoonhwan and Seoyul ran toward Jaehwan.

The door to the new world was beginning to open a man's smallest and darkest box.

Unique worlds existed in this world. It was not a parallel universe. It always existed together in the same world that people could see. It was sometimes labeled as delusion, but the possibility was always there.

Of course, this unique world was different from the unique world that Jaehwan knew.

In this place, having a unique world didn't allow him to make a [Setting] or utilize it. Unique worlds moved in a more complicated way in this world.

-Jaehwan, please...

The doctor gave him a small notebook that he took out from his clothes as he was taken to the hospital. It was the record of Jaehwan's story. It was so severely discolored that it showed how much it had been read through. Jaehwan understood how the doctor had succeeded in reaching his unique world.

-Jaehwan, there's only one way to defeat reality. It's not like [Chaos] or [Depth]. You cannot fight the world alone now.

Even in this place, people could enter someone else's unique world and believe in the same thing to live on. They could enjoy the free world outside or classical mechanics and other oppressions, but...

-I am just the first. You must let people know about your world.

That was only possible when a lot of people believed in that world. In the last page of the notebook, there was the doctor's short novel that Jaehwan once ripped away. The novel had been taped back with the pieces of paper.

'He didn't throw it away.'

Jaehwan read it again. It was a boring and uninteresting novel. But maybe the doctor wanted to change the world with this. Maybe he wanted to show it to the world and invite people over to the World After the Fall. Jaehwan touched the paragraphs of the novel for a long time.

'Doctor, if that is what your wish...'

Jaehwan turned on his laptop computer. There was an unedited novel that he was working on before he quit. He opened the document, erased everything, and began typing in other words.

One by one, the white document was soon filled. Memories slowly began coming back. In the same way he would stab or slash, Jaehwan kept on typing. Stories began to play from his head. Just like when he succeeded in his [World Stab] for the first time, or when he acquired the [Fall], his head exploded with countless realizations.

The paragraphs were rough and weak. He didn't have good metaphors and he had many grammatical errors.

But he kept on going. Just like he didn't give up on his stabs, he kept on writing. Even when a crude paragraph made him think harder, he did not give up and kept on typing everything down. He did it as if this was the reason why he lived that world, as if this were the reason for the history of his life. He grew suspicious, understood, forgot, created another theory, proved it, and edited.

He wrote and wrote again.

After an uncertain amount of time, Jaehwan finally finished the prologue of his novel. As he read through the completed prologue and fixed any errors, a certain question came to him.

'Oh, what was the doctor's name by the way?'

It was strange. The name that was clear until a while ago, the name that was shown in various media stations, was fuzzy now. Jaehwan then found the doctor's name written below the title of his short novel.

'...You've got to be kidding.'

Jaehwan smiled as he looked at the name. It was a funny name.

Jaehwan opened the web novel website and there were countless novels waiting to be read. Jaehwan saw all of these novels in a new light now. He thought maybe all these novels had their own unique worlds. Some were crude and some were great, but all of these had various unique worlds to create this universe as a whole.

Jaehwan typed in the doctor's name as the pen name and opened a novel with the same name as the doctor's short novel. Then a message popped up to add a description for the work.

Description?

Jaehwan thought long and hard about it as if he was a god showing his unique world for the first time. He couldn't make it sound too grand or else people would avoid it. But it couldn't still be too weak because people wouldn't anticipate it either.

Jaehwan opened up the note again.

In that note, Jaehwan read through the paragraphs that the doctor had left very slowly. And at some point, one sentence caught his attention. He grinned. Yes, maybe this was the only fitting sentence for the beginning of this story. This was it. Jaehwan positioned his hands over the keyboard. And he gave himself ample time to type in each word carefully.

-This is the story of a man who did not return while everyone else returned to the past.

Chapter 245: Ouroboros (1)

[I have to remember it. That's the only way it will not disappear.]

Sirwen Armelt.

Epilogue. Ouroboros.

"Hey, do you really think we should consider this a masterpiece?"

Nightmares who attended a celebration party mumbled to each other. As the music began to play, the party started and Nightmares drank and ate freely. But the old Nightmares from the Nightmare Union who sat around the main table of the party were busy frowning at each other.

"Ugh."

In front of their eyes, there was a small statue-sized 'tower'.

It was once called the 'Tower of Nightmares' but it was only called a 'Tower' now. It was once an art that glorified Nightmares above all other beings, but it was now an old structure that was only used to reminisce about the old days for old Nightmares. The leader of the Union looked closely into the Tower's interior and frowned.

"What is this trying to say? This is just a copy of our world!"

"Isn't it supposed to be the Tree of Imagery? I think it shows the Tree of Imagery."

"Tree of Imagery? What do you know about the Tree of Imagery? It does look like a tree but..."

"Look at the top floor. This is a joke!"

They criticized as they glared at the exterior of the tower. It was the new creation of the last [Master], Sirwen Armelt.

"That arrogant girl keeps on creating strange towers after becoming a Master."

"What's all this fuss about over a tower..."

"The girl's got good looks. That's what the young ones are into. A girl with no artistic sense!"

"...Hush. Be quiet."

One of the old Nightmares brought a finger to his lips and a beautiful woman with a lovely dress walked behind them. They all became quiet at the sudden coldness. Only the sound of her heels echoed for a while and she walked up to the stage.

"Everyone, please welcome Sirwen Armelt!"

Young Nightmares shouted in excitement. Sirwen received the microphone from the host and glanced around the party. There were some new faces as well as the faces she recognized. There were also some that she didn't want to see anymore.

'Those old bums are here again.'

Sirwen frowned at the old Nightmares from the Union. They always joined the party to ruin it. They were old, but they did not become Masters. And now, death was waiting for them.

At the word 'death', memories swept through Sirwen.

'No. Let's not think about that.'

Sirwen calmed down and spoke.

"Everyone, eat, drink and enjoy. That's all I have to say."

Young Nightmares shouted again. Sirwen's parties were always like this. She introduced her work and they enjoyed it. There were no boring lectures about the work. Attendees just enjoyed a good time at the party. That was all. But the host this time seemed to be shocked by Sirwen's way.

"Huh? Is that it? How about some comments about your work or..."

Sirwen turned to the host. The host kept on going.

"This work is characterized by its contrast against the new world and the Tree of Imagery. It is complicated, so if you would explain the motive and..."

"No."

The host became dumbfounded.

"What?"

"I won't say anything."

The host was shocked and confused.

"But you should... uh, everyone's curious about the top floor of the [Nightmare of the Beginning] for example.... At least if you give us the theme of..."

"A theme?" Sirwen scoffed. "Why would I create a tower if I'm going to spill it all by talking? I can just talk about it without making it."

"Y-yes, but..."

The host frantically searched through his cue cards and Sirwen spoke.

"If you want me to say something so badly..."

"O-oh! Please!"

The host smiled and looked at Sirwen, but she wasn't there anymore. Or metaphorically at least.

She was looking for an old past. The time that most beings had forgotten now. The days when everyone fought to be a 'being'. Many scenes flashed past her eyes.

"This is a tower for a certain person."

After the [Fall] came, the Tree of Imagery was destroyed. Every being was present when it happened.

The branches and trunk fell down and the Tree of Imagery dispersed into silver.

Lords and Gods. Adapters and Awakeners. They all looked up at the scene. They felt the disaster they could never even hope to stop. Then they accepted it.

This was the end. This was how it all was going to end.

With an explosion, the world turned and everything was covered in silver dust. It took about one week for the silver dust to die down.

A silvery 7 days.

But even after that one week, people still survived. The beings that survived now realized that they were living in a 'new world'. It was the creation of a mixture between [Depth], [Chaos], and the [Great Lands]. It was the world that had Gods, Lords, Adapters, and in one place. There was no Tree of Imagery and the world was free from the chains of the System.

New World.

People named the new world.

"You're back."

"Yeah."

"How was the party?"

"It was the same as always."

"Were the Union people grumpy again?"

"..."

"Don't mind them. They always do that."

"Yeah, and it doesn't make me feel any better each time."

Sirwen smiled and took off her coat, placing it on the chair of the hospital room.

"How's your condition?"

"I'm fine."

"Fine? You look like you're dying."

Sirwen looked at the old man lying on the bed. He had white hair and a wrinkly face. Time and age were ruining his body. Sirwen remembered the old man's past of when he was a boy.

A rude boy from [Depth]. A boy who was so stubborn that it was easy to tell whose Follower he was. The boy who acted like he was grown up was now a old man.

Sirwen caressed the old man's forehead and thought about his name. As if she would remember his name after time was up, she thought about the name.

This old man's name was Runald.

"Yeah. I will die someday, right?"

"Someday? I think it'll be soon."

"Ugh, don't say it like that. I feel racism every time you say that, you know."

"Haha..."

"Do you think Chunghuh would have felt it this way? Or Karlton...?"

"Runald."

"Haha, I'm joking. Joking."

Runald smiled, slightly shaking his lips.

"I'm just... scared. Unlike Chunghuh, it's the first time for me... to die. It will be the first and last."

"Don't be stupid. It's the first time for everyone."

"Sirwen. What do you think death is? Is it returning to nothing? Is there nothing beyond this world? No memory, spirit or..."

Runald's lips then soon became silent. It seemed like he was out of his energy. Small, shallow breaths were heard. Sirwen caressed Runald's forehead with a sad look on her face.

"Kid, that's what makes us human."

Chapter 246: Ouroboros (2)

When the New World first appeared, the most popular name was of course, 'Jaehwan'.

He was the one who destroyed the Tree of Imagery and the System.

People were curious about who he was. What kind of man was he, and why did he destroy the world to bring about a new world? Everyone looked around for him, but no one seemed to know where Jaehwan had disappeared off to.

There were some who claimed that they were 'Jaehwan'.

"I am the God of the New World!"

Most of them said such things, but their corpses were soon found a few months later. The reason for the deaths varied. They were sometimes killed by stabs and slashes, and sometimes they were burned to death. The worst one of all was when they were killed by a golden club.

-Anyone who imposter Jaehwan will die.

As the imposters all died out, Jaehwan became a more mysterious being. Some even considered Jaehwan to be a true God of the New World, but a lot of people condemned him.

-No skill, no status! How can we live in this world!

-Bring back our world! Bring it back!

People were shocked. There was no interface, no guide, and no status. They had to endure the world by themselves. And that wasn't the only thing.

-I... I don't want to die...

The 'immortal' life was taken away as the System had fallen. Every being in the world now faced 'death'. The 'aging' that was removed had returned. Now, every being could not escape time. That's how they became 'beings'.

There was the coming of certain death even when nothing was done.

Some were afraid and felt that it was painful, but not everyone felt the same way. There were some who accepted 'death' gladly.

-It's okay. Don't be so sad.

-...

-Hey, stop crying girl.

-I-I'm not crying!

Chunghuh's weakened old voice brought tears to some people. Sirwen was one of them. Tears? Did she still have such emotions left in her? Sirwen smiled bitterly but she couldn't stop herself from crying.

-I've lived long enough... this isn't the first time but it still makes me nervous. Hehe...

Some smiled at Chunghuh still making jokes on the last day. They all grabbed Chunghuh's hand. It was the hand of an old warrior, the hand of an old man who fought for what was right throughout his entire life. Sirwen held his hand.

-Just once... I wanted to see Jaehwan for the last time... I hope he's well.

The old man who lived his entire life looking up at the sky, died while looking up at the sky.

And with Chunghuh to start, people began to die.

Cayman, Euren, and the clan Leaders of [Chaos]...

Those who had outlived the normal human lifespan were the first to go. Yoo Surha was one of them.

-I feel jealous of you for the first time. I am what you see, but you still look the same as the day I met you.

-Nightmares live for a long time.

-Yeah...

Surha smiled bitterly.

-You're going to wait for him, aren't you?

-Yeah.

-Please, tell him when he comes back. That he's not wrong. Even if everything was pointless, that he wasn't wrong...

Surha did not lose her strong will even when she became old.

The people who remembered the Tree of Imagery, people who remembered Jaehwan, disappeared one by one, just like that. And then came the people after Jaehwan's time.

40 years. 50 years.

Time passed quickly.

Now, there weren't many left who remembered the Tree of Imagery or the System. They did not know that there were times when people could use the status window, inventory, and show their strength through the level, status, and stages of Adaptation. Moreover, they also did not know that there was a man who fought against the world.

Karlton once said this:

-It's strange, isn't it? Kids these days don't know about the Master.

-We remember him. That's all that matters.

-Yes. It's okay, yet.

-You... your wings look weaker.

-...

Sirwen's raised her eyebrow.

-Aren't you half Angel? You shouldn't be weak already.

-I am half, yes. I'm old if you consider the fact that I'm half-human.

The two became silent for a while.

-Aren't you lonely?

-Shut up. Why would I?

-But you will be.

-...

-I really hope you will not become lonely.

Karlton looked up to the sky as he spoke.

-I am afraid this isn't the last.

And it was a month later that Sirwen heard about Karlton's death.

70 years passed.

Sirwen was still waiting for someone. There was no need to explain who she was waiting for. She looked everywhere for any trace of Jaehwan.

'There is no way he would disappear like this. He has to be out there somewhere.'

'Even if he's not in this world, he has to be alive.'

And the number of people on her 'expedition' team kept on decreasing. Mino, Claire... people who volunteered to search for Jaehwan disappeared from the member list one by one, from accidents or of old age.

'I wish they were here at least.'

Sirwen thought about the people who disappeared during the 'Silvery 7 days' that came after the destruction of the Tree of Imagery.

Yoonhwan and Seoyul.

They were the only people who disappeared after the Fall of the old world. It was strange to consider it a coincidence and Sirwen thought maybe there was a connection to their disappearance and Jaehwan.

"Captain! There's something here!"

When they were searching through the northern lands where the Tree of Imagery's trunk was rumored to be, they found dark and long objects there.

"T-this..."

Sirwen, who was a Nightmare, realized what they were the moment she laid her eyes upon them.

"These are the Roots."

"...Roots? You mean the Roots of the Tree of Imagery?"

"Yeah."

"But how... don't the Roots grow in the direction of the [Remote Region]?"

Sirwen narrowed her eyes at the man.

"Hey, where do you think the [Remote Region] is located?"

"Isn't it under us? I mean, that's where Roots grow right?"

"Under? No. The universe isn't that simple."

"Huh? What do you mean? What is..."

But he couldn't hear Sirwen's answer. Sirwen froze in place as the man looked back.

"Captain?"

Sirwen's hands were shaking. Step by step, she walked over to the corner of the giant root and found something stuck in there.

'I searched for so long.'

She held back the tears and caressed the object that was stuck there. It was a sword that had been destroyed. It was the sword that the loneliest man in the world, the most stubborn man in the world, once used.

It was Jaehwan's broken sword.

Chapter 247: Ouroboros (3) - Epilogue

In the same year, Sirwen announced a new theory about the Tree of Imagery.

"So, you saying that maybe the Nightmare of the Beginning is located at the Roots?"

"Yeah, in summary."

"Ugh, that's nonsense!"

Nightmares still studied the Tree of Imagery even after it disappeared. The Tree of Imagery held every secret behind birth. It was a motive for every tower and allowed 'Cultivation' to give Nightmares a purpose. They still were clinging onto that tree.

"There's no way. If the Nightmare of the Beginning was located at the roots, we would have found it a long time ago."

"No. We do not know what the Nightmare of the Beginning looks like. We might've even visited the place and didn't even realize it."

But even those Nightmares didn't seem to be convinced by the new theory. It wasn't because Sirwen's theory was complicated. The theory itself was simple. It just said the Tree of Imagery didn't grow in one direction.

"We all know that the branches or the roots didn't grow in one direction."

"Yes, but..."

"My theory has a point. What if the roots and branches circled the universe to meet each other? What if the Tree of Imagery was in the shape of a circle? That might explain why we couldn't find the Nightmare of the Beginning when the Tree of Imagery was destroyed. That's why there's no 'top floor' to the tree!"

"That is nonsense!"

"Finding the Roots in this land is proof! We might not know what the Tree of Imagery looked like!"

Sirwen spoke desperately. She had a reason to as she needed the help of these old Nightmares this time.

"You cannot prove your point. Besides, we can't go to the [Remote Region] anymore. Even if there is the Nightmare of the Beginning there... there is no Tree of Imagery and..."

"That's why I'm telling you! If we change our views, we might be able to reconstruct the way! We might even be allowed to travel through dimensions freely again!"

"No way. Let's cut this nonsense now."

Sirwen bit her lips. She hoped that the old Nightmares who still longed for the Tree of Imagery would understand her, but it was no use.

Sirwen knew that the time of Nightmares was over.

No more Nightmares were born after the Tree of Imagery disappeared. The tower just became a hollow form of art after Cultivation was gone as if the horrific Cultivation was the true identity of art.

Sirwen shouted angrily.

"FINE! Be fools! Die in your past glory!"

The fall of her race? She didn't care anymore.

Sirwen returned to the only person who understood her.

"...Didn't go well?"

"No."

Sirwen smiled at Runald's concerned expression.

"Don't worry. I can do it alone. I will do it someday. I can meet him again. You just have to stay alive until then."

Runald smiled without energy.

"He's still alive, isn't he?"

"Yeah. I'm sure of it."

Runald blinked slowly.

"I have a strange dream these days. I hear voices calling me somewhere. It's like when I was in his unique world..."

"Don't make it sound like you will die soon, kid."

"...Stop calling me kid, will you? You should respect your elder."

Sirwen quietly tapped Runald's forehead.

They smiled at each other and began talking about the old days like every other day. They talked about the days when Jaehwan first appeared in [Depth]. Then they talked about what followed after. They talked about the stubborn Jaehwan, and days of impossible plans. And...

"When do you die?"

"I don't know. Maybe after 1,000 years?"

"1,000... I didn't know I would feel that time to be so long."

Runald looked up at Sirwen with a lonely expression.

"Sirwen."

"What."

"You have to keep talking to someone even when I'm gone. Okay?"

"...Shut up, kid."

"You should at least talk to yourself. Don't break. Even if everyone forgets everything except you. Don't consider everything as an illusion or a dream. Okay?"

"Of course, I won't."

"Right. You're a Nightmare. I'm sure you have better memory than me."

"Of course."

Runald smiled.

"That's good."

"..."

"You know, those days have become hazy these days. It sometimes even feels like it didn't exist... as if I was in a long dream, that Jaehwan never existed and everything was just a dream..."

And Runald fell asleep. Sirwen felt his breathing slowing down. His heartbeat was dying out. She knew this was the last, but she couldn't wake him up.

She couldn't even dare to close her eyes as it would bring tears. She just placed her hand over Runald's forehead.

"Silly. There's no way it was a dream."

Everyone who had the same dreams disappeared and the old Nightmares died one by one.

Sirwen was left alone. She alone remembered everything.

No more Roots were found. She thought maybe the Root she found was the last Root that the Tree of Imagery had left. She kept it well and studied it whenever she had time. The Root was the only way to reach the end of her questions. It was the only piece of evidence to answer why she was born in this world, why she met Jaehwan, and what the Nightmare of the Beginning was.

This was the only possible tunnel that might connect her to Jaehwan.

She studied and studied.

She collected documents from dead Nightmares and asked for help from other races. But the research didn't go so well.

10 years passed. 20 years passed. 100 years passed. And then 200 years.

All of a sudden, she realized everyone except for her had forgotten about a being named Jaehwan. History did not record Jaehwan anymore and no one stabbed. And there was a sign of the return of the System. It wasn't obvious like before. There were no levels or statuses, but Sirwen was able to feel it.

The System was coming back.

Sirwen still did not know anything. She didn't know what the Nightmare of the Beginning was, and why the Tree of Imagery gave birth to her. Sirwen did not know.

And Sirwen placed down the Root she was researching.

She wasn't sure if it was an act of giving up or the beginning of a new challenge. But she remembered when she was creating the tower for the last time, the tower she created for Jaehwan.

Maybe it was a sudden urge, but Sirwen acted on it. She peeled off the Root and began shaping it using her tools.

She began working on her last tower.

With faint longing and severe loneliness, she created the tower. It wasn't a tower for Cultivation. It was a tower that allowed no Cultivation. It had no use, but that's why it was unique.

As she created the tower, she dreamed often.

'This is not a dream. I cannot consider every memory to be a dream.'

But she still dreamed. It was a dream of her quarreling with Chunghuh. There was Karlton and there was Runald. It was also a dream of her arguing with Surha, and it was the dream of his return.

At the end of the long nightmare, she was fixing up the exterior of the tower. There was a lonely tree at the end of her hand.

'Just a bit more. I just need to work on a bit more...'

And she fell asleep again without finishing her work. It was a deep sleep this time. She thought she might not wake up in time before she had fallen asleep.

The sound of quiet breaths filled her small room.

The quietness was steady and calm. It felt like it would continue endlessly, as if it were telling Sirwen that she had done well. That she could rest now.

But it was then that a small sound came from her tower. It was so small that Sirwen could barely hear it. Within the tower, a small crack opened up and the dark room was soon filled with the faint light.

It was a familiar crack.

It was like the day the sky was ripped open by the stab.

The crack began to spread across the tower as if one world was calling upon another world. As if one world was overlapping into another.

Even in her dream, Sirwen saw the crack. She smiled as she knew what it was. In the faint sight, she tried to open her mouth.

She wanted to say that she had waited for too long.

But her drowsiness was too heavy and she couldn't bring herself up. The tower shined brightly and embraced her. It was as if it was saying that she can sleep more, that it was okay to sleep.

Sirwen felt relieved and closed her eyes.

It was a rest that she could take because she knew this wasn't over.

And in the bright light, she dreamed for a long time.

In that dream, she thought that she should rest well and regain her energy.

Because when she woke up, a new world would be waiting for her.